Paige

Contents

Freshman Year **7**
Band Camp . . . 7
Scene 1: The Downbeat . . . 7
Scene 2: Breakfast . . . 8
Scene 3: The Section Leader . . . 9
Scene 4: Texture . . . 11
Scene 5: The File . . . 12
Scene 6: Rocket Burger . . . 13
Scene 7: The Connection . . . 15
Scene 8: The Overwatch . . . 17
Scene 9: The All Clear . . . 18
Scene 10: The Table . . . 20
The Fall . . . 21
Scene 1: Third Quarter . . . 21
Scene 2: The Signal . . . 25
Winter 2000 . . . 26
Scene 1: The Visitor . . . 26
Scene 2: The Confrontation . . . 29
Scene 3: The Clinic . . . 31
Scene 4: The Law of the Lunchroom . . . 34
The Static . . . 36
Scene 1: The First Satellite . . . 36
Scene 2: The Inside Man . . . 39
Scene 3: The Dinner Table . . . 43

The Blueprint **45**
The Cracks . . . 45
Scene 1: Static . . . 45
Scene 2: The Escape Vehicle . . . 48
Scene 3: The Route . . . 51
Scene 4: The Sugar Rush . . . 53
Scene 5: The Calculation . . . 55
Scene 6: The Collapse . . . 57

Scene 7: The Closet 60
The Severance 63
Scene 1: The Sofa 63
The Iron City 65
Scene 1: The Transfer Point 65
Scene 2: The Red Booth 67
Scene 3: The Detour 69
Scene 4: Pepper Plaza 70
Scene 5: The Configuration 71
The Machine 73
Scene 1: Route 1 73
Scene 2: The Acoustic Engine 75
Scene 3: The Pitch 77
Scene 4: The Terminal 80
Scene 5: The Foundry 82
Scene 6: The Old Lady on the Hill 83
Scene 7: The Reset 88
Scene 8: The Iron Sea 90
Scene 9: The Forger's Call 93
Scene 10: The False Start 96
Scene 11: System Overload 97
Scene 12: The Human Grid 99
Scene 13: Zero Tolerance 101
Scene 14: The Shutout 103
Scene 15: The Shuttle 105
The Source Code 108
Scene 1: The Diagnosis 108
Scene 2: The Firewall 112
Scene 3: The Protocol Upgrade 116

A New Beginning **118**
The Launch Code 118
Scene 1: The Loop 118
Scene 2: The Frequency 121
Scene 3: The Base 124
The Source Code 126
Scene 1: The Manual 126
Scene 2: The Calibration 129
Scene 3: The Curriculum 131
Scene 4: The Open Door 132
Scene 5: The Morning After 136
Scene 6: The Cartridge Exchange 139
Scene 7: Channel 3 141
The Syllabus 143
Scene 1: The Loophole 143
Scene 2: The Run 145

Scene 3: The Medical Logistics . . . 150
Scene 4: The Schematic . . . 151
Scene 5: Data Verified . . . 152
Scene 6: The Clear Curtain . . . 153
Scene 7: The Silo . . . 155
The Network . . . 156
Scene 1: The Primary Node . . . 156
Scene 2: The Red Flag . . . 158
Scene 3: The Maintenance Run . . . 160
Proper Terminology . . . 163
Scene 1: Ground Rules . . . 163
Scene 2: Zero Tolerance . . . 164
Scene 3: Safe Harbor . . . 166
Scene 4: The Predator . . . 167
Scene 5: Geometry and Physics . . . 171
Scene 6: The Safe Zone . . . 174
Scene 7: The Incorrect Variable . . . 176
Scene 8: The Distortion . . . 181
Scene 9: The Contaminant . . . 185
Scene 10: The Humidity Index . . . 189
The Admin Console . . . 191
Scene 1: The Cool Down . . . 191
Scene 2: The Signal . . . 193
Scene 3: The Final Frontier . . . 198
Scene 4: The System Architecture . . . 201
Scene 5: The Sandwich Configuration . . . 203
Autism Diagnosis . . . 205
Scene 1: The Debugger . . . 205
Scene 2: Operating Systems . . . 207
Scene 3: The King Bed Defense . . . 208
Scene 4: The Source Code . . . 209
Scene 5: The Uplink . . . 210
Scene 6: The Thunderhead . . . 211
Scene 7: The Warning . . . 215
Scene 8: The All Clear . . . 218
The Prime Time Block . . . 219
Scene 1: The Decompression Protocol . . . 219
Scene 2: The Emergency Brake . . . 223
Scene 3: The Dark Closet . . . 225
Scene 4: The Awakening . . . 226
Scene 5: The Recovery Cycle . . . 229
Scene 6: The System Halt . . . 231
Scene 7: Manual Override . . . 233
The Anatomy of Resilience . . . 235
Scene 1: The Purge . . . 235
Scene 2: The Buffer . . . 237

Scene 3: The Quiet Room . . . 239
Scene 4: The Transit & The Trail . . . 244
Scene 5: The Recharge . . . 247
Scene 6: The Drive-Thru . . . 249
Scene 7: Dinner . . . 251
Scene 8: The Cost-Benefit Analysis . . . 252
Scene 9: The Analog Archive . . . 254
Scene 10: The Captaincy Protocol . . . 257
Scene 11: The Shutdown Sequence . . . 259

The False Anchor **261**
The New Variable . . . 261
Scene 1: The Remainder . . . 261
Scene 2: The Static Stack . . . 264
The Seed . . . 267
Scene 1: The Observation . . . 267
Scene 2: The Recoil . . . 270
Scene 3: The Split Screen . . . 272
Scene 4: The Syntax Error . . . 276
The Orbital Decay . . . 280
Scene 1: The Logic Bomb . . . 280
Scene 2: The Presentation . . . 283
Scene 3: The Disconnect . . . 287
Scene 4: The Horizon Line . . . 291
Scene 5: The Point of No Return . . . 296
Scene 6: The Detour . . . 300
Scene 7: The Burning Mile . . . 304
Scene 8: The Pasco Lock . . . 306
Scene 9: The Silence . . . 309
The Rescue . . . 310
Scene 1: The Advance Team . . . 310
Scene 2: The Intercept . . . 317
Scene 3: The Time Lock . . . 325
Scene 4: The Decontamination Protocol . . . 326
Scene 5: Frequency Tuned . . . 332
Scene 6: The Signal Cut . . . 335
The Tourist Protocol . . . 348
Scene 1: Fueling the Expedition . . . 348
Scene 2: The Mode Switch . . . 350
Scene 3: The Observation Deck . . . 352
Scene 4: The Deep Blue . . . 354
Scene 5: The Wheelchair Epiphany . . . 357
Scene 6: The Scar . . . 358
Scene 7: High Voltage . . . 360
Scene 8: The Silent Signal . . . 363
Scene 9: The Restoration . . . 365

Scene 10: The Flight Plan . . . 368
Scene 11: The Northern Trajectory . . . 371
Flight to Tahoma . . . 374
Scene 1: The Bypass . . . 374
Scene 2: The Iron Creek Lodge . . . 376
Scene 3: The Bear's Den . . . 378
Scene 4: The Supply Run . . . 380
Scene 5: The Hypothesis & The Lock . . . 382
Scene 6: The Iron Giants & The Safe Mode . . . 385
Scene 7: Factory Settings . . . 388
Scene 8: The Iron Spirits . . . 390
Scene 9: The Silent Engines . . . 392
Scene 10: The Refueling . . . 393
Scene 11: Glacial Flour . . . 395
Scene 12: The Return Vector . . . 396
Scene 13: The Holding Pattern . . . 399
Scene 14: The Null Hypothesis . . . 402
The Flight Home . . . 404
Scene 1: The Final Bill . . . 404
Scene 2: The Departure Protocol . . . 406
Scene 3: The Gateway Protocol . . . 408
Scene 4: The Checkpoint Protocol . . . 410
Scene 5: The Soundtrack Protocol . . . 413
Scene 6: The Hub Dilemma . . . 415
Scene 7: The Safety Protocol . . . 416
Scene 8: The Ascent Protocol . . . 418
Scene 9: The Mid-Air Transfer . . . 421
Scene 10: The Descent Protocol . . . 423
Scene 11: The Neon Horizon . . . 426
Scene 12: The Refueling Protocol . . . 429
Scene 13: The Propeller Protocol . . . 431
Scene 14: The Valley Protocol . . . 433
Scene 15: The Final Mile . . . 434
Scene 16: The Shutdown Protocol . . . 437
The Trojan Horse . . . 438
Scene 1: The Invalid Variable . . . 438
Scene 2: The Legal Shield . . . 444
Scene 3: The Null Hypothesis . . . 448
Scene 4: The Restoration . . . 452
The Optimization Protocol . . . 455
Scene 1: The Transaction . . . 455
Scene 2: The Hardware Upgrade . . . 457
Scene 3: The Deed of Trust . . . 460
The Satellite Convergence . . . 463
Scene 1: The Invasion Force . . . 463
Scene 2: The Dungeon . . . 464

Scene 3: The Privacy Protocol 465
Scene 4: Settlement 466
Scene 5: The Throne of Shame 466
Scene 6: The Morning Audit 468
Scene 7: Fueling the Army 471
Scene 8: Division of Labor 473
Scene 9: The Laundry Brigade 474
Scene 10: The Anchor Point 477
Scene 11: The Zero-Privacy Protocol 478
Scene 12: Structural Integrity Test 480
Scene 13: The Rotation of the Guard 482
Scene 14: The Black Box Review 484
Scene 15: Clearance Denied 488
The Big One-Five 496
Scene 1: Trajectory Calculations 496
Scene 2: The Ramp 496
Scene 3: The Arcade Intervention 499
Scene 4: The Carbohydrate Loading 500
Scene 5: Pyrotechnic Redundancy 503
Scene 6: The Voltage Spike 506
Scene 7: The Shutdown Sequence 508
Scene 8: The Photographic Evidence 510
Scene 9: The Platoon Deployment 512
Scene 10: The Decompression Chamber 514

System Integration **517**
The Transfer Point 517
Scene 1: The Pathfinder 517
Scene 2: The Bunker 520
Scene 3: The Heap Protocol 522
Scene 4: The Pressure Check 526
Scene 5: The Migration 527
The Physical Layer 531
Scene 1: The Descent 531
Scene 2: The Search Query 536
Scene 3: The Mega-Bed 539
Scene 4: The Pittsburgh Toilet 541
Scene 5: The Permit Phase 543
Scene 6: The Wet Room 547
Scene 7: The Mega-Bed Assembly 551
The Satellite Link 554
Scene 1: The Radford Protocol 554
Scene 2: The Holding Pattern 559
Scene 3: The Cargo Bay 561
Scene 4: The Mess Hall 564
Scene 5: The Supply Line 567

Scene 6: The Transit Bible 570
The Fishersville Protocol 574
Scene 1: The Last Supper 574
Scene 2: Barnett Hall 575
Scene 3: Suite 200 576
The Signal-to-Noise Ratio 576
Scene 1: The Circuit 576
Scene 2: The Shift Change 577
Scene 3: The PERT Lounge 578
Scene 4: The Carrier Wave 581
Scene 5: The Countdown 583
Scene 6: The Midnight Threshold 584
The Extraction 585
Scene 1: The Pickup 585
Scene 2: The Debrief 586
Scene 3: The Reunion 587
The Closed Circuit 590
Scene 1: The Intruder 590
Scene 2: The Emergency Brake 591
Scene 3: The Exception 592

Freshman Year

Band Camp

Scene 1: The Downbeat

The red numbers on the digital alarm clock flipped from 6:59 to 7:00 AM, accompanied by the harsh, electronic buzz of the radio springing to life. It wasn't music; it was a static-filled Morning Zoo commercial for a local car dealership, shouting about low financing rates.

Freddie groaned, burying his face into the pillow. The sound felt like sandpaper against his eardrums. He tried to retreat into the darkness behind his eyelids, clinging to the phantom logic of a dream he was already forgetting, but the physical world was demanding entry.

Beside him, the mattress shifted. A hand, warm and steady, placed itself gently in the center of his back. It didn't pat him; it just pressed down, a firm, grounding weight that seemed to hold his spine together.

"Time to get up, Freddie," Paige whispered. Her voice was the opposite of the radio—soft, devoid of sharp edges.

Freddie turned his head, squinting against the morning light filtering through the blinds. Paige was already sitting up, her hair a messy halo of sleep. They were fourteen years old, far too old for siblings to be sharing a bed by normal standards, but "normal" had never really applied to the Avery house. Nights

were difficult for Freddie. The silence of the house magnified the ticking of clocks and the settling of the foundation until it sounded like gunfire. Paige was the only thing that made the noise stop. She was his white noise.

"It's summer," Freddie muttered, his voice thick with sleep. "Summer is for sleeping."

"Not anymore," Paige said, sliding out of bed. She stretched, her silhouette mirroring his own frame, just softer. "Today is the day. High school doesn't wait."

Freddie sat up, his legs heavy. His cerebral palsy—spastic diplegia, though he just thought of it as 'bad wiring'—always felt worse in the morning. His muscles were tight, like rubber bands left in the freezer. He rubbed his calves, trying to wake them up.

"Do I have to?" he asked, though he already knew the answer.

"Yes," Paige said, tossing a pair of gym shorts at him. "We're in the Pit. We don't have to march. We just have to hit things with other things. It'll be fine."

Scene 2: Breakfast

Downstairs, the kitchen was already a hub of controlled activity. A small CRT television sat on the counter, humming with the local news, the weather map a pixelated blur of yellow and orange indicating another humid Virginia Beach day.

Jessica stood by the stove, flipping pancakes. She was sixteen, a Junior, and wearing her 'at-home' uniform: oversized t-shirt and athletic shorts. Even this early, she looked awake, her posture straight, her movements efficient. She was the Matriarch in training, the one who made sure the bills were sorted and the cereal bowls were full.

"Eat," Jessica commanded gently as Freddie and Paige shuffled in. She slid two plates onto the table. "Carbohydrates. You're going to need them. It's going to be ninety degrees out there."

Freddie sat down, stabbing a pancake. He looked at Jessica, then at the empty space by the door where instruments usually sat.

"Where's your clarinet case?" Freddie asked.

Jessica poured orange juice into three glasses. "Upstairs."

"But... we're going to band camp." Freddie frowned. The routine was broken. The logic didn't hold. "You're in the band."

"Not until Wednesday," Jessica explained, her voice patient. She knew Freddie needed the schedule to make sense. "Monday and Tuesday are just for Percussion, Colorguard, and the Pit. Winds and Brass don't come in until Wednesday morning."

Freddie paused, processing the data. "So... you're driving us there, but you're not staying?"

"Exactly. I'm the taxi service today. I'll drop you off at eight and pick you up at five."

It bothered him. It felt like walking into a battle without their general. Jessica was the wall between them and the world; she was the one who knew how to talk to adults, how to fill out forms, how to make people stop staring.

"It'll be okay," Paige said, sensing the spike in his anxiety. She nudged his knee with hers under the table. "It's just us and the drummers. Less people. Less noise."

Scene 3: The Section Leader

Paige was wrong. There were not *less* people. Or rather, there were fewer people than the full band, but the people who were there were the loudest human beings Freddie had ever encountered.

Northwood High School was a sprawling brick fortress, and the band room was its cavernous heart. As soon as Jessica dropped them off at the curb—promising to be back at 5:00 PM sharp—the wall of sound hit Freddie like a physical blow.

Inside the band room, fifty kids were unpacking gear. Snares were rattling like machine guns. Bass drums were thumping deep enough to vibrate Freddie's ribcage. The "Pit"—the stationary percussion section up front—was a clutter of xylophones, marimbas, vibraphones, and gongs.

And there, right in the center of the Pit setup behind a massive rosewood marimba, was a chair.

It wasn't a standard folding chair. It was a high-backed, padded drafting chair with a foot ring, looking distinctly out of place among the standing instruments. Mom must have called ahead. Seeing it anchored Freddie. It was a tangible sign that he was allowed to exist here.

He started to make his way toward it, his gait uneven, his spastic muscles fighting the friction of the floor wax. Paige was right beside him, her presence a shield against the sensory chaos.

"Hey! You! Freshman!"

The voice was sharp, cutting through the ambient noise like a piccolo. A girl marched over to them, clipboard clutched to her chest like a weapon. She was a Senior, wearing a shirt that said *PERCUSSION* in aggressive block letters. Her ponytail was pulled back so tight it pulled at her eyelids.

This was Heidi, the Pit Section Leader.

"What do you think you're doing?" Heidi demanded, stepping between Freddie and the marimba.

Freddie froze. "I... I was going to set up."

"Not with that," Heidi snapped, pointing a manicured finger at the drafting chair. "We don't sit in the Pit. We stand. It's about posture. It's about presence. If you sit, the audience can't see you."

"He needs it," Paige interrupted, her voice dropping an octave, becoming dangerous. She stepped slightly in front of Freddie. "He has Cerebral Palsy."

Heidi rolled her eyes, a gesture of supreme teenage annoyance. "Look, everyone's feet hurt, okay? We're all going to be standing for eight hours. It's not fair if he gets a throne just because he doesn't want to work as hard as the rest of us. If you can't stand, you can't march."

"We aren't marching," Paige countered, her fists clenching at her sides. "That's why we're in the Pit."

"It's the principle," Heidi insisted. She grabbed the back of the chair. "I'm moving this. You can stand like everyone else, or you can join the chess club."

The shame hit Freddie harder than the noise. He felt small. The "Architecture" of his safety was collapsing. He looked at his legs, the "bad wiring" that made him different, and wished he could just dissolve into the floor. He wasn't a musician; he was a problem. A logistics issue.

"Heidi."

The name was spoken calmly, but it carried enough weight to stop the room.

Mr. Panoff stood near the office door. He didn't look angry, but he looked serious. The manic energy of the "Morning Zoo" conductor was gone, replaced by the stillness of a teacher who was disappointed.

"Sir," Heidi straightened up, putting on her 'perfect student' mask. "I was just explaining the posture standards to the freshman. We can't have chairs cluttering the visuals."

Mr. Panoff didn't look at the chair. He looked at Heidi. "Heidi, bring your clipboard. Come to my office, please. Now."

"But I need to tune the—"

"Now," Panoff repeated. He looked past her, making direct eye contact with Freddie. His expression softened. He nodded once toward the drafting chair. "Freddie, take your seat. We'll start warm-ups in five minutes."

Heidi flushed pink, her mouth opening and closing like a fish, but she didn't argue. She followed Panoff into the glass-walled office. Through the window, Freddie saw Panoff gesturing—not shouting, but explaining with firm, chopping hand motions. He was dismantling her argument piece by piece.

Freddie let out a breath he didn't know he was holding. He stepped past the invisible line Heidi had drawn and sank into the chair. The padded back support

caught him, holding his spine straight without him having to fight gravity. His legs, already tight from the morning, relaxed against the foot ring.

Paige leaned in, pretending to adjust a mallet bag on the floor next to him.

"She's going to hate us," Freddie whispered, watching the office door.

"Let her," Paige whispered back, her voice fierce. "You have the chair. That's all that matters."

Scene 4: Texture

When Heidi returned five minutes later, she looked chastened. She didn't look at Freddie. She walked stiffly to the vibes, clapped her hands twice, and yelled, "Okay! Warm-ups! Let's go!"

But the chair remained.

For the next hour, the world narrowed down to the keys in front of him. The anxiety that usually buzzed in the back of Freddie's skull—the fear of social cues he was missing, the ambient noise of the room—began to quiet. The marimba made sense.

"Mallets up!" Heidi barked, though the bite was gone from her voice.

Freddie raised the yarn-wrapped sticks. From his seated position, the marimba was at the perfect height. He didn't have to hunch; he didn't have to lock his knees.

"Hit the bar in the center," Mr. Panoff instructed, wandering out of his office and back into the flow of the room. "Do not kill the bar. Pull the sound *out* of it."

Freddie struck the C key.

Thump.

It wasn't just a sound; it was a physical sensation. The vibration traveled up the mallet shaft, through his wrists, and settled somewhere behind his sternum. It was a warm, woody resonance that felt clean. Unlike the jagged screech of the feedback loop or the chaotic clatter of the drumline, this sound had a shape. It was round.

"Again," Panoff commanded.

Freddie hit it again. *Thump.*

The patterns emerged. C went to D. D went to E. There were no hidden meanings, no sarcasm, no subtext. It was a binary system of *hit* or *rest*.

"You're good at this," Paige whispered during a water break. She was leaning against her vibraphone, wiping sweat from her forehead.

“It’s just patterns,” Freddie said, looking at the keys. He spun slightly in his chair, the swivel mechanism silent and smooth. “It’s just a grid.”

“It’s an architecture,” Paige corrected softly, using the word he used for his internal world. “You’re building the sound.”

Freddie smiled. It was the first time that morning his smile reached his eyes. He looked over at Heidi, who was aggressively tuning a timpani, ignoring him completely. It didn’t matter. He had his chair. He had his sister. And now, he had the rhythm.

“Yeah,” Freddie said, gripping the mallets. “I can build this.”

Scene 5: The File

By noon, the humidity had breached the band room walls, making the air thick and heavy, but Freddie was still sitting upright.

The drafting chair was a miracle. While the other freshmen were shifting their weight from foot to foot, grimacing as the blood pooled in their heels, Freddie was stable. He had spent the last three hours learning the warm-up packet—a series of exercises called “Eight on a Hand” and “Accent Tap.”

Heidi was still angry, but she had shifted from vocal confrontation to aggressive silence. She communicated with the rest of the Pit using words; she communicated with Freddie by pointing at things or slamming music sheets onto his stand.

“Lunch break!” Panoff announced, checking his watch. “One hour. Be back at one o’clock, watered and ready to sweat.”

As the room dissolved into the chaos of teenagers scrambling for their bags, Freddie stayed in his chair for a moment, letting his arms hang loose. His wrists were sore, but his legs—usually burning by this time of day—felt fine.

“Avery,” Mr. Panoff called out.

Freddie tensed. He saw Heidi pause near the door, her ears practically swiveling around to catch the conversation.

Mr. Panoff walked over to the marimba, holding a manila folder. He didn’t look like he was about to scold anyone; he looked administrative.

“I just wanted to double-check that the height is working for you,” Panoff said, tapping the back of the drafting chair. “Your mom called the main office last week to make sure the paperwork came over from Pope Middle.”

Freddie nodded. “It’s perfect. Thank you.”

“Good. The file from Pope was very specific,” Panoff said, opening the folder briefly. Freddie caught a glimpse of official-looking forms—the accommodations his parents had fought for since elementary school. The transfer from Pope

Middle to Northwood was supposed to be seamless, just a matter of moving a file from one cabinet in the city to another, but Freddie knew his mother hadn't left it to chance. She had ensured the "system" followed him.

"We don't want you burning out in the first week," Panoff continued, closing the folder. "If the section leader gives you any more grief about the seating arrangement, you send her to me. The chair is non-negotiable. It's in the file."

Heidi, realizing there would be no vindication for her, pushed the door open and stormed out into the hallway.

Paige appeared at Freddie's elbow, handing him his lunch bag. "See? Mom and Dad handled it."

"Yeah," Freddie said, sliding off the chair. He felt steady on his feet. The chair hadn't just saved his energy; it had legitimized his presence. He wasn't breaking the rules; he was following a different set of them, written down in ink in a file from Pope Middle School.

"Come on," Paige said, hooking her arm through his. "Let's go find a quiet place to eat. I think I saw a tree outside that isn't surrounded by drummers."

"A tree sounds good," Freddie agreed. He looked back at the drafting chair one last time—his fortress in the middle of the battlefield—and followed his sister out into the sun.

Scene 6: Rocket Burger

The tree Paige had found offered shade, but it didn't stop the humidity. The air was a wet blanket, heavy with the drone of cicadas and the distant rattle of snare drums. Freddie sat at the base of the oak, legs stretched out to prevent cramping, while Paige unpacked a sandwich.

A car horn honked—two short, authoritative bursts.

Freddie looked up. Idling at the curb of the bus loop was the family van. The passenger window rolled down, and Jessica leaned out. She was sitting in the front passenger seat, wearing sunglasses that made her look impossibly cool for sixteen. Behind the wheel was their mother, Ellen.

"Get in," Jessica called out. "We're busting you out."

"Busting us out?" Freddie asked, grabbing Paige's hand so she could hoist him up. "We aren't allowed to leave campus. It's a closed camp."

"It's closed unless a parent signs you out," Ellen said, leaning across Jessica to smile at them. "I have the day off, and I am not letting you eat warm bologna on your first day. Get in. We're going to Rocket Burger."

Freddie and Paige climbed into the backseat, the blast of the van's air conditioning hitting them like a blessing. As they pulled away, Freddie saw the other freshmen watching them with envy. The rule was strict—once you were dropped off,

you stayed until five—but the "Parental Override" was the one loophole in the system.

Five minutes later, they were sitting in a red vinyl booth inside Rocket Burger. The smell of grease, salt, and sanitizer was comforting. It was a sensory environment Freddie understood perfectly.

"So," Ellen said, unwrapping her burger. She looked at Freddie with that scanning, maternal gaze that checked for injuries or distress. "How was the morning? Did the noise get to be too much?"

"The noise was fine," Freddie said, dipping a fry into a puddle of ketchup. "The people were the problem. Specifically, a girl named Heidi."

Ellen's eyebrows shot up. "Heidi? Is that the section leader?"

"She tried to take my chair away," Freddie said, the indignation flaring up again in his chest. "I walked in, and she told me I had to stand because of 'visuals.' She said it wasn't fair that I got to sit."

Ellen stopped chewing. Her face went hard—the same expression she wore during IEP meetings when administrators tried to cut corners. "She did what?"

"It's okay," Freddie added quickly, seeing the storm gathering. "Mr. Panoff stopped her. He called her into his office and showed her the file from Pope Middle. He told her the chair was non-negotiable."

Ellen relaxed, but only slightly. "Good. That file is there for a reason. I don't want you hurting yourself just to look like everyone else."

Jessica, who was stealing fries from Freddie's tray despite having her own, let out a loud snort. "Mom, you don't have to worry about Heidi. Everyone hates her."

"Everyone?" Ellen asked.

"Everyone," Jessica confirmed. "The clarinets hate her. The trumpets hate her. Even the other percussionists can't stand her. She's been bossy since freshman year, but ever since she got the Section Leader badge, the power went straight to her head. She thinks she's the band director."

"Why did Mr. Panoff give her the job if she's terrible?" Freddie asked. It didn't make sense. The architecture of leadership should be built on competence and respect, not tyranny.

"Because it was the only way to get her to shut up," Jessica explained, pointing a fry at him for emphasis. "If she wasn't Section Leader, she would be complaining from the back row every five seconds. Panoff figured if he gave her a title, she'd be too busy micromanaging you guys to bother him. It's a containment strategy."

"So, she's a problem he delegated to us," Freddie muttered.

"Exactly," Jessica said. "But now you know. She's not powerful, Freddie. She's just loud. And the rest of the band is on your side. You just have to survive her."

Freddie looked at Paige, who was quietly eating her cheeseburger, content to let the others talk. Survival. That was the theme of the family.

"I can do that," Freddie said, taking a bite of his burger. The "Spoons" were returning to his body with every calorie. "As long as I have my chair, she can yell all she wants."

Scene 7: The Connection

The air conditioning of the family van was a sanctuary they were reluctant to leave, but the digital clock on the dashboard read 12:55 PM.

"Go," Ellen said, unlocking the doors. "Hydrate. And ignore the girl."

"We will," Freddie promised.

Jessica hopped out of the front seat. She wasn't staying for the afternoon block—her clarinets didn't report until Wednesday—but she smoothed her oversized t-shirt and adjusted her glasses with the focused demeanor of someone clocking in for a shift.

"I'm walking you in," Jessica said, slinging her purse over her shoulder. "I need to talk to Panoff about the section leader binders for the woodwinds."

The three of them walked into the band room together. The chaos had returned, the room vibrating with the sound of fifty teenagers digesting fast food and slamming locker doors.

Heidi was standing near the marimba, holding her clipboard like a shield. She looked ready to pounce. Her eyes locked onto Freddie's drafting chair, and her mouth opened, likely to make a comment about how it was taking up too much space or ruining the aesthetic of the setup.

Then, she saw Jessica.

Heidi froze. Her eyes darted from Freddie, to Paige, to Jessica, and then back to Freddie. It was a visible calculation. A connection was being made in real-time.

"Jessica?" Heidi said, her voice pitching up into a tone Freddie recognized immediately. It was the "Teacher Voice" used by students who wanted extra credit. "I didn't know you were coming in today!"

"Just dropping off the twins," Jessica said coolly, placing a hand on Freddie's shoulder. It was a claiming gesture. "And I need to check the roster with Panoff."

Heidi's face went through a rapid transformation. The scowl vanished, replaced by a wide, plastic smile that didn't reach her eyes.

"The twins?" Heidi repeated, looking at Freddie and Paige as if seeing them for the first time. "Oh my gosh! I didn't realize they were *your* siblings! Avery! Of course! I should have put that together."

Freddie watched the performance with fascination. It was like watching a computer program crash and reboot into a different operating system.

"Yeah," Paige said, her voice dry. "We're the Averys."

"Well!" Heidi clapped her hands together, beaming at Freddie. "We are so lucky to have them in the Pit. Freddie has great hands! Really great texture." She looked at the drafting chair, the object of her rage only an hour ago. "And I'm so glad we got the seating sorted out. We want you to be comfortable, Freddie. Seriously, if you need a water break or if the sun glare hits you through the window, just let me know."

Freddie blinked. The falseness of it was almost physically painful. It was a frequency that grated on his nerves more than the snare drums. He preferred the hostility; at least the hostility was honest.

"I'm fine," Freddie said, looking at his mallets.

"Great! Just great," Heidi chirped. She turned back to Jessica. "So, are you excited for the woodwinds on Wednesday? I was telling the drumline, we really need to coordinate our sectionals this year. . . "

Jessica nodded politely, but her posture remained the unshakable foundation of the family. She saw right through it. "We'll see, Heidi. I need to catch Panoff before he gets sucked into a drill writing session. I'll see you later."

"Bye, Jessica!" Heidi waved enthusiastically.

As Jessica walked toward the office, the air around the marimba changed. Heidi was still smiling, but she looked nervous now. She busied herself with straightening a stack of music stands, giving Freddie and Paige a wide berth.

"She's terrified of her," Paige whispered, picking up her mallets.

"She should be," Freddie whispered back, adjusting his height on the chair.

He watched Jessica knock on the glass door of Mr. Panoff's office. Panoff looked up, saw her, and waved her in immediately, smiling. It was clear who held the actual respect in the room.

Freddie took a breath, feeling the tension in his shoulders dissolve. The social architecture of the band room had just revealed its load-bearing walls, and fortunately for him, his sister was one of them.

"Okay, Pit!" Heidi announced, though her voice was significantly less shrill than it had been at 8:00 AM. "Let's run the warm-ups. From the top!"

Freddie hit the first note of the exercise. It rang out clear and true. He was safe.

Scene 8: The Overwatch

When the door to Mr. Panoff's office opened, Freddie expected Jessica to walk straight out of the band room and toward the parking lot to wait for their mother. The air conditioning in the office was fierce, and the band room was rapidly becoming a sauna of teenage sweat and humidity.

Instead, Jessica walked over to the stack of surplus chairs near the wall—about ten feet away from the Pit setup—and pulled one down. She placed it carefully, angled so she had a clear line of sight to the marimbas and the vibraphones, but far enough away that she wasn't technically "in" the rehearsal space.

She sat down, crossed her legs, and opened a paperback novel she had pulled from her purse.

"Okay, let's reset!" Heidi called out. Her voice, usually a weaponized shriek by 2:00 PM, was now coated in a layer of sugary artificiality. She glanced nervously at Jessica, who didn't look up from her book but turned a page with deliberate slowness.

The effect was instantaneous.

Usually, the afternoon block was when Heidi's patience snapped. It was when she would single out a freshman for holding a stick wrong or for missing a visual cue. But today, with the Clarinet Section Leader acting as a silent sentinel in the corner, Heidi was a model of encouragement.

"Great wrist rotation, Kevin!" Heidi chirped to a freshman boy on the xylophone whom she had terrified into silence that morning. "Really nice rebound!"

Kevin looked confused, then relieved. He looked over at Jessica, realizing the correlation.

Freddie caught Paige's eye across the instruments. She gave a microscopic nod. *She's the firewall,* the nod said.

The presence of the "Matriarch" changed the physics of the room. It wasn't just Freddie and Paige who were safe; the protection extended to the entire freshman class of the Pit. Jessica was the variable that balanced the equation. As long as she was sitting there, turning pages and occasionally glancing over her glasses to scan the room, Heidi couldn't be the tyrant she wanted to be.

"Let's try that run one more time," Heidi said, her smile fixed and rigid. "And remember to breathe! We want to be relaxed!"

Freddie struck the bars of the marimba, feeling a new kind of ease. He didn't have to watch his back. He didn't have to worry about his chair being snatched away or his posture being critiqued for the sake of "visuals."

He looked at Jessica again. She wasn't even looking at them; she was completely absorbed in her book. But Freddie knew better. She was the "Control Group."

She was monitoring the environment, regulating the temperature of the room just by existing in it.

The afternoon, which had loomed ahead of them like an endurance test, suddenly felt manageable. They weren't just surviving the day; thanks to the girl in the corner with the paperback book, they were actually going to learn the music.

Scene 9: The All Clear

"Band! Detail, ten-hut!"

Mr. Panoff's voice cracked like a whip across the room.

Hut!

The response was a single, deafening syllable shouted by fifty voices in perfect unison. It was followed immediately by the sharp *crack* of heels snapping together (or a heavy thud, in the case of the tired freshmen). Freddie braced himself for the noise, but because it was synchronized—because he knew exactly when it was coming—it didn't hurt. It was just another pattern.

"Band, dismissed!"

The formation broke instantly. The room dissolved into a cacophony of zippers, velcro, and teenagers groaning as they stretched sore muscles. The first day of camp was over.

Freddie remained in his chair for a second longer than necessary, letting the adrenaline drain out of his system. He had made it. He had played the right notes, he had kept the rhythm, and most importantly, he hadn't fallen over.

Heidi stood by the equipment locker, aggressively wrapping a pair of yarn mallets. Her knuckles were white. She kept shooting glances toward the corner of the room where Jessica was calmly putting her bookmark into her novel. Heidi looked like a pressure cooker waiting to explode; she wanted to scream at someone—anyone—to re-stack a vibraphone or straighten a cover, but she couldn't. The "Matriarch" was watching.

"Good work today, Pit," Heidi said, the words sounding forced, like they were being squeezed out of a tube. She didn't look at Freddie. "See you all at 8:00 AM sharp."

Jessica stood up, slinging her purse over her shoulder. She walked over to the marimba, not as a sister, but as a senior officer inspecting the troops. She looked at Heidi.

"See you Wednesday, Heidi," Jessica said pleasantly.

Heidi's smile twitched. "See you, Jessica."

Freddie slid off the drafting chair. His legs felt heavy, the "bad wiring" stiff from the transition, but before he could sway, Paige was there. She didn't ask; she

just wrapped her arm around his waist, hooking her hand on his belt loop. It was a physical anchor.

"We're out," Paige whispered. "Load complete."

They walked out of the double doors, flanked by Jessica. The heat of the parking lot hit them, a humid wall of 5:00 PM Virginia air, but it felt like freedom.

Waiting in the bus loop, idling like a massive blue whale among the smaller sedans, was the family van. It was a 15-passenger Holt Club Wagon—the only vehicle capable of transporting the "Avery Corporation."

The side door slid open with a heavy mechanical rumble.

"Survivors!" a voice shouted from the back row. It was Harper, seven years old and already loud. She was bouncing in her seat, wearing purple headphones around her neck.

Behind the wheel was their father, Robert. He looked tired—he had likely come straight from work—but he grinned as he saw them. Beside him, Ellen turned in the passenger seat.

"Get in, get in!" Robert called out over the engine. "We're burning gas!"

Freddie climbed in, Paige right behind him. The van was chaos, but it was *their* chaos. In the middle rows, ten-year-old Sarah was furiously reorganizing a stack of coloring books that Jenna, her twin, had knocked over. In the far back, four-year-old twins Amanda and Elara were strapped into their car seats; Amanda was staring silently out the window, while Elara was narrating everything she saw in the parking lot at high speed.

"Did you march? Did you play drums? Did you see the teacher?" Elara fired off the questions before the door was even closed.

"We played the big xylophones," Paige answered, buckling her seatbelt next to Freddie. "And we sat down."

"Victory," Robert said, checking the rearview mirror. "So, where are we going? It's a celebration. We survived Day One."

"Gus's," Jessica said, claiming the bench seat behind the parents. "We need real food."

"Gus's it is," Robert agreed, shifting the massive van into drive.

Gus's Grille was a small, locally-owned spot tucked into a strip mall on Independence Boulevard. It had vinyl booths, checkered floors, and waitresses who called everyone "sugar." It was loud, but it was the good kind of loud—clinking silverware and frying grease, not snare drums and judgments.

As the van pulled out of the school lot, leaving the brick fortress of Northwood High behind, Freddie leaned his head back against the seat. Paige kept her hand

on his arm, a constant reminder that he was grounded, he was safe, and the day was done.

"Heidi didn't say a word," Freddie said quietly to Jessica.

Jessica smirked, looking out the window at the passing cars. "Of course she didn't. She knows the hierarchy."

Freddie closed his eyes, listening to Elara explain the concept of a 'green light' to a silent Amanda in the back row. The architecture of the family was complex, noisy, and crowded, but it held up. It was the only structure that truly worked.

Scene 10: The Table

Gus's Grille was a sensory experience that Freddie usually found challenging, but tonight, it felt like a victory lap. The restaurant was a long, narrow establishment with black-and-white checkered floors and red vinyl booths that squeaked when you sat on them. It smelled of frying oil, coffee, and lemon polish.

"Party of ten!" Robert announced to the hostess, a woman named Barb who had seen the Avery clan grow from a manageable quartet to a small army over the last decade.

"I'll put two tables together in the back, hon," Barb said, grabbing a handful of laminated menus.

The logistics of seating the Avery family were complex. It required a strategy that rivaled the marching band's drill charts.

Robert and Ellen took the ends of the long, improvised table. Jessica sat near the middle, acting as the peacekeeper between the younger sets of twins. Sarah and Jenna (age 10) were immediately engaged in a silent, high-stakes battle over who got the salt shaker. Harper (age 7) was vibrating with energy, her purple headphones pulled down around her neck, loudly explaining the plot of a cartoon to anyone who would listen.

Freddie slid into the booth side against the wall. Paige slid in next to him, effectively trapping him in the corner. This was calculated. It meant Freddie only had to defend one side. He didn't have to worry about waiters bumping his chair or people walking behind him. He was encased in the "Safe Zone."

"So," Robert said, opening his menu. "High school. Big league. How bad was it?"

"It was loud," Freddie admitted, picking up a crayon to doodle on the paper placemat. He drew a series of squares—the keys of the marimba. "But the math is good."

"Math?" Robert asked, raising an eyebrow.

"The rhythm," Paige translated, pouring water from a pitcher into Freddie's glass. "Mr. Panoff says music is just math in time. Freddie likes the grid."

"And the chair?" Ellen asked, looking over the top of her menu. "No more issues with the section leader?"

"Jessica handled it," Freddie said, shading in the squares.

All eyes turned to Jessica. She didn't look up from her menu. "I didn't do anything. I just read my book."

"She sat in the corner and terrified Heidi with her aura," Paige corrected, smirking. "It was beautiful."

The waitress arrived to take their drink orders. This was usually the point where the noise level spiked, but the family had a system. They ordered in age order, descending.

"Cola," Jessica said. "Lemon-Lime," Paige said. "Lemon-Lime," Freddie repeated (he always ordered what Paige ordered to minimize decision fatigue). "Root Beer!" Jenna shouted. "Water," Sarah corrected, moving the soda away from her twin.

As the order went around the table, Freddie leaned back against the vinyl seat. The "Spoons" were low, but they weren't gone. The drafting chair had saved his back, and Paige had saved his mind.

He looked at his father, who was currently trying to stop four-year-old Elara from climbing onto the table to reach the basket of rolls. He looked at Amanda, the silent twin, who was methodically tearing a napkin into perfect, identical strips.

This was his unit. The band was a new system, a new architecture he had to learn, but this table was the foundation.

"I think I can do this," Freddie said quietly, more to himself than anyone else.

Paige heard him. She bumped his shoulder with hers. "I know you can. We're just hitting things with sticks, remember?"

"Texture," Freddie whispered, drawing a final line on his placemat. "It's all about texture."

The Fall

Scene 1: Third Quarter

Friday nights in Virginia Beach were a religion, and the Northwood High School football stadium was the cathedral. The air smelled of popcorn, diesel fumes from the buses, and the ozone of impending rain.

For Freddie, the stadium was a sensory minefield. The lights were too bright, buzzing with a high-pitched frequency that only he seemed to hear. The crowd noise was a chaotic ocean of screaming, stomping, and air horns.

He sat on the metal bleachers in the designated Band Section, clutching his sketchbook like a shield. Paige sat right next to him, their shoulders touching. She wasn't drawing; she was just being there, a physical anchor preventing him from floating away into the noise.

"Break time!" Mr. Panoff's voice boomed through a megaphone. "Be back in your seats by the start of the Fourth! Do not make me come find you at the nacho cheese pump!"

Freddie exhaled, opening his sketchbook to a fresh page. He began to draw. It wasn't the football field; it was a schematic for a starship engine, a complex cylinder of rings and intake valves.

"That's really cool."

Freddie looked up, blinking against the stadium lights.

Sitting in the row below them was a girl from the Color Guard. She was wearing the sequined tunic of her uniform, her flag bag resting at her feet. She had bright eyes and a smile that seemed to ignore the social barrier between the "cool" Guard and the "nerdy" Pit.

"I'm Courtney," she said, leaning her chin on the back of the bleacher seat. She looked at Freddie, then at Paige, and smiled. "You guys are the Avery twins, right? The ones in the Pit?"

"Yeah," Paige said, offering a friendly smile. "I'm Paige. This is Freddie."

Courtney looked back at the sketchbook. "Is that... like, a car engine?"

"It's a warp drive," Freddie corrected automatically, his voice quiet. He tensed, expecting the mockery that usually followed.

But Courtney didn't laugh. She tilted her head. "A warp drive. Like Stellar Voyage? I love that show. My dad watches it."

Freddie felt a flush of warmth. She liked Stellar Voyage. She liked his drawing.

"It's for a story," Freddie said, relaxing slightly against Paige. "About a ship that travels through music frequencies."

"That is so weird," Courtney smiled, and this time, the word weird sounded like a compliment. "You're really talented, Freddie."

"Avery crew!"

Jessica appeared at the end of the row. She wasn't barking orders; she looked relieved to see them. She stepped into the row and wrapped an arm around Freddie's shoulders, pulling him into a gentle side-hug.

"You doing okay with the noise?" Jessica asked softly, ignoring the crowd around them.

"I'm okay," Freddie said, leaning into his older sister's embrace. "Paige is blocking the speakers."

Courtney watched the interaction—the protective sister, the gentle hug, the obvious closeness of the three siblings. She didn't look weirded out. She looked like she thought it was sweet.

"Concession run," Jessica announced, releasing him but keeping a hand on his back to guide him. "Dad's holding fries for us."

Courtney pulled back to let them pass, giving Freddie a small wave. "See you later, Space Man. Bye, Paige!"

"Bye!" Paige waved.

As they walked down the metal steps, Freddie felt lighter. "She was nice," he whispered to Paige.

"She was," Paige agreed. "She didn't mind the hugging."

The concession stand was a cinderblock bunker located under the home stands. It was the hub of social activity for the entire school, but for the Averys, it was family territory.

Behind the counter, moving with the efficiency of a short-order cook, was their father, Robert. He was wearing a grease-stained apron over his work clothes, shouting orders to a terrified freshman volunteer.

"Two hot dogs, one pretzel, large Mega-Cola!" Robert yelled, then looked up and saw his children approaching the window. His face brightened. "VIPs inbound!"

"Hi, Dad," Paige said, leaning on the counter. "We need fuel."

"I saw the halftime show," Robert said, sliding a tray of fresh fries toward them before they even ordered. "Pit looked tight. Freddie, you were right on the beat with the tympani."

"Thanks," Freddie said, grabbing a fry. He felt safe here. The concession stand was loud, but it was managed noise. His father was in control.

"Where's Mom?" Jessica asked, looking around the crowded plaza.

"She's in the stands with Harper and the twins," Robert said, wiping his hands on a rag. "She'll be down in a minute. Harper wants Rainbow Drops."

As they stood there eating their fries, a boy wearing a snare drum harness walked up. He had the confident swagger of someone who knew he was at the top of the band hierarchy. This was Jason, a Sophomore on the drumline. He had been eyeing Paige during rehearsals all week.

"Hey, babe," Jason said, leaning his elbow on the counter next to Paige, invading her personal space.

Paige stiffened instantly. She hated being called "babe."

"My name is Paige," she said, her voice flat.

"Feisty," Jason smirked, ignoring the correction. He looked at Freddie, who was staring at the ground, rocking slightly on his heels. The buzzer for the end of a timeout sounded—a harsh, electronic grind that spiked Freddie's anxiety.

Freddie flinched, shifting his weight and moving closer to Paige. He reached out, needing the contact to recalibrate.

Paige immediately turned, opening her arms to wrap him in a firm, grounding hug. She squeezed his shoulders, applying the deep pressure he needed to stop the world from spinning.

Jason's hand shot out, grabbing Paige's shoulder to pull her back.

"Whoa, babe," Jason laughed, stepping between them. "Give him some space. He's a big boy, right? He doesn't need his sister cuddling him in front of the whole school. It looks weird."

The air around the concession stand seemed to drop ten degrees.

Paige pulled away from Jason's grip as if she had been burned. She looked at him, then at Freddie, who looked terrified that he had done something wrong.

"He is regulating," Paige said, her voice turning dangerous. "Get your hand off me."

"I'm just saying," Jason chuckled, looking around for support. "You guys are in high school now. You gotta cut the cord. It's embarrassing."

"Jason," Jessica's voice cut through the noise like a blade. She stepped forward, holding her soda like a weapon. "You're a snare drummer, right?"

"Yeah," Jason puffed up his chest, looking at the older sister. "Section leader next year, probably."

"Cool," Jessica said, her eyes narrowing behind her glasses. "Then you should know about rhythm. And right now, you are completely out of time."

Jason frowned. "I'm just trying to help him man up."

Paige stepped fully in front of Freddie, shielding him. "He doesn't need your help. And I don't need a boyfriend who acts like a jerk. Go pound sand, Jason."

Jason's mouth fell open. He had expected a giggle, or maybe a shy deflection. He hadn't expected a wall. "Whatever," he muttered, backing away with a bruised ego. "You guys are freaks anyway."

He disappeared into the crowd.

Freddie let out a shaky breath. He looked past Paige and saw Courtney standing a few feet away, waiting for a pretzel. She had seen the whole thing.

Freddie froze, expecting the judgment Jason had promised.

Courtney just smiled at him. She looked at Paige, then at Freddie, and gave a small, respectful nod. She didn't look embarrassed for him; she looked like she was glad Jason was gone.

Paige turned back to Freddie, ignoring the crowd, and wrapped him in the hug Jason had tried to stop. She squeezed hard, grounding him back to the earth.

"You okay?" she whispered.

"Yeah," Freddie whispered back, the tension leaving his spine. "He's gone."

"He's history," Paige promised.

Scene 2: The Signal

The crowd at the concession stand flowed around them like a river around a rock, but the space where Jason had stood felt strangely empty.

"He's an idiot," Jessica declared, taking a long sip of her Mega-Cola. She adjusted her glasses, her eyes tracking Jason's retreating figure as he disappeared toward the drumline equipment truck. "He thinks volume equals personality. Common percussion error."

Paige didn't say anything. She just kept her arm around Freddie, her breathing synchronizing with his. She was shaken—not by Jason's rejection, but by the threat he had posed to the "System."

Freddie looked down at his fries. They were cold now. The encounter had drained his "Spoons," leaving him feeling heavy and brittle. He expected the world to be looking at him, judging him for needing his sister to fight his battles.

"Hey."

A voice spoke from his left. It wasn't loud, and it wasn't mocking.

Freddie turned. Courtney was standing at the condiment station, squirting yellow mustard onto a pretzel. She wasn't looking at the crowd; she was looking at him.

"Don't worry about Jason," Courtney said, capping the mustard bottle. "He yells at the freshmen for breathing wrong. He's just noise."

Freddie blinked. She had used the exact same word Paige had used. Noise.

"He said it was weird," Freddie mumbled, looking at Paige's arm still wrapped around his waist.

Courtney shrugged, tearing a piece off her pretzel. "My little brother is ten. He still crawls into my bed when it thunders. Siblings are supposed to have each other's backs. It's not weird. It's lucky."

She smiled at Paige. "You guys are lucky."

Paige's expression softened instantly. The defensive wall she had erected against Jason crumbled. "Thanks, Courtney."

"Anyway," Courtney turned back to Freddie, her eyes bright. "Bring that sketchbook back to the stands? I want to see the rest of the engine. The warp drive thing."

"Okay," Freddie whispered. "I will."

"Cool. See you up there, Space Man." She gave a little salute with her pretzel and walked back toward the stadium tunnel.

Freddie watched her go. The anxiety that Jason had spiked in his chest was replaced by something else—a fluttering, warm sensation that felt like a major chord resolving.

"She stayed," Freddie said, almost to himself.

"She did," Jessica noted, sounding surprised. She looked at Paige. "She seems... adequate."

"She's nice," Paige agreed, finally letting go of Freddie's waist now that the threat was neutralized. "She didn't care about the hug."

"She liked the drawing," Freddie added. He looked at his hands, which had been trembling moments ago, and realized they were steady.

Jessica checked her watch. "Fourth Quarter is starting. We need to get back before Panoff notices the percussion section is missing its bottom end."

They walked back up the concrete ramp toward the stadium lights. Usually, the transition from the dim concession tunnel to the bright, screaming bowl of the stadium was painful for Freddie. But tonight, he didn't flinch. He walked with his head up, clutching his sketchbook, looking for the girl in the sequined tunic who thought his warp drive was cool.

For the first time in high school, the signal was stronger than the noise.

Winter 2000

Scene 1: The Visitor

Christmas Day in the Avery household was less of a holiday and more of a logistical event. With eight children, the living room floor was a sea of torn wrapping paper, cardboard boxes, and tangled ribbons.

Freddie, usually sensitive to the visual chaos, didn't mind it today. He was too focused on the clock.

It was 11:55 AM.

He stood near the front door, wearing a nice sweater that Paige had picked out for him. He was shifting his weight from foot to foot, his leg muscles tight with

anticipation, but he refused to sit down.

"She said twelve, right?" Freddie asked, checking his watch for the third time in a minute.

"She said twelve," Paige confirmed from the couch, where she was helping four-year-old Amanda assemble a plastic farm set. "Relax, Freddie. She's coming."

Freddie took a deep breath. It was hard to process the magnitude of this event. A girl—who was not his sister, not his cousin, but a girl from school who chose to spend time with him—was coming to his house. On Christmas.

At 12:01 PM, the doorbell rang.

Freddie didn't wait. He pulled the door open immediately.

Courtney stood on the porch, wrapped in a thick wool coat and a scarf that matched the color of the Northwood Color Guard uniforms. Her cheeks were flushed from the cold, and she was holding a small gift bag.

"Merry Christmas, Freddie!" she beamed.

The excitement that had been building in Freddie's chest since dawn released all at once. He forgot about being cool. He forgot about social rules. He stepped out onto the porch and wrapped his arms around her in a fierce, tight hug.

He squeezed her, pouring all his gratitude into the pressure. He was just so happy she was real, that she was here.

For a split second, he worried he had squeezed too hard, but Courtney laughed and hugged him back, patting his shoulder with a gloved hand.

"It is good to see you, too, Space Man," she said, stepping back as he let go.

"Come in," Freddie said, ushering her into the warmth. "Everyone is here."

Courtney stepped into the foyer and stopped, her eyes widening as she took in the scene. The "Avery Corporation" was in full swing. Harper was running loops around the sofa with her new headphones on. Sarah and Jenna were arguing over a board game. Jessica was methodically folding wrapping paper for recycling. The babies, Amanda and Elara, were surrounded by piles of blocks.

"Wow," Courtney whispered, smiling. "It's... a lot."

"It's the system," Freddie explained, closing the door.

Jessica stood up and walked over, offering a polite smile. "Hello, Courtney. Welcome to the madness. Can I take your coat?"

"Thanks, Jessica," Courtney said, handing it over. "It's nice to meet everyone. Freddie talks about you guys all the time."

She looked at the younger siblings, who had paused their chaos to stare at the newcomer. Courtney didn't look overwhelmed; she looked charmed. She waved at Harper, who shyly waved back.

"Come to the tree," Freddie said, guiding her through the obstacle course of toys.

They stood in front of the massive Douglas Fir, which was struggling to hold up the sheer volume of ornaments the family had collected over the years.

"I have something for you," Freddie said, reaching under the tree for a small, flat package wrapped in silver paper.

"Me first," Courtney said, handing him her gift bag.

Freddie opened it. Inside was a set of high-quality, fine-point ink pens—the kind draftsmen used.

"For the engine schematics," Courtney said. "So the lines stay clean."

Freddie looked at the pens, then at her. It was a perfect gift. It meant she listened. "Thank you," he whispered. He handed her his package.

She unwrapped it carefully. It was a framed drawing—not of a starship, but of a singular, perfect snowflake, drawn with geometric precision. At the bottom, in his neatest handwriting, it said: Every pattern is unique.

"Freddie," Courtney said softly, touching the glass. "This is beautiful."

"Picture!" Ellen called out, appearing with the family camera.

It was a brand-new Lumina Z-90, a bulky point-and-shoot marvel that Robert had bought for Christmas. It boasted a motorized zoom lens that buzzed like an angry insect as Ellen framed the shot, and inside was a fresh roll of SpectraChrome 400—the good film, the kind that promised to capture the greens of summers and the reds of the holidays with vivid clarity.

Freddie stood next to Courtney. Without hesitation, she leaned into him, resting her head lightly against his shoulder.

Freddie felt a surge of boldness—a rare impulse to secure the moment physically. He lifted his arm and, somewhat awkwardly but firmly, placed it around her shoulders. He felt the wool of her coat under his hand. She didn't pull away; instead, she adjusted her stance, leaning into his side to fit perfectly against him.

Freddie smiled—a genuine, unforced smile that reached his eyes.

Click-whirrrrr.

The flash blinded them for a second, followed immediately by the mechanical whine of the camera automatically winding the film to the next exposure.

That sound—the whirrrrr—was the sound of a memory being physically etched onto silver halide crystals. Freddie blinked the spots from his eyes, already thinking about the future. He would have to wait. They would have to take the roll to the pharmacy down on Kempsville Road, wait three days for the lab to process it, and then flip through the packet of glossy 4x6 prints.

But the wait made it valuable. Somewhere inside that plastic black box, on a strip of SpectraChrome, this moment existed forever.

"I can't stay long," Courtney said apologetically, stepping out of the pose but giving Freddie's waist a quick squeeze before letting go. "My aunt and uncle are in town, and we have a big lunch at one."

"That is okay," Freddie said, his arm feeling strangely light now that she wasn't under it. "I am just glad you came."

"Me too," Courtney said. She looked around the room one last time, watching Paige help Elara stack a tower of blocks. "You're lucky, Freddie. To have all of this. It's a good crew."

"Yeah," Freddie agreed, looking at his sisters. "They keep me grounded."

Courtney squeezed his hand—a quick, secret signal like they had in the movie theater. "Merry Christmas, Freddie."

"Merry Christmas, Courtney."

He watched her walk back to her car, waving until she turned the corner. He stood in the doorway for a long time, clutching the pens, thinking about the roll of film sitting on the kitchen counter. He couldn't wait to see it. He couldn't wait to see the proof that, for one Christmas, he wasn't just the boy in the chair or the kid in the Pit—he was the boy with his arm around the girl.

Scene 2: The Confrontation

The first week back after Winter Break always felt like a reboot. The school smelled of damp wool coats and cleaning fluid. Outside, the Virginia sky was a flat, miserable gray, leaking a freezing rain that turned the sidewalks into slush.

But Freddie did not mind the cold. He was carrying a piece of the sun in his pocket.

It was a 4x6 glossy print, picked up from the pharmacy the day before. The colors were vibrant—the green of the Douglas Fir, the silver of the tinsel, and the two of them standing together. In the photo, Freddie looked confident, his arm around Courtney's shoulder, and she was leaning into him, safe and happy.

He walked into the band hallway on Tuesday afternoon, his thumb brushing the edge of the photo in his pocket. He couldn't wait to give it to her. He had put it in a protective plastic sleeve so it wouldn't get bent.

He spotted her near the trophy case, talking to two other girls from the Guard.

Freddie smiled, the memory of her sitting on his living room floor surrounded by his siblings still fresh in his mind. She was part of the system now. She had survived the Avery chaos.

"Courtney?" Freddie said, stepping up to the group.

The conversation stopped dead.

Usually, Courtney would turn and smile. Today, she turned, and her face was unrecognizable. It was pale, drawn, and looking at him with a mixture of humiliation and fury.

"Courtney?" Freddie repeated, his smile faltering. He reached into his pocket. "I got the pictures back. The one by the tree came out really—"

"Don't," Courtney interrupted. Her voice was sharp, brittle. She took a step back, as if he were holding a weapon instead of a photograph. "Don't you dare show me that."

Freddie froze. The input did not match the expected output. "But... it's the Christmas picture. You said you wanted a copy."

"That was before I knew," Courtney hissed. The girls next to her glared at Freddie, their arms crossed like castle walls.

"Knew what?" Freddie asked, his voice shrinking.

"I know about the bet, Freddie," Courtney said, her voice rising. Tears welled up in her eyes, hot and angry. "I know what you told Derek and the guys in the locker room. I know that you were bragging about... about scoring with me."

The word hung in the damp air of the hallway. Score.

Freddie blinked. His mind raced back to the concession stand, to the football games. "I don't play sports," he whispered, confused. "I don't keep score."

"Stop lying!" Courtney shouted. She reached into her bag and pulled out the box of fine-point ink pens she had given him two weeks ago. She shoved them into his chest. "Take them back."

Freddie automatically grabbed the box to stop it from falling. "Courtney, these were a gift. For the schematics."

"It was all a game to you, wasn't it?" Courtney was crying now, ignoring the students who were stopping to watch. "You invited me to your house. You introduced me to your sisters. You acted so sweet and innocent, just so you could go back to school and tell everyone I was easy? That I was just some... some achievement?"

"No," Freddie stammered. The photo in his pocket felt heavy now, like lead. "You are the Diplomat. We are friends."

"We aren't friends," Courtney choked out. "You're a liar. And you're gross. I actually thought you were different, but you're just meaner than the rest of them because you pretend to be nice."

She wiped her face aggressively with her sleeve. "Stay away from me, Freddie. Don't look at me. Don't talk to me. Just leave me alone."

She turned and ran down the hall toward the restrooms, her friends chasing after her.

Freddie stood alone in the hallway. The bell rang, and the flood of students poured out of the classrooms, jostling him, bumping his shoulders. He didn't move. He stood clutching the box of pens against his chest, the plastic edges digging into his skin.

The Christmas memory—the warmth of the living room, the smell of the pine tree, the feeling of her head on his shoulder—curdled in his stomach. It didn't make sense. The data was corrupted. How could the girl who hugged him on his porch look at him with that much hate?

He felt the tears before he felt the sadness. They were hot and blinding.

He backed up until he hit the wall, sliding down until he was sitting on the dirty linoleum floor. He pulled his knees to his chest, burying his face in his arms, the box of pens clutched tight. He began to rock, a rhythmic, desperate motion to try and restart his crashing system.

"Freddie?"

He didn't look up. He couldn't stop the shaking.

"Freddie!"

It was Paige. She had found him. She dropped her heavy backpack on the wet floor and fell to her knees in front of him. She didn't ask what happened. She didn't ask who did it. She saw the pens. She saw the rocking. She saw the absolute devastation in the way he was trying to hide from the world.

"I don't understand," Freddie choked out into his knees, his voice broken. "She gave me the pens. She came to the house."

"Shh," Paige whispered, her own eyes filling with tears of rage on his behalf.

She reached out and wrapped her arms around him. It wasn't a gentle hug; it was maximum force. She squeezed him as tightly as she physically could, using her entire body weight to compress him, to hold his shattering pieces together.

"I've got you," Paige said, her voice fierce and trembling into his ear. She pressed her cheek against the top of his head, squeezing harder, providing the deep pressure he needed to survive the crash. "I'm right here. I'm not letting go."

Scene 3: The Clinic

The bell for fourth period lunch rang, a jarring electronic shriek that signaled the migration of two thousand students toward the cafeteria. The hallway, momentarily empty during class, was about to become a stampede.

Freddie flinched at the sound, curling tighter into himself. His stomach gave a painful, hollow growl—he hadn't eaten breakfast due to nervous excitement about

giving Courtney the photo—but the thought of the cafeteria was impossible. The clattering trays, the yelling, the smell of industrial pizza... it was a sensory assault he could not survive right now.

He just wanted to stay here, anchored to the floor by Paige's arms.

"I can't go," Freddie whispered, his face pressed against Paige's shoulder. "It's too loud."

"We aren't going there," Paige promised, shifting her weight to shield him from the first wave of students exiting the classrooms. "We're staying right here until the hall clears."

"Report," a voice said from above them.

It was Jessica.

She didn't look like a student; she looked like a crisis manager arriving on the scene. She stood over them, her backpack slung over one shoulder, her expression shifting from confusion to immediate concern as she took in the tableau: Freddie on the floor, Paige guarding him, and the box of rejected pens lying on the linoleum.

"He's crashing," Paige said, looking up at their older sister. Her eyes were wide with confusion and anger. "It was Courtney. She... she just exploded."

Jessica dropped to a crouch, ignoring the skirt of her winter outfit touching the dirty floor. She looked at the abandoned gift, then at Freddie. "What happened? What did she say?"

"I don't know," Freddie choked out, his voice thick with tears. "She threw the pens back. She said I was a liar."

"A liar about what?" Jessica asked, her "Matriarch" instincts kicking in as she tried to find the logic in the situation.

"She didn't make sense," Paige explained, shaking her head. "She was screaming that she 'knew what he did' and that he was 'bragging,' but she wouldn't say about what. She just kept saying he was gross and to stay away."

"Bragging?" Jessica frowned. "Freddie doesn't brag. He barely talks to anyone but us."

"I know," Freddie whispered. "I don't understand. I just wanted to give her the picture."

"It's a mystery," Jessica muttered, her eyes narrowing. "But whatever she *thinks* she knows, she didn't bother to ask you about it first."

She reached out and placed her hand on Freddie's back, right between his shoulder blades. Freddie leaned into the touch. Now he had bookends—Paige on the front providing deep pressure, Jessica on the back providing stability.

"I know it hurts," Jessica said softly. "I know it feels like the end of the world. But if she is going to believe some mystery story without giving you a chance to speak, then she wasn't the one, Freddie."

Freddie sniffled, lifting his head slightly. "Why is she so mad?"

"We'll find out," Jessica promised, her voice turning steely. "But right now, we need to deal with your legs."

She glanced down. Freddie's knees were drawn up tight to his chest, trembling violently. The emotional stress was firing his spastic diplegia into overdrive, locking his muscles into painful knots.

"You're seizing up," Jessica observed. "We need to get you to the clinic. You need your medication before the spasms get worse."

"I can't walk," Freddie said, panic rising again. "Everyone is looking."

"Let them look," Jessica said. "But we aren't going to make you walk the gauntlet. Paige, help me get him up. We're going to the nurse."

Paige nodded. Together, the sisters coordinated the lift. Paige took his left arm, Jessica took his right. They hoisted him up, taking the weight off his stiff legs.

Freddie felt heavy, drained of all energy, but being sandwiched between his sisters felt like armor. They walked him down the hall, ignoring the stares of the students rushing to lunch. They moved as a phalanx—the Avery unit in defensive formation.

The school clinic was quiet. It smelled of rubbing alcohol and peppermint. The nurse, Mrs. Gable, knew the Averys well. One look at Freddie's pale face and his sisters' grim expressions, and she pointed immediately to the cot in the back room.

"Lay down," Jessica instructed, helping him swing his stiff legs onto the paper-covered mattress.

Mrs. Gable brought a small paper cup with water and his mid-day muscle relaxer. Freddie swallowed it, his throat tight.

"I'm sorry," Freddie whispered, looking at his sisters standing by the cot. "I ruined lunch."

"You didn't ruin anything," Paige said, sitting on the edge of the cot and taking his hand. "We're better off here. Less noise."

"We aren't going anywhere," Jessica said, pulling up a chair on the other side. She took his other hand. "We're going to sit right here until the bell rings. We'll figure out what Courtney is talking about later. For now, just breathe."

Freddie closed his eyes. The medicine would kick in soon, loosening the knots in his legs. But the confusion remained—a cold, heavy weight in his chest. He didn't know what he was accused of, only that he had been convicted.

Scene 4: The Law of the Lunchroom

The journey from the clinic to the cafeteria was a slow, agonizing shuffle. The muscle relaxer Mrs. Gable had administered was beginning to soften the edges of the spasms, but Freddie's legs were still heavy, unresponsive columns of lead.

He was dead weight.

Paige was on his left, Jessica on his right. His arms were draped over their shoulders, his toes dragging slightly on the linoleum. To an outsider, it might have looked like they were carrying a wounded soldier off a battlefield. In a way, they were.

"Almost there," Jessica grunted, adjusting her grip on his waist. "Just focus on moving your feet, Freddie. Left, right, left."

Freddie didn't answer. He couldn't. His voice had locked itself away in the same vault where he kept his eye contact. The physical exhaustion of the meltdown, combined with the medication, had rendered him non-verbal. He just stared at the floor, letting the rhythmic movement of his sisters guide him.

He was starving. The hollow ache in his stomach was the only thing grounding him to the physical world, sharper even than the emotional pain of the hallway.

They pushed through the double doors.

The cafeteria was a wall of sound—a roar of hundreds of conversations bouncing off hard surfaces. Freddie flinched, squeezing his eyes shut, but his sisters tightened their grip, creating a mobile forcefield.

Standing at the end of the serving line, arms crossed like a sentry guarding the gates of the underworld, was Mrs. DeMarco.

She was a short woman with hair the color of steel wool and eyes that could spot an unreturned tray from three zip codes away. As the Averys approached, her gaze locked onto them. She saw the drag of Freddie's feet. She saw the protective set of Jessica's jaw. She saw the red-rimmed eyes of all three siblings.

She did not smile. She simply nodded—a subtle, imperceptible granting of asylum.

"We need a table in the back," Jessica whispered to Paige. "Far corner."

"Food first," Paige said. "He needs calories."

They maneuvered him into the line. The queue was long, but as soon as the other students saw the terrifying determination on Jessica's face, they parted like the Red Sea. No one dared to disrupt the sacred flow of the line when the Matriarch was on a mission.

They reached the serving station. Freddie couldn't lift his head to look at the lunch lady.

"He's non-verbal right now," Paige told the woman behind the glass, her voice steady. "He needs the chicken patty on a bun. Plain. French fries. And a chocolate milk."

"Double fries," Jessica added, reaching for her wallet. "And a cookie."

They loaded the tray. Freddie leaned heavily against the metal railing, his breathing shallow.

"Did you hear about it? Man, it was classic."

The voice was loud. Obnoxious. It cut through the ambient noise like a jagged knife.

Freddie tensed. He knew that voice. It was the same frequency of arrogance he had heard earlier in the year at the football games, but louder now.

Standing two spots behind them in line was Josh Riley. He was a Freshman, like them, but he carried himself with the unearned swagger of a king. He was holding court with a group of snickering boys.

"I told everyone," Josh bragged, loud enough for half the cafeteria to hear. "I said, 'You gotta watch out for the quiet ones.' I shut that down before it even started. Saved Courtney the trouble."

Paige froze. The tray in her hands rattled against the metal slide.

"Wait," one of the other boys laughed. "So you're the one who told her?"

"Hell yeah, I told her," Josh preened, running a hand through his gelled hair. "Someone had to tell the truth about Avery. Can't have a freak like that thinking he has a shot. I told her exactly what he was up to."

Jessica stopped moving. She slowly turned her head, her eyes locking onto Josh Riley. The air around her seemed to crackle. She didn't know *what* Josh had told Courtney—she still didn't know the content of the lie—but she knew he was the architect of her brother's destruction.

"You," Jessica said, her voice low and dangerous.

Josh looked up, seeing Jessica. He smirked. He didn't know he was looking at the Matriarch. He just saw a girl in a skirt.

"What's up, Clarinet?" Josh sneered. "Your brother crying somewhere?"

Jessica took a step forward, leaving Freddie propped against the rail. She was about to violate every known rule of decorum by dismantling Josh Riley on a molecular level.

"Mr. Riley."

The name was spoken softly, yet it silenced the entire serving line.

Mrs. DeMarco materialized from the ether. She didn't walk; she simply arrived. She stood between Jessica and Josh, her steel-wool head barely reaching Josh's chest, yet looking down on him from a great height.

"M-Mrs. DeMarco," Josh stammered, his swagger evaporating.

"I believe," Mrs. DeMarco said, her voice smooth and terrifyingly calm, "that I heard you discussing the personal affairs of another student. And I believe I heard you taking pride in causing distress."

"I was just... talking," Josh said, shrinking back.

"Harassment," Mrs. DeMarco listed, staring into his soul. "Malice. And loud, boorish behavior in my line. You have violated the sanctity of this room, Mr. Riley."

She pointed a single, manicured finger toward the back of the kitchen—the door marked *CUSTODIAL*.

"Trash duty," she said. "One week. You start today. You will carry Mr. Avery's tray to his table, and then you will report to the scullery."

"But—" Josh started.

Mrs. DeMarco raised an eyebrow. "Backtalk? To me? Make it two weeks. Move."

Josh Riley, the future legend of detention, went pale. He looked at Jessica, then at Freddie, who was still staring at the floor. He picked up Freddie's tray with trembling hands.

Mrs. DeMarco turned to Jessica. The terrifying mask vanished, replaced by the look of a grandmother who had seen too much.

"Take him to table four," she said gently, nodding at Freddie. "It's quiet. I'll make sure no one bothers you."

"Thank you, Mrs. DeMarco," Jessica whispered.

"Go," Mrs. DeMarco said, turning back to glare at the line to ensure the flow continued. "Eat."

Jessica and Paige hoisted Freddie up again. As they walked toward the quiet table in the back, followed by a humiliated Josh Riley carrying their lunch, Freddie let out a long, shaky breath. The noise was still there, and the hurt was still fresh, but under the watchful eye of the cafeteria supervisor, they were safe.

The Static

Scene 1: The First Satellite

The ride home in the family van had been a blur of grey noise. Freddie sat in the back, staring at the floor mats, his hands clamped over his ears even though

the radio was off. The words Josh Riley had shouted in the cafeteria—I told her exactly what he was up to—were looping in his head like a corrupted audio file.

He felt dirty. He felt like the "monster" Josh had painted him to be.

When they got inside the house, Freddie didn't make it to his bedroom. His legs, heavy with the spasticity triggered by the stress, simply gave out in the living room. He collapsed onto the beige sofa, curling into the corner, burying his face in a throw pillow to muffle the sound of his own ragged breathing.

"I didn't do it," Freddie sobbed into the fabric. "I didn't bet. I didn't say those things."

"We know," Paige whispered. She was sitting right next to him, her arm wrapped tight around his shoulders, her cheek pressed against the back of his head. "We know you didn't. Josh is a liar. He's static, Freddie. Just static."

Jessica was pacing the rug in front of them, her fists clenched. She was still wearing her coat, too angry to take it off.

"I should have hit him," Jessica hissed, kicking at a loose thread on the carpet. "I should have dumped his tray on his head. Mrs. DeMarco went too easy on him. Trash duty? He deserves to be expelled."

She stopped pacing and looked at Freddie. Her expression softened instantly from rage to heartbreak. She sat down on the coffee table, leaning forward to rub Freddie's knee.

"He's jealous, Freddie," Jessica said fiercely. "He sees that you're smart, and that you're talented, and that Courtney actually liked you. He couldn't handle it, so he broke it. That's what weak people do."

"She hates me," Freddie choked out. "She looked at me like I was... a virus."

"She's confused," Paige said, squeezing him tighter. "She'll figure it out. And if she doesn't... then she didn't deserve the snowflake drawing anyway."

Freddie squeezed his eyes shut. The logic helped, but the pain was a physical weight in his chest. He felt like he was floating away, untethered by the rejection. He needed more gravity.

Then, there was a sound of small, stomping feet.

Harper, seven years old and wearing a shirt covered in glitter paint, marched into the living room. She had her purple headphones around her neck, but she wasn't listening to music. She was looking at the scene on the sofa.

She saw Jessica's angry face. She saw Paige holding Freddie. And she saw Freddie, his shoulders shaking, his face hidden in the pillow.

Harper stopped. She tilted her head. She didn't understand the high school drama. She didn't know about Josh or Courtney or the cruel rumors.

She just knew the data she could see: The Captain is leaking.

She walked up to the sofa. She stood right in front of Freddie's knees.

"Freddie?" Harper asked, her voice small.

Freddie didn't look up. He couldn't let her see him crying. He was the big brother. He was supposed to be the strong one.

"Go play, Harper," Jessica said gently. "Freddie isn't feeling well."

Harper ignored the order. She reached out and patted Freddie's knee, right where Jessica's hand was.

"Is he broken?" Harper asked.

"His heart is hurt," Paige explained softly.

Harper processed this. She knew what to do when her knee was hurt. She knew what to do when she fell out of her chair. You went to a safe place. You got a hug.

She looked at the space on the sofa. It was full. Paige was taking up the side.

So Harper improvised.

She gripped Freddie's thigh with her small hands. She stepped on his foot (he flinched, but didn't pull away). She climbed.

"Harper, be careful," Jessica warned, reaching out to steady her.

Harper scrambled up. She didn't sit next to him. She sat on him. She wiggled her way into the space between his chest and his knees, settling herself directly in his lap.

Freddie froze. He stopped crying for a second, shocked by the sudden weight.

He lifted his head from the pillow. He looked down.

Harper was sitting there, looking up at him with wide, serious brown eyes. She reached up with her small hands and placed them on his tear-stained cheeks.

"Don't cry," Harper commanded.

Freddie blinked, looking at her through his fogged glasses.

"Harper," he whispered, his voice cracking. "I am... sad."

"I know," Harper said. She leaned forward and pressed her forehead against his chin. "But I am here. I am heavy."

She snuggled closer, wrapping her arms around his neck. She was warm. She smelled of grape juice and crayons. She was a solid, undeniable reality in a world that felt like it was dissolving.

Freddie hesitated. His sensory system usually rejected sudden touch. But this... this was grounding. It was a specific, heavy pressure centered on his chest.

Slowly, carefully, Freddie brought his arms up. He wrapped them around her small back, holding her steady.

"You are heavy," Freddie agreed, a tiny, watery smile touching his lips.

"I'm a rock," Harper declared, resting her head on his chest. "I'm holding you down so you don't fly away."

Paige looked at Jessica. Jessica looked at Paige.

They saw Freddie's breathing slow down. They saw his hands stop shaking as he focused on holding his little sister.

"She's a rock," Paige whispered, leaning her head on Freddie's shoulder, completing the pile.

"She's a Avery," Jessica corrected, wiping her own eyes.

Freddie closed his eyes again. The static of the cafeteria was still there, but it was quieter now. It was muffled by the weight of the seven-year-old girl who didn't care what Josh Riley said, who didn't care about the rumors, and who just wanted her brother to stop leaking.

"Status?" Harper whispered into his shirt.

"Better," Freddie breathed. "Status is... better."

Scene 2: The Inside Man

Freddie held Harper for another minute, letting the heat of her small body soak into his chest. It was a good weight. It was a simple weight. The pressure on his sternum was actually helping to regulate his breathing, slowing the frantic thump-thump-thump of his heart.

But the question marks in his head were getting louder, drowning out the comfort. He needed to process the data. He needed to analyze the crash. And he couldn't do that with a seven-year-old who thought he was just "leaking."

"Harper," Freddie whispered, loosening his grip slightly on her back.

"Yeah?" Harper mumbled into his shirt, snuggling deeper. "I'm still being a rock."

"You are an excellent rock," Freddie said gently. "But I need to... debrief. I need to have a Big Kid conversation with the Lieutenants. It is classified."

Harper pulled back. She pouted, her lower lip jutting out in a display of supreme disappointment. She liked being the one to fix things. She liked the rare privilege of being allowed in the "Cuddle Zone."

"I can keep secrets," Harper insisted. "I know about the stash of candy bars in the pantry. I never told Mom."

"I know," Freddie said, managing a weak, watery smile. "But this is High School Business. It is... boring. And sad. I do not want to upload sadness to you."

Jessica leaned in, brushing a stray glitter-flake off Harper's shoulder. "He needs a minute, Harp. We just need to talk about schedules and boring stuff. Go check on the twins? I think I heard them fighting over the red crayon."

Harper sighed—a long, dramatic exhale that ruffled Freddie's bangs.

"Fine," she grumbled. She slid off his lap, her feet hitting the carpet with a thud. She adjusted her purple headphones around her neck. "But I'm coming back later. The rock is still available."

"Noted," Freddie said.

Harper turned to march out.

"Harper," Jessica added softly. "Close the door behind you? Gently, please. No slams."

Harper nodded solemnly. She walked to the double doors of the living room. She grabbed the brass handle. She looked back at Freddie one last time—verifying he was still intact—and then pulled the door shut with infinite care.

Click.

The silence that followed was heavy. The room felt suddenly larger and colder without the seven-year-old's energy.

Freddie looked at Paige. Then he looked at Jessica.

"Why?" Freddie asked. It was a single word, but it carried the weight of the entire afternoon.

"Because Josh is a snake," Jessica said immediately, her hands balling into fists on her lap.

"No," Freddie shook his head, staring at his hands. "I understand Josh. He is a predator. He attacks to establish dominance. That is... logical behavior for a bully."

He took a shaky breath, picking at a loose thread on the sofa cushion.

"I do not understand Courtney."

Paige shifted, turning to face him fully, taking his hand again. "What do you mean?"

"I was nice," Freddie said, his voice trembling. "I gave her the snowflake. I listened to her stories about the magnet program. I never... I never touched her without permission. I never bragged. I followed the protocols of friendship."

He looked up at his sisters, his eyes red and searching for a data point he had missed.

“I input kindness. I input respect. The expected output is friendship. Or at least... a query. Why did she believe the lie without asking me? Why did she just... delete me?”

Jessica sighed, her expression darkening. She sat back on the coffee table, crossing her arms.

“Because Josh didn’t just say it to her face, Freddie,” Jessica said, her voice tight. “He planted it. He used Derek.”

Freddie blinked. “Derek? The snare drummer?”

“Yes,” Jessica spat. “Josh told Derek the lie in the locker room. And because Derek is an idiot who loves drama, he went straight to Courtney and ‘confirmed’ it. He told her, ‘Yeah, I heard Avery talking about it too.’ ”

Freddie felt the blood drain from his face. “Corroboration,” he whispered. “Two sources. Independent verification.”

“False verification,” Paige corrected fiercely. “Derek didn’t hear anything. He just wanted to be important. But Courtney... she’s fifteen, Freddie. And fifteen-year-old girls are terrified of being played. Josh and Derek made her feel stupid, and when people feel stupid, they panic. She panicked and hit the eject button.”

“So I did nothing?” Freddie asked.

“You did nothing,” Paige confirmed.

“It... it bothers me,” Freddie choked out, a fresh wave of tears leaking from his eyes. “It bothers me that I have no data to correct. If I had made a mistake, I could fix it. But if the error is external... I cannot patch it.”

The unfairness of it washed over him. He had lost his first crush, his first connection outside the family, not because of a failure in his system, but because of a glitch in someone else’s.

“It hurts,” Freddie whispered.

“I know,” Jessica said softly, reaching out to rub his shin. “It sucks. It’s the worst kind of hurt.”

They sat there for a long time, the afternoon light fading in the windows. Paige held him. Jessica guarded him. They didn’t have a solution, because there wasn’t one. Courtney was gone.

Eventually, Freddie pulled back. He sniffed, wiping his face with his sleeve. It came away wet and sticky.

“I am... gross,” Freddie murmured. “My face is tight. The salt is drying.”

“Tears do that,” Jessica noted.

"I require... cleanup," Freddie said. He started to stand, then hesitated. He didn't want to go to the bathroom alone. The mirror was in there. If he looked in the mirror right now, alone, he would just see the red eyes and the "freak" Courtney had looked at.

"We got you," Paige said, standing up and offering him a hand.

They walked him to the hallway bathroom. It was small, smelling of lavender soap and damp towels.

Freddie sat on the closed toilet lid. He didn't have the energy to stand at the sink.

Jessica ran the water until it was warm. She wet a soft washcloth.

"Glasses off," Jessica commanded gently.

Freddie took off his glasses. The world blurred, becoming soft and indistinct.

Jessica wiped his face. She started at his forehead, wiping away the sweat of the panic. She moved to his eyes, pressing the warm cloth gently against the swollen lids.

"It feels good," Freddie whispered.

"Warmth helps the swelling," Jessica said.

Paige stood by the door, handing Jessica a dry towel when she was done. She watched them. This was their system. When the world broke Freddie, they put him back together.

Jessica dried his face. She put his glasses back on him.

"Better?" Jessica asked.

Freddie blinked. His eyes still burned, and he knew they looked puffy, but the crusty, tight feeling was gone. He felt... reset.

"Better," Freddie confirmed.

He stood up. He smoothed his shirt.

"What now?" Paige asked. "Do you want to go to the room? We can close the door. Block out the signal. I can read to you."

Freddie considered it. The bedroom was safe. It had his drawing table. It had silence.

But then he heard a noise from the kitchen. The rumble of the garage door opening. The sound of the twins running down the hall screaming about a lost toy.

"Mom is home," Freddie noted.

"Dad isn't," Jessica added, checking her watch. "Late shift at the plant. He won't be back until midnight."

Freddie processed this. No Robert. No judgment. Just the sisters and Mom.

If he went to his room, he would be alone. He would be hiding. And if he hid, it felt like admitting he was guilty.

"I am... hungry," Freddie realized. The emotional purge had hollowed him out.

"Dinner?" Paige asked.

"I do not want to hide," Freddie stated. He looked at his sisters. "I want to be in the living room. With the Unit."

"Red eyes and all?" Jessica asked, smiling slightly.

"Red eyes and all," Freddie said. "I am damaged. But I am operational."

"That's the spirit," Paige said, squeezing his hand.

They walked out of the bathroom together, heading not for the shadows, but for the kitchen, ready to face the noise of the family dinner.

Scene 3: The Dinner Table

The transition from the quiet, emotional triage of the bathroom to the kitchen was like stepping out of a submarine and into a riot.

As Freddie, Paige, and Jessica walked into the kitchen, the back door flew open.

"I'm home!" Ellen Avery announced, dropping her heavy nursing bag on the counter with a thud. She looked exhausted, her scrubs slightly wrinkled from a twelve-hour shift, but her energy was instantly maternal and commanding. "And I am starving. Who started the water? Please tell me someone started the water."

"I got it, Mom," Jessica said, moving smoothly past her to grab the big pot. "Water is on. Sauce is in the pantry."

The kitchen was already filling up. The "Satellite" sisters were converging on the food source.

Sarah and Jenna (age 10) were at the table, arguing over homework.

"You can't use a marker for math!" Sarah insisted, trying to snatch a purple marker from Jenna's hand.

"It makes the numbers louder!" Jenna shouted back, dodging her twin.

Harper (age 7) was sitting under the table—her preferred spot when the noise got too high—tying the shoelaces of unsuspecting siblings together. The toddlers, Amanda and Elara (age 4), were banging plastic cups on the high chair trays in a rhythmic demand for juice.

Freddie stood in the doorway. The noise hit him—a wall of shouting, clattering, and humming appliances. Usually, this level of decibels would make him reach for his earplugs.

But today, it felt different. It felt... safe.

This noise wasn't malicious. It wasn't Josh Riley laughing. It wasn't Courtney screaming. It was just the operational hum of the Avery Corporation.

"Freddie?" Ellen asked, pausing as she washed her hands. She squinted at him. "Your eyes are red. Are you okay?"

Freddie froze. He felt Paige step closer to his right side, her shoulder pressing against his arm. Jessica paused at the stove, turning her head slightly to monitor the interaction. The Shield and the Anchor were active.

"Allergies," Paige lied smoothly. "The pollen count is crazy today."

"And the wind," Jessica added, dumping pasta into the boiling water. "Dust everywhere."

Ellen looked at Freddie. She saw the puffiness. She saw the way he was leaning slightly against Paige. She suspected "allergies" was code for "high school is hard," but she also knew her son. If she pushed him now, he would shut down.

"Well, take a Claritin after dinner," Ellen said briskly, drying her hands. "Set the table, Freddie. We need nine spots."

"Affirmative," Freddie whispered.

He moved to the cupboard. He grabbed the stack of plates. The ceramic was cool and heavy in his hands.

One. Two. Three...

He counted them out. He placed them around the long wooden table. The rhythm of the task grounded him.

Plate. Napkin. Fork. Plate. Napkin. Fork.

"Move your elbow, Jenna," Freddie said quietly as he placed a plate near the math homework war zone.

Jenna looked up. She saw his red eyes. She didn't make a joke. She moved her elbow.

"Thanks, Freddie," she said.

He finished the circuit. He sat down in his spot—the corner seat, where he was protected on two sides by walls.

"Food!" Jessica shouted. "Deployment!"

She brought the pot of spaghetti to the table. Aunt Linda (who had slipped in the side door moments ago to help) followed with a bowl of salad.

They all sat down. The noise level spiked again as food was passed, drinks were poured, and arguments were settled.

Freddie looked at his plate. The steam from the pasta rose up, smelling of tomato and garlic.

He felt a hand on his knee under the table. It was Paige. She gave him two quick squeezes. I'm here.

He looked across the table. Jessica caught his eye and gave a nearly imperceptible nod. You're safe.

He looked down at the end of the table. Harper crawled out from underneath, climbed into her chair, and immediately looked at him. She held up her fork like a weapon.

"I'm eating the big meatball," Harper announced, pointing at the serving bowl. "I called it."

"It's community property," Sarah argued.

"I claimed it!" Harper yelled.

Freddie picked up his fork. He stabbed a noodle.

"Harper gets the meatball," Freddie ruled, his voice quiet but audible over the din. "She provided... structural support today."

Harper beamed. "See? The Captain says so."

Ellen looked at Freddie, confused but smiling tiredly. "Structural support? What did you build?"

"A wall," Freddie murmured, taking a bite of spaghetti. "We built a wall."

He chewed. The food was warm. The kitchen was loud. Courtney was gone, and Josh was a snake, but the Avery Unit was eating dinner.

And for tonight, that was enough.

The Blueprint

The Cracks

Scene 1: Static

The summer heat in Virginia Beach was usually a physical weight, a wet blanket of humidity that smelled of asphalt and salt. But inside the Avery house, the air felt heavy for a different reason.

Freddie sat at the top of the stairs, pressing his forehead against the banister. He was sixteen now. His legs were longer, his shoulders broader, but the

"Architecture"—the internal structure he built to make sense of the world—felt more fragile than it had in years.

Downstairs, the television was off. The younger twins, Amanda and Elara, were napping. It should have been quiet.

But silence, Freddie had learned, had different textures. There was the warm, fuzzy silence of reading a book next to Paige. Then there was this silence—sharp, jagged, and cold.

"I'm just going to the hardware store," his father's voice drifted up from the hallway. It wasn't a shout, but the pitch was wrong. It was too tight.

"For three hours?" his mother's voice replied. It lacked its usual maternal warmth. It sounded like glass breaking under water.

"I need to fix the latch, Ellen. It's broken."

"A lot of things are broken, Robert."

The front door opened and closed. It didn't slam—slamming was against the rules—but the latch clicked into place with a finality that made Freddie flinch.

He pulled his knees to his chest. The house felt like it was vibrating at a low frequency, a subsonic hum of tension that made his teeth ache. He didn't understand the data. The bills were paid (Jessica saw to that). The grades were good. The band was on hiatus for the summer. Yet, the system felt like it was crashing.

"Freddie?"

Freddie looked up. Paige was standing in the doorway of their shared bedroom. She was wearing oversized gym shorts and a tank top, her hair pulled up in a messy bun. She looked tired, the kind of tired that sleep couldn't fix.

"The air is wrong," Freddie whispered, rubbing his arms. "It feels spiky."

"I know," Paige said softly. She walked over and sat on the top step next to him, her shoulder pressing against his. "Dad's just... stressed. Work is busy."

"Mom is cleaning the counters," Freddie noted. "She has cleaned them three times since breakfast. That is a loop. A glitch."

Paige sighed, resting her chin on her knees. She knew what the glitch was, or at least, she suspected it. She saw the way their parents moved around each other like magnets with the same polarity, pushing away whenever they got too close. But she couldn't explain that to Freddie. He dealt in logic, and falling out of love was the most illogical thing in the world.

"Come on," Paige said, standing up and offering him a hand. "Let's go to the room. It's safe there."

Freddie took her hand. His spastic diplegia was always better in the summer warmth, but he still relied on her balance.

They retreated into their bedroom. It was a sanctuary of order. Freddie's side was meticulous—books stacked by height, drawing pens aligned by millimeter width. Paige's side was softer, a nest of pillows and blankets.

Freddie sat on the edge of the bed—*their* bed. They were sixteen, and the world said they should have separated years ago. But the world didn't understand the night terrors. The world didn't understand that when the sensory input of the day became too much, Paige was the only anchor that kept Freddie from drifting away.

"I've been thinking," Paige said, closing the door and locking it—a rare move. She turned to lean against the wood. "About the future. About the Blueprint."

Freddie looked up, intrigued. "The schematic?"

"Yeah. The schematic for us." She walked over and sat next to him. The mattress dipped, shifting their weight together. "We have two years left of this. Junior year. Senior year. Then graduation."

"College," Freddie added. "CCHR. Community College of Hampton Roads. It is the logical path."

"Right," Paige nodded. "And after that, maybe a university. But even for CCHR, we have to live somewhere. And this house..." She trailed off, gesturing vaguely toward the door. "It's getting loud, Freddie. And I don't think it's going to get quieter."

Freddie stiffened. Change was terrifying. The house was loud, but it was *his* house.

"What is the variable?" Freddie asked.

"Dorms," Paige stated, her eyes lighting up with a plan that seemed perfectly logical to her. "Student housing. We can apply for a dorm room together."

Freddie processed this. "A shared unit. Controlled environment. Close to classes."

"Exactly," Paige said, leaning back on her hands. "Like in the movies, but better because we won't have random roommates. We'll just put that on the application—that we're twins, and we're a set. They have to let us room together. It makes the most sense."

"Efficiency," Freddie agreed. "Shared resources."

"And the sleeping arrangements," Paige added, her voice dropping to a softer, more serious tone. She looked at the bed they were currently sitting on. "I was thinking... when we get the dorm, we'll just tell them we need one big bed. Or if they give us two small ones, we'll just push them together and strap the mattresses."

Freddie looked at her. "Is that standard protocol?"

"Why wouldn't it be?" Paige shrugged. "We're family. We're not some random couple trying to sneak around. It's a medical accommodation. They'll understand that you sleep better when I'm there. It's for regulation."

She reached out and covered his hand with hers. Her palm was warm, the same steady weight that woke him up every morning.

"I don't want to be in a bed across the room from you, Freddie," she admitted. "And I definitely don't want to be in a different room down the hall. I want to keep this. The deep pressure. The white noise. It works."

Freddie thought about the nights—the terrifying gunfire sound of the house settling, the way his muscles locked up in the cold sheets. Then he thought about Paige—the warmth, the safety, the singular unit they formed against the dark.

"It is the only way I sleep," Freddie said simply.

"Then it's the plan," Paige smiled, a look of immense relief washing over her. "We graduate. We get a dorm. We push the beds together. And we get out of the noise."

She moved her hand from his grip to his back, pressing her palm between his shoulder blades—that familiar, grounding spot.

"You and me," she whispered. "Against the static."

Freddie leaned into her touch, the tension in his spine dissolving. The house downstairs was cracking, the parents were drifting, but the Blueprint for the future felt solid.

"Yes," Freddie said. "That is the plan."

Scene 2: The Escape Vehicle

The calendar on the kitchen wall read **June 19, 2001**. It was a Tuesday, and the humidity outside was pushing ninety percent.

Inside the house, the air conditioning was humming, but it wasn't enough to scrub the tension from the atmosphere. Their mother was Upstairs, ostensibly organizing the linen closet for the fourth time that month. Their father was at work, though he had called an hour ago to say he would be "late again" due to a project deadline.

Freddie sat at the kitchen table, staring at a bowl of cereal that had gone soggy. The house felt like a tightly wound spring waiting to snap.

"Grab your shoes," Paige said, walking into the kitchen and twirling a set of keys on her finger.

The keys were new. They belonged to the family's secondary vehicle, a beat-up sedan that Paige had inherited access to after passing her road test two weeks ago.

The plastic rectangle in her wallet—*License Class D*—was the most valuable item in the Avery inventory. It was a ticket out.

"Where are we going?" Freddie asked, pushing the cereal away.

"Emerald Creek," Paige announced. "It's too quiet in here. And Sarah and Jenna turn twelve on Thursday. Mom and Dad..." She paused, looking up at the ceiling where footsteps creaked overhead. "Mom and Dad are distracted. So we're doing it. We're taking them out."

Freddie stood up. The logic was sound. If the primary command structure (the parents) was failing, the secondary command (the older siblings) had to take over.

They walked down the hall to the room shared by the middle set of twins.

The door was open. Inside was a study in contrasts.

On the left side of the room, Jenna was currently doing a handstand against the wall while trying to read a magazine on the floor. Her side of the room was a colorful explosion of clothes, posters, and half-finished craft projects. Her ADHD meant her brain moved at the speed of light, and her environment usually reflected that velocity.

On the right side, Sarah was sitting perfectly still on her bed, arranging her stuffed animals by height and color gradient. Her side was pristine. The comforter was smoothed to military standards. Her OCD demanded order in a chaotic world, and she maintained her perimeter with fierce dedication.

"Happy early birthday, monsters," Paige said, leaning against the doorframe.

Jenna crashed down from her handstand, bouncing to her feet in one fluid motion. "Are we going somewhere? Is it cake? Did you buy a pony?"

"No pony," Paige laughed. "But I have keys, and I have twenty dollars. We're going to the mall."

"Emerald Creek?" Jenna gasped, her eyes widening. "Can we go to the arcade? Can we go to the pretzel place? I want to see the new sparkly notebooks at the stationery store!"

Sarah looked up from her bears. She didn't bounce. She looked at the clock on her nightstand. "It's 1:14 PM. If we go now, traffic will be moderate. But is the car clean?"

"It's clean enough," Paige promised. "Come on, Sarah. We'll get you a smoothie. A symmetrical one."

Sarah considered this. She looked at her bears, checked the alignment one last time, and nodded. "Okay. But I get the window seat behind the driver. It's statistically safer."

"Deal," Paige said.

The drive to Chesapeake was a short but intense experience. Paige was a careful driver, gripping the wheel at ten and two, checking her mirrors every fifteen seconds. She took her responsibility as the transport pilot seriously.

In the backseat, the energy differential was palpable.

"Look at that truck! It's huge!" Jenna shouted, pointing out the window. "Oh, look, a dog! Two dogs! Paige, can we play the license plate game? I see a Florida! I see a New York!"

"Jenna, volume," Freddie murmured from the passenger seat. He was clutching the door handle, not because Paige was driving badly, but because being in a moving vehicle always messed with his vestibular system.

"Sorry, Freddie!" Jenna whispered, a volume that lasted exactly three seconds before she saw a billboard for a movie. "Oh my gosh, *Action Force 3*! We have to see that!"

Next to her, Sarah was silently counting the telephone poles passing by, tapping her finger against her knee in groups of four. She checked the door lock. Then she checked it again.

"Locked," Sarah whispered to herself. "Safe."

Freddie watched them in the rearview mirror. He saw Jenna's leg bouncing like a piston. He saw Sarah's rhythmic tapping. They were just like him—governed by their own internal wiring, their own unique operating systems.

"We're here," Paige announced, using her turn signal to pull into the sprawling parking lot of Emerald Creek Mall.

The mall was a monolith of beige concrete and glass, a temple of commerce rising out of the heat. To most people, it was just a place to buy clothes. To the Avery kids, it was a neutral zone—a place where the air conditioning was freezing, the smells were artificial, and for a few hours, they didn't have to worry about the silence at home.

"Operation Birthday Protocol is in effect," Paige said, putting the car in park. "Jenna, stay with the group. Sarah, I have hand sanitizer in my purse if you need it. Freddie, you have point."

"Copy," Freddie said, unbuckling his seatbelt.

Jenna burst out of the car like a majestic, energetic firework. *Mall!*

Sarah stepped out carefully, closing the door and checking the handle to make sure it locked behind them. "Door secured," she confirmed.

Paige looked at Freddie over the roof of the car. She smiled, a tired but genuine expression. "We got them out."

"We did," Freddie agreed. He offered his arm to Paige, not for balance this time, but as a gesture of partnership. They were the captains now.

"Let's go get some pretzels," Paige said, locking the car. "Before Jenna vibrates into another dimension."

Scene 3: The Route

The beige sedan sat vibrating in the driveway of 1852 Delaney Street. The engine idle was rough, shaking the dashboard slightly and making Freddie's teeth chatter if he didn't clench them.

Paige sat in the driver's seat, staring intensely at the tachometer. Her left foot was doing something complicated with a pedal Freddie didn't understand, and her right hand was gripping the gear stick like it was the controls of a fighter jet. It was a manual transmission—a "stick shift"—which to Freddie meant the car spent a lot of time lurching before it decided to move.

"Radio check," Paige muttered, reaching for the dial.

She twisted the knob until the static cleared and a heavy, distortion-filled guitar riff filled the cabin. A gruff voice announced: *"You're tuned to the erratic heartbeat of Hampton Roads... Rock 107, The Wolf."*

"Classic rock," Freddie noted, approving of the structured, predictable chord progressions coming from the speakers. It was a nice counter-balance to the engine noise, which was currently whining in a high pitch that hurt his ears.

"Hang on," Paige said, wrestling the stick into what Freddie assumed was Reverse. "Here comes the lurch."

The car jerked backward, then smoothed out as she backed out of the driveway. She stopped, stomped on the brake, and shoved the stick forward.

"Belt secure," Sarah announced from the back. "Tension is optimal."

"Copy," Paige said. The car bucked once—Freddie grabbed the door handle reflexively—before catching the gear and rolling forward.

They made a left onto Pope Street. The engine roared louder and louder until Paige moved the stick again, and the roar dropped to a comfortable hum. Freddie didn't know *why* she did it, only that he was grateful when the noise stopped.

"Are we getting pizza?" Jenna shouted from the back seat, leaning forward so far her seatbelt locked. "I want the pepperoni with the little cups of grease! Or maybe the Chinese place with the chicken on a stick? No, wait! The cookie place!"

"I require a pretzel," Sarah stated calmly, though she was tapping her window button to check that it was locked. "Salted. No dip. Dip is messy."

"We can get pretzels *and* cookies," Paige promised, her eyes glued to the road. She made a sharp right onto Brandon Boulevard. The suspension groaned, but she held the line.

"Right turn in 500 feet," Freddie murmured, reading the street signs. He might not know how to operate the machine, but he knew the grid. He was the navigator.

"Thanks, map man," Paige said. She signaled right for Kempsville Road.

As they cruised down the main artery, the backseat conversation dissolved into a high-speed negotiation of birthday demands.

"If we go to the arcade," Jenna said, vibrating with kinetic energy, "I'm playing the motorcycle game. You have to lean on it, Sarah. You have to actually lean!"

"That game is unsanitary," Sarah countered. "Thousands of hands touch the handlebars. I will play the claw machine. It involves precision."

"The claw machine is a scam!" Jenna yelled. "It's rigged! The claw is loose!"

"Volume," Freddie whispered, pressing his head back against the headrest. The classic rock on the radio was fighting a losing battle against Jenna's excitement.

"Jenna, bring it down a notch," Paige commanded from the pilot's seat. "Crossing city limits. Entering Chesapeake."

"Fun density increasing!" Jenna cheered, bouncing in her seat.

Paige navigated the turns—Volvo Parkway, then Eden Way North—her hand moving the stick shift back and forth in a rhythm Freddie couldn't follow. Emerald Creek Mall rose out of the asphalt sea like a fortress.

"Turning onto the ring road," Paige narrated. "Drop to Second gear."

The engine revved high again as they slowed down. On their left, the massive, blocky facade of **Pennyworth's** loomed, its red logo distinct against the grey sky.

"Don't park here," Jenna warned. "It's too far. My legs will fall off."

"We aren't parking at Pennyworth's," Freddie observed, watching Paige steer them past the loading docks. "She is aiming for the tower."

They swung around the back of the complex toward **Silverman's**. Rising between the brick walls of the mall and the side of the department store was the beacon.

Vertical white letters ran down the center of the dark glass: **FOOD COURT**.

"Elevator entrance," Paige confirmed. "Neutral. Handbrake."

She pulled the car into a spot three rows back. It was 1:35 PM. She did something with her feet, moved the stick to the middle, and yanked the parking brake lever up with a ratchet-like *crrr-click*.

"Engine off," Paige said, killing the ignition. The classic rock faded into silence, instantly replaced by the sound of Jenna unbuckling her seatbelt.

"WE'RE HERE!" Jenna shouted.

"Door check," Sarah whispered, waiting for the distinct *click* of the unlock mechanism before opening her door.

They spilled out onto the asphalt. The air was thick and humid, smelling of rain and car exhaust.

"Okay, listen up," Paige said, rounding the hood of the car. "We go in through the glass doors. We take the elevator up. That drops us right at far end of the Food Court. Stay together."

"I know how elevators work!" Jenna scoffed, already skipping toward the building. "I'm pressing the button!"

Freddie looked up at the Food Court tower. The dark glass reflected the grey clouds. It was a good entry point—direct access, low traffic, and a straight shot to the food.

"Let's go," Paige said, linking her arm with Freddie's. "I promised Sarah a symmetrical smoothie."

They walked toward the double doors, the "Avery Corporation" moving from the stifling heat of the parking lot into the cool, conditioned promise of the mall.

Scene 4: The Sugar Rush

The elevator doors slid open with a cheerful *ding*, and the noise hit them like a physical wave.

The Food Court at Emerald Creek Mall was a cavernous hall. The high, tent-like ceiling trapped every sound—screaming toddlers, clattering trays, the sizzle of woks from the Chinese counter—and bounced it around the room. It wasn't an open atrium; it was a contained ecosystem of noise and neon.

Freddie flinched, his shoulders hiking up toward his ears.

Paige didn't hesitate. She stepped slightly in front of him, breaking the visual wall of the crowd, and hooked her pinky finger through his belt loop. It was a subtle anchor, a tactile reminder that he wasn't drifting in the sea of noise alone.

"Target acquired," Paige said, her voice pitched just loud enough for him to hear over the din. "Twelve o'clock. **Auntie Mae's**."

The smell hit them next—a warm, buttery cloud of yeast and cinnamon that cut through the smell of floor wax. It was the only thing that made the noise bearable.

"Cinnamon sugar!" Jenna chanted, bouncing on her toes as they joined the line. "Cinnamon sugar! Cinnamon sugar!"

"Jenna, you are vibrating," Sarah observed, checking her watch. "And we haven't even ingested the sucrose yet. Your baseline energy is concerning."

"It's birthday energy!" Jenna corrected, spinning in a circle until she bumped into a velvet rope.

They reached the counter. The glass case was filled with rows of golden-brown pretzels, glistening with butter and toppings.

"Welcome to Auntie Mae's," the teenager behind the counter droned. She looked bored, wearing a visor that was slightly too big for her head.

Paige stepped up, pulling the crisp twenty-dollar bill from her pocket like it was a diplomatic credential.

"Four cinnamon sugars, please," Paige ordered. "And two large lemonades. No ice."

"No ice?" the girl blinked.

"More volume per cup," Sarah whispered to Freddie. "Ice displaces approximately 30% of the liquid. It is a scam."

"Smart," Freddie whispered back.

The girl punched the keys. "That'll be twelve-fifty."

Paige handed over the twenty. The transaction was smooth. The return of change—seven dollars and fifty cents—meant the arcade was still a go.

They moved to the pickup counter. A moment later, the tray arrived: four hot, paper-wrapped pretzels radiating heat, and two massive, wax-paper cUDS of yellow lemonade, filled to the brim.

"Secure the cargo," Paige instructed.

They bypassed the crowded tables in the center of the room. Freddie needed a defensible position. They found a high-top table in the far corner, tucked against the brick wall near the windows that looked out over the rainy parking lot.

It was the perfect spot. No one could walk behind them. Freddie sat with his back firmly against the wall, his field of vision covering the entire food court entrance without being *in* it. Paige sat right next to him, their knees touching under the table.

"Okay," Paige said, distributing the goods. "One for the birthday monsters. One for the pilot. One for the navigator."

She placed the massive lemonade cUDS in the center. "We share. Jenna and Sarah, you guys are on cup two. Freddie and I are on cup one."

Jenna tore into her pretzel immediately. Sugar crystals exploded onto the table, onto her shirt, and onto the floor. "It burns! But it's so good!"

Sarah opened hers methodically, folding the wrapper into a neat square to catch any falling debris. She took a small, precise bite. "Acceptable texture," she decided. Then she looked at the lemonade cup she had to share with Jenna.

"We need a straw protocol," Sarah stated, eyeing her twin. "You backwash."

"I do not!" Jenna protested, mouth full of dough.

"You do. We will use the 'sip and release' method," Sarah decreed. "Five sips for you. Wipe the straw. Five sips for me."

On the other side of the table, Freddie took a bite of his pretzel. The warmth spread through his chest. The sugar was gritty and sweet, and the dough was soft. He chewed slowly, letting the sensory input of the food override the sensory overload of the room.

He felt Paige lean against him. She took a long drag from their shared straw, then nudged the cup toward him.

"You doing okay?" she asked, her voice low.

Freddie looked out at the chaotic room—the teenagers flirting near the pizza place, the moms wrestling strollers. Then he felt the solid brick wall behind his back and the pressure of Paige's knee against his.

"The noise is static," Freddie said, taking the straw. "But the signal is good."

"Good," Paige smiled, wiping a speck of cinnamon off his chin. "Eat up. We have seven dollars and fifty cents burning a hole in my pocket, and Jenna is eyeing the arcade."

"The claw machine," Sarah reminded them, wiping her hands on a napkin. "I have calculated the grip strength. Today is the day we win."

Scene 5: The Calculation

The arcade at Emerald Creek Mall was named **The Starcade**. It was located just past the food court restrooms, a dark cave illuminated by the flashing CRTs of attract screens and the neon glow of Lane-Master lanes.

To Freddie, the Starcade was a paradox. It was louder than the food court—a cacophony of 8-bit explosions, synthesized voices shouting *Reload!*, and the clatter of tokens hitting metal trays. Yet, unlike the chaotic noise of the crowds, this noise was *designed*. It was computerized. It followed rules.

Paige stopped at the change machine. She fed the remaining bills into the slot.

Whirrrrrr-clink-clink-clink-clink.

The machine spit out a heavy stream of brass tokens into the metal cup. Thirty tokens.

"Okay," Paige said, dividing the loot. "Seven for Jenna. Seven for Sarah. Eight for Freddie because he's the navigator. Eight for me because I'm the pilot."

"Go!" Jenna shouted, grabbing her handful. She sprinted immediately toward a game called *Torrent-X*, vibrating with the need for speed.

Sarah held her seven tokens in a neat stack. She didn't run. She walked past the noisy shooters and the flashing racing games until she reached the back wall.

There it stood. **The Claw**.

It was filled with generic plush animals—neon bears, unauthorized cartoon characters, and weirdly shaped pillows. But Sarah didn't care about the prize quality; she cared about the physics.

"Target identified," Sarah whispered. She pointed to a blue bear that was sitting loosely on top of the pile, its tag snagged on a red pillow. "The friction coefficient is favorable."

Freddie walked over, standing behind her. He loved watching Sarah work. When she focused, her OCD wasn't a burden; it was a supercomputer.

"Do you require vector assistance?" Freddie asked.

"Negative," Sarah said, slotting a token. "I need you to block the glare from the overhead light. It interferes with my depth perception."

Freddie stepped to the side, raising his hand to cast a shadow over the glass. "Glare blocked."

Sarah gripped the joystick. She didn't jerk it. She tapped it—*tap, tap, tap*—moving the metal claw into position. She leaned forward, pressing her forehead against the glass, checking the X-axis. Then she moved to the side of the machine to check the Y-axis.

"Aligning," she muttered. "Drop zone calculated."

She hit the big red button.

The claw descended. It spun slowly, the metal fingers opening. It hit the pile.

Clunk.

The fingers closed around the blue bear's head.

"Grip is weak," Sarah observed instantly. "But the tag loop is engaged."

The claw lifted. The bear dangled precariously by its ear tag. The machine rattled as it moved toward the chute. The bear swung—left, right, left...

"Steady," Freddie whispered.

The claw opened over the chute.

Plop.

The blue bear tumbled down the plastic slide and landed in the retrieval bin.

"VICTORY!" Jenna screamed, appearing out of nowhere. She had already blown through four tokens in three minutes and was looking for action. "SARAH WON! SARAH BEAT THE SYSTEM!"

Sarah reached into the bin and pulled out the blue bear. She inspected it for defects, straightened its ribbon, and then—for the first time all day—a genuine, wide grin broke across her face.

"The physics were sound," Sarah declared, handing the bear to Freddie. "Hold this. I have six tokens left. I am going for the red pillow."

Paige leaned against a pinball machine nearby, watching her siblings. Jenna was jumping up and down. Sarah was calculating her next attack vector. Freddie was holding the blue bear with a look of serious pride.

For a moment, the tension of the house, the "spiky air" of their parents' marriage, and the uncertainty of the future didn't exist. There was just the neon light, the smell of ozone, and the victory of the blue bear.

"You guys good?" Paige asked, walking over.

"We are operational," Freddie said, handing the bear back to Sarah so she could clutch it. "And Sarah is lethal."

"Good," Paige smiled. "Burn the rest of the tokens. Then we ride."

Scene 6: The Collapse

The high of the Starcade lasted exactly until the front door of 1852 Delaney Street clicked shut behind them.

The house was not quiet. The silence Freddie had feared earlier had been replaced by something worse: the sharp, staccato rhythm of an argument.

Jenna and Sarah, sensing the atmospheric pressure change, immediately retreated. Jenna grabbed her new blue bear and bolted for the stairs. Sarah followed, her face blank, disappearing into the safety of their room.

That left Freddie and Paige standing in the foyer, the "captains" of a ship that was suddenly taking on water.

"I'm just saying look at the numbers, Robert!" their mother's voice came from the kitchen. It was pitched high, tight with frustration. "I picked up the catalog from VDU today. The nursing program is two years. If I start now—"

"And pay for it with what?" their father's voice cut in. It wasn't angry; it was exhausted. It was the sound of a man who had given up. "We have eight kids, Ellen. I'm working fifty hours a week. The job pays the bills. The lights are on. The fridge is full. Why isn't that enough?"

"Because 'enough' is suffocating!" Ellen snapped. "I don't want to just survive, Robert. I want to build something. And you should too. They have a management track. You could—"

"I am forty years old!" Robert shouted. The volume spiked, a sudden red line on the equalizer. "I am not going back to school to sit in a classroom with a bunch

of twenty-year-olds and pretend I have a future! I am tired, Ellen! I just want to come home and sit down!"

The shout hit Freddie like a physical blow.

He was standing near the coat rack, still holding his half-empty cup of lemonade. The sudden spike in decibels scrambled the signal. His brain, already fatigued from the sensory input of the mall, couldn't process the aggression.

The "Architecture"—the carefully built grid of logic and safety—shattered.

It started in his hands. They began to shake, not a little, but violently. The lemonade cup slipped from his grip. It hit the hardwood floor.

SPLAT.

The lid popped off. Yellow liquid and ice exploded across the foyer, soaking Freddie's socks and splashing onto the wall.

The sound of the cup hitting the floor stopped the argument in the kitchen.

"Freddie?" Ellen called out, her voice shifting from angry to startled.

But it was too late.

Freddie wasn't there anymore. He was vibrating apart. The noise in his head was a white-hot static, drowning out thought, drowning out logic. He dropped to his knees, not because he wanted to, but because his legs simply stopped receiving commands.

He brought his hands up to his ears, pressing hard, trying to physically crush the sound out of his head. He began to rock back and forth, a desperate, rhythmic motion to try and find a center that didn't exist. A sound tore out of his throat—a low, guttural keen that rose into a high-pitched scream of pure, unfiltered agony.

"Make it stop!" Freddie screamed, squeezing his eyes shut. "The air is breaking! Stop the breaking!"

Robert and Ellen rushed into the foyer. They froze when they saw him—curled on the floor in a puddle of lemonade, rocking violently, hitting the side of his head with his palms.

"Freddiey. . . " Robert started, reaching out.

"DON'T!" Paige yelled.

She threw herself between her parents and her brother. She wasn't the scared little girl anymore; she was the pilot, and she was furious. Her face was flushed, her eyes blazing with an anger that shocked both of them.

"Don't touch him!" Paige hissed, shoving her father's hand away. "Look at him! Look what you did!"

"We were just talking. . . " Ellen stammered, pale.

"You weren't talking! You were screaming!" Paige shouted, tears of rage spilling over. "You do this every day! You pick at each other and you yell and you don't care who hears it! He can't handle it! His wiring can't take it!"

She turned her back on them, dropping to her knees in the lemonade puddle without a second thought. Her voice dropped instantly from a scream to a soothing, low murmur.

"Freddie. Freddie, I'm here. I've got the signal."

Freddie was hyperventilating, his chest heaving. "Too loud. Too sharp."

"I know," Paige whispered. She grabbed his wrists, gently pulling his hands away from his head before he could hurt himself. She replaced his hands with her own, cupping his ears firmly, blocking out the world. "I'm blocking the frequency. It's just me. Just static."

She looked back over her shoulder at her parents. Robert looked defeated, staring at the floor. Ellen looked horrified, her hand over her mouth.

"We're going to our room," Paige said, her voice cold and hard. "Do not come in. Do not knock. Just... stop."

She turned back to Freddie. "Up, soldier. We're aborting the mission. We're going to the bunker."

It took a minute to get him to stand. His legs were locking up, the spasticity firing wildly in response to the stress. Paige took his entire weight, wrapping her arm around his waist, letting him drag his feet.

They shuffled past the stunned parents, up the stairs, and down the hall.

Paige opened their bedroom door, shoved them inside, and locked it. Then she went to the window and pulled the blackout shades down, plunging the room into a soothing, grey twilight.

"Bed," Paige ordered gently.

Freddie collapsed onto the mattress. He curled into a tight ball, facing the wall, shaking.

Paige didn't hesitate. She climbed onto the bed behind him. She wrapped her arms around him, pulling his back against her chest. She hooked her legs over his, creating a human straightjacket of deep, firm pressure.

"Squeeze," Freddie gasped.

"I'm squeezing," Paige whispered into the back of his neck. She tightened her grip, holding his shattered pieces together with everything she had. "I've got you. The noise is gone. I'm not letting go."

She lay there in the dark, holding her brother, listening to his ragged breathing slowly sync with hers. She wasn't mad at him. She loved him more than anything.

But as she stared at the locked door, listening for the footsteps of the parents who had caused this, she felt a new kind of resolve hardening in her chest.

The Blueprint wasn't just a dream anymore. It was a necessity. They had to get out.

Scene 7: The Closet

The trigger wasn't a slammed door this time. It was the sound of paper hitting the kitchen table—a sharp *thwack* that echoed up the ventilation shafts like a gunshot.

"Three thousand dollars, Ellen?" Robert's voice started low, vibrating through the floorboards. "Three thousand dollars on a card that was supposed to be for emergencies?"

"School clothes are an emergency!" Ellen shouted back, her voice already pitched at the frequency that made the air pressure in the house feel like it was dropping. "The twins outgrew everything. Freddie needed new shoes. What did you want me to do, Robert? Send them to school in rags?"

Upstairs in their bedroom, Paige sat on her bed, reading. At the first shout, she slammed her book shut, her jaw setting into a hard line. She was tired of this. She was tired of the money fights. She was tired of the way the house shook every time the credit card bill arrived.

"I want you to stick to the budget!" Robert roared from the kitchen. "I am drowning here! I am working six days a week, and I come home to this?"

Paige took a breath, preparing to say something soothing to Freddie. She looked over at his desk.

"It's okay, Freddie, just put your headphones—"

She stopped. The desk chair was spinning slowly, empty.

Rumble-click.

The sound came from the other side of the room. It was the distinctive, heavy sound of the sliding closet door hitting its frame.

Paige stared at the closed wooden door. For a second, her brain didn't process it. *Where did he go?* Then, the realization hit her. The noise had spiked too fast. He hadn't waited for orders. He had retreated to the bunker on his own.

She stood up and walked quickly to the closet. She didn't yank the door open; she slid it back just a few inches, gentle and slow.

Freddie was huddled in the far corner, wedged behind a row of hanging winter coats. He was slumped awkwardly against the side wall, his chin tucked into his chest, his hands clamped over his ears. He was rocking, and with every backward motion, the back of his head hit the drywall with a dull *thud*.

“Freddie?” Paige whispered.

He didn’t answer. He was vibrating, lost in the static.

Paige looked back at the bedroom door. The shouting downstairs was escalating.

“I am forty years old, Ellen! I am tired!”

Paige stepped into the closet, pushing a pile of old board games out of the way with her foot. She reached up and pulled the sliding door shut.

Click.

The darkness was instant. The air smelled of cedar chips and old wool.

Paige knelt beside him. She put her hand on the back of his neck and felt the tension; his muscles were rock hard, and the way he was slouched against the wall was forcing his neck into a painful angle.

“Freddie,” she whispered, her voice calm and authoritative. “We need to fix your position. You’re hurting your neck.”

He didn’t move on his own, so she took charge. She gently guided his shoulders away from the wall.

“Down,” she instructed. “Lie down. The wall is too hard.”

She guided him down to the floor. It was cramped—the closet was only two feet deep—but if they lay lengthwise, they could fit. Freddie curled onto his side, his knees drawn up to his chest, shivering violently.

Paige reached into the darkness and grabbed a handful of sweaters from a low shelf. She bundled them into a soft, lumpy mound and tucked it under his head.

“Pillow,” she whispered.

Freddie let his head sink into the wool. He was still squeezing his eyes shut, his hands pressed over his ears.

Paige lay down beside him. The space was tight; her back was pressed against the sliding door, and her front was pressed against his back. She wrapped her arm over his waist and pulled him in tight, spooning him in the pitch black.

“I’m here,” she whispered into his ear, her voice a low rumble designed to cut through the panic.

She tightened her grip, squeezing him with as much force as she could muster. She hooked her leg over his ankles, pinning him down, providing the deep pressure grounding he needed to stop floating away.

“I’ve got the perimeter,” Paige promised. “I’m right here. I’m not going anywhere. We stay in the bunker until the all-clear.”

Downstairs, the fight raged on. Words like *tuition*, *interest rates*, and *mistake* floated up through the floorboards.

Freddie flinched at a particularly loud shout. Paige squeezed harder, absorbing the shockwave with her own body.

"Just static," she soothed, burying her face in the back of his shirt. "Focus on the squeeze. Just the squeeze."

Time became fluid in the closet. The air grew hot and stale.

One hour passed. The screaming downstairs evolved into the slamming of doors, then the heavy, angry silence of two people ignoring each other in the same room.

Two hours passed. The silence upstairs stretched out. Freddie's shivering had stopped. He was heavy against her arm now, his breathing shallow and even. The adrenaline crash had hit him, leaving him limp in her hold.

Three hours passed. It was now evening. The gray line of light under the door had faded to black. Paige's arm was asleep, stinging with pins and needles, but she didn't move. She kept her promise. She stayed right at his side.

"Freddie?" she whispered finally. Her throat was dry.

"System... rebooting," Freddie mumbled into the pile of sweaters. His voice sounded thick, detached.

"Is the noise gone?"

"The noise is gone."

Paige slowly unhooked her leg and pulled her numb arm back. She reached up and pushed the sliding door open.

The bedroom light, even though it was just the lamp on the desk, felt blinding. They blinked, emerging from the cave like survivors of a bombing raid. They were stiff, their clothes wrinkled, their dignity left somewhere back in the dust bunnies.

Freddie crawled out first. He stood up, swaying slightly. He looked at the closed bedroom door, terror flashing in his eyes that it might open.

"We stay here," Paige said firmly, climbing out and rubbing her cramping arm. "We don't go down for dinner. We don't go down for water. We stay in the room."

Freddie nodded. He walked to his bed and sat down, staring at the wall.

Paige looked at him—at the fear still lingering in his posture—and then she looked at the floor where the vibrations of the screaming had come from. She wasn't just his sister anymore. She was the only adult in the house. And she made a silent promise to the room: *The dorms. The apartment. Whatever it takes. We are getting out.*

The Severance

Scene 1: The Sofa

The announcement hadn't been a scream. It hadn't been a dramatic fight with broken plates. It had been a conversation at the dinner table, delivered with the cold, sterile efficiency of a legal deposition.

"Your father and I are taking some time apart."

That was the phrase. Under the Commonwealth of Virginia law, to file for a no-fault divorce, a couple had to live "separate and apart" for one year. For the Averys, with eight children and a tight budget, "separate and apart" started with the beige microfiber sofa in the den.

It was 11:30 PM. The house was finally quiet, but it was a heavy, suffocating silence.

Jessica was gone. She was a freshman at CPI now, living in a dorm in Blacksburg, escaping the blast radius. That left Paige and Freddie as the senior officers on the deck of a sinking ship.

Freddie stood in the hallway, clutching his toothbrush like a talisman. He was vibrating. It was a subtle, high-frequency tremor that started in his hands and rattled his teeth. The "Architecture" of the house had changed. The Master Bedroom—the command center—was now solely occupied by his mother. His father was an exile in the den. The geometry of the family was broken.

"Come on," Paige whispered, appearing at his elbow. She was wearing her oversized t-shirt and holding her pillow. "Brush teeth. Then bed. We stick to the routine."

"The routine is invalid," Freddie murmured, staring at the closed door of the Master Bedroom. "The variables have shifted."

"The house routine is broken," Paige corrected gently, steering him toward the bathroom. " *Our* routine is fine. We are the constant."

They brushed their teeth in silence, the rhythm of the bristles against enamel providing a brief moment of familiarity. When they finished, they walked back into the hallway.

To get to their bedroom, they had to pass the den.

The television was on, playing a late-night talk show at low volume. The blue light flickered against the walls. Robert was lying on the sofa, a tangled mess of sheets and a scratchy wool blanket pulled up to his chest. He looked smaller than Freddie remembered. He looked like a guest who had overstayed his welcome.

Freddie stopped. He couldn't help it. Seeing his father on the couch—the place where they watched movies, not where people *slept*—was a glitch in the matrix.

Robert rolled over. He blinked, squinting at his children in the semi-darkness.

"Hey," Robert croaked, his voice rough with sleep and misery. "You guys okay?"

Freddie didn't answer. He couldn't. He just stared at the wool blanket.

"We're fine, Dad," Paige said, her voice cool and detached. She put her hand on Freddie's back to guide him forward. "Goodnight."

"Wait," Robert said, sitting up slightly. He rubbed his eyes, looking at Paige, then at the pillow tucked under her arm. Then he looked at Freddie, who was clearly heading toward the same room.

"Paige?" Robert asked, a frown creasing his forehead. "Where are you going?"

Paige paused. "To bed."

"In Freddie's room?"

"It's *our* room, Dad," Paige said, the irritation flaring instantly. "We've shared a room since we were babies."

"I know you share a room," Robert said, shifting uncomfortably on the narrow sofa cushions. "But... you're taking your pillow. Are you sleeping *in* his bed?"

The question hung in the air, heavy and accusing.

Freddie took a step back, hiding behind Paige's shoulder. He felt a spike of shame, hot and sharp. He knew, logically, that sixteen-year-olds weren't supposed to share beds. He knew the social data said it was weird. But he also knew that without the deep pressure of Paige's presence, the night terrors would tear him apart.

Paige didn't step back. She stepped forward.

"Yes," she said. "I am."

"Paige," Robert sighed, running a hand through his thinning hair. "You're sixteen now. You're almost adults. It's... it's not appropriate anymore. You need your own space. Freddie needs to learn to sleep on his own."

Paige stared at him. The silence stretched for five seconds, ten seconds. When she finally spoke, her voice wasn't loud, but it was trembling with a rage so pure it felt like heat radiating off her skin.

"Appropriate?" she whispered.

She gestured to Freddie, who was now rocking slightly on his heels, his eyes squeezed shut to block out the confrontation.

"He wakes up screaming three nights a week, Dad. He shakes so hard his teeth chatter. The only thing—the *only* thing—that stops it is deep pressure. I have been sleeping in that bed every single night since we were twelve years old."

Robert blinked, looking stunned. "Twelve? No. I would have noticed."

"You didn't notice," Paige snapped. "You didn't notice the night terrors. You didn't notice the sensory overload. You didn't notice that he spent three hours in the closet last week because you and Mom were screaming about the credit card bill."

She took a breath, her voice cracking. "You don't get to sleep on the couch for one night and suddenly decide you have an opinion on how we survive this house. You checked out years ago, Dad. Do not pretend you care about the sleeping arrangements now."

Robert opened his mouth, but no words came out. He looked at Freddie—really looked at him—and saw the sixteen-year-old boy cowering behind his sister, vibrating with anxiety. He saw the truth of it, the years of missed data points, the entire reality of his children's lives that he had missed while he was at work or staring at the television.

I... Robert stammered. "I just thought..."

"Go back to sleep, Dad," Paige cut him off.

She turned to Freddie, her demeanor softening instantly. "Come on. Let's go."

She led Freddie past the den, past the father who was a stranger in his own home, and into their bedroom.

She shut the door. She locked it.

"Safe," Paige whispered.

Freddie stood in the center of the room, shaking. "He said it was inappropriate. He said I have to learn."

"He doesn't know the schematic," Paige said firmly, tossing her pillow onto the bed—*their* bed. "He's working off old data. We ignore him."

She climbed in, patting the space beside her. "Deployment positions. Come on."

Freddie hesitated for only a second. Then, the need for safety overrode the shame. He climbed into the bed, curling onto his side. Paige wrapped her arm over him, pulling the quilt tight, sealing them into their capsule.

Outside in the den, the TV flickered on the face of a man who realized, far too late, that he had lost his family long before he lost the house.

The Iron City

Scene 1: The Transfer Point

The silence inside the silver sedan was heavier than the Blue Ridge Mountains rising in the distance.

Ellen drove with both hands gripping the wheel at ten and two, her knuckles pale. She wasn't driving like a mother taking her children on a college visit; she

was driving like a courier transporting fragile, volatile cargo through a war zone.

In the passenger seat sat Aunt Linda—Ellen's younger sister. Linda was usually a woman who filled rooms with perfume, loud laughter, and stories about her latest bingo wins. Today, she was muted. She stared out the window at the passing landscape of Augusta County, a look of wistful recognition on her face.

"I miss living out here," Linda said softly, breaking the silence. "Route 254... the way the light hits the fields in the fall. It was always so peaceful."

"You lived here a long time ago, Linda," Ellen murmured, her eyes glued to the road. "Things change."

"The land doesn't," Linda countered gently. She sighed, tracing a finger against the glass. "Sometimes I wish I never left."

In the back seat, Freddie and Paige sat like statues.

It had been exactly one year since Robert moved to the sofa. Eleven days ago, the separation period had officially met the twelve-month legal requirement for a no-fault divorce in the Commonwealth of Virginia. The paperwork had been filed. The "Avery Corporation" was dissolving.

Freddie looked out the window. The scenery was changing—the flat, marshy Tidewater giving way to the rolling hills of the Piedmont, and now, the imposing wall of the mountains.

The "Architecture" of his life was gone. His father lived in a small apartment on the other side of Virginia Beach now. The chaotic family van was gone, replaced by this sensible, used sedan that smelled of the previous owner's cherry air freshener. The only thing that remained constant was Paige, sitting inches away from him, her thigh pressing against his.

"Are we making good time?" Paige asked, breaking the silence.

"We're fine," Ellen said shortly. "We'll be at the Zane's on Route 250 by 4:30. Just like the schedule says."

They passed the large green highway sign: **EXIT 222 - STAUNTON / FISHERSVILLE / US-250**.

Freddie stared at the word on the sign as it flashed by: **FISHERSVILLE**.

He didn't know why, but the name stuck in his head. *Fishersville.* It sounded quiet. It sounded like a place where things didn't break. He filed the name away in his mental archive, cataloging it under "Locations of Interest," right next to the schematics for warp drives and drum patterns.

"Exit 222," Freddie whispered. "Fishersville."

"We're taking the Staunton side, Freddie," Ellen corrected, signaling right. "We aren't going to Fishersville."

"I know," Freddie said. "Just noting the coordinates."

Ellen took the ramp onto Route 250, merging onto Richmond Avenue. The landscape here was a mix of historic charm and highway commerce. Ellen navigated the traffic, passing fast-food chains and car dealerships until the massive, glowing sign appeared on the left: **ZANE'S MARKET**.

Scene 2: The Red Booth

The Zane's at 1250 Richmond Avenue was a beast of a building. It wasn't just a gas station; it was a brightly lit fortress of neon red and yellow, bustling with truckers, weary travelers, and college students heading south to Blacksburg or north to Harrisonburg.

Ellen pulled the sedan into a parking spot away from the pumps.

"There she is," Aunt Linda said, pointing.

Parked near the entrance was a silver Avalon with a **CPI IRONHEADS** sticker on the back glass. Leaning against it was Jessica.

She looked different. She wasn't just the "Matriarch" who managed the household anymore; she was a Sophomore. She was wearing a maroon sweatshirt with **FORGERS** emblazoned across the chest in block letters, and her hair was cut in a sharp, efficient bob. She looked like she belonged to a different tribe.

"Okay," Ellen said, turning off the engine. "Let's eat. Then the handoff."

They walked into the Zane's. To Freddie, it was a paradise of order. The convenience store aisles were bright and symmetrical, but the real marvel was the food counter.

Unlike a fast-food joint where you had to shout over a counter, Zane's used the **"Touch-Tap"** system. A row of glowing screens allowed you to build your order digitally.

"This is efficient," Freddie noted, stepping up to a kiosk. He tapped the screen. *Sub. Turkey. Provolone. Lettuce. No Tomato. Confirm.*

No talking. No confusion. Just data entry.

"I'm getting the fries," Paige said, tapping the screen next to him. "Curly. Large. Side of ranch."

They grabbed their receipt tickets and waited for their numbers to be called. When the food arrived—wrapped in foil and sitting in red plastic baskets—they carried it over to the seating area.

It was a small section partitioned off from the aisles by a low glass wall, filled with hard red vinyl booths and a few high-top tables. They slid into a booth near the window. It was tight—Aunt Linda and Ellen on one side, Jessica, Paige, and Freddie squeezed into the other—but it worked.

"So," Jessica said, unwrapping a massive burger. "How was the drive?"

"Quiet," Ellen said, picking at a salad she had grabbed from the cooler case. "Linda got nostalgic for Route 254."

"It's pretty country," Jessica conceded. "Quieter than the beach."

"Linda, did you bring the itinerary for the return trip?" Ellen asked, shifting gears back to logistics.

"I did," Linda nodded, sipping a fountain soda. "We're going straight back. No stops."

"Good," Ellen said. She looked at the twins. "Jessica has the schedule for tomorrow. The Open House starts at 0800. I want you both to listen to her. No wandering off. No incidents."

"We know the protocol, Mom," Paige said softly, dipping a curly fry into ranch.

"And Freddie," Ellen added, her eyes darting to him. "If it gets... loud. If there's a crowd. You tell Jessica immediately. Do not wait until you crash."

"I will communicate," Freddie whispered, staring at his turkey sub. The bread was perfectly toasted. The consistency was safe.

"He'll be fine, Mom," Jessica said, her voice firm. "We're in Ironhead country now. It's different here. People mind their own business."

They ate quickly. The atmosphere in the red booth was a strange mix of relief and melancholy. It was the last meal before the definitive split—the moment the children crossed the border into their own lives, leaving the wreckage of the marriage behind in the rearview mirror.

"Okay," Ellen said, checking her watch. "It's 5:00. We need to get back."

They cleared the table. The goodbye in the parking lot was brief. Ellen gave the twins a quick, fierce hug, her perfume smelling faintly of stress.

"Be good," she said. "Call me on Sunday when you're on the way back."

"We will," Paige promised.

Ellen and Aunt Linda got back into the beige sedan. As they pulled out onto Route 250, turning back toward the highway, Freddie watched the car disappear. He felt a physical weight lift off his chest.

Jessica turned to them, her hardness melting into a grin.

"Alright, recruits," she said, popping the trunk of her Civic. "Welcome to the DMZ. You made it out."

"The air is thinner here," Freddie observed, looking up at the sky over Staunton. "It feels cleaner."

"It is cleaner," Jessica agreed. "Load up. Next stop: The Iron City."

They threw their bags into the trunk and climbed into the Avalon. The interior of Jessica's car didn't smell like divorce or air freshener; it smelled of old coffee, textbooks, and freedom.

"Music," Jessica announced, turning the key. "Real music."

She cranked the volume. It wasn't soft rock. It was loud, driving alternative rock. The bass thumped in Freddie's chest, replacing the anxiety of the drive with a new, energetic rhythm.

As they merged onto I-81 South, leaving Zane's Market behind, Freddie watched the neon sign fade in the mirror. He didn't know it yet, but he had just crossed the border into the most important forty-eight hours of his life.

Scene 3: The Detour

Friday, October 25, 2002

The merge onto I-81 South from Route 250 was supposed to be the start of the open road. Instead, it was a parking lot.

Jessica's silver Avalon sat near the end of the on-ramp, the engine idling roughly. Ahead, a sea of brake lights stretched into infinity, glowing angry red against the twilight.

"Gridlock," Freddie observed from the back seat. "Zero velocity."

"It's a wreck," Jessica growled, shifting the stick into Neutral and pulling the handbrake. "I-81 is a chute. One semi jackknifes, and the whole valley shuts down. We could be here for three hours."

She looked at the rearview mirror. Freddie was tapping his knee, the lack of forward motion clearly agitating his internal gyroscope. Paige was staring out the window, looking bored.

"Not today," Jessica declared.

She stomped on the clutch, slammed the stick into First, and did something illegal. She cut the wheel hard to the right, driving over the painted gore point and onto the exit ramp for **Exit 221**, which merged onto I-64 East toward Richmond.

"Evasive maneuvers," Paige grinned, grabbing the grab handle.

"We're going backwards," Freddie noted, looking at the compass on the dash. "East is wrong."

"Trust the pilot," Jessica said.

The traffic vanished instantly. The Avalon roared up the empty highway. Jessica took **Exit 91**, swinging the car onto the ramp for Route 285/Route 608.

"Left goes to Fishersville," Jessica narrated, pointing toward the lights of the town Freddie had noted earlier. "But we're going right. Route 608 to Stuarts Draft. It's the back door."

She banked the car right. The road narrowed to a two-lane blacktop winding through farmland. It was pitch black out here, save for the headlights cutting through the cornfields.

"This is where you learn to drive, Freddie," Jessica said, downshifting for a sharp curve. The engine revved—a precise, mechanical growl. "You hear that?"

"High RPM," Freddie said.

"That's torque," Jessica explained. "This is a stick shift. An automatic transmission guesses what you want. A manual transmission waits for your command. When you're passing a truck on I-81, you don't want the car to guess. You want to drop a gear and disappear."

She worked the pedals with a dancer's grace—clutch, shift, gas—keeping the car smooth through the twisting back roads of Augusta County.

"I have passed the theory exam," Freddie said, watching her hand on the stick. "I understand the gear ratios."

"Theory is one thing," Jessica said. "Doing it when you have a Iron-Haul grille in your rearview mirror is another. Next time I'm home, we're going to a parking lot. You're learning."

They reached the end of Route 608. Jessica made a right onto US-340 South, blasting past sleepy farmhouses until the road dead-ended at US-11.

"North to go south," Jessica muttered, turning right onto US-11 North. A quarter-mile later, she signaled left, merging onto the I-81 South on-ramp.

They slid onto the interstate. The highway was empty. In the northbound lanes to their left, miles of headlights sat motionless, trapped behind the wreck they had just circumnavigated.

"Clear skies," Jessica smirked, shifting into Fifth gear. "That is how you beat the system."

Scene 4: Pepper Plaza

The rest of the drive was a blur of darkness and trucks. Jessica navigated the "chute" of I-81 with aggressive competence, darting between massive 18-wheelers that swayed in the wind.

"Exit 118B," Jessica announced an hour later. "Christiansburg. Blacksburg. The Holy Land."

She took the ramp, looping around onto **US-11 / Business US-460**.

"Falling Branch Park and Ride is right there," Jessica pointed to a dark lot off the exit. "That's the end of the line for the local buses. But we're going downtown."

She turned left, heading into the heart of Christiansburg. The town was older, grittier than the polished suburbs of Virginia Beach. They passed auto parts stores and diners until the road opened up into a square dominated by the county courthouse.

"Pepper Plaza," Jessica announced, turning into a side street. "Transfer point."

Freddie looked out the window. It was a hub of activity.

Three buses were idling in the plaza, their engines rumbling. They weren't the yellow school buses he was used to. These were sleek, white and maroon city buses marked **Blue Ridge Transit**.

"Look at the signs," Freddie whispered, reading the LED headers.

The first bus, a massive 60-foot articulated vehicle that bent in the middle like an accordion, displayed: **1 CPI**. "That one goes to the university," Jessica explained. "Straight shot."

The second bus, a standard 40-foot model, displayed: **1 FALLING BRANCH**. "That one goes back to where we just got off the highway," Jessica said. "It runs the full length. No short turns.".

A third bus sat nearby, displaying **3 RADFORD**.

"The grid is active," Freddie said, fascinated by the coordination of the heavy machines.

"It runs seven days a week," Jessica said. "If you have a student ID, you ride for free. Anywhere.".

She pulled the Avalon into a parking lot just a block away from the plaza. It was a brick apartment building that looked like it had been built in the 70s—solid, unpretentious, and quiet.

Scene 5: The Configuration

"Second floor," Jessica said, grabbing her bag. "Apartment 2B."

They hauled their luggage up the concrete stairs. Jessica unlocked the door, revealing a sparse, tidy living room.

"Okay," Jessica said, tossing her keys on the counter. "Here's the schematic."

She walked over to the beige sofa and pulled the cushions off. She gripped a metal bar hidden in the frame and pulled. With a squeak of springs and a heavy *thunk*, the sofa unfolded into a double bed with a thin mattress.

"It's not a luxury cloud," Jessica admitted, patting the thin surface. "It's a generic sleeper. But it's flat."

She pulled a set of jersey sheets from a closet and started making the bed.

"Dad had a malfunction about this," Paige said quietly, watching her sister work. "About the sleeping arrangement. He looked at us like we were... contaminated."

Freddie stood by the door, his hands clenching and unclenching. The memory of his father's disgust in the hallway was a corrupted file he couldn't delete.

"Why?" Freddie asked. He didn't look at them; he looked at the floor. "We are siblings. We are a unit. Why does he generate an error code when we regulate? Why is he afraid?"

Jessica stopped tucking the sheet. She straightened up, looking at the two of them. They were seventeen. They were seniors. They had sat through the awkward Health class videos. They knew the biological mechanics of the world, even if they didn't participate in them.

"Sit down," Jessica said gently.

Freddie and Paige sat on the edge of the newly made sofa bed. Jessica sat on the coffee table facing them, leaning forward with her elbows on her knees.

"Freddie," Jessica started, her voice steady and serious. "You know in Family Life class, when they talked about... adult intimacy? Reproduction?"

"Yes," Freddie said, stiffening slightly. "The biological imperative."

"Right," Jessica nodded. "Well, Dad... he operates on a very standard, very rigid program. To him, and to a lot of people in the world, a bed isn't just a place to sleep. It's a place for *that*."

She took a breath, choosing her words carefully.

"When Dad sees a seventeen-year-old male and a seventeen-year-old female in a bed together, he doesn't see a brother and sister helping each other survive sensory overload. He sees a man and a woman. And he is terrified—absolutely terrified—that you two are engaging in... inappropriate activities. He thinks you're crossing a line that siblings are never supposed to cross."

Paige's face went pale. "He thinks... he thinks we're..."

"Yes," Jessica said softly. "He thinks you're being intimate. Like a couple."

Freddie looked up, his eyes wide with genuine confusion. "But that is illogical. The genetic data prohibits it. The social contract prohibits it. We are just... sleeping. We are holding on."

"I know," Jessica said firmly. "I know that. I know that Paige is your ground wire. I know that for you, touch is about pressure and safety, not sex. But Dad? He can't separate the two. His software is outdated, Freddie. He can't

understand a world where a boy and a girl share a bed just to keep the noise out."

She reached out and put a hand on Freddie's knee.

"He's wrong," Jessica said. "He's wrong to project that onto you. But that is *why* he freaks out. It's not because he hates you. It's because he's scared of something that isn't even happening."

Freddie processed this. He imagined his father's fear, not as hatred, but as a miscalculation. A data error.

"He is reading the wrong sensor data," Freddie concluded.

"Exactly," Jessica smiled sadly. "He's reading the wrong data."

She stood up and finished smoothing the blanket.

"But in this house," Jessica declared, her voice returning to its usual confident tone, "we know the truth. We prioritize regulation over optics. You guys sleep however you need to sleep to get through the night. I don't care what it looks like. I care that you wake up rested."

Freddie felt his shoulders drop three inches. The "Architecture" here was different. It was based on truth, not fear.

"Thank you," Freddie whispered.

"You're welcome," Jessica said, turning off the main light. "Now get some sleep. Tomorrow, we hit the Open House. And then... we Stomp."

The Machine

Scene 1: Route 1

"Rise and shine, recruits. Boots on the ground in twenty."

Jessica's voice cut through the morning silence of the apartment like a whistle. She was already dressed in her maroon "Forger" sweatshirt and jeans, standing in the kitchenette with the efficiency of a shift commander.

Freddie groaned, untangling his legs from the sheets of the pull-out sofa. Beside him, Paige blinked against the light, shielding her eyes.

"Breakfast is light," Jessica announced, setting three bowls on the small laminate counter. She shook a box of generic "Honey Oat Rings" into them and splashed milk from a jug. "There's a continental spread at the Open House—bagels, fruit, bad coffee—so don't fill up. This is just fuel to get us to the launch pad."

Freddie sat up, rubbing his face. The anxiety hit him instantly—a low-level hum in his chest. *Open House. Crowds. Evaluation.*

" Eat," Jessica commanded, handing him a spoon. "We catch the bus at 07:15."

"Bus?" Paige asked, yawning. "Why don't we drive? You have a car."

"Driving onto campus is a tactical error," Jessica said, crunching a spoonful of oats. "I don't have a parking permit. Even though they lift restrictions for the Open House, the lots will be a zoo. Parents fighting for spaces, circling like sharks. We don't do that. We take the system."

She pulled her wallet out of her bag.

"We're taking **Blue Ridge Transit**," she explained. "It's the local municipal system. I have a CPI ID, so I ride for free. You two are civilians, so you pay the standard fare: one dollar each."

She placed two crisp one-dollar bills on the counter.

"We're catching the **Number 1**," Jessica continued. "It runs along Business 460. On a weekday, that bus is a sardine can—students packed in so tight you can't move your arms. It's what we call 'crush load.' But it's Saturday morning, so it'll just be 'crowded.' We should be able to get seats."

Freddie ate his cereal mechanically, processing the data. *Bus. Number 1. One dollar. 07:15.*

"Okay," Freddie said. "I am ready."

They stepped out of the apartment building into the crisp mountain air. It was cold—much colder than Virginia Beach—and the sky was a piercing, cloudless blue.

"One block," Jessica said, pulling her hood up. "Target is Pepper Plaza."

They walked down the quiet street toward the center of town. Pepper Plaza was a concrete island located right next to the historic Montgomery County Courthouse. It served as a transfer hub for the area.

A small crowd was already waiting—mostly students heading to the library for weekend study sessions and a few locals with grocery bags.

Then, they heard it. The deep, diesel rumble of a heavy engine.

"Inbound," Jessica said.

The bus turned the corner. It was white with maroon and orange stripes, emblazoned with the logo **Blue Ridge Transit**. The LED destination sign above the windshield glowed amber: **1 CPI**.

"It's on time," Freddie noted, checking his watch. "Precision."

"It runs every fifteen minutes on the weekdays," Jessica said. "It's the heartbeat of the town."

The bus hissed to a halt in front of them. The doors folded open.

"Money out," Jessica instructed.

She climbed the steps first, flashing her student ID at the driver. The driver nodded. Paige followed, feeding her dollar bill into the farebox. Freddie went last, carefully inserting his bill and listening to the machine accept it with a *whir-click*.

The interior of the bus smelled of vinyl seats and floor cleaner. It wasn't empty, but Jessica was right—it wasn't "crush loaded." There were empty seats near the back.

"Take the window," Paige told Freddie, sliding into the row behind the rear exit door.

Freddie sat down. The engine roared as the bus pulled away from Pepper Plaza, merging onto North Franklin Street.

"Next stop," the automated voice announced, "Business 460."

The ride was smooth. They rolled out of downtown Christiansburg and onto the four-lane highway that connected the two towns. Freddie watched the world go by—strip malls, car dealerships, and the rolling hills of the valley.

"Thirty minutes," Jessica said, leaning forward from the seat behind them. "We'll get off across the street from Newman Hall, which is hosting the open house."

Freddie pressed his forehead against the cold glass. The bus was a contained environment. The rules were posted on the wall. The stops were announced. The fare was fixed.

"I like the bus," Freddie whispered to Paige. "It makes sense."

"It does," Paige agreed, squeezing his hand.

The automated voice chimed again.

"Route 1 to Commonwealth Polytechnical Institute Transit Center," it droned.

Ahead of them, the stone towers of the university rose up against the mountains. The Machine was waiting.

Scene 2: The Acoustic Engine

The bus hissed to a halt on the Alumni Mall.

"End of the line," Jessica announced, standing up as the doors folded open. "Everyone out."

They stepped onto the concrete platform. The Transit Center was a massive, open-air loop located in the heart of the campus. To Freddie, it looked like a docking bay. Buses were pulling in and out with clockwork precision, their diesel engines rumbling in a synchronized, low-frequency hum that he found soothing.

"Newman Hall is this way," Jessica said, pointing toward a large, limestone building across the Drillfield. "It's the Student Union. That's where they hold

the welcome ceremony."

They walked into the wind. The campus was waking up. The distinctive campus architecture—rough-cut grey limestone with accents of deep maroon—looked like a fortress against the bright blue sky.

"It's called **Ironstone**," Jessica said, tapping one of the heavy blocks as they passed an archway. "It's local limestone. It's what makes the campus look like a castle. It feels... solid."

"The geometry is consistent," Freddie noted, his eyes tracking the lines of the mortar. "It feels safe."

They reached the double doors of Newman Hall. Jessica pulled one open, and the cold mountain air was instantly replaced by the warmth of the atrium.

It was a cavernous space, filled with the smell of brewing coffee and the murmur of hundreds of prospective students and their parents. But cutting through the noise was a sound that stopped Freddie in his tracks.

Music.

But it wasn't the recorded music from the bus. It was live. It was raw.

"Target acquired," Jessica grinned, pointing toward a small stage set up near the continental breakfast station. "You guys are in for a treat. That's the home team."

On the stage, two people were performing.

To the right sat a woman behind a portable keyboard setup. She had long dark hair and was playing a sweeping, intricate melody that sounded like classical music mixed with pop.

To the left was a man with a guitar. He had a microphone stand positioned directly in front of him. He was singing with a voice that was gritty, powerful, and filled with a raw energy that seemed to vibrate the air in the atrium.

But Freddie didn't look at the guitar. He looked at the chair.

The man wasn't standing. He was sitting in a sleek, lightweight wheelchair. His legs were still, resting on the footplate, but his upper body was moving with the rhythm of the song. He wasn't hiding behind the keyboard. He wasn't tucked in the back. He was front and center, commanding the room.

"That's **The Stardust Engine**," Jessica whispered, leaning down to Freddie's ear. "Ryan and Cassidy O'Connell. They're alumni. Class of '89."

Freddie stared. "He is... sitting."

"Yeah," Jessica said matter-of-factly. "Ryan's a T10 paraplegic. Car crash back in '90." "But listen to him. He's still the Engine."

Ryan strummed a hard, acoustic chord, his face contorted with the effort of the note.

"But when the world is spinning out of my control," Ryan sang, his voice soaring up to the high rafters of the atrium. *"You're the one true thing that I can hold!"*

Cassidy harmonized instantly, her voice blending with his in a perfect, biological lock—the kind that only siblings can achieve. *"Through the static and the driving rain, you're the one who keeps me sane."*

Freddie felt Paige squeeze his hand. Hard.

"Did you hear that?" Paige whispered, her eyes wide. "The static. They're singing about the static."

"My anchor holds," Ryan roared the final line, hitting a resonant chord that hung in the air. *"My anchor in this crazy youth."*

The crowd in the atrium broke into applause. Ryan didn't stand up to bow. He just grinned, spinning his wheelchair slightly to acknowledge the applause on the left, then the right. He looked powerful. He looked unbroken.

"He is not hiding the error," Freddie murmured, unable to take his eyes off the singer. "The system has a physical limitation, but the output is... nominal. It is exceeding parameters."

"He doesn't hide anything," Jessica said with pride. "That's why we love them. They're Forgers. They built this."

Ryan leaned into the mic. "Welcome to the Iron City, everyone!" he shouted, his voice booming without a hint of hesitation. "Grab a bagel. We're gonna take a short break, but we'll be back with some 'Electric Color' in ten minutes."

Freddie watched as Cassidy stood up and walked over to her brother. She didn't look down at him with pity. She handed him a bottle of water, and he laughed at something she said, punching her lightly on the arm. They were a unit. A team.

"Come on," Jessica said, nudging Freddie toward the food tables. "Let's get some fruit. You need glucose for the brain."

Freddie walked toward the bagels, but he kept glancing back at the stage. For the first time, the idea of being "different" at this school didn't feel like a fatal error. If the "Engine" could run on wheels, maybe Freddie could run on a different operating system too.

Scene 3: The Pitch

"Intel first, then fuel," Jessica instructed, steering them away from the bagel table for a moment. "We need the packet."

They joined the line at the registration tables. It was moving efficiently—a hallmark of an engineering school. A student volunteer in a maroon polo asked for their names, checked a list, and handed Freddie and Paige their "Candidate Kits."

It was a glossy maroon folder containing a campus map, a schedule of engineering breakout sessions, a CPI pen, and a sticker that said **FUTURE FORGER**.

Freddie opened the folder immediately. The map was laid out on a grid. The schedule was color-coded.

"The data is organized," Freddie noted, running his finger down the itinerary. "10:00 AM: Mechanical Engineering Presentation. 11:00 AM: Computer Science Lab Tour."

"Solid," Jessica nodded. "Now, we eat."

They retreated to a high-top table near a pillar. The continental breakfast was standard institutional fare: trays of bagels, tubs of cream cheese, and a large bowl of cut melon that Freddie eyed with suspicion.

"I will stick to the dry carbohydrates," Freddie decided, selecting a plain bagel. "The moisture content of the fruit is uncontrolled."

"Smart play," Jessica said, sipping her coffee. "You don't want sticky hands before the handshake line."

As they ate, the noise in the atrium began to shift. The murmuring crowd was flowing toward the double doors of the Grand Ballroom.

"Showtime," Jessica announced, checking her watch. "The President's Welcome Address starts in five minutes. We need to secure a perimeter seat."

The Grand Ballroom of Newman Hall was a sea of folding chairs. Jessica led them to a row near the back, on the aisle.

"Escape route secured," she whispered to Freddie. "If it gets too loud, we can slip out the side door."

"Acknowledged," Freddie whispered back. He sat down, clutching his folder like a shield.

The lights dimmed. The room went quiet. On the stage, a podium bearing the CPI seal—a hammer and a quill crossed over a shield—was spotlighted.

A man in a dark suit walked onto the stage. He looked like a statesman, grey-haired and distinguished, but he walked with a brisk, energetic stride.

"Good morning," the man said. His voice was warm but authoritative. "I am President Harrison. And on behalf of the faculty, the staff, and the Forger Nation... welcome to the Iron City."

Polite applause rippled through the room.

"You are here because you are looking for something," Harrison continued, resting his hands on the podium. "You are looking for a college. You have brochures from the **University of the Piedmont**, from **The Royal College**, from **Atlanta Poly** and **Massachusetts Tech**. They are all fine institutions. They will teach you theory. They will teach you history."

He paused, leaning forward.

"But at Commonwealth Polytechnic, we do not just teach history. We forge the future."

He gestured to the screen behind him, which flashed images of students welding steel, coding in dark labs, and launching rockets.

"Our motto is *Ut Prosim*—That I May Serve. That is not a suggestion. That is a command. We believe that knowledge is useless unless it is applied to the service of humanity. We don't just want you to be smart. We want you to be useful."

Freddie sat up straighter. *Useful.* That was a variable he understood.

"This is not an easy school," Harrison warned, his voice dropping to a serious register. "The wind blows harder here. The winters are colder. The curriculum is rigorous. We will push you. We will test your metal. We will put you in the crucible and turn up the heat."

He smiled, a genuine, challenging smile.

"But if you stay... if you do the work... you will not just leave with a degree. You will leave with a spine of iron. You will leave as a Forger. And you will be ready to build the world that everyone else just dreams about."

The screen faded to the CPI logo.

"Look around you," Harrison commanded. "Look at the person sitting next to you. They might be your future lab partner. They might be the person you start a company with. Or..." he smiled at the parents, "...they might just be your ride home."

Laughter rippled through the crowd.

"Enjoy the day," Harrison concluded. "Ask hard questions. Explore the labs. And ask yourself: Are you ready to pick up the hammer?"

The applause was louder this time. The lights came up.

"He is persuasive," Freddie said, standing up. "He defines the variables clearly."

"He's good," Jessica agreed. "Now comes the real test. We have thirty minutes to get you to the Computer Science building. And Freddie?"

"Yes?"

"Prepare yourself," Jessica grinned. "You're about to see the servers."

Scene 4: The Terminal

The Computer Sciences building, **Kelvin Hall**, was different from the rest of the campus. It didn't smell like old limestone or floor wax. It smelled of ozone, heated plastic, and coffee.

And it was cold.

"Server cooling," Jessica explained, seeing Freddie zip up his jacket. "They keep the ambient temperature at 68 degrees year-round to protect the hardware. You get used to wearing hoodies in July."

They walked into the main lab—a massive room filled with rows of beige towers and heavy CRT monitors. It was quiet here, the only sound being the rhythmic clatter of keyboards and the low, constant hum of cooling fans.

"Avery!" a voice boomed from the front of the room.

A man with a messy beard and a t-shirt that said **THERE IS NO PLACE LIKE 127.0.0.1** walked over. He was holding a stack of papers.

"Dr. Aris," Jessica grinned. "I'm not on duty today. Just bringing the reinforcements."

"Recruits?" Dr. Aris asked, looking at the twins.

"Potential recruits," Jessica corrected. "This is my brother Freddie and my sister Paige. They're seniors."

"Avery, huh?" Dr. Aris nodded at Freddie. "If you're half as stubborn as your sister, you'll do fine. Look around. Don't touch the red switches. Anything else is fair game."

Freddie drifted away from the group. He wasn't interested in the posters on the wall or the brochures. He was drawn to a workstation in the corner that looked different from the Quantum machines he used at home.

The monitor wasn't displaying a desktop with a start button and colorful icons. It was black. Pitch black.

In the top left corner, a single cursor blinked green.

user@cpi-cs-lab:~$ _

Freddie stared at it. It was stark. It was empty. It was beautiful.

"It's a terminal," Jessica said, appearing behind him. "It's running Nix-OS. No GUI. No mouse. You talk to the computer directly."

"Directly?" Freddie whispered.

"Type ls," Jessica instructed. "That lists the files."

Freddie reached out. The keyboard was mechanical, the keys heavy and satisfying.

l... s... Enter.

Instantly, text cascaded down the screen—a neat, ordered list of directories.

Documents Downloads Projects scripts.sh

"It... obeyed," Freddie said, his eyes wide. "There was no delay. No animation. No hourglass."

"Graphical User Interfaces—GUIs—are just a mask," Jessica explained. "They act like a translator between you and the machine. They add layers of abstraction. But the Terminal? That's the raw language. You type a command, the kernel executes it. Zero ambiguity."

Freddie felt a rush of dopamine hit his brain. *Zero ambiguity.*

He turned to Dr. Aris, who had wandered over to watch.

"Question," Freddie said, his voice steady. He wasn't looking at the floor; he was looking at the screen.

"Shoot," Dr. Aris said.

"Does the curriculum start with abstraction layers, or do we interact with the metal?"

Dr. Aris raised an eyebrow. He looked at Jessica, then back at Freddie.

"Most freshmen ask if we teach game design," Dr. Aris smiled. "But to answer your question: We don't touch High level code or GUIs until your junior year. Freshman year is C and C++. You manage your own memory. You handle your own pointers. If you write bad code, you crash the kernel. We teach you to drive the car by building the engine first."

"Memory management," Freddie repeated, savoring the words. "So we control the allocation?"

"Every byte," Dr. Aris confirmed. "It's tedious. It's unforgiving. And it's the only way to really understand how the machine thinks."

Freddie looked back at the blinking green cursor. It wasn't just a tool. It was a mirror. It was a system that operated exactly like he did—logical, literal, and overwhelmed by unnecessary visual noise. The GUI was the "mask" he had to wear every day to interact with people. The Terminal was who he really was.

"I like the black screen," Freddie decided. "It is quiet."

"It's the cleanest signal in the world," Jessica agreed.

Freddie looked at Dr. Aris. "I am applying. I want to learn the syntax."

"We'll be looking for your application, Mr. Avery," Dr. Aris said, nodding with genuine respect. "We need more coders who like the metal."

As they walked out of Kelvin Hall back into the bright sunlight, Freddie felt invincible. The "Architecture" of his future was falling into place. He had the school (CPI). He had the major (Computer Science). And he had the Blueprint for the housing.

"The variables are aligning," Freddie said, adjusting his backpack. "This is a viable environment."

"I told you," Jessica grinned. "Now, let's go refuel. You're going to need energy for the Housing Session. We have to measure those furniture dimensions, right?"

"Affirmative," Freddie said, pulling out his tape measure. "Precision is key."

Scene 5: The Foundry

The main dining hall at CPI was a massive, rotunda-style building known as **The Foundry**.

If Kelvin Hall was a sanctuary of silence, The Foundry was a cathedral of chaos.

As soon as they approached the entrance, the wall of sound hit Freddie like a physical blow. It was the sound of three thousand students talking, the clatter of silverware on ceramic, the hiss of soda fountains, and the relentless *thrum-clack-thrum* of the massive dish return conveyor belt that circled the room.

"Tickets out," Jessica instructed, pulling the perforated lunch vouchers from their "Candidate Kits." "It's all-inclusive today. We just scan and go."

They handed their vouchers to the cashier, who scanned them with a beep and waved them through the turnstiles.

Freddie stopped. His hands immediately went to the straps of his backpack, pulling them tight.

"It is loud," Freddie stated. His voice was flat, a sign that he was manually adjusting his audio input levels.

"It's the lunch rush," Jessica said unapologetically. "Grab a tray. Follow me. We go to the pasta station. It's the fastest line."

They navigated the crowd. Freddie kept his eyes on Paige's back, using her as a shield against the visual noise of the room. He focused on his breathing. *In for four. Hold for four. Out for four.*

They got their food—bowls of pasta with red sauce and plastic cups of blue Blue Ion—and found a table near the window. It was slightly quieter here, but the ambient roar was still intense.

Freddie sat down. He didn't eat immediately. He stared at the pasta, waiting for his hands to stop vibrating.

"You okay?" Paige asked, breaking her breadstick in half. She didn't look worried; she looked operational. She was checking his gauges.

"The signal-to-noise ratio is critical," Freddie admitted, glancing at a table of loud fraternity brothers nearby. "It is a hostile acoustic environment."

"It is," Paige agreed. "But look at the map."

She tapped his maroon folder.

"We have the dorm," she reminded him. "Think about the schematic. Quiet. Blackout curtains. Deep pressure. When the day is over, you eject from this..." she gestured to the loud cafeteria, "...and you go to the bunker."

Freddie nodded slowly. The logic held.

"I can sustain this," Freddie calculated, picking up his fork. "I can endure the Foundry and the classes and the crowds... if I have the recharge station."

"Exactly," Jessica said, stealing a fry from Paige's plate (she had used her voucher for the burger line). "That's how everyone survives engineering, Freddie. You grind all day, and you crash at night. And since you guys are rooming together, you'll have your own ecosystem. You won't have to deal with some random roommate playing loud music or bringing girls over."

"Zero random variables," Freddie said, taking a bite of pasta. The thought was soothing. The "Twin Dorm" wasn't just a room; it was the structural support beam for his entire college career. As long as he had that, he could handle anything.

"Okay," Jessica said, checking her watch. "Eat up. The **Housing & Residence Life** presentation is at 13:00 in the Squires Auditorium. We need to get there early to ask about the bed straps."

"I have the dimensions ready," Freddie said, tapping his pocket. "I am ready to finalize the contract."

He finished his pasta with renewed purpose. He wasn't afraid of the Housing Director. Why would he be? The plan was logical. The medical need was documented. It was just a formality.

They cleared their trays on the loud conveyor belt—*clack-clack-clack*—and walked out into the sunshine, heading toward the auditorium to sign the paperwork that Freddie believed would save his life.

Scene 6: The Old Lady on the Hill

They arrived at **Bennett Hall**.

It sat perched on the steep incline of the campus geography, a brick-and-limestone structure that looked less like a dormitory and more like a fortress that had seen better days.

"They call her 'The Old Lady on the Hill'," Jessica explained as they approached the lower entrance at the bottom of the slope. "She's one of the oldest dorms. No air conditioning in the rooms, radiator heat that clanks all night, and the elevators are slower than a dial-up modem. But the location is prime."

They entered the first-floor lobby. It was a functional space with tile floors, a front desk, and a few worn sofas. A "Welcome to CPI" banner hung over a folding table where a woman with a kind face and a name tag reading **HALL DIRECTOR** was organizing pamphlets.

"Check-in is here," Jessica said, signing them in on a clipboard.

"Welcome," the Hall Director smiled. "The tour group is gathering by the elevator. Your guide is Mandy."

Waiting by the silver elevator doors was a girl in a manual wheelchair. She wore a maroon CPI polo and had a bright, efficient energy about her.

"Hi everyone," Mandy said, spinning her chair to face the small group of parents and students. "I'm Mandy. I'm a sophomore, and I live in Bennett. We're going to head up to the second floor to see my suite. Fair warning: it's tight. We're in a housing crisis, so we're getting really cozy this year."

She pressed the call button.

"Since the building is built into the hill," Mandy explained, "the first floor is down here, but the second floor actually exits out onto the top of the hill on the other side. I use the elevator to avoid the climb, and if you have a documented disability, you can get access to use it as a pass-through too."

The elevator dinged. They piled in and rode up to the second floor.

Mandy led them down a hallway that smelled of popcorn and floor wax, stopping at a door marked **214**. She tapped a sensor next to the handle with her ID card, and the heavy door clicked and swung open automatically.

"Welcome to the sardine can," Mandy joked, rolling inside.

Freddie stepped in and immediately felt the walls close in.

The room was designed for two people. It currently held three.

To his left was a single Twin XL bed. "This is my spot," Mandy explained. "I have the standalone bed so I can transfer easily."

To the right was a bunk bed.

"My roommate Aubrie is on the bottom," Mandy pointed to the lower bunk. "And Madison takes the altitude training on the top."

The room was packed. There were two desks and two dressers, which meant sharing. There was a sink on the wall with no cabinet underneath, allowing Mandy to roll right up to it.

"It is... dense," Freddie whispered, calculating the square footage per person.

"It gets better," Mandy said. "Or worse, depending on how you look at it."

She opened a door at the back of the room. It revealed a tiny, tiled room containing a single toilet and grab bars on the walls.

"This connects us to Room 216," Mandy explained. "On the other side are Hannah, Zoe, and Lauren. So, that's six girls sharing one toilet."

"Where do you shower?" a parent asked.

"Communal bathrooms in the hall," Mandy said. "But we have a separate accessible shower room down the hall for privacy or if anyone needs assistance."

Freddie looked at the bunk bed. It was tight. It was chaotic. But he looked at Paige. If they had this—if they had the "bunker"—he could make it work.

The tour concluded, and the group took the elevator back down to the first-floor lobby.

As the other families drifted toward the exit, Freddie stopped. His mind was racing. He needed to confirm the variable. He needed the stamp of approval.

"Jessica," Freddie said. "I have a query for the Administrator."

He walked over to the welcome table where the Hall Director was stacking brochures.

"Excuse me," Freddie said. His voice was steady, hopeful.

The Hall Director looked up, smiling. "Yes? Did you enjoy the tour?"

"The architecture is efficient," Freddie said. "I have a question regarding the assignment protocol. My sister Paige," he gestured to her, "and I are applying. We are twins."

"That's wonderful," the Director said. "Legacies?"

"Yes," Freddie said. "We have a medical requirement. I suffer from night terrors and sensory dysregulation during sleep cycles. Paige provides deep pressure regulation. We share a bed at home to maintain stability."

He took a breath, delivering the solution he had carried in his head for weeks.

"We would like to request a room assignment together. We do not require a suite. A standard double room is sufficient, provided we can configure the beds."

The Hall Director's smile faltered. She put down the brochure she was holding. She looked at Freddie's open, earnest face, and then at Paige and Jessica standing just behind him. She realized instantly that this wasn't a joke.

"Honey," the Director said, her voice dropping to a gentle, apologetic tone. "I'm afraid we can't do that."

Freddie blinked. "I can provide documentation. The medical necessity is—"

"It's not about the documentation," she interrupted softly. "It's university policy. All residence halls are strictly single-gender assignment. Men in the male wings, women in the female wings. We cannot place a brother and sister in the same room. It's simply not done."

The words hit Freddie like a physical object.

Cannot.

Single-gender.

Not done.

The logic of the Blueprint—the logic that had sustained him through the noise of the cafeteria, the chaos of the tour, the stress of the day—shattered.

The buzzing in his ears, usually a low hum, screamed into a high-pitched whine. The lobby lights seemed to flare brighter. The floor tilted.

"Freddie?" Paige stepped forward, reaching for his hand.

He pulled away.

"Invalid," Freddie choked out. "The structure is... invalid."

Then, the vibration took over.

He let out a sound that wasn't a word—a guttural, terrified cry of absolute despair. He dropped to his knees on the tile floor, his hands clapping over his ears, rocking violently back and forth.

"Freddie!" Jessica dropped her bag and lunged for him.

"NO! NO! NO!" Freddie screamed, the sound tearing out of his throat. It wasn't a tantrum. It was the sound of a world ending. "SYSTEM FAILURE! SYSTEM FAILURE!"

The lobby went silent. Every head turned.

"It's okay, Freddie, I've got you," Paige was on the floor with him instantly, wrapping her arms around his chest, trying to apply the squeeze, trying to be the anchor.

But he was too far gone. He thrashed against her, his limbs flailing, his eyes squeezed shut, tears streaming down his face. He was non-verbal, lost in a white-hot static of panic.

"Is he okay? Should I call security?" the Hall Director asked, stepping around the table, looking alarmed.

"No security!" Jessica snapped, her voice fierce. "He's having a meltdown. We need a quiet room. Now."

"My office," the Director said, pointing to a door behind the desk. "It's soundproof."

It took both of them to move him. Paige held his torso, Jessica guided his legs, as they shuffled him into the small office. The Director closed the door, cutting off the stares of the lobby.

Freddie curled into a ball in the corner of the office, rocking and keening, a high, thin sound of misery. Paige sat behind him, wrapping her legs around his, pulling him tight against her chest, burying her face in his neck.

"I'm here," she whispered over and over. "I'm here. I'm not leaving."

Jessica knelt in front of him, trying to catch his eyes, but he wouldn't look.

"Freddie," Jessica said, keeping her voice low and steady. "Listen to me. We have other options. We can look at off-campus apartments. We can find a place where the rules are different."

She was careful not to say *share a bed* in front of the Director, but she poured every ounce of reassurance she had into her tone.

"It's broken," Freddie sobbed, his voice ragged. "The Blueprint is broken."

They sat there for fifteen minutes. Slowly, the screaming stopped. The rocking slowed. The energy drained out of him, leaving him limp and exhausted against Paige's chest.

The Hall Director watched them from her desk, her expression softening from alarm to sympathy. She looked at the way Paige held him, the way Jessica guarded him.

"Has he..." the Director hesitated, then asked gently. "Has he ever been evaluated for autism? Or being on the spectrum?"

Jessica and Paige looked at each other. They had heard the word *retarded* used by bullies. They had heard *sensitive* used by their mother. They had heard *difficult* used by their father. But *autism*? That was a word for people who couldn't speak at all, or who rocked in corners...

Jessica looked at Freddie, who was currently rocking in a corner, unable to speak.

Oh.

"We don't know," Jessica said shortly. "We just know he needs to get out of here."

"Of course," the Director nodded. "Take all the time you need."

"We're leaving," Jessica decided. "He needs to evacuate."

Getting him out was a slow process. Freddie was drained, his face pale and streaked with tears. He stood up on shaky legs.

Paige didn't let go of his hand. She gripped it so tight her knuckles were white.

"Ground me," Freddie whispered, his voice a ghost.

"I've got you," Paige promised.

They walked out of the office, through the silent lobby, and out the front doors into the cool afternoon air of the valley.

Jessica led them to a wooden bench near the treeline, away from the path. Freddie collapsed onto it, staring at the mountains. They didn't look like a fortress anymore. They looked like walls.

Paige sat next to him, pulling his arm through hers.

"We will fix this," Paige said, her voice fierce and absolute. "I don't care what the policy says. I don't care what Dad says. We will find a loophole. You and me. We are not sleeping apart."

Freddie looked at her. The static in his head was still deafening, but her voice cut through it.

"A loophole," Freddie repeated, closing his eyes. "I need a loophole."

Scene 7: The Reset

The bench was made of rough-hewn wood and cold iron, sitting on the edge of a grassy overlook near Bennett Hall. From here, the campus spread out below them like a circuit board—the grid of the Drillfield, the stone towers of the academic buildings, and in the distance, the massive concrete bowl of **The Crucible**.

Freddie sat in the middle, staring at the mountains. He was completely silent. The screaming had stripped his throat raw, leaving him in a state of absolute mute exhaustion. The static in his head had settled from a roar into a dull, heavy gray noise.

Paige sat pressed against his side, her arms wrapped tightly around his ribs, her head resting on his shoulder. She wasn't just hugging him; she was holding him together. She was applying the deep pressure he couldn't ask for.

Jessica stood in front of them, blocking the sun, acting as a visual shield against the few students walking past on the sidewalk.

"Autism," Jessica whispered the word, tasting it. It felt heavy. "That's what she asked."

"I've heard the word," Paige said softly, her cheek still pressed against Freddie's jacket. "But I thought it meant... I didn't think it meant *this*. I thought it meant you couldn't look at people at all."

"He looks at *us*," Jessica said. "He looks at the terminal."

"We'll look it up," Paige vowed, squeezing Freddie tighter. "Tonight. We'll go to the library or use Jessica's computer. We'll find out what the variables are."

Freddie heard them, but the words were distant. He was focusing on the wind. The air here was thin and cold. It bit at his cheeks. It was real. It grounded him.

Autism.

He filed the word away. It was a label. A diagnostic code. If it was a valid code, it meant there was a manual. And if there was a manual, there was a way to operate the system.

They sat there for twenty minutes. The sun began to dip lower, casting long shadows across the "Ironstone" fortress.

Jessica finally crouched down so she was at eye level with Freddie. She didn't touch him—she knew Paige was handling the tactile input—but she spoke clearly and directly.

"Okay, Freddie," Jessica said. "Status check. We are done with the official schedule. The Housing Office is a fail state. We know that."

Freddie didn't blink. He just stared at her nose, avoiding her eyes.

"Here is the decision tree," Jessica continued. "Option A: We walk to the bus stop right now. We take the Number 1 back to Christiansburg. We order pizza, we watch a movie, and we go home tomorrow."

She paused.

"Option B: We stay. The game starts at 19:00. The sun is going down. The 'Ironheads' are gathering. We go to the stadium tunnel. We watch the team run out. We feel the Stomp."

Paige shifted slightly. "Jess, maybe we should just go. . . "

"No," Jessica said firmly, keeping her eyes on Freddie. "He decides. He came here for the architecture. He came here for the machine. I want to know if he still wants to see it."

She waited.

Freddie looked at the mountains. He replayed the day in his head. *The Terminal. The black screen. The blinking green cursor. The Stardust Engine. The man in the wheelchair who didn't hide his broken legs. The Housing Director. The rejection. The broken Blueprint.*

It was a critical error. A fatal system crash.

But. . .

He thought about the Terminal again. *user@cpi-cs-lab:~$*. It was the only time in his life he had felt like he was speaking his native language. If he left now, he was leaving that language behind. He would go back to Virginia Beach, back to the noise, back to the silence of his father's house.

He didn't want to go back. He wanted to find a loophole.

Freddie took a deep, shuddering breath. He slowly peeled his right hand away from his chest.

He pointed a shaking finger toward the massive stadium in the distance.

"The... Machine," Freddie rasped. His voice was a wreck, barely a whisper.

Jessica smiled. It was a fierce, proud smile.

"Affirmative," Jessica said, standing up. "We proceed to The Crucible."

"Are you sure?" Paige asked, pulling back to look at his face. "It's going to be loud. Louder than the cafeteria."

Freddie nodded slowly. "Structured... noise," he whispered. "The... grid."

"Okay," Paige said, wiping a stray tear from his cheek with her thumb. "Then we go."

She helped him stand up. He was shaky, his legs feeling like lead, but once he was upright, he locked his knees. He checked his backpack straps. He adjusted his collar.

"Reset complete," Jessica announced. "Let's go see the anvil."

They walked down the hill, away from Bennett Hall and its impossible rules, moving toward the dark, looming shape of the stadium where Freddie hoped he could drown out the rejection in sixty thousand decibels of rhythm.

Scene 8: The Iron Sea

The sun had dipped below the mountains, turning the sky into a bruised purple, but the campus was brighter than noon.

They left the quiet refuge of the bench and descended toward the south end of campus. As they walked, the atmosphere changed. It wasn't just the air getting colder; it was the ground getting hotter.

A low rumble—like a distant thunderstorm that refused to break—began to vibrate through the soles of Freddie's shoes.

"The Transit Center is empty," Freddie observed, looking at the bus loops they had used earlier. They were deserted, the bays dark.

"Diversion protocol," Jessica explained, pointing down the road. "On Game Day, the hub moves. The center of gravity shifts."

As they crested the hill overlooking Washington Street, Freddie saw it.

A convoy of **Blue Ridge Transit** buses was roaring toward the stadium in a continuous, unbroken line. They were massive, 60-foot articulated leviathans, groaning under the weight of passengers.

Every single window was steamed up. Every single bus was packed to "crush load"—bodies pressed against the glass, maroon jerseys everywhere.

Freddie focused on the LED destination signs. They were synchronized.

CRUCIBLE SHUTTLE...click... GO FORGERS!

"The logic," Freddie whispered, watching the buses discharge thousands of people onto the sidewalk in a coordinated flood. "It is a mass injection system."

"It's an invasion," Jessica grinned, applying a stripe of maroon greasepaint to her left cheek and an orange stripe to her right. "And we're the army."

The plaza outside **The Crucible** was a sensory riot. The smell of grilled sausages and funnel cake hung heavy in the air.

"Equipment check," Jessica said, steering them toward a white tent marked **FORGER FAN SHOP**. "You are currently out of uniform. That is a tactical error."

They ducked inside the tent. It was crowded, but Paige kept a tight grip on Freddie's sleeve.

"Pick a color," Jessica commanded. "Maroon or Orange. We don't do neutral here."

Paige grabbed a thick, maroon hooded sweatshirt. "Maroon matches the brick," she decided.

Freddie touched a bright, safety-orange hoodie. It was loud. It was visible. It was the color of a warning sign.

"Orange," Freddie said. "High visibility."

"Good choice," Jessica said, grabbing it and tossing it on the counter. She also grabbed a small blister pack from a display near the register.

She paid with cash, handing the bag to Paige.

"Put them on," Jessica said. "And Freddie? Install these."

She handed him the blister pack. **High-Fidelity Earplugs**.

Freddie opened the pack. He rolled the foam cylinders and inserted them into his ears. The roar of the crowd instantly dulled. The sharp, piercing spikes of laughter and shouting were smoothed out into a manageable, muted hum.

"Better?" Paige asked, pulling her maroon hood up.

Freddie pulled his orange hood up, creating a tunnel for his vision. He nodded. "The gain has been reduced. It is acceptable."

They approached the South End Zone entrance. The stadium loomed over them, a massive brutalist structure of concrete and steel that looked less like a sports arena and more like a reactor core.

"Hold hands," Jessica ordered, stopping in the crush of the crowd. "Do not let go. If you get separated, you go to the anvil statue and wait. But do not get separated."

Paige grabbed Freddie's left hand. Her grip was a vice, a physical reminder of her promise on the bench. Jessica grabbed his right.

They moved as a chain. Jessica pulled her **CPI ID** (PolyPass) out of her pocket. At the turnstile, she scanned it three times—*Beep. Beep. Beep.*—holding the gate for her siblings.

They burst into the concourse.

The noise was physical. Even with the earplugs, Freddie could feel it in his chest cavity. It was a deep, resonant thrumming, the sound of sixty thousand people breathing and shouting in unison.

"Food!" Jessica shouted over the noise, pointing to a concession stand. "We need calories!"

They waited in line, moving efficiently. Three hot dogs. Three large sodas. A tub of popcorn.

"Section 22, Row 14," Jessica read from her ticket stub. "That's the North End Zone. The Anvil. Student Section. We're in the blast radius."

They climbed the concrete stairs. As they emerged from the tunnel into the open bowl of the stadium, the sheer scale of the machine hit Freddie.

The field was a brilliant, impossible green under the stadium lights. The stands were a vertical wall of color—a sea of maroon and orange that stretched up to the stars.

"This is The Crucible," Jessica announced, leading them down the bleachers.

They found their row. Jessica took the aisle seat. Paige took the inside. They put Freddie in the middle, sandwiching him between them.

"Safe?" Paige asked, leaning close so he could hear her through the plugs.

Freddie looked around. To his left, a student was painted entirely silver. To his right, a group was chanting a complex mathematical cheer.

Cosine, Secant, Tangent, Sine! Three-point-one-four-one-five-nine! Go! Forgers!

Freddie blinked. He looked at the massive scoreboard.

CPI FORGERS vs. TALLAHASSEE STATE RENEGADES

"Tallahassee State," Jessica noted, following his gaze. "Ranked number four in the nation. They are a powerhouse. They have speed. They have money. They think they're going to walk in here and crush a bunch of engineering nerds."

She looked at Freddie, her face painted for war.

"But they forgot one thing, Freddie."

"What?" Freddie asked, clutching his soda.

"They aren't playing on grass," Jessica smiled, stomping her boot on the aluminum bleacher. "They're playing in a factory."

She checked the countdown clock on the scoreboard. **00:05:00**.

Jessica leaned in, putting a hand on Freddie's shoulder. Her expression was serious, almost religious.

"Okay, listen to me," she said, her voice cutting through the ambient roar. "In exactly five minutes, the lights are going to go out. It's going to get dark. And then, it's going to get loud. Louder than anything you've ever heard."

Freddie tightened his grip on his soda cup. "The Stomp?"

"The Stomp," Jessica confirmed. "Just remember the rhythm. It's a grid. It's structure. Don't fight it. Ride it."

Freddie nodded, checking his earplugs one last time. He looked at the clock ticking down. **00:04:58**.

"I am ready," Freddie whispered. "Initialize the sequence."

Scene 9: The Forger's Call

The countdown clock on the scoreboard hit **00:00**.

The world ended.

Every light in the stadium—the massive banks of floodlights, the concourse fluorescent strips, even the scoreboard advertisements—died instantly. The Crucible was plunged into a heavy, suffocating darkness, lit only by the faint, ghostly glow of thousands of digital watches and the stars above the mountain rim.

For three seconds, there was absolute silence. Sixty thousand people held their breath. The air pressure seemed to drop, sucking the oxygen out of the bowl.

Freddie stopped breathing. His hand was crushed in Paige's grip. He felt the panic rising in his throat—the darkness was too sudden, the silence too heavy.

Then, a sound cut through the cold mountain air like a knife.

TING...

It was the recorded sound of a hammer striking steel—sharp, high-pitched, and clear.

And then, the response.

THUD.

Jessica brought her boot down on the aluminum bleacher with all her strength. Sixty thousand other people did the same.

The impact was physical. The entire concrete structure of the North End Zone lurched. It wasn't a sound; it was a seismic event. Freddie felt the vibration travel up through the soles of his shoes, rattling his teeth.

TING...

THUD.

The second stomp was louder. The sheer mass of the sound hit Freddie in the chest. It was terrifying. It was the sound of a giant walking.

"Ride it!" Jessica screamed into the darkness, her face illuminated by a sudden, blood-red glow.

On the massive Jumbotron, a single image appeared: **A GLOWING, MOLTEN ANVIL.**

TING...

THUD.

Freddie squeezed his eyes shut. His heart was hammering against his ribs, trying to escape. *Too loud. Too big. Too much.*

But then, he felt it. The pattern.

It wasn't random. It wasn't chaotic. It was a perfect, binary grid.

Signal. Response. Signal. Response.

He took a breath. He waited for the *TING*. He anticipated the *THUD*.

TING...

Freddie stomped his foot. *THUD.*

He felt the connection. He was one pixel in a sixty-thousand-pixel image. He wasn't an error code here; he was part of the operating system.

TING...

THUD.

On the field, the Tallahassee State Renegades were huddled near their sideline. They were looking up at the stands, shifting nervously. They were used to booing. They were used to cheering. They weren't used to *this*. They weren't used to a machine.

The rhythm sped up.

TING-THUD. TING-THUD. TING-THUD.

The anvil on the screen began to spark. The sound was deafening now, a rolling thunder that shook the very foundations of the earth.

"HERE WE GO!" Jessica roared, grabbing Freddie's shoulder.

The music exploded.

A massive, distorted industrial guitar riff ripped through the stadium speakers, shaking the air. The drums kicked in—a thunderous, driving beat that matched the frantic pounding of Freddie's heart.

"The lights go dark... the tension builds..." Ryan O'Connell's voice roared from the towers, gritty and aggressive. *"A single, pounding, heavy sound!"*

Pyrotechnics blasted from the top of the scoreboard—jets of flame shooting into the night sky, turning the smoke maroon.

Ignition! the crowd screamed along with the track.

Down in the tunnel, the smoke poured out. And then, they emerged.

The **CPI Forgers**.

They didn't dance out. They sprinted. A wave of maroon jerseys poured onto the field, holding a massive sledgehammer high in the air.

The noise in the stadium went from deafening to impossible. It wasn't a cheer anymore. It was a roar—a primal, unified sound of intimidation that drowned out thought, drowned out fear, and drowned out the rejection letter waiting in Freddie's future.

This is the forger's call! the speakers blasted. *Ignition!*

Freddie was screaming. He didn't even realize it. He was on his feet, his orange hoodie vibrating with the noise, his earplugs barely holding back the tide. He was stomping. He was clapping. He was part of the machine.

"LOOK AT THEM!" Jessica yelled, pointing at the terrified Renegades on the sideline. "THEY ARE SCARED OF THE NOISE!"

Freddie looked. The opposing team looked small. They looked disorganized. They looked like they had walked into a factory and gotten caught in the gears.

"It is... effective!" Freddie yelled back, his voice lost in the roar.

He looked at Paige. She was grinning at him, her face flushed with adrenaline. She squeezed his hand.

"You okay?" she mouthed.

Freddie looked at the field. He looked at the anvil on the screen. He looked at the thousands of people screaming in unison.

"I am online!" Freddie shouted. "The system is online!"

Scene 10: The False Start

The first fifteen minutes of the game were not a sporting event. They were an execution of physics.

The Tallahassee State Renegades, ranked number four in the nation, had walked onto the field expecting a football game. Instead, they had walked into a sonic weapon.

"Watch the line!" Jessica screamed, pointing a gloved finger at the Renegades' offensive tackle. "He can't hear the snap count! He's vibrating!"

On the field, the Renegades' quarterback was frantically clapping his hands, trying to signal his center. But the noise from the North End Zone—where Jessica, Paige, and Freddie stood—was a physical wall of sound.

False Start, Number 76, Offense.

The referee's voice was barely audible over the roar of delight from the crowd.

"That's five yards!" Jessica yelled, high-fiving the silver-painted student next to her. "The Machine is eating them alive!"

Freddie watched the game through the tunnel of his orange hood. With the earplugs dampening the chaos into a dull roar, he wasn't overwhelmed. He was fascinated.

He saw the game not as violence, but as a complex, real-time algorithm. The players moved in vectors. The ball followed a parabolic arc. The collision of the defensive line was a transfer of kinetic energy.

"It is... chess," Freddie shouted to Paige. "But with momentum."

"It's a ground war," Paige shouted back, gripping his arm as the play started.

CPI didn't play flashy football. They played "Ironhead" football.

On offense, they didn't throw long, spiraling passes. They ran the ball. Again. And again. And again. It was a mechanical, grinding advance—three yards, four yards, three yards. First down.

"It is inefficient," Freddie critiqued after a short run. "The aerial route offers lower resistance."

"No," Jessica corrected, leaning down. "It's attrition, Freddie. We wear them down. We grind the steel until it breaks. Look at their defense. They're hands on their hips. They're gasping. The altitude is killing them."

With 4:00 left in the first quarter, the Renegades tried to speed up. Their quarterback dropped back, looking for a deep pass to silence the crowd.

But the CPI defensive end—a massive senior majoring in Civil Engineering—broke through the line. He didn't just tackle the quarterback; he dismantled the pocket.

CRUNCH.

The ball popped loose. It bounced on the turf like a chaotic variable.

A maroon jersey fell on it.

The stadium didn't just cheer. It detonated. The "Anvil" noise meter on the Jumbotron redlined and shattered the graphic glass.

CPI capitalized instantly. Three plays later, their running back found a hole in the Renegades' defensive line and powered into the end zone.

The cannon in the South End Zone fired. *BOOM.*

The band struck up *Ignition*.

Freddie found himself stomping again. *TING-THUD.*

As the quarter ended, the scoreboard told a story that the sports analysts on TSN hadn't predicted:

CPI FORGERS: 10 TALLAHASSEE ST: 0

"We have the advantage," Freddie stated, looking at the data. "The probability of an UDSet is increasing."

"You're damn right it is," Jessica grinned, wiping sweat from her forehead despite the freezing temperatures. "Welcome to the Iron City, Renegades. We're just getting warmed up."

Scene 11: System Overload

The temperature in the valley dropped to 38 degrees, but inside **The Crucible**, the heat was rising.

The second quarter wasn't a battle; it was a malfunction. The Tallahassee State Renegades, a team built on speed, flash, and television contracts, were suffering a catastrophic system failure.

"Look at them," Freddie said, pointing a gloved finger at the field. "They are arguing."

On the sideline, the Renegades' head coach was screaming at his offensive coordinator. The quarterback was throwing his helmet. They were disintegrating.

"Panic logic," Jessica explained, her breath steaming in the cold air. "They expected to be up by twenty points. Now they're down by ten, and they can't hear themselves think. The pressure is cracking the pipe."

Tallahassee had the ball on their own 20-yard line. Third down and eight.

The "Ironheads" in the North End Zone didn't just scream; they synchronized.

WHOOOOOOOOOO....

The noise rose in pitch, a continuous, deafening siren designed to disrupt communication.

The Renegades' quarterback tapped his helmet, looking confused. He hiked the ball.

The Blitz.

A CPI linebacker, disguised as a safety, shot through the gap like a piston. He hit the quarterback before he could even look downfield.

BOOM.

The ball fluttered harmlessly to the turf. Fourth down.

"PUNT TEAM!" Jessica roared, joining the chant that echoed around the bowl. "BLOCK! THAT! KICK!"

CPI took over on the 45-yard line.

They didn't get fancy. They ran the "Steamroller" offense.

Handoff. Four yards. First down. Handoff. Six yards. First down.

It was boring. It was brutal. It was engineering applied to sport.

"They are maximizing time of possession," Freddie noted, watching the clock tick down. "They are starving the other system of resources."

"Exactly," Jessica grinned. "We keep the ball. They get cold."

On the fifth play of the drive, the CPI quarterback faked the handoff. The entire Tallahassee defense bit on the run, crashing the middle.

The quarterback rolled right. He floated a perfect, gentle pass to a tight end standing all alone in the end zone.

TOUCHDOWN FORGERS.

The cannon fired. The stadium shook. The band struck up the fight song.

CPI FORGERS: 17 TALLAHASSEE ST: 0

Desperation set in. The Renegades got the ball back with less than a minute to play. They abandoned their playbook and started throwing "Hail Marys"—long, low-probability passes hoping for a miracle.

"Error," Freddie whispered as the quarterback wound up for a deep throw. "Low probability."

The ball soared through the night air. A CPI cornerback read the trajectory perfectly. He didn't just bat it down; he caught it.

INTERCEPTION.

The crowd noise hit a frequency that Freddie felt in his teeth. He pressed his hands over his earplugs, but he was smiling. He was smiling because the logic was holding. The "Machine" was working.

With ten seconds left, CPI kicked a 40-yard field goal as time expired.

The ball split the uprights.

HALFTIME

CPI FORGERS: 20 TALLAHASSEE ST: 0

The scoreboard glowed with the impossible numbers. The number four team in the nation wasn't just losing; they were being erased.

"Number four in the nation, huh?" Jessica laughed, high-fiving Paige. "Maybe they should try playing some actual football."

"They are incompatible with this environment," Freddie concluded, looking at the dejected Renegades jogging toward the locker room. "The Iron City is a closed system. And they are not admins."

"You got that right," Jessica said, putting an arm around his shoulder. "Now, stay close. Halftime means the marching band. And we have the best damn band in the land."

Scene 12: The Human Grid

The football teams jogged off the field, leaving the green turf empty. But the stadium didn't empty out. In The Crucible, nobody leaves at halftime.

"Here we go," Jessica said, sitting down but leaning forward eagerly. "This is the real show."

Down on the field, a whistle blew. Sharp. Piercing.

From the tunnel, a new army emerged. They weren't wearing pads; they were wearing tall, crested shakos and crisp maroon uniforms with orange piping.

"The **CPI Marching Forgers**," Paige whispered, squeezing Freddie's arm. "Look at the size of them."

There were hundreds of them—over three hundred musicians—marching in a block so dense and so perfect it looked like a single solid object moving across the grass.

Rat-a-tat-tat. Rat-a-tat-tat.

The drumline—the "Engine Room"—set the cadence. It was a crisp, mechanical rhythm that echoed off the concrete walls.

Freddie leaned forward. His eyes went wide behind his glasses.

"The spacing," Freddie murmured. "It is... equidistant."

"22.5-inch steps," Jessica cited the spec like a proud alum. "Six-to-five spacing. It's engineering, Freddie. They don't just walk; they calculate."

The Drum Major—a senior conducting from a tall ladder—raised his baton. He bowed backward until his plume touched the ground.

The baton snapped up.

BLAST.

Three hundred brass instruments hit a single chord. It was massive. It was a wall of sound that washed over the stadium, rich and harmonious and perfectly tuned.

The show wasn't a pop medley. It was titled **Orbit.**

They played Holst's *Jupiter*, but accelerated, turned into a driving, powerful march.

Freddie watched, mesmerized. This wasn't the chaotic noise of the game. This was structured sound.

On the field, the band began to move. They didn't just walk in circles. They expanded and contracted like a breathing lung. Lines intersected, passed through each other with inches to spare, and reformed into perfect geometric shapes.

"Triangles," Freddie narrated, tracing the shapes in the air. "Parabolas. The geometry is valid."

"Watch the woodwinds," Paige pointed. "They're forming the thrusters."

The music shifted. The low brass—the tubas and trombones—began a deep, rumbling ostinato. The trumpets soared over the top, playing a melody that sounded like flight.

The band split into three sections.

- **Left:** A swirling galaxy of flutes and clarinets.
- **Right:** A rigid grid of percussion.
- **Center:** A phalanx of trumpets moving in a wedge.

They marched blind, trusting the count, trusting the person next to them.

"They are operating as a single organism," Freddie said, a smile breaking across his face. "No variables. Just code."

The music swelled to a crescendo. The drumline hammered out a frantic, high-speed roll.

The three sections collided in the center of the field. For a second, it looked like chaos. Then, they snapped into place.

From the chaos emerged a perfect, crystalline image on the field: **THE CPI HAMMER AND ANVIL.**

The crowd erupted.

The band played the final chord of the *CPI Tech Triumph* (the fight song), holding the note until Freddie could feel it vibrating in the plastic of his seat.

The Drum Major cut them off.

SNAP.

Silence. Perfect, disciplined silence.

Then, the stadium roared its approval.

Freddie clapped. He didn't just clap; he cheered. He stood up, his orange hoodie bright against the night sky, and shouted.

"PRECISION!" Freddie yelled, beaming at the field. "THAT WAS PRECISION!"

Paige laughed, clapping with him. She looked at Jessica over Freddie's head.

"He loves it," Paige mouthed.

"I knew he would," Jessica winked. "It's a giant calculator made of people. It's his dream world."

As the band marched off to the beat of the drumline, Freddie sat back down, watching them go. The rejection at the housing office still hurt. The meltdown still lingered in his muscles. But right now, seeing the order, the structure, and the power of the Marching Forgers, he felt something else.

He felt like he belonged in the Iron City.

"That," Freddie decided, adjusting his glasses, "was the optimal halftime entertainment."

Scene 13: Zero Tolerance

The halftime break didn't reset the game. It just let the concrete freeze harder.

As the third quarter began, the temperature inside **The Crucible** dipped into the low 30s. A biting wind swirled down from the mountains, cutting through jackets and turning breath into clouds of steam.

For the CPI Forgers, this was standard operating procedure. They stood on the sideline in their heavy capes, breathing calmly.

For the Tallahassee State Renegades, it was a biological crisis. They huddled around the few portable heaters on their sideline, shivering, looking miserable.

"They are thermal-crashing," Freddie observed, tucking his hands deeper into the pocket of his orange hoodie. "Their operating temperature is too low. Their reaction times are lagging."

"They're soft!" Jessica yelled, cup of hot chocolate in hand. "They're used to Florida sunshine! Welcome to the mountains, boys!"

The Renegades received the kickoff. They needed a spark. They needed a touchdown to prove they were the number four team in the nation.

They tried to throw deep. The quarterback dropped back, his breath visible in the stadium lights. He wound up and launched a pass toward their star wide receiver.

But the ball wasn't a soft leather oval anymore. In the freezing air, it was a rock.

The receiver reached up. The ball hit his frozen hands. *CLUNK.*

It bounced off his chest and fell harmlessly to the turf.

"Incomplete!" the crowd roared.

"Friction coefficient," Freddie noted. "Cold hands. Hard surface. High probability of drop."

Tallahassee punted. Again.

CPI took over on their own 30. And the "Steamroller" started up again.

Handoff. Five yards. Handoff. Four yards. Handoff. First down.

It was demoralizing. The CPI offensive line, big corn-fed engineers who understood leverage better than anyone, simply pushed the freezing, exhausted Tallahassee defenders backward.

"Why are they ranked fourth?" Paige asked, watching a Renegade linebacker fail to wrap up a tackle. "They look terrible."

"They're ranked on stats," Jessica explained, her voice hoarse from cheering. "They play fast teams on grass fields. They put up 50 points a game against weak defenses. But they've never played in a factory before. They can't handle the physics of this place."

The drive consumed seven minutes of the clock. It was a slow, deliberate suffocation.

On the 5-yard line, the CPI quarterback didn't even fake a pass. He turned and handed the ball to their fullback—a human wrecking ball with a neck roll and dirty uniform.

He hit the line. The pile didn't move. So he kept his legs churning.

Drive. Drive. Drive.

The entire offensive line surged forward. The Renegades slid backward on the cold turf.

TOUCHDOWN FORGERS.

The cannon fired. *BOOM.*

The student section began a new chant, low and rhythmic, pointing at the opposing sideline.

O-VER-RA-TED! clap-clap-clapclapclap O-VER-RA-TED! clap-clap-clapclapclap

CPI FORGERS: 27 TALLAHASSEE ST: 0

As the teams switched sides for the final quarter, the stadium was in a frenzy. The shutout was intact. The giant wasn't just sleeping; it was in a coma.

Freddie looked at the scoreboard. 27 to 0.

"The data is conclusive," Freddie said, adjusting his glasses. "The ranking algorithm is flawed. It failed to account for environmental variables."

"That's exactly right, Freddie," Jessica beamed, putting her arm around him. "They forgot to factor in the Ironheads. One more quarter. Let's finish them."

Scene 14: The Shutout

The fourth quarter wasn't a contest. It was a coronation.

The Tallahassee State Renegades had stopped playing to win; they were just playing to get back to the bus. The cold had seeped into their bones, and the noise had seeped into their minds. They looked shell-shocked.

In the stands, the atmosphere had shifted from aggression to pure, unadulterated joy. The "Ironheads" weren't screaming anymore; they were dancing.

"Look at the scoreboard, Freddie," Jessica shouted, pointing to the massive glowing numbers. "Do you see that zero? That is the most beautiful number in the world."

CPI FORGERS: 27 TALLAHASSEE ST: 0

"A zero balance," Freddie nodded, watching the clock tick down. "Total negation."

Tallahassee made one last, desperate push. They didn't want to win; they just wanted to avoid the humiliation of a shutout. They drove to the CPI 20-yard line, using short passes to the sidelines.

But the "Machine" had a failsafe.

On 4th and Goal from the 10-yard line, the Renegades' quarterback dropped back. He looked left. He looked right. He saw nothing but maroon jerseys.

He scrambled up the middle, diving for the goal line.

Three CPI linebackers met him at the 2-yard line.

CRACK.

It was the sound of a wall stopping a car. The quarterback went backward. The ball didn't cross the plane.

Turnover on downs! the PA announcer boomed.

The stadium shook so hard Freddie thought the bleachers might actually shearing off their bolts.

"THE ZERO STANDS!" Jessica screamed, grabbing Paige and shaking her. "THEY DON'T GET A SINGLE POINT! NOT ONE!"

The CPI offense took the field in "Victory Formation."

The quarterback took the snap and kneeled. The clock ran. *Tick. Tick. Tick.*

"What does this mean?" Freddie asked, watching the Tallahassee players walking slowly toward their tunnel, heads down. "We defeated a higher value target. What is the output?"

Jessica turned to him, her eyes shining in the stadium lights.

"This changes everything, Freddie. We were unranked. Nobody respected us. They thought we were just a bunch of engineers playing in the mud."

She gestured to the scoreboard.

"But beating the number four team in the country? In a shutout? On national television?"

She grinned, a fierce, proud Forger grin.

"Tomorrow morning, when the polls come out, we won't be unranked anymore. We're going to be Top 20. Maybe Top 15. We just put the Iron City on the map."

The crowd began the final countdown. It wasn't chaotic. It was synchronized.

TEN. NINE. EIGHT.

Freddie joined in. He liked the counting. It was precise.

SEVEN. SIX. FIVE.

Paige squeezed his hand. "We did it, Freddie. We survived the day."

FOUR. THREE. TWO.

ONE.

The cannon fired one last time. *BOOM.*

The siren wailed.

The scoreboard flashed: **FINAL.**

CPI FORGERS: 27 TALLAHASSEE ST: 0

The band struck up the fight song, but you couldn't hear it. You could only hear the sound of sixty thousand people losing their minds.

Students began to spill over the walls in the lower bowl, rushing the field to celebrate with the team. It was a sea of maroon and orange flooding the green turf.

"We aren't going down there," Jessica said, protecting Freddie from the surge. "Too many variables. We stay here. We watch the victory lap."

Freddie stood still in the middle of the chaos, his orange hoodie bright against the night. He looked at the scoreboard. He looked at the celebrating fans. He looked at the dejected Renegades leaving the field.

The logic held up. The "Machine" worked. If you built a strong enough structure—whether it was a stadium, a defense, or a family—you could withstand anything. Even the number four team in the nation. Even a housing rejection.

"It is a valid result," Freddie decided, a small, rare smile touching his face. "The Forgers are... efficient."

"Yeah," Paige said, leaning her head on his shoulder. "We're pretty tough."

Scene 15: The Shuttle

The game was over, but the logistics were just beginning.

They exited The Crucible not into a void, but into a massive, organized mobilization of heavy transport. The road in front of the stadium had been converted into a bus terminal. A fleet of **Blue Ridge Transit** buses was platooned bumper-to-bumper, their engines idling in a deep, collective growl that vibrated the pavement.

"Target identification," Jessica said, scanning the LED signs above the windshields.

The signs were flipping in unison, a synchronized pulse of orange text.

FALLING BRANCH SHUTTLE...click... GO FORGERS!

PEPPER PLAZA SHUTTLE...click... GO FORGERS!

"We need Pepper Plaza," Jessica said, pointing to a line that snaked down the sidewalk. "It's long, but look at Falling Branch."

Freddie looked. The line for the **Falling Branch Shuttle**—the commuter lot out by Interstate 81—stretched for hundreds of yards, a sea of shivering fans waiting to get back to their cars.

"That is the high-volume vector," Freddie noted. "Commuter traffic."

Further down the line, there was confusion. A group of fans was arguing with a transit supervisor, pointing at their watches.

"They missed the **Roanoke Valley Transit**," Jessica noted sympathetically. "The Roanoke Express leaves at 19:45 PM, game or no game. Those guys are

stranded."

Near the end of the platoon, a different kind of bus was loading. It was a coach bus, distinct from the city transit fleet. Its sign didn't flash the school cheer. It simply read: **BLUEWATER via FALLING BRANCH**.

"That's the **Bluewater Transit Maroon Express**," Jessica explained. "That's the long haul. Ninety minutes down I-81 and I-77. Those guys won't be home until midnight."

"We are fortunate," Freddie calculated. "Our transit time is minimal."

"Exactly," Jessica said. "Come on. Let's get you home."

They reached the front of the line for the **Pepper Plaza Shuttle**. It was a massive, 60-foot articulated bus. The doors folded open.

"IDs?" Freddie asked, reaching for his pocket.

"Negative," Jessica said, guiding him forward. "Game Day Protocol. No fares. Just load and go. They prioritize flow rate over revenue."

They stepped onto the bus. It was "crush load"—standing room only. Jessica grabbed a strap near the articulation joint, bracing herself.

"No seats," Jessica called out.

"Improvise," Paige said.

She pushed Freddie toward a single vacant seat near the wheel well. He sat down, and without a word, Paige sat down on his lap, facing forward.

Around them, other couples and friends were doing the same. The bus was packed so tight that personal space was a mathematical impossibility.

The doors hissed shut. The air brakes released. The bus lurched forward, accelerating onto the express lane.

Freddie wrapped his arms tightly around Paige's stomach, interlocking his fingers. He buried his face in the back of her maroon hoodie.

Normally, the crowding, the smell of strangers, and the lurching motion would have triggered a sensory overload. But the weight of Paige on his lap acted like a heavy blanket. She was a physical shield between him and the rest of the world. He tightened his grip, pulling her closer.

Pressure. Gravity. Safety.

He realized, with a sudden clarity, that he liked this configuration. It felt like she was physically pressing his frayed nerves back into his body, holding his chaotic system together with her own mass.

"Twenty minutes," Paige whispered, leaning back against him. "Non-stop."

"Acknowledged," Freddie mumbled into her hood.

The bus hissed to a halt at **Pepper Plaza**. The doors opened, spilling the exhausted, happy crowd onto the concrete.

The air in Christiansburg was silent compared to the roar of The Crucible. They walked the one block to the apartment building, their footsteps echoing on the pavement. Freddie moved on autopilot, his legs heavy, his battery drained to 0%.

They climbed the concrete stairs to Apartment 2B. Jessica unlocked the door.

The familiar, quiet smell of the apartment hit Freddie like a sedative. He didn't say a word. He walked straight to the beige sofa, dropped his backpack on the floor, and collapsed face-first onto the cushions.

He didn't take off his orange hoodie. He didn't take off his shoes. He just shut down.

"System offline," Jessica whispered, locking the deadbolt.

Paige sat down on the edge of the sofa bed. She looked at him—a lump of orange fabric and exhaustion. She reached out and gently tapped his leg.

"Hey," she whispered. "Let's make you comfortable."

She worked the laces of his sneakers, pulling them off one by one and setting them neatly by the door. She tugged at the cuffs of his jeans. Freddie groaned but lifted his hips enough for her to slide the denim down and off, leaving him in his boxers and the orange hoodie.

"Better," Paige breathed.

She stood up and kicked off her own shoes. She peeled off her jeans, tossing them onto the chair.

"Be right back," she whispered.

She padded into the bathroom and closed the door. In the privacy of the small room, she reached under her maroon shirt and unhooked her bra, pulling it out through her sleeve. She sighed as the constriction released. She splashed cold water on her face, washing away the greasepaint stripes.

She walked back out, wearing just her oversized maroon t-shirt and underwear. She looked soft, tired, and safe.

Jessica was already standing by her bedroom door.

"Goodnight, guys," Jessica said softly. "We conquered the world today."

"Goodnight, Jess," Paige said. "Thanks for the ride."

Jessica smiled, closed her door, and the click of the latch signaled the final end of the day.

Paige climbed onto the sofa bed. She pulled the jersey sheet up over them.

Freddie shifted, sensing her heat. He turned toward her, curling into his usual position, his forehead pressing against her shoulder. He was still wearing the orange hoodie, hood up, like a protective shell.

"Paige?" Freddie whispered. His voice was thick with sleep.

"Yeah?"

"The Housing Director... she said no."

"I know," Paige whispered, running her hand up and down his arm, over the rough fabric of the hoodie.

"But... the variable is critical," Freddie said, his voice trembling slightly. "I cannot... sleep... without the anchor."

Paige shifted, wrapping her arms around him, pulling him so close that there was no space left between them.

"Listen to me, Freddie," she said, her voice fierce in the quiet room. "I promise you. I am willing to share a bed with you for the rest of your life if it helps with even one night terror. I don't care what the policy says. I don't care what Dad says."

Freddie let out a long, shuddering breath. He snuggled closer, burying his face in her neck, trying to tell her without words that he would love nothing more than that. That was the only future he wanted.

"I will only consider living somewhere where I am allowed to share a bed with you," Paige vowed, kissing the top of his hooded head. "If the dorm says no, we find an apartment. If the apartment says no, we find a house. But we don't split up. Ever."

The knot of anxiety in Freddie's chest finally unraveled. The rejection from Bennett Hall didn't matter. The rules didn't matter. The only thing that mattered was the promise.

"Confirmed," Freddie whispered.

The static in his head faded to silence. The rhythm of the day—the bus, the stomp, the game—slowed down to match the steady, rhythmic beating of Paige's heart.

Freddie Avery closed his eyes, anchored and safe, and drifted into the deep, dreamless sleep of the victorious.

The Source Code

Scene 1: The Diagnosis

The morning sun filtered through the blinds of the Christiansburg apartment, casting slats of dust-mote light across the living room. It was quiet. The roaring

static of the stadium, the pounding rhythm of the stomp, and the screaming meltdown of the afternoon were all distant memories.

Jessica stood in the doorway of her bedroom, holding a steaming mug of coffee. She looked at the beige sofa bed.

It was a tangle of limbs and jersey sheets. Freddie and Paige were asleep, but they weren't just sleeping near each other; they were structurally integrated. Freddie was curled on his side, his face pressed against Paige's shoulder, his arm draped heavily over her waist. Paige had one arm wrapped around his head, her hand resting protectively on his hair, her legs tangled with his.

It looked less like two people sleeping and more like a single organism that had evolved to survive a hostile environment.

Jessica took a sip of coffee. She thought about the Hall Director's face. *Single-gender policy.* She thought about Freddie's scream in the lobby. *System failure.*

She walked softly across the carpet, careful not to creak the floorboards, and sat down at her desk in the corner. She pressed the power button on her bulky beige tower.

The computer hummed to life. The fans whirred. The CRT monitor flickered, then glowed with the **Quantum OS 2000 Professional** startup screen. A clean, blue progress bar filled across the bottom.

Jessica waited for the desktop to load. She double-clicked the **WebCompass** icon. The dial-up modem screeched its electronic handshake—*reeee-urrrr-ding-ding*—connecting her to the outside world.

She opened the search bar. She typed the word the Hall Director had whispered.

A-U-T-I-S-M.

She hit Enter.

The progress bar at the bottom of the browser crawled forward. *Connecting... Waiting for reply...*

Finally, a list of blue hyperlinks appeared on the white background. It wasn't a sleek, modern interface; it was a wall of text. She clicked the top result: "Autism Society of America."

The page loaded one element at a time. The banner graphic slowly rasterized from top to bottom.

She started reading.

... a developmental disability that significantly affects verbal and nonverbal communication and social interaction...

... evident before age three...

... adversely affects a child's educational performance...

Jessica frowned. That sounded severe. That sounded like the non-verbal kids she had seen in special education classes who needed full-time aides. That didn't sound like Freddie, who could explain the physics of a football game or code a directory in Nix-OS.

She scrolled down, the text jumping slightly as the browser refreshed. She found a section labeled **"The Spectrum."**

... symptoms can vary widely...

... hypersensitivity to sensory input (sight, sound, touch)...

Jessica paused. *The cafeteria. The earplugs. The hoodie.*

... insistence on sameness; resistance to change...

The Blueprint. The schedule. The meltdown when the plan broke.

... intense absorption in specific interests or topics...

The Terminal. The Architecture. The obsession with systems.

... difficulties in social reciprocity; lack of eye contact...

He looks at my nose. He never looks at my eyes.

Jessica felt a chill go down her spine. It wasn't a chill of fear; it was the chill of recognition. It was the feeling of finding a key that fit a lock she had been trying to pick for seventeen years.

"Jessica?"

She spun around in her chair.

Freddie was sitting up on the sofa bed. His hair was a mess, sticking up in tufts. He was rubbing his eyes behind his glasses. Paige was stirring beside him, blinking in the morning light.

"Hey," Jessica said softly. "Did I wake you?"

"The modem," Freddie noted, his voice raspy with sleep. "The frequency is piercing."

"Sorry," Jessica grimaced. "Technological limitations."

She hesitated, then turned her chair fully toward them.

"Freddie," she said. "Paige. Grab a blanket. Come over here. I want to show you something."

Paige sat up, wrapping the top sheet around her shoulders like a cape. She nudged Freddie. They got up and walked over to the desk, pulling up two folding chairs to sit on either side of Jessica.

"What is the research topic?" Freddie asked, squinting at the glowing screen.

"Yesterday," Jessica started, choosing her words carefully. "When the Hall Director asked if you had been evaluated... she used a word."

"Autism," Paige said. She remembered.

"Right," Jessica nodded. "I'm looking it up. And I want you to read this list of... specifications."

She pointed to the section on **Sensory Processing**.

Individuals may experience sensory overload. Ordinary sounds may be painful. Fluorescent lights may be blinding. Fabrics may feel like sandpaper.

Freddie leaned forward. He read the text. He read it again.

"That is... correct," Freddie whispered. "The cafeteria is not just loud. It is physical pain. It is static."

Jessica scrolled down. **Social Interaction.**

Difficulty understanding unwritten social rules. Interpretation of language is often literal. confusion with metaphors or sarcasm.

"Literal," Freddie said. "I do not understand the subtext. I only hear the text."

Jessica scrolled again. **Routine and Structure.**

A strong need for predictability. Changes in routine can cause severe distress or 'meltdowns,' which are an involuntary reaction to being overwhelmed, not a tantrum.

Paige gasped softly. She put her hand on Freddie's arm.

"A meltdown," Paige whispered. "Not a tantrum. It's not you being difficult, Freddie. It's... it's a system crash."

Freddie stared at the screen. For years, his father had told him he was broken. That he was weird. That he just needed to "toughen up" and "act normal."

But this screen wasn't saying he was broken. It was saying he was *different*. It was describing an operating system that processed data differently than the standard **Quantum OS** build most people ran.

"It is a manual," Freddie said, his voice filled with wonder. "There is a manual."

"Yeah," Jessica smiled, tears prickling her eyes. "There's a manual."

She looked at her brother.

"You aren't a 'bad kid,' Freddie. You aren't 'defective.' You're autistic. Your brain is wired for high-resolution input in a low-resolution world. That's why you need the earplugs. That's why you need the schedule. And that's why..." she looked at Paige, "...that's why you need the anchor."

Freddie processed the new variable. *Autism.*

It fit. It explained the Terminal—why he loved the black void and the blinking cursor. It explained the "Engine"—why he connected with the raw, unfiltered mechanics of the world. It explained why he couldn't sleep alone—because the sensory input of the dark was too chaotic without a ground wire.

"I am... autistic," Freddie tested the word. It didn't feel heavy. It felt precise.

"We all have to learn the new code," Jessica said firmly. "Me, you, Paige. And eventually... Dad."

Paige stiffened. "Dad won't read the manual."

"Then we'll read it for him," Jessica said. "But right now? We know. And that means we can build a better Blueprint."

Freddie looked at the screen one last time. He memorized the symptoms. He memorized the data.

"Hypothesis accepted," Freddie said, turning to his sisters. "Now. What is the breakfast protocol?"

Jessica laughed, wiping her eyes. "Pancakes. The protocol is pancakes."

"With high-viscous syrup?" Freddie checked.

"Maximum viscosity," Jessica promised.

"Excellent," Freddie said, standing up. "Let us proceed."

Scene 2: The Firewall

The peaceful Sunday morning atmosphere—pancakes, syrup, and the quiet humming of the computer tower—was shattered by three heavy, authoritative knocks on the front door.

THUD. THUD. THUD.

Freddie froze. He was sitting at the small kitchen table, a forkful of pancake halfway to his mouth. He didn't need to look at the door to know who it was. The rhythm was distinctive. It wasn't the polite knock of a neighbor or the casual rap of a delivery driver. It was the knock of an owner inspecting his property.

"Robert," Paige whispered, her face going pale.

Jessica stood up instantly, putting her coffee mug down on the counter with a sharp *clack*. She held up a hand, signaling them to stay put.

"Hold position," Jessica ordered softly.

She walked to the door, moving on the balls of her feet. She leaned in, pressing her eye to the peephole.

Distorted by the fish-eye lens, but unmistakable in his stiff posture and angry expression, stood their father. He was wearing his "court clothes"—a charcoal suit that looked out of place in the grim hallway of a college apartment complex. He looked impatient. He looked ready to issue commands.

"Open the door," his voice came through the wood, muffled but distinct. "I know they are in there. I am here to collect my children."

My children. Not "Jessica." Not "Paige." Not "Freddie." Just possessive nouns.

Jessica stepped back from the door, careful not to make the floorboards creak. She turned to Freddie and Paige.

"It's Dad," Jessica whispered. "He wants to take you. He's demanding to speak to you."

She looked at them, her expression fierce and protective.

"This is your call," Jessica said. "You are seventeen. You aren't toddlers. If you want to talk to him, I will open the door. If you don't, it stays locked. I am the admin of this network. He has no root access here."

Freddie looked at the door. He imagined opening it. He imagined the wall of noise, the criticism, the demands to "stop acting weird," the dismissal of the "Twin Dorm" plan as nonsense. He imagined the static rising until it drowned out the clarity he had just found on the computer screen.

He looked at Paige. She was gripping the edge of the table, her knuckles white.

Freddie shook his head. A sharp, definitive *No.*

Paige shook her head too. "No," she whispered. "Please, Jess. No."

Jessica nodded. "Understood. Access denied."

She didn't yell through the door. She didn't try to argue with him. She simply turned the deadbolt a second time, engaging the heavy security lock she had installed herself.

Click-THUNK.

Outside, Robert knocked again, louder this time.

"I know you're in there!" he shouted. "This is ridiculous. I have a schedule to keep! Send them out!"

Jessica walked back to the table and sat down. She picked up her coffee.

"Eat your pancakes," she said calmly. "He'll time out eventually."

They sat in silence for ten agonizing minutes. Robert knocked a few more times, paced the hallway (they could hear his heavy dress shoes clicking on the concrete), and muttered something about "ungrateful."

Finally, the sound of retreating footsteps echoed down the hall. The heavy fire door to the stairwell slammed shut.

"Target has left the perimeter," Jessica announced.

Freddie let out a breath he didn't know he was holding. He looked at his sister. She was the firewall. She had held the line.

"We have to move," Jessica said, checking her watch. "The handover is at 13:00. Mom is meeting us in Staunton."

They packed quickly. Freddie folded his new orange hoodie carefully, placing it in his backpack like a sacred relic. He packed the Candidate Kit folder with the campus map. He packed the memory of the Terminal.

They walked down to Jessica's car, a battered Kyoto Citizen that she kept running with duct tape and prayer.

"I wish I could keep you," Jessica said as they pulled onto Interstate 81, heading north. "I really do. But the legal code is strict. You're still minors. If I kidnap you, I lose my scholarship, and then I can't help anyone."

"It is logical," Freddie said from the back seat. "We must return to base to complete the academic cycle."

"Just until June," Paige added. "Then we graduate. Then we come back."

"Exactly," Jessica said, merging onto the highway. "Eye on the horizon."

They pulled off the highway in Staunton, Virginia, spotting the massive, glowing red-and-yellow sign of **Zane's Market**.

It wasn't just a gas station; it was a cathedral of convenience. Twelve gas pumps sat under a brightly lit canopy, but the main attraction was the sprawling glass-fronted store. In 2002, Zane's was revolutionary—it was one of the first chains to introduce touch-screen food ordering, a beacon of high-tech caloric intake.

"Mom's car is here," Paige pointed to the station wagon parked near the air pumps.

Jessica pulled in next to it. Their mother was waiting, looking anxious, but she smiled when she saw them.

"Lunch protocol," Jessica declared. "I'm not sending you back on an empty stomach. Come on, my treat."

They all walked inside. The interior was a sensory blast of bright lights and red tile, but it was a happy kind of noise. They walked past the racks of chips and sodas to the **"Z-Kitchen"** ordering terminals.

Freddie stood in front of the touch screen. He loved this interface. No talking to a cashier. No misheard orders. Just buttons.

Item: Zane Burger. Option: No Onions. No Tomatoes. Option: Extra Cheese. Side: Fryz. Confirm.

"It is efficient," Freddie noted, tapping the screen with satisfaction.

They grabbed a booth in the corner with their tray of food. For twenty minutes, it felt like a normal family. Mom asked about the tour (Jessica censored the meltdown and the housing rejection, focusing on the engineering lab and the football game). They ate their fries and drank massive sodas.

"Your father is... heading to the courthouse," Mom said quietly, dipping a fry in ketchup. "He's very focused on the proceedings tomorrow. He was furious that you didn't open the door, Jessica."

"He didn't have a warrant," Jessica joked dryly. "And the tenants declined entry."

Mom sighed, but she reached across the table and squeezed Jessica's hand. "Thank you for taking them. They look... lighter."

"We saw the machine," Freddie said suddenly.

"The machine?" Mom asked.

"The stadium," Paige explained. "The stomp. It was amazing, Mom. Freddie loved it."

They finished their meal. The reality of the handoff began to settle in.

They walked back out to the cars. The bright neon of Zane's Market hummed above them.

"Okay," Jessica said, her voice catching slightly. "This is it. You guys go back, finish senior year, and keep your grades up. I've got school and work tomorrow, so I have to head back to Blacksburg."

She hugged Paige hard. Then she stood in front of Freddie.

"Check your email," Jessica whispered. "I'll send you the links to the research we found this morning. Read the manual, Freddie. Learn the code."

"Affirmative," Freddie said. He looked at her nose. "Thank you for the... Stomp."

"Anytime, little brother."

She watched them climb into their mother's station wagon. As they pulled away, heading east toward Norfolk and the silence of their father's house, Jessica didn't wave. She stood under the glowing red sign of Zane's Market, watching them go, already planning the architecture of their escape in June.

Scene 3: The Protocol Upgrade

The lunch rush at Zane's Market was winding down. The red vinyl booths were emptying out as travelers got back on the road, heading toward their respective destinations. At the Avery table, the tray of fries was gone. The sodas were empty. It was time for the transfer.

"Aunt Linda, can you take the kids to the car?" Jessica asked, standing up. "I need a minute with Mom. Administrator level stuff." "Of course, hon," Aunt Linda smiled, oblivious to the subtext. She grabbed her purse. "Come on, twins. Let's get the AC running. It's humid down in the flatlands." Freddie and Paige stood up. Paige looked at Jessica, a silent question in her eyes. Did you tell her? Jessica gave a microscopic nod. I'm handling it.

Freddie and Paige followed Aunt Linda out to the parking lot, leaving Jessica and Ellen alone in the booth. Jessica sat back down. She looked at her mother. Ellen looked tired. The stress of the divorce proceedings, the nursing classes, and the solo parenting was etched into the lines around her eyes. "Okay," Ellen sighed, stirring the ice in her empty cup. "Give me the damage report. You said there was a meltdown." "There was," Jessica admitted. "At the Housing Office. They told him he couldn't room with Paige because of the gender policy. He crashed. Hard."

Ellen rubbed her temples. "I knew it. I told Robert that would happen. He thinks Freddie just needs to 'toughen up,' but you can't toughen up a neurological condition." "Exactly," Jessica said. She leaned forward, lowering her voice. "But Mom, listen to the rest of the data. Last night? After the game? We went back to my apartment." "And?" "I pulled out the sofa bed," Jessica said. "It's a double. Not huge, but big enough. Freddie and Paige slept on it together." Ellen stiffened slightly, her programming as a mother of the 90s kicking in. "Jessica..." "Stop," Jessica held up a hand. "Just listen to the output. He slept for nine hours, Mom. Nine. Zero night terrors. Zero waking up screaming. He didn't even twitch. I woke up this morning, and they were still asleep, just... holding onto each other."

Jessica took a breath. "It works. It's not weird. It's not 'inappropriate.' It's a medical device. She is his weighted blanket." Ellen looked out the window at the parking lot, where Freddie was pacing near the station wagon while Paige leaned against the door, watching him. "I can't keep waking up at 2:00 AM, Jessica," Ellen whispered. "I have Anatomy exams. I have the younger kids. I can't do the screaming anymore."

"Then don't," Jessica said firmly. "Upgrade the protocol. My old room—the big one at the end of the hall—it has my Queen bed in it. The mattress is good. There's plenty of square footage." "That's the girls' room," Ellen murmured. "Not anymore," Jessica declared. "Give it to them. Let them move into the Queen bed. Officially. No more sneaking down the hall. No more shame. Just let them have the Command Center." "And Freddie's room?" "Keep it," Jessica

advised. “Keep the twin bed in there. That’s the ‘Decoy.’ If Dad visits, or if Aunt Linda snoops, that’s Freddie’s room. But at night? They are in the Queen.”

Ellen was silent for a long moment. She watched Paige reach out and touch Freddie’s arm, stopping his pacing instantly. The evidence was right there in the parking lot. “Okay,” Ellen said finally. “The Queen bed. It’s theirs.” “Good,” Jessica smiled, sliding out of the booth. “Now let’s get them home.”

The parking lot of Zane’s Market was bright under the afternoon sun. Jessica walked Ellen to the station wagon. “We have a deal,” Jessica whispered to Paige as she hugged her goodbye. “The Queen bed is approved. Mom is on board.” Paige’s eyes widened, then softened with immense relief. “Thank you, Jess.” “Just get him to June,” Jessica said. “Then you guys come back to the Iron City.”

She turned to Freddie. “Check your email, Navigator. The manual is there.” “Affirmative,” Freddie said. He looked at her nose. “Your assistance was... critical. Thank you.”

Jessica waved as she walked back to her silver Avalon. She didn’t look back. She had her own drive to make—back to the mountains, back to the future she was building for all of them.

“Shotgun!” Aunt Linda announced, jingling the keys. “Ellen, you look like you’ve been through a war. You sit. I drive. I know the way.” “Thanks, Linda,” Ellen said, sinking into the passenger seat. She adjusted the recline, closing her eyes almost immediately.

Freddie and Paige climbed into the back seat. The station wagon smelled of stale french fries and Aunt Linda’s floral perfume. “Buckle up, buttercups!” Aunt Linda chirped, adjusting the rearview mirror. “We are taking the scenic route... or at least the interstate route. I-64, here we come!”

The engine turned over. Aunt Linda pulled out of the Zane’s lot, merging onto the connector road. As they hit the highway, heading east toward Richmond and the sea, the dynamic in the car shifted. In the front, Aunt Linda was a chatterbox, filling the silence with updates about her bingo league and her neighbor’s cat. “And then Mrs. Gable said the prize pot was only fifty dollars, can you believe that? For a blackout round!”

In the passenger seat, Ellen was checked out. She wasn’t sleeping, but she was in “Power Saving Mode,” staring blankly at the passing trees, letting her sister’s voice wash over her like white noise.

In the back, a separate universe existed. Freddie sat behind the driver. Paige sat behind the passenger. But the middle seat was not a barrier; it was a bridge. Freddie leaned toward the center. Paige did the same. Their knees pressed together—a solid, constant point of contact. Paige reached over and

took Freddie's hand, lacing her fingers through his. She rested their joined hands on the seat between them.

"The Queen bed," Freddie whispered, so low that Aunt Linda couldn't hear him over her story about the cat. "Variable confirmed," Paige whispered back, squeezing his hand. "No more Twin. Maximum surface area." "And the Decoy," Freddie noted. "Security through obscurity." "Exactly," Paige smiled.

Freddie looked out the window. The mountains of the Shenandoah Valley were receding in the distance, fading into the blue haze. He was leaving the Iron City. He was leaving the Terminal and the Stomp. He was going back to the flat, humid, noisy reality of Virginia Beach. But he wasn't going back the same. He had a diagnosis. Autism. He had a manual. And he had a Queen bed waiting for him.

"Look at that truck!" Aunt Linda exclaimed, pointing at a massive Iron-Haul semi passing them on the left. "That thing is huge!" "Class 8 Heavy Duty," Freddie murmured automatically. "Turbo-diesel. High torque." Paige rubbed her thumb over his knuckles. "We're good," she whispered. "We're good," Freddie agreed.

The station wagon sped down I-64, carrying the Avery unit back to the coast, ready to face the divorce, the graduation, and the future.

A New Beginning

The Launch Code

Scene 1: The Loop

The Atlantic Dome was a massive, concrete tortoise shell sitting just blocks away from the Virginia Beach oceanfront. Usually, it hosted boat shows or monster truck rallies. Today, it was hosting the Northwood High School Class of 2003.

Inside the concrete bowels of the arena, the "holding tunnel" was a thick soup of humidity, cheap body spray, and nervous energy.

Freddie stood in the alphabetical line, sandwiched between Quinn, Jason and Avery, Paige.

He was wearing a maroon polyester gown that felt like it was made of woven static electricity. It clung to his dress pants. It scratched against his neck. Every time he moved, it crackled.

The mortarboard cap was worse. It dug into his forehead like a vice, a square cardboard shackle.

"Status?" Paige whispered. She was standing so close their arms brushed, the only point of contact in the chaotic tunnel.

She reached up and adjusted his tassel, moving it out of his eye line.

“Sensory input is at 85%,” Freddie reported, his eyes darting around the tunnel. “The acoustics are terrible. It is a concrete echo chamber. The humidity is affecting my skin conductivity.”

“We just walk,” Paige reminded him, her voice a low, steady hum below the noise of four hundred teenagers. “We walk. We shake the hand. We take the paper. We exit.”

“Walk. Shake. Take. Exit,” Freddie repeated. “A four-step algorithm.”

The signal began.

From the orchestra pit inside the arena, the brass section lifted their instruments.

The first four notes of Sir Edward Elgar’s “Pomp and Circumstance” rang out.

Da-da-da-DAAA... da-da-da-DAAA...

It was dignified. It was traditional.

And because there were four hundred graduates to process, it was infinite.

“Here we go,” Paige whispered. “Stay with me.”

The line began to move.

They shuffled out of the dark tunnel and into the cavernous bowl of the arena.

The sensory shift was violent.

Visual: Flashbulbs popping like strobe lights. Thousands of faces in the stands, a blur of color and movement.

Auditory: The roar of the crowd. Air horns blowing (despite the warnings). And underneath it all, that song.

Da-da-da-DAAA...

Freddie focused entirely on the back of Jason Quinn’s neck.

Count the steps, he told himself. Left. Right. Left. Right.

The music looped. It didn’t resolve. It just started over.

Loop 1 complete.

Loop 2 complete.

They reached their row of folding chairs. They sat.

The gown bunched up around Freddie’s legs. The heat in the arena was rising, the air conditioning unable to cope with the body heat of three thousand people.

Speeches followed. The Valedictorian spoke about “wings” and “flying.” The Principal spoke about “responsibility.”

Freddie heard none of it. He was listening to the high-frequency whine of the PA system feedback.

He was vibrating. His leg bounced up and down, a rapid-fire piston dissipating the nervous energy.

Paige reached over and placed her hand on his knee.

Pressure.

The bouncing stopped.

"Avery, Freddie."

The name boomed over the loudspeakers.

Freddie stood up. The blood rushed in his ears.

He walked toward the steps.

Walk. Shake. Take. Exit.

He ascended the stage. The lights were blindingly hot here.

He saw the Principal extending a hand.

Freddie took it. It was clammy.

Shake.

He took the fake leather folder.

Take.

He didn't look at the audience. Somewhere out there, Ellen was cheering. Somewhere out there, perhaps Robert was watching.

Freddie didn't care. He just needed to get off the stage.

He walked down the ramp on the other side.

"Avery, Paige."

He heard the cheers for his sister. He waited at the bottom of the ramp until she descended.

She looked composed, her face a mask of polite disinterest, until she reached him. Then, she exhaled, her shoulders slumping.

"Halfway," she whispered.

They sat back in their chairs.

The alphabet continued. S... T... V...

The band played the song again for the recessional.

Da-da-da-DAAA...

It was the same loop. Over and over.

It was drilling a hole into the base of Freddie's skull.

"It's not stopping," Freddie hissed, gripping the armrests of his chair. "The loop is infinite."

"Almost done," Paige promised. "Look at the exit signs. Focus on the exit."

The final graduate walked. The caps were thrown (Freddie did not throw his; that was illogical, he would just have to pick it up).

The Principal dismissed the class.

"Ladies and Gentlemen, the Class of 2003!"

The explosion of noise was physical. A wall of sound slammed into them.

"Move," Paige commanded, grabbing his hand. "We execute the exit strategy now."

They speed-walked up the center aisle, ignoring the friends trying to high-five them, ignoring the teachers trying to say goodbye.

They pushed through the double doors.

They burst out of the Atlantic Dome and into the blinding sunlight of the parking lot.

Scene 2: The Frequency

The ceremony ended. The Atlantic Dome disgorged the graduates into the blinding June sunlight of the parking lot. The air was hot—90 degrees and heavy with salt spray. Freddie stripped off his cap immediately, throwing it on the ground. "Air," he gasped, loosening the gown. "Too hot. System overheating." "We're done," Paige said, grabbing his arm to steady him. "We did it. We're free."

They found their mother near the fountain. Ellen was holding a bouquet of flowers, crying soft, happy tears. "You made it," she sobbed, hugging them both. "I am so proud. You survived." "We need to evacuate," Freddie said, scanning the chaotic parking lot. "The crowd density is critical." "We're going to lunch," Ellen said, wiping her eyes. "Just us. And Jessica. She's bringing the car around." "Jessica is here?" Freddie felt a wave of relief. Jessica meant the Avalon. Jessica meant safety.

"Well, isn't this a touching scene."

The voice didn't match the sunlight. It was cold, grey, and sounded like rain in Washington. Freddie froze. The vibration in his chest stopped, then restarted at double speed. He turned. Standing near the fountain, wearing a wrinkled suit that looked like it had slept on an airplane, was Robert. He looked older. His face was puffier, his eyes bloodshot. He was holding a lit cigarette, ignoring the *No Smoking* sign, his hand shaking slightly as he brought it to his mouth. He wasn't smiling. But he was trying to look successful. He was trying to look like a man with a plan.

"Robert," Ellen said, her voice turning into ice. "What are you doing here?" "I'm here for my kids," Robert said, flicking ash onto the pavement. He didn't look at Ellen. He couldn't look at Ellen—because if he did, he would crumble. The ex-girlfriend in Washington had been right; he was still obsessed with her. "Get your bags," Robert commanded, turning to the twins. "I have a rental car. We're going to the airport. My flight leaves at 4:00."

Freddie took a step back, bumping into Paige. "Flight?" Freddie whispered. "You're coming to Washington," Robert stated, stepping forward. He put on a smile—a salesman's smile. It didn't reach his eyes. "I have a house now," he lied. "A big place in Orchards. It's got a basement. A finished basement. You two can have the whole floor to yourselves. Private entrance. Everything."

It was a total fabrication. There was no house. There was no basement. There was just a rented room in a stranger's split-level with a shared bathroom and a landlord who hated noise. But Robert needed this. He needed to win *something*.

"I'm not paying child support anymore, Ellen," Robert continued, the lie gaining momentum. "I'm taking custody. They're eighteen. They can choose." He looked at Freddie with a sneer, trying to bully him into compliance. "You need a father, Freddie. Not a... whatever this is. You need to toughen up. Washington will be good for you. Rain. Work. No more coddling." "No," Paige said. She stepped in front of Freddie. "We aren't going anywhere with you." "I didn't ask you, Paige," Robert snapped, his desperation leaking through. "I'm telling you. I'm your father. You get in the car."

Behind them, the school band had moved outside to play for the departing families. They struck up the song again. *Da-da-da-DAAA... da-da-da-DAAA...*

The trigger pulled. The combination of the heat, the flashing cameras, the shouting, the Lie, and now that song—that relentless, looping, unresolved nightmare—crashed the system. Freddie's vision tunneled. The face of his father became a distorted monster. The music became a siren. *Da-da-da-DAAA...*

"NO!" Freddie screamed. It wasn't a word. It was a release of pressure. He dropped to his knees on the hot asphalt. He slammed his hands over his ears, digging his fingers into his scalp. "MAKE IT STOP! THE LOOP! STOP THE LOOP!"

"Get up!" Robert yelled, looking around nervously. This wasn't part of the fantasy. "Stop acting like a retard! Get up and get in the car!" "DON'T YOU CALL HIM THAT!" Ellen screamed, dropping the flowers. She lunged at Robert, shoving him back.

But Freddie couldn't hear them. He was gone. He was rocking violently, slamming his forehead against his knees. *Da-da-da-DAAA...* The music was inside him now. It was rewriting his code. It was pain. Pure, white-hot, sonic pain. "SYSTEM FAILURE!" Freddie shrieked, tears streaming down his face. "INVALID INPUT! ABORT! ABORT!"

Tires screeched. A silver Avalon mounted the curb, scattering a group of parents. The driver's door flew open. Jessica jumped out. She wasn't wearing graduation clothes. She was wearing jeans and a black t-shirt. She looked like a soldier. She didn't look at Robert. She went straight to the ground. She dropped to her knees in the grit, right next to Freddie. She didn't try to pull him up. She leaned in close, blocking out the sun, blocking out the father. "Freddie!" Jessica shouted, her voice cutting through the static. "The terminal is open! Look at me! The cursor is blinking!"

Freddie rocked, sobbing. "The loop... the music..." "We are cutting the cord," Jessica promised. She looked up at Paige. "Load him. Now."

"You aren't taking them!" Robert shouted, stepping toward the car. "I have a house! I have a plan!" Jessica stood up. She was taller than him in her boots. She was angrier than him. She reached into her pocket and pulled out a folded piece of paper. She stepped up to Robert and slammed the paper against his chest. But she held it tight, her thumb deliberately pressing over the top header where the street address was typed.

"Read it, Dad," Jessica hissed. "It's a lease. A private residence in Christiansburg, Virginia." She pointed to the signature line at the bottom. "Tenant 1: Jessica Avery. Tenant 2: Paige Avery. Tenant 3: Freddie Avery." "They signed it. They are adults. They are residents of the Iron City." She stepped closer, invading his space, piercing his lie with the truth. "They don't belong to you. They belong to themselves. And if you ever—ever—try to touch them again, I will get a restraining order so fast your head will spin."

Robert stared at the paper. He saw the legal signatures. He saw the reality of his failure staring back at him. He tried to look at the top line, to memorize the location, but Jessica's thumb was an unmoving bar of iron over the words *105 Pepper Street*. He thought about the room in Orchards with the stained carpet. He thought about going back there alone. He crumbled.

"Fine," Robert spat, throwing his cigarette on the ground to mask his defeat. "Take the broken one. See how long you last." He turned and walked away, disappearing into the crowd, a man walking toward a terminal to catch a flight back to nothing.

"Load," Jessica repeated, turning back to the twins. Paige grabbed Freddie's arm. "Freddie," she whispered, her voice fierce. "We're leaving. We're going to the Base. The King bed is there. It's waiting." Freddie looked up. His face was a mask of terror, red and wet. "The... bed?" "The King bed," Paige promised. "76 inches of safety. And silence. No music."

She helped him stand. He stumbled, dead weight, but they shoved him into the backseat of the Avalon. Paige climbed in after him, pulling the door shut. She immediately pulled his head down into her lap, covering his ears with her hands. "Drive," Paige commanded.

Jessica slammed the car into gear. The Avalon peeled out of the parking lot,

leaving the Atlantic Dome, the father, and the looping nightmare of *Pomp and Circumstance* behind in the dust. They hit the highway. West. Toward the mountains. Toward the Dollar Contract. Toward home.

Scene 3: The Base

The silver Avalon pulled away from the highway and turned down a quiet residential street in Christiansburg. It was a different world from the humid, crowded sprawl of Virginia Beach. Here, the air was thin and smelled of pine needles. The Blue Ridge Mountains stood silent in the distance, a fortress wall protecting the valley.

Jessica slowed the car as they approached the intersection of First and Pepper. "Target acquired," Jessica announced. "Look to your left." Freddie looked out the window. Directly across the street wasn't a parking lot; it was a hub of infrastructure. **Pepper Plaza Transit Center.** It was a proper terminal with a sawtooth curb design, allowing three buses to dock simultaneously without blocking traffic. A heavy shelter with a glass windscreen stood waiting. "That is the node," Jessica explained, pointing. "Blue Ridge Transit. Route 1 goes straight to campus. Route 3 goes to Radford. You can see the bus arrive from your front porch. Visual confirmation." Freddie nodded, entranced by the efficiency of the sawtooth bays. "Optimal geometry," he noted. "No guessing."

Jessica turned the wheel to the right and pulled into the driveway of a small, white house directly diagonally across from the transit center. "And this," Jessica said, killing the engine, "is The Base." **105 Pepper Street.** It was a modest, detached single-story house with a small porch and white siding. It looked solid. Unpretentious. Private. "Low density," Freddie noted, approving of the lack of shared walls. "And high security," Jessica added. "Grab your bags."

They walked up the short concrete path. Jessica pulled out a keyring with three brass keys. She handed one to Freddie and one to Paige. "Protocol One," Jessica said, sliding her key into the deadbolt. "This is a private residence. No buzzer. No landlord walking the halls. You control the perimeter." *Click-thunk.* The door swung open. "Secure," Freddie whispered, stepping onto the hardwood floor. It smelled of lemon polish and old wood—the smell of safety.

The interior was deceptively spacious. The living room had soft carpet and a large window looking out toward the tree line in the backyard. The kitchen had a small island with three bar stools. But the most important feature was the short hallway that branched off to the bedrooms. "Okay," Jessica said, dropping her keys on the counter. "Briefing time. Drop the bags." Freddie and Paige set their duffel bags down. Ellen, who was carrying a bag of groceries she'd insisted on buying at the last stop, set them on the island.

Jessica hopped up onto the counter, swinging her legs. She looked at her siblings—not as a parent, not as a babysitter, but as a squad leader addressing her team. "Welcome to the Iron City," Jessica smiled. "This is a new system.

The rules of 1852 Delaney Street do not apply here. We have a new Constitution."

"First," Jessica pointed to the ceiling. "Rent. Utilities. Internet." "We need jobs," Paige said immediately. "I can wait tables. Freddie can do tech support." "Negative," Jessica shook her head. "We have a sponsor." She reached into her back pocket and pulled out a folded document. She placed it on the counter. **Lease Agreement. Rent: $1.00 per annum.** "Mom's Great Aunt Margaret," Jessica explained. "She moved to assisted living last month. She owns this place. She hates Dad. She drafted this lease herself." Ellen nodded from the kitchen. "She wants you safe. She's covering the utilities and the high-speed cable internet. She's also depositing a stipend for food and books every month." Freddie blinked. "We are... fully funded?" "You are fully funded," Jessica confirmed. "Your job is to get the grades. That's it."

Jessica hopped off the counter and led them down the hall. "There are two rooms. One is the Ops Room." She pointed to the smaller bedroom on the right, where three desks were already pushed against the walls, creating a U-shaped command center. "That's where we work. Computers, printers, homework." She walked to the door at the end of the hall. "And this is the Silo." She pushed the door open. The Master Bedroom was dominated by a massive piece of furniture. **A King-Sized Bed.** It took up almost the entire room. "76 inches," Jessica stated the spec. "Enough for three." Freddie froze. He looked at Jessica. "Three?" "Three," Jessica confirmed. "We aren't doing shifts. We aren't doing 'Jessica sleeps on the floor.' We are a unit. We sleep together. Every night. Safety in numbers." She looked at Paige. "If you're okay with that?" Paige looked at the vast expanse of the mattress. She imagined the nights without the static. She imagined the safety of the wall. "I'm okay with it," Paige whispered. "I prefer it." Freddie looked at the bed. The logic was undeniable. Maximum regulation. Maximum security. "Accepted," Freddie said. "The King configuration is optimal."

They walked back into the living room. "Guests," Jessica listed. "Mom is welcome anytime. She has a key." She looked at Ellen, then back at the twins. Her expression hardened. "Robert is banned. He doesn't know this address. The lease is in a trust. If he shows up, you do not open the door. He has no jurisdiction here. This is a secure facility." "Understood," Freddie said, his voice cold. "Robert is blocked."

"Substances," Jessica continued. "No smoking. No drinking. No drugs. I don't want this place smelling like an ashtray." "We do not partake," Freddie confirmed. "Those variables introduce chaos."

"And finally," Jessica said, grabbing a water bottle from the fridge. "We're adults. We're siblings. We've changed diapers, we've cleaned up vomit, and we've survived a war. There is no modesty here. If you need to change, change. If you need to shower, shower. We don't hide from each other. We just live." She took a sip of water. "Any questions?" "The fridge," Freddie asked, eyeing the stainless steel appliance. "Common stock," Jessica said. "Unless you put a

name on it, it's fair game. But don't eat my yogurt if you value your life."

The briefing was adjourned. Freddie and Paige took their bags into the Silo. It was perfect. The King bed sat against the far wall, dressed in maroon sheets. The blackout curtains were already drawn. The walk-in closet was empty, waiting for their clothes.

Freddie unzipped his duffel bag. He felt sticky from the graduation gown, the sweat of the meltdown, and the long car ride. He didn't ask Paige to leave. He didn't turn around. He simply pulled his shirt over his head and tossed it on the bed. He unbuckled his belt and stepped out of his dress pants. He stood there in his boxers, grabbing a pair of soft gym shorts from his bag. Paige was doing the same. She shucked off her jeans and the blouse she'd worn for graduation, revealing a simple bra and panties. She didn't flinch. She didn't look away. It was just skin. It was just Freddie. She pulled on an oversized t-shirt and cotton shorts.

"The air conditioning is optimal," Freddie noted, pulling on his orange hoodie—not for warmth, but for comfort. "It's quiet," Paige agreed, tossing her clothes into the hamper. She walked over to him. She didn't hug him; she just leaned her forehead against his shoulder. "We're here, Freddie. 105 Pepper."

Freddie looked around the room. No parents fighting downstairs. No Robert trying to drag him to a basement. Just Jessica in the kitchen, Paige at his side, and a fully funded future waiting for them. And across the street, the buses were waiting in their sawtooth bays. "The launch code is accepted," Freddie whispered. "Systems are go."

The Source Code

Scene 1: The Manual

The morning sun hit the Blue Ridge Mountains, filtering through the sliding glass door of **105 Pepper Street**. The house smelled of coffee and the cinnamon rolls Jessica had pulled from a tube. It was quiet. Not the tense, waiting-for-a-fight quiet of Delaney Street, but a settled, structural silence. Ellen had left an hour ago, driving the **Holt Meridian** back to the coast to study for her Monday exams. She had hugged them tight, left a check on the counter for "emergency pizza," and driven away, leaving the three siblings alone in their new fortress.

Freddie sat at the kitchen island—a sturdy butcher-block piece Aunt Margaret had installed during the remodel—wearing his orange hoodie and pajama pants. He was eating a cinnamon roll with a fork, dismantling it spiral by spiral. Paige sat next to him, nursing a mug of tea. Jessica stood on the other side of the island. She wasn't eating. She was holding a thick, three-ring binder. The cover was Maroon and Orange—the official colors of **Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute (CPI)**. The logo on the front showed a muscular blacksmith hammering a glowing piece of iron on an anvil: **The Forger.**

"Okay," Jessica said, placing the binder on the granite countertop with a heavy *thud*. "We have the Base. We have the funding. Now, we need the software patch." Freddie stopped eating. He looked at the binder. "Is that the research?" "This is everything," Jessica said, tapping the cover. "I spent the last three months in the CPI library. I pulled medical journals, psychology textbooks, and case studies. I used the university printers until they cut off my paper allowance."

She opened the binder. The first page wasn't a wall of text. It was a list of bullet points. "Freddie," Jessica said softly. "You know how Dad always said you were 'broken'? How he said you were 'wrong'?" Freddie stiffened. "My code is incompatible with standard protocols." "No," Jessica corrected. "Your code is just written in a different language."

She spun the binder around so he could read it. The header read: **DIAGNOSTIC CRITERIA: AUTISM AND SENSORY PROCESSING VARIANCES.**

Freddie leaned in. He adjusted his glasses. He began to read.

- **Criterion A:** Qualitative impairment in social interaction... failure to develop peer relationships appropriate to developmental level... lack of social or emotional reciprocity.
- **Criterion B:** Restricted repetitive and stereotyped patterns of behavior, interests, and activities... encompassing preoccupation with one or more stereotyped and restricted patterns of interest that is abnormal either in intensity or focus.
- **Criterion C:** Clinically significant impairment in social, occupational, or other important areas of functioning.
- **Sensory Processing:** Hyper- or hypo-reactivity to sensory input (e.g., apparent indifference to pain/temperature, adverse response to specific sounds or textures, excessive smelling or touching of objects).

Freddie read the list. Then he read it again. He felt a strange sensation in his chest. It wasn't the panic of a meltdown. It was the click of a lock tumbling into place. "The intensity of focus," Freddie whispered, tapping the page. "The Architecture. The file structures." "And the sensory input," Paige pointed out, reading over his shoulder. "The textures. The clothing tags. The lights at the graduation."

Freddie looked up at Jessica. "This document... it describes the operating system." "It describes *your* operating system," Jessica said. "You aren't broken, Freddie. You're Autistic. Your brain is wired to process data differently. You take in everything—every sound, every light, every pattern—all at once. Most people filter that stuff out. You don't. That's why you crash. It's a buffer overflow."

Freddie processed the analogy. "Buffer overflow," he repeated. "Too much data. System hang." "Exactly," Jessica said. "Dad tried to run you like a standard

Windows machine. He kept smashing the keyboard wondering why it wouldn't work. But you're not Windows. You're Linux. You're a custom build."

Freddie looked back at the binder. He touched the word **Autism**. For eighteen years, he had been called "shy," "weird," "difficult," and "broken." He had been yelled at for covering his ears. He had been mocked for rocking. But here, in black and white text from a major university, it wasn't an insult. It was a spec sheet.

"If it is a hardware specification," Freddie said slowly, "then it can be optimized." "Yes," Jessica grinned. She flipped the page to a section she had highlighted in orange. The header read: **THE SENSORY DIET.**

"We don't try to 'fix' you," Jessica explained. "We engineer the environment to match the hardware. We control the inputs so you don't crash." She pointed to the list.

- **Deep Pressure Therapy:** Use of weighted blankets or compression garments to regulate the nervous system.
- **Vestibular Input:** Rhythmic movement (rocking, swinging) to soothe anxiety.
- **Visual Control:** Reduction of fluorescent lighting; use of natural or incandescent light.

"We're already doing some of this," Paige noted. "The hugging. The squeezing in the bed. That's Deep Pressure Therapy." "Exactly," Jessica said. "You two hacked the system by accident. Now, we're going to do it on purpose." She pulled a pen out of her pocket. "We're going to build a schedule. A 'Sensory Diet' for the house. We control the lights. We control the noise. We schedule the pressure." She looked at Freddie. "You're the Admin now, Freddie. You tell us what the system needs."

Freddie looked around the kitchen. He looked at the soft morning light filtering through the blinds. He heard the quiet hum of the refrigerator. He looked at Paige, his "anchor." He looked at Jessica, his "engineer." He wasn't a defect. He was a distinct model.

"I need..." Freddie started. He paused, testing the new authority. "I need the overhead lights off. They hum." Jessica reached over and flipped the switch. *Click.* The kitchen was bathed only in the natural light from the sliding door. The 60-cycle hum stopped.

"Better?" Jessica asked. "Latency reduced," Freddie confirmed. "Processor speed increasing." "Good," Jessica smiled, opening the binder to a fresh page. "Let's write the code."

Scene 2: The Calibration

Freddie kept his finger on the highlighted section of the binder: Deep Pressure Therapy. He read the clinical definition again. Use of firm, heavy pressure to calm the sensory system. He looked at the bullet points about weighted blankets, compression vests, and "holding."

He looked up at Paige. She was leaning against the counter, blowing on her tea, looking relaxed in her oversized t-shirt. For years, she had been his weighted blanket. She had been the one squeezing the static out of him in the middle of the night. A variable occurred to him—one he hadn't processed before because he had been too busy surviving.

"Question," Freddie said, his voice quiet. "Query?" Paige asked, putting her mug down. "The manual says this is 'therapy.' It implies a service provider and a patient." He gestured between himself and Paige. "You provide the pressure. I receive the regulation. But... what is the cost to the provider?" He looked at her, his eyes searching for data he might have missed. "Is it... taxing? Do you require... do you tolerate the hugs because the manual requires it? Am I a burden on your chassis?"

The room went silent. The hum of the refrigerator seemed to stop. Paige's face crumpled—not with sadness, but with a fierce, protective affection. "Oh, Freddie," she breathed.

She didn't answer with words. She moved. She crossed the small distance between them and wrapped her arms around his neck, pulling his head against her chest. Jessica moved in from the other side. She wrapped her arms around his shoulders, pinning him between them. It was a containment field of pure affection.

"Listen to me," Paige said, her voice vibrating against his ear. "I don't do it because it's in a binder. I don't do it because I have to. I do it because you're my brother. I do it because I love you." "We both do," Jessica added, squeezing him tight. "We know the world is loud, Freddie. We know it wasn't built for your operating system. It was built for people like Dad—loud, messy, and insensitive." "But we are building a new world here," Paige whispered. "And in this world, you are not a burden. You are the core. If you need a hug, you take it. If you need to be held for an hour, we hold you for an hour."

Freddie felt the pressure on both sides. It wasn't just physical weight. It was emotional density. For eighteen years, the primary male authority in his life had told him to "toughen up" and "stop acting weird." Now, the two most important women in his life were telling him to let go.

The data was too much. The "Buffer Overflow" happened—but this time, it wasn't a meltdown of terror. It was a spillover of relief. Freddie's breath hitched. His chest heaved. "I..." he choked out. A tear leaked out from under his glasses. Then another. "System... overwhelmed," he gasped.

"Okay," Paige said softly. "Okay. Let's regulate." She gently pulled away, taking his hand. "Come to the couch. We're going to run a test."

She led him to the plush beige sofa in the living room. "Lie down," she instructed. "On your back." Freddie obeyed. He lay down, sinking into the cushions. He wiped his eyes with his sleeve, feeling exposed. Paige kicked off her slippers. She climbed onto the sofa. She didn't sit next to him. She straddled his hips, then lowered herself down until she was lying completely on top of him, stomach to stomach. She rested her head on his shoulder, her hair spilling over the orange hoodie. She wrapped her arms around his torso and squeezed. She let her full weight settle—all of gravity pressing her down into him.

"How is the pressure?" Paige whispered. Freddie let out a long, shuddering exhale. The weight was immense. It was heavy. It forced his lungs to work harder, which mechanically slowed his breathing. It pinned his arms. It pinned his legs. It silenced the nerves that usually fired random "flight" signals to his brain. "Pressure is... maximum," Freddie whispered. "Static is clearing."

"Good," Paige murmured, digging her chin into his shoulder. "This is the protocol, Freddie. If you need this—if you need my full weight to keep the world from shaking apart—you ask. I am right here. I am not going anywhere."

Jessica sat on the edge of the coffee table, watching them with a soft smile. "I can do this too, Freddie," Jessica offered. "If Paige isn't here, and you need the weight, I will lie on you. I will squash the panic out of you." She paused, raising a finger. "However, there is a logistical restriction." Freddie opened his eyes, looking at Jessica. "Restriction?" "You can't lie on me," Jessica said with a small laugh. "I'm the older sister, but I don't have the twin reinforcement. You're too tall and too dense. You'd crush me flat."

She pointed at Paige. "But Paige... she's built different. She's your mirror. If you need to reverse the polarity—if you need to lie on her to feel the heartbeat—she can take it. She can take your weight." Paige nodded against his chest. "She's right. I can take it. You can't break me, Freddie. We're made of the same iron."

Freddie processed this rule. Jessica: Top only. Paige: Top or Bottom. Reason: Structural compatibility.

He closed his eyes again, focusing on the sensation of the moment. He felt Paige's heartbeat drumming against his own sternum. He felt the rise and fall of her breath syncing with his. It was "Deep Pressure Therapy," yes. It was a "Sensory Diet," yes. But as he lay there, crushed into the sofa by the person who knew him best in the universe, it didn't feel like medicine. It felt like being found.

"I like this," Freddie whispered, his voice steadying. "I like the weight." "I know," Paige whispered back, squeezing him one more time, locking him into the safety of the Iron City. "I've got you."

Scene 3: The Curriculum

The living room of **105 Pepper Street** was quiet, save for the low hum of the window AC unit and the faint sound of a diesel bus engine idling across the street at **Pepper Plaza**. On the beige sofa, the "Deep Pressure Therapy" session was reaching its natural conclusion. Freddie lay still, breathing deeply. The weight of Paige lying on top of him was no longer just a medical intervention; it was a physical confirmation of his new reality. She was heavy, warm, and present. She was compressing his frayed nerves back into a cohesive cable. He wasn't just tolerating the pressure; he was enjoying the hug for what it was. A deep, trusting, silent connection.

"Status?" Paige whispered, her chin still resting on his chest. "Integrity restored," Freddie said softly. "The static is gone. I am... regulated." "Good." Paige squeezed him one last time—a tight, rib-compressing hug that felt like love, not just therapy—before pushing herself up. She rolled off him and sat back on the cushion.

Freddie sat up. He adjusted his orange hoodie, pulling it straight. He patted the spot on the sofa to his left. He looked at Jessica. "Sit," Freddie requested. "I require the formation." Jessica smiled and sat down on his left. Paige remained on his right. Freddie sat in the middle, sandwiched between his sisters. It was a different kind of pressure—side-to-side contact—but it was just as grounding.

"Logistics," Freddie stated, looking from one to the other. "Proceed," Jessica said. "The briefing regarding 'Modesty,' " Freddie said, choosing his words carefully. "You stated that we 'do not hide.' That we change without barriers. That we exist as a unit." "Correct," Paige confirmed. "We've seen it all before, Freddie. We're past the point of closing doors."

Freddie nodded. He processed this. "I accept the protocol. However, my database on... biological differences... is limited to high school biology textbooks. If we are to operate without barriers, I need to ensure my internal software is updated. I do not want to react with... error." He looked at his hands, twisting the drawstring of his hoodie. "I do not want to be weird."

Jessica leaned back, crossing her legs. A spark of an idea lit up her eyes. "You know," she started, "we all have to fulfill the General Education requirements for CPI. There's a Health and Physical Education credit we need." "I do not enjoy organized sports," Freddie noted immediately. "The sensory input of a gymnasium is torture." "Not sports," Jessica said. "There's a lecture course. I saw it in the course catalog when I was registering for my summer classes. **HPE 204: Dimensions of Human Sexuality.**"

Freddie blinked. "A university-level course on... reproduction?" "More than that," Jessica explained. "It covers anatomy, physiology, psychology, relationships, boundaries... everything. It's a science class, Freddie. It explains the mechanics of how people work. No shame. Just data."

Paige sat up straighter. “That actually sounds... useful. Especially if we’re living like this. It would normalize everything.” “Exactly,” Jessica said. “If we take it together in the Fall, we all get the same information. We learn the correct terminology. We demystify the human body so that when you see me or Paige changing, it’s not a ‘girl thing’ or a ‘secret.’ It’s just anatomy.”

Freddie ran a simulation in his mind. A classroom. A textbook. Structured data about the very things that confused him most about social interaction and physical bodies. Instead of guessing, he would have a manual. Instead of being terrified of doing the wrong thing, he would have a grade.

“A scientific approach to human anatomy and behavior,” Freddie summarized. “With us,” Paige added, bumping his shoulder with hers. “We’d be right there in the row with you. Wingmen.”

Freddie looked at Jessica. “The syllabus covers... everything?” “Everything,” Jessica promised. “From chromosomes to social dynamics.”

Freddie felt a strange sense of anticipation. Usually, the topic of “sexuality” was a minefield of embarrassment and unknown variables. But framed as a university course—as data—it felt manageable. It felt like another “Source Code” he could learn.

“I agree to the curriculum,” Freddie stated firmly. “We will enroll in HPE 204 for the Fall Semester.” “It’s a plan,” Jessica grinned. “The Avery Unit takes on Human Sexuality. We’re going to ace that class.”

Freddie leaned back into the sofa, feeling the warmth of his sisters on both sides. He looked out the window. Across the street, he saw a **Route 1** bus pull out of the sawtooth bay, heading toward campus. He had a sensory diet. He had a King bed waiting down the hall. And now, he had a syllabus.

“This is efficient,” Freddie said, closing his eyes. “I like The Base.” “We know, Navigator,” Paige whispered, resting her head on his shoulder. “We know.”

Scene 4: The Open Door

The living room was dim, lit only by the soft glow of a floor lamp. Outside the sliding glass door, the mountains were invisible against the black sky. On the beige sofa, the “Deep Pressure” session had been running for over an hour. Freddie lay still, his breathing slow and heavy, synced with Paige’s. Paige shifted her weight. She was tired. The long day of moving in, the emotional weight of the “Manual” review, and the constant regulation of her brother had drained her battery. “Okay,” Paige whispered into the quiet room. “I need to shower before bed. I’ll be right back.”

The words were meant to be a simple transition to the night routine. To Freddie, they were a severance order. His brain didn’t process “right back.” It only processed *leaving*. The connection was breaking. The anchor was lifting right before the terrifying void of sleep. “No!” Freddie tried to say. But the word

didn't come out. The vocal processor had crashed. As Paige stood up to head to the bathroom, Freddie's hand shot out. He grabbed her wrist, his grip frantic and unmeasured. He yanked her back. Paige stumbled, falling back onto the cushions with a soft *oomph*. "Freddie?" she asked, startled.

She looked at his face in the dim light. It wasn't just anxiety. It was a full system crash. His eyes were wide and wet, staring at her with absolute, primal terror. He opened his mouth to speak, but no sound emerged. Not a whisper. Not a squeak. The static in his head was so loud it had severed the connection to his vocal cords. Tears spilled over his cheeks. He tightened his grip on her wrist, shaking his head violently. *Don't go. Don't go.*

"Oh, Freddie," Paige whispered, realizing the error. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry." She wrapped her arms around him, pulling him into a crushingly tight hug. "I wasn't leaving *you*. I was just going to the water. I'm here. I'm right here."

Jessica watched from the kitchen, where she had been tidying up the last of the mugs. Her expression was calculating. "He's non-verbal," Jessica observed calmly, walking over. "The stress broke the audio driver." She looked at Paige, then at Freddie, who was sobbing silently into Paige's neck, his body shaking with the effort to scream without a voice. "Protocol change," Jessica announced. "We do it now. No more hiding. No more modesty. If he needs to see you to know you're there, then he sees you."

Paige nodded against Freddie's hair. She understood the assignment. "Okay," she whispered to him. "Okay, Freddie. Listen to me. You don't have to talk. I know you can't. Just listen." She pulled back slightly to look him in the eye. "We are going to the bathroom. Together. I am going to shower, and you are going to sit right there and watch me so you know I'm not leaving. Okay?" Freddie stared at her. He squeezed her hand once. *Yes.*

"And," Paige continued, her voice steady and practical, "we are going to get undressed. Both of us. Because if we're going to share a bed tonight, we need to get over the 'shy' thing right now. It is what it is."

She stood up again, but this time she kept his hand in hers. "Come on," she said gently. "Command Center."

The Shower They walked into the master bathroom attached to the main bedroom. It was a standard setup: a toilet, a sink, and a bathtub with a showerhead. The fluorescent light buzzed softly overhead. "Sit," Paige instructed, pointing to the toilet. She put the lid down. Freddie sat. He was trembling, his hands gripping his knees. He looked at her, his eyes begging her not to disappear behind the curtain. Paige didn't hesitate. She pulled her t-shirt over her head. She pushed her shorts down. She stood there, completely exposed. She looked at Freddie. He looked at her. It was the first time he had ever seen a female body. It was the first time she had shown one to a guy. But in the small, bright bathroom, with the ghost of a meltdown hovering in the air, it wasn't sexual. It was just biology. It was just Paige.

"See?" Paige said softly. "Just skin. Just me." Freddie stared. He blinked slowly. He didn't look away. The panic in his chest ratcheted down a notch. *She is still here.* "Your turn," Paige said. "You're sweaty from the panic. Let's get the armor off." She helped him stand. She helped him pull off the orange hoodie and the pajama pants. He stood before her, pale and shivering. He opened his mouth to say *It is cold*, but nothing came out. He just shivered violently. "I know," Paige said, reading the shiver. "The water will fix it."

She stepped into the tub and turned the handle. The shower hissed to life. She reached for the shower curtain—a heavy, opaque white plastic. She started to pull it closed, then stopped. If she closed it, the wall would return. He wouldn't see her. "Nope," Paige muttered. She left the curtain wide open. "I'm going to make a mess," she told him. "The floor is going to get wet. We'll buy a clear curtain tomorrow. But for now, you watch."

She stepped under the spray. Water splashed out onto the tile, soaking the bathmat. Paige didn't care. She washed quickly, keeping her eyes on him. Freddie sat on the toilet lid, watching her. He wasn't staring at her anatomy; he was staring at her presence. She was there. She was real. She wasn't leaving. The silence in the room wasn't empty; it was heavy with trust.

"Okay," Paige said, turning off the water. She dripped onto the mat, slick and clean. She looked at him. He was slumped on the seat, utterly drained. His head hung low. "Your turn," she said. "You're exhausted. You need the heat." Freddie tried to stand, but his legs were jelly. He stumbled. Paige caught him. "I've got you," she whispered.

She walked him to the edge of the tub. "Sit on the edge," she instructed. He sat. He couldn't lift his legs. The signal from his brain to his muscles was too weak. Paige didn't wait for him to try. She bent down, lifted his left leg, and swung it over the porcelain lip. Then the right. "Slide down," she said. He slid into the warm, wet tub. He sat with his knees drawn up, his head resting on his knees. The silence wrapped around him like a blanket.

The door opened. Jessica walked in. She was naked, her clothes left in a pile in the hallway. She walked in with the casual confidence of someone entering a locker room. She saw the wet floor. She saw Paige kneeling by the tub. She saw Freddie curled in the water, silent and broken. "Reinforcements," Jessica said simply. She grabbed a washcloth from the rack and knelt beside the tub, opposite Paige.

"Hi, Freddie," Jessica said softly. "We're all here. No secrets." Freddie lifted his head. He looked at Jessica. He looked at Paige. Both of his sisters, stripped of all barriers, kneeling on the wet tile to take care of him. He opened his mouth, trying to force out a *Thank you*, but his throat just clicked. "Don't try," Jessica said gently. "We know." She dipped the washcloth in the water and began to gently wash his back. "We're scrubbing the static off."

Paige took the shampoo. She poured a dollop into her hand. "Lean back a

little," Paige murmured. Freddie tipped his head back. He closed his eyes. Paige worked her fingers into his scalp. It was a clinical, rhythmic massage. *Scrub. Scrub. Rinse.* She didn't ask if the pressure was okay; she knew. She pressed hard, grounding him through his skull. Jessica washed his arms, her movements efficient and firm. "You see?" Jessica said quietly. "This isn't scary. It's just maintenance. You help us, we help you."

Freddie sat in the warm water, surrounded by the steam and the scent of soap. He felt cherished. He felt safe. The shame of the meltdown—the embarrassment of needing help—evaporated. He realized he didn't need words. They spoke his language. He let his head loll to the side, resting against Paige's arm. He let out a long, shaky exhale. It was the only sound he made.

The Cocoon Getting him out was a team effort. Paige turned off the water. Jessica grabbed the big fluffy towel. "Up," Jessica commanded gently. They gripped his arms and hoisted him out of the tub. He was dead weight, but they were strong. He stood on the wet mat, shivering slightly. Jessica wrapped the towel around him instantly, rubbing his shoulders briskly to generate heat. Paige grabbed a second towel and dried his legs. They dried him off completely before they even reached for their own towels. "Dry?" Paige asked. Freddie nodded once.

He looked at them. They were still wet, water beading on their skin. He pointed at the door, then at his clothes pile, raising an eyebrow in a silent question. *Clothes?* "Negative," Jessica said, tossing her wet hair back. "We're testing the theory, remember? We sleep without the armor tonight. We trust the room." Freddie looked at Paige. She nodded. Freddie nodded back. *Okay.*

They walked into the **Silo**. The blackout curtains were drawn, sealing out the Virginia sun. The room was cool, dark, and smelled faintly of the lemon polish from the hallway. The **King Bed** waited. It was a massive, 76-inch island of maroon fabric in the center of the room.

"We have space," Jessica noted, pulling back the heavy duvet. "But tonight, we don't use it." She looked at Freddie. He was standing by the edge of the bed, his shoulders slumped, his eyes half-closed. The silence in his throat was absolute; the audio drivers were completely offline. "Compression Protocol," Jessica whispered. "I'll take the left flank. Paige, you take the right. Freddie, you're the core."

They climbed in. Even though the mattress was wide enough for them to sleep without touching, they ignored the real estate. They gravitated to the center. Freddie lay on his back in the middle. Jessica lay on his left, curling into his side, her arm draped heavily over his chest to provide the deep pressure he needed. Paige lay on his right, mirroring her, her head resting on his shoulder, her leg hooked over his to pin him to the mattress.

It was a cocoon of skin and heat. The extra space on the edges of the mattress lay empty. In the center, there was zero space between them. There was no

room for nightmares. There was no room for the graduation song. There was only the steady, synchronized breathing of the Avery Unit.

"Safe?" Paige whispered in the dark, her voice barely louder than the air conditioner.

Freddie felt the weight of them pressing him down into the mattress, anchoring him to the earth. He tried to form the word, but his throat was a locked door. The exhaustion was too deep. He didn't force the glitch. He didn't panic. He simply reached out with his left hand and squeezed Jessica's forearm. *Squeeze.* Then he reached out with his right hand and found Paige's fingers. *Squeeze.*

Safe.

He closed his eyes. The static was gone. The loop was broken. For the first time in his life, he wasn't just sleeping. He was being held.

Scene 5: The Morning After

The morning sun hit the mountains, reflecting off the peaks and finding a gap in the blackout curtains of **105 Pepper Street**. The beam of light hit Freddie's eyes. He woke up. For a microsecond, the data processing was slow. Warmth. Weight. Safety. Then, the visual sensors came online. He looked to his left. Jessica was asleep, her arm thrown over her eyes. She was naked. He looked to his right. Paige was asleep, her cheek pressed against his shoulder. She was naked. He looked down at himself. He was naked.

The "Robert Virus" activated instantly. *ERROR. ERROR. CONTAMINATION DETECTED.* The voice in his head—his father's voice—screamed at him. *Disgusting. Wrong. Pervert. If I catch you in that bed...* Freddie gasped, a sharp intake of air that sounded like a seal breaking. He scrambled backward. He tried to shout *No!*, but his throat was a dry, clicking ruin. The mutism from yesterday's meltdown was still holding the line. He thrashed against the maroon sheets, kicking free of the King-sized cocoon, his heart hammering a frantic techno beat against his ribs. *Thump-thump-thump.* He tumbled off the side of the high mattress and hit the hardwood floor with a heavy thud, scrambling backward until his spine hit the wall. He pulled his knees to his chest, covering his exposed body with his arms, shaking violently.

"Status!" Jessica yelled, bolting upright in bed. Her "Admin" brain went from sleep to crisis mode in 0.5 seconds. She saw Freddie pressed against the wall, eyes wide with terror, vibrating. She realized the variable immediately. "Whoa, hey!" Jessica said, holding up her hands. She didn't reach for a sheet to cover herself. She stayed exactly as she was to reinforce the data. "Freddie, look at me. No secrets. Remember?"

Paige stirred, the loss of Freddie's warmth waking her up. She rubbed her eyes, saw the empty space in the middle, and then looked at the floor. "Freddie?" she whispered, her voice sleep-rough. She saw the terror in his eyes. She saw

him looking at the bedroom door, waiting for it to be kicked open. “Oh,” Paige breathed. “He thinks Dad is coming.”

She slid out of bed. She walked across the room to him. She didn’t rush. She moved calmly, ignoring her own nudity. She knelt in front of him, blocking his view of the door. “Freddie,” she whispered. “Look at the door lock.” Freddie’s eyes darted past her to the bedroom door. “Is it locked?” Paige asked. Freddie nodded jerkily. “Is Robert here?” Freddie shook his head, tears leaking out. “Robert is in Washington,” Paige said firmly. “He is three thousand miles away. He can’t see you. He can’t touch you. And even if he was standing right there. . . ” She pointed to the door. “. . . Jessica would throw him off the porch.”

“Damn straight,” Jessica said from the bed. “Freddie, listen to me. You are an adult. You pay rent—well, Aunt Margaret pays rent, but your name is on the lease. You make the rules now. If we say nudity is okay, then it’s okay. You aren’t in trouble. You aren’t ‘gross.’ You’re just human.”

Freddie looked at Jessica. Then he looked at Paige. They weren’t ashamed. They weren’t hiding. The “Robert Virus” tried to run its script again, but the firewall of the Iron City blocked it. *Logic Check:*

1. Are we safe? Yes.
2. Is the door locked? Yes.
3. Do the admins approve? Yes.

Freddie’s shoulders dropped. The vibration in his hands slowed. He looked at Paige and tapped his chest, then pointed at her. *Safe.* “Safe,” Paige confirmed. She reached out and hugged him—skin on skin, just a brother and a sister grounding each other. “Now,” Jessica announced, clapping her hands. “Reboot complete. Let’s get some clothes on. I’m starving, and we have administrative tasks to complete.”

Twenty minutes later, they were dressed. Freddie wore fresh jeans and a grey t-shirt. His voice was still gone—the reset hadn’t fully restored the audio drivers yet—but he was communicating fluently with hand signals. They stood in the kitchen. Jessica was holding a notepad. “Agenda,” Jessica listed. “Item 1: Breakfast. I know a place near campus.” “Item 2: The Post Office. We need to file the Change of Address forms. You two officially live at **105 Pepper Street** now.” “Item 3: Insurance and Taxes.”

She looked at Freddie and Paige. “Okay, tax law crash course. Mom called me last week. She’s going to claim both of you as dependents on her tax return this coming January.” Freddie frowned. He tapped the table two times. *Query?* “I know,” Jessica said. “You moved out in June. Technically, you lived with her for 5.5 months. But since you’re students, she can claim this time as a ‘temporary absence’ for education. It helps her wallet, and frankly, she needs the deduction more than we do. It’s the last time, though. Starting next year, you belong to the Iron City.” Freddie nodded. *Acceptable.*

"Insurance," Jessica continued. "Health is covered under Mom's plan until you're older. But car insurance..." She pulled out her keys. "I added both of you to my policy this morning. You are authorized drivers of the Fleet." Paige's eyes lit up. "The Avalon?" "The Avalon," Jessica confirmed. "And since it's a stick shift, and I know Freddie can't operate the third pedal..." Freddie shook his head vehemently. *Negative. Too many variables.* "...Freddie is listed as a 'Licensed Household Resident' for legal reasons, but Paige... you're the secondary pilot." Jessica tossed the keys to Paige. "You're driving to breakfast. I want you to get a feel for the clutch before classes start." Paige caught the keys. She grinned. "I prefer manual. More control." "I know," Jessica smiled. "Let's roll."

They walked out the front door. Across the street, a **Route 1** bus was just pulling out of Pepper Plaza, its diesel engine roaring as it turned toward Main Street. Freddie watched it go, appreciating the punctuality. Then he turned to the driveway. The Silver Avalon wasn't a "boat" like the automatic sedans Freddie was used to. It was an older model that Jessica had specifically hunted down—a rare V6 with a 5-speed manual transmission. A "sleeper" car.

"Shotgun," Freddie signed, tapping his chest and pointing to the passenger door. He needed to be next to Paige. If the car lurched, he needed to be able to grab her arm. "Navigator position confirmed," Jessica said, opening the back door. "I'll issue course corrections from the rear."

Paige slid into the driver's seat. She adjusted the mirrors. She wiggled the stick shift. *Neutral.* She pressed the clutch pedal. It was stiff. "Heavy clutch," Paige noted. "I like it." "It bites early," Jessica warned from the back. "Don't ride it."

Paige turned the key. The engine purred. She shifted into First. She eased off the clutch. The car rolled forward smoothly. No lurch. No stall. "Smooth," Freddie signed, giving a thumbs up. "She's a natural," Jessica said. "Head for Business 460. We're going to **The Daily Grind**."

The drive to Blacksburg was a short hop up the road. Freddie watched Paige's hand on the gear stick. *Shift. Down. Shift. Up.* It was rhythmic. It was a fidget spinner that controlled a two-ton machine. He saw why she liked it. It kept her hands busy. It kept her focused. He reached over and rested his hand on her knee. She didn't flinch. She just shifted to Third gear and patted his hand with her pinky.

They sat in a booth at The Daily Grind, a coffee shop popular with the off-campus crowd. The waitress arrived with the coffee pot to refill Jessica's mug. "So," Jessica said, unfolding her napkin and stirring in a packet of sugar. "After we eat, we hit the Post Office to file the paperwork." She took a sip, looking at Freddie over the rim of the mug. "And then... I noticed a shop two doors down. It's called '**The Cartridge Exchange**'."

Freddie's eyes snapped up from his eggs. He stopped chewing. "I saw a bin of old grey cartridges in the window," Jessica teased. "The 8-bit stuff. The 16-bit stuff. The systems that don't need the internet."

Freddie dropped his fork. It clattered onto the plate. He grabbed his notepad and scribbled furiously. He turned it around. **HARDWARE?**

"Wall to wall," Jessica confirmed. "I think I saw a **Super Bit-System** in the case."

Freddie looked out the window. He couldn't speak, but his leg started bouncing under the table—not a nervous bounce, but an eager one. The "Comic Book" variable was acceptable, but Vintage Code? That was superior. That was pure logic encased in grey plastic. He took a deep breath. **Status: Online.**

Scene 6: The Cartridge Exchange

The bell above the door chimed as they walked into **The Cartridge Exchange**. The air inside was cool and smelled of ozone, old cardboard, and heated plastic—a scent Freddie associated with pure happiness. The walls were lined with shelves: to the left were the modern discs for current consoles, but to the right was the "Retro Zone," where bins and shelves overflowed with grey and black cartridges.

"Okay," Jessica said, taking charge. "We have the TV—the **MagnaView** combo unit. It has the VCR and DVD built-in, but it only has one set of inputs on the front." She walked over to a rack of cables and grabbed a black plastic box. "**Infrastructure**," she announced, showing it to Paige. "A 3-Way AV Selector Switch. Input 1 will be the **Bit-System**, Input 2 will be the **Super Bit-System**, and Input 3 is the VCR. You just push the button to change the channel. No unplugging cables."

"Smart," Paige noted.

They moved to the glass counter where the clerk, a guy named Dave with a ponytail, looked up from his magazine. "Help you folks?"

"We're building a setup," Jessica said. "We need a **Bit-System**—the original toaster model—a **Super Bit-System**, and two controllers for each."

Freddie scribbled on his notepad and showed it to Jessica. *LIGHT GUN.*

"And a **Bit-Zapper**," Jessica added. "Orange, please. Not the grey one."

Dave pulled the consoles from the case. The Bit-System was a boxy grey unit, while the Super Bit-System was flatter with purple sliding switches. "Refurbished," Dave grunted. "New 72-pin connectors in the toaster. It'll read the carts on the first try. No blowing required." Freddie smiled; that was a critical repair.

"Okay," Jessica said, turning them toward the bins. "Freddie, you have the budget. Fill the basket. But remember, we have to carry this home."

Freddie's hands trembled slightly with excitement. He walked to the bins, his fingers brushing against the textured plastic of the cartridges. He didn't just pick

random games; he picked the foundational texts of his childhood. He started pulling cartridges and stacking them in Paige's arms.

He began with the platformers, the "Plumber" series that defined the genre. He grabbed the essential combo cartridge, ***Super Plumber Bros. / Mallard Hunt***, for platforming perfection and target practice. He added ***Super Plumber Bros. 2: The Dream World***, the strange sequel with the vegetables, and ***Super Plumber Bros. 3***, the masterpiece with the raccoon tail and the map screen. For the 16-bit console, he added ***Super Plumber World***, loving the physics of the yellow cape, and ***Super Plumber All-Stars***, the remake collection with updated graphics but the same perfect logic. He even grabbed the educational titles, ***The Plumber is Missing*** and ***The Plumber's Time Machine***, because he loved the geography and history lessons wrapped in a game engine.

Next, he moved to the pre-rendered graphics of the "Kongo" series. He picked up ***Kongo Country***, ***Kongo Country 2: Diddy's Quest***, and the final chapter, ***Kongo Country 3: Double Trouble***. The mine cart levels in the first game were pure rhythm, a sensory experience he could play with his eyes closed.

He moved to the simulation and puzzle section. He found his absolute favorite, ***Metro-City: Super Bit Edition***. On the PC it was just a spreadsheet, but on the console, it felt alive, complete with the "Monster Statue" gift and a soothing jazz soundtrack. He added ***Block-Drop*** for the original system—falling tetrominos were pure geometry—and ***Demolition Squad***, a puzzle game where the Plumber broke walls with a hammer.

He rounded out the collection with the 8-bit classics: ***Stone Age Olympics*** for the "Dino Vault" event, ***Dirt Bike Rally*** for the custom track editor, and the logic-heavy ***Puzzle Ball Lolo***. Finally, he grabbed the two gold cartridges that needed no introduction: ***The Golden Quest*** and its side-scrolling sequel, ***The Golden Quest II***.

Freddie was digging through a "Rare/Import" bin near the back when he froze. He saw a box art that made his heart stop. It showed a teenager in a puffy red vest riding a pink Grav-Board. The title was in Japanese katakana, but he knew the logo instantly: ***Super Time Traveler II***.

He loved the *Time Traveler* movie trilogy. He loved the **Dorian**—that sleek, stainless steel sports car converted into a time machine. He loved the logic of time paradoxes. He grabbed the box and turned it over. The cartridge inside looked different—it was rounded and smooth, unlike the blocky, angular US Super-Bit carts. He hurried over to Jessica, his eyes wide, thrusting the box at her. He scribbled on his pad: *I NEED THIS. THE GRAV-BOARD.*

Jessica looked at the box. She saw the Japanese text and the shape of the cart. "Oh, Freddie," she said gently. "We can't play this."

Freddie frowned, pointing to the Super Bit-System on the counter. *Compatible?*

"No," Jessica explained, taking the box and showing him the bottom of the cartridge. "See the shape? This is for the **Super Family-Com**—the Japanese version of the system. The American Super Bit-System has plastic tabs inside the slot that physically block this cartridge from fitting." She tapped the Japanese text on the back. "Plus, the whole game is in Japanese. You wouldn't be able to read the menus or the paradox warnings."

Freddie stared at the box. He felt a pang of deep disappointment. The cover art was perfect, but Jessica's logic was sound. There was physical incompatibility due to the tabs, and software incompatibility due to the language. He sighed, a silent exhale through his nose, and put the box back on the shelf. *Someday,* he thought. *Someday I will learn the mod to break the tabs.*

They hauled the mountain of grey and black plastic to the counter. "Solid haul," Dave said, scanning the carts. "Metro-City is a classic. Good choice on the Zapper."

Jessica paid with the Avery Corporation debit card. "Okay," she said, handing Freddie the heavy bag of games. "You are the Keeper of the Software."

Freddie hugged the bag to his chest. The weight was grounding. He had his system. He had his library. He looked at Paige and gave a thumbs up. *Status: Equipped.*

"Let's go home," Jessica said. "I want to see if I can still beat you at *Mallard Hunt*."

Paige laughed. "In your dreams, Jess. I'm a sniper."

They walked out into the sunshine of Blacksburg, ready to wire up the Iron City.

Scene 7: Channel 3

Back at **105 Pepper Street**, the energy was electric. Jessica unpacked the groceries while Freddie and Paige engaged the "Entertainment Protocol" in the living room. The **MagnaView** TV sat on its low wooden stand, a heavy silver monolith waiting to be awakened.

"Cabling," Freddie announced, kneeling behind the stand. He laid out the wires. It was a puzzle he knew how to solve, but there was one piece of geometry that bothered him. The **Bit-System** (Input 1) only had **Mono Audio**. If he plugged it in standard, sound would only come out of the Left speaker. *Asymmetry.* The thought made his skin crawl. "Wait," Freddie signed to Paige. He dug into the bottom of the cable bag Jessica had brought. He found it. A small, black cable with one female jack on one end and two male plugs on the other. **The Y-Adapter.**

"Splitter," Freddie whispered satisfyingly. He began the hookup:

1. **The Hub:** He placed the black **AV Selector Switch** on top of the VCR.

2. **Input 1 (The Bit-System):**
    1. He plugged the single Red audio cable into the side of the grey console.
    2. He plugged the other end into the female port of the **Y-Adapter**.
    3. He plugged the Y-Adapter's two male ends (Red and White) into the switch.
    4. *Result:* Dual Mono. Balanced sound from both speakers.
3. **Input 2 (The Super Bit-System):** He plugged the standard stereo cable into the back.
4. **Output:** He ran the master cable from the switch to the front inputs of the TV.

"Power," Freddie requested. Paige handed him the heavy black power bricks. He plugged them into the surge protector strip. *Click. Click.* The red LEDs on the power strip glowed. "System ready," Freddie said, sitting back on his heels.

The First Boot Jessica came in from the kitchen with three cans of cola. "Moment of truth," she grinned. "Input 2." Freddie pressed the middle button on the switch. *Clunk.*

He picked up the **Super Plumber World** cartridge. He blew on the pins—habit, pure and simple—and slid it into the slot. He pushed the purple power switch up. *Click.*

Da-ding! The TV speakers popped, then filled the room with the jaunty, synthesized trumpet fanfare. The **MagnaView** screen flashed white, then resolved into the vibrant, colorful title screen. **SUPER PLUMBER WORLD.** The Plumber rode the Dinosaur across the screen. "It works," Paige whispered. "Look at the colors." "It's brighter than the old TV," Freddie noted. "The flat glass minimizes glare."

He picked up the controller. It felt perfect in his hands—the rounded edges, the grey plastic, the four colored buttons (Purple and Lavender). It wasn't just a controller; it was a steering wheel for his childhood. "Co-Op?" Paige asked, picking up Player 2. "Always," Freddie nodded.

The afternoon dissolved into a blur of 16-bit bliss. The sun went down, but they didn't notice. The only light that mattered was the glow of the CRT. They played through the **Donut Plains**. They found the **Secret Key**. They unlocked the **Star Road**. Freddie wasn't mute anymore. The game had unlocked his voice. "Jump!" he yelled. "Spin jump! Use the cape!" "I'm trying!" Paige laughed, mashing the B button. "The physics are slippery!" "Inertia," Freddie corrected. "You have to account for momentum."

Jessica sat on the floor behind them, leaning against the sofa, eating pizza bites. She watched them. She saw Freddie leaning into Paige every time the character made a difficult jump. She saw Paige nudging Freddie's shoulder every time

they beat a level. They weren't just playing a game; they were syncing their processors. The stress of the move, the meltdown, the father—it was all being overwritten by the clean, logical code of the game.

"Okay, Engineers," Jessica announced during a level transition. "It's 10:00 PM. We have orientation stuff tomorrow." "One more castle?" Paige pleaded. "We're right at Iggy's Castle." "One more," Jessica conceded. "But then we save."

They beat the castle. They saved the egg. Freddie pressed **START**. The menu popped up. **SAVE GAME? > YES** Freddie hit the button. *Ding.* The save noise. The sound of permanence. He didn't know about batteries. He didn't know about voltage decay. He just knew that his progress was locked in. He existed in the machine.

The TV was off. The house was dark. They went through the new routine. Bathroom. (The new clear curtain was hung; it worked perfectly, keeping the water in while keeping the line of sight open). Toothbrushes. And then, the **Silo**.

"No armor," Jessica reminded them, pulling back the maroon duvet of the massive bed. "No armor," Freddie agreed. He stripped down to his boxers, then hesitated for just a second before removing those too. The morning panic was gone. The "Robert Virus" had been purged. This was just procedure. He looked at Paige. She was already under the covers, waiting. He climbed in.

The **King Bed** offered 76 inches of width—enough for them to sleep without touching if they wanted to. They didn't want to. Freddie lay in the middle. Jessica on the left. Paige on the right. They collapsed the space, gravitating to the center until they were pressed together. The weight of the duvet, combined with the heat of his sisters, pressed him down into the mattress.

"Good game," Paige whispered, resting her head on his shoulder. "High score," Freddie whispered back. He closed his eyes. The static was gone. The channel was clear. And tomorrow, they would explore the Iron City.

The Syllabus

Scene 1: The Loophole

The morning sun filtered through the blinds of 105 Pepper Street, slicing the living room into strips of light and shadow. The air conditioner hummed a steady, white-noise drone that kept the humid Virginia summer at bay.

In the kitchen, the mood was quiet but stable. They were in pajamas—their soft armor against the morning. Jessica wore a worn CPI t-shirt and flannel pants. Paige was in an oversized shirt and shorts. Freddie wore his standard grey sleep pants and a fresh grey t-shirt, his orange hoodie draped over the back of his stool like a sentry.

Breakfast was a sensory baseline: bowls of cereal (Honey Oat Rings) and tall

glasses of chocolate milk. The high viscosity and sugar content of the milk were grounding.

Freddie sat at the island, staring at the milk swirling in his glass. His throat felt tight, the muscles still locked from yesterday's meltdown. He had not spoken since the shower. He tapped the counter twice. *Tap-tap.*

"Status check," Jessica said from the sink, where she was rinsing a spoon. She turned around, leaning against the counter with a folder in her hand. "We have a logistical problem, and I found a loophole."

Freddie looked up. He tilted his head. *Problem?*

"Mobility," Jessica said, sliding a printout across the island. "The buses are free for students, but only if you have an active **PolyPass**. Your IDs do not activate until the Fall Semester starts in August. That leaves us stranded for two months unless we pay cash fares every single time. And I am not driving you to **Valu-Mart** for every soda run."

Paige groaned into her cereal. "I am not walking to the mall in July heat."

"Agreed," Jessica said. "However..." She tapped the paper. "If you are enrolled in a **Summer Session** course, your PolyPass is active immediately upon tuition payment."

Freddie reached for the paper. His hand shook slightly, but he pulled it closer. *Session 1: Closed. Session 3: Closed. Session 2: July 7 – August 15.*

"Session Two starts in two weeks," Jessica explained. "It is a six-week accelerated track. If we enroll, we get our IDs tomorrow. The buses become free. We get full access to the grid."

Paige looked at Freddie. "That sounds good. But what class? Geology? Intro to listening to music?"

Jessica straightened up. She looked from Paige to Freddie. Her expression was serious, devoid of mockery.

"No," she said softly. "I think we should take **HPE 204: Dimensions of Human Sexuality**."

Freddie froze. His spoon stopped halfway to his mouth. The memory of yesterday—the panic, the bathroom, the shower, the exposure—flashed through his mind. They had seen everything. They had broken the ultimate social barrier of siblings to stop him from crashing.

"Look," Jessica continued, her voice clinical and calm. "We saw each other yesterday. We broke the seal. But we do not have the *data* to process it. We are scared of our own biology because Robert weaponized it. He made us think bodies were shameful."

She pointed to the course description on the paper. "This class is not about shame. It is about mechanics. Psychology. Anatomy. If we take this *now*,

together... we can fix the code. We can turn the 'Secret' into 'Data'."

Paige looked at Freddie. "She is right, Freddie. If we wait until August, we will just be awkward for two months. If we do this... we normalize it. We learn the manual."

Freddie stared at the chocolate milk. *Data. Normalize. Access to Transit. Repair the Unit.*

He felt a grinding sensation in his throat. The vocal cords were rusty, unused for twenty-four hours. He pushed air through them. It hurt, but he needed to confirm the variable.

L... Freddie croaked. The sound was a cracked whisper. He swallowed and tried again. "Log... ic."

Paige smiled, reaching out to squeeze his forearm. "There he is."

Freddie took a deep breath. "The... logic... is... sound."

Jessica let out a breath she had been holding. "Okay. Good. I will handle the registration online. But we need materials."

She checked her watch. "The Campus Bookstore is open today for the summer intake. If we go now, we can buy the textbooks, pick up our PolyPasses, and drop off your disability paperwork at the Dean of Students' office."

"Paperwork?" Freddie whispered, his voice gaining a little more traction.

"CP and ADHD," Jessica confirmed. "We have the files from Northwood. We get those in the system today so you have your accommodations for the summer class. The Autism diagnosis..." She paused. "We do not have that yet. But we will. I am working on finding a local doctor."

"Okay," Freddie said. He took a long drink of chocolate milk, coating his raw throat. "Let's... execute."

Scene 2: The Run

The silver **Horizon Avalon** sat in the driveway of 105 Pepper Street, reflecting the mid-morning sun. It was a rare beast for a sedan of its size—a V6 engine paired with a 5-speed manual transmission. "I will drive," Paige said, snagging the keys from the hook by the door. "I need the practice on the hills. If I can drive in Blacksburg, I can drive anywhere."

They dressed quickly, shedding the soft armor of pajamas for the functional uniform of the day: jeans and t-shirts. Freddie pulled on his orange hoodie. He hesitated for a moment, then left the zipper open. It was already eighty degrees outside, too hot for the full cocoon, but he needed the heavy fabric within arm's reach. It was his safety net.

They walked out to the car. Freddie took the front passenger seat—the Navigator's station. Jessica slid into the back, the Commander in the rear.

Paige adjusted the seat. She pressed the clutch pedal. It was heavy, with a bite point that demanded respect. "Clutch in," Paige whispered to herself. She turned the key. The V6 engine purred to life, a low, steady rumble that vibrated through the chassis. "Status?" Paige asked. "Green," Freddie rasped. His voice was still thin, like a radio signal with weak reception, but it was there. "Route confirmed. Business 460 to the prices Fork exit."

Paige shifted into Reverse. She eased off the clutch. The car rolled back smoothly. She braked, shifted to First, and pulled out onto Pepper Street. "Smooth," Jessica approved from the back seat. "No lurch."

The drive to Blacksburg was a short, straight shot, but the terrain changed rapidly. The flat roads of Christiansburg gave way to the rolling, steep geography of the university town. "Hill start," Freddie warned as they approached the traffic light at the edge of campus. "Gradient is approximately eight percent."

The light turned red. Paige stopped. The car rocked slightly on its suspension. "Handbrake," Jessica advised. "Don't ride the clutch holding it." Paige pulled the handbrake up. *Click-click.* When the light turned green, she executed the maneuver perfectly: revs up, clutch to the bite point, handbrake down. The Avalon surged forward without rolling back an inch. "Textbook," Freddie noted. "Torque application nominal."

They pulled into the **Visitor Center**, a small brick building at the campus entrance. Jessica ran in with a five-dollar bill and returned with a maroon hang-tag. "Day Pass," she said, hanging it from the rearview mirror. "Valid for Perry Street Lot. It is a hike to the bookstore, but it is the only place we won't get ticketed."

Paige docked the Avalon in a narrow spot between a massive pickup truck and a faculty sedan. She killed the engine. "Secure," Paige said, pocketing the keys.

They stepped out into the heat. The campus was quieter than it had been during the graduation or the game day, but it still hummed with the low-level energy of summer session students and faculty. They walked past the massive construction site of the new engineering building, the sound of jackhammers echoing off the limestone. To Freddie, the noise wasn't chaotic; it was the sound of construction. It was the sound of things being built.

The bookstore was a massive, rotunda-shaped building located at the edge of the academic district. The automatic doors slid open with a pneumatic hiss. The air conditioning hit them instantly—a wall of freezing, dry air that smelled of new paper, adhesive, and expensive coffee from the café in the corner.

"Textbooks are downstairs," Jessica said, leading the way to the escalator. They descended into the basement level, a labyrinth of tall metal shelves packed

with knowledge. Freddie scanned the aisle markers. *Engineering. Mathematics. Biology. Health & Physical Education.*

"Target acquired," Freddie whispered, pointing to Aisle 4. They walked down the row. The shelves were stocked with colorful softcovers and massive, intimidating hardcovers. Jessica stopped at a tag labeled **HPE 204**.

There was a stack of thick, glossy textbooks. The cover featured a generic, abstract image of a double helix DNA strand merging with a silhouette of diverse people. **Title:** *Human Sexuality: Biological and Psychosocial Perspectives.* **Edition:** 4th. **Condition:** New.

Jessica picked one up. It was heavy. "Price check," she noted, flipping it over to check the barcode sticker. "$115.00 New." She looked at Freddie and Paige. "We need three," Freddie said immediately. His voice was gaining strength, fueled by the logic of the situation. "Three?" Paige asked. "That is... three hundred and forty-five dollars. Can't we share?"

Freddie shook his head. "Negative. We need to annotate independently. I need to highlight the definitions. You might need to highlight the social dynamics. If we share, the data gets corrupted. We need individual databases."

Jessica nodded. "He is right. If we are going to treat this like a manual, we each need our own copy to study." She reached out and grabbed two more copies from the stack. The weight of three textbooks in her arms was substantial. "That is a lot of money, Jess," Paige worried.

Jessica smiled, adjusting her grip on the books. "Don't worry about the budget. That is what the 'Avery Grant' is for." "Aunt Marge," Freddie clarified. "Aunt Marge," Jessica confirmed. "She told me specifically: 'Buy the kids whatever they need to get smart.' I think this qualifies."

They walked to the checkout counter. The cashier, a student worker wearing a maroon polo, scanned the three identical books. *Beep. Beep. Beep.* "Taking the class together?" the cashier asked, making small talk. "Study group," Jessica said smoothly, pulling out her debit card. She swiped the card through the reader. *Authorizing... Approved.*

The receipt printed with a rhythmic *zzzt-zzzt-zzzt.* Jessica handed a bag to Freddie and a bag to Paige. "Possession is nine-tenths of the law," Jessica said. "You own the knowledge now."

Freddie looked into the plastic bag. The heavy book sat there, a dense brick of information. It wasn't a dirty magazine. It wasn't a secret whispered in a locker room. It was a textbook. It had an ISBN number. It had an index. For the first time since the shower incident, the knot of shame in Freddie's stomach loosened just a fraction more. It was just a subject. And he was a good student.

"We have the manual," Freddie whispered, clutching the bag against his chest. "Now," Jessica said, turning toward the exit. "Let's go get your PolyPasses. I want to see you swipe onto a bus before we go home."

The ID Office was tucked into a corner of the Student Union, smelling of warm plastic and lamination chemicals. Since it was summer orientation season, the line was short—mostly transfer students and a few confused freshmen who had lost their cards during the first week of Session 1.

"Next," the camera operator called out. She sat behind a beige counter, looking bored, her finger hovering over a capture button.

Jessica went first. She stood on the tape mark on the floor. *Flash.* "Done," the operator said. "Next."

Paige stepped up. She smoothed her hair, offered a polite, closed-mouth smile. *Flash.* "Next."

Freddie stepped onto the tape. He looked at the camera lens. It looked like a mechanical eye. He didn't smile; that felt performative. He just looked at the lens, ensuring his eyes were open and his head was level. *Flash.* The sudden burst of light left a purple afterimage in his vision, but he didn't flinch. He held his ground.

They moved to the waiting area. Behind the counter, a specialized printer began to whir. *Zzzzt-clack. Zzzzt-clack.* It was a rhythmic, industrial sound—the sound of identity being manufactured.

Five minutes later, the operator handed three warm plastic cards across the counter. "Don't punch a hole in them," she recited the standard warning. "It breaks the antenna coil. If you lose it, it is ten dollars to replace."

Freddie took his card. It was still warm from the printer. It was sleek. The background was a deep Maroon with Orange accents. **CPI POLYPASS**. His name was printed in raised, black thermal lettering: **FREDDIE AVERY**. His photo was to the right—he looked serious, alert, and present.

He ran his thumb over the raised letters of his name. It was tactile proof of his existence in the system. He flipped it over. A thick black magnetic stripe ran across the top. A barcode sat at the bottom. "Access granted," he whispered. He looked at Jessica. "This works on the bus?" "Swipe and ride," Jessica confirmed, sliding her own card into her wallet. "Starting right now. It is your key to the city. It opens the library, it gets you into the gym—if you ever wanted to go there—and it pays the fare."

Freddie slid the card into the front pocket of his jeans. He patted it. It wasn't just plastic. It was mobility.

"Phase Two," Jessica announced as they walked out of Newman Hall into the bright sunshine. She pointed across the massive, grassy expanse of the Drillfield toward the imposing stone fortress on the hill: **Burruss Hall**. "We have the IDs. Now we have to pay the toll."

"Tuition?" Paige asked. "Tuition," Jessica confirmed. "Summer classes aren't covered by standard financial aid packages. The Pell Grant doesn't run in July.

This is a cash-on-the-barrelhead transaction." She patted her purse. "Luckily, the Avery Grant is liquid."

They walked across the grass. Freddie watched the heavy limestone buildings loom closer. "Burruss Hall," Freddie noted. "Administrative Command." "Exactly," Jessica said. "The Office of the Bursar is on the first floor. They want their money before you sit in the chair."

The final stop was a quieter building near the edge of the Drillfield. They entered the office marked **SERVICES FOR STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES (SSD)**. It was carpeted, quiet, and smelled of lavender—a deliberate choice, Freddie suspected, to lower anxiety.

A receptionist looked up from a desk. "Welcome to SSD. How can I help you?" "Intake," Jessica said, placing the thick manila envelope on the desk. "This is Freddie Avery. Incoming Freshman, starting Session 2. We have his documentation for Cerebral Palsy and ADHD."

The receptionist took the folder. She opened it, scanning the medical records from the Virginia Beach school system. "Everything looks standard here," she said. "We can set up your accommodations letter for the summer session today. Extended time on tests, note-taking assistance... the usual suite."

She turned to her computer. "We need to schedule an intake interview to finalize the plan. Is Monday at 10:00 AM acceptable?" Freddie nodded. "Monday is acceptable."

Then, he hesitated. He looked at Jessica, then at Paige. They both nodded slightly. *Go ahead.* Freddie turned back to the receptionist. He cleared his throat. "There is... another variable," Freddie said. The receptionist stopped typing. She looked at him with patient, open eyes. "Yes?"

"My sisters and I... we suspect I am Autistic," Freddie said. The word felt heavy in the quiet room, but saying it out loud didn't cause the walls to collapse. "I do not have a diagnosis on file. The data is... empirical observation. I would like a recommendation for a provider who can perform an evaluation."

The receptionist smiled warmly. She opened a drawer and pulled out a separate pamphlet. "We work closely with the **Psychological Services Center** right here on campus, and there is a specialist in Blacksburg, **Dr. Aris Thorne**, who handles adult diagnoses. He is excellent." She wrote a name and number on a sticky note and attached it to the pamphlet. "Call him. Tell him SSD sent you. It can take a few weeks to get an appointment, but having the referral helps."

"Thank you," Freddie said, taking the paper. It felt like a treasure map.

He looked at the sticky note, then at his sisters standing behind him. A critical logical gap occurred to him. He was eighteen. Legally, he was a sealed database. But his operating system required external administrators. "One query," Freddie said, looking back at the receptionist. "I am eighteen. My records are encrypted by privacy laws, correct?"

"That is correct," the receptionist confirmed. "FERPA laws protect your educational and medical records. We cannot discuss them with anyone but you."

"That is a flaw in the architecture," Freddie stated. "I require my support team to have full visibility. If I am non-verbal, or if I am in a crash state, they need to be able to speak for me. They need to be able to schedule appointments and view my grades." He pointed to Jessica and Paige. "They are the Admins. They need root access."

The receptionist nodded, understanding immediately. She reached into a file sorter and pulled out a single sheet of paper. "You're looking for the **FERPA Waiver and Release of Information** form," she said, sliding it across the desk. "This authorizes us to communicate with designated individuals."

Freddie didn't even read the fine print. He picked up the pen. He signed his name on the line: *Freddie Avery*. Then he checked the boxes: [**X**] **Full Access** [**X**] **Financial** [**X**] **Medical/Disability** [**X**] **Academic**

He wrote the names in the authorized field, pressing hard to ensure the ink was permanent: *Jessica Avery Paige Avery Ellen Avery*

He slid the paper back. "Access granted," Freddie said. "Do not lock them out."

The receptionist stamped the form. **FILED**. "They are in the system, Freddie. You're all set. See you Monday at ten."

They walked out of the building. The sun was high and bright. "Okay," Jessica said, putting her sunglasses on. "Now we go home." Paige spun the keys on her finger. "I'm driving." Freddie touched the pamphlet in his pocket. *Dr. Aris Thorne.* He had a name. He had a plan. And now, his Admins had the keys. "Let's go," Freddie said. "The King bed is waiting."

Scene 3: The Medical Logistics

Paige navigated the Avalon smoothly down West Campus Drive, shifting from 2nd to 3rd gear with a satisfying *thunk*. "Clutch control is improving," Freddie noted from the passenger seat. "Thanks, Navigator."

"Briefing on medical," Jessica said from the back seat. "Since we are not going back to the Beach, we need local providers. I am transferring our files."

"Primary Care?" Paige asked. "There is a practice in Christiansburg near the hospital. But for the... specialized stuff," Jessica hesitated slightly, then pushed through. "I see a gynecologist in **Riner**. Dr. Halloway. She is quiet, she is efficient, and her office is in the middle of nowhere, so it is private."

"Riner?" Freddie asked. "Route 8?" "Yes. And there is a bus," Jessica added, knowing his brain needed the transit connection. "Route 8 runs once an hour. It drops off right in front of her clinic."

"Why do we need a special doctor?" Paige asked, glancing in the rearview mirror.

"Because we are living in close quarters," Jessica said frankly. "And because periods are a variable we need to control. Dr. Halloway put me on the shot—the **Cycle-Stop**. One injection every three months. No pills to remember. No... mess."

Paige thought about the King bed. She thought about the white sheets. She thought about the cramping that usually laid her out for two days a month. "No mess?" Paige asked. "It stops the cycle completely for most people," Jessica said. "It stabilizes the hormones. Less mood swings. Less pain."

Paige shifted into 4th gear. "Sign me up. If I am going to be sleeping next to Freddie every night, I do not want to worry about... leaks. Or being crazy."

"I will make the appointments," Jessica said. "We will take the bus down to Riner next week."

Freddie looked out the window as they turned onto Pepper Street. The bus to Riner. The textbook on human sexuality. The shot. It was all maintenance. It was all keeping the machine running smoothly so they could just... live.

"Systems normalizing," Freddie whispered. He touched the PolyPass in his pocket. The summer was just beginning, and they were already ahead of schedule.

Scene 4: The Schematic

The silver Avalon crunched into the gravel driveway of **105 Pepper Street**. The house was quiet, the air conditioner humming its steady, protective rhythm.

They unloaded the cargo. Jessica carried the bag from the Bursar's office (receipts and paperwork). Paige carried the PolyPasses. Freddie carried the books.

He walked straight to the living room and sat on the beige carpet, using the coffee table as a desk. He pulled the heavy, glossy textbook out of the bag. **Title:** *Human Sexuality: Biological and Psychosocial Perspectives.* **Weight:** 4.2 lbs. **Status:** The Manual.

He cracked the spine. The smell of new paper and binding glue wafted up—a sensory input he usually loved. He skipped the Preface. He skipped the Introduction. He went straight to Chapter 3: Anatomy and Physiology.

Jessica and Paige sat on the sofa behind him, kicking off their shoes. "How is the data?" Jessica asked, opening a can of soda.

"The diagrams are... two-dimensional," Freddie noted, tracing a line drawing of the female reproductive system with his finger. He frowned. The diagram was a cross-section. It was color-coded (pink for muscle, blue for veins, yellow for nerves), but it looked like a map of a subway system, not a biological entity.

He looked up at the TV, which was off. He looked at the VCR. When he learned to wire the entertainment center, he didn't just look at the diagram in the

manual. He looked at the ports on the back of the device. He traced the cables. He verified the input/output physically. *Theory is useless without verification.*

He turned around to face his sisters. He held the book up, pointing to the diagram. "This schematic," Freddie stated, tapping the page. "It represents the internal and external architecture. But it is an abstraction. It is a drawing."

"It is," Paige agreed. "It is a model."

"I have difficulty translating 2D models into 3D reality without a reference point," Freddie admitted. "The 'Robert Virus' says looking is wrong. But the 'Science Class' protocol says verification is necessary."

He looked at Jessica. "If we are to demystify the hardware... if I am to understand the mechanics so I do not freeze up or react with error..."

Jessica set her soda down. She understood the request immediately. It wasn't about gratification. It was about calibration. He was an engineer trying to understand the engine. "You want to compare the schematic to the actual unit," Jessica stated flatly.

"Affirmative," Freddie whispered. "Visual confirmation only. To map the vocabulary to the reality."

Jessica looked at Paige. Paige nodded. She didn't look scared. She looked like she was ready to help him study for a test. "It is just biology, Freddie," Paige said. "We promised. No secrets. No shame."

"Okay," Jessica said, standing up. She walked over to the windows and adjusted the blinds, ensuring they were fully closed. The room dimmed. "Class is in session," Jessica announced. "Bring the book."

[**NARRATIVE GAP: CLINICAL OBSERVATION & INSTRUCTION**]
Time Elapsed: 45 Minutes

Scene 5: Data Verified

The living room was bright again; Jessica had opened the blinds to let the afternoon sun wash over the carpet. The atmosphere in the room was calm. There was no tension. The air didn't feel heavy with secrets; it felt light, scrubbed clean of the mystery that usually plagued teenagers.

Freddie sat on the sofa, the textbook open on his lap. He wasn't staring at the diagrams with confusion anymore. He was looking at them with recognition. The abstract lines of the cross-section now made sense. He could visualize how the 2D drawing translated into 3D space. *Structure. Function. Design.*

Jessica was in the kitchen, making sandwiches. Paige was sitting next to Freddie on the sofa, reading her own copy of the textbook, highlighting a section on hormones.

"The variance is significant," Freddie murmured, running his finger down a paragraph about biological diversity. "The book says 'average' dimensions, but the variance is standard."

"Exactly," Paige said, not looking up from her highlighting. "Like how every car engine is basically the same design, but the layout varies by model year."

"Correct," Freddie said. He closed the book. *Thump.* The sound was final. He leaned back into the cushions. The "Robert Virus"—the voice in his head that shouted *Pervert! Wrong! Dirty!*—was silent. It had been deleted. He had seen the reality. It wasn't a monster. It wasn't a glowing radioactive core of sin. It was just tissue. It was just plumbing. It was just his sisters.

"Status?" Jessica called out from the kitchen, bringing a plate of sandwiches.

Freddie looked at her. He didn't blush. He didn't look away. He looked her in the eye. "The mystery is resolved," Freddie stated calmly. "The hardware matches the documentation. I understand the mechanics."

Jessica smiled, setting the plate down on the coffee table. "Good. That means when we get to class on July 7th, you won't be giggling in the back row like a freshman."

"I do not giggle," Freddie said, picking up a sandwich. "I process."

He took a bite. It tasted like ham and cheese. The world was simple again. He checked his mental inventory. *Bus Routes: Memorized. Tuition: Paid. Anatomy: Verified. Bed: King Size.*

"We are operational," Freddie decided. "The system is stable."

Paige leaned her head on his shoulder. "Systems go, Navigator."

Scene 6: The Clear Curtain

The sun had finally dipped below the ridge, leaving the sky a bruised purple over the Iron City. Inside **105 Pepper Street**, the lights were low, casting long shadows across the hallway.

Jessica walked into the bathroom holding a plastic package she had picked up during their supply run to **Valu-Mart**. "Upgrade time," she announced.

Freddie stood in the doorway, watching. He was wearing his orange hoodie over his boxers—his transition armor. He watched Jessica grip the old, opaque white shower curtain. *Zip. Zip. Zip.* The metal rings slid off the rod with a rhythmic clatter. The white curtain pooled on the floor like a deflated parachute. To Freddie, it looked like a wall coming down.

Jessica tore open the new package. The smell of fresh vinyl filled the small room—a sharp, chemical scent that Freddie associated with "New" and "Clean." She unfolded it. It was heavy-duty, commercial-grade plastic. And it was completely transparent.

She hung it up, hook by hook. "Visual confirmation," Jessica said, sliding it closed. The curtain rippled, but it didn't block anything. She stood inside the tub. Freddie could see her perfectly through the plastic—her silhouette, her face, the maroon CPI t-shirt she was wearing. "Water stays in," she said, tapping the liner with her fingernail. *Tick-tick.* "Data flows out."

Freddie nodded slowly. His brain processed the variable. *Old Curtain:* Isolation. Unknown variables. Fear of abandonment. *New Curtain:* Containment. Visibility. Constant stream of data.

"Logical compromise," Freddie whispered. "It maintains the moisture barrier but prevents visual disconnect."

"Exactly," Paige said, appearing behind him holding her toothbrush. She looked through the clear plastic at Jessica. "No more open curtains. No more wet floors. But you never have to wonder if we left. We are right here."

"Testing phase," Jessica said, stepping out of the tub. "You're up, Freddie. Let's verify the protocol."

Freddie stepped into the bathroom. The "Robert Virus" attempted to run its startup script—*You are eighteen. You cannot need help. This is wrong.* But the script failed. He had read the manual. He had seen the diagrams. The body was just a machine. Washing it was just maintenance.

He stripped off the orange hoodie and his boxers. He didn't rush. He placed them in the hamper. He stepped into the tub. He sat on the porcelain edge, just like yesterday. But today, he wasn't crashing. He was calibrating.

He turned the water on. Warm spray hit his back. He looked through the clear liner. He could see the sink. He could see the mirror. He could see Paige standing right there, leaning against the counter, squeezing toothpaste onto her brush. She wasn't leaving. She was maintaining the perimeter.

"Do you need assistance?" Paige asked, catching his eye through the plastic. Freddie paused. He could wash himself. His motor control was functional today. But the "Science Class" protocol wasn't just about utility; it was about desensitization. It was about proving, physically, that the shame was gone.

"Affirmative," Freddie whispered. "Scrub assist."

Paige set her toothbrush down. She didn't hesitate. She pulled the clear curtain back just enough to reach in. She picked up the washcloth and the bar of soap. She lathered it up until it was thick with white foam.

"Arms up," Paige said gently. Freddie lifted his arms. Paige washed him. She started at his shoulders, working the warm, soapy cloth down his back in firm, circular motions. *Scrub. Scrub. Scrub.* It was rhythmic. It was tactile. It was the same deep pressure she applied when she hugged him, but transferred through the medium of the sponge.

"Pressure okay?" Paige asked. "Optimal," Freddie said, closing his eyes. He felt the tension draining out of his trapezius muscles. He wasn't being "bathed like a baby." He was being cared for. She moved to his chest, scrubbing away the sweat of the day, the invisible residue of the bookstore anxiety, and the last clinging atoms of the "Robert Virus."

She rinsed him off with the handheld sprayer. The warm water cascaded down his skin. "All clear," Paige announced, turning off the tap. She handed him the towel. "Dry off. Meet us in the Silo."

Freddie stood up. He dried himself behind the clear curtain, watching Paige finish brushing her teeth. He wrapped the towel around his waist. He looked in the mirror. He looked clean. He looked stable. "Test successful," Freddie whispered to his reflection.

Scene 7: The Silo

The door to the Master Bedroom clicked shut. The blackout curtains were drawn, sealing the room into a protective, cool twilight. The **King Bed** dominated the space. It was a massive, 76-inch plain of maroon jersey sheets—a landscape of safety.

"Armor off," Jessica said, dropping her towel by the hamper. She climbed into the bed on the left side, pulling the sheet up to her waist. Paige followed suit, claiming the right side.

Freddie stood by the edge of the bed. Yesterday, this moment had been terrifying. Yesterday, he had woken up screaming because he thought he had broken a rule. Today, he knew there were no rules. There was only the System they built.

He dropped his towel. He didn't scramble to cover himself. He walked calmly to the side of the bed. He climbed into the center.

He lay on his back. The mattress absorbed his weight. "Formation," Freddie whispered.

Jessica rolled onto her side, pressing against his left arm. Paige rolled in from the right, resting her head on his shoulder, draping her arm over his chest to lock him in. They collapsed the empty space. They became a single thermal unit.

Freddie closed his eyes. He ran a system diagnostic. *Heart Rate:* Nominal. *Anxiety:* Zero. *Shame:* Not Detected.

He felt Paige's breathing. He felt the weight of Jessica's arm. It wasn't sexual. It wasn't weird. It was **Gravity**. It was the force that held him to the earth.

"Textbooks on the nightstand?" Freddie asked into the dark. "Right there," Paige whispered. "Ready for class." "Good," Freddie said.

He let out a long, slow breath. The static in his head—the white noise of fear that had been running in the background for eighteen years—finally went silent.

He was safe. He was funded. He was understood.

"Goodnight, Admins," Freddie whispered. "Goodnight, Navigator," they replied in unison.

The Network

Scene 1: The Primary Node

The silver **Horizon Avalon** idled in the driveway of 105 Pepper Street. The morning was already hot, the air shimmering above the asphalt of Pepper Plaza across the street.

Paige sat in the driver's seat. She adjusted the rearview mirror, checking the sightlines. "Clutch in," she whispered. She shifted into Reverse. The gear stick clicked into place with mechanical precision. "We are mobile," Freddie confirmed from the passenger seat. He had his clipboard ready—a literal clipboard he had found in the Ops Room supplies. It held their insurance cards, the FERPA copies, and a list of objectives.

"Destination: **Montgomery General Internal Medicine**," Jessica announced from the back seat. "Dr. Vance. He's the primary node. He handles my physicals, and he's the gateway to the specialists."

Paige eased the car out of the driveway. Her clutch control was becoming muscle memory now; the car didn't even shudder. They turned onto the main road, heading toward the hospital district on the south side of Christiansburg.

The waiting room smelled of antiseptic and old magazines. It was quiet, save for the low murmur of the receptionists behind the sliding glass window. They approached the desk as a unit.

"Checking in," Jessica said. "Three appointments. Avery, Avery, and Avery." The receptionist blinked, looking at the three siblings who stood shoulder-to-shoulder. "New patients?" "I'm established," Jessica said. "They are new. Transfers from Virginia Beach."

The receptionist handed over three heavy clipboards stacked with forms. "Update yours, and fill out the new patient packets for them. Insurance cards?" Freddie handed over the cards from his clipboard. He watched her scan them. *Beep.* "Okay," she said. "Have a seat. Bring the forms up when you're done."

They sat in a row of chairs. Freddie looked at the stack of paper. *Medical History. Family History. Surgical History.* He uncapped his pen. He liked forms. Forms were binary. *Yes/No. Check Box.*

Then he reached the last page: **HIPAA Authorization & Release of Information**. *I hereby authorize this practice to release my protected health information to...*

"Hold," Freddie said. Jessica and Paige looked up from their own clipboards. "We need a policy decision," Freddie stated. "Standard protocol is privacy. My records are sealed." He looked at Jessica. "But you are the Admin. You need to know if the hardware fails." He looked at Paige. "You are the Anchor. You need to know if the chemicals are imbalanced."

"And you need to know about us," Jessica countered. "If Paige has a reaction to the shot, or if I get sick during finals, you need to be able to talk to the doctor."

"Redundancy," Freddie nodded. "Total transparency." He wrote in the blank lines on his form: *1. Jessica Avery (Sister) 2. Paige Avery (Sister) 3. Ellen Avery (Mother)*

He checked the box for **[X] ALL RECORDS**.

Paige watched him, then copied the list onto her form. Jessica did the same on her update form.

"This is the Tri-Lateral Agreement," Freddie whispered, signing his name at the bottom. "If one unit goes down, the others have the schematic."

Dr. Vance was a tall man with wire-rimmed glasses and a demeanor that was efficient but kind. He didn't blink when all three siblings crowded into the exam room. "Okay," Dr. Vance said, looking at the charts. "We're doing intake for Freddie and Paige today?"

"Affirmative," Freddie said from the exam table. He was sitting on the crinkly paper, legs dangling. "I require a maintenance check and referrals."

"Let's start with the history," Dr. Vance said. "I see Cerebral Palsy and ADHD on the transfer file." "Spastic Diplegia," Freddie corrected. "Mild. Mostly affects the lower extremities. I require Baclofen for the spasticity." "And the ADHD?" "Ritalin," Freddie said. "Standard dosage. It maintains focus."

Dr. Vance nodded, making notes. Then he looked at Jessica, then back to Freddie. "Anything else?"

Freddie took a breath. He looked at Paige. She gave him a small nod. *Use the manual.* "There is a suspected discrepancy in the operating system," Freddie stated clearly. "Suspected?" Dr. Vance asked. "Autism," Freddie said. "My sisters and I have reviewed the diagnostic criteria. My sensory processing, social deficits, and reliance on routine match the profile. However, I lack a formal diagnosis code."

Dr. Vance stopped writing. He looked at Freddie—really looked at him. He saw the lack of eye contact, the slight rocking, the precise, mechanical speech patterns. He looked at Jessica and Paige, who were standing guard like Secret Service agents. "I see," Dr. Vance said softly. "Well, you're in the right place. We can get that looked at."

"We have a lead," Jessica interjected. "The Dean of Students recommended **Dr. Aris Thorne** in Blacksburg. But we need a referral for insurance."

"Dr. Thorne is excellent," Dr. Vance agreed. "I'll write the referral today. 'Evaluation for Autism Spectrum Disorder.' That should get you in the door."

"Thank you," Freddie said.

"Now," Dr. Vance turned to Paige. "And for you?" Paige sat up straighter. "I need a referral too. To **Dr. Halloway** in Riner." "OB/GYN?" Dr. Vance asked. "Yes," Paige said. "I want to start the **Cycle-Stop** injection. Jessica is on it. We... we live in close quarters. We want to stabilize the variables."

Dr. Vance didn't ask why siblings living together needed birth control. He was a doctor; he cared about health, not living arrangements. "Dr. Halloway is great," he said. "I'll put that referral in as well. Anything else?"

"Just maintenance," Jessica said. "We want to make sure everyone is running at 100% before the semester starts."

Dr. Vance finished his notes. "You guys have a good system here," he observed, tearing off the prescription slips for the referrals. He handed them to Freddie. "You're the keeper of the papers?" "I am the Archivist," Freddie said, taking them.

They walked back to the Avalon. The sun was high overhead. Freddie held the referrals in his hand. *Referral: Dr. Aris Thorne (Psychiatry/Neurology). Referral: Dr. Halloway (Gynecology).*

He looked at the papers. They weren't just slips of paper. They were patch notes. They were upgrades waiting to be installed. "We have the keys," Freddie said. "We have the keys," Paige agreed, unlocking the car. "Now let's go get some lunch. I'm starving."

"Route 8 next?" Jessica asked. "Negative," Freddie said, checking the schedule in his head. "Today is Wednesday. We need to call Dr. Halloway first. But the bus run... that is a tactical necessity. We need to verify the route."

"Next week," Jessica promised. "Next week, we ride to Riner."

Scene 2: The Red Flag

The Silo was silent. The air conditioner hummed its steady, protective white noise. On the King Bed, the formation was holding. Freddie lay in the center, flanked by Jessica on his left and Paige on his right. The room was cool, the blackout curtains sealing them in a timeless dark.

Paige shifted. It wasn't a normal sleep movement. It was a sharp, sudden jolt. She sat up, gasping softly. Her hand went to her thigh. "Oh," she whispered. "Oh no."

Freddie woke up instantly. The sudden movement next to him triggered his proximity sensors. "Paige?" he mumbled, his voice thick with sleep. "Status?"

Paige was already scrambling out of bed. She moved fast, her feet hitting the floor with urgency. In the faint light filtering from the streetlamp outside, Freddie saw her check her leg. There was a dark smear on her upper thigh. Blood.

The "Robert Virus" surged. *Injury. Attack. Danger.* Panic spiked in his chest. His breathing hitched. "Paige!" he gasped, sitting up. "You are bleeding!"

"I'm fine!" Paige hissed, rushing toward the door. "Just... bathroom. Go back to sleep." She disappeared into the hallway, closing the bathroom door with a click.

Freddie couldn't go back to sleep. The image of the blood on her skin was burned into his retinas. He turned to the left. He shook Jessica's shoulder. "Jessica. Wake up. Emergency."

Jessica groaned, rolling over. "What? What time is it?" "Paige is bleeding," Freddie said, his voice rising in pitch, the vibration of panic starting in his hands. "She stood up and there was blood. She ran to the bathroom. Is she injured?"

Jessica was awake in an instant. She sat up, scanning the bed. She checked the sheet where Paige had been sleeping. It was clean. No transfer. "Okay," Jessica said, her voice dropping to a calm, command-level register. She put a hand on Freddie's chest to steady him. "Freddie, listen. She isn't injured. She didn't cut herself."

"I saw the blood," Freddie insisted, pointing at his own leg to indicate the location. "Femoral artery location. High volume risk."

"No," Jessica said firmly. "It's her cycle, Freddie. Her period." Freddie froze. "Period?" "Menstruation," Jessica clarified. "Remember the textbook? Chapter 4? The shedding of the uterine lining?"

Freddie blinked. The data from yesterday's reading session loaded into his RAM. *Uterus. Endometrium. Monthly cycle. Bloody discharge.* The panic wavered. It wasn't trauma. It was a function. "But... it is messy," Freddie whispered. "It looks like injury."

"It does," Jessica agreed. "But it is just biology. She woke up because she felt it start. She's in the bathroom taking care of it before it stains the sheets. That was a close call."

The bathroom door opened. Paige walked back in. She wasn't nude anymore. She was wearing a pair of black cotton panties. She walked to the bed, looking tired but relieved. "Clear?" Jessica asked. "Clear," Paige confirmed, climbing back in. "Caught it just in time. No breach on the bedding."

She settled back into her spot on Freddie's right. Freddie looked at her. He looked at the black panties. "Status?" Freddie asked, his voice still trembling slightly. Paige offered a tired, reassuring smile. "Status is Red, Freddie. Literally. It's just that time of the month." She saw the fear still lingering in his eyes. She took his hand and placed it on her stomach, right over her belly button. "I am

not hurt," she promised. "My body is just doing a system reset. It's annoying, and tomorrow it's going to hurt, but I'm okay."

Freddie felt the warmth of her skin. He felt the steady rise and fall of her breathing. *Not trauma. Maintenance.* "Pain levels?" he asked. "Zero right now," Paige said. "But Day Two is usually the bad one. I might need the **Cycle-Ease** and the heating pad tomorrow." "And pressure," Jessica added from the other side. "Don't forget the squeeze."

"I can provide pressure," Freddie stated immediately. The mission parameters had changed from 'Rescue' to 'Support.' He could do Support. "I know," Paige whispered. "That's why you're the best."

She pulled the sheet up. "Panties are mandatory for the next five days," she noted. "Containment protocol." "Understood," Freddie said. "Hygiene standard."

He lay back down between them. Jessica draped her arm over him again. Paige snuggled close, her head back on his shoulder. The black cotton barrier was there, but the warmth was the same. The fear evaporated. It wasn't a crisis. It was just life. And now that he knew what it was—now that he had seen the reality of it without the shame—he didn't have to be scared.

"This is why we need the doctor in Riner," Paige mumbled into his shoulder, her eyes already closing. "Get on the shot. Stop the bleeding." "Efficiency," Freddie whispered. "Upgrade the system."

"Sleep," Jessica commanded gently. "Sleep," Freddie agreed. He closed his eyes. The King Bed held them all—the biology, the anxiety, and the safety of the truth.

Here is Part 3 of the narrative, detailing the trip to Riner and the medical appointments.

Scene 3: The Maintenance Run

The morning at **105 Pepper Street** started earlier than the alarm clock intended. Around 3:00 AM, Paige had woken up with the familiar, dull ache of cramps, signaling the start of her cycle—and the "Red Flag" status Freddie had learned to recognize. While the timing meant a groggy start to the day, it was actually serendipitous for the logistics of the morning.

They had 9:00 AM appointments at the clinic in Riner. Blue Ridge Transit's **Route 8** was the only link between the two towns, a lifeline designed primarily to shuttle seniors from the rural hills into Christiansburg. It ran on a strict hourly pulse, leaving Pepper Plaza at 45 minutes past the hour.

"Strategy," Jessica announced, checking her watch in the kitchen. "The 8:45 AM bus gets us there at 9:05 AM. That is too tight for intake paperwork. We take the **7:45 AM** departure."

They left the Base at 7:35 AM. It was a short walk—diagonally across the street to the **Pepper Plaza Transit Center**. The morning air was humid, but the view of the mountains was clear.

The bus pulled into the sawtooth bay right on time. It was smaller than the massive articulated buses used for the university runs, better suited for the winding state roads. The amber destination sign glowed against the morning sun:

8 RINER

They boarded, swiping their newly minted **PolyPasses**. The bus was mostly empty, save for a few locals heading out to the farms.

The ride was deceptively short but scenic. As soon as the bus left the commercial density of Christiansburg, the landscape opened up. They rolled down **SR-8**, passing rolling farmland, misty cow pastures, and scattered farmhouses. For twenty minutes, Freddie watched the telephone poles whip by, counting the intervals. It was a quiet, rhythmic transition from the "Iron City" to the country.

"Next stop," the driver announced. "Riner Road and Union Valley."

The bus slowed, pulling over to the side of the highway at the intersection of **SR-8** and **SR-669**. They stepped off onto the gravel shoulder.

"Landmarks," Jessica pointed out.

Directly in front of them, at **4021 Riner Rd**, stood a boxy, metal-sided building with a yellow sign: **Riner Value Mart**. It was the only retail anchor in sight.

"Target is across the street," Jessica said, pointing to the other side of the highway. "1917 Union Valley Road."

The geography here was tricky. The medical building was built directly into the steep hillside. From the bus stop at the top of the hill, they were looking at the roof and the second floor of the brick structure.

"We have to go down," Paige noted, clutching her stomach slightly as a cramp hit.

They waited for a break in the traffic on SR-8—mostly pickup trucks and landscaping trailers—and crossed the highway. They navigated the sidewalk that sloped steeply downward, descending the hill to the main parking lot level.

The entrance to **Dr. Halloway's** office was on the first floor. Inside, the waiting room was quiet, smelling of sanitizer and potpourri. It was a small practice, far removed from the hustle of the hospital district.

"Freddie," Jessica said, pointing to a comfortable chair in the corner. "This is your post. You hold the perimeter."

"Acknowledged," Freddie said, sitting down. He pulled a book from his bag, happy to be the silent sentry while his sisters handled the biological maintenance.

Jessica and Paige went to the check-in window. Jessica was a regular; she simply signed her name. Paige, however, had the new patient clipboard to navigate.

They were called back quickly. For Jessica, the appointment was routine clockwork. She knew the drill: a quick vitals check, a brief chat with Dr. Halloway, and the administration of the **Cycle-Stop** injection. It was a quick pinch, and she was protected for another three months.

For Paige, the consultation took longer. Dr. Halloway, a woman with a kind face and efficiency that matched Jessica's, reviewed Paige's file.

"So, we're looking to start the Cycle-Stop today?" Dr. Halloway asked.

"Yes," Paige said. "My sister is on it. We live together. We want to... synchronize the systems."

"That makes sense," Dr. Halloway nodded. "Now, usually we have to wait to administer the first shot to ensure you aren't pregnant. We prefer to give it during the first five days of your menstrual cycle."

Paige blinked. "I started at 3:00 AM today."

"Perfect timing," Dr. Halloway smiled, grabbing a pair of gloves. "Since you are on Day 1, we can do this right now. You'll be effective immediately, though we always say give it a week to be safe. This should help with the cramping you mentioned, too. Eventually, it might stop the bleeding altogether."

"That is the goal," Paige said, exhaling in relief.

Ten minutes later, Paige walked out of the exam room, rubbing her arm. She felt lighter. The anxiety about "leaks" and "mess" in the King Bed was gone. She had the patch.

They collected Freddie from the lobby at 9:45 AM.

"Mission complete?" Freddie asked, standing up.

"Systems updated," Jessica confirmed. "Let's catch the ride home."

They walked back out into the humidity, trudging back *up* the steep hill to SR-8. They crossed the street to the return stop, located near **4010 Riner Rd**, just down from the intersection.

They checked the schedule posted on the sign. The bus departed from Auburn High School nearby at **10:15 AM**.

A few minutes later, the white bus appeared over the crest of the hill. The destination sign had flipped for the return leg:

8 CHRISTIANSBURG

They boarded, taking their seats in the cool air conditioning. As the bus wound its way back through the farmland toward Pepper Plaza, Freddie watched his

sisters. They were relaxed. The medical logistics were handled. The "Base" was fully operational.

"Next stop," Freddie whispered to himself as the bus rolled on. "Home."‘

Proper Terminology

Scene 1: Ground Rules

The fluorescent lights of the classroom hummed, a stark contrast to the humid warmth of a Blacksburg summer afternoon outside. This was HPE 204: Dimensions of Human Sexuality.

For Freddie, this class was a strategic maneuver. The university's Health and Physical Education requirement was mandatory for graduation, usually filled by sweating through tennis, jogging, or swimming. With his cerebral palsy, those options ranged from "difficult" to "logistical nightmare." But HPE 204 counted for the same credit, and the only muscle he had to exercise here was his brain.

He sat in the second row, the sweet spot for serious students who didn't want to appear eager. Flanking him were Paige and Jessica, the three of them claiming a block of desks like a defensive line.

"I give it ten minutes before the frat boys in the back row crack," Jessica whispered, leaning in from Freddie's left. She had her notebook open but her pen was capped, her eyes scanning the room with amused cynicism.

"Five," Paige countered from his right. She had already written the date and the course title at the top of her page in neat, architectural block letters. "Look at them. They're already vibrating."

She wasn't wrong. The room was set for thirty, and while half the class looked like Freddie—students checking a box for a degree requirement—the other half were the types who had seen the word "Sexuality" in the course catalog and assumed this would be an easy A or a comedy hour.

The door shut with a heavy click, and Dr. Aris Thorne walked to the podium. She was a woman who radiated a clinical, no-nonsense authority. She didn't smile. She didn't try to be cool. She set a stack of syllabi on the desk and looked over her glasses at the room.

"Welcome to Dimensions of Human Sexuality," Dr. Thorne said. Her voice was calm but projected to the back corners of the room without a microphone. "Let us establish the ground rules immediately."

The shuffling of backpacks ceased.

"In this room, there are no secrets," she began, pacing slowly in front of the whiteboard. "We are studying human biology, psychology, and sociology. We will treat these subjects with the scientific dignity they deserve. If you are here

to giggle, drop the class now. There is a waiting list of students who actually need this credit."

Freddie adjusted his posture, grateful for the sturdy desk chair. He saw Paige nod in approval.

"I will use proper terminology," Dr. Thorne continued. "You will hear words like 'penis,' 'vulva,' 'intercourse,' and 'masturbation' frequently. However..." She paused, picking up a dry-erase marker. "You are entering a world where you may be educators, healthcare providers, or counselors. The people you interact with will not always use textbooks terms."

She turned and wrote a single word on the board: *Terminology.*

"We will learn the clinical definitions," she said, facing them again. "But we will also introduce and discuss the slang. The street terms. The words you hear in movies and locker rooms. Not because I want you to use them in your papers, but because when a patient or a student comes to you confused and uses those words, you need to know exactly what they are talking about without flinching."

From the back row, a stifled snort broke the silence. It was the distinct sound of someone trying to hold back a laugh and failing.

Dr. Thorne didn't even look up from her notes. "I assume that was a involuntary reflex," she said dryly. "Get it out of your system now. By Chapter 3, the novelty will have worn off."

Jessica leaned toward Freddie, her voice barely a breath. "She's good."

"She has to be," Freddie whispered back.

"This is a safe space," Dr. Thorne said, her eyes locking on the back row. "Questions are encouraged. Ignorance is expected—that is why you are here. But disrespect will result in an immediate ejection. We are discussing the mechanics of human life. You will respect the subject, and you will respect each other."

She tapped the stack of papers on her desk.

"Syllabuses are coming around. We start with anatomy on Wednesday. I suggest you do the reading. If you are uncomfortable discussing the human body, the registrar closes at 5:00 PM."

Freddie took a syllabus as the pile passed him, handing the rest to Paige. He glanced at the course schedule. It was dense, clinical, and thorough. It was exactly what he needed to get his degree without worrying about his legs giving out on a track. He uncapped his pen. He was ready to work.

Scene 2: Zero Tolerance

Dr. Thorne moved through the syllabus with the efficiency of a surgeon. She didn't pace; she planted herself behind the podium and let the weight of the

topics settle over the room.

"Week four covers reproductive anatomy," she said, tapping the document. "Week five, the physiology of sexual response. Week six, we begin our unit on contraception and STI prevention. Do not assume you know this material because you took a health class in ninth grade. The statistics suggest otherwise."

She flipped a page. "Regarding visual aids: We will be viewing diagrams and clinical photography. These are medical images. They are not pornography. If you cannot distinguish between the two, you will struggle to pass the midterm."

The room was silent, save for the scratching of pens. Freddie appreciated the bluntness. There was no ambiguity here.

Then, Dr. Thorne reached the section on sexual dysfunction. "We will discuss common issues ranging from erectile dysfunction to vaginismus. . . "

A sharp, high-pitched giggle erupted from the third row.

It wasn't a cough disguised as a laugh. It was a full-blown, open-mouthed cackle. A girl with blonde highlights and a popped collar—who had spent the last ten minutes whispering to her neighbor—had apparently found the medical terminology hilarious. She was exactly the type Freddie had clocked earlier: someone who signed up hoping for an "easy A" and perhaps some titillating live demonstrations, treating a university course like a bachelorette party.

The silence that followed was absolute.

Dr. Thorne stopped mid-sentence. She didn't sigh. She didn't scold. She simply pointed a manicured finger at the door.

"Out," she said. Her voice was level, devoid of anger but terrifyingly final.

The girl blinked, her smile faltering. "What? I was just—"

"You were disrupting my lecture and disrespecting the material," Dr. Thorne said. "Pack your bag. You are dropped from the course effective immediately. I will email the registrar before this class ends."

"But—"

"Now."

The girl's face flushed a deep crimson. The reality of losing three credits in the first twenty minutes of the semester seemed to crash down on her. She shoved her notebook into her bag, the sound of the zipper loud in the quiet room. She stood up, smoothing her skirt, trying to salvage some scrap of dignity by pretending she didn't care.

She walked down the aisle, chin held high, passing the second row.

As she came abreast of Freddie, she paused. She had seen him walk in earlier, noting the uneven rhythm of his gait, the way his foot dragged slightly, and how

heavily he leaned on the blonde girl next to him for stability. In her mind, she did the quick, cruel calculus of the immature: *Disability means desperation.*

She slowed her pace and locked eyes with him. Her expression shifted from embarrassment to a bizarre, heavy-lidded sultry gaze—an exaggerated, "I want you" look. It was performative and predatory, a smirk that said, *I bet you'd take whatever you could get.*

She winked, then pushed through the double doors, letting them slam behind her.

Freddie stared at the closed door, his stomach turning. He wasn't flattered; he was insulted. She had looked at him and seen an easy target, a lonely guy who would be grateful for the attention of a girl who just got kicked out of sex ed.

She couldn't have been more wrong.

He felt a hand slide firmly onto his forearm, squeezing with a familiar, grounding pressure. It was Paige. She didn't look at the door; she was looking at him, her blue eyes calm and knowing. On his other side, Jessica shifted in her seat, her shoulder pressing solidly against his, creating a physical barrier of support.

Freddie let out a breath, the tension in his spastic muscles easing under Paige's touch. He didn't need the validation of a stranger looking for a rebound. He had Paige, his twin and safe person. He had Jessica, his rock. He had five other sisters back home in Virginia Beach who made up his entire world. He had more love and support in his life than that girl would likely ever understand.

He glanced at Paige, offering a small, dismissive shrug. She smiled—a tiny, private expression that said, *I know. She's gone. You're safe.*

"As I was saying," Dr. Thorne continued, her voice slicing through the lingering awkwardness. "Vaginismus. Now, let's turn to page four regarding the attendance policy. . . "

Scene 3: Safe Harbor

The rest of the lecture blurred into a stream of biological terms and syllabus dates. Dr. Thorne didn't let the tension linger; she buried it under a mountain of academic expectations. By the time she capped her marker and announced, "Class dismissed," the incident with the girl felt like a distant memory to everyone—except the three people in the second row.

As the room erupted into the sound of zippers and shuffling feet, Freddie didn't move immediately. This was part of the routine. The adrenaline spike from the confrontation, combined with sitting still for fifty minutes in a rigid desk chair, meant his legs would be seized up. The spasticity always hit harder after stress.

"Take your time," Jessica said, her voice low and steady. She stood up first, smoothing the front of her dark green top. She turned to face the aisle, effectively becoming a human shield against the rush of students trying to exit. Her posture

was relaxed but firm—the Matriarch holding the line. No one was going to push past her to rush Freddie.

On his right, Paige shifted her backpack to her outside shoulder, leaving her left side clear. She stood up and turned toward him, her expression softening into that familiar, easy smile—the same one she'd worn in family photos since they were kids.

"Ready?" she asked.

Freddie nodded, gripping the edge of the desk to lever himself up. His right leg dragged, the muscle tight and resisting the command to straighten. He wobbled for a fraction of a second, a moment of vulnerability that usually made him grit his teeth in frustration.

But the moment he swayed, Paige was there.

She didn't make a big deal out of it. She simply stepped into his space, offering her shoulder as a solid, immovable anchor. Freddie wrapped his arm around her, pulling her close. To an outsider, it might have looked like a simple side-hug between siblings. To Freddie, it was a structural necessity.

He leaned his weight onto her, exhaling sharply as the tension in his lower back released. This was their default state. The grey cotton of her shirt against his arm, the scent of her shampoo, the way she instinctively braced her stance to support him—it was deep pressure therapy in motion.

"You okay?" Paige murmured, her voice vibrating against his side.

"Yeah," Freddie said, the tightness in his chest finally unspooling. "Just stiff."

"I got you."

Jessica glanced back at them, doing a quick visual check. Seeing Freddie secure against Paige, she nodded—a quick, professional confirmation that the "server" was stable.

"Let's get out of here," Jessica said, finally stepping aside to open the path. "I need coffee, and if we hurry, we can beat the rush at the student center."

They walked out together, a tight formation against the chaos of the hallway. Freddie moved with his distinct, uneven gait, heavily leaning on Paige with every other step. He wasn't hiding the limp, and he wasn't hiding the affection. If anyone else in the hallway looked at him with pity or mockery, he didn't notice.

He was too busy holding onto the sister who made the world stop spinning.

Scene 4: The Predator

The journey from the classroom door to the building lobby was only fifty yards, but to Freddie, it felt like a forced march across a gravity-heavy planet.

His arms were draped heavily over his sisters' shoulders. To his left, Jessica bore his weight, her shoulder pressing into his armpit. She was wearing a maroon CPI t-shirt emblazoned with the school mascot—**The Forger**—a muscular, bearded blacksmith raising a hammer. The graphic seemed to mock the current situation; while the painted man on her chest was made of iron, Freddie felt like he was made of wet sand.

To his right was Paige. She was wearing a plain navy blue t-shirt that was, objectively, a size too small. The fabric pulled tight across her chest and shoulders, outlining her bust in a way that usually made Freddie avert his gaze out of respect. But right now, he wasn't looking at her geometry; he was relying on her structure. She gripped his waist firmly, her hip locking against his thigh with every step to prevent his knee from buckling.

Freddie himself wore a simple tan t-shirt that fit perfectly, though it was currently damp with the sweat of exertion.

"Almost there," Paige whispered, adjusting her grip on his belt loop. "The bench is at twelve o'clock. Visual confirmation."

They rounded the corner into the lobby. The air was cooler here, the sunlight streaming in through the glass walls.

"Target acquired," Jessica murmured. "Preparing for docking procedure."

But the path to the bench was blocked.

Leaning against a pillar, right in the center of the lobby, was the girl.

She hadn't left the building. She was waiting. Her arms were crossed over her chest, pushing up her cleavage in a way that seemed calculated. She was popping gum with a rhythmic *snap-crack* that cut through the lobby noise.

When she saw them emerge—Freddie sagging between his sisters, his face pale—her eyes lit up. She didn't see three college students moving as a unit. She didn't see the Forger on Jessica's shirt or the family resemblance in their faces.

She saw a target. She saw a guy who, in her estimation, probably spent his Saturday nights alone and would be grateful for a scrap of attention from someone like her.

She pushed off the pillar and stepped directly into their path.

"Hey," she purred. Her voice had dropped an octave from the shriek she'd used in class. It was now smoky, suggestive.

The Avery unit came to a halt. Freddie blinked, trying to clear the sweat from his eyes. He looked at her, then past her to the bench.

"Obstruction," Freddie whispered to Paige. "Path blocked."

The girl ignored the women holding him up. To her, they were background noise—staff, aides, maybe volunteers from the disability office. She scanned over

Paige's tight navy shirt with a dismissive sneer, writing her off completely.

"Rough class, huh?" the girl said, stepping closer, invading Freddie's personal space. She smelled of cheap vanilla perfume and ambition. "That teacher is such a prude. I bet you were bored out of your mind."

Freddie frowned. "The material was... standard," he rasped. "She enforced the syllabus."

The girl laughed, tossing her hair. "You're funny. I like that." She looked him up and down, her gaze lingering on his denim-clad legs, then moving up to his eyes with a predatory smirk.

"You look like you've had a hard day," she said, lowering her voice to a conspiratorial whisper. "You look tense. Maybe you need someone to help you... relax?"

She reached out, her hand aiming for the tan fabric of his chest. "I was thinking, since I got kicked out, maybe I need a private tutor? Someone to show me the... practical application?"

Jessica stiffened. Her grip on Freddie's waist tightened. The Forger on her shirt seemed to glare.

Freddie stared at the girl. His brain attempted to parse the data. *Input:* Girl from class. *Status:* Expelled. *Action:* Blocking the bench. *Dialogue:* Illogical. Suggestive.

"I am not a tutor," Freddie said flatly. "I am a student. And I require a seat. My legs are failing."

The girl pouted, a theatrical expression. "Aww, poor baby. Your legs hurt?" She took another step, virtually chest-to-chest with him now. "I bet I can make you forget all about your legs. I bet I can make you feel *real* good."

She shot a dismissive glance at Paige and Jessica. "Why don't you ditch the help? We can go to my dorm. It's close."

The silence that followed was heavy.

"The help?" Jessica repeated. Her voice was ice cold.

The girl rolled her eyes. "Yeah. The nurses. The aides. Whatever. You guys can go. I've got him from here."

She reached for Freddie's arm, trying to pull him away from Paige's navy-clad shoulder.

That was a tactical error.

Paige didn't let go. She clamped down on Freddie's bicep like a vice. She didn't look at the girl with anger; she looked at her with the pity one reserves for a mosquito about to hit a bug zapper.

"He isn't going anywhere," Paige said pleasantly.

"Excuse me?" the girl snapped, her mask slipping. "I'm talking to him. Not you."

"And he is talking to you," Jessica interjected, stepping forward slightly, effectively using her shoulder to box the girl out. "He said he needs to sit down. You are in the way."

"He wants to go with me," the girl insisted, looking at Freddie with that same sultry, desperate look. "Don't you, tiger? You want to have some fun? You want to know what a real woman feels like?"

Freddie looked at her. He looked at the heavy makeup and the popped collar. Then he looked at the two women holding him up.

He looked at Jessica in her maroon school colors, the architect of his safety. He looked at Paige in her tight navy tee, the anchor of his sanity. These were the women who bathed him when he couldn't move, who slept next to him to keep the nightmares away, who learned an entire medical textbook just to make him feel safe.

He knew exactly what a real woman felt like. He was holding two of them.

"No," Freddie said. His voice wasn't loud, but it was clear. "I do not want 'fun.' I want stability. And you represent chaos."

The girl's mouth fell open.

"Chaos?" she sputtered.

"Variable rejected," Freddie confirmed. "Please move. I need the bench."

He didn't wait for her to move. He gave the signal—a slight lean forward.

"Forward," Jessica commanded.

The phalanx moved. They didn't walk around her; they walked *through* the space she was occupying. The girl had to scramble backward, her sneakers squeaking on the tile, to avoid being run over by the sheer momentum of the Avery unit.

She stood there in the middle of the lobby, mouth agape, as the three siblings bypassed her completely.

They reached the bench. Paige and Jessica coordinated the descent, lowering Freddie gently until he was seated. He leaned back against the wall, closing his eyes, letting out a long, ragged exhale.

"Safe," Freddie whispered.

"Safe," Paige confirmed, sitting next to him and wrapping her arm around his shoulders.

The girl watched them for a moment, her face twisting into a sneer of rejection. She huffed, spun on her heel, and stormed out the front door, muttering something about "freaks."

Jessica watched her go, brushing a piece of lint off her Forger t-shirt. Then she sat on Freddie's other side.

"She thought we were staff," Jessica noted dryly. "Nurses."

"She thought I was desperate," Freddie corrected, opening one eye. "She calculated that disability equals a zero-sum game for romantic selection. She assumed I would take any input provided."

"She sucks at math," Paige said, resting her head on his shoulder.

"Agreed," Freddie said, closing his eye again. He felt the warmth of his sisters on both sides—maroon on the left, navy on the right. The bench was hard, the lobby was bright, but the perimeter was secure.

"Five minutes," Freddie requested. "Then the bus."

"Take ten," Jessica said, crossing her legs in her blue jeans. "We aren't going anywhere."

Scene 5: Geometry and Physics

The lobby bench was hard wood, but to Freddie, it felt like a recharge station. He sat in the middle, eyes closed, letting his breathing sync with the steady rise and fall of Paige's chest against his right side.

"Heart rate decelerating," Freddie murmured. "System cooling."

"Good," Paige whispered, keeping her arm firmly around his shoulders. "We'll sit here as long as it takes."

But the peace was short-lived. The heavy glass doors of the lecture hall swung open again, releasing the stragglers—the students who had hung back to pack their bags or avoid the initial crush.

Among them was a boy Freddie had noted earlier in the back row. He was wearing a polo shirt with the collar flipped up—a fashion choice Freddie found illogical as it offered no neck protection—and he had spent the majority of the lecture snickering at the diagrams.

He stopped when he saw them on the bench. His eyes didn't go to Freddie. They didn't go to Jessica.

They went straight to Paige. Specifically, they went to the navy blue t-shirt.

Freddie opened his eyes. He saw the vector of the boy's gaze. It was a direct line of sight to Paige's chest, where the tight fabric struggled to contain her anatomy. Freddie felt a spike of protective irritation. He knew the shirt was too small; it was an error in the laundry cycle, not an invitation.

But the boy didn't see an error. He saw an opportunity.

He sauntered over, ignoring the fact that Paige was clearly engaged in a support maneuver.

"Hey," the boy said, stopping right in front of her. He leaned against the wall, trying to look casual. "You were in the second row, right? The one taking all the notes?"

Paige looked up. Her expression was flat. She tightened her grip on Freddie's shoulder. "I was."

"I noticed," the boy smirked, his eyes dropping to her neckline again. "Hard to miss. That shirt is doing a lot of heavy lifting. I respect the effort."

Jessica sat up straight on Freddie's left, her eyes narrowing behind her glasses. She opened her mouth to eviscerate him, but Paige squeezed Freddie's arm, signaling *Hold.*

"Can I help you?" Paige asked, her voice dropping to a temperature that could freeze nitrogen.

"Just thought you might want a study partner," the boy said, stepping closer. "That class looks... intense. I figured maybe we could compare notes. Grab a drink? You look like you could use a break from... "

He gestured vaguely at Freddie, waving a hand as if Freddie were a piece of luggage or a confusing piece of furniture. "... whatever this is."

Freddie felt a sudden, sharp jolt of recognition.

The data retrieval system in his brain spun up. He accessed a file from **Freshman Year, September 1999**. *Subject:* Jason. Snare Drummer. *Incident:* Concession Stand. *Dialogue:* "He's a big boy... cut the cord... it's embarrassing."

This was the same algorithm. Different face, same code.

Freddie lifted his head. He looked at the boy. "This," Freddie stated, pointing to himself, "is her brother. And she is not 'babysitting.' She is anchoring."

The boy laughed, a dismissive bark. "Brother? Right. Look, man, no offense, but she looks a little cramped. I'm just offering to give her some space."

He looked back at Paige, flashing a winning smile. "Come on. Ditch the family reunion. Let me buy you a coffee. I bet you're fun when you aren't weighted down."

Paige didn't smile back. She didn't blush. She didn't look flattered.

She gently removed her arm from Freddie's shoulders, but she didn't stand up. She shifted her weight, turning her body so she was facing the boy directly. The tight navy shirt stretched across her chest, but she didn't cross her arms to hide it. She used her geometry as armor.

“I had a boyfriend once,” Paige said conversationally. Her tone was light, dangerously so. “Back in high school. His name was Jason. He played the snare drum.”

The boy blinked, confused by the non-sequitur. “Uh. Cool?”

“He thought the same thing you do,” Paige continued. “He thought that because I love my brother, because I take care of him, that I must be desperate for an ‘out.’ He thought that if he made fun of Freddie, I would laugh along to prove I was cool.”

She stood up. She wasn’t tall, but in that moment, she looked ten feet high.

“I dumped him in front of the entire football team,” Paige said, her voice turning into steel. “Because he made one mistake. He disrespected the Unit.”

She took a step toward the boy. “Freddie isn’t weight. He’s my gravity. And you?” She looked him up and down, unimpressed. “You’re just noise.”

The boy’s smirk vanished. He looked at Paige, then at Freddie (who was watching with a look of clinical satisfaction), and finally at Jessica, who was inspecting her fingernails like she was deciding which one to use to cut his throat.

“Whatever,” the boy muttered, his ego bruised. “You’re all weirdos. Enjoy your… group therapy.”

He turned to leave, but he found his path blocked.

Dr. Thorne was standing there.

She had exited the classroom quietly, holding her stack of files. She had heard the last part of the exchange. She looked at the boy over the rim of her glasses.

“Mr. Henderson,” Dr. Thorne said. Her voice was calm, but it carried the weight of the Dean’s office.

“I was just leaving,” the boy stammered.

“You are,” Dr. Thorne agreed. “And you won’t be coming back.”

“What?”

“I heard your comment,” Dr. Thorne said. “And I observed your conduct. Harassing students in the lobby after class constitutes a violation of the safe space policy I outlined thirty minutes ago.”

She pulled a pen from her pocket and made a mark on her roster.

“I suggest you visit the registrar immediately, Mr. Henderson. You have been dropped from HPE 204. I will not have students who treat anatomy like a joke and my classroom like a pickup bar.”

The boy’s face went pale. He looked at Paige, then at the professor. He realized, too late, that he had walked into a minefield.

He fled. The double doors swung shut behind him.

Dr. Thorne watched him go, then turned to the bench. She looked at Freddie.

"The 'Jason Protocol'?" she asked, raising an eyebrow.

"It is a highly effective filter," Freddie confirmed. "It removes incompatible variables from the social circle."

"I can see that," Dr. Thorne smiled faintly. She nodded to Paige. "Good geometry."

Paige grinned, sitting back down and wrapping her arm around Freddie again. "Thanks, Doc."

"Rest up," Dr. Thorne said, walking toward her office. "Wednesday's lecture is on Physiology. It's dense."

Freddie leaned back against the wall. The lobby was quiet again. The threats—the girl, the boy—had been neutralized.

"Two for two," Jessica noted. "We are clearing the roster."

"Efficiency," Freddie whispered, closing his eyes. "Now... can we catch the bus?"

"Yeah," Paige said, squeezing him tight. "Let's go home."

Scene 6: The Safe Zone

The walk to the **CPI Transit Center** was a silent march. The adrenaline from the confrontation in the lobby was fading, replaced by the heavy, humid weight of a Virginia afternoon.

A white-and-maroon bus was already idling in the loop, its diesel engine rumbling with a deep, patient rhythm. The destination sign glowed amber: **1 FALLING BRANCH**

"That's us," Jessica said, her voice tired. "Let's get out of here."

They boarded. Freddie pulled his **PolyPass** from his pocket and held it up for the driver to see. The driver gave a quick nod of acknowledgment—a visual check, no beep, no machine. Just a flash of plastic to prove he belonged.

Jessica and Paige flashed their IDs behind him, and they moved to the back of the bus, finding a row of empty seats near the rear exit door.

Freddie slid in next to the window. Paige sat in the middle. Jessica took the aisle seat, effectively boxing them in.

As the bus hissed and pulled away from the curb, merging into the campus traffic, Paige let out a long, frustrated sigh. She slumped in her seat, crossing her arms over her chest—not to hold Freddie this time, but to hide herself.

She looked down at the navy blue t-shirt. It was tight. She knew it was tight. It was a laundry error, a remnant from high school that had accidentally made it into the college rotation. But looking at the way the fabric pulled across her chest, she felt a sudden, burning wave of resentment.

"I hate it," Paige muttered, tugging at the hem of the shirt.

"The fabric?" Freddie asked, looking at her. "Is the texture abrasive?"

"No," Paige said, shaking her head. She looked out the window at the passing stone buildings of the university. "I hate that I can't just... exist. I hate that I walk into a room to learn about anatomy, and some jerk thinks I'm there to *be* the anatomy."

She turned to Freddie. Her eyes were wet, frustrated tears gathering in the corners.

"He didn't even look at my face, Freddie. He looked at my chest. He talked to my t-shirt. It's like... it's like the rest of me didn't even matter. I was just a shape to him."

Freddie processed the data. He recalled the boy's gaze in the lobby—the vector, the smirk, the comments about "heavy lifting."

"He reduced you to geometry," Freddie stated. "He ignored the architecture."

"Exactly," Paige whispered. She wiped her eyes. "It's exhausting. Being looked at like... like meat."

Freddie wasn't looking at her chest. He never did.

And he never will. He had seen her naked—in the shower, in the King Bed—and even then, stripped of all fabric, he would not stare at her chest. He would always lock his eyes to her eyes, overriding his natural autistic urge to look away, specifically out of respect.

His eyes were focused entirely on her face, scanning her expression for data on her emotional state. His hand was resting on his own knee, tapping a slow, rhythmic pattern. He wasn't assessing her curves; he was assessing her stability.

To Freddie, she wasn't a collection of "parts." She wasn't "breasts" or "hips."

She was **Paige**. She was the Anchor. She was the person who knew how to wash his hair without getting soap in his eyes. She was the weight that stopped the world from spinning.

She was his sister.

The relief of that realization hit Paige harder than the anger. In a world full of boys who only saw what was under her shirt, Freddie was the one man who only cared about what was in her heart.

"Come here," Paige whispered.

She didn't wait for him to initiate. She leaned forward and wrapped her arms around him. It wasn't a protective hug this time; it was a seeking one. She buried her face in the hollow of his neck, breathing in the scent of his laundry detergent and the faint, metallic smell of the bus.

She pressed herself against him. Her chest was pressed against his arm, but there was no weirdness. There was no tension.

Freddie reacted instantly. He didn't pull away. He didn't get awkward. He lifted his arm and wrapped it around her shoulders, pulling her in tighter. He rested his chin on the top of her head.

"Pressure applied," Freddie murmured.

"Yeah," Paige breathed, closing her eyes. "Pressure applied."

She felt safe. She felt human. For the first time all day, she didn't feel like an object. She felt like a person who was loved.

"You are not geometry," Freddie said softly, his voice vibrating against her hair. "You are the structural integrity of the system. You are the Safe Person."

Paige squeezed him, a fierce, bone-crushing hug that poured all her gratitude into him.

"And you're mine," she whispered. "My safe person."

Jessica watched them from the aisle seat. She saw the way the other passengers on the bus glanced at them—a guy and a girl hugging intensely in the back row.

Let them look, Jessica thought. They didn't know the code. They didn't know that this wasn't romance; it was survival.

"Next stop," the automated voice announced. *"Pepper Plaza."*

Paige pulled back, but she didn't let go of his hand. She looked down at her shirt one last time, then shrugged.

"I'm burning this shirt when we get home," she decided.

"Illogical," Freddie countered, adjusting his glasses. "Cotton is a useful material. Use it for rags. Cleaning the Avalon."

Paige laughed, a real, genuine sound that chased the shadows away. "Okay. Rags it is."

The bus hissed to a halt. The doors opened. They stepped out into the sunshine of Christiansburg, leaving the predators and the geometry behind, walking toward the safety of the Base.

Scene 7: The Incorrect Variable

Newman Hall was the living room of the university. While the library was for silence and the labs were for code, Newman was for noise, food, and decompres-

sion.

Freddie sat on a low, plush sofa in the main atrium. He physically could not sit at the high-top tables near the café; the bar-stool height required a climb his spastic diplegia made dangerous, and his balance was too precarious for a seat without a back. The sofa was the only viable option.

He had the emergency brake engaged and was currently in "Recharge Mode." His legs were stretched out on the coffee table (a minor violation of etiquette he ignored). Paige sat next to him, reading a paperback. Freddie was lying with his head in her lap.

It was a public display of intimacy that most siblings abandoned in middle school. But for the Avery Unit, it was functional. The weight of her hand resting on his chest provided the necessary pressure to keep his heart rate steady in the bustling student center.

"Page turn," Freddie murmured, hearing the rustle of paper above him.

"Chapter four," Paige replied softly, tracing a pattern on his shoulder with her thumb.

A shadow fell across them.

Freddie opened his eyes. He saw a pair of designer jeans, a tight pink top, and a face that was trying very hard to look friendly. It was the girl from Monday. The one Dr. Thorne had ejected.

"Hey," she said. She didn't sound aggressive today. She sounded... rehearsed.

Freddie tensed. He felt Paige's hand stop moving on his chest.

"I didn't catch your name the other day," the girl said, shifting her weight to one hip. "I'm Krystal. With a K."

Freddie sat up slowly. He didn't want to engage, but the social contract required an acknowledgment of a direct address. He swung his legs off the table.

"Freddie," he stated.

"Freddie," Krystal repeated, testing the word like it was a flavor. "That's a nice name. Look, Freddie, I wanted to apologize. For Monday. I came on a little strong in the lobby."

She glanced at Paige, then back to Freddie. She offered a smile that didn't quite reach her eyes.

"I figured maybe we got off on the wrong foot. I wanted to see if I could buy you a coffee? There's a place right over there." She pointed to the **Espresso Bar** in the corner. "My treat. No strings attached. Just... getting to know you."

Freddie processed the offer. *Input:* Coffee. *Variable:* Caffeine causes tremors. *Variable:* Bitter taste profile. *Conclusion:* Incompatible.

"I do not drink coffee," Freddie said flatly. "It induces kinetic instability."

Krystal blinked. "Oh. Okay. Well, they have tea? Or soda?"

"I drink hot chocolate," Freddie corrected. "With whole milk. But I do not require a beverage at this time."

He turned his body away from her, rotating toward Paige. He lifted his arm and wrapped it around Paige's waist, pulling himself into her side. He buried his face in her shoulder, further engaging the "emergency brake" protocol.

It was a clear, non-verbal signal: *I am occupied. I am safe. Go away.*

Krystal watched the hug. She saw the way Freddie clung to the girl in the navy t-shirt. She saw the way the girl instinctively wrapped her arms around him, resting her chin on his head. To Krystal, this wasn't a signal of rejection. It was a signal of *dependency.*

She's good, Krystal thought, assessing Paige. *Very hands-on. Probably one of those specialized aides for the severe cases.*

"That's sweet," Krystal said, her voice dripping with a condescending kind of sympathy. "She takes good care of you, huh?"

Freddie pulled back slightly. "She is essential," he said into Paige's shirt.

"I bet," Krystal nodded. She stepped closer, lowering her voice so "the help" wouldn't hear (even though Paige was literally holding him). "But hey... does she have to be there *all* the time? I mean, surely you get some free time? When you aren't... doing therapy?"

Paige looked up. Her expression was unreadable. She tightened her grip on Freddie.

"He isn't in therapy," Paige said calmly. "He's resting."

"Right, right," Krystal waved a hand dismissively. "Resting. Look, Freddie... I'm just saying. If you ever want a break... from the routine... "

She pulled a small piece of paper from her pocket—a slip of notebook paper with a phone number written in purple gel ink. She tucked it boldly into the pocket of Freddie's orange hoodie.

"Call me," Krystal whispered. "I bet I can show you some things that aren't in your textbook."

She straightened up, waiting for a reaction. She expected a blush, a smile, or for him to push the girl away now that a "better option" was available.

Instead, Freddie stared at the slip of paper in his pocket like it was a contaminant. He looked at Paige.

"She thinks you are an employee," Freddie whispered.

"She thinks you're a project," Paige countered.

Freddie shoved the paper deeper into his pocket to hide it, then leaned back into Paige, closing his eyes again. He assumed the interaction was over.

But Krystal didn't leave.

She stood over them, hands on her hips, her posture aggressive. She watched the way Paige resumed stroking Freddie's hair—a gentle, rhythmic motion that seemed to melt the tension right out of his body. She watched the way Freddie settled deeper into her lap, turning his face inward toward her stomach, completely ignoring the "hot girl" standing right there.

It infuriated her.

"You know," Krystal said, her voice losing its sugary coating and becoming tight with genuine annoyance. "You're really possessive. It's not cute. He's a grown man, not a pet."

Paige stopped stroking Freddie's hair. She slowly lifted her gaze. She didn't look angry anymore; she looked genuinely baffled.

She studied Krystal's face—the heavy eyeliner, the plucked brows, the sheer determination to ignore reality. Then she looked down at Freddie.

They had the same dark, thick hair. They wore identical black-rimmed glasses. They had the same nose—a slightly upturned Avery trait inherited from their mother. They even had the same jawline.

To anyone paying attention, they looked like two versions of the same person.

"Are you blind?" Paige asked quietly.

Krystal blinked. "Excuse me?"

"Look at his face," Paige commanded, pointing a finger at Freddie. "Then look at mine. Really look."

Krystal frowned. She looked down at Freddie, who opened his eyes to peer up at her through his lenses. Then she looked at Paige.

She saw the eyes. Dark brown. Identical. She saw the nose. She saw the set of the mouth.

The realization hit her.

"Wait," Krystal said, taking a step back. "You guys look... alike."

"We're twins," Paige stated flatly. "Fraternal. Born twelve minutes apart."

Krystal froze. Her mind raced, processing the new data. *Twins.*

She looked at Freddie, lying comfortably across Paige's thighs. She looked at Paige's hand resting intimately on his chest. She looked at the way their bodies were pressed together on the sofa.

And then, she looked at herself. She looked at her own tight pink top, her designer jeans, the offer she had just put on the table.

She realized what had just happened. He hadn't rejected her because he had a girlfriend. He hadn't rejected her because he was busy.

He had rejected her for his *sister*.

The confusion on Krystal's face curdled into something ugly. It was the look of a merchant who realizes someone is burning money in front of them.

"You're his *sister*?" Krystal repeated, her voice rising in disbelief.

"Yes," Paige said.

Krystal gestured wildly between herself and Paige. "So... you can't... you know. You can't *do* anything with him."

"No," Paige said, her voice dropping to zero degrees Kelvin. "We can't."

"Then why did he pick *you*?" Krystal burst out, the frustration boiling over. She pointed at Freddie. "I offered you a sure thing! I offered you my room! And you're choosing to sit here and cuddle with the one girl on campus you *can't* have?"

She shook her head, looking at Freddie like he was a broken appliance.

"That is such a waste," Krystal hissed. "You're trading sex for... what? A hug? That doesn't make any sense!"

In Krystal's world, sex was the ultimate currency. To see someone trading it for mere safety felt like an insult to her entire economy.

"It makes perfect sense," Freddie said. He sat up, sliding his hand into Paige's. "I require stability. You offer transaction."

"It's gross!" Krystal snapped, pivoting to shame because logic had failed her. "It's creepy! Look at you two! Brothers and sisters don't touch like that. It looks like you're together!"

Paige stood up. She moved so fast that Krystal flinched.

Paige stepped between Freddie and Krystal. She didn't shout. She didn't scream. She spoke with the absolute, terrifying calm of a woman defending her home.

"You listen to me," Paige said softly. "You see 'gross' because your mind is in the gutter. You see 'creepy' because you can't imagine a man touching a woman without wanting something from her."

She took a step forward, forcing Krystal to retreat.

"He touches me because I am safe," Paige hissed. "He touches me because the world is loud and I am quiet. There is nothing 'sick' about it. The only thing 'sick' here is that you can't handle the fact that he picked a Safe Person over a cheap hookup."

“I am not cheap!” Krystal sputtered, her face flushing red. “And people are staring! It looks bad!”

“Let them stare,” Freddie said.

He stood up behind Paige. He placed his hand on her shoulder—not for support this time, but for solidarity. He squeezed.

“Your definition of ‘value’ is flawed,” Freddie stated. “You are dismissed.”

Krystal looked at them—the united front, the identical glasses, the unbreakable wall of the Avery Unit. She realized she couldn’t win. She couldn’t shame them because they refused to be ashamed.

“Freaks,” she muttered one last time, turning on her heel. “You deserve each other.”

She stormed off toward the exit, her heels clicking angrily on the tile.

Paige watched her go until she pushed through the doors. Then, she let out a long breath and slumped against Freddie.

“Status?” she asked.

“Status: Validated,” Freddie said. He looked down at her. “She called us freaks.”

“Yeah,” Paige shrugged, turning to hug him. “But she left. And we’re still here.”

“And we have the sofa,” Freddie added.

“And we have the sofa,” Paige agreed.

She sat back down. Freddie lay back down, putting his head right back in her lap. He closed his eyes.

“Resume regulation,” Freddie murmured.

“Resuming,” Paige whispered, running her fingers through his hair.

The noise of the student center continued around them, but in their little bubble on the sofa, the signal was clear. They were weird. They were different. But they were right.

Scene 8: The Distortion

The heavy glass doors of Newman Hall swung shut, cutting off the cool air conditioning. Krystal stepped out into the humid heat of the afternoon, her heels clicking angrily on the concrete.

She walked to the low brick wall near the entrance and dug into her purse. She pushed past her lip gloss and her ID card until her fingers brushed against the cellophane of a pack of cigarettes.

She didn't smoke. Not really. A girl from her dorm—some drama major named Ashley—had shoved the pack into her hand last week, saying, *"For when the stress gets real."*

Krystal looked at the pack. She felt ridiculous holding it. But the rage in her chest was so hot it felt like heartburn, and she needed to do something with her hands. She needed to look like she didn't care.

She fumbled with the lighter, taking three tries to get a flame. She put the white stick between her lips and inhaled, just like she'd seen in movies. **Mistake.**

The smoke hit her throat like tear gas. She gagged, doubling over as a violent coughing fit wracked her body. Her eyes watered, ruining her mascara. It tasted like burnt paper and chemicals.

"Gross," she wheezed, wiping her mouth.

She wanted to throw it away. But she didn't. She straightened up, holding the burning stick away from her body with awkward, stiff fingers. She forced herself to take a tiny, shallow puff, just to prove she could. She needed the prop. She needed to feel like the bad girl, the one who didn't care.

"Freaks," she whispered, her voice raspy from the smoke.

She replayed the scene in her head. She analyzed the data, but through the corrupted processor of her own insecurity.

She saw Freddie. He didn't stutter—that would have been too simple. It was worse. It was the way he paused, his mouth opening and closing like a fish while he searched for words that wouldn't come, only to blurt out something weird and robotic like "Variable rejected."

He had a limp. He had zero game. He was the kind of guy who should have been on his knees thanking God that a girl like Krystal even looked in his direction.

But he wasn't. He was... secure.

Why?

Because of the sister.

Krystal took another tiny, distasteful drag, narrowing her eyes as she stared at the glass doors. She thought about the way the sister (Paige) held him. The way she stroked his hair. The way she let him lay his head in her lap in the middle of the student center.

"It's sick," Krystal muttered.

But then, her mind twisted the logic to protect herself.

Freddie hadn't rejected Krystal because she wasn't attractive. That was impossible. She was hot. She knew she was hot. Her shirt was tight; her jeans were expensive. The math was on her side.

No, Freddie had rejected her because he was *forcing* his sister to fill that role.

The narrative clicked into place in Krystal's mind, dark and twisted but comforting to her bruised ego.

He's a manipulator, she thought. *He knows he can't get a real girlfriend. He knows no normal girl wants to deal with his... pausing and his walking. So he uses the sister.*

She remembered Paige's face. The defiance. The protectiveness.

To Krystal, that wasn't love. That was **Stockholm Syndrome**.

He's making her do it, Krystal decided, flicking the ash (and almost burning her thumb). *He probably plays the 'I'm disabled and lonely' card until she feels so sorry for him that she lets him treat her like a girlfriend. He's trapped her.*

A new emotion bubbled up in Krystal's chest. It wasn't just jealousy anymore. It was a twisted kind of self-righteous indignation.

She wasn't the predator. She was the *liberator*.

"That poor girl," Krystal whispered, tossing the half-smoked cigarette onto the pavement and crushing it with her heel to stop the awful smell. "She's stuck with him. She probably wants a boyfriend, but she can't because she has to babysit her creepy brother who wants to cuddle all day."

If she could get Freddie... if she could show him what *real* sex was like... maybe he would stop clinging to his sister. Maybe she could break that weird, incestuous little bubble they lived in.

She wasn't just trying to get laid anymore. She was on a crusade.

She looked at the slip of paper she'd shoved in his pocket in her mind's eye.

"Call me," she whispered to the closed doors. "Call me when you realize your sister can't give you what you actually need."

She adjusted her top, pulling it lower to maximize her geometry, and walked toward the dorms. She hadn't lost. She had just found a new angle of attack.

Inside Newman Hall, the air was cool and scrubbed clean. Freddie remained horizontal on the plush sofa, his head resting comfortably in Paige's lap.

He reached into the pocket of his orange hoodie and pulled out the slip of paper Krystal had violated his personal space with. He held it by the very corner, as if the purple gel ink were radioactive.

He didn't want to stand up. His legs were currently "offline," resting in recharge mode. He looked to his right. A large blue recycling bin sat directly next to the arm of the sofa, just within reach.

"Disposal protocol," Freddie whispered, holding the paper up to Paige.

Paige didn't look up from her book immediately. She reached down, took the slip of paper from his fingers, and leaned over the armrest to drop it into the bin.

As she leaned, her line of sight cleared the edge of the sofa and aligned perfectly with the glass wall of the atrium.

She froze.

"Ugh," Paige said, her nose scrunching up in immediate, visceral disgust.

"Status?" Freddie asked, feeling her muscles tense beneath his head.

"Visual confirmation on the glitch," Paige murmured, nodding toward the window. "She's right outside the doors. And she's smoking."

Freddie flinched. He didn't even have to smell it to feel the revulsion. Smoking was a "Class A" sensory violation. It was particulate matter. It was a chemical assault on the olfactory system. It was dirty.

"Smoke," Freddie shuddered. "Contamination."

"She looks ridiculous," Paige noted, watching Krystal cough and hack through the glass. "She doesn't even know how to hold it. She's just... polluting herself."

Freddie ran the simulation in his head. *Scenario A:* Accept Krystal's offer. Result: Exposure to smoke, erratic behavior, overwhelming sensory friction, and the chaotic unknown of sexual performance with a stranger. *Scenario B:* Remain here. Result: Clean air (scented only of Paige's detergent), deep pressure, structural stability, and absolute safety.

The choice wasn't even a choice. It was a survival instinct.

He turned his face inward, pressing his cheek directly into the soft fabric of Paige's jeans, burying his nose against her stomach to block out even the *idea* of the smoke outside. He wrapped his arm tightly around her waist, deepening the hug, anchoring himself to the only solid ground he knew.

"I have made a calculation," Freddie mumbled into her lap.

Paige looked down at him. She dropped her hand to the back of his neck, her fingers threading through his dark hair, scratching gently at the base of his skull—a stim she knew calmed him instantly.

"What's the calculation, Navigator?" she asked softly.

"I would rather spend the next fifty years holding you," Freddie stated, his voice muffled but absolute, "than spend one night engaging in friction with her."

He squeezed her waist, pulling her down slightly so he could feel the weight of her existence.

"She offers smoke," Freddie whispered. "You offer oxygen."

Paige smiled. It wasn't a triumphant smile; it was a peaceful one. She looked out the window at Krystal, who was stomping out her cigarette in frustration, and felt a wave of pity. Krystal was chasing a currency that had no value here.

Paige looked back down at her brother. She smoothed his hair, shielding his eyes from the overhead lights.

"Then stay," Paige whispered. "You can hug me for the rest of your life, Freddie. I'm not going anywhere."

"Promise?"

"Promise," Paige said. "Infinite loop. No exit condition."

Freddie let out a long, slow breath. The static in his head cleared completely.

"System optimized," he murmured.

He kept his face buried in her lap, ignoring the world, ignoring the girl outside, and focusing entirely on the perfect, stable rhythm of his sister's breathing.

Scene 9: The Contaminant

Jessica returned from the restrooms, her heavy boots making a confident *thud-thud* on the tile. She looked refreshed, having splashed cold water on her face to combat the summer humidity.

She stopped at the edge of the sofa area, assessing the scene. Freddie was still lying with his head in Paige's lap, his face pressed against her stomach. Paige was stroking his hair, her eyes fixed on the entrance with the vigilance of a sentry gun.

"Status?" Jessica asked, keeping her voice low.

"Stable," Paige reported. "We had a... perimeter breach. But we handled it."

"The girl?" Jessica guessed, noting the tension in Paige's shoulders.

"Yeah. She was persistent. Freddie shut her down. Hard."

Freddie sat up slowly. The recharge session had been effective. His vision was clear, and the static in his head had receded to a manageable background hum.

"I am operational," Freddie stated. He looked at Jessica. "Hunger levels are rising. I require caloric intake before transit."

"Agreed," Jessica said. "The main cafeteria is closed for the summer, but the **Burger Hub** counter is open. Let's grab some fries."

They stood up. Freddie adjusted his orange hoodie. He felt lighter. He had made his choice—Structure over Friction—and the universe felt orderly again.

But the universe, or at least Krystal, wasn't done with him.

The heavy glass doors opened again. Krystal stepped back inside, seeking relief from the heat and the awful taste in her mouth. She had expected to see Freddie alone, or maybe seeing the "girlfriend" leaving.

Instead, she saw *two* of them.

She saw the girl in the navy shirt (Paige) standing on his right. And now, she saw the girl in the maroon shirt (Jessica) standing on his left. They were flanking him, boxing him in, adjusting his hood and checking him over like he was a piece of precious cargo.

Krystal stopped dead. Her mind reeled.

Two of them?

She looked at Freddie—at his uneven stance, his glasses, the way he seemed to shrink between the women. In her mind, the equation shifted. He wasn't just a guy with a sister-complex. He was a hoarder.

Look at him, she thought, her lip curling. *The cripple.*

She used the word deliberately in her mind, a weapon to restore her own sense of superiority. *He can't even walk straight, and he has two women fawning over him? He must be desperate. He must be paying them. Or maybe he's playing them against each other.*

The injustice of it burned her. She was alone. She was available. And he was surrounded.

She didn't leave. She walked toward them. She had to know. She had to prove that she could break through that wall.

"Hey," Krystal called out, putting a sway in her hips that she had practiced in the mirror. "You guys still here?"

She closed the distance rapidly, stepping right into Freddie's personal bubble.

"I was thinking," Krystal said, ignoring the sisters entirely and locking her eyes on Freddie. "Maybe we start over. I'm Krystal. And I really think you and I could—"

She stopped.

Freddie had recoiled violently. He scrambled backward, colliding with Jessica. He brought his hand up to cover his nose and mouth, his eyes watering behind his glasses.

It wasn't fear. It was **Olfactory Assault**.

Krystal had smoked exactly one cigarette, and she had done it badly. The smoke hadn't blown away; it had clung to her. It was in her hair. It was in the fabric of her pink top. It was on her breath.

To a neurotypical person, she smelled like stale tobacco.

To Freddie, whose sensory processing was dialled up to maximum resolution, she smelled like a chemical fire.

"Contamination!" Freddie choked out through his hand. "Particulate matter! High concentration!"

He gagged, turning his face into Jessica's shoulder to filter the air.

Jessica smelled it too. She wrinkled her nose. "You reek," she said flatly to Krystal.

"Excuse me?" Krystal gasped, offended.

"Smoke," Paige clarified, stepping in front of Freddie. "He hates it. It makes him sick. You are a walking biohazard."

They didn't wait for Krystal to argue. They didn't explain.

"Move," Jessica commanded.

They grabbed Freddie by the arms—not gently, but with urgency. They executed a tactical retreat, steering him away from Krystal and toward the food court on the other side of the atrium.

They didn't look back. They didn't say goodbye. They just treated her like a bad smell that needed to be avoided.

Krystal stood there, stunned.

She sniffed her shirt. She couldn't smell anything (her own nose was desensitized from the smoke).

She watched them hurry away. She saw Freddie stumbling, leaning heavily on the women, hiding his face.

She didn't interpret his reaction as disgust. Her ego wouldn't allow it.

He's playing hard to get, she decided.

He didn't say no, she reasoned, twisting the logic until it broke. *He didn't tell me to go away this time. He just panicked. He's nervous. He's intimidated by me.*

She smiled, a slow, predatory curving of her lips. The "cripple" was just shy. He was overwhelmed by a real woman. And those two guard dogs were dragging him away because they knew they couldn't compete.

"Okay," Krystal whispered. "I like a chase."

The quick-service counter was located in a tiled alcove of Newman Hall. It smelled of grease and sanitizer—a familiar, safe combination.

"Atmosphere clear?" Freddie asked, slowly lowering his hand from his face.

"Clear," Jessica promised. "The air scrubbers are working. No smoke."

They stood in line. Freddie scanned the menu board. It was simple. Burgers. Chicken Tenders. Fries.

"I require a safe meal," Freddie said. "Chicken tenders. Three count. Fries. No salt on the fries if possible, but standard sodium is acceptable."

"I got it," Paige said. "Go sit. We'll bring it to you."

Freddie found a table in the corner, far away from the main walkway. He sat down, facing the wall to minimize visual input. He needed to recalibrate. The smell of the smoke lingered in his memory file like a corrupted sector.

Paige and Jessica brought the tray a moment later. Three baskets of chicken tenders and a mountain of fries.

"Fuel," Jessica said, sliding a soda toward him.

They ate in silence for a few minutes. Freddie dipped a fry in ketchup, focusing on the texture. *Crispy outside. Soft inside. Predictable.*

"She is watching," Paige murmured, not looking up from her food.

"Where?" Jessica asked, biting into a tender.

"Six o'clock. By the ATM."

Freddie didn't turn around. He didn't need to. He could feel the weight of the gaze on his back.

Krystal was leaning against the ATM machine fifty feet away. She wasn't approaching. She was just... hovering. She was pretending to look at her phone (a silver flip-phone), but every few seconds, her eyes flicked over to their table.

She was stalking them.

"She is persistent," Freddie noted, chewing mechanically.

"She's delusional," Jessica corrected. "She thinks this is a game. She thinks she has a chance."

"Does she not understand the sibling protocol?" Freddie asked. "We established the genetic link."

"She doesn't care about the link," Paige said darkly. "She thinks you're a prize she can win if she just waits long enough for us to leave."

Freddie reached out and took Paige's hand. He squeezed it.

"Then she will wait forever," Freddie said. "Because you are not leaving."

"Damn straight," Jessica said, dipping a fry in Freddie's ketchup pile. "Eat up. We have a bus to catch. And if she tries to follow us onto Route 1, I'm going to introduce her to the concept of a restraining order."

They finished their meal under the watchful, hungry eyes of the girl who thought she could fix him, unaware that he was already whole.

Scene 10: The Humidity Index

The automatic doors of **Newman Hall** slid open, and the atmosphere changed instantly.

Inside, the air had been cool, filtered, and sane. Outside, the **New River Valley** in July was a physical assault. The heat wasn't dry; it was a heavy, wet blanket of humidity that wrapped around them the second they stepped onto the pavement.

"Thermal shock," Freddie gasped, stopping immediately to adjust his breathing. "The air density has increased."

"It's a sauna," Jessica agreed, wiping a bead of sweat from her forehead. "Welcome to Blacksburg in the summer. It's 90 degrees and the air is soup."

They stood on the edge of **Alumni Mall**, the broad avenue that ran through the heart of campus. Across the street, the bus shelter waited. It was only fifty feet away, but in this heat, it looked like a mirage.

Behind them, inside the cool safety of the glass doors, Krystal watched them go.

She stood by the recycling bin, her arms crossed. She watched the way the sisters flanked Freddie, shielding him from the crowd, checking on him as the heat hit. She watched the way he leaned into them, trusting them completely.

She looked down at her purse. The pack of cigarettes poked out of the side pocket.

She pulled it out. She looked at the white box. It hadn't made her look cool. It hadn't made her look mysterious. It had just made her smell like an ashtray and caused the guy she wanted to look at her like she was a biological weapon.

"Useless," Krystal muttered.

She tossed the pack into the trash can with a heavy *thunk*. She didn't need props. She needed a new strategy. She turned and walked toward the elevators to her dorm, leaving the Avery unit to the heat.

"Movement is required," Freddie stated, peeling his shirt away from his chest. "If we remain stationary, we will melt."

"Bus is coming," Paige said, pointing down the mall.

The white-and-maroon **Blue Ridge Transit** bus turned the corner, its large windshield reflecting the harsh sun. The destination sign flickered in the heat waves:

1 FALLING BRANCH

"Route 1," Jessica confirmed. "Straight shot down 460. AC included."

They crossed the street, moving quickly to minimize exposure to the sun. By the time they reached the shelter, Freddie felt a trickle of sweat running down his

back under the orange hoodie. He hated the sensation—it was wet, unpredictable, and overstimulating.

The bus hissed to a halt. The doors opened, releasing a blast of refrigerated air that felt like a blessing.

"PolyPasses," Jessica reminded them.

They boarded. Freddie flashed his ID card at the operator. The driver nodded, too hot and tired to care about inspecting the expiration date.

They moved to the back. Freddie took the window seat on the shady side of the bus. He pressed his face against the cold glass, letting the chill seep into his cheek.

"System cooling," Freddie whispered.

"Yeah," Paige sighed, sitting next to him and blowing a strand of hair out of her face. "That was awful. I felt like I was swimming."

The bus rumbled forward, turning onto Main Street and then merging onto **Business 460**.

The ride to Christiansburg was a thirty-minute decompression chamber. They watched the campus fade away, replaced by the rolling green hills and the commercial strip of the highway.

Freddie watched the landmarks pass: the car dealerships, the fast-food signs, the slow transition from "University Town" to "Real World."

He didn't think about Krystal. He didn't think about the cigarette smoke. He thought about the math of the bus schedule. Every **15 minutes**, a pulse. High frequency. Low latency. Predictable. Reliable.

"Approaching **Pepper Plaza**," the automated voice announced.

The bus slowed, turning off the road and navigating into the sawtooth bays of the transit center in Christiansburg.

They stepped off the bus. The heat in Christiansburg was just as bad as Blacksburg, but here, it was manageable because safety was visible.

Directly across the street sat **105 Pepper Street**. The white siding gleamed in the sun. The windows were dark, signaling that the blackout curtains were doing their job.

"Home," Freddie said.

They waited for a break in traffic and crossed the street diagonally. Jessica unlocked the front door.

They stepped inside. The air conditioner hit them. The smell of lemon polish greeted them.

"Door locked," Jessica said, throwing the deadbolt.

Freddie unzipped his orange hoodie. He was sweaty, tired, and socially drained. But he was home.

"Shower protocol?" Paige asked, kicking off her sneakers.

"Affirmative," Freddie said. "Then... the Silo?"

"Then the Silo," Paige promised. "We have a textbook to read."

Freddie smiled. He didn't want Krystal's dorm room. He didn't want the friction. He wanted this. The cool air, the locked door, and the family that knew exactly how to keep the static away.

The Admin Console

Scene 1: The Cool Down

The **Blue Ridge Transit** bus hissed to a halt in the sawtooth bay of **Pepper Plaza**. The doors folded open, and the Avery unit stepped out onto the concrete.

The heat in Christiansburg was just as aggressive as it had been in Blacksburg. The air was heavy, thick with moisture and the smell of asphalt baking in the sun.

"Home," Jessica announced, pointing diagonally across the street.

They waited for a break in the traffic on First Street, then crossed quickly to the sanctuary of **105 Pepper Street**.

Jessica unlocked the front door. They stumbled inside, the air conditioning hitting them like a blessing. The hum of the window unit was the best sound Freddie had heard all day.

"Locking," Jessica said, throwing the deadbolt and engaging the security chain.

"Decontamination," Paige gasped, pulling her sticky t-shirt away from her skin. "I feel gross. The humidity is... excessive."

"Agreed," Freddie said, leaning against the wall to kick off his sneakers. "Thermal regulation is required immediately."

They moved as a unit down the hallway to the Master Bedroom—the **Silo**.

There was no hesitation. The "Modesty Protocol" had been deleted days ago. In this heat, and after the stress of the encounter at Newman Hall, clothes were just another layer of friction.

Freddie peeled off his orange hoodie, which felt heavy and suffocating. He dropped it into the hamper. His jeans followed.

Paige and Jessica did the same, shedding their sweat-dampened clothes with sighs of relief.

"Tub," Jessica commanded. "Cool water. Not cold. Just cool."

They walked into the bathroom. The clear curtain was pulled back. Jessica reached in and turned the tap. She adjusted the mix until the water running over her wrist was a refreshing, tepid temperature—perfect for bringing down a core body temperature without shocking the system.

"Ready, Freddie?" Paige asked.

"Ready," Freddie said.

His legs were trembling from the exertion of the day. The spasticity was flaring up due to the heat. He couldn't lift his leg high enough to clear the porcelain rim on his own.

He didn't have to ask. Jessica took his left arm; Paige took his right. They braced themselves, their skin slick against his.

"Up," Jessica counted. "And over."

They managed the transfer with the efficiency of a pit crew. Freddie slid down into the water. He let out a long, groaning exhale as the cool liquid surrounded him, sapping the heat from his tired muscles.

"Better?" Paige asked, kneeling on the bathmat.

"System cooling," Freddie murmured, closing his eyes. "Operating temperature normalizing."

Jessica stepped into the tub behind him, sitting on the edge to let her feet soak, grabbing the sponge. Paige knelt beside the tub, taking the soap.

They began to wash him. It wasn't a frantic scrub; it was a rhythmic, calming maintenance routine. Paige soaped his arms, her hands firm and sure. Jessica squeezed the sponge over his shoulders, letting the water cascade down his back.

Freddie opened his eyes. He looked at his sisters. He saw them clearly—no clothes, no barriers, just skin and care.

And suddenly, he started to laugh.

It wasn't a nervous laugh. It was a genuine, bubbling chuckle that shook his shoulders and made the water ripple.

Paige paused, the soap hovering over his elbow. "What? What's funny?"

"Krystal," Freddie wheezed, a smile breaking across his face.

"What about her?" Jessica asked, wringing out the sponge.

"I am running a simulation," Freddie said, looking from Jessica to Paige. "I am imagining Krystal standing in this doorway right now."

He gestured to the scene: him, naked in the tub; his sisters, naked and washing him.

"She believed you were aides," Freddie explained. "Hired staff. Employees."

"Right," Jessica scoffed. "The 'Help'."

"If you were 'The Help'," Freddie continued, his logic engine finding the humor in the absurdity, "this scenario would be a violation of Occupational Safety and Health Administration protocols. Aides remain clothed. Aides wear gloves. Aides wash with clinical detachment."

He looked at Paige's hand resting gently on his chest.

"Aides do not provide... this. This is not clinical. This is structural."

Paige giggled. She imagined the look on Krystal's face—the absolute, brain-melting confusion she would experience if she saw them right now.

"She would explode," Paige laughed. "Her brain wouldn't be able to process it. She'd probably call the police."

"Or she would think it was an orgy," Jessica added dryly, pouring water over Freddie's hair. "Because her database only has two folders: 'Professional' and 'Sexual.' She doesn't have a folder for 'Family.' "

"She lacks the source code," Freddie agreed. "She cannot compile the file."

The three of them laughed together, the sound bouncing off the tiled walls. It was a victory laugh. They had taken the thing Krystal tried to make weird—their closeness, their intimacy—and they had reclaimed it.

"Well," Jessica said, wiping a bubble of soap from Freddie's nose. "She is never going to find out. Because she is never setting foot in this house."

"Banned," Freddie stated firmly. "Blacklisted."

"Added to the firewall," Paige agreed. "List of Banned Entities: 1. Robert. 2. Krystal."

"Security level: Maximum," Jessica confirmed. "No unauthorized packets allowed."

She rinsed Freddie's back one last time. "Okay, Navigator. You're clean. And you're cool. Let's get dried off and get in the bed. I think we earned a nap."

"Affirmative," Freddie said, reaching for the towel.

He felt clean. Not just from the soap, but from the laughter. The static was gone. The heat was gone.

He was in the Base, and the perimeter was secure.

Scene 2: The Signal

The decontamination process was a staged operation. Freddie was clean, cool, and dressed in a fresh pair of soft grey lounge pants and a white undershirt.

They had established a temporary base camp in the living room while the bathroom was occupied. The **MagnaView** TV was the focal point.

"Rotation protocol," Jessica announced, grabbing her towel. "I'm taking the first shift in the shower to wash my hair. Paige, you hold the perimeter."

"Copy," Paige said. She was wearing a loose t-shirt and panties—her "at-home" uniform—sitting next to Freddie on the beige sofa. "We aren't going anywhere."

Jessica disappeared into the hallway. A moment later, the sound of the shower started again—a distant, white-noise hiss behind the closed door.

Freddie held the remote control. He aimed it at the TV. He wasn't looking for news (too much friction) or cartoons (too loud). He needed something stable.

He cycled through the channels. *Static. News. Soap Opera. Static.*

He landed on **Channel 11**, a local independent station known as **WNRV**. In the afternoons, WNRV didn't play trashy talk shows. They played "The Classics."

The screen flickered. A logo appeared: a radio tower transmitting lightning bolts over a city skyline.

Title Card: **"W-JAM in Philly"**

Freddie had never seen this show before. The date on the screen said **1978**.

Then, the music started.

It wasn't a jarring orchestral blast like the graduation song. It was a soft, rhythmic piano melody, joined quickly by a smooth, melodic bass line.

A singer with a warm, raspy voice began to croon. It sounded like a friend talking to you across a table in a diner.

"Baby... if you're listenin' to the wind... "

Freddie stopped breathing for a second. The sound wasn't just audio; it was a texture. It was like velvet. It was warm, analog, and perfectly balanced.

"... and you're lookin' for a place to fit on in... "

He watched the opening montage. He saw a man with a mustache running a soundboard. He saw a blonde woman smiling at a receptionist's desk. He saw a guy in sunglasses pointing coolly at a microphone.

"... just turn that dial to the right, and let the music light the night... "

Freddie lowered the remote. He didn't change the channel. He stared at the screen, mesmerized.

"Status?" Paige asked, noticing his stillness.

"The audio profile," Freddie whispered, not looking away. "It is... welcoming. It lacks aggression."

"W-JAM... we're livin' on the air in Philly..."

The song ended on a gentle fade-out that felt like a hug.

"What is this?" Freddie asked.

"I think it's **W-JAM**," Paige said, reading the screen. "It's an old sitcom about a radio station."

"A radio station," Freddie repeated. "An audio transmission hub."

He liked the concept immediately. A radio station was a system. It had transmitters. It had frequencies. It had a control board with buttons and sliders.

The show started. The scene opened in the broadcast booth. The DJ—the guy in sunglasses—was queuing up a vinyl record. He moved with a practiced, rhythmic efficiency that Freddie recognized.

He is operating the machine, Freddie thought. *He is the Admin of the airwaves.*

The door to the hallway opened. Jessica walked in, drying her hair with a towel. She was wearing a fresh t-shirt and shorts, looking scrubbed and pink from the heat of the shower.

"All clear," Jessica said. "Water pressure is nominal. Paige, you're up."

"Roger," Paige said, standing up. "Freddie found a new show. It's about radio."

Jessica walked over and sat in Paige's spot, instantly re-establishing the contact pressure against Freddie's side. She looked at the TV.

"Oh, **W-JAM**," Jessica smiled. "Dad used to hate this show. He said the DJs had too much hair."

"Dad was incorrect," Freddie stated, watching the DJ slide a fader up. "The hair density is irrelevant. The signal quality is the primary variable."

"Fair point," Jessica agreed, wrapping the towel around her wet hair. "Is it funny?"

"I do not know yet," Freddie admitted. "But the theme song... it felt like the King Bed."

Jessica looked at him. That was the highest praise in the Avery dictionary.

"Warm?" she asked.

"Warm," Freddie confirmed. "And safe."

Paige grabbed her towel. "Okay, I'm going in. Don't let him change the channel. We need to see if the blonde receptionist runs the place."

"Hypothesis: She is the true Matriarch," Freddie predicted.

"Likely," Jessica nodded.

As Paige went to shower, Freddie settled back into the cushion, pressing his shoulder against Jessica. On the screen, the chaotic, funny, and warm world of the fictional radio station unfolded.

For the first time all day, Freddie wasn't analyzing threats or dodging smoke. He was just watching a system that worked.

"I will add this to the scheduled recordings," Freddie decided. "Daily at 16:00."

"Adding to the queue," Jessica said, reaching for the popcorn bowl. "Welcome to the playlist, W-JAM."

The credits for *W-JAM in Philly* rolled, the funky bass line fading into a commercial for a local car dealership (Holt Automotive).

Freddie remained rooted to the spot. The warm feeling from the first show lingered, a sense of having witnessed a functional system.

"Channel hold," Freddie instructed. "Do not switch inputs."

"Holding," Jessica confirmed, crunching a piece of popcorn. She was still in her post-shower towel turban, relaxed and pink-cheeked.

The screen flickered. The station ID for **WNRV** played. Then, a new show began.

It didn't start with a high-energy montage. It started with a slow, sepia-toned slide show of old city streets—cobblestones, gas lamps, and people in bowler hats.

Then, a piano began to play.

It wasn't funky. It was... melancholic. But hopeful.

A gentle, male voice began to sing.

"Making your way in the world today takes everything you've got..."

Freddie felt a tightness in his chest loosen. The lyrics resonated instantly. He knew what it took to make his way in the world—it took structure, it took admins, it took energy he didn't always have.

"Taking a break from all your worries, sure would help a lot..."

"True," Freddie whispered.

"Wouldn't you like to get away?"

The chorus hit, and the energy lifted. It wasn't loud; it was an invitation.

"Sometimes you want to go..."

"Where everybody knows your name..."

Freddie's eyes widened. That was the core desire. Not to be famous, but to be *known*. To walk into a room and not be a glitch. To be a recognized user with full permissions.

"And they're always glad you came. . . "

The title card appeared over a shot of a cozy, basement-level pub with stained glass windows:

THE LOCAL

"What is this?" Freddie asked, entranced.

"It's **The Local**," Jessica said, smiling fondly. "It's about a bar in Boston. The owner is an ex-baseball player for the **Beacons**."

The show started. A tall man with great hair stood behind the bar, polishing a glass. The door opened. A heavy-set man walked in.

"Norm!" the entire bar shouted in unison.

Freddie sat up straight. "They. . . acknowledged him."

"It's the ritual," Jessica explained. "Every time he enters, the system recognizes him. Immediate validation."

"Norm," Freddie whispered, testing the sound. "It is a login script."

The door to the hallway opened. Paige walked in. She was clean, dressed in soft shorts and a tank top, her hair damp and smelling of apple shampoo.

"Decontamination complete," Paige announced. She saw Freddie staring at the screen. "Another one?"

"It is called **The Local**," Freddie said, not looking away. "The primary variable is community. They know the names."

Paige walked over and sat on Freddie's other side, completing the formation on the beige sofa. She leaned her head on his shoulder.

"Do you like it?" she asked.

"The theme song," Freddie said, his voice quiet. "It describes a sanctuary. A place where the social mask is not required."

"You want to go where people know, people are all the same. . . " the song finished on the TV. *"You want to go where everybody knows your name."*

"That's what this is," Paige whispered, squeezing his arm. "Here. 105 Pepper Street. We know your name, Freddie."

"And we're always glad you came," Jessica added, poking his ribs gently.

Freddie looked at the TV, where the characters were bickering affectionately. He looked at his sisters, clean and safe in their fortress.

He realized that **The Local** wasn't just a bar on TV. It was a blueprint for what they were building right here.

"I will add this to the recording schedule," Freddie decided firmly. "Daily at 16:30. It is... essential viewing."

"Double feature," Jessica agreed. "W-JAM and The Local. The Avery Afternoon Block."

As the show continued, Freddie didn't just stay seated. He shifted, sliding down until he was horizontal again, swinging his legs up onto the sofa. He laid his head back down in Paige's lap, exactly as he had done at Newman Hall.

But this time, there was no smoke. There was no Krystal. There was no sweat or gritty humidity.

There was only the scent of apple shampoo, the cool air of the silent house, and the rhythmic, grounding motion of Paige's hand resuming its place in his hair.

The heat outside, the confusion of the day, the friction of the world—it all felt very far away. Here, in the cool light of the TV, listening to the laughter of the bar where everyone belonged, Freddie closed his eyes for a moment.

He was in the Safe Zone. He was with the people who knew his name. And that was all he needed.

Scene 3: The Final Frontier

The afternoon sun was still blazing outside, but inside **105 Pepper Street**, the blackout curtains held the line. The living room was a cool, dim sanctuary illuminated only by the glow of the MagnaView TV.

"News block initiated," Jessica announced. "Prepare for local intake."

The screen shifted to the familiar blue-and-gold graphics of **WNRV-TV Channel 11**.

The broadcast began with **"Valley News Tonight"**. Freddie tolerated the 5:00 PM and 5:30 PM segments—mostly traffic reports on I-81 and weather updates confirming the oppressive humidity—but he perked up for the flagship **6:00 PM Broadcast**.

The anchor, a man with silver hair and a voice like gravel, read the headlines with comforting predictability. There were no surprises. Just facts.

"National news at 6:30," Paige noted, handing Freddie a bowl of grapes. "Do you want to watch the national feed?"

"Negative," Freddie decided. "Global variables are too volatile. Stick to the local signal."

At 7:00 PM, the tone of the evening shifted. The news desk was replaced by a brightly colored set filled with flashing lights and a giant, glittering wheel.

Freddie watched as three contestants spun the heavy wheel, the clicking sound—*tik-tik-tik-tik*—providing a satisfying auditory stim.

"R," a contestant shouted. "Is there an R?"

Ding!

"Variable confirmed," Freddie whispered, popping a grape into his mouth. He liked this show. It was just pattern matching. He was faster than the contestants. He saw the fragments of the letters and the logic engine in his head filled in the blanks instantly.

"Walking on Sunshine," Freddie blurted out before the lady on screen even spun the wheel.

"Show-off," Jessica grinned.

At 7:30 PM, the smart show started.

At 7:30 PM, the tone shifted from luck to logic. **The Daily Quiz** began.

This was serious business. The three of them sat forward, slices of pizza forgotten, competing for the title of "Living Room Champion."

"History for 400," the host announced. "The treaty that ended World War I." "What is the Treaty of Versailles?" Jessica shouted. "Correct," the host said.

"Science for 600." "The process by which plants use sunlight to synthesize foods." "What is... Photosynthesis?" Freddie guessed. "Correct."

Then came the visual clue. An image of a brass instrument with mirrors and an arc appeared on the blue screen. "Navigation for 800," the host read. "This doubly reflecting navigation instrument measures the angular distance between two visible objects."

"Sextant," Freddie corrected instantly. "Navigation tool."

"WRONG!" Jessica shouted, pointing a pizza crust at him like a gavel. "Error! Syntax error!"

Freddie blinked, looking at her. "The identification is accurate. It is a sextant."

"Phrasing, Freddie!" Paige laughed, nudging his ribs. "You have to format the data!"

"Oh," Freddie realized. The arbitrary rule of the game show. The social contract of the quiz. He sighed, adjusting his glasses. "What is a sextant?"

"That is correct," the host on the TV said.

"Point restored," Jessica declared, taking a bite of her crust. "But you're on thin ice, mister. Respect the format."

Freddie allowed a tiny smile. He liked the format. Even if the rule was silly, it was a rule. And in this house, rules were followed.

Then, the game shows ended. The screen went black for a moment.

"Okay," Jessica said, checking the TV Guide. "Channel 11 is running a double feature of that sci-fi show. **'Stellar Voyage: The New Era'**. You want to try it?"

"Genre?" Freddie asked.

"Space," Paige said. "Exploration. Dad said it was boring, but..."

"Dad is an unreliable narrator," Freddie corrected. "Proceed."

The screen lit up.

It began with a field of stars. Just blackness and pinpricks of light, moving slowly, majestically.

Then, the voice spoke. It was a deep, resonant baritone—the voice of a Captain.

"Space... The infinite expanse."

Freddie stopped chewing his grape.

"These are the voyages of the Starship Avalon. Its continuing mission: to explore strange new worlds. To seek out new life and new civilizations."

The music swelled—an orchestral fanfare of French horns and strings that felt like a sunrise. It wasn't cheesy; it was noble. It was soaring.

"To boldly go where no one has gone before."

A massive, sleek silver ship swept across the screen, its warp engines glowing a soft, pulsating blue. It didn't look like a machine of war. It looked like a machine of *science*.

Freddie sat up, pulling himself out of Paige's lap for the first time in hours. He leaned toward the screen, his eyes wide behind his glasses.

"The music," Freddie whispered. "It sounds like... hope."

The episode started. It wasn't about shooting lasers. It was about diplomacy. It was about a crew of hyper-competent officers solving a complex astrophysical puzzle involving a binary star system.

Freddie watched **Captain Miller** sit in his chair and ask for "Input." He watched **Commander Stone** execute a maneuver. He watched **Unit 7** analyze the situation without emotion, purely on logic.

"He is like me," Freddie pointed at the synthetic officer. "He processes data. He does not understand the joke."

"Yeah," Paige smiled softy. "He is like you."

But it was the **Main Engineering** set that captivated him. The Master Systems Display—a giant, backlit wall of schematics showing the energy flow of the entire ship. The interface was clean, organized, and perfectly logical.

"Look at the interface," Freddie breathed. "It is a perfect structure. Everything is labeled."

By the time the second episode started at 8:30 PM, Freddie was gone. He wasn't in the living room anymore. He was on the bridge of the *Avalon*.

"Astronomy," Freddie announced during the commercial break.

"What?" Jessica asked.

"The field of study," Freddie clarified. "It is the study of the ultimate system. Stars. Orbits. Gravity. It is all math. It is all predictable."

He looked at his sisters.

"I require books on astronomy. And I require a website update."

"A website update?" Paige asked.

"The portfolio," Freddie said, his mind racing faster than the warp drive on screen. "We are building a digital archive. It should be modeled after the *Avalon* computer. Dark background. Glowing text. Structured data."

"An astronomical theme," Jessica mused. "RaggieSoft... in space."

"Affirmative," Freddie said, turning back to the screen as the theme song swelled again. "Space. The final frontier."

He watched the ship streak into warp speed, a streak of light against the darkness. For a boy who spent his whole life feeling gravity hold him down, looking up at the stars felt like the first time he could truly fly.

Scene 4: The System Architecture

The double feature of *Stellar Voyage: The New Era* was halfway through its second episode. The living room at **105 Pepper Street** was pitch black, save for the cool, flickering blue light of the MagnaView screen.

Freddie was no longer leaning back in the "Safe Harbor" position. He was sitting on the edge of the beige sofa, his body tense with focus, a notepad and pen in his hands—tools he usually reserved for lecture halls.

He wasn't taking notes on the plot. He didn't care that the Romulan-analogue aliens were threatening the Neutral Zone. He was taking notes on the *interface*.

On the screen, **Officer Echo** (the pale-skinned android operations officer) tapped a console. The screen displayed a massive, beautiful schematic of the ship's warp core. It wasn't cluttered. It was a masterpiece of information design: a stark

black background, glowing amber curves for data streams, and crisp, legible purple text for labels.

"It is moving too fast," Freddie hissed, his eyes darting across the screen. "I cannot capture the hierarchy before the camera cuts away."

"Memorize the shape," Jessica advised, watching him panic slightly. "Don't try to read the text. Just get the structure."

Freddie stared unblinking at the screen, burning the image into his retinas.

"Stark background," he muttered, sketching frantically. "Amber data streams. Purple labels. No bevels. Pure geometry."

The camera cut away to Captain Miller's face.

"Signal lost," Freddie sighed, dropping his pen. He looked down at his crude drawing. He had managed to capture the signature "header rail"—the sweeping curve that contained the navigation buttons on the left side of the screen.

"It optimizes screen real estate," Freddie whispered, tracing the curve on his paper. "Top-level navigation is curved. Sub-menus are linear. It is efficient. There are no wasted pixels. Just data."

"It looks cool," Paige agreed, squinting at the TV. "Very... futuristic."

"I require this aesthetic," Freddie murmured. "When I construct the archive... when I build the portfolio... it must look like this. Dark mode. High contrast. Logical grouping."

"You want your website to look like a starship computer?" Jessica asked.

"I want my life to function like a starship computer," Freddie replied. "Predictable. Color-coded. Alert status indicators."

He pointed at the android on the screen. "And he understands the code. He does not guess."

The episode continued. The ship warped away, leaving a trail of light across the starfield.

As the credits rolled at 9:00 PM, the house was silent again. But Freddie's mind was loud—not with static, but with calculation.

"Future variable analysis," Freddie announced suddenly, capping his pen.

"What variable?" Paige asked, stretching her arms over her head.

"The Spring 2004 schedule," Freddie said. "Our Fall 2003 classes are locked. We are registered for the Introduction to Programming logic. But for Spring... I will require a Laboratory Science credit."

Jessica groaned, rubbing her temples. "Don't remind me. I pushed my science elective off until Spring of my Junior year because I didn't want to deal with it. I was going to register for Biology. Dissecting frogs. It's going to be gross."

Freddie shuddered visibly. “Biology is wet. It involves fluids and unpredictable organic textures. I do not wish to engage with amphibian internal organs.”

He gestured toward the TV, which was now showing a commercial, but the image of the stars was still burned into his mind.

“Astronomy,” Freddie stated. “Course Code: **PHY 102**.”

The sisters looked at him.

“Astronomy?” Jessica repeated. “Instead of Bio?”

“It is the study of systems on a macro scale,” Freddie explained, his hands moving to shape the air. “Orbits are mathematical loops. Gravity is a constant variable. Stars are just fusion reactors with predictable life cycles.”

He looked at the notepad, where he had drawn a small Saturn-like ringed planet in the corner.

“And the labs,” Freddie added, a hopeful note entering his voice. “Astronomy labs occur at night. In the dark. While looking through telescopes. It is quiet. It is solitary.”

“That actually sounds perfect,” Paige realized, looking at Jessica. “No bright lights. No loud noises. Just us and the math. And since Freddie and I are taking all our Gen-Eds together anyway. . . ”

“We could all take it,” Jessica finished the thought. “I still need the credit. You guys need the credit. We could register for the same section.”

“The Avery Unit in space,” Freddie said softly.

Jessica smiled. The idea of spending a semester looking at stars instead of cutting open dead frogs was infinitely more appealing.

“Okay, Captain,” Jessica agreed. “Mental note made. When Spring registration opens in October, we are all signing up for PHY 102. No frogs. Just stars.”

Freddie stood up. He felt tired, but it was a good tired. The day had been full of friction—Krystal, the smoke, the heat—but he had neutralized the threats. He had his Safe People. He had a mission. And now, he had a destination.

“Course laid in,” Freddie whispered to himself. “Engage.”

Scene 5: The Sandwich Configuration

The credits of the sci-fi show faded, leaving the room in silence. The blue light of the TV vanished as Jessica pressed the power button, plunging the living room into total darkness.

“System shutdown,” Jessica announced softly. “Time to dock.”

They moved through the hallway, guided by the muscle memory of the house layout. They entered the Master Bedroom—**The Silo**.

It was pitch black. The blackout curtains were drawn tight, sealing out the streetlights of Pepper Plaza. The only light came from the small red digits of the alarm clock: **21:12**.

"Alarm is set for 06:30," Paige whispered. "That gives us plenty of time to catch the 08:00 bus."

Freddie stood by the edge of the massive King Bed. He felt a flutter of static in his chest—not the bad kind, but the vibrating hum of anticipation.

"Tomorrow," Freddie said, his voice cutting through the dark. "The Specialist."

"Dr. Arrington," Jessica confirmed. "10:00 AM."

"He holds the Manual," Freddie stated. "Tomorrow, we verify the operating system. We confirm the diagnosis."

"We already know the diagnosis, Freddie," Paige said gently, pulling back the duvet. "We know who you are."

"I suspect," Freddie corrected. "I require official documentation. I require the label. A system cannot be optimized if the specifications are unknown."

"Well," Jessica said, "tomorrow we get the specs. But tonight, we recharge."

They stripped off the light lounge clothes they had worn for the evening. In the sanctuary of the Silo, clothing was unnecessary friction. It was just another texture to get tangled, another seam to press against skin.

They climbed into the bed.

The configuration was non-negotiable. It was the only way the Avery Unit could sleep effectively.

The Sandwich Configuration:

- **Left Flank:** Jessica. The oldest. The Shield. She took the side closest to the door, placing herself between the world and her family.
- **Right Flank:** Paige. The Anchor. She took the side closest to the wall, creating a soft, immovable boundary.
- **The Core:** Freddie.

He climbed into the middle. The mattress dipped slightly under their combined weight, creating a gravity well that pulled them together.

He lay on his back. To his left, he felt the warmth of Jessica's arm against his. To his right, Paige shifted, pressing her side against his ribs.

There was no space between them. They were packed tight, skin against skin, creating a continuous feedback loop of pressure and heat.

"Pressure check?" Jessica asked from the darkness.

"Optimal," Freddie breathed.

He felt the weight of the heavy duvet settle over them. Even in the summer heat, the AC was cranked low enough to justify the weight. Freddie needed the weight. It held his legs down. It stopped the involuntary twitches.

He closed his eyes.

He thought about the stars on the TV screen. He thought about the clean, logical interface of the starship *Avalon*. And he thought about tomorrow.

For twenty years, he had felt like he was running the wrong software. He had felt like a glitch. Tomorrow, a man in a white coat was going to look at him and tell him that he wasn't broken—he was just a different model.

"Goodnight, Captain," Paige whispered, draping her arm over his chest to lock him in.

"Goodnight, Navigator," Freddie murmured.

"Goodnight, Shield," he added to Jessica.

"Night, little brother," Jessica said.

The silence of the house wrapped around them. Secure in the center of the bed, held in place by the only two people in the universe who spoke his language, Freddie Avery let the system enter Sleep Mode.

One day ended. The next—the day he would finally get his name—was waiting in the queue.

Autism Diagnosis

Scene 1: The Debugger

The waiting room of **Dr. Arrington's** office was located in a quiet brick building off North Main Street in Blacksburg. It felt less like a clinic and more like a professor's study, which helped lower the ambient threat level.

The floor was carpeted in a muted blue that absorbed the sound of footsteps. A small fountain in the corner provided a constant, rhythmic *trickle-splash-trickle*—white noise for the soul.

Freddie sat in the corner chair. He was wearing his "Standard Uniform": loose-fitting jeans and a soft grey t-shirt with no tags.

On his right sat Paige. She was his mirror. She wore an almost identical grey t-shirt, her leg pressed firmly against his to provide a constant stream of tactile data.

On his left sat Jessica. She wore a long-sleeved forest green top—the color of the mountains, the color of stability. She held the clipboard with the intake forms.

"Question 4," Jessica read softly. "Does the patient experience distress during changes in routine?"

Freddie looked at the fountain. He thought about the time his father tried to trade the family's Holt Club Wagon for a sedan without a family meeting.

"Distress is... inaccurate," Freddie corrected. "It is a fatal error. The system hangs."

"Checking 'Severe'," Jessica murmured, marking the box. "Question 5: Does the patient have difficulty interpreting non-verbal cues?"

Paige squeezed Freddie's knee. "Remember when Heidi told you to 'break a leg' before the concert, and you asked her which bone?"

"It was a valid query," Freddie defended. "The tibia is the most structurally sound choice."

"Checking 'Yes'," Jessica said.

She flipped to the back page. "Okay, last part. **HIPAA Authorization**. Who is allowed to access your medical records and discuss your care?"

"The Admin Team," Freddie stated immediately.

"I need names, Freddie," Jessica smiled.

"Paige Avery," Freddie listed. "Jessica Avery. And Ellen Avery."

"Mom?" Paige asked softly.

"She is the primary source of genetic code," Freddie said. "She requires read-only access."

Jessica wrote the names down and signed the witness line. Just as she finished, the heavy oak door to the inner office opened.

A man stood there wearing a tweed jacket with patches on the elbows. He held a mug of tea and looked kind, but tired.

"Freddie Avery?" he called out. His voice was gravelly but soft.

Freddie stood up. Paige and Jessica rose with him, forming a wall.

"I'm Dr. Arrington," the man said. He looked at the three of them. "I usually only take one support person back with the patient. The room is a bit small."

Freddie froze. Separation anxiety spiked. He looked at Jessica.

"Go," Jessica said firmly, handing the clipboard to Paige. "I'll hold down the fort out here. Paige is the Primary Anchor today."

"Protocol accepted," Freddie whispered.

Paige took Freddie's hand. "Come on, Architect. Let's go see the wizard."

Scene 2: Operating Systems

Dr. Arrington's office was lined with bookshelves stuffed with medical texts and psychology journals. There was a leather couch and two armchairs. On his desk sat a beige Quantum workstation with a bulky CRT monitor that hummed with a high-pitched frequency only Freddie seemed to hear.

Freddie sat on the leather couch. Paige sat right next to him, her shoulder pressed into his.

"So," Dr. Arrington started, sitting in his armchair and crossing his legs. "The referral says you suspect Autism. Tell me why."

Freddie took a breath. He squeezed Paige's hand.

"I process sensory input at a higher resolution than standard hardware," he began. "Light. Sound. Texture. It does not get filtered. It accumulates until the buffer overflows."

"And when it overflows?" Dr. Arrington asked, taking notes.

"System crash," Freddie said. "Meltdown."

Dr. Arrington nodded. He didn't write that down; he just watched Freddie's face. He reached for a small wooden box on the table, took out a set of colored blocks, and placed them on the coffee table.

"Organize these," Dr. Arrington said. "Any way you like."

Freddie looked at the blocks. He didn't build a tower. He didn't build a house. He sorted them by color spectrum—Red, Orange, Yellow, Blue—and aligned the edges perfectly, ensuring the spacing between each block was equidistant. Exactly 5 millimeters.

"Done," Freddie said. "The geometry is consistent."

Dr. Arrington watched him. "Pattern recognition. Excellent. Now, tell me about the social aspect. Eye contact?"

"Inefficient," Freddie stated, looking at Dr. Arrington's tie knot. "Eyes provide too much variable data. Micro-expressions. Pupil dilation. It introduces noise."

Dr. Arrington leaned back. "You speak in systems metaphors. Computers. Architecture."

"It is the only language that follows the rules," Freddie said. "Code executes exactly what is written. If I write a script in Quantum Basic, and it fails, it is a syntax error. I can find it. If a conversation fails, it is a mystery."

Dr. Arrington smiled. "It's not a mystery, Freddie. It's just a different operating system. You are running MagnaDesk or Open Systems in a Quantum OS world."

Freddie froze. That was exactly it.

"Am I... broken?" Freddie whispered.

"No," Dr. Arrington said firmly. "You are not broken. You are specialized hardware."

Scene 3: The King Bed Defense

Dr. Arrington picked up his notepad again. "Let's talk about regulation. How do you reboot? How do you handle the 'static'?"

Freddie hesitated. The voice of his father—the "Robert Virus"—flared up in his mind. *Don't tell him. He'll think you're a freak. He'll take you away.*

He felt Paige's hand tighten around his. She rubbed her thumb over his knuckles.

"I require... deep pressure," Freddie said, his voice trembling slightly. "Tactile grounding."

"Like weighted blankets?"

"Better," Freddie said. "I have a twin."

Dr. Arrington looked at Paige. "You provide the pressure?"

"I do," Paige said, her voice steady and protective. "We hug. Hard. And... we sleep together."

The silence in the room was heavy. The air conditioner hummed.

"In the same bed?" Dr. Arrington clarified.

"Yes," Paige said, lifting her chin defiantly. "A King Size. Us and our older sister, Jessica. We sandwich him. It stops the night terrors."

She waited for the judgment. She waited for the lecture about boundaries or age-appropriateness.

Dr. Arrington didn't frown. He didn't look disgusted. He nodded slowly, seemingly impressed.

"Co-regulation," he said.

Freddie blinked. "Variable definition?"

"Co-regulation," Dr. Arrington repeated. "Your nervous system is dysregulated. Hers is calm. By maintaining physical contact, she acts as a grounding wire. You've built a biological life-support system."

He wrote something down on his pad. "Given your history... it is brilliant."

Freddie let out a breath he felt like he'd been holding since childhood. *Brilliant.* Not sick. Not weird. *Brilliant.*

"So... we can keep the bed?" Freddie asked.

"Freddie," Dr. Arrington said seriously. "If it works, you keep it. You do whatever you need to do to survive the static."

Scene 4: The Source Code

Dr. Arrington typed on his computer for twenty minutes. The keys clacked rhythmically. Finally, the dot-matrix printer whirred to life, spitting out a sheet of crisp white paper.

He signed it and handed it to Freddie.

To Whom It May Concern: Patient: Freddie P. Avery **Diagnosis:** Autism Spectrum Disorder **Recommendations:** Sensory accommodations. Deep Pressure Therapy as needed. Allow support persons (Paige Avery, Jessica Avery) full access to educational and medical environments.

Freddie held the paper. It was the Source Code. It was the answer key to the test he had been failing for eighteen years.

"This is the manual," Freddie whispered. "This explains the errors."

"It's a map," Dr. Arrington corrected. "Now you can navigate."

They walked back out to the waiting room. Jessica looked up from a magazine, her eyes scanning their faces for distress.

"Status?" Jessica asked, standing up.

Freddie held up the paper. "Validated."

Jessica let out a long sigh of relief. "Okay. Let's get out of here."

They walked out of the office building into the bright July sunshine. The heat was oppressive, but Freddie felt light. He folded the paper carefully and placed it in his pocket, right next to his PolyPass.

He turned to Paige. She was smiling at him, wearing the same grey shirt, the same glasses.

"We did it," she said.

Freddie stepped forward and wrapped his arms around her right there on the sidewalk. He squeezed her, feeling her arms lock around his back. Jessica placed a hand on his shoulder, completing the circuit.

"Thank you," Freddie whispered. "System stable."

"Always," Paige whispered back.

Freddie pulled back and adjusted his glasses. He checked his watch.

"The diagnostics are complete," he announced. "Now... we have a class to attend."

"Human Sexuality?" Jessica asked with a smirk.

"Affirmative," Freddie said seriously. "I have questions about the diagrams in the textbook. The labeling is inconsistent."

Paige laughed, hooking her arm through his. "Let's go, Architect."

Scene 5: The Uplink

The walk from **105 Pepper Street** to the **Pepper Plaza Transit Center** took exactly three minutes. It was a diagonal line across the street, a vector Freddie had already memorized.

The summer heat was oppressive, shimmering off the asphalt, but Freddie didn't mind. He had the letter. He had the "Source Code" folded neatly in his back pocket, right next to his wallet.

"Bus inbound," Jessica announced, shielding her eyes against the sun.

Turning the corner from North Franklin Street was a white bus with maroon and orange stripes. It was a heavy-duty, 40-foot **Stalwart** city bus, the workhorse of the **Blue Ridge Transit** fleet.

The LED destination sign above the windshield glowed amber in the bright light: **1 CPI**

"On time," Freddie noted, checking his watch. "The grid is active."

They stood in the shelter of the sawtooth bay. As the bus hissed to a halt, the air brakes purged with a sharp *psshhh*—a sound Freddie associated with the start of a journey. The doors folded open.

"Badges out," Jessica said, pulling her **PolyPass** from her purse.

She stepped up first. *Beep.* The card reader chirped a valid read. Paige followed. *Beep.* Freddie stepped up last. He pulled his card from his pocket—the warm plastic rectangle that identified him as **FREDDIE AVERY**. He tapped it against the target.

Beep.

The driver nodded. "Welcome aboard."

Freddie walked down the aisle. It was the summer session, so the bus wasn't at "crush load." There were plenty of seats. He chose a row near the back window. He slid in next to the glass. Paige sat next to him. Jessica took the seat in front, turning sideways to face them.

"Next stop," the automated voice announced as the bus rumbled out of the plaza. *"Business 460."*

The bus merged onto the highway, the diesel engine shifting gears smoothly. Freddie pressed his forehead against the cool glass. For the next thirty minutes, he didn't have to make decisions. He didn't have to interpret facial expressions. He just had to sit.

He felt the vibration of the road through the seat. He felt Paige's shoulder against his. He felt the paper in his pocket.

"We are delivering the patch," Freddie whispered, watching the trees blur by.

"We are," Paige agreed. "Straight to the SSD office. Once they have that letter, the accommodations are locked in. Extended time. Quiet rooms. No more surprises."

"No more surprises," Freddie repeated.

The bus rolled past the strip malls of Christiansburg, climbing the hill toward Blacksburg. The landscape shifted from commercial sprawl to the green, rolling hills of the New River Valley.

Usually, this transition made Freddie anxious—leaving the known for the unknown. But today, he wasn't just a passenger. He was an Admin. He had his credentials.

"Automated Voice," the speaker crackled overhead. *"Approaching CPI. End of the line."*

The stone towers of **Commonwealth Polytechnic** rose in the distance, looking less like a fortress to be conquered and more like a server farm waiting to be programmed.

"Ready to upload?" Jessica asked, standing up as the bus slowed.

Freddie stood up. He adjusted his glasses. He checked his pocket one last time to make sure the letter was still there.

"Upload sequence initiated," Freddie said. "Let's go."

Scene 6: The Thunderhead

The sky over the **New River Valley** had turned a bruised, angry purple. The summer heat had broken, but it had broken violently.

Inside **Archer Hall**, the world was shaking.

A massive thunderstorm was parking itself directly over the campus. Rain lashed against the plate-glass windows of the student lounge area with such force that it sounded like gravel. Outside, visibility was zero; the building across the quad had vanished behind a curtain of grey water.

BOOM.

Thunder cracked directly overhead, vibrating through the terrazzo floor.

Freddie flinched violently. He was lying on a vinyl bench in the corner of the lounge, his legs curled up, his head pressed hard into Paige's lap. He had his hands clamped over his ears, eyes squeezed shut.

"Sensory overload," Freddie gasped. "Audio input exceeds safety limits."

"I know," Paige whispered, leaning over him to create a human shelter. She pressed her hands over his hands, adding another layer of pressure. "It's just noise, Freddie. It's just electricity discharging. It can't get in here."

FLASH.

Lightning lit up the lounge like a strobe light, followed instantly by another earth-shaking *CRACK.*

Freddie whimpered, burying his face in Paige's stomach. To him, the thunder wasn't just sound; it was a physical assault. It was unpredictable. It was chaotic. It was the opposite of structure.

Jessica walked quickly across the lounge, balancing a cardboard tray from the vending machines. She looked wet; she had sprinted from the snack bar down the hall.

"Fuel secured," Jessica announced, sliding onto the bench at Freddie's feet. "I got pretzels and water. The main cafeteria is a no-go. We are trapped until this cell passes."

"Status of the storm?" Paige asked, looking up.

"Radar is red," Jessica reported grimly. "It's a heavy cell. Probably another twenty minutes of the heavy stuff."

Freddie groaned into Paige's shirt. "Twenty minutes is 1,200 seconds. That is too many seconds."

"Focus on the count," Paige instructed gently. "Breathe in... one, two, three..."

They were in their formation. The Avery Unit. Shield up. Anchor down. Waiting out the chaos.

But the chaos had an avatar.

Krystal emerged from the hallway. She was bored. She was stuck in the building, her flip-phone had no signal in the storm, and she was agitated.

She spotted them in the corner. She saw Freddie curled up in a fetal position, hiding in his sister's lap.

To anyone else, it looked like a medical situation. To Krystal, it looked like an opportunity.

He's scared, she thought. *He's vulnerable.*

She walked over, her heels clicking on the hard floor. She stopped right in front of the bench, looming over them.

"Wow," Krystal said, her voice cutting through the hum of the rain. "He really doesn't like the thunder, huh?"

Jessica looked up. Her eyes were hard. "Go away, Krystal. Now is not the time."

Krystal ignored her. She stepped closer to Freddie's head. She leaned down, putting her face uncomfortably close to his ear.

"Hey, Freddie," she purred. "It's pretty loud out here, isn't it? All that banging? It's scary."

Freddie stiffened. He could smell her perfume—too sweet, too chemical. It mixed with the ozone smell of the storm to create a nauseating cocktail.

"I have an idea," Krystal whispered, glancing at the sisters with a smirk. "I know a place where you can't hear the thunder. There's a janitor's closet down the hall. In the interior corridor. It's thick concrete. Totally soundproof."

She paused, letting the implication hang in the air like humidity.

"It's dark in there," she added. "And it's private. Just you and me. I could... distract you. Make you forget all about the storm. We could have some real fun while we wait."

Paige froze. Her hands stopped rubbing Freddie's back.

Freddie peeled one eye open. He looked at Krystal.

"Janitor's closet," Freddie repeated, his voice shaking. "Storage for chemical solvents. Mops. Buckets. High risk of contamination."

"No, silly," Krystal giggled, reaching out to touch his arm. "It's cozy. Come on. Leave your sisters here. Let me take care of you. I promise, I can make you feel *so* much better than a hug."

That was the line.

Jessica didn't stand up. She *launched* herself.

She slammed the tray of pretzels onto the table and rounded the bench in a single, fluid motion. She stepped directly into Krystal's personal space, forcing the girl to stumble back in her high-heeled sandals.

"THAT IS ENOUGH!" Jessica screamed.

The sound was louder than the thunder. The few other students in the lounge turned to look. Jessica didn't care.

"Are you deaf?" Jessica shouted, pointing a finger inches from Krystal's nose. "Or are you just stupid? He doesn't want you! He is in distress! He is overwhelmed! And you are trying to *seduce* him into a broom closet?"

"I was just trying to help!" Krystal stammered, shrinking back. "He needs—"

"He needs safety!" Jessica roared. "He needs stability! He does not need a quickie in a room that smells like bleach with a girl who thinks 'no' is just a suggestion!"

Krystal flushed red. "You're just jealous because he—"

"Jealous?" Jessica laughed, a harsh, terrifying sound. "I am his sister! I am his protector! You are a predator, Krystal. You see a boy who struggles to walk, a boy who is sensitive to noise, and you think, 'Easy target.' You think you can just wear him down."

Jessica took another step forward. Krystal hit the wall.

"You are done," Jessica hissed, her voice dropping to a lethal, low register. "If you come near him again—if you offer him sex, cigarettes, or a 'good time'—I will file a harassment complaint with the Dean so fast your head will spin. I will get you expelled. Do you understand me?"

Krystal looked at Jessica. She looked at the fury in her eyes. Then she looked past her at the bench.

Freddie had sat up. He wasn't looking at Krystal. He was looking at Paige.

Paige had her arms wrapped tight around his shoulders. She was rocking him gently.

"She is a virus," Freddie stated clearly, his voice cutting through the silence of the room. "Quarantine her."

"You heard him," Jessica snarled. "Get. Out."

Krystal scrambled. She didn't have a comeback. The fantasy of being the savior, the seductress, crumbled under the weight of Jessica's rage. She turned and practically ran down the hallway, disappearing toward the restrooms.

Jessica stood there for a moment, her chest heaving. She smoothed her shirt. She took a deep breath.

She turned back to the bench.

"Threat neutralized," Jessica announced, her voice returning to normal.

She sat back down. She picked up a pretzel and handed it to Freddie.

"Eat," she commanded. "Salt helps the shock."

Freddie took the pretzel. He took a bite. The crunch was grounding.

"That was... loud," Freddie said, looking at Jessica.

"Sometimes you have to be louder than the storm," Jessica shrugged.

BOOM.

Another clap of thunder shook the room. Freddie flinched, dropping the pretzel and diving back into Paige's lap.

"It is still here," he whimpered.

"I know," Paige whispered, resuming her stroking of his hair. "But Krystal isn't. It's just us, Freddie. Just the Unit."

"Hug required," Freddie mumbled. "Duration: Infinite."

"Accepted," Paige promised, leaning her cheek on top of his head as the rain battered the glass. "I will hug you for the rest of your life if you want, Freddie. I'm not going anywhere."

"Good," Freddie sighed, closing his eyes. "The closet... was an illogical proposal."

"Very illogical," Paige agreed.

Outside, the storm raged on. But inside the circle of the Avery Unit, the perimeter was finally, completely secure.

Scene 7: The Warning

The silence in the student lounge following Jessica's explosion was brief. It was replaced not by conversation, but by a sound that triggered a primal instinct in anyone who grew up in the mountains.

It started as a low growl outside, penetrating the brick walls, rising steadily in pitch until it became a deafening, mechanical wail.

WHOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO-OOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO.

The Blacksburg Civil Defense siren.

It cut through the sound of the rain like a knife. Inside **Archer Hall**, there were no flashing lights, no strobes—just the eerie, vibrating hum of that siren coming from everywhere at once.

The music in the lounge cut out abruptly. The PA system crackled to life with a burst of static, overriding the ambient hum of the building.

"May I have your attention please," a calm, male voice announced, echoing through the ceiling speakers. *"The National Weather Service has issued a Tornado Warning for Blacksburg and the immediate campus area. Seek shelter immediately in an interior hallway on the lowest floor. Stay away from windows. This is not a drill."*

Freddie didn't move. He couldn't.

The siren, combined with the earlier confrontation and the thunder, had severed the connection between his brain and his legs. He was in **Total System Lockout**. His hands were clamped over his ears, his eyes wide and unseeing. He was shaking, a high-frequency tremor that rattled his teeth.

"Freddie," Jessica said, her voice sharp and urgent. "We have to move. Interior hallway. Now."

"Can't," Freddie choked out. "Legs offline."

Jessica didn't hesitate. She looked at Paige.

"Transport protocol," Jessica commanded. "Grab his right side. I've got the left."

They moved with practiced efficiency. Jessica hooked her arm under Freddie's left armpit; Paige did the same on the right.

"On three," Jessica counted. "One. Two. Up."

They hoisted him. Freddie was dead weight, his legs dragging uselessly on the terrazzo floor. He didn't try to help. He simply tucked his head into his chest, surrendering control to the Unit.

They half-carried, half-dragged him out of the lounge, away from the terrifying plate-glass windows that were now rattling with the force of the wind. They turned the corner into the main interior corridor—a long, windowless tunnel of cinderblock and linoleum.

"There," Paige shouted, pointing to a heavy oak study table bolted to the floor against the wall.

"Under," Jessica ordered.

They lowered Freddie to the floor. He scrambled under the table, curling into the tightest ball his spastic muscles would allow. Paige crawled in immediately after him, sitting cross-legged and pulling his head into her lap. Jessica slid in last, taking the position at the opening, using her body to block the view of the hallway.

They were a knot of limbs in the dark space beneath the table.

"Siren," Freddie whimpered, pressing his face into Paige's stomach. "Too loud. Frequency is... hostile."

"I know," Paige whispered, wrapping her arms around his head, covering his hands with hers to create a double seal against the noise. "I've got you. I'm blocking it."

"Radar indicated rotation," Jessica reported, checking the small screen of her phone. "It means they saw a hook echo. It doesn't mean it's on the ground. It's just a precaution."

CRACK-BOOM.

Thunder shook the floor beneath them, louder than before.

Suddenly, the overhead fluorescent lights buzzed and died, plunging the hallway into darkness. A second later, the emergency backup lights kicked on—dim, yellow beams that cast long, eerie shadows down the corridor.

Freddie let out a sound that was half-sob, half-scream, muffled entirely by Paige's shirt.

"Squeeze him," Jessica said. "Maximum pressure."

Jessica wrapped her arms around both of them from behind, crushing them into a single, solid mass. Paige squeezed Freddie from the front.

They held him in the **Press**, the ultimate Avery defense. They became a human weighted blanket.

"We are the bunker," Paige whispered into Freddie's ear, over and over. "We are concrete. We are steel. Nothing gets through the table. Nothing gets through us."

Time distorted.

15:25 PM. The siren wailed on outside, a relentless cycle of doom. Freddie's shaking was violent, sweating through his shirt. He was completely non-verbal, his mind retreated to a safe room deep inside his head where there was no sound.

15:35 PM. The siren finally winded down, dropping in pitch until it faded into silence. The quiet that followed was heavy, filled only by the sound of rain hammering the roof—but the rain sounded different now. Heavier. Metallic.

"Hail," Jessica noted. "That's the core passing over."

They didn't move. They held the formation.

15:45 PM. The PA system crackled again, loud in the quiet hallway.

"Attention. The Tornado Warning has expired. The severe weather threat has passed. Please remain cautious of slick floors and debris. All clear."

Jessica let out a breath that shuddered in her chest. She loosened her grip on Paige's back.

"All clear," Jessica announced softly. "Freddie? Did you hear that? The warning is over."

Freddie didn't move for a long time. Slowly, incrementally, he uncurled. He pulled his face away from Paige's shirt. His glasses were crooked. His face was pale and wet with sweat and tears.

"Status?" Paige asked gently, wiping his cheek with her thumb.

"Battery... zero percent," Freddie whispered. His voice was a rasp. "System depleted."

"I bet," Jessica said, crawling out from under the table and standing up. She stretched her cramped legs. "Come on. Let's get you out from under there."

They helped him crawl out. He sat on the floor under the dim emergency lights, leaning back against the wall, eyes closed.

"Home," Freddie whispered. "Requesting... immediate transit to Base."

"We're going," Jessica promised. She looked down the hall toward the doors. "It's still raining pretty hard, but the hail stopped. No tornado. Just a radar scare."

"Scare was sufficient," Freddie mumbled.

"Yeah," Paige agreed, helping him stand. His legs were wobbly, trembling with the aftershocks of adrenaline, but they held.

They walked slowly toward the exit. Freddie didn't look for Krystal. He didn't check the architectural lines of the hallway. He didn't think about his diagnosis letter.

He just walked, flanked by his sisters, moving toward the bus stop. He was empty, drained of every ounce of energy. But he was walking. The storm had thrown everything it had at him—sex, rage, thunder, wind—and the Unit was still standing.

Scene 8: The All Clear

The heavy glass doors of **Archer Hall** pushed open, and the Avery Unit stepped out into a changed world.

The sky was still a flat, featureless grey, and the rain was falling in a steady, relentless sheet, but the violence was gone. The wind had died down. The hail had melted into slushy piles in the gutters.

The air smelled like ozone and shredded leaves—the signature scent of a storm that had just tried to kill something.

"Transport inbound," Jessica noted, pointing toward the loop.

The bus—a massive white transit vehicle with maroon and orange stripes—was splashing through the puddles, its headlights reflecting off the wet pavement.

The amber LED sign above the windshield read: **1 FALLING BRANCH**

"It's the Falling Branch run," Jessica confirmed. "It stops at Pepper Plaza on the way out."

They walked to the shelter. Freddie moved stiffly. His adrenaline had crashed, leaving him with the "battery drained" feeling that made his limbs feel like lead. He kept his head down, focusing only on the heels of Jessica's boots in front of him.

They boarded the bus. It was crowded—everyone who had been sheltering in the library and the student center was now making a break for it.

Freddie slid into a window seat. Paige sat next to him, immediately taking his hand and placing it on her knee, re-establishing the physical link. Jessica sat in the seat ahead, turning sideways to watch them.

The bus driver, a heavy-set man with a mustache, had the radio playing softly over the speakers. It was tuned to **WNRV**, the local AM station.

"...folks, that was a close one," the radio announcer said, his voice crackling with static. *"We just got word from the Weather Service office out by the airport.*

They actually had to hand off forecasting duties to the Wakefield office for about ten minutes there. The meteorologists had to take shelter themselves when that rotation passed right over the radar dish."

Jessica shook her head. "It was right on top of them."

"They saw the variable," Freddie murmured, staring out the window at the wet trees blurring by. "They reacted to the data."

"They did," Paige agreed softly. "And so did we."

The bus merged onto **Route 460**, the tires hissing on the wet asphalt. Freddie watched the rain streak horizontally across the glass.

He felt empty. The day had taken everything.

- The intellectual friction of the Human Sexuality class.
- The social friction of Krystal's harassment.
- The sensory violence of the thunder.
- The primal fear of the siren.

He was operating on emergency power.

"I require..." Freddie started, then trailed off. He didn't even have the energy to formulate the request.

"I know," Paige whispered. "We're getting off at Pepper Plaza. We're going home. We're going to order pizza. We're going to turn off all the lights. And we're going to watch *Stellar Voyage*."

"With the volume down," Freddie added weakly.

"With the volume way down," Paige promised. "And subtitles on."

Freddie leaned his head against her shoulder. The vibration of the bus engine was a steady, low-frequency hum that began to overwrite the memory of the siren.

He closed his eyes. He wasn't the Captain right now. He wasn't the Architect. He was just a passenger, safe in the gravity well of his sisters, riding the Route 1 back to the only place where the static couldn't find him.

The Prime Time Block

Scene 1: The Decompression Protocol

The front door of **105 Pepper Street** clicked shut, and the heavy deadbolt slid home with a reassuring *thunk*.

The silence inside the house was absolute. The air conditioner hummed its steady, white-noise rhythm, scrubbing the humidity and the memory of the tornado siren from the air.

"Decontamination," Jessica announced, dropping her keys in the bowl. "Immediate execution."

They moved to their respective zones. The "Armor" of the day—jeans, shoes, bras, and the sweat of the storm—was stripped away.

Ten minutes later, the Avery Unit reassembled in the living room. They were now in **Safe Mode**.

Freddie: Wearing soft grey lounge pants and his safety-orange hoodie (zipper open, hood down).

Paige: Wearing an oversized t-shirt and cotton shorts.

Jessica: Wearing flannel pajama pants and a tank top.

"Food protocol?" Jessica asked, moving to the kitchen phone.

"Pizza," Freddie stated from the sofa. He was already building the "Nest"—arranging the pillows in the corner. "Pepperoni. Thin crust. It provides a consistent texture profile."

"Papa Tony's it is," Jessica agreed, dialing the number for the local delivery spot that knew their order by heart.

The TV was on, volume set to "Level 12"—audible, but not aggressive.

On the screen, the local news team at **WNRV-TV** was wrapping up the weather segment. The weatherman, a guy with a pointer and a map full of red zones, was apologizing for the earlier siren.

"...rotation has lifted, folks. The severe thunderstorm warning remains in effect until 8 PM for the eastern counties, but here in the New River Valley, we are just looking at rain."

"Variable confirmed," Freddie whispered, curling his legs up onto the beige sofa. "The threat has passed."

Paige sat next to him, sliding her arm through his. She didn't crowd him; she just re-established the link. "Just rain, Freddie. Just water."

The doorbell rang. It wasn't the heavy knock of a threat; it was the rhythmic *ding-dong* of calorie delivery.

Jessica handled the transaction. She returned with two steaming cardboard boxes.

"Fuel," she announced, setting them on the coffee table.

They ate while the **GBS Evening Report** played. The anchor, **David Clark**—a man with silver hair and a voice like trustworthy gravel—delivered the national headlines. Freddie liked David Clark. He didn't shout. He didn't use sensational graphics. He just read the data.

"In Washington today, Congress debated the new budget..."

Freddie chewed his thin-crust pepperoni. The crunch was grounding. The tomato sauce was savory. The world outside was chaotic, but inside the living room, the variables were controlled.

At 7:30 PM, the tone shifted from luck to logic. **The Daily Quiz** began.

This was serious business. The three of them sat forward, slices of pizza forgotten, competing for the title of "Living Room Champion."

"History for 400," the host announced. "The treaty that ended World War I." "What is the Treaty of Versailles?" Jessica shouted. "Correct," the host said.

"Science for 600." "The process by which plants use sunlight to synthesize foods." "What is... Photosynthesis?" Freddie guessed. "Correct."

Then came the visual clue. An image of a brass instrument with mirrors and an arc appeared on the blue screen. "Navigation for 800," the host read. "This doubly reflecting navigation instrument measures the angular distance between two visible objects."

"Sextant," Freddie corrected instantly. "Navigation tool."

"WRONG!" Jessica shouted, pointing a pizza crust at him like a gavel. "Error! Syntax error!"

Freddie blinked, looking at her. "The identification is accurate. It is a sextant."

"Phrasing, Freddie!" Paige laughed, nudging his ribs. "You have to format the data!"

"Oh," Freddie realized. The arbitrary rule of the game show. The social contract of the quiz. He sighed, adjusting his glasses. "What is a sextant?"

"That is correct," the host on the TV said.

"Point restored," Jessica declared, taking a bite of her crust. "But you're on thin ice, mister. Respect the format."

Then, the game shows ended. The commercials faded. The station ID for **WNRV** played—a simple animation of the New River winding through the valley.

The room went quiet.

"Here we go," Jessica said, dimming the lights until the room was lit only by the blue glow of the CRT. "Prime Time block engaged."

"Status check?" Paige asked, looking at Freddie. He was sitting on the edge of the cushion, his eyes fixed on the screen, but his shoulders were slumped. The adrenaline of the quiz was fading, leaving behind the heavy residue of the day's exhaustion.

"Battery critical," Freddie admitted, rubbing his eyes. "I require... a recharge cycle."

"Understood," Paige said softly. She shifted on the beige sofa, moving her legs to create space. She patted her lap. "Docking bay open."

Freddie didn't hesitate. He slid down from his seated position, swinging his legs up onto the sofa. He laid his head down in Paige's lap, curling on his side facing the TV.

Paige immediately rested her arm across his chest, her hand settling over his heart. The weight was instant relief. It was a physical anchor, holding him down to the earth, preventing him from floating away into the static.

"Pressure applied," Paige whispered.

"System stabilizing," Freddie murmured, closing his eyes for a moment to savor the safety.

The screen faded to black. A field of stars appeared—pinpricks of light moving slowly, majestically across the void.

Then, the voice spoke. Deep. Resonant. The voice of **Captain Miller**.

"Space... The infinite expanse."

Freddie opened his eyes. From this angle, looking up past Paige's arm, the stars seemed even brighter.

"These are the voyages of the Starship Avalon."

The orchestral music swelled—the French horns rising like a sunrise over a planet. It wasn't just music to Freddie; it was a frequency that vibrated in his chest, syncing with the steady rhythm of Paige's breathing beneath him.

"Its continuing mission: to explore strange new worlds. To seek out new life and new civilizations."

He felt Paige's hand tighten slightly on his chest as the music peaked. It sounded like order. It sounded like a future where logic was respected, where the rules were written in the stars, and where a crew of different species worked together without friction.

"To boldly go where no one has gone before."

The silver ship streaked into warp, a flash of light against the darkness.

Freddie let out a long, slow breath. The tension in his legs unspooled. The knot in his stomach vanished.

"Status?" Paige whispered, looking down at him.

"We are at warp," Freddie whispered back, a small smile touching his lips. "The static is gone."

For the next hour, there was no Krystal. There was no tornado. There was only the bridge of the *Avalon*, the hum of the warp core, and the safety of the Avery Unit, flying through the night together.

Scene 2: The Emergency Brake

The credits for *Stellar Voyage: The New Era* rolled silently up the screen. The music had faded, replaced by the low hum of the air conditioner and the ticking of the hallway clock.

The "Prime Time Block" was over. The mission was complete.

"Show's over," Jessica announced softly from the recliner. She stood up and stretched, her joints popping in the quiet room. "Time to dock, Captain."

On the sofa, there was no movement.

Freddie lay curled on his side, his head resting heavily in Paige's lap. He didn't lift his head at Jessica's voice. Instead, he did the opposite.

He turned his face inward, pressing his forehead directly into the soft cotton of Paige's t-shirt, burying himself against her stomach. He let out a long, shaky exhale that shuddered through his frame.

Paige looked down at him. She felt the tension in his shoulders, the way his hand gripped the fabric of her shorts.

"He's engaging the brake," Paige whispered to Jessica.

Jessica walked over and looked down at her brother. She saw the signs. The day had taken too much. The Human Sexuality class, the confrontation with Krystal, the tornado siren, the sensory overload of the storm—it had all drained his battery to absolute zero.

He wasn't being stubborn. He was stuck. He was safe right here, in the "Recharge Mode," and the thought of moving, of standing up, of transitioning to the bedroom felt like climbing a mountain without oxygen.

"Battery critical?" Jessica asked gently.

Freddie nodded against Paige's stomach, a tiny, almost imperceptible movement.

"Okay," Jessica said. "Manual override."

She didn't tell him to get up. She didn't tell him to be a man. She simply moved into position.

"Paige, you hold the head," Jessica instructed. "I've got the legs."

Paige shifted her hands, sliding one under Freddie's neck and the other under his shoulder blades. "I've got him," she whispered, stroking his hair with her thumb. "It's okay, Freddie. We're just moving the nest."

Jessica bent down and scooped her arms under Freddie's knees.

"On three," Jessica counted. "One. Two. Lift."

They hoisted him. Freddie was dead weight, limp with exhaustion. He didn't try to help, but he didn't fight them. He simply kept his eyes squeezed shut, trusting the system.

They carried him down the short hallway—a clumsy, shuffling procession of love. Jessica walked backward, guiding the way. Paige walked forward, cradling his upper body against her chest.

"Watch the doorframe," Jessica warned as they reached the **Silo**.

They navigated the turn into the master bedroom. The room was cool and dark, the blackout curtains already drawn tight.

They lowered him onto the massive King Bed. The mattress absorbed his weight with a soft *whump*.

Freddie immediately curled into a ball, pulling his knees to his chest. He was still wearing his grey lounge pants and t-shirt.

"Armor off," Paige whispered, sitting on the edge of the bed next to him. "You can't sleep in the day clothes."

Freddie groaned, a sound of pure fatigue. He tried to lift his arm, but it flopped back onto the mattress.

"I got it," Jessica said. She moved efficiently. She pulled his socks off. She unbuttoned his pants. "Lift your hips, Freddie."

He managed a weak lift. Jessica slid the pants and underwear down and off.

Paige handled the shirt. She gently lifted his head, pulling the fabric up and over. Freddie let her move him like a doll.

He was left in birthday suit. He shivered slightly in the cool air.

"Cover," Paige said, pulling the heavy duvet up over him.

Now came the final step.

Jessica and Paige stripped off their own clothes quickly in the dark, tossing them into the hamper. There was no hesitation, no modesty. Just the urgent need to complete the circuit.

They climbed into the bed.

Jessica took the left flank. She slid under the covers and immediately wrapped her arm over Freddie's chest, pressing him down into the mattress.

Paige took the right flank. She slid in and pulled Freddie's head onto her shoulder. She hooked her leg over his legs, pinning him in place.

They collapsed the space. They pressed in tight, creating a solid wall of warmth and skin on both sides.

"Brake release," Paige whispered into his ear. "You're docked."

Freddie let out a breath he felt like he had been holding since he woke up that morning. The pressure was perfect. The weight of his sisters anchored him to the bed, to the room, to the earth.

He wasn't back at Newman Hall. He wasn't in the storm. He was here.

"Zero percent," Freddie mumbled, his voice thick with sleep.

"We know," Jessica whispered from the other side, squeezing his hand. "Recharging now."

Safe in the sandwich configuration, held by the only two people who knew how to carry him when he couldn't walk, Freddie finally let go. The system entered Sleep Mode.

Scene 3: The Dark Closet

WHOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO-OOOOOOOOOOOOOOOOO.

The sound was everywhere. It wasn't just in the air; it was vibrating through the floor tiles of **Archer Hall**.

The PA system crackled, the voice distorted by static and fear. *"Tornado Warning. Seek shelter immediately. This is not a drill."*

"We have to move!" Krystal screamed, her fingers digging into Freddie's bicep like claws.

"My sisters," Freddie gasped, trying to pull back toward the restrooms. "They are in the lavatory. I cannot leave the Unit."

"There's no time!" Krystal yelled over the roar of the wind. "The roof is coming off! We have to go now!"

She yanked him hard. Freddie stumbled, his legs heavy and unresponsive, like they were moving through wet concrete. He tried to shout for Paige, but his voice was a dry rattle.

Krystal dragged him down the hallway. It stretched out endlessly, the fluorescent lights flickering and buzzing like angry insects. He saw other students running, their faces blurred and panicked, disappearing into classrooms.

"Not there," Krystal hissed, pulling him past the open doors. "Too crowded. We need privacy. We need to be *safe*."

The roar outside grew deafening—a freight train grinding against the brick walls. The windows at the end of the hall shattered, glass exploding inward.

"Here!" Krystal shouted.

She wrenched open a heavy steel door marked **CUSTODIAL**. She shoved Freddie inside. He stumbled into the darkness, tripping over a mop bucket.

Krystal slammed the door shut.

CLICK.

The sound of the lock engaging was louder than the storm. The roar of the tornado muffled instantly, replaced by a heavy, suffocating silence. The air smelled of bleach and aggressive perfume.

"Safe," Krystal whispered.

A beam of light cut through the blackness. Krystal had clicked on a flashlight. She shone it right in Freddie's face, blinding him. He threw his hands up to shield his eyes.

"Put your hands down," Krystal commanded.

She lowered the beam until it illuminated her own face. She was smiling. It wasn't a nice smile. It was the smile of a hunter who had finally cornered the prey.

"See?" she purred, stepping closer. "No sisters. No noise. Just us."

"I require... evacuation," Freddie stammered, backing up until he hit the shelves of cleaning supplies. "This environment is confined."

"It's cozy," Krystal corrected. She stepped right up to him, pressing her body against his. He could feel the heat radiating off her.

"Now is the time, Freddie," she whispered, reaching out to grab the zipper of his orange hoodie. "No one can hear us in here. No one can stop us. You're finally going to learn what you really need."

She pulled the zipper down. Her hand slid inside the hoodie, touching his chest. Her fingers were cold.

"Please," Freddie begged, freezing in terror. "Stop."

"Don't be shy," Krystal giggled, moving her face closer to his. "You're going to thank me."

She leaned in, her lips inches from his—

Scene 4: The Awakening

Freddie's eyes flew open.

He gasped, a sharp, desperate intake of air that sounded like he was drowning. He bolted upright, his heart hammering against his ribs so hard it hurt.

He was in the dark. He was trapped.

"No!" he choked out, scrambling backward, his hands flailing, trying to push the phantom girl away. "No access! Access denied!"

He hit something soft. A wall of pillows.

He blinked, his chest heaving. The air didn't smell of bleach. It smelled of lavender laundry detergent and cool air conditioning.

He wasn't in a closet. He was in the **Silo**.

But the terror didn't fade. The image of the flashlight, the feel of the cold hand on his chest—it was still firing in his brain.

"Freddie?"

The voice came from his right. Sleepy, but instantly alert.

Freddie let out a sob. It wasn't a scream; it was the sound of something breaking. He brought his knees to his chest and buried his face in his hands, shaking violently.

"Crying," Paige announced, her voice shifting from drowsy to tactical in a split second. "Code Blue."

She sat up. She didn't ask what was wrong. She knew the sound. She had heard it a hundred times in their childhood bedrooms. This wasn't the blank stare of a night terror; this was the raw pain of a nightmare.

"Lights," Jessica whispered from the left. She reached out and clicked the bedside lamp on to its lowest setting—a dim, warm yellow glow.

Both women sprang into action. They didn't need to communicate; they knew the protocol.

The Comfort Protocol:

1. **Contact:** Establish physical presence immediately.
2. **Pressure:** Apply weight to ground the system.
3. **Validation:** Confirm safety.

Paige moved first. She scooted across the mattress and wrapped her arms around Freddie's shaking shoulders. She didn't just hug him; she compressed him. She pulled him hard against her chest.

"I've got you," Paige whispered, pressing her cheek against his wet hair. "You're here. You're at 105 Pepper. You're in the Silo."

Jessica moved in from the other side. She saw the tears streaming through Freddie's fingers. She saw the way he was recoiling from an invisible touch.

She placed her hand firmly on his back, right between his shoulder blades—the structural center. She rubbed in slow, heavy circles.

"Breathe, Freddie," Jessica commanded gently. "In through the nose. Out through the mouth. Feel the bed. Feel us."

Freddie sobbed, leaning into Paige's hold. "The closet," he gasped. "She locked the door. The siren..."

"No siren," Paige said firmly, rocking him slightly. "Listen to the room. Just the AC. Just the hum."

"She touched me," Freddie whispered, his voice trembling with violation. "She wouldn't stop."

Paige's eyes flashed with a momentary, terrifying anger at the dream-girl, but she pushed it down. She needed to be soft right now.

"She's not here," Paige promised. "She can't get in here. The firewall is active. Jessica locked the door. I checked it myself."

"I checked it too," Jessica added, leaning her head on Freddie's shoulder, sandwiching him completely. "Nobody gets in this room without getting past us. And nobody gets past us."

Freddie lowered his hands slowly. He looked at Paige. He looked at Jessica.

They were there. Real. Warm. Safe.

He let out a long, shuddering breath. The panic began to recede, replaced by the crushing weight of exhaustion and the lingering sadness of the dream.

"It felt real," Freddie sniffled. "The data... was vivid."

"That's a nightmare," Paige explained softly, wiping his tears with her thumb. "It's a glitch in the memory file. But we flushed it. It's gone."

"Reset?" Freddie asked weakly.

"Reset," Jessica confirmed.

She reached over and turned off the lamp, plunging the room back into the protective darkness. But she didn't move away.

"Configuration Delta," Jessica whispered.

They lay back down. Freddie lay in the center.

Paige curled around him from the right, throwing her heavy leg over his legs to pin him down, wrapping her arm across his chest to protect his heart.

Jessica curled around him from the left, pressing her back against his side, creating a solid wall of defense.

"Squeeze," Freddie requested, his voice barely audible.

"Squeezing," both sisters whispered.

They tightened the hold. The pressure was immense. It was perfect. It pushed the memory of the closet out of his mind and replaced it with the absolute certainty of the bed.

"Safe," Freddie breathed.

"Always," Paige murmured into his ear.

Held tight in the center of the Avery Unit, Freddie finally closed his eyes. The nightmare was deleted. The system was secure.

Scene 5: The Recovery Cycle

The morning sun pressed against the blackout curtains of the **Silo**, but inside, the darkness held.

Freddie woke up slowly. He didn't bolt upright this time. He floated to the surface of consciousness, anchored by the heavy, reassuring weight of the **Sandwich Configuration**.

To his left, Jessica was a warm, solid wall. Her arm was still draped over his chest, a protective bar across the gate. To his right, Paige was curled into his side, her leg hooked over his ankles, pinning him to the mattress.

Freddie blinked in the dark. The memory of the closet nightmare was still there—a jagged edge in his mind—but it felt distant now. It was a file that had been quarantined.

"Status?" Paige whispered. She wasn't asleep. She had felt his breathing change.

"Battery... low," Freddie admitted, his voice raspy. "Recharge incomplete. Sleep cycle was interrupted."

"I know," Paige murmured, squeezing him. "It was a rough night."

"We're taking a zero day," Jessica announced from the darkness. She lifted her arm, stretching. "No bus. No campus. No Krystal."

"Zero day," Freddie repeated. "Acceptable."

They lay there for another ten minutes, just existing in the safe, warm pile of the Unit. Finally, the biological imperative of morning (coffee and bathrooms) forced a movement.

"Armor up," Jessica said, sitting up and rubbing her eyes. "We need to secure the perimeter if we're going to the living room."

They climbed out of the King Bed. The air was cool on their skin.

Freddie walked to the hamper. He ignored the jeans he had worn yesterday. He ignored the orange hoodie (too heavy for today).

He pulled out his "Safe Mode" uniform: soft, worn-in grey jersey pajama pants and a white tag-less t-shirt.

Paige pulled on a pair of loose cotton shorts and one of Freddie's old grey t-shirts that she had claimed years ago. It smelled like him—laundry detergent and safety.

Jessica threw on her flannel pants and a tank top.

"Ready?" Jessica asked.

"Ready," Freddie nodded. He felt heavy, his limbs moving through syrup, but he wasn't shaking.

The living room of **105 Pepper Street** was filled with the soft morning light filtering through the blinds.

Jessica went to the kitchen to start the coffee maker. The gurgle and hiss of the machine was a familiar, grounding sound.

"Breakfast?" Jessica called out.

"Cereal," Freddie said, moving toward the beige sofa. "Dry. No milk. Texture maintenance."

He reached the sofa. He didn't sit. He looked at Paige.

Paige didn't need to be asked. She sat down in the corner of the sofa, leaning back against the armrest. She extended her legs along the cushions, creating a nest.

She patted her lap. "Docking bay open."

Freddie climbed onto the sofa. He lay down, positioning his head carefully in her lap. He curled his legs up, fitting his body into the curve of hers.

Paige rested her arm along his side, her hand settling on his chest, right over his heart.

Freddie closed his eyes.

This was the variable Krystal didn't understand. She thought this was about "touch." She thought it was about skin.

It wasn't. It was about **Architecture**.

Paige's lap wasn't just a pillow; it was a structural support beam. She knew exactly how to hold his head so his neck muscles could release. She knew exactly how much weight to put on his chest to stop the sensory static.

If Krystal touched him, it was a demand. *Look at me. Want me.* When Paige touched him, it was a promise. *I've got you. Rest.*

"Pressure applied," Paige whispered, looking down at his face. She saw the dark circles under his eyes, the tension still lingering in his jaw.

"System... stabilizing," Freddie breathed.

Jessica walked in with a bowl of dry Honey Oat Rings and a mug of coffee. She set the bowl on the floor within Freddie's reach.

She sat in the recliner, picking up a book.

"We aren't doing anything today," Jessica stated firmly. "We are watching TV. We are eating carbs. And we are staying inside the firewall."

"Firewall active," Freddie murmured.

He reached blindly for a handful of cereal, crunching quietly. He felt Paige's fingers start to card through his hair, a slow, rhythmic motion that sent waves of calm down his spine.

The nightmare of the closet faded. The image of the flashlight dissolved.

Here, in the light of the living room, with the taste of oats and the weight of his sister's hand on his heart, Freddie Avery let the system go offline. He drifted into a doze, safe in the only place in the world where he didn't have to be on guard.

Scene 6: The System Halt

The silence in the living room had stretched on for fifteen minutes. It was peaceful, but Jessica, ever the manager, felt the urge to introduce a new variable.

She picked up the remote control from the armrest of the recliner.

"Maybe some background noise?" Jessica suggested softly. "WNRV usually runs old cartoons right now. Something low impact."

She pressed the power button.

Click.

The **MagnaView** screen crackled to life. A burst of static was followed immediately by the bright colors and frantic orchestral score of a chase scene.

It wasn't loud—Volume 12—but it was sudden.

On the sofa, Freddie reacted instantly. He didn't just flinch; he engaged the **Emergency Brake**.

He turned his head sharply away from the screen, burying his face directly into the soft cotton of Paige's t-shirt, pressing his forehead hard against her stomach. His entire body went rigid, his legs locking into a curled position. He gripped the fabric of Paige's shorts with a white-knuckled intensity.

It was a full stop. A rejection of all external input.

"Off," Paige whispered, her hand immediately going to the back of his neck to shield him. "Jessica, kill it."

Jessica didn't hesitate. She hit the power button.

Click.

The TV died. The room plunged back into silence.

"My bad," Jessica murmured, setting the remote down as if it were a loaded weapon. "Input rejected."

She looked at Freddie. He hadn't relaxed. He was still buried in Paige's lap, hiding from the world. His breathing was shallow.

"Battery check?" Jessica asked quietly.

Paige shook her head. "One percent," she estimated, running her hand down his spine in a slow, firm massage. "Maybe less. The nightmare really drained him. He's running on fumes."

Jessica sighed. She looked at the bowl of dry Honey Oat Rings sitting on the floor. Freddie hadn't touched them in ten minutes.

She stood up and walked over to the sofa. She picked up the bowl and placed it on the coffee table, right next to his head. It was a strategic move—he wouldn't have to sit up to reach it. He could just reach out a hand.

"Fuel is staged," Jessica said. "If you want it."

Freddie didn't move. He didn't reach for the cereal. The Emergency Brake was applied, and the wheels were locked. He wasn't eating. He wasn't watching TV. He was just holding on.

Jessica sat back down in the recliner. She glanced at the stack of textbooks on the floor—*Human Sexuality*, *Intro to Astronomy*.

"We have reading to do," Jessica noted, mostly to herself. "The Physiology chapter is dense. Dr. Thorne expects us to know the endocrine system by Wednesday."

Paige looked at the books, then down at Freddie. "Not right now," she said softly. "The server is down for maintenance. If we try to run a complex program like 'Endocrine Systems' right now, he'll crash."

"I know," Jessica agreed. She leaned back, pulling her legs up into the chair.

She looked at the three of them.

They were in their "Safe Mode" uniforms—flannel, jersey cotton, worn-out t-shirts. No bras, no jeans, no shoes. They were soft. They were vulnerable.

But they were together.

"We wait," Jessica decided. "We have twenty-four hours until the next class. We spend as many of them as he needs right here."

Paige continued the massage, her thumb working a knot out of Freddie's shoulder blade. Freddie let out a tiny, shuddering breath against her stomach, the first sign that the brake might be easing, just a fraction.

"We're here," Paige whispered to him. "Nowhere to go. Just us."

The homework sat on the floor, ignored. The TV stared blankly at them. But in the quiet room, the most important work was already being done. The Unit was holding the line until the Captain could come back online.

Scene 7: Manual Override

The stalemate in the living room broke not with a sound, but with a rumble.

Freddie's stomach growled—a low, demanding vibration that echoed through his chest and into Paige's lap.

The biological imperative had finally issued an override command. *Fuel required.*

Freddie slowly, incrementally turned his head. He peeled his face away from the soft cotton of Paige's shirt. His glasses were crooked, his hair messy. He blinked, his eyes adjusting to the soft light of the room.

He looked at the coffee table. The bowl of Honey Oat Rings was there, a beacon of beige carbohydrates.

He lifted his hand. It trembled slightly. The connection between his brain and his arm felt laggy, like a computer struggling to run a program with insufficient RAM. He reached out, his fingers twitching, but the distance felt infinite.

Jessica didn't wait for him to struggle.

She stood up from the recliner, closing her book. She walked over to the sofa, stepping quietly on the carpet. She didn't stand over him; that would be intimidating. Instead, she sat down directly on the coffee table, facing him.

She picked up the bowl.

"I got it," Jessica whispered.

She reached into the bowl and picked up a single oat ring. She held it out to him, hovering it right in front of his lips.

Freddie looked at the cereal. Then he looked at Jessica.

To an outsider, a twenty-year-old woman hand-feeding her eighteen-year-old brother might have looked strange. But inside the walls of 105 Pepper Street, it wasn't strange. It was a manual override. It was a bypass of the broken motor functions to ensure the system received power.

Freddie opened his mouth. Jessica placed the cereal on his tongue. He crunched it slowly.

"Good?" Jessica asked.

Freddie nodded slightly. "Texture... valid."

She offered him another. And another. She fed him like a bird, patient and steady. With every bite, a little bit of color returned to his cheeks. The sugar and the grain were doing their job, firing up the glucose receptors in his brain.

Paige adjusted her position, shifting slightly to support his upper back better so he could swallow easier. She kept her hand on his chest, feeling his heartbeat steadying.

"I appreciate... the assistance," Freddie whispered between bites. "Motor control is... laggy."

"We know," Jessica said, offering him a cluster of three rings this time. "That's why we're here. Admins have root access."

Freddie chewed. He looked down at himself—the soft grey pajama pants, the white t-shirt. He looked at Jessica in her flannel pants. He looked at Paige's legs stretched out on the sofa.

"Pajamas," Freddie noted. "Optimal uniform."

"The best," Jessica agreed. She set the bowl down on the table, now half-empty. "Fuel transfer complete for now."

She leaned forward, resting her elbows on her knees, bringing her face level with his. Her expression was gentle but serious—the look of a mechanic explaining a necessary repair.

"Freddie," Jessica said softly. "We can stay in pajamas all day. We are not leaving the perimeter. That is a promise."

Freddie nodded. That was good data.

"But," Jessica continued, "we have the *Physiology* chapter. It's dense. It's looming."

Freddie flinched slightly, the "Emergency Brake" threatening to re-engage.

"Listen to the logic," Jessica said quickly, putting a hand on his knee to stop the retreat. "If we wait until tonight, it will hang over your head all day. It will be a background process eating up your RAM. You won't be able to fully relax because you'll know the task is incomplete."

She pointed to the stack of books on the floor.

"If we do it now—just for an hour, while we're comfortable, while Paige is holding you—then it's done. The file is closed. And you can spend the rest of the day at 100% idle. No guilt. No deadlines. Just *Stellar Voyage* and naps."

Freddie processed the logic.

- **Option A:** Delay work. Result: Anxiety accumulation. Low-quality rest.
- **Option B:** Execute work now with support. Result: Task completion. High-quality rest. Total freedom.

It was efficient. It was the correct architectural decision.

"Clear the buffer," Freddie whispered.

"Exactly," Jessica smiled. "Clear the buffer."

"Okay," Freddie said. He pushed himself up a few inches, leaning heavily back against Paige's chest. "Retrieve the manual."

"Retrieving," Jessica said, reaching for the heavy textbook.

She didn't make him hold it. She opened it on her own lap, sitting on the coffee table in front of him, turning the book so they could all see.

"Chapter 5," Jessica announced, smoothing the page. "The Endocrine System. Let's learn about hormones."

Freddie adjusted his glasses. He was still drained. He was still in his sister's lap. But the panic was gone, replaced by the quiet, steady rhythm of learning.

"Proceed," Freddie said.

The Anatomy of Resilience

Scene 1: The Purge

The atmosphere in **Room 204** of Archer Hall was tense. The humidity of the Virginia summer pressed against the windows, but inside, the air conditioning kept the room at a crisp, clinical temperature.

Dr. Aris Thorne stood at the front of the room, her posture rigid. She did not look like a professor who was about to lecture; she looked like a general inspecting the troops before a battle.

On the whiteboard behind her, she had written a single word in stark, black letters:

ANATOMY

Freddie sat in his usual spot in the second row, flanked by the Avery Phalanx. Jessica was on his left, Paige on his right. His notebook was open. His pen was uncapped.

He was ready. The "Manual" had been reviewed. The data had been verified.

"Today," Dr. Thorne announced, her voice cutting through the murmurs of the class, "we begin our detailed study of the reproductive systems. We start with the female anatomy."

A ripple of nervous energy went through the room.

"As I stated on day one," Dr. Thorne continued, pacing slowly, "this is a science class. We will use proper terminology. We will view clinical diagrams. We will discuss function and physiology without euphemism."

She clicked a button on her remote. The overhead projector whirred to life.

A detailed, cross-section diagram appeared on the screen. It was clinical, labeled with numbers corresponding to structures like the uterus, fallopian tubes, and ovaries.

From the back row—the row Freddie had internally labeled "The Noise Sector"—came the sound.

It started as a snicker. Then a whisper. Then a distinct, frat-boy voice said something that was definitely not a medical term.

It was followed by a chorus of stifled laughter from three other guys sitting nearby. They were leaning back in their chairs, hats backward, clearly treating the lecture like a locker room joke.

Dr. Thorne didn't flinch. She didn't even look at the screen. She looked directly at the back row.

"Mr. Peterson," she said.

The laughter died instantly.

"Dr. Thorne?" the boy asked, trying to look innocent.

"Pack your bag," Dr. Thorne said. "And take Mr. Davies and Mr. Miller with you."

"Whoa, wait," Peterson protested, sitting up. "We didn't do anything. We were just—"

"You were demonstrating that you lack the maturity required to be in this room," Dr. Thorne interrupted, her voice ice cold. "I warned you on Monday. Zero tolerance."

She walked to her desk and picked up a red folder.

"Furthermore," she added, enjoying the moment, "today is July 16th. The deadline to drop a class with a refund passed on Friday. The deadline to withdraw with a 'W' grade passed yesterday at 5:00 PM."

The color drained from the boys' faces.

"That means," Dr. Thorne continued, "that when I administratively remove you from this roster for disruptive conduct, the Registrar will record a grade of **F**."

"You can't fail us!" one of the other boys shouted, standing up. "My GPA—"

"Your GPA reflects your performance," Dr. Thorne stated. "And your performance here is a failure. Get out."

The silence that followed was heavy. The three boys stood up, grabbing their bags with a mix of fury and humiliation. They stomped out of the room, muttering curses, slamming the door behind them so hard the frame rattled.

Dr. Thorne watched the door close. Then she turned back to the class.

She looked at the remaining students. The room felt different now. It was lighter. The "static" was gone.

The only people left were the ones who were writing notes. The nursing students. The psychology majors. And the Avery Unit.

"Now," Dr. Thorne said, her voice returning to a calm, lecture tone. "That concludes the filtration process. Let us proceed with the science."

She pointed to the diagram on the screen.

"Who can identify Structure Number 4?"

Freddie looked at the screen. He looked at the diagram. It matched the one in his textbook perfectly.

He didn't giggle. He didn't blush. He raised his hand.

"Yes, Mr. Avery?" Dr. Thorne asked.

"Structure Number 4 is the Fallopian Tube," Freddie stated clearly. "It serves as the transport vessel for the ova."

"Correct," Dr. Thorne nodded. "Excellent terminology."

Freddie lowered his hand. He felt Paige squeeze his arm. He felt Jessica bump his shoulder.

He looked around the room. The creeps were gone. The noise was gone.

"Stable," Freddie whispered to himself. "The class is stable."

Scene 2: The Buffer

The walk from Archer Hall to **Newman Library** was different today. The air was still hot, the humidity still oppressive, but the social atmosphere was lighter.

The "Noise Sector" had been purged. The class roster had been refined down to the serious, the studious, and the Avery Unit.

They entered the library, the automatic doors sliding open to release a blast of cool, book-scented air. It was a smell Freddie loved—paper, adhesive, and the quiet hum of concentration.

"Study Room 4 is booked," Jessica announced, checking her watch. "We have it until 16:15. That gives us two hours to build the buffer."

They bypassed the main stacks and headed for the group study rooms on the second floor. These were glass-walled aquariums of silence, perfect for isolation.

Jessica swiped her **PolyPass** to unlock the door.

"Base established," Freddie whispered, stepping inside.

The table was round, but they sat in a semi-circle—Jessica on the left, Paige in the middle, Freddie on the right.

The laptop deployment began.

Jessica opened her sleek **Titanium MagnaByte**. It was the envy of the engineering department—thin, metallic, and running the proprietary Magna-OS.

Paige opened her standard-issue **Quantum**. It was a boxy, beige workhorse, identical to the ones in the campus labs.

Freddie set up his workstation with the precision of a field medic. He opened his heavy **Iron-Logic** laptop. He didn't reach for the trackpad. His spastic diplegia made the small, sensitive surface a nightmare; his fingers would jump or drag, sending the cursor flying across the screen in erratic vectors.

Instead, he reached into his bag and pulled out his **Digi-Track**—a heavy, stationary mouse with a large red ball on top. He didn't have to move his arm to use it; he just had to roll the ball with his palm or fingers. It was stable. It was precise.

He plugged the USB cable into the side port. *Ding-dong.* The computer recognized the device.

"Input device active," Freddie confirmed, rolling the red ball. The cursor moved smoothly to the browser icon.

"Okay," Jessica said, logging into the **Edu-Link** portal. "Dr. Thorne posted the assignment for next week. It's a labeling exercise and a short reflection on the physiological differences between the male and female response cycles."

"I have the diagrams," Freddie said, navigating to the file directory where he saved his scans.

"We work together," Jessica instructed. "We discuss the answers. But we type our own words. Academic honesty is non-negotiable. If we get flagged for plagiarism, we lose the scholarship."

"Understood," Paige said, cracking her knuckles. "Let's do this."

For an hour, the only sounds in the room were the clicking of keys, the rolling of Freddie's trackball, and the low murmurs of collaboration.

"Structure 7," Freddie asked, squinting at the screen. "Is that the fimbriae or the ovary?"

"Look at the attachment point," Paige guided him, pointing to her own screen. "It's the finger-like projections at the end of the tube."

"Fimbriae," Freddie corrected himself. "Catching the ova."

He typed the answer. His typing was slow—he used a "hunt and peck" method with two fingers—but it was accurate. He didn't rush. He didn't panic.

They moved through the assignment with the efficiency of a well-oiled machine. There was no "I'll do it later." There was no procrastination.

Jessica kept them on track. "Reflection question," she read. "Discuss the role of the refractory period."

"System reboot," Freddie muttered, typing. *'A mandatory recovery phase in the male physiological cycle where restimulation is impossible.'*

"Good phrasing," Jessica noted, glancing at his screen. "Clinical."

Freddie clicked the final box on the digital form.

He rolled the red ball over to the **SUBMIT** button. He hovered there for a second, savoring the moment.

The class didn't meet again until Friday. The homework wasn't due until Monday.

If he clicked this button now, the "Deadline" variable would be deleted from his mental RAM. If he had a meltdown tomorrow, or if his batteries drained to zero again, it wouldn't matter. The work was done.

"Click it," Paige whispered.

Click.

SUBMISSION CONFIRMED. GRADE STATUS: PENDING

Freddie let out a long exhale. He leaned back in his chair, taking his hand off the trackball.

"Buffer established," Freddie announced.

Jessica clicked submit on her own screen a second later. Paige followed.

"We are clear," Jessica smiled, closing her MagnaByte with a satisfying *snap*. "No homework for five days. The weekend is ours."

"Zero anxiety," Freddie noted. "The queue is empty."

He unplugged his mouse, winding the cord carefully. He packed his heavy laptop.

He looked at his sisters. They weren't just study partners; they were his safety net. They had anticipated the crash and built a guardrail before he even got close to the edge.

"Thank you," Freddie whispered. "For the... pre-emptive maintenance."

"Always," Paige said, slinging her bag over her shoulder. "Now come on. We have fifteen minutes left on the room reservation, but I say we get out of here early. I think there's a frozen yogurt place in the Student Center that needs our attention."

"Frozen yogurt," Freddie agreed, standing up. "Texture: Smooth. Temperature: Cold. Variable accepted."

They walked out of the library, leaving the stress of the assignment behind them in the digital ether, stepping back into the summer afternoon with nothing but free time ahead.

Scene 3: The Quiet Room

The morning of the Midterm Exam did not begin with panic. It began with logistics.

The Avery Unit stood at the crossroads of the Drillfield, a paved hub where the paths to different academic buildings diverged. To the left lay Archer Hall, where the main body of HPE 204 would assemble to take their test in the standard, fluorescent-lit classroom.

To the right lay Henderson Hall, the home of Services for Students with Disabilities (SSD).

"Operational check," Jessica announced, adjusting her backpack. She looked at Freddie. "You have your implements?"

Freddie patted his pocket. "Two Titan Graphite No. 2 pencils. One polymer eraser. One bottle of water, label removed per testing center protocol."

"And the data?" Paige asked, smoothing the collar of his grey t-shirt.

"The database is indexed," Freddie tapped his temple. "Anatomy. Physiology. The endocrine system. The variables are locked."

"Good," Jessica said. She checked her watch. "Our exam starts at 10:00. Yours starts at 10:00, but you have the 'Double Time' modification. That gives you until 12:00. We will be done by 11:00."

"Rendezvous point?" Freddie asked.

"The bench outside Henderson," Paige said. "We'll come to you. Don't move. Just wait."

"Understood," Freddie said. He looked at the split in the path.

Usually, separation induced a spike in his cortisol levels. The idea of entering a building without his flank guards was a "High Risk" scenario. But today felt different. He wasn't going into a chaotic lecture hall filled with whispering students and unpredictable social variables.

He was going to the Quiet Room.

"Go get 'em, Captain," Paige smiled, squeezing his hand one last time before letting go. "Show them you know the schematics."

"Affirmative," Freddie said.

He turned and walked toward Henderson Hall. He didn't look back. He focused on his gait—heel, toe, heel, toe—keeping his rhythm steady.

The SSD Testing Center was a sanctuary of silence. The floor was carpeted in a thick, sound-absorbing weave. The walls were painted a soothing, neutral beige.

Freddie walked to the front desk. The receptionist—the same woman who had helped him with the intake forms—smiled.

"Good morning, Freddie," she whispered. "You're in Carrel 4 today."

She handed him the exam packet. It was sealed in a large manila envelope.

Freddie walked to Carrel 4. It was a high-walled cubicle, creating a visual "blinder" effect that blocked out the rest of the room. Inside, there was a simple desk, a comfortable chair, and a white noise machine set to "Low Fan."

He sat down. He arranged his pencils. He took a sip of water.

He broke the seal on the envelope.

He pulled out the exam. HPE 204: MIDTERM EXAMINATION.

He looked at the clock on the wall. 10:00 AM. He had two hours. The pressure valve in his chest released. Without the ticking clock of a standard 50-minute period, the anxiety of "running out of time" vanished.

He turned to Page 1.

Question 1: Define the function of the Epididymis.

Freddie smiled. The data appeared in his mind like a pop-up window in an operating system. *Storage and maturation vessel for sperm cells. Located on the posterior surface of the testes.*

He filled in the bubble on the Opti-Scan sheet. The graphite moved smoothly.

He moved through the multiple-choice section with mechanical precision. He didn't second-guess. He didn't get distracted by the sound of someone else coughing (because in the Quiet Room, no one coughed, or if they did, the white noise machine ate the sound).

Then, he reached Page 5. The Diagrams.

There were two large, black-and-white line drawings. Cross-sections.

Figure A: Female Reproductive System (Lateral View). Figure B: Male Reproductive System (Lateral View).

The instructions were simple: *Label structures 1 through 10.*

Freddie looked at Figure A.

To a standard student, this was just a drawing in a book. It was abstract lines and shapes.

But Freddie had the "Source Code."

He closed his eyes for a microsecond. He accessed the memory file from Monday afternoon—the "Verification Session" in the living room.

He didn't see anything salacious. He didn't see "pornography." He saw the clinical reality. He remembered Jessica sitting on the coffee table, the textbook open, pointing to her own anatomy to clarify the difference between the *urethra* and the *introitus* because the diagram in the book was confusingly drawn.

He remembered Paige explaining the angle of the *uterus* based on where she felt cramps.

The mystery was gone. The shame was gone. It was just hardware.

He looked back at the paper. Structure #3 pointed to the muscular wall of the uterus.

Myometrium, Freddie wrote in neat, block letters.

Structure #7 pointed to the external fold of skin protecting the vestibule.

Labia Majora, he wrote.

He moved to Figure B. Again, the memory file opened. He recalled the discussion about the *vas deferens* and how it routed around the bladder—a piece of biological plumbing that Freddie had found inefficient but fascinating during their study session.

He labeled the *Prostate Gland*. He labeled the *Seminal Vesicle*.

He finished the diagrams in four minutes.

He sat back in his chair. He was only forty-five minutes into a two-hour block.

He checked his work. Every bubble was dark. Every label was legible.

He felt a surge of pride. Not just because he knew the answers, but because he was sitting in a room by himself, handling the subject matter without a single tremor of embarrassment.

The "Robert Virus"—the voice that told him bodies were dirty and he was broken—was silent. It couldn't survive in this environment of pure data.

Freddie Avery stood up. He walked to the front desk.

"Finished?" the receptionist whispered, looking surprised.

"Output complete," Freddie confirmed. "Time elapsed: 52 minutes."

He handed over the packet. He walked out of the quiet building into the heat of the July morning, feeling lighter than air.

Freddie sat on the wooden bench outside Henderson Hall. He had his orange hoodie draped over his lap (too hot to wear, but necessary to have nearby).

He watched the stream of students pouring out of Archer Hall across the Drillfield.

He spotted them immediately.

Jessica was walking with a long, confident stride, her backpack slung over one shoulder. Paige was right beside her, matching her pace.

They saw him on the bench. Paige waved, a big, sweeping motion.

They closed the distance.

"You're out early!" Paige said, dropping her bag on the grass and sitting next to him. "How was it?"

"The environment was optimal," Freddie reported. "White noise. Visual barriers. Zero friction."

"And the test?" Jessica asked, sitting on his other side.

"I decimated it," Freddie stated flatly.

Jessica laughed, high-fiving him. "That's what I like to hear. The diagrams?"

"Labeled," Freddie said. "The reference data... proved useful. The textbook illustrations regarding the *fimbriae* are spatially misleading, but I corrected for the distortion based on our review."

"Good," Paige smiled, leaning her head on his shoulder. "We crushed it too. I think I missed one on the hormone cycle, but the rest was easy."

"So," Jessica stood up, dusting off her jeans. "Midterm: Conquered. That means the 'Study Block' is officially lifted."

She looked at her siblings.

"We have the rest of the day. We have mobility. We have a car. What is the celebration protocol?"

Freddie thought about it. He ran the options.

- *Option A:* Go home. Safe, but routine.
- *Option B:* The Mall. Loud, chaotic.
- *Option C:* Something new. Something they hadn't done yet because they were too busy surviving.

He looked at the sky. It was blue, clear, and vast.

"I require... elevation," Freddie said.

"Elevation?" Paige asked.

"We are in the mountains," Freddie observed. "But we have remained at street level. I want to see the grid from above."

Jessica grinned. "I know a spot. It's called Wind Rock. It's a bit of a hike—about a mile—but the trail is wide. It's on the Appalachian Trail."

She looked at Freddie's legs. "It's uneven terrain. Roots. Rocks. Can you handle the input?"

Freddie looked at his sisters. He felt the phantom weight of Paige's arm around his waist, the solid presence of Jessica on his left.

He thought about the "Machine" of the football team, the "Engine" of the wheelchair singer.

"If I stumble," Freddie said, "the Unit will stabilize."

"Damn straight," Jessica said. "To the Avalon. We're going to the top of the world."

Scene 4: The Transit & The Trail

The celebration at the bench was brief; the heat of the day was rising, and the logistics of the next phase required execution.

"We have a vehicle problem," Freddie noted, checking his watch as they stood up. "The Avalon is docked at Base. We are at CPI. Displacement is six miles."

"Standard retrieval protocol," Jessica said, swinging her backpack onto one shoulder. "We catch the **Route 1** southbound. It drops us right at our front door."

They walked from Henderson Hall across the Drillfield to **Alumni Mall**.

There was no terminal here, no sleek concrete loop. The "hub" was simply the side of the road. Buses lined up bumper-to-bumper along the curb across from **Newman Hall**, fighting for space with cars and pedestrians jaywalking to the student center. It was a chaotic, diesel-choked strip of asphalt that served as the nerve center of the transit network.

They stood at the signpost marking the Route 1 stop, waiting as a bus pulled away, revealing the next one in the queue.

"Inbound," Freddie announced.

The white-and-maroon **Blue Ridge Transit** bus hissed as it kneeled to the curb, its tires grinding against the concrete gutter. The amber LED sign read:

1 FALLING BRANCH

"Boarding," Jessica commanded.

They climbed the steps, flashing their **PolyPasses**. The chirp of the card reader was a familiar, comforting sound—the sound of authorized access in the middle of the street-side chaos.

They moved to the back. Freddie took the window seat. The bus pulled out, merging aggressively into the traffic on the Mall before turning onto Main Street.

For thirty minutes, Freddie decompressed. The exam was over. The diagrams were labeled. The "Robert Virus" had tried to delete his confidence, but the system had held. He watched the familiar landmarks of the commute roll by: the stone arches of the university giving way to the strip malls of the 460 corridor, the transition from "Gown" to "Town."

"Approaching **Pepper Plaza**," the automated voice announced.

The bus turned off the highway and navigated into the small, concrete transit hub in downtown Christiansburg. It wasn't pretty—just a sawtooth curb cut

into a lot with a few heavy, weathered shelters—but it was efficient. The bus docked in its bay with a heavy *thud* of air brakes.

They stepped off the bus onto the stained concrete of the plaza. The heat in the valley was heavy, but the sight of their white house directly diagonally across the street was grounding.

"Quick turnaround," Paige said as they jogged across the street to the driveway. "Bathroom, water, car."

They entered the cool sanctuary of the house just long enough to grab water bottles and use the facilities. Freddie swapped his testing pencils for his hiking gear—zipping his safety-orange hoodie over his t-shirt despite the July heat. It was his armor against insects, branches, and the unknown variables of the woods.

"I'm driving," Jessica announced, grabbing the keys to the silver **Horizon Avalon** from the hook. "It's a mountain road. I want the control of the stick."

They piled into the car. Jessica depressed the clutch, shifted into Reverse, and backed out of the driveway. She shifted to First, and they rolled past the bus idling in the plaza, heading for the mountains.

The drive took them out of the valley and up a winding, two-lane road that climbed steadily into the canopy of the Appalachian chain. The air changed as they ascended—thinning out, losing the heavy humidity of the town and gaining the sharp, pine-resin scent of the high altitude.

Jessica parked the Avalon in the gravel lot of the **Wind Rock** trailhead. She set the handbrake with a firm *ratchet-click*.

"Engine off," she said. "We are on foot."

" hydration check," Paige said, handing Freddie a water bottle.

"The trail is this way," Jessica pointed to a blaze painted on a tree.

They started the climb.

It wasn't easy. The path was a mix of packed dirt and jagged limestone rocks—an ankle-twisting nightmare for anyone, but a complex physics calculation for Freddie.

Every step required conscious input. *Angle of foot placement. Friction coefficient of the rock. Balance distribution.*

His spastic muscles fought him. Ten minutes in, his right toe dragged, catching on an exposed root. He stumbled forward, gravity taking hold.

"Gotcha," Paige said instantly.

She didn't gasp. She didn't panic. She had linked arms with him the moment they left the car, and now she simply tightened her grip, using her own momentum to pull him upright.

"Course correction," Freddie murmured, regaining his footing.

"Keep moving," Paige said comfortably. "We're a tank. Tanks go over everything."

They fell into a rhythm. Jessica walked ahead, scouting the path like a point man.

"Big step coming up," she'd call out. "Loose gravel on the left. Stay center."

Paige walked beside him, their hips bumping occasionally, her body acting as a constant gyroscopic stabilizer. She adjusted her speed to match his, absorbing his stumbles before they became falls.

They climbed for forty-five minutes. Freddie was sweating under his hoodie. His legs burned with lactic acid. The sensory input of the forest—the crunch of dry leaves, the cry of a hawk, the wind in the trees—was intense, but it wasn't static. It was organic. It was a natural frequency he could process.

"Almost there," Jessica called from a ridge above them. "One last push."

They scrambled up a final embankment of grey stone.

And then, the world opened up.

They stepped out onto a massive, flat outcropping of rock that jutted out over the valley floor like the prow of a ship.

There were no trees here. Just stone, wind, and sky.

Freddie stopped. He forgot about his burning legs. He forgot about the sweat trickling down his back.

Below him, the **New River Valley** spread out like a living map. He could see the tiny ribbon of the river reflecting the sun. He could see the geometric grid of the farmlands.

In the distance, he could see the toy-like structures of the university—the "Iron City" reduced to a circuit board.

"The scale," Freddie whispered, adjusting his glasses. "It is... infinite."

He walked toward the edge (not too close; Paige held his belt loop just in case).

He looked at the horizon. It was a flat, blue line where the mountains met the sky.

"We are above the noise," Paige said, standing next to him. The wind whipped her hair across her face, but she looked peaceful.

"High altitude," Freddie agreed. "Signal clarity is 100%."

Jessica sat down on the warm rock, opening her backpack. "Who wants a victory snack? I have **Choco-Bricks** and **Fizzy-Pop**."

Freddie sat down carefully, pulling his knees to his chest. He took the chocolate wafer bar.

He ate it slowly, looking out at the world.

For the first time in his life, he didn't feel small. He felt like he was sitting on the bridge of his own starship, looking out at the galaxy.

He had passed the test. He had navigated the medical system. He had climbed the mountain.

He looked at his sisters.

"We are functional," Freddie stated.

"We are fully operational," Jessica corrected, clinking her soda can against his water bottle.

"To the Unit," Paige said, clinking hers.

"To the Unit," Freddie whispered.

They sat there for an hour, watching the cloud shadows drift across the valley—three specks on a rock who had built their own world out of spare parts, bus schedules, and stubborn love.

And for Freddie Avery, the view was perfect.

Scene 5: The Recharge

The descent from **Wind Rock** was faster than the ascent, aided by gravity and the adrenaline of success.

They reached the gravel lot where the **Horizon Avalon** waited, its silver paint dusty from the mountain air.

"Decontamination required," Jessica noted, unlocking the doors. "We are covered in particulate matter."

"Dirt," Paige smiled, wiping a smudge from her cheek. "It's good dirt."

They piled into the car. Jessica started the engine, and the AC blasted cool air into the cabin.

Freddie sat in the passenger seat. Usually, after a physical exertion of this magnitude—a mile hike over uneven terrain in 90-degree heat—he would be in "System Failure."

He would be non-verbal. He would be shaking. He would require immediate horizontal stabilization in the "Recharge Mode"—head in Paige's lap, arm over his chest, total silence.

But as the car wound its way down the mountain road, Freddie sat upright.

He looked out the window at the passing trees. His legs burned, yes. His shirt was soaked with sweat.

But his mind was clear. The static wasn't there.

"Status check?" Paige asked from the back seat, leaning forward to check on him. "Battery level?"

Freddie blinked. He ran a diagnostic.

Energy: Low. Physical Fatigue: High. Mental Clarity: Maximum.

"Battery is... functional," Freddie said, surprised. "I do not require the brake."

"Really?" Jessica glanced at him. "No crash?"

"No crash," Freddie confirmed. "The input was organic. The wind. The rock. The view. It was high-bandwidth, but it was... compatible."

He looked at the forest flashing by. He thought about the silence of the summit.

It wasn't the artificial silence of the testing center, created by white noise machines and soundproofing. It was real silence.

"I enjoyed the isolation," Freddie murmured. "No sirens. No crowds. No friction."

"It's peaceful up here," Paige agreed. "Just us and the bears."

"Bears?" Freddie asked.

"Black bears," Jessica said. "They live in the woods. But they leave you alone if you leave them alone."

Freddie processed this. A biological entity that respected boundaries.

"I have a new objective," Freddie announced suddenly.

"Oh yeah?" Jessica shifted gears as they hit the bottom of the mountain. "What's the mission?"

"Camping," Freddie stated.

"Camping?" Paige laughed. "Like, in a tent?"

"Affirmative," Freddie said, his mind already building the schematic. "Rugged back country. Not a campground with RVs and generators. The wild."

He turned in his seat to look at them.

"I want to spend a night in the signal-free zone. Just the Unit. In a tent. Sleeping on the ground."

Jessica raised an eyebrow. "Freddie, none of us know how to camp. We're suburban kids. We consider 'roughing it' to be a hotel without **PBO** (Premiere Box Office)."

"We can learn," Freddie insisted. "There are manuals. There are equipment lists. We can acquire the gear."

He looked at the mountain receding in the rearview mirror.

"I want to see the stars from the ground," he whispered. "Without the light pollution of the streetlamps."

Paige leaned forward and wrapped her arms around his shoulders from the back seat.

"I'm in," she said. "If you want to sleep in the woods, we sleep in the woods. I'll fight the bears."

"I'll bring the bug spray," Jessica sighed, but she was smiling. "Okay. Add it to the bucket list. 'Operation: Wilderness.' "

Freddie settled back into his seat. He didn't need to lie down. He didn't need to hide.

He watched the trees turn back into telephone poles, the dirt road turn back into pavement.

He was tired, but he wasn't broken. The mountain had recharged him in a way the sofa never could.

"Operation: Wilderness," Freddie repeated. "Status: Pending."

The Avalon rolled back into the heat of the valley, carrying three explorers who had just found a new map.

Scene 6: The Drive-Thru

The silver **Horizon Avalon** merged off the highway and back onto the main drag of Christiansburg. The transition from the cool, pine-scented air of the mountain to the humid, asphalt-scented air of the valley was abrupt.

Freddie sat in the passenger seat, his body cooling down. But with the cooling came the stiffness.

The adrenaline that had powered him up the trail was gone, replaced by a heavy, leaden fatigue. His spastic muscles, agitated by the uneven terrain, were beginning to tighten up like shrinking leather.

"Status report," Jessica said, downshifting as they hit the first traffic light on Roanoke Street. "How are the legs?"

"Seized," Freddie admitted, staring at the dashboard. "Mobility is... compromised. If I stand up now, I might not sit down again."

"Hunger level?" Paige asked from the back.

"Critical," Freddie said. "Caloric deficit is high."

"We need food," Jessica decided. "But we need it fast. I don't think you can handle a sit-down restaurant wait."

"Negative," Freddie said. "I request... minimal transitions. I want to get out of the car exactly one time: when we reach Base."

"Drive-thru it is," Jessica nodded. She signaled left.

Directly ahead, at the corner of Roanoke Street and First Street—practically in the shadow of their own neighborhood—stood the familiar, backlit sign of **Brawny Burger**.

In 2003, Brawny Burger was in the middle of a rebranding revolution. They were moving away from the smaller burgers of the 90s and doubling down on massive, charbroiled beasts known as the **Thick-Stack**.

"Target acquired," Jessica said, pulling the Avalon into the loop. "103 Roanoke Street. It is literally walking distance from our house, but today, we drive."

"Efficiency," Freddie murmured, grateful he didn't have to walk the hundred yards.

They pulled up to the speaker box. The tinny voice crackled. *"Welcome to Brawny Burger. Try our new 1/3 Pound Thick-Stack today."*

"Order protocol," Jessica said, looking at Freddie.

"The **1/3 lb. Original Thick-Stack**," Freddie ordered clearly. "Cheese. Ketchup only. Large fries. Large **Mega-Cola**."

"Classic," Jessica said. She leaned out the window. "One Original Thick-Stack combo, large, Mega-Cola. Ketchup only."

"I'll take the **Mushroom & Swiss**," Paige added from the back. "And a Strawberry Shake."

"And let me get a **Crispy Chicken Sandwich**," Jessica finished. She checked the menu board, confirming the breakfast menu was long gone—hidden behind the plastic slats of the lunch board. "And a side of onion rings."

"Pull around," the voice said.

Jessica paid with cash from the Avery Grant fund. She handed the warm, grease-stained paper bags to Freddie.

The smell of charbroiled beef and salty fries filled the cabin. It was intoxicating.

"Hold the payload," Jessica commanded. "We are two minutes from docking."

She pulled out of the Brawny Burger lot, turned right onto First Street, and then made the immediate left onto Pepper Street.

Scene 7: Dinner

They pulled into the driveway. The house stood waiting, white and solid.

"Okay," Jessica said, killing the engine. "This is the hard part. The dismount."

Freddie unbuckled his seatbelt. He took a deep breath. He knew his legs were going to scream.

"I got the food," Paige said, hopping out of the back and grabbing the warm, grease-stained bags from his lap. "You just focus on the landing gear."

Jessica came around to the passenger side and opened the door. She offered her arm.

"On three," she said. "One. Two. Up."

Freddie grabbed her arm and hauled himself out. His knees buckled slightly, trembling under the sudden return of gravity, but he locked them.

"Stable?" Jessica asked.

"Stable," Freddie gritted out. "Forward motion."

He walked stiffly up the concrete path, focusing on the front door. Every step was a victory.

They entered the house. The air conditioning hit them instantly—cool, dry, and smelling of lemon polish.

"Dining room," Paige called out, heading for the small wooden table adjacent to the kitchen.

"Audio protocol," Jessica said as she locked the door. She picked up the remote for the small counter-top TV in the kitchen—a secondary unit to the massive MagnaView in the living room.

She pressed power.

Click.

The screen flared to life, displaying the blue-and-gold graphics of **WNRV-TV Channel 11**, the local GBS affiliate broadcasting out of Blacksburg.

"...temperatures remaining in the upper 80s through the evening," the weatherman announced, waving at a map of the New River Valley. *"So if you're headed out to the County Fair this weekend, bring plenty of water."*

"Background noise established," Jessica said, turning the volume to a low, companionable hum.

They sat down at the dining table. Freddie sank into his chair with a groan of pure relief. The familiar cadence of the local news anchors—talking about road work on I-81 and a bake sale in Riner—was a grounding signal. It meant they were back in civilization.

"You made it," Jessica smiled, distributing the food.

She placed the massive, foil-wrapped **Thick-Stack** in front of him. She set the large cup of bubbling dark soda next to it.

Freddie unwrapped the burger. It was hot, heavy, and simple.

He took a bite. The grease, the cheese, the beef—it hit his system like a recharge pack.

"Status?" Paige asked, dipping a fry into her strawberry shake.

Freddie chewed slowly. He looked at his sisters. They were sweaty, tired, and smelling of the woods. They were eating fast food at a cheap table in a rental house, bathed in the soft glow of the local news.

But they had climbed a mountain. They had beaten the test. They had secured the perimeter.

"Status," Freddie said, taking a long pull of the cold **Mega-Cola**. "Optimal."

On the TV, the news anchor shuffled his papers. *"Coming up at 5:30, we'll have a report on the new construction over at the university. But first, a word from* ***Holt Automotive****."*

He took another bite.

"The camping trip," Freddie said between chews. "I have determined the menu."

"Oh?" Jessica raised an eyebrow over her **Crispy Chicken Sandwich**. "What are we eating in the wild?"

"Hot dogs," Freddie stated firmly. "Roasted on a stick. It is the only logical campfire protein."

"Hot dogs it is," Paige agreed. "And s'mores?"

"S'mores are mandatory," Freddie confirmed.

They ate their Brawny Burgers in the quiet safety of the Iron City, planning their next mission while the WNRV news ticker scrolled by, knowing that whatever mountain came next, they would climb it the same way: together.

Scene 8: The Cost-Benefit Analysis

The dining room was quiet, save for the crinkling of foil wrappers and the low hum of the television on the kitchen counter.

Freddie was halfway through his **Thick-Stack**, eating methodically around the circumference to save the center—the "prime bite"—for last. The combination of heavy protein, salt, and sugar (the **Mega-Cola**) was bringing his systems back online. The tremor in his hands from the mountain descent had faded to a manageable vibration.

On the small screen, the WNRV news anchor—a woman with hair sprayed into an immovable helmet of blonde—smiled brightly.

"And finally tonight," she announced, the graphic behind her shifting to an image of a Ferris wheel silhouetted against a sunset. *"Get your walking shoes ready, folks. The* ***Great Valley Fair*** *opens this Friday at the* ***Valley Civic Pavilion*** *in Salem."*

Paige looked up from her fries. "The Fair," she murmured. "I haven't been to a fair since we were kids. Funnel cakes."

"That's right," the weatherman chimed in. *"They've got the 'Fireball' ride this year, the petting zoo, and of course, the giant slide. Gates open at noon. Expect heavy traffic on Interstate 81 near Exit 141."*

Jessica wiped ketchup from her lip. "It does sound kind of fun. Greasy food. People watching. We could win a goldfish."

She looked at Freddie. "What do you think, Captain? We conquered a mountain today. You think we can conquer the midway?"

Freddie stopped chewing. He looked at the TV screen, which was now showing b-roll footage from last year's fair.

He saw the flashing strobe lights of the Tilt-A-Whirl. He saw the screaming children running through the crowd. He saw the dense, shoulder-to-shoulder pack of people fighting for space in the heat.

He ran a simulation.

- **Input:** Flashing lights.
- **Variable:** Screaming machinery.
- **Variable:** Unpredictable touching by strangers.
- **Variable:** Smells (Deep fryer grease mixed with livestock manure and diesel generator exhaust).

"Negative," Freddie stated, putting his burger down. "The proposal is rejected."

"Too much?" Paige asked gently.

"It is a sensory minefield," Freddie explained, pointing a fry at the screen. "Look at the density. There is no grid. People move in chaotic vectors. The noise level of the midway is likely exceeding 100 decibels. And the rides..." He shuddered. "Spinning induces nausea. Sudden drops induce panic. It is an environment designed to induce vomiting."

"But... funnel cake," Jessica countered weakly. "Fried dough. Powdered sugar."

"The caloric reward does not justify the sensory cost," Freddie ruled. "The ratio is inefficient."

He picked up his burger again.

"Besides," Freddie added, "we have a superior mission pending."

"Operation: Wilderness," Paige smiled.

"Correct," Freddie said. "The woods offer silence. The Fair offers static. I choose silence."

Jessica nodded, taking a bite of her chicken sandwich. "You know what? You're right. Why pay twenty bucks to get a headache and step in goat poop when we can go sleep in the woods for free?"

"Exactly," Freddie said. "The logic is sound."

"Camping it is," Paige agreed. "Although... we could probably replicate the funnel cake here. I bet we can buy a mix."

"Acceptable compromise," Freddie noted. "Controlled environment frying."

On the TV, the news ended. The screen faded to the **GBS Evening Report** logo. The serious, orchestral theme song played—a signal that the "fun" news was over and the "real" news was beginning.

"Volume up," Freddie requested. "David Clark is on."

Jessica adjusted the remote. The anchor appeared, looking grave and trustworthy.

"Good evening. In Washington tonight... "

They settled in. The sun began to dip lower outside, casting long shadows across the table. The Great Valley Fair could keep its flashing lights and screaming crowds.

Here, in the dining room of 105 Pepper Street, they had burgers, they had a plan, and they had the quiet.

And for the Avery Unit, that was the only ride they needed.

Scene 9: The Analog Archive

The dining room table was cleared. The Brawny Burger wrappers were in the trash. The "Thick-Stack" fuel had done its job.

They moved to the living room. The sun had finally set behind the mountains, and the house was lit only by the soft, amber glow of the floor lamp in the corner.

Jessica sat cross-legged on the beige carpet in front of the TV stand. A plastic crate, hauled all the way from Virginia Beach, sat open next to her.

"Inventory time," Jessica announced, pulling out a stack of plastic clamshell cases. "If we're going to survive the summer without a cable movie package, the tape library is critical infrastructure."

Freddie stood by the sofa. His legs were tired from the mountain, aching with a dull, satisfying burn, but his mind was clear. The static was gone.

He looked at Paige, who was already seated in the corner of the couch, fluffing a pillow on her lap. She looked up at him and patted the cushion.

"Docking bay open," she smiled.

Usually, Freddie engaged this protocol because his battery was at 0%. He did it because he *had* to—because if he didn't, he would crash.

Tonight, his battery was at 60%. He could have sat in the recliner. He could have sat on the floor with Jessica.

But he didn't want to.

He wanted the weight. He wanted the warmth. He wanted the specific, tangible feeling of being held by his favorite person in the world.

"Initiating docking sequence," Freddie murmured.

He climbed onto the sofa. He lay down on his side, settling his head into the soft cradle of Paige's lap. He curled his legs up, fitting his body against the back cushions.

Paige draped her arm over his chest immediately. Her hand settled over his heart—a heavy, grounding weight.

He didn't *need* the grounding to stop a panic attack tonight. He just liked it. It felt like a seatbelt. It felt like home.

"Comfortable?" Paige whispered, her fingers idly tracing the zipper of his orange hoodie.

"Optimal," Freddie breathed, closing his eyes for a second to savor the contact. "Affection levels... high."

"Category check," Jessica said from the floor, interrupting the moment with administrative efficiency.

"We have the Animation Block," she listed, stacking tapes. "The Action Block. And... the Holy Trinity."

She reached into the bottom of the crate and pulled out a shimmering Gold Box Set. It was heavy, battering at the corners from years of use.

GALAXY WARS: THE TRILOGY

Freddie's eyes snapped open. He lifted his head slightly. "The sacred texts."

"We have all three," Jessica confirmed, reading the spines. " *Hope of the Rebellion* , *The Imperial Counterattack* , and *Return of the Sentinels* ."

"And the prequels?" Paige asked.

"DVD shelf," Jessica pointed to the small rack by the TV. " *The Shadow Protocol* and *Rise of the Replicants* are digital. But the originals... these are analog. You can't replace the tracking fuzz."

Freddie looked at the gold box. He felt a specific, warm familiarity wash over him.

" *Return of the Sentinels* ," Freddie murmured. "Episode Six."

"Your favorite," Paige smiled, smoothing his hair back. "Why do you like that one best? Everyone says *Counterattack* is the cinematic masterpiece."

" *Counterattack* is unresolved," Freddie stated, settling his head back down into her lap. "The narrative arc is severed. The captain is frozen in carbonite. The hero is maimed. The system is left in chaos. It creates anxiety."

He pointed a finger toward the gold box.

" *Return* resolves the chord. The Battle Station is destroyed. The Dark Emperor is deleted. The father is redeemed. Balance is restored to the Galaxy."

"Plus," Jessica grinned, sliding the tape out of its sleeve, "you like the fuzzy guys."

"They are not just fuzzy guys," Freddie corrected, though his voice lacked any real bite. "They are the **Forest Dwellers**. They are an indigenous species utilizing guerrilla warfare tactics against a technologically superior force. It is a prime example of asymmetrical combat."

"Sure," Paige laughed softly, her chest vibrating against his back. "Asymmetrical combat with cute ears."

"Also," Freddie added, his voice softening as he looked at the ceiling, "The Sanctuary Moon. The trees. The bunkers."

He visualized the scene where the speeder bikes raced through the giant redwoods.

"It looks like the trail we walked today," Freddie realized. "The ferns. The light filtering through the canopy. It is... attainable."

"That's true," Jessica said, holding the tape. "Maybe that's where we go for 'Operation: Wilderness.' We find a forest that looks like the Sanctuary Moon."

"Confirmed," Freddie whispered. "We will establish a base camp in the forest."

He watched Jessica place the gold box on the shelf, right next to his recorded tapes of *W-JAM* and *The Local*.

Theme songs. Orchestral scores. Structured narratives.

His world was made of stories that had rules, and music that resolved.

"Play the theme," Freddie requested softly.

"We just watched TV," Jessica said. "You want to watch a movie? It's getting late."

"No," Freddie said. "Just the opening. The fanfare. I need to hear the brass section. It verifies the signal."

Jessica nodded. She popped the tape into the VCR.

Clunk-whirrr.

The screen flickered static blue. Then, the logo appeared in bright yellow letters, receding into the infinite starfield.

GALAXY WARS

DA-DAAA! DA-DA-DA-DAAA-DA!

The massive Bb Major chord blasted from the speakers. It was bright. It was triumphant. It was the sound of adventure without risk.

Freddie closed his eyes. He felt the vibration of the music in the air. He felt the vibration of Paige's hand on his chest.

"Status?" Paige whispered into his ear.

"Stabilized," Freddie breathed.

The music faded into the opening crawl, describing a civil war and a galaxy far, far away. Jessica pressed stop. She rewound it for next time.

The Archive was secure. The Unit was online. And the Sentinels were waiting on the shelf, ready to return whenever he needed them.

Scene 10: The Captaincy Protocol

The credits for *The New Era* had finished, but the TV was still on. Jessica, in a moment of curiosity, hit the "Previous Channel" button on the remote.

The screen flickered to **Channel 24**, a retro-rerun station.

Grainy, Technicolor footage filled the screen. The aspect ratio was 4:3, the colors oversaturated in that distinct 1960s way.

And then, the music started.

It wasn't the soaring, orchestral French horn fanfare of *The New Era*.

It was a strange, warbling theremin melody overlaid with bongos and a jazzy brass section.

Wooo-weee-oooo... Dum-da-dum-da-dum...

Freddie winced. He physically recoiled.

"Audio dissonance," Freddie stated, his nose wrinkling. "This sounds like a game show in space. It lacks... gravitas."

"It's the original," Jessica explained, watching the screen where a spaceship—clearly a model on a string—wobbled past a papier-mâché planet. " *Stellar Voyage: The First Missions* . 1966."

On screen, the bridge of the ship appeared. It was colorful, filled with jellybean buttons and blinking lights that didn't seem to do anything.

Sitting in the center chair was **Captain Sterling**.

He was wearing a gold velour shirt that was slightly too tight. He was leaning forward, grinning at a female alien with green skin and a silver miniskirt.

The dialogue was melodramatic.

"But you see, Princess... in my world... we know how to love."

Sterling grabbed the alien's shoulders. He pulled her in for a dramatic, music-swelling kiss. He didn't ask. He just took.

Freddie stiffened. He felt a sudden, sharp spike of revulsion.

He looked at the way Sterling held the woman. It wasn't the protective, grounding hold Freddie used with Paige. It wasn't the "Sandwich Configuration."

It was predatory. It was... *Krystal*.

"He is a variable of chaos," Freddie whispered, pointing a trembling finger at the screen.

"Captain Sterling?" Paige asked, looking down at him.

"He operates on impulse," Freddie analyzed, his voice hardening. "He ignores the Prime Directive to engage in romantic friction. He endangers the crew for the sake of his own ego. He is not a diplomat. He is a cowboy."

He shifted his weight, settling deeper into the sofa.

He was lying on his side, his head resting comfortably in Paige's lap, his face turned toward the television.

Paige had her arm draped over his chest, her palm resting flat and warm directly over his heart. It was her signature move—a physical promise that she was there, that she was the anchor.

Usually, Freddie required this configuration to survive. He needed the weight to stop his heart from racing, to keep his batteries from draining to zero.

But tonight, his batteries were fine. He wasn't crashing. He wasn't panicked.

He realized, with a quiet sense of wonder, that he didn't *need* to be here. He *wanted* to be here. He was staying in her lap simply because he enjoyed the affection.

He looked at Sterling on the screen, who was now punching a lizard-man in the face while winking at the camera.

"He treats the crew like accessories," Freddie noted. "Captain Miller asks for input. Captain Sterling gives orders and takes what he wants."

"He's a bit of a womanizer," Jessica agreed, reaching for the remote. "Different era. Different coding."

"It is flawed coding," Freddie stated firmly.

He felt the gentle rise and fall of Paige's breathing against the back of his head. He felt the steady pressure of her hand on his heart.

He realized with absolute clarity that he never wanted to be a man like Sterling. He never wanted to look at a woman—especially the women who kept him safe—and see a conquest.

He wanted to be Miller. The man who sat in his ready room, drinking tea, listening to his officers, and respecting the structure of the ship.

"Change the input," Freddie requested. "Return to the *New Era* theme. I require the French horns."

Jessica smiled and hit the power button on the VCR to eject the tape, but not before switching the TV input back to the blue screen of silence.

"Captain Miller it is," Jessica said.

"Miller," Freddie confirmed.

He didn't move from Paige's lap. He stayed right there, secure under the weight of her hand, choosing the safety of the Unit over the chaos of the cowboy.

In his mind, the debate was settled. The 1960s were noise. The *New Era* was music.

"System purged," Freddie whispered, closing his eyes and enjoying the hug. "We stick to the Next Generation."

Scene 11: The Shutdown Sequence

The credits for the retro sci-fi show had long since faded, and the VCR hummed in the silence of the living room before Jessica clicked it off.

"All systems standby," Jessica announced, standing up and stretching. Her joints popped in the quiet room. "The best news of the day isn't the hike or the burger."

"Query?" Freddie asked, lifting his head from Paige's lap.

"Tomorrow is Thursday," Jessica grinned. "Dr. Thorne doesn't lecture until Friday. We have zero obligations for the next twenty-four hours. No class. No homework. Just... existence."

"Free float," Freddie whispered. "An entire rotation of idle time."

"Exactly," Paige said, helping him sit up. "So let's hit the rack. I want to sleep until noon."

They moved to the hallway. The logistics of the house were efficient.

"I'll take the hallway bath," Jessica said, grabbing her toothbrush. "You guys take the ensuite. Meet in the Silo in ten."

"Copy," Freddie said.

He and Paige entered the master bathroom. The routine was silent and synchronized. Teeth brushed. Faces washed. The toilet flushed.

There was no awkwardness, no hesitation. They were a team servicing the equipment before a long shutdown.

They converged in the master bedroom. The blackout curtains were already drawn, sealing the room in a permanent, protective night. The air conditioner hummed its steady, white-noise lullaby.

The King Bed waited—a 76-inch island of maroon jersey sheets.

"Armor off," Jessica said, closing the door and locking it.

They stripped down. In the dim light, clothing was just debris—fabric that would twist, bind, and pull during the night. Sleeping without it wasn't just about temperature control; it was about eliminating variables. No drawstrings to knot. No elastic bands to dig in.

Just skin. Just the Unit.

They climbed in.

The Formation:

- **Left Flank:** Jessica. She slid in first, taking the side nearest the door. She was the eldest, the Matriarch, the first line of defense.
- **Right Flank:** Paige. She took the side against the wall. She was the Anchor, the immovable object.
- **The Core:** Freddie. He climbed into the center.

He lay back on the cool sheets. The mattress dipped under their combined weight, creating a gravity well that pulled them together.

Jessica rolled onto her side, draping her arm heavily over his chest. Her leg hooked over his left ankle.

Paige rolled in from the right. She didn't just lie next to him; she pressed her entire length against his side. She rested her head on his shoulder, her arm wrapping around his waist to lock hands with Jessica's.

They collapsed the space. They became a single thermal mass.

"Squeeze check," Jessica whispered.

"Pressure is... optimal," Freddie breathed.

He felt the weight of them pinning him to the mattress. It was a physical seatbelt. If the nightmares tried to come back—if the closet or the siren tried to invade the Silo—they wouldn't be able to move him. He was anchored.

"No class tomorrow," Paige murmured into his neck, her voice already heavy with sleep.

"No class," Freddie confirmed. "Just the Unit."

"Goodnight, Captain," Jessica said.

"Goodnight, Shield," Freddie whispered. "Goodnight, Anchor."

"Night, Freddie," Paige sighed.

Freddie closed his eyes. The static was gone. The day's friction was gone.

Held tight in the center of the bed, surrounded by the only people who knew his source code, Freddie Avery let the system power down.

System Status: *Offline.* **Security:** *Maximum.* **Sleep Mode:** *Engaged.*

The False Anchor

The New Variable

Scene 1: The Remainder

The lecture hall in **Copernicus Hall** was a vast, tiered cavern designed to hold two hundred students, but for **PHY 102: Introduction to Astronomy**, it felt comfortably full with just over a hundred.

For Freddie Avery, this room was a sanctuary compared to the biological chaos of a dissection lab.

The air was cool and dry. The lighting was dim to allow for the overhead projector. The subject matter—*Stellar Evolution and Orbital Mechanics*—was pure, unadulterated logic.

Freddie sat in the fourth row, center.

As the noise of the pre-class chatter rose, he initiated the "Docking Protocol." He wasn't just sitting next to Paige; he was integrated with her.

Paige sat on his right. She had her arm wrapped firmly around his shoulders, her hand resting protectively on his upper arm. It wasn't a casual drape; it was a shield wall.

She pulled him in close, and Freddie leaned heavily into her side, pressing his face against the soft cotton of her sweater.

To the uninitiated, it might have looked intense. To Paige, it was a necessary signal to the room: *He is occupied. He is protected. Keep walking.*

She scanned the aisle with narrow eyes, looking for any "Krystals"—anyone with popped collars or chewing gum who might see a vulnerable target.

"Okay, everyone," **Professor Haldeman** announced, his voice booming over the PA system. "We are moving into the practical application phase. The semester-long project is **'Designing a Solar System.'**"

Freddie perked up, though he stayed glued to Paige's side. *World-building.*

"This is a collaborative effort," Haldeman continued. "You will form groups of **four**. No more, no less. The workload is calibrated for a quartet. Take the next five minutes to assemble your teams."

The room dissolved into chaos. Chairs scraped. Backpacks thumped.

"Hold fast," Jessica said calmly from Freddie's left, opening her **MagnaByte** laptop. "Let the particles settle. We are the nucleus."

"We are three," Freddie whispered into Paige's shoulder. "The integer is incorrect. We require a fourth variable."

"We'll find one," Paige said, tightening her grip on his shoulder. She glared at a guy in a backward baseball cap who looked like he was about to approach. The guy saw the hug, saw the glare, and moved on.

"Is this seat taken?"

The voice was soft. It wasn't shrill. It wasn't loud. It was low, modulated, and calm.

Freddie peered out from the safety of Paige's shoulder.

Standing in the aisle was a girl. She looked... tidy.

She was wearing a pressed button-down shirt tucked into a knee-length skirt. Her hair was pulled back in a severe, efficient bun held in place by a tortoise-shell clip. She held a notebook clutched to her chest with both arms.

Paige didn't let go. She kept her arm locked around Freddie, staring the girl down. *State your business.*

The girl looked at the hug. She looked at Freddie's face—the dark eyes, the glasses, the nose. Then she looked at Paige's face.

She didn't sneer. She didn't look confused. She nodded, a small, clinical gesture of recognition.

"I see the resemblance," the girl said quietly. "Strong genetic markers. Siblings?"

Paige blinked. The girl hadn't made it weird. She had identified the data.

"Twins," Paige stated, her grip relaxing just a fraction.

"Efficiency," the girl noted. "You already have a communication shorthand. That will be useful for the project."

She looked at Freddie. She didn't look at his legs or the way he was hiding. She looked past him to the screen of his heavy **Iron-Logic** laptop sitting on the desk.

"I noticed your interface," she said to Freddie. "You're using the dark mode setting on the astronomical software. White text on black background."

Freddie sat up slightly, though he kept Paige's arm around him.

"It reduces eye strain," Freddie replied automatically. "It mimics the vacuum of space. It is superior for data retention."

"I agree," the girl said. She offered a small, contained smile. It wasn't a predatory smirk. It was a polite expression of data alignment.

"I'm Vanessa," she said. "I am currently unassigned. My previous lab partner dropped the course. I have a 4.0 GPA in mathematics, and I actually enjoy spreadsheets."

Jessica looked her up and down from the other side. The "Matriarch Scan" was running.

- **Smoke smell?** Negative. She smelled like soap and old paper.
- **Chaotic energy?** Negative. She stood perfectly still.
- **Reaction to the Hug:** Neutral/Positive.

"We need a fourth," Jessica admitted, relaxing her shoulders. "I'm Jessica. This is Paige. And the Captain there is Freddie."

"The Captain?" Vanessa asked.

"He understands the orbital mechanics," Paige explained. She finally let her arm drop from Freddie's shoulder, though she kept her hand resting on his arm. "We just handle the logistics."

Vanessa nodded. She looked at the empty seat next to Jessica (on the outside of the phalanx).

"May I?" she asked.

Freddie looked at her. She felt... orderly. She felt like a person who read the manual before opening the box.

"Clear for docking," Freddie whispered.

Vanessa sat down. She didn't slam her bag. She placed it quietly on the floor. She opened her notebook. She uncapped a pen.

She sat up straight, ready to work.

"So," Vanessa said, her voice dropping to a library whisper that didn't trigger Freddie's sensory alarms. "For the habitable zone calculation... are we assuming a G-type main sequence star, or are we going exotic?"

Freddie looked at her. She spoke the language. She respected the volume.

"G-type," Freddie said, turning his body slightly toward her. "Standard yellow dwarf. It provides the most stable baseline for life."

"Agreed," Vanessa said, writing it down. "Stability is key."

Paige looked at Jessica over Freddie's head. She raised an eyebrow. *She seems okay. She gets it.*

Jessica nodded. *She's quiet. She's smart. She's safe.*

Freddie looked at his screen, then at the new variable in their equation.

For the first time in a long time, a stranger had entered the perimeter, and the alarms hadn't gone off.

"Group 4 formed," Freddie noted. "Status: Complete."

Scene 2: The Static Stack

The transition from the academic rigor of Copernicus Hall to the social hub of **Newman Hall** was a sensory shift Freddie usually found jarring.

The air in Newman smelled of floor wax, old coffee, and the grease of the fryers. The ambient noise was a chaotic mix of student chatter, the clatter of pool balls from the game room, and the hum of vending machines.

But today, the "Group 4" formation held the line.

"Refueling is required before data entry," Jessica announced as they entered the atrium. "The **Burger Hub** is open. Meal plans are active."

They approached the counter. It was a standard quick-service setup—stainless steel counters, backlit menus, and student workers in visors.

"I have the orders," Jessica said, taking charge. "Freddie, you want the Standard?"

"Chicken tenders. Three count. Fries. Mega-Cola. No ice," Freddie recited automatically.

"Got it," Jessica said. She looked at Vanessa. "Do you have a meal plan?"

"I do," Vanessa said, pulling a pristine **PolyPass** from her bag. "I'll get a garden salad and a water. I try to keep it light in the afternoon."

They swiped their cards. *Beep. Beep. Beep. Beep.*

Trays loaded, they navigated the crowded seating area. Freddie scanned for a "Low Density" zone.

“Sector 4,” Freddie pointed toward a corner near the large windows overlooking the Drillfield. “Corner table. Maximum visibility. Minimum traffic.”

“Lead the way,” Vanessa said, stepping back to let Freddie and Paige walk ahead.

They claimed the round table. Freddie took the seat facing the room (so no one could sneak up on him). Paige sat on his right, thigh-to-thigh. Jessica sat on his left.

Vanessa sat across from them. She unpacked her salad with surgical precision, arranging her napkin and fork in perfect alignment.

“Okay,” Jessica said, popping a fry into her mouth. “The assignment. ‘Design a Solar System.’ We need an outline by Thursday.”

“We need a format,” Vanessa corrected gently. She opened her notebook. “Professor Haldeman said we could submit a written report, a poster, or a presentation.”

Freddie stopped chewing his chicken tender. He looked at the heavy **Iron-Logic** laptop sitting in his bag.

He thought about a paper report. Static. Linear. Boring. He thought about a poster. Messy. Glue sticks. Imperfect alignment.

“Negative,” Freddie stated.

The three women looked at him.

“A paper report is dead data,” Freddie explained, wiping his hands carefully on a napkin. “A solar system is a dynamic environment. It requires navigation. It requires structure.”

He pulled his laptop out of the bag. He set up the **Digi-Track** mouse with its glowing red ball.

“I will build a website,” Freddie announced.

“A website?” Vanessa asked, her eyes widening slightly behind her wire-rimmed glasses. “For a class project? Isn’t that… ambitious?”

“It is logical,” Freddie countered. “The University provides server space. I have already mapped the directory.”

He booted up the laptop. The screen flickered to life. He opened the FTP client (**WS_FTP LE**) to show them the login screen.

Host: student-web.cpi.internal **Directory:** /students/~mrags002/public_html **Quota:** 100 MB

“I have one hundred megabytes,” Freddie said, pointing to the stats bar. “That is sufficient for text and optimized JPEGs.”

“Can you work on it from the apartment?” Jessica asked. “Like, upload it tonight while we watch TV?”

Freddie frowned. He shook his head.

"Security restriction," Freddie explained, his voice dropping with professional seriousness. "The student server is on the **Internal Network**. It resolves only to local IP addresses. It is not accessible from the public internet."

"No VPN?" Jessica asked.

"Student accounts are not authorized for VPN tunneling," Freddie confirmed. "To upload, I must be physically connected to the campus grid. Wired or Wireless."

He pointed to the ethernet jack on the wall near their table.

"This is the airlock. I can write the code at home on the local drive. But to deploy... to make it live... we must be here. We must be on site."

Vanessa nodded, understanding the workflow immediately.

"So, Tuesdays and Thursdays," Vanessa said. "We meet here. We build the data offline. We review. Then you upload."

"A synchronous deployment cycle," Freddie agreed.

"Can you use a database?" Jessica asked, pivoting back to the tech. "Like that PHP stuff you play with?"

Freddie shook his head again.

"Another restriction," he sighed. "The Student Server environment is locked down. The SysAdmins have disabled server-side scripting. No PHP. No Perl. No SQL. It is a security precaution to prevent students from crashing the node."

"So... how do you build it?" Paige asked, confused. "If you can't use the code you like?"

"Hard-coded HTML," Freddie said, sounding like a blacksmith describing forging iron by hand. "Static pages. I will use **Tables** for the layout. It will be rigid. It will be unbreakable."

He looked at Vanessa.

"If we do this... the data must be formatted perfectly. I cannot pull from a database. I have to type the atmospheric composition into the HTML code for every single planet. If we change a number, I have to edit the file and re-upload while on campus."

Vanessa didn't look scared. She didn't look bored. She looked... impressed.

She leaned forward, resting her chin on her hand.

"You're going to hand-code the entire solar system?" she asked softly. "That's incredible dedication, Freddie. Most people would just staple five pages together and call it a day."

"Dedication yields accuracy," Freddie said.

"I can help," Vanessa offered. "I don't know HTML, but I know how to format data. I can write the descriptions for the planets in a text file. I'll make sure the character counts are identical so your tables line up perfectly."

Freddie blinked. *Character counts.* She understood the geometry of the table cells.

"You understand the grid," Freddie whispered.

"I love the grid," Vanessa smiled. It was a warm, safe smile. "Order is beautiful."

She looked at Paige and Jessica.

"You two are lucky," Vanessa said. "He's brilliant. I'm just glad I got into this group before the frat guys tried to recruit him to do their homework."

Paige relaxed. She smiled back. "Yeah. He's pretty cool."

"Okay," Jessica said, opening her notebook. "Project: Helios is a go. Freddie handles the architecture. Vanessa handles the math and the data entry. Paige and I will handle the creative writing—naming the planets, the history, the 'lore'."

"Acceptable," Freddie said.

He opened **Notepad**. He typed the first tag.

<html>

The cursor blinked. The page was blank. The server was waiting on the other end of the campus network.

"We begin," Freddie said.

The Seed

Scene 1: The Observation

The solar system project was 60% complete. The website—Project Helios—was a masterpiece of static HTML tables and hand-coded CSS.

The group sat in their usual spot in **Newman Library**, a secluded table near the windows. The winter sun was low, casting long shadows across the stacks.

Freddie was typing. He was in "The Zone." His fingers flew across the keyboard of his **Iron-Logic** laptop, coding the description for *Planet 3: The Forge*.

On his right, Paige sat thigh-to-thigh with him. She was reading a paperback novel, her left hand resting absently on the back of Freddie's neck, playing with the hem of his hoodie. It was a constant, subconscious stream of tactile data: *I am here. You are safe.*

On his left, Jessica was reviewing the lore document.

Across the table, Vanessa sat watching them.

She had been part of the group for a month. She had been perfect. She was diligent, quiet, and respectful. But she was calculating.

To Vanessa, the Avery Unit was an anomaly. She had a brother at the **University of the Piedmont**, and she hadn't spoken to him since Christmas. That was *normal*. This... this tangled knot of codependency... was fascinating. And inefficient.

"You guys really do everything together, don't you?" Vanessa asked softly, closing her notebook.

Freddie paused his typing. He looked up. "Clarification?"

"Your schedules," Vanessa said, gesturing to the printouts spread on the table. "I noticed when we were comparing availability. You and Paige... it's not just similar. It's a mirror. Same classes. Same sections. Same professors. Even your free blocks align."

"We are a binary system," Freddie stated simply. "We orbit a common center."

"It's efficient for logistics," Jessica added without looking up. "One car. One gas bill. They live in the same house, they go to the same class."

"Right," Vanessa nodded slowly. "Efficient."

She turned her gaze to Paige. Her expression shifted to one of gentle, pitying admiration.

"I saw you guys at the **Daily Grind** yesterday," Vanessa said. "With those girls from your English Lit section?"

Paige looked up. "Oh. Yeah. Sarah and Emily."

"I was a few tables away," Vanessa lied smoothly (or perhaps she was stalking; the distinction was blurring). "They were so excited. They were trying to get you to go to that concert in Richmond this weekend. The indie band?"

Paige shrugged, her hand still resting on Freddie's neck. "Yeah. They invited us."

"They invited *you*," Vanessa corrected gently. "And you said no. Instantly. You didn't even check the date. You just looked at Freddie... saw he was covering his ears because the espresso machine was too loud... and you shut it down. You said you had plans."

Freddie stiffened. He stopped typing.

He remembered the coffee shop. He remembered the noise. He remembered Paige saying, *"Sorry, guys. Not our scene."*

"I didn't want to go," Paige said defensively, tightening her grip on Freddie. "Concerts are loud. They're crowded. It's a sensory nightmare."

"For Freddie," Vanessa pointed out. Her voice was soft, like she was explaining a difficult diagnosis. "It's a nightmare for *Freddie*."

She leaned forward, dropping her voice to an intimate whisper.

"It's really noble, Paige. Most sisters—especially twins—spend college trying to find their own identity. Trying to be... just Paige. But you don't do that. You stay right there. You clear the path for him."

She looked at Freddie.

"You're lucky, Freddie. She loves you so much. She gives up everything—parties, concerts, having her own schedule, having her own *life*—just to make sure you don't get scared."

The seed hit the soil.

She gives up everything.

Freddie felt a cold spike of static in his chest. He looked at Paige.

He saw the twin sister who was born twelve minutes before him. The sister who, according to family lore, had kicked her way out first to make sure the coast was clear.

"I... I do not require her to decline events," Freddie stammered, his voice small. "If she requires... a solo mission... "

"She would never leave you," Vanessa cut in, her voice sweet and poisonous. "That's the point. She's too good. She knows you can't function without your Safe Person. So she makes herself small to fit inside your world."

Paige slammed her book shut. The noise made Freddie jump.

"Stop," Paige said. Her voice wasn't soft. It was sharp.

She turned to Freddie. She didn't pull away. She did the opposite. She wrapped both arms around him, pulling him into a aggressive cuddle right there in the library. She buried her face in his neck.

"Don't listen to her," Paige whispered fiercely into his ear. "I didn't want to go to Richmond. I hate traffic. I hate crowds. I wanted to stay home and build the solar system with you."

She looked up at Vanessa, her eyes flashing.

"I promised him," Paige said to Vanessa. "When we were twelve. I promised I would always clear the path. I'm not stuck with him. I *am* his path. And he is mine."

"I know," Vanessa said quickly, raising her hands in surrender. "I know! I didn't mean to UDSet you. I just think it's... tragic. In a beautiful, Shakespearean way. The devotion is overwhelming."

She smiled. "I wish my brother cared enough to let me hold him like that."

Freddie buried his face in Paige's shoulder. He smelled her shampoo. He felt the solid, undeniable reality of her protection.

Signal confirmed.

But the static remained.

He thought about Sarah and Emily. He thought about the concert. Even if Paige *said* she hated crowds... did she hate them because she really hated them? Or did she hate them because she knew *he* couldn't handle them?

Was he the reason she didn't have a boyfriend? Was he the reason she didn't have a "normal" college life?

"Your hypothesis is flawed," Freddie mumbled into Paige's shirt, trying to convince himself. "We are a Unit."

"Of course you are," Vanessa soothed, picking up her pen. "And it's working perfectly. Look at the website. A perfect, closed system."

She went back to work.

Paige held him for a long time, rubbing his back, glaring at the top of Vanessa's head.

But for the first time, Freddie wondered if the "closed system" was a sanctuary... or a cage.

Scene 2: The Recoil

The silence in the corner of Newman Library was thick, heavy, and dangerous.

Paige hadn't let go of Freddie. Her arms were still locked around him, her chin resting defiantly on his shoulder. But she wasn't just holding him for comfort anymore; she was holding him like a weapon she was ready to use.

She lifted her head. Her eyes, usually warm and laughing, were narrowed into slits of pure, protective aggression.

"You know what?" Paige said, her voice shaking slightly—not with fear, but with adrenaline. "Maybe you *should* hug your brother more often."

Vanessa blinked, taken aback by the sudden counter-attack. "I—"

"Seriously," Paige interrupted, her voice rising just enough to turn heads at the nearby tables. "You think this is tragic? You think I'm missing out?"

She tightened her grip on Freddie, pressing her cheek against his temple.

"Do you know what it's like out there, Vanessa?" Paige demanded. "Do you know what it's like to go to a party or a bar in this town? Every guy I meet is running a calculation. They're looking at my chest. They're trying to figure out how many drinks it takes to get me into bed. They don't want *me*. They want a conquest."

Freddie stayed perfectly still, his eyes wide behind his glasses. He felt the vibration of her anger in his chest.

"It is rather nice," Paige hissed, "having a man in my life who isn't interested in my breasts. Who isn't desperately trying to have sex with me. Who just wants me to be *there* because I make him feel safe."

She looked down at Freddie, softening for a split second, before snapping her gaze back to Vanessa.

"He's the only guy I know who doesn't want something *from* me," Paige said. "He just wants *us*. So don't you dare tell me I'm the one losing out."

Across the table, Jessica slowly lowered her red pen.

She didn't speak. She didn't have to. She turned her head and fixed Vanessa with a look that was colder than liquid nitrogen.

It was the "Matriarch Gaze." It was a calculation of utility versus threat.

- **Utility:** Vanessa does the math. She organizes the data.
- **Threat:** Vanessa is destabilizing the Core.

The look said clearly: *One more strike. One more word against the Unit, and you are deleted. I don't care if you have a 4.0 GPA. I will drag you out of this library myself.*

Vanessa froze.

She looked at Paige, fierce and trembling. She looked at Jessica, silent and lethal. She looked at Freddie, huddled in the center, looking terrified not of his sisters, but of *her*.

Miscalculation, Vanessa thought. *Severe error.*

Her mind flashed back to her own home in Portsmouth, Virginia. She thought about her brother, David. The screaming matches over the remote. The time he locked her out of the house in the rain. The way they flinched if they accidentally brushed arms in the hallway. *Hug him?* She would sooner hug a cactus.

To Vanessa, affection was a weakness. It was leverage. But here... looking at Paige... she realized she was looking at something she couldn't break with logic.

She couldn't shame Paige into leaving Freddie. Paige didn't see it as a burden. She saw it as her sanctuary.

They will never separate voluntarily, Vanessa realized. *The bond is structural. You cannot untie a knot that has been fused.*

She needed to retreat. Immediately.

Vanessa's face crumpled. The arrogant pity vanished, replaced by a look of contrite, wide-eyed innocence.

"I... I am so sorry," Vanessa whispered, her voice trembling perfectly.

She reached out a hand, palm up, in a gesture of peace.

"Paige, please. You're right. I was projecting. I was..." She looked down at the table. "I was jealous. Me and David... we fought every single day. I don't think he ever made me feel safe. Not once."

She looked up, tears shimmering in her eyes (a calculated physiological response).

"I see what you have, and I don't understand it because I've never had it," Vanessa said. "I didn't mean to insult you. I was just... trying to make sense of how lucky Freddie is."

She looked at Jessica, silently pleading for mercy.

"Please don't kick me out," Vanessa whispered. "I really want to finish Project Helios. I like being part of the team. I promise... no more amateur psychology. Just math."

Jessica held the gaze for three seconds. Then, slowly, the ice thawed.

"Just math," Jessica confirmed, her voice flat.

She looked at Paige. "Stand down, Lieutenant."

Paige took a deep breath. She let it out slowly. She lowered her chin back onto Freddie's shoulder, resuming her post.

"Just math," Paige agreed, though she didn't smile.

"Accepted," Freddie whispered, his heart rate slowly returning to normal.

Vanessa picked up her pencil. Her hand wasn't shaking.

She had lost the skirmish. She had nearly been exiled. But she had learned a valuable piece of data: *The sisters are the firewall. And firewalls cannot be reasoned with.*

They must be bypassed.

"Okay," Vanessa said softly, looking at the spreadsheet. "Let's calculate the orbital resonance of Planet 4."

She went back to work. She was quiet. She was helpful. She was safe. But behind her wire-rimmed glasses, she was already planning her next move.

Scene 3: The Split Screen

Location: 105 Pepper Street **Status:** Decontamination

The master bathroom was a sealed ecosystem of warmth and steam. The exhaust fan had been left off intentionally, allowing the humidity to build until the mirrors were fogged and the world outside the door felt a million miles away.

Freddie wasn't sitting on a bench. He was deep in the water, fully submerged up to his chest. He sat with his legs extended, the water lapping against his collarbones, enveloping him in a heavy, liquid blanket that dulled the sensory sharp edges of the day.

Outside the tub, kneeling on the plush bath mats like acolytes at a shrine, were his sisters.

They were naked, having discarded the armor of the day, but they remained on the dry land of the tile floor. They leaned over the porcelain rim, their arms submerged as they tended to him.

Jessica was at his head. She had a cup, pouring warm water over his hair, rinsing away the sweat of the library.

Paige was at his side. She held a soft, soapy sponge, running it down his arm in long, rhythmic strokes.

"Query," Freddie murmured, his voice echoing slightly against the tile. "Why did she classify the proximity as 'tragic'?"

He looked at Paige. His glasses were off, so she was a soft, beautiful blur.

"She used the word 'sacrifice'," Freddie added, the word tasting bitter. "She implied a loss of function on your part."

Paige paused the sponge. She rested her wet hand on his shoulder, her thumb stroking his skin.

"Because she's running a different operating system, Freddie," Paige said softly. "In her world—the 'normal' world—independence is the highest value. If you aren't standing alone, you're failing."

"But standing alone is inefficient," Freddie countered, splashing the water slightly. "A single column is vulnerable to shear force. A tripod is stable."

"She doesn't know about tripods," Jessica said from behind him, massaging conditioner into his scalp. "She's a solo act. Remember what she said about her brother? They fight. They compete. To her, love is a zero-sum game. If I give love to you, I have less for myself."

"Is that how you calculate it?" Freddie asked, turning his head slightly to look at Paige. "Do you have less?"

"I have more," Paige said fiercely.

She leaned further over the tub, ignoring the water soaking the front of her torso. She looked him right in the eyes.

"Think about Sarah and Emily," Paige said, referencing the girls from the coffee shop. "They spent three hours yesterday talking about how lonely they are. They go to these parties hoping to find *one person* who understands them. One person who makes them feel safe."

She squeezed his shoulder.

"I already have that," Paige whispered. "I have you. I have Jess. Why would I wander around a loud, smelly frat house looking for something I already have at home?"

"She thinks you are... constrained," Freddie said. "Trapped in my orbit."

"I'm not trapped," Paige smiled, a genuine, warm expression that melted the last of the library's ice. "I'm anchored. There's a difference. A trap holds you down. An anchor keeps you from drifting away."

"She was projecting," Jessica diagnosed, her voice clinical and calm as she rinsed his hair. "She looked at us, and she didn't see a burden. She saw a team. And she realized she's playing the game alone."

Jessica tapped his shoulder. "Sit up. Let me get your back."

Freddie sat up, water cascading off his chest. He leaned forward.

Jessica began to wash his back, her movements firm and sure. Paige moved to his other arm, continuing the symmetry.

"She's weird, Freddie," Jessica decided. "Not bad. Just... lonely. She's trying to decode us because she wants what we have. She just doesn't know how to ask for it without trying to break it first."

"So we do not delete her?" Freddie asked.

"Not yet," Paige said, rinsing the sponge. "But we keep the shields up. She can help with the math. She can help with the code. But she doesn't get a key to the house."

"Agreed," Freddie whispered.

He sank back down into the water, letting it cover him up to his chin.

On either side of him, his sisters watched over him. They weren't missing out on anything. They weren't sacrificing anything.

In the steam-filled silence of 105 Pepper Street, the Avery Unit was exactly where it was supposed to be: together.

Location: Westgate Hall (CPI Campus Housing), Room 304 **Status:** Discharge

The air in the cramped dorm room smelled of cheap body spray and the lingering humidity of exertion.

The door to the hallway clicked shut. The heavy deadbolt slid home with a final *clack*.

Braden (a sophomore from Sigma Chi, or maybe Pike—it didn't matter) was gone. He hadn't asked for their numbers. They hadn't offered. He had retrieved his backwards baseball cap, mumbled a "Catch ya later," and exited the premises.

It was a successful transaction. The biological pressure had been vented.

Lauren, Vanessa's roommate, flopped back onto her twin XL mattress. She pulled the duvet up to her chin, looking tousled and smug.

"Well," Lauren yawned, checking the time on her Kova brick phone. "That was efficient. Solid six out of ten. But he had good stamina."

Vanessa stood by the mini-fridge. She grabbed a bottle of water and downed half of it in one long pull. She was wearing a silk robe that looked out of place in the cinderblock room.

"He served the function," Vanessa said coolly.

She walked to her desk, which was meticulously organized—textbooks stacked by height, pens in a cup, laptop closed.

"So," Lauren asked, rolling onto her side to watch Vanessa. "Does this mean you're finally done with Project Boy? The one with the twin shadows?"

Vanessa wiped a smudge of eyeliner from her cheek. She stared at her reflection in the small mirror mounted on the back of the door.

She thought about the library. She thought about Paige's fierce, trembling arms wrapped around Freddie. She thought about Jessica's eyes—cold, calculating, and dangerous.

She had tried to use logic to break an emotional bond. It was like trying to cut a diamond with a plastic knife.

"No," Vanessa said softly. "I'm not done."

"Van, come on," Lauren groaned. "The guy is a walking red flag. He brings his *sisters* to class. They bathe him. I heard you say they bathe him! That is... it's too much work. Just find a nice engineering major who can walk without a chaperone."

Vanessa turned around. Her eyes were sharp.

"You don't get it, Lauren," Vanessa said. "Freddie isn't like Braden. Braden is... noise. He's static. He comes in, he takes what he wants, he leaves. There's no signal."

She walked over to the window, looking out at the dark campus.

"Freddie has a signal," Vanessa whispered. "He builds worlds in his head. He has this... intense, focused capacity for devotion. Did you see how he looked at Paige? He looked at her like she was the only thing keeping him on the planet."

"Yeah," Lauren countered. "Because she's his sister. It's weird."

"It's potent," Vanessa corrected. "I want that directed at *me*."

She leaned her forehead against the cold glass.

"I made a mistake today," Vanessa admitted. "I attacked the Unit. I tried to shame Paige into leaving. It backfired. They just tightened the formation."

"So you're giving up?" Lauren asked hopefully.

"No," Vanessa smiled, but it didn't reach her eyes. "I'm changing tactics."

"Firewalls cannot be brute-forced," she murmured to herself, using Freddie's own terminology. "They have to be bypassed."

She turned back to the room.

"I'm going to apologize," Vanessa announced. "I'm going to be the perfect friend. I'm going to bring Jessica coffee. I'm going to ask Paige for advice on... I don't know, hair care. I'm going to make them think I'm harmless."

"You? Harmless?" Lauren snorted. "Good luck selling that."

"I'm a Business major," Vanessa said, smoothing her robe. "I know how to sell anything."

She climbed into her own bed. The sheets were cold. The room was quiet.

Unlike the steam-filled bathroom on Pepper Street, where three people were currently safe and warm and together, Vanessa lay in the dark alone.

"I'll make it work," she whispered to the ceiling.

She would wait. She would watch. And the next time a crack appeared in the Avery Unit, she wouldn't try to pry it open with a crowbar. She would slip in like water.

And then, she would freeze.

Scene 4: The Syntax Error

The atmosphere at the corner table in **Newman Library** was tense. The Avery Unit had deployed their defensive perimeter early.

Freddie sat in the center, his **Iron-Logic** laptop open, but he wasn't typing. He was watching the elevators. Paige sat on his right, her posture rigid, her arms crossed over her chest. Jessica sat on his left, tapping her pen against the table.

They were waiting for the Variable.

Ding.

The elevator doors slid open.

Vanessa stepped out.

She wasn't carrying her usual stack of books. She was carrying a cardboard drink carrier from **The Daily Grind**.

She walked toward them slowly. She didn't march. She didn't look confident. She looked... humble. Her shoulders were slightly slumped, her head bowed just enough to signal submission.

She stopped five feet from the table—outside the engagement zone.

"Permission to approach?" Vanessa asked softly.

Jessica stopped tapping her pen. She looked at the drink carrier. She looked at Vanessa's face.

"Depends on the payload," Jessica said coolly.

Vanessa stepped forward carefully. She placed the carrier on the table.

"For the Matriarch," Vanessa said, sliding a large cup toward Jessica. "Double-shot espresso, black. I noticed last week you were rubbing your temples around 4 PM. I figured you were running low on fuel."

Jessica looked at the cup. It was exactly what she needed. It showed observation. It showed respect for the hierarchy.

"Accepted," Jessica said, taking the cup. She took a sip. Her shoulders relaxed—just a fraction.

"For the Lieutenant," Vanessa said, sliding a cup toward Paige. "Chamomile tea with honey. Non-caffeinated. Calming. I know... I know I caused a stress spike last week. I wanted to help lower the voltage."

Paige looked at the tea. It was a peace offering. A literal "calm down" drink.

"Thanks," Paige muttered, taking the cup. She didn't smile, but she stopped glaring.

Then, Vanessa stood up straight. The carrier was empty.

There was no cup for Freddie.

A ripple of agitation went through the table. Jessica frowned. Paige tightened her arm around Freddie's waist, pulling him closer into a protective squeeze. *She excluded him?*

Vanessa saw the look. She raised her hands quickly.

"I didn't get one for the Captain," Vanessa explained hastily. "I know he doesn't drink coffee. And I didn't want to guess his tea preference and get it wrong. That would be inefficient."

Freddie looked at the empty spot. She was correct. If she had brought him Earl Grey or English Breakfast, he would have rejected it. He only drank White Hot Chocolate with whipped cream, or water.

"That is a valid logic path," Freddie stated. "Guessing introduces variables."

"I can get you water?" Vanessa offered. "Or..."

“I’ve got it,” Jessica said, standing up. She grabbed Freddie’s reusable water bottle from the table. “I need to stretch anyway. I’ll hit the fountain around the corner.”

Jessica walked away, leaving the perimeter temporarily compromised.

Paige compensated immediately. She wrapped both arms around Freddie, resting her chin on his shoulder, staring up at Vanessa. It was a clear signal: *My sister is gone, but the shield is still up.*

Vanessa didn’t flinch. She didn’t roll her eyes or make a comment about codependency. She simply nodded, acknowledging the hug as a fact of nature.

“I brought something else for you, Freddie,” Vanessa said softly.

She reached into her bag and pulled out a translucent purple jewel case containing a silver CD-R.

“I finished the descriptions for the Outer Rim planets,” Vanessa explained. “And... I tried to format them. I opened the HTML file you sent me, and I studied your tags. I tried to speak your language.”

Freddie picked up the disc. He popped the drive tray on his laptop. *Whirrrr-click.*

He opened the file outer_rim_data.txt in Notepad.

He stared at the code.

<td>The frozen giant of the outer rim.</td><td>Mass: 14.5 Earths</td>

<td>Atmosphere: Methane ice storms.</td><td>Orbit: 84 Years</td>

Freddie frowned. He adjusted his glasses.

“This is... incomplete,” Freddie stated.

“Is it?” Vanessa asked, leaning in, but keeping a respectful distance from Paige’s territory. “I used the <td> tags like you did.”

“You have the data cells,” Freddie explained, pointing to the screen. “But you have no container. Data cannot float in the void. It requires a row <tr>. And the row requires a table <table>.”

He typed quickly, showing her what it *should* look like.

<table border=“1” cellpadding=“5”>

<tr>

<th>PLANET DESCRIPTION</th>

<th>MASS</th>

</tr>

<tr>

<td>The frozen giant of the outer rim.</td>

<td>14.5 Earths</td>

</tr>

</table>

“See?” Freddie said. “Structure. Hierarchy.”

Vanessa looked at the screen, then at Freddie. Her eyes were wide with what looked like genuine awe.

“I see it now,” Vanessa whispered. “I was just floating data. You built the grid.”

She looked at him humbly.

“I don’t know this language, Freddie,” she admitted. “I’m good at math, but I’m illiterate in code. Would you... would you be willing to teach me? I don’t want to just be the data entry girl. I want to build the walls correctly.”

Freddie felt a surge of pride. She wasn’t challenging his system. She was asking to be initiated into it.

“I can instruct you,” Freddie said, his voice firm. “We will start with the Table Object Model.”

Jessica returned with the full water bottle. She set it down in front of Freddie.

“Hydration secured,” Jessica said, sitting back down.

She looked at the scene. Freddie was typing, explaining tag nesting. Vanessa was taking notes furiously, nodding along. Paige was still hugging Freddie, drinking her tea, looking bored but no longer murderous.

“She didn’t try to touch the keyboard?” Jessica asked Paige quietly.

“Nope,” Paige whispered back, blowing on her tea. “She admitted she didn’t know how to do it. She asked him to teach her.”

Jessica took a sip of her espresso.

“Smart,” Jessica noted.

Vanessa looked up and caught Jessica’s eye. She smiled—a small, tentative, apologetic smile.

“We’re debugging,” Vanessa said. “I missed the <tr> tags. Freddie is fixing my mess.”

“He’s good at that,” Jessica said, her voice neutral.

Vanessa went back to her notes. She didn’t push. She didn’t try to join the hug. She didn’t try to act like a sister.

She played the student. And the Avery Unit, lowered their shields just enough to let her in.

The Orbital Decay

Scene 1: The Logic Bomb

The lobby of **Copernicus Hall** was buzzing with the frantic, caffeinated energy of Finals Week. Students sat on the floor surrounded by flashcards. Others paced the tile corridors muttering formulas.

The Avery Unit stood near the display case containing a model of the Voyager probe. They were ready.

Freddie was wearing his "Presentation Gear"—a clean black polo shirt (Jessica insisted) and khaki pants. He held his **Iron-Logic** laptop bag tight against his chest.

The website—**Project Helios**—was live on the local server. It was perfect.

"Okay," Jessica said, checking her watch. "T-minus twenty minutes until launch. I need to hit the restroom. Too much espresso."

"Me too," Paige said, smoothing her skirt. She looked at Freddie. "Do you need to go, Captain?"

"Negative," Freddie said. "Bladder is empty. Systems nominal."

Paige hesitated. She looked at the crowded lobby. Usually, she wouldn't leave him alone in a crowd this dense. The noise level was Yellow-Alert.

She looked at Vanessa.

Vanessa was standing next to Freddie, holding her stack of index cards. She looked calm. She looked capable. For four months, she had been a model citizen of the group. She had learned HTML. She had brought coffee. She had stopped analyzing them.

"Vanessa," Paige said. "You got him for five minutes?"

"I have the con," Vanessa said, using the terminology she had picked up just to please them. "We'll stay right here."

"Okay," Paige smiled. She reached out and squeezed Freddie's hand. "Be right back. Don't let anyone orbit-jack our planet."

The sisters walked away toward the restrooms down the hall.

Freddie watched them go. He felt a momentary spike of anxiety as his anchors disappeared into the crowd, but then he looked at Vanessa. She was safe. She was the Patch.

Vanessa watched them leave, too. She waited until the restroom door swung shut.

Then, she turned to Freddie. The warm, submissive smile vanished, replaced by a look of deep, sorrowful concern.

"They're amazing, aren't they?" Vanessa said softly.

"Affirmative," Freddie said, clutching his bag. "They are optimal units."

"I heard them talking yesterday," Vanessa lied. Her voice was smooth, pouring like syrup into his ear. "In the bathroom at the library. When you were coding."

Freddie froze. "Query?"

"They were talking about summer," Vanessa said. She stepped closer, invading his personal space just enough to create a sense of intimacy, of shared secrets. "Jessica was talking about an internship in New York. A marketing firm. Huge opportunity."

Freddie blinked. Jessica hadn't mentioned New York.

"And Paige," Vanessa sighed. "There's a study abroad program. Italy. Art History. She was looking at the brochure. She looked... she looked so happy just imagining it."

Freddie felt a cold stone drop in his stomach. "They did not inform me."

"Of course they didn't," Vanessa whispered. "Because they turned them down. Both of them."

She looked deep into Freddie's eyes behind his glasses.

"Jessica said, 'I can't leave Freddie alone for three months.' And Paige said, 'Who would help him on the bus?' "

She let the words hang there. *Who would help him.*

"Freddie," Vanessa said, her voice trembling with fake empathy. "They are giving up their lives for you. Italy. New York. Their careers. Their dreams. They are throwing it all away to sit in a house in Norfolk and watch TV with you."

"They... they want to stay," Freddie stammered. "Paige said... she said she is where she belongs."

"She *has* to say that," Vanessa corrected gently. "She loves you. She would never tell you that you're a burden. She would never break your heart."

She reached out and touched his arm. A light, clinical touch.

"But think about the astronomy project, Freddie. Think about gravity."

She pointed to the Voyager probe in the case—the machine that flew away from Earth to see the stars.

"Right now, you are the black hole," Vanessa whispered. "You are pulling them in. They can't escape your gravity. As long as you are here, as long as you need them to hold your hand and wash your hair... they will never leave orbit. They will burn up in your atmosphere."

Freddie stared at the Voyager. He saw the logic. *Gravity traps objects. He was the gravity. Therefore, he was trapping them.*

"How..." Freddie whispered, his voice cracking. "How do I stop it?"

"You can't ask them to leave," Vanessa said. "They won't go. The bond is too strong. They will stay until they resent you. Until they hate you."

She leaned in close to his ear.

"If you truly love them, Freddie... *you* have to be the one to break the orbit. You have to set them free. You have to leave the system."

Freddie's breath hitched. *Leave the system.*

"How?"

"I have an aunt," Vanessa whispered quickly, checking the hallway. "In Washington State. Seattle. It's far away. It's beautiful. I'm going there this summer. You could come. We could start over. You could be... independent. And they could go to New York. They could go to Italy. They could be free."

She pulled back as the restroom door opened down the hall.

"Just think about it," Vanessa said, her voice returning to normal volume. "Think about what Paige is giving up. Think about whether you love her enough to let her go."

Freddie stood frozen. The logic bomb had detonated.

Italy. New York. Resentment. Black Hole.

"All clear!" Paige's voice rang out.

She came bouncing back down the hall, Jessica right behind her. Paige looked happy. She looked relieved.

She walked straight up to Freddie.

"Missed you, Captain," Paige grinned.

She wrapped her arm around his waist. She squeezed him tight. She rested her head on his shoulder.

Five minutes ago, this touch felt like safety. Now, thanks to the data Vanessa had just uploaded, it felt like chains.

Freddie looked at Paige. He saw the sister who should be in Italy. He saw the sister who was stuck in a lobby in Virginia because he couldn't use a public restroom alone.

He felt a wave of self-loathing so strong it nearly knocked him over.

"Freddie?" Paige asked, pulling back slightly to look at his face. "You okay? You look pale. Sensory overload?"

Freddie forced his face to go blank. He adjusted his glasses.

"Negative," Freddie lied. "Pre-presentation adrenaline. Systems nominal."

"Okay," Paige smiled, buying it. She tightened her grip, steering him toward the double doors of the lecture hall. "Let's go knock Haldeman's socks off. Team Helios for the win."

"Team Helios," Vanessa echoed, falling into step beside them.

They walked into the lecture hall. Paige guided him to their seats. Jessica prepped the laptop.

But as Freddie sat there, waiting to present his perfect, static solar system, he wasn't thinking about planets.

He was thinking about the bus. He was thinking about Seattle. He was thinking that the only way to save his sisters was to disappear.

Scene 2: The Presentation

The lights in the lecture hall were dimmed. The air hummed with the whir of the overhead projector fan and the collective anxiety of a hundred students.

Group 3 was finishing up. They were using **Quantum Suite Presentation** (the standard slide software). Their slides were white with blue bullet points that flew in with a cheesy *woosh* sound effect.

"And... uh... that concludes our findings on Gas Giant migration," the Group 3 leader stammered.

"Thank you," Professor Haldeman boomed from the back of the room. "Next up. Group 4. Team Helios."

Jessica stood up first. She adjusted her blazer. "Showtime," she whispered.

The Unit moved to the front.

Freddie walked stiffly. His movements were mechanical, lacking his usual fluid efficiency. He plugged the VGA cable into his **Iron-Logic** laptop.

Paige stood next to him. She watched his hands. They were trembling slightly as he tightened the screws on the cable connector.

He's nervous, Paige thought, stepping closer to offer a subtle, grounding presence. *He hates public speaking. Just get through the next ten minutes, Captain.*

She reached out to touch his elbow—a silent "I'm here."

Freddie didn't lean into it. He held himself rigid, staring at the screen.

Italy, the voice in his head whispered. *New York. You are the black hole.*

"System online," Freddie croaked.

He hit the enter key.

The massive projection screen behind them didn't show a white slide with bullet points.

It went **True Black**.

A collective "Oooooh" rippled through the bored class.

On the screen, the amber curve of the interface glowed. The title **SYSTEM: HELIOS** pulsed slowly in the center (a GIF Freddie had animated pixel by pixel).

"Good afternoon," Jessica announced, her voice projecting clearly. "Most groups built a report. We built a simulation."

She gestured to the screen.

"We designed a G-Type Star system," Jessica continued. "Located 40 light-years from Earth. Our goal was to determine habitability based on stellar luminosity and orbital mechanics. I'll let our Systems Architect demonstrate."

She looked at Freddie.

Freddie clicked the trackball.

[ENTER SYSTEM]

The screen refreshed. A navigation grid appeared.

"Navigation," Freddie said, his voice flat and devoid of its usual passion. "The user can access data via the primary array."

He clicked [PLANET 2: AETHEL].

The table Vanessa and Freddie had built appeared. The data was perfectly aligned.

MASS: 1.02 Earths **ATMOSPHERE:** 78% N, 21% O **WATER:** 65% Surface Coverage

"Vanessa?" Jessica prompted.

Vanessa stepped forward. She looked modest, capable, and professional.

"We calculated the habitable zone based on a luminosity of 1.1," Vanessa explained, pointing to the data table. "As you can see, Planet Aethel sits at 1.05 AU. If it were any closer, the greenhouse effect would trigger a Venus-scenario. Any further, and the water freezes."

She looked at the class.

"We ran the numbers for orbital resonance with the outer gas giant, 'The Forge.' The gravitational tug keeps Aethel's orbit slightly elliptical, which creates distinct seasons."

Paige watched Freddie. Usually, when they showed off his work, he beamed. He loved the "oohs" and "ahhs." He loved explaining the logic.

But today, he was staring at the floor. He looked pale. He looked... sick.

It's the crowd, Paige told herself. *Too many eyes. We need to get him out of here.*

"And for the biosphere," Paige said, jumping in to cover the silence. "We theorized that the slightly higher gravity would result in flora with thicker, sturdier root systems. The 'Lore' section detailed in the sub-menu describes a world of heavy forests and deep oceans."

Freddie clicked the link. The page loaded instantly. The text was formatted beautifully in Courier New.

They ran through the presentation. The mechanics were flawless. The math was perfect. The interface was unlike anything anyone else had done.

"And that," Jessica concluded, "is System Helios."

The room applauded. It was enthusiastic applause. Even the frat guys in the back row looked impressed by the "movie computer" graphics.

"Excellent work," Professor Haldeman said, leaning forward in his chair. "Truly distinct presentation style. We have time for questions."

A hand went up in the third row. A girl with glasses.

"You mentioned the Gas Giant, 'The Forge,' protects the inner planet," she asked. "Did you calculate the impact frequency of asteroids? A Jupiter-sized planet usually acts as a shield."

Freddie looked up. This was his section.

"Yes," Freddie said. He forced the words past the lump in his throat. "We... we modeled the asteroid belt density. The Forge absorbs 94% of potential impactors. It... it clears the path."

Clears the path.

He looked at Paige. *Like she does for you.*

"Without the Giant," Freddie whispered into the microphone, "the inner planet would be destroyed. The Giant takes the hits so the small planet can survive."

Paige smiled at him. She thought he was talking about the project. Freddie knew he was talking about them.

Another hand went up. A guy in a hoodie.

"How did you figure out the tidal locking on the first planet? Wouldn't the star's gravity rip it apart if it was that close?"

"Roche Limit," Vanessa answered smoothly, stepping in before Freddie had to speak again. "We calculated the Roche Limit of the star. Planet 1 is close, but it's outside the disintegration zone. It's tidally locked, meaning one side is always burning, one is always frozen. But it's stable."

"Stable," Freddie echoed softly. *Trapped.*

"One final question," Haldeman said.

A student in the front row raised his hand. "Okay, the astronomy is cool, but... seriously. Is that just HTML? How did you get it to look like that? It looks like the computer from *Stellar Voyage*."

Freddie looked at the screen. The amber text. The black background. The perfect grid.

It was his masterpiece. It was the proof that he could build something beautiful.

But now, looking at it, all he saw was the wasted time. Time Paige could have spent applying for Italy. Time Jessica could have spent getting that internship.

"It is... tables," Freddie said dully. "HTML 4.0. No database. Just... structure."

"Well, it's very effective," Haldeman said. "A-plus work, Group 4. Please disassemble so Group 5 can set up."

Freddie unplugged the laptop. The screen went dark.

"We crushed it!" Jessica whispered, high-fiving Vanessa. "Did you hear Haldeman? A-plus!"

"You guys were amazing," Vanessa beamed. She looked at Freddie. "Especially you, Captain. The interface sold it."

Paige grabbed Freddie's arm as they walked off the stage.

"Hey," she whispered, leaning close. "You okay? You seem... miles away."

Freddie looked at her. He wanted to scream. He wanted to tell her about the conversation in the lobby. He wanted to beg her to go to Italy.

But Vanessa's logic held him in a chokehold. *If you tell them, they'll just deny it. You have to be the one to break the orbit.*

"I am fine," Freddie lied, pulling his arm away gently—the first time he had ever initiated the separation. "Just... tired. I require recharge."

Paige frowned, her hand hovering in the air where his arm had been.

"Okay," she said slowly. "We'll go home. We'll order pizza. We'll celebrate."

"Celebrate," Freddie repeated.

They walked up the aisle. Vanessa walked behind them, her face a mask of supportive joy.

But as she watched Freddie pull away from Paige, she smiled a real, genuine smile.

The gravity was failing. The orbit was decaying. It wouldn't be long now.

Scene 3: The Disconnect

The ride from CPI to **Pepper Plaza** usually took thirty minutes. Today, to Freddie, it felt like re-entry burn.

He sat next to Paige. She was buzzing with post-presentation energy, talking about Haldeman's face when the screen went black.

"Did you see the guy in the third row?" Paige laughed, squeezing Freddie's knee. "His jaw literally dropped. We are legends, Captain. Legends."

Freddie forced a smile. *Legends.* In his mind, he saw a different image. He saw Paige in Italy, drinking wine in a plaza, laughing with people who didn't need her to hold their hand on a bus. He saw Jessica in a high-rise in New York, commanding a boardroom.

They are legends, Freddie thought. *I am the anchor weight.*

The apartment smelled of victory and pepperoni. Jessica had ordered from **Pizza Palace** on the way home.

They sat in the living room. The TV was tuned to **WNRV-TV**, the volume set to Freddie's preferred level (14).

On the screen, the **GBS Evening Report** was winding down. The anchor was signing off with a story about a cat stuck in a tree.

"So," Jessica said, grabbing a slice. "Summer plans. We need to figure out the schedule. I was thinking we could do a beach trip in July. Maybe the Outer Banks?"

"Yes!" Paige agreed, kicking her feet up on the coffee table. "Freddie loves the aquarium. We could rent that cottage again. The one with the quiet porch."

Freddie chewed his pizza. It tasted like cardboard. *The Outer Banks.* Another trip where they would have to watch him. Another summer where they wouldn't go to Europe or New York because he needed a "quiet porch."

It has to be tonight, the logic bomb whispered. *Before the gravity resets.*

The TV jingle for **Phrase Spin** blared through the speakers. The audience clapped. The colorful wheel began to spin.

"Oh, I love this puzzle," Paige said, leaning forward. "Things found in a... kitchen!"

Freddie stood up.

"I require... the restroom," Freddie lied. His heart was hammering against his ribs like a trapped bird.

"Okay," Paige said, not looking away from the screen. "Yell if you need backup."

Freddie walked down the hall. He didn't go to the bathroom. He went to his bedroom.

He had packed the bag that morning. Just the essentials.

- Three pairs of underwear.
- Two t-shirts.
- His spare glasses.
- His medication (enough for three days).
- The **Iron-Logic** laptop (he couldn't leave the architecture).

He put on his orange hoodie. He pulled the hood up.

He took a piece of notebook paper from his desk. He had written it during the bus ride, shielding it from Paige.

I am setting you free. - M

He placed it on the kitchen counter next to the house keys he was leaving behind.

He looked at the back of Paige's head over the sofa. She was shouting, "Spatula! It's Spatula!"

He looked at Jessica, who was laughing.

Goodbye, Lieutenants, Freddie thought. *End of watch.*

He slipped out the front door.

The sun was setting. The air was cooling.

Freddie stood at the shelter. His phone buzzed in his pocket. A text from Vanessa.

On the transport. ETA 2 mins.

The **Number 1** bus roared around the corner. The brakes squealed. The doors hissed open.

Freddie stepped up. He swiped his pass for the last time.

He looked down the aisle.

Vanessa was sitting in the back. She wasn't wearing her "student" clothes. She was wearing jeans and a jacket. She looked... older. Harder.

She patted the empty seat next to her.

Freddie walked down the aisle. His legs felt heavy. The bus lurched forward before he sat down, and he stumbled. Vanessa caught his arm.

"Gotcha," she said softly.

Freddie sat. He looked out the window as the bus passed the entrance to his neighborhood.

"Did you leave the note?" Vanessa asked.

"Affirmative," Freddie whispered.

"Good," Vanessa said. She didn't let go of his arm. "You did the right thing, Freddie. They're going to be so proud of you for being strong."

The Number 1 bus terminated at the Falling Branch shopping center. It was a concrete island in a sea of parking lots.

They stepped off. The wind was picking up.

"Transfer required," Freddie muttered, checking the schedule on the signpost. "Roanoke Express. Departure 19:45."

"It's right there," Vanessa pointed.

The **Roanoke Express** was a large, coach-style bus. It was the commuter line that connected the university town to the city of Roanoke.

They boarded. The driver didn't look at them. The bus was mostly empty—just a few tired workers heading home.

Vanessa led him to a seat in the middle.

"Phone," Vanessa said, holding out her hand.

Freddie pulled his Kova from his pocket. It was on.

"If you leave it on," Vanessa explained, her voice reasonable and calm, "they will track the signal. Jessica will call the police. They'll drag you back before you even get to see Seattle. Do you want them to drag you back to the cage?"

Freddie shook his head. "Negative."

"Turn it off," Vanessa commanded gently. "Go dark."

Freddie pressed the power button. The screen faded. The connection to the network—to Paige—was severed.

He handed the brick of plastic to Vanessa. She put it in her bag.

"Safe mode engaged," she smiled.

The bus descended into the city. It turned into **Campbell Court**.

It wasn't a terminal in the romantic sense. It was the ground floor of a concrete parking garage. The ceiling was low and stained with soot. The lighting was sickly yellow sodium-vapor.

The air was thick. Heavy diesel fumes hung in the stagnant space, trapped by the concrete beams. The noise was deafening—engines idling, air brakes hissing, people shouting.

Freddie coughed. He pulled his hoodie tight around his face.

Sensory Overload: Critical.

"It smells like poison," Freddie choked out.

"It's just the city," Vanessa said, steering him toward the ticket window. "Focus on me, Freddie. Look at my back."

They approached the **Pathfinder** window. The glass was scratched and bullet-proof.

"Will Call," Vanessa told the agent. "Two for Seattle. Transfer in Nashville."

The agent slid two envelopes under the glass.

"Bus 492," the agent grunted. "Lane 4. Departs 9:10 PM. Don't wander off. Security goes off duty at 9."

Vanessa took the tickets. She led Freddie to a metal bench near Lane 4.

A bus was idling right in front of them, its exhaust pipe spewing gray smoke directly into the waiting area.

Freddie sat down. He curled in on himself, knees to chest, rocking slightly.

"It is too loud," Freddie whispered. "The air quality is hazardous."

"I know," Vanessa said. She sat next to him, but she didn't hug him like Paige. She put a hand on his knee—a controlling grip, not a comforting one.

"This is the hardest part," Vanessa said. "But you have to endure it. For them. Think of Paige in Italy. Think of her eating gelato. She can't do that if you're calling her to pick you up because it smells bad."

Freddie squeezed his eyes shut. He visualized Paige in Italy. He visualized the Colosseum.

Endure, he told himself. *Endure the smog. Endure the noise.*

He checked his mental clock. **20:30 PM.**

Back at the house, *Stellar Voyage: The New Era* was starting on WNRV. Paige and Jessica would be settling in on the couch.

They would look for him. They would find the note.

Freddie let out a small, broken sound that was lost in the roar of a diesel engine.

"Shh," Vanessa soothed, patting his knee. "Almost there. The bus is coming."

They sat in the gray smog, waiting for the ride that would take him 2,600 miles away from his anchor.

Scene 4: The Horizon Line

The **Pathfinder** bus hissed, its pneumatic suspension lifting the heavy chassis off the grime of the Campbell Court pavement.

"Departure," Freddie whispered.

He was sitting in the window seat, Row 4. Vanessa was the barrier between him and the aisle.

The bus lurched forward, winding through the tight, smoggy turns of the parking garage before bursting out into the Roanoke night.

Freddie pressed his forehead against the cold glass. The city lights smeared into streaks of sodium-orange and fluorescent white.

Adventure, he told himself. *This is a Stellar Voyage. I am leaving the starbase.*

He felt a vibration in the floorboards—the massive diesel engine roaring as they hit the on-ramp for **I-581**. They were moving north, then west. Toward the mountains. Toward the future.

On the television, the credits for *Stellar Voyage: The New Era* were rolling. The majestic orchestral theme swelled, filling the living room.

Paige stretched her arms over her head, letting out a long yawn, her bare feet propped up on the coffee table.

"That was a good one," she said. "I love the episodes where the Captain gets trapped in the holodeck and has to outsmart the computer."

She looked down the short, dark hallway. The bathroom door was open and empty. The bedroom door—the only bedroom in the small house—was pulled shut.

"He never came back out," Paige noted, checking her watch. "He's been in there for... thirty minutes?"

Jessica stood up and gathered the empty pizza box and soda cans.

"He was exhausted, Paige," Jessica said quietly. "Did you see him after the presentation? He was gray. He probably stripped down, crawled under the weighted blanket, and initiated a hard reset."

"I should check on him," Paige said, instinctively standing up.

"Don't," Jessica ordered gently. "You know the protocol for a Presentation Crash. If he's under the heavy blanket, he needs zero sensory input. If we open the door and let the light in, or try to cuddle him too soon, we'll wake him up and reset the cycle."

Paige hesitated. She looked at the closed door.

Usually, the nightly ritual involved the three of them stripping down, climbing into the massive King bed that took up ninety percent of the room, and tangling their limbs together until they fell asleep. It was their safe space.

But she remembered the look in Freddie's eyes in the lobby. The way he had pulled his arm away. *Sensory Overload.*

"Okay," Paige sighed, accepting the logic. "We'll let him charge. Sensory Quarantine tonight."

Jessica walked toward the kitchen to throw away the pizza box.

"Wait," Paige said, reaching out to click off the living room lamp. "Don't go in there. The fluorescent light hums. He might hear it through the wall."

Jessica paused. She was standing in the entryway darkness. The kitchen counter was just five feet away, shrouded in deep shadow.

"Good call," Jessica whispered.

Instead of walking into the kitchen—where she might have seen the counter—she turned and stuffed the pizza box into the tall recycling bin by the front door.

"Night, Jess," Paige whispered, tiptoeing toward the bedroom.

"Night, Lieutenant," Jessica replied, locking the front door.

They opened the bedroom door with practiced silence.

The room was pitch black. The heavy blackout curtains Freddie insisted on blocked every photon of streetlamp light.

Paige navigated by memory. She moved to the side of the bed. She could see the dark, heavy mound of the 20-pound weighted blanket bunched up in the center of the mattress.

He's deep in the cocoon, she thought affectionately.

She stripped off her clothes, leaving them in a pile on the floor. Jessica did the same on the other side.

They climbed into the bed with infinite care.

Usually, they would slide to the middle. Tonight, respecting the "Quarantine," they stayed on the perimeter.

Paige lay on her side, facing the center. She reached out a hand and gently patted the heavy velvet of the weighted blanket. It felt solid. It felt full.

"Sleep well, Captain," she whispered into the dark.

She pulled her own sheet up. Across the vast expanse of the mattress, she heard Jessica settle in.

"Love you guys," Jessica murmured sleepily.

"Love you too," Paige replied.

The Avery sisters closed their eyes, drifting off to sleep on the edges of the bed, giving their brother the space they thought he needed, unaware that they were guarding an empty cocoon.

The bus was cruising at 65 miles per hour. The rhythm was hypnotic. *Thump-thump. Thump-thump.*

Freddie watched the green highway signs flash by in the headlights.

EXIT 118 - CHRISTIANSBURG / BLACKSBURG

Freddie's heart seized.

That was the exit. That was the road to Pepper Street. That was the road to the bed where he should be sleeping.

He felt a sudden, sharp panic. A physical urge to grab his phone and text Paige. *I made a mistake. Turn around. Come get me.*

He reached for his pocket. It was empty.

"Vanessa," Freddie whispered, turning to her. "We are passing the perimeter. I should... I should have informed them. They will worry."

Vanessa was reading a magazine by the overhead reading light. She looked at him calmly.

"If you told them," Vanessa said, keeping her voice low so the other passengers wouldn't hear, "they would have stopped you. They would have cried. They would have guilt-tripped you into staying in the cage."

"But they will panic," Freddie said.

"They'll find the note in the morning," Vanessa soothed. "By then, we'll be in Nashville. You're ripping the band-aid off, Freddie. It stings for a second, but then it heals."

She reached out and took his hand.

"Look forward," she commanded gently. "Don't look at the exit. Look at the road ahead."

Freddie looked back at the window. The exit sign disappeared into the darkness behind them.

The gravity of home was gone. He was drifting.

The bus slowed. It pulled off the highway into the small town of **Marion**.

"Stop?" Freddie asked.

"Pick up," Vanessa checked the schedule. "Near the **Appalachian Youth Corps** center."

They watched as a group of young men in denim jackets boarded the bus. They looked tired. They carried duffel bags.

"Like me," Freddie thought. "Travelers."

The bus merged back onto the highway. The excitement began to bleed back in, replacing the guilt. He was part of a crew now. A crew of the night.

The bus drifted off the dark ribbon of Interstate 81, its brakes hissing as it descended into a pool of harsh, sodium-vapor white light.

Freddie blinked awake, the sudden brightness stinging his eyes behind his glasses. Through the condensation on the window, the terminal came into view. It was a low, brick building, utterly unremarkable except for the sign glowing in block letters above the idling bay: **BRISTOL**.

For a heartbeat, the word felt like a warm blanket. It felt familiar. Safe.

He had been to Bristol with Jessica and Paige more times than he could count. It was a standard waypoint on the Avery map—a place of shopping trips, family drives, and stopping for milkshakes at that retro diner on State Street before heading deeper into the mountains. Bristol was a known quantity. It was still within the perimeter of *Home*.

Then his eyes adjusted, catching the smaller, less forgiving letters beneath the city name.

TN.

There was a half-second delay in his processing, a glitch in the visual recognition software, followed by a sharp, audible click in his brain. A recalibration.

This wasn't the Virginia side.

This wasn't the familiar parking lot where he had stood with his sisters, sharing a basket of fries and laughing at the touristy gimmick of the "Twin Cities." This was the other Bristol—the shadow side, the one across the line.

And he had crossed that line without them.

"State line," Vanessa announced, stretching her arms over her head with the lazy, fluid grace of a cat waking from a nap. "See it? Look out the left side. That street right there is the border. One side Virginia, one side Tennessee."

Freddie pressed his forehead against the cold glass, feeling the vibration of the idling engine rattle his teeth. He looked down at State Street.

He saw the brass markers embedded in the pavement, the ones he used to hop across as a kid. He could see the memory playing out like a hologram on the asphalt: a younger version of himself hopping back and forth—*Virginia foot, Tennessee foot*—giggling uncontrollably while Paige stood with her arms crossed, pretending to be a stern customs officer demanding to see his papers.

It had been a game then. A funny line on the ground.

Now, as the bus lurched forward and rolled over those markers with a low, humming vibration, a shiver ran up his spine that had nothing to do with the bus's air conditioning.

He imagined the wheels slipping through a force field, the kind he used to draw in the margins of his astronomy notebooks. It wasn't just a street. It was a heliopause—the boundary where the solar wind of his home system stopped, and the cold, crushing silence of interstellar space began.

He was crossing a boundary between galaxies. And he was doing it in a vessel he didn't control, with a pilot he didn't trust.

"We are in the void," Freddie whispered, the words fogging the glass.

Vanessa laughed softly, patting his knee. "We're in Tennessee, Captain. It's just new map data. We'll be in Knoxville in two hours."

But Freddie barely heard her. His chest felt tight, hollowed out, as if the gravity he had left behind had taken his breath with it.

He wasn't just in Tennessee—he was *out* of Virginia. He was out of the jurisdiction of the only two people who knew how to calibrate his world. He had crossed the border with someone who saw him as a project, not a person. Someone who didn't know that he needed white hot chocolate, or that he rocked when he was anxious, or that silence was sometimes the loudest noise in the room.

He looked at Vanessa. She was smiling at the road ahead, oblivious to the hull breach in his chest.

For the first time, the trip felt real. The adrenaline of the "secret mission" evaporated, leaving only a cold, hard residue of truth.

This wasn't an adventure. This wasn't a mistake he could fix with a phone call.

This was a departure. A one-way trajectory into the dark.

He swallowed hard, gripping the strap of his backpack until his knuckles turned white. He tried to visualize the mountains of Seattle, but all he could see was the invisible line on the pavement receding into the distance behind them.

The first seed of regret hadn't just germinated; it had taken root, deep and thorny, right in the center of his heart.

The lights of **Knoxville** appeared on the horizon—a glowing orange nebula in the valley.

The bus navigated the interchange and pulled into the Knoxville terminal.

"Bus change," the driver announced over the intercom. "All passengers for Nashville, St. Louis, and points West, transfer to Bus 104 in Bay 6."

Freddie stood up. His legs were stiff. He grabbed his small bag.

He stepped off the bus into the cool Tennessee air. It smelled different here. It smelled like humidity and distant pine.

"We made it to the first waypoint," Vanessa said, standing beside him. She looked energized. She looked proud of him.

"How are you holding up, Captain?"

Freddie adjusted his glasses. He looked at the new bus waiting in Bay 6. It was huge. Silver. Powerful.

"Systems nominal," Freddie said, the thrill of the unknown temporarily overpowering the silence of his phone. "Ready for the next jump."

"That's my guy," Vanessa said.

She led him toward the next leg of the journey, while three hundred miles behind them, the sun began to creep toward the horizon of a house that was about to wake up to a nightmare.

Scene 5: The Point of No Return

The sun was rising over the **Cumberland River**, casting a sickly yellow light over the Nashville skyline.

The bus—**Pathfinder 104**—idled in the station. It was the halfway point of the first leg.

Freddie sat by the window. His neck was stiff. His legs were cramping. The air in the bus smelled of stale coffee and strangers.

He looked out at the neon signs of Broadway, flickering out as the day began.

Regret. It wasn't a whisper anymore. It was a scream.

He thought about the weighted blanket. He thought about the warmth of the King bed on Pepper Street. He thought about Paige's breathing, the steady rhythm that helped him regulate his own heart rate.

I am not an explorer, Freddie thought, shivering despite the orange hoodie. *I am a component that has been removed from its machine.*

He wanted to turn around. He wanted to get off the bus, find a payphone, and call Jessica. *Come get me. I made a mistake.*

He looked at Vanessa. She was sleeping next to him, her head resting against the seatback. She looked peaceful. She believed in the mission.

If he woke her up... if he said he wanted to go back... she would look at him with that pity. She would say, *See? You can't function.*

He squeezed his eyes shut.

I have to keep going, Freddie told himself. *For them. So they can go to Italy.*

The sunlight hit the blackout curtains, bleeding just enough light around the edges to signal morning.

Paige rolled over. Her hand instinctively reached out to the center of the King bed, expecting to feel the heavy, comforting mound of the weighted blanket.

She felt flatness.

Her eyes snapped open.

The center of the bed was empty. The weighted blanket wasn't bunched around a sleeping form; it was lying flat, a deflated velvet skin on the mattress.

Paige sat up, her heart hammering a frantic rhythm against her ribs. She looked directly at the en-suite bathroom door, which was wide open.

It was dark. It was empty.

If Freddie needed the bathroom, he left the door open so they would hear him. If he needed water, he woke them up. If he had a bad dream, he woke them up.

He *never* moved without a signal.

"Jessica!"

It wasn't a whisper. It was a siren.

Jessica sat up instantly, adrenaline flooding her system before she was even fully awake. "What? Is he seizing?"

"He's gone," Paige gasped, scrambling out of the sheets. "The bed is cold. The bathroom is empty."

"Did he go to the kitchen?" Jessica asked, already throwing off the covers, but her face was pale. She knew the answer. Freddie didn't go to the kitchen alone. He didn't do *anything* alone.

They ran out of the bedroom, naked and terrified, into the hallway.

"Freddie!" Jessica screamed.

Silence.

They sprinted into the living room. Empty. The kitchen. Empty.

But there, on the counter where the morning sun hit the laminate, was a single sheet of notebook paper next to a set of house keys.

Paige grabbed it. Her hands shook so violently she almost dropped it.

I am setting you free. – F

"No," Paige wailed, the sound tearing out of her throat. "No, no, no!"

She shoved the paper at Jessica.

Jessica read the six words. Her mind raced. *Free?* Free meant he thought he was a captive. Free meant he thought he was a burden.

"Where is he?" Paige was hyperventilating, pacing a tight circle in the kitchen. "He didn't take his keys. He didn't take his phone—I didn't see it on the charger!"

Jessica dropped the note. The shock evaporated, replaced by cold, hard tactical fury.

"The computer," Jessica commanded. "He plans everything digitally. If he left, he built a route."

They ran into the office. The **Iron-Logic** laptop was gone, but the tower—the command center—was humming in sleep mode.

Jessica hit the spacebar. The monitors flared to life. The **Quantum OS XN Pro** login screen appeared.

User: SYSADMIN **Password:** _____

"Password," Jessica snapped.

Ncc-1701-d, Paige recited, her voice cracking. "Enterprise D. It's always the Enterprise."

Jessica typed it in. *Enter.*

The desktop loaded. Starfield background.

"Browser history," Jessica said, grabbing the mouse.

Tuesday, 14:00 PM: *Seattle Sky-Spire* **Tuesday, 14:15 PM:** *Pathfinder Bus Lines - Schedule* **Tuesday, 14:30 PM:** *Email - Order Confirmation #4492*

Jessica clicked the email link.

CONFIRMATION: ROANOKE (ROA) -> SEATTLE (SEA) DEPARTURE: TUESDAY, MAY 4 - 21:10 PM PASSENGERS: 2

"Two?" Paige whispered, looking over Jessica's shoulder. "Who is the second passenger?"

Jessica scrolled down. The receipt didn't list a name, just "Adult Ticket."

"Vanessa," Jessica hissed. The name tasted like poison. "She was whispering to him in the lobby. She was at the presentation. She took him."

"She put him on a bus?" Paige screamed. "Jessica, it's four days to Seattle! The sensory overload... the vibration... he can't survive that!"

She stopped. Her eyes went wide.

"The meds," Paige gasped.

She turned and ran into the en-suite bathroom. She threw open the medicine cabinet.

There, on the second shelf, was the orange bottle. **Baclofen**.

It was full.

"He left them," Paige cried, grabbing the bottle and running back to the desk. "He thinks he doesn't need them? Or he thinks he doesn't deserve them? Jessica, without these... the spasticity... he's going to lock up. He's going to be in agony by tomorrow."

Jessica stood up. She wasn't crying. She was mobilizing.

"He isn't going to be on that bus for four days," Jessica stated.

"We have to call the police," Paige said.

"No," Jessica cut her off. "He's an adult. He left a note. The police will call it a voluntary departure. We handle this ourselves."

She sat back down at the computer. She opened a new tab. **Gateway Airlines**.

"Roanoke to Seattle," Jessica muttered, typing furiously. "Transfer in Nashville (BNA). If we leave now, we can catch the 11:00 AM flight. We land in Seattle tonight."

"Tonight?" Paige asked, clutching the pill bottle to her chest.

"We aren't chasing the bus," Jessica said, her eyes locked on the screen. "We're beating it. We will be standing on the curb when he gets off."

She clicked **CONFIRM**.

"Hotel," Jessica said. "I need tactical positioning."

She pulled up a map of downtown Seattle. She found the **Pathfinder Terminal** on Stewart Street.

"There," she pointed. "**The Cascade Suites**. Extended Stay. Directly across the street. We can watch the arrival bay from the window."

She booked it. **Guest Names:** Jessica Avery, Paige Avery, Freddie Avery. **Room Type:** Grand Suite. One King Bed.

"One King Bed," Jessica said firmly. "Because when we get him back, we are never letting him go again."

She stood up. "Pack a bag. Essentials only. And bring the meds."

The bus had been moving for twenty hours.

Freddie was asleep, his head bouncing against the window as the bus rumbled down **Interstate 70**.

The bus slowed, pulling off the highway into a gravel lot.

COLBY TRUCK STOP - 15 MINUTE BREAK

"Freddie," Vanessa shook his shoulder. "Rest stop. Stretch your legs."

Freddie woke up. He groaned. His back felt like it was on fire. His legs were locked tight.

"Pain," Freddie mumbled.

"I know," Vanessa said. "Walk it off."

They stepped off the bus.

Colby, Kansas, was not an adventure. It was a desolate, wind-swept concrete slab in the middle of nowhere. The wind howled across the plains, kicking up dust that stung their eyes.

The sun was setting, painting the sky a bruised purple.

Vanessa shivered. She looked at the endless, flat horizon.

Suddenly, the "romance" of the road trip evaporated. This wasn't a movie. This was a dirty truck stop with a broken vending machine and a smell of diesel and manure.

She looked at Freddie. He was limping. He was holding his back. He looked small and broken against the vast emptiness of the plains.

What have I done?

The doubt hit her like a physical blow. She had taken a disabled boy away from his caregivers. She had put him on a four-day torture test.

I should turn around, Vanessa thought. *I should call Jessica. I should send him home.*

But then she thought about the "Matriarch Gaze." She thought about Paige's smug hug.

If she turned back now, she was the villain. She was the failure.

No, Vanessa decided, hardening her heart against the wind. *We push through. Once we get to Seattle... once he sees the mountains... he'll be happy. I just have to get him there.*

"Let's get a soda," Vanessa said, grabbing Freddie's arm. "We're halfway there."

Freddie looked at the horizon. He didn't see the mountains. He only saw the distance growing between him and the note on the counter.

"Halfway," Freddie whispered.

They got back on the bus. The door hissed shut. There was no turning back.

Scene 6: The Detour

The silver **Avalon** sedan tore down the left lane of Interstate 81, the engine whining as the RPMs climbed.

Jessica Avery was driving. Her hand rested on the stick shift, gripping the knob so hard her knuckles were white.

Clutch. Shift. Fourth to Fifth. Gas.

She drove with a terrifying, mechanical precision. She wasn't driving to class. She wasn't driving to the grocery store. She was driving to war.

In the passenger seat, Paige was curled into a ball. She clutched Freddie's orange pill bottle in one hand and the printout of the flight itinerary in the other. She stared out the window at the blurred trees, her eyes red-rimmed and unblinking.

"We're making good time," Jessica announced, her voice tight. "ETA to Roanoke Long Term Parking is 09:40. Flight departs at 11:00."

"He's been gone twelve hours," Paige whispered, the math playing on a loop in her head. "Twelve hours without meds. Twelve hours of vibration. Jess, what if he gets off the bus before Seattle? What if he panics and gets off in... I don't know, Missouri?"

"He won't," Jessica said, downshifting smoothly as a truck cut them off. "He follows the plan. The ticket says Seattle. He will go to Seattle. And we will be there."

They pulled into the **Roanoke Regional Airport**. Jessica bypassed the expensive garage and headed for the Long Term lot. She parked the Avalon under a light pole—Position G-14.

"Move," Jessica commanded.

They grabbed their single duffel bags. They ran to the shuttle stop.

Inside the terminal, **Gateway Airlines** was a chaotic sea of people. It was a budget carrier, famous for its "cattle call" boarding process. No assigned seats. First come, first serve.

"We need Boarding Group A," Jessica said, eyeing the monitors. "If we get stuck in middle seats, we can't plan."

They checked in at the kiosk. **Group A, Position 14 & 15.**

"Perfect," Jessica breathed.

They moved through security. Paige carried Freddie's medication in a clear plastic bag, ready to fight any TSA agent who questioned it. No one did.

At **Gate 4**, the plane was waiting. A 737 painted in gaudy orange and blue.

"Flight 492 to Nashville," the agent announced. "Group A, line up."

Jessica and Paige stood at the front of the line.

"We're coming, Captain," Paige whispered, clutching the boarding pass. "We're flying over the void."

The landscape had changed. The endless flat cornfields of Kansas had given way to the rolling, scrub-brush foothills of the Rockies.

Freddie sat by the window. He was exhausted. The vibration of the bus had settled into his bones, a constant, buzzing frequency that made his teeth ache.

He looked for the mountains. He wanted to see the snow-capped peaks Vanessa had promised.

But as they passed **Fort Collins**, the bus didn't stay on the massive, comforting concrete ribbon of **Interstate 25**.

The blinker clicked. The bus took an exit.

"Query?" Freddie asked, his voice raspy. "Why are we exiting the primary artery?"

"Detour," Vanessa said, checking the map she had bought at the last gas station. "The main highway goes through the Eisenhower Tunnel. It's high altitude. Sometimes they route the buses north to avoid the grade and the traffic."

The bus turned onto **US-287**.

It wasn't an interstate. It was a two-lane blacktop cutting straight through the high desert.

The civilization of the highway—the gas stations, the billboards, the other cars—vanished.

Suddenly, they were alone.

To the left, jagged rock formations rose up like teeth. To the right, endless sagebrush. The sun was dipping below the horizon, casting long, menacing shadows across the road.

Freddie gripped the armrest.

"This is incorrect," Freddie whispered. "This is a secondary route. It is dark. There are no lights."

"It's a shortcut to Laramie," Vanessa soothed, though she looked a little nervous herself. "It's fine, Freddie. Look at the rocks. It's scenic."

"It is desolate," Freddie corrected.

The bus picked up speed, roaring down the empty road. Without the streetlights of the interstate, the cabin was plunged into darkness.

Freddie felt the isolation wrap around him. On I-81 or I-70, help was always an exit away. Here, on this lonely stretch of 287, if the bus broke down, they would be swallowed by the night.

He squeezed his eyes shut and started to rock.

Paige would not take this road, he thought. *Paige takes the well-lit path.*

The bus hissed into the **Salt Lake City** intermodal hub. It had been a grueling run through Wyoming, bouncing over expansion joints in the dark.

"Bus change," the driver announced. "Layover is two hours. Next bus departs at 04:00."

"Okay," Vanessa yawned, standing up. "Let's get off. We need food."

"Stand by," Freddie murmured.

He tried to stand up.

A bolt of white-hot lightning shot up his spine.

"Ah!" Freddie gasped, collapsing back into the seat.

"Freddie?" Vanessa asked, looking back. "Leg cramp?"

"Back," Freddie gritted out, tears springing to his eyes. "Lower quadrant. Burning."

He tried again. He used his arms to push himself up, keeping his weight off his tailbone. He shuffled into the aisle, his legs stiff and uncooperative.

They made it off the bus and into the terminal. It was bright, sterile, and cold.

"Restroom," Freddie said urgently.

Vanessa pointed to the men's room. "I'll wait here."

Freddie shuffled into the restroom. It was empty. He moved into the large accessible stall and locked the door.

He leaned against the sink, breathing hard. The burning sensation on his lower back wasn't fading. It was throbbing.

He turned around and lifted the back of his shirt in the mirror.

He twisted his neck to see.

There, right at the base of his spine, the skin wasn't just red. It was angry. A dark, purple bruise the size of a half-dollar had formed, and in the center, the skin was broken and weeping. **Pressure Sore. Stage 2.**

Freddie stared at it in horror.

At home, Jessica checked his skin every night. Paige made sure he shifted his weight every hour. They had special cushions. They had protocols.

Vanessa had told him to "walk it off" in Colby. She hadn't reminded him to shift. She didn't know the schematic.

He let his shirt fall. The fabric scraped against the open wound, sending a fresh wave of nausea through him.

He unlocked the stall. He walked out to the waiting area.

Vanessa was buying a bag of pretzels.

"You okay?" she asked cheerfully. "Ready for the last leg?"

Freddie looked at her. He wanted to scream. He wanted to tell her he was bleeding. He wanted to demand a doctor.

But he heard her voice from the lobby in his head: *He's a burden. He can't function.*

If he told her he had a sore, she would be right. She would see how broken he was.

"Affirmative," Freddie lied, his voice trembling. "Systems nominal."

"Great," Vanessa smiled, handing him a pretzel. "Next stop, Idaho. Then... Seattle."

Freddie took the pretzel. He sat down gingerly on the hard plastic bench, forcing himself not to wince as the sore pressed against the seat.

He was 2,000 miles from home. He was injured. And he was alone.

Scene 7: The Burning Mile

The Boeing 737 banked sharply, the engines whining as they began their descent into Nashville.

"Ladies and gentlemen, we're starting our initial approach into BNA," the captain's voice crackled over the intercom. "Weather in Nashville is sunny and seventy-five."

In Seat 14A, Paige Avery didn't look out the window. She was gripping the armrests so hard her knuckles were white.

"We land in twenty minutes," Jessica said from Seat 14B. She had her **MagnaByte** laptop open on the tray table, running a spreadsheet of arrival times. "Layover is forty-five minutes. Tight, but manageable. We stay in the A-terminal."

"He's still moving," Paige whispered. She wasn't looking at the flight tracker. She was staring at the back of the seat in front of her, visualizing a silver bus moving across a map in her head. "I can feel it. He's bouncing."

"He's in Utah," Jessica calculated, checking her watch. "Or crossing into Idaho. We are travelling at 500 miles per hour. He is travelling at 65. We will pass him over the Rockies."

"Did you pack the cushion?" Paige asked suddenly, panic flaring in her eyes. "The gel cushion for his chair? If he's sitting on a bus seat for this long..."

"I couldn't bring the chair cushion, Paige," Jessica said gently. "It wouldn't fit in the overhead. But I grabbed the memory foam travel pillow. It's better than

nothing."

Paige squeezed her eyes shut. She knew Freddie's skin. She knew how fragile it was.

"He's hurting," Paige murmured. "I know he is. And he's not telling her."

"We'll fix it," Jessica promised, closing her laptop with a snap. "Tonight. In Seattle. We fix everything."

The landscape had flattened out into a relentless, monotonous expanse of brown scrub brush and gray asphalt. This was **The Idaho Line**.

Inside the bus, the air was stale and hot. The air conditioning was struggling against the high desert sun beating down on the metal roof.

Freddie sat in the window seat. He wasn't looking at the scenery anymore. He was focused entirely on the screaming nerve endings in his lower back.

The pressure sore—the "secret fire" —was no longer a dull ache. It was a sharp, biting agony that throbbed with every vibration of the engine.

Shift right, his brain commanded. He leaned to the right, pressing his shoulder against the hot window.

Pain spike. The movement pulled the skin.

Shift left. He leaned toward Vanessa.

Vanessa looked up from her magazine. She lowered her sunglasses.

"You're fidgeting, Captain," she said. Her voice wasn't mean, but it was tired. She was exhausted too. "Try to sit still. We'll be in Boise soon."

"It hurts," Freddie whispered. He didn't say *skin.* He didn't say *sore.* He just said the generic word.

"I know," Vanessa sighed. "It's a long ride. My back hurts too. Just try to sleep."

She didn't offer to help him move. She didn't check his positioning. She just told him to endure it.

Freddie looked at her.

In the beginning, back in Roanoke, she had been the Pilot. The partner in the adventure. Now, as he looked at her profile against the endless gray plains, the lyrics of his own future song began to form in the static of his mind.

Are you my lover, or are you my guard? Is this a journey, or a prison yard?

She held his phone in her bag. She held the tickets. She held the water bottle. She held the key to every single part of him .

"Boise," Freddie croaked, his throat dry.

"Just a quick stop," Vanessa said. "Driver swap. Then we push to Washington."

The bus rumbled on. Mile after mile. The vibration traveled up the seat, through his spine, and into his teeth.

He closed his eyes and tried to summon the image of the King Bed on Pepper Street. He tried to feel the weight of the blanket. But the image was fuzzy, distorted by the pain and the distance.

I am drifting, Freddie thought. *The anchor is gone.*

Scene 8: The Pasco Lock

The door to the Family Restroom clicked shut. Vanessa threw the deadbolt with a sharp, metallic clack.

The room was small, smelling of industrial bleach and stale water. The fluorescent light overhead buzzed with a dying, flickering hum that grated against Freddie's nerves like sandpaper.

Freddie leaned against the sink, his legs trembling uncontrollably. The pressure sore on his lower back was a "fire burning on his skin," throbbing in time with his racing heartbeat. He just wanted to sit down. He just wanted water.

But Vanessa didn't move to the sink. She moved to him.

She stepped into his personal space, pressing him back against the cold tile wall. Her eyes were bright, almost feverish. She wasn't looking at him with kindness; she was looking at him with expectation.

"We're alone," Vanessa whispered, her voice tight. "Finally. No sisters. No bus driver. Just us."

She placed her hands on his shoulders, her grip tight, digging in.

"Stop shaking, Freddie," she commanded. "Stop being the victim. I want to see the *real* you. I want to see the Wolf."

Freddie blinked, the buzz of the light seeming to get louder. "Wolf?"

"The part of you that takes what he wants," Vanessa hissed, pressing her body against his. "The primal part. The part that isn't afraid to break the rules."

She reached for the waistband of his jeans.

"Let's make this real. Sunday morning is coming, Freddie. Do you know what the scripture says about Sunday morning?"

Freddie shook his head, his breath hitching. "No data."

"It says a man shall leave his father and mother," Vanessa recited, her voice taking on a strange, fanatical edge, "and he shall **cleave** to his wife."

Freddie's eyes widened behind his glasses. The word hit him like a physical threat.

"Cleave?" Freddie stammered. "Like... to cut? Like a butcher?"

"Like glue!" Vanessa laughed, but it wasn't a happy sound. It was impatient. "No, Freddie. You leave them behind. You cut them off. You sever the limb to save the body. That's what we're doing. You have to cleave to me."

"I do not want to be cut," Freddie whispered, terrified. "I do not want to amputate."

"Stop talking!" Vanessa snapped. She was losing patience with his literalism. She grabbed his hands and forced them onto her hips. "Stop thinking! Feel! Be the Wolf, Freddie! Take this!"

She kissed him. It wasn't soft. It was aggressive. She ground her hips against him, trying to force a reaction, trying to drag a response out of his exhausted, pain-racked body.

Freddie flinched violently. The sensory input was overwhelming—her perfume, the hum of the light, the pain in his back, the terrifying image of a meat cleaver severing him from Paige.

"Negative," Freddie rasped, pulling his head back. "Stop. Variable rejected."

"Don't you dare reject me," Vanessa growled, pulling him back in. "I kidnapped you for this! I dragged you across the country to set the animal free! Now show me!"

"Refusal!" Freddie shouted, panic rising.

He didn't just pull away. He shoved her. It was a frantic, clumsy shove of survival, fueled by the terror of being "cleaved."

Vanessa stumbled back, her hip hitting the hard plastic of the baby changing table.

The rejection hit her like a physical blow. To Vanessa, who used sex as control, this wasn't just a "no." It was an insult. It was a declaration that she—even here, alone, offering herself—wasn't enough to wake the "man" inside him.

The mask shattered.

"You ungrateful little freak!" Vanessa screamed.

The sound was deafening in the tiled room. It bounced off the walls, a sonic weapon.

"I am trying to save you!" she yelled, her face twisting into ugliness. "I am trying to give you a life! And you just stand there shaking like a child! You ruin everything, Freddie!"

"Please," Freddie whimpered, sliding down the wall to the floor, covering his ears. "Too loud. Too loud."

"Oh, now it's too loud?" Vanessa shrieked, looming over him. "You didn't mind the noise when Paige was babying you! But when I want something? When I want one moment?"

She didn't just scream. She lashed out.

She swung her hand and slapped him. Hard.

CRACK.

Her palm connected with the side of Freddie's face, knocking his glasses askew and snapping his head to the side. The sound was sharp and shocking in the tiled room.

Freddie gasped, a sharp intake of air. The pain was immediate, but the shock was worse. Tears sprang to his eyes instantly. He let out a sob—a raw, broken sound of absolute betrayal.

He dropped to the floor, curling into a tight ball against the dirty tiles. He covered his head with his arms, burying his face in his knees.

"Please," Freddie wept, his shoulders shaking. "Please don't. No cleaving. No more."

"Pathetic," Vanessa spat, looking down at him with pure disgust.

She checked her watch. The bus for Seattle departed in four minutes.

She looked at the door. She could leave him. She could walk away right now.

But if she arrived in Seattle alone, she was just a girl who ran away to live in a trailer. She was a failure. If she arrived with *him*, she was still the leader. She was still the one in charge. She needed him as proof that she had done something.

"Get up," she commanded coldly.

Freddie didn't move. He was in full system lockout, rocking slightly, humming a low note of distress.

"I said, get up!" Vanessa yelled.

She didn't wait for him to comply. She bent down and grabbed a handful of his orange hoodie near the shoulder. She grabbed his upper arm with her other hand, her nails digging in.

She yanked.

It wasn't a helping hand. It was a dead-lift.

"No!" Freddie shrieked as he was hauled upward.

His spastic legs, stiff from days of travel, didn't want to unbend. His feet scrambled uselessly on the slick tile. The sudden movement stretched the skin on his lower back, tearing the pressure sore wide open.

Vanessa didn't care. She dragged him up, hauling his dead weight until he was forced to stand or fall. She shoved him toward the sink.

"Wash your face," she hissed, breathing hard from the exertion. "Put your glasses on. We are getting on that bus, and you are going to smile."

Scene 9: The Silence

The bus was quiet, the engine humming a monotonous drone as it climbed the arid hills toward Yakima. The afternoon sun was hidden behind a thick layer of gray cloud cover, making the cabin feel dim and claustrophobic.

Freddie sat in the window seat, pressed as far against the glass as he could get, trying to put millimeters of distance between himself and the aisle seat.

He wasn't rocking. He wasn't humming. He was frozen.

The pain in his lower back was a constant, white-hot knife. The stage 2 sore had ruptured during the scuffle in the Pasco bathroom, and now the rough denim of his jeans chafed the raw wound with every vibration of the road.

But the physical pain was secondary to the cold, hard knot of terror in his stomach.

Kidnapped.

Vanessa had said it. *I kidnapped you.*

She hadn't stuttered. She hadn't joked. She had screamed it in the tiled echo of the restroom.

He looked at her out of the corner of his eye. She was sitting next to him, arms crossed, staring straight ahead at the seatback in front of her. She had her headphones on, listening to a CD player, blocking him out.

She wasn't his girlfriend. She wasn't his friend. She was his captor.

He thought about the bathroom. The way she had tried to force him. The way she had touched him when he said no. The way her hand had cracked across his face.

Violation, the logic center of his brain cataloged. *Assault.*

He gripped the armrest. His hands were shaking—not from spasticity, but from a cold, lucid rage he had never felt before.

He had let her do this. He had walked onto the bus. He had turned off his phone and left it in Christiansburg.

I broke the protocol, Freddie thought bitterly. *I left the Unit.*

He made a vow then, staring out at the sagebrush and the dark, looming mountains of the Cascades ahead.

The moment this bus stops. The moment the doors open.

I am not going with her. I will find a phone. I will call the Operator. I will say: "Collect call from Freddie." And Paige and Jessica will accept the charges.

He didn't know they were already in the city. He didn't know they were watching the bus terminal from a window across the street.

He just knew he had to survive the next two hours without breaking.

The Rescue

Scene 1: The Advance Team

The rain in Seattle wasn't like the rain in Virginia. It wasn't a storm; it was a pervasive, mist-like drizzle that soaked everything instantly.

Jessica and Paige stepped out of the sliding doors at the Rental Car Center. They were exhausted, but the clock was on their side. They had flown across the country in seven hours, chasing the sun west, landing while it was still afternoon.

"Reservation for Avery," Jessica told the agent at the counter. "Mid-size."

They were given the keys to a mid-sized sedan.

Jessica threw her bag in the trunk. She got in the driver's seat. She didn't check the mirrors. She didn't adjust the seat. She just put the car in drive.

"GPS says twenty minutes to downtown," Jessica said, peeling out of the garage. "Traffic is light."

Paige sat in the passenger seat. She had the orange pill bottle in her lap. She was turning it over and over in her hands.

"He's quiet now," Paige whispered, staring at the rain-streaked window. "I can't feel him screaming anymore. He's just... hurting."

"He's conserving energy," Jessica said, merging onto **I-5 North**. "He's shutting down non-essential systems. It's a survival mechanism."

They drove in silence, the windshield wipers slapping a steady rhythm against the glass. *Slap-swish. Slap-swish.*

As the skyline of Seattle rose up out of the mist—the Sky-Spire glowing white in the distance—neither of them remarked on the view.

They weren't tourists. They were a retrieval team.

They took the **Stewart Street** exit.

"There," Jessica pointed.

On the left, a gritty, low-slung building with buses idling in the bays. **The Pathfinder Terminal**.

Directly across the street, a generic brick high-rise. **The Cascade Suites**.

Jessica pulled into the hotel garage.

"Check-in," Jessica commanded. "Then we establish the lookout."

The mid-sized white sedan, a generic fleet model from "Blue Sky Rentals," pulled into the covered garage of **The Cascade Suites**.

Jessica put the car in park. She turned off the engine. For a moment, neither of them moved. The silence in the car was heavy, a stark contrast to the roar of the jet engines that had filled their ears for the last seven hours.

"We're here," Paige whispered. "We're actually here."

"We beat him," Jessica said, unbuckling her seatbelt. "Now we dig in."

They grabbed their bags and took the elevator to the lobby. It was a functional, slightly dated space with beige tile and fake Ficus trees, but it smelled clean.

Jessica approached the front desk. The clerk, a young man with a name tag reading *DAVE*, looked up.

"Checking in," Jessica said, sliding her credit card across the marble. "Reservation for Avery."

"Ah, yes," Dave typed. "Grand Suite. One King Bed. For two adults?"

"Three," Jessica corrected firmly. "Myself, my sister here, and my brother, Freddie Avery. He will be arriving on Friday."

"Okay, I'll add him to the registry," Dave said. "And how many nights will you be staying?"

"We aren't sure," Jessica said. "Put us down for three nights for now, but keep it open-ended. We might need... recovery time."

"No problem," Dave said, handing over two key cards. "Room 412. Fourth floor, street view."

"Perfect," Jessica said. "Thank you."

Jessica dropped the duffel bags on the floor. The room smelled of lemon disinfectant and aggressive air conditioning—a sterile, manufactured scent that was infinitely preferable to the air outside.

She went straight to the window. It was a large, single pane of heavy glass, looking directly down onto Stewart Street.

Below them, the city was a wet, grey river of traffic. Directly across the street sat the Pathfinder Terminal. It was a low, ugly building of beige brick and

grime-streaked windows. The bus bays were open to the air, covered only by a corrugated metal roof that dripped rainwater onto the idling silver coaches.

Clouds of blue diesel smoke drifted up from the bays, swirling in the wind before smashing against the hotel glass.

"Can you smell it?" Paige asked, standing near the kitchenette, afraid to come closer.

Jessica pressed her hand against the cold glass, checking the seal. "No. The seal is tight. But I can see it. It looks like a factory down there."

She watched a driver in a uniform smoking a cigarette by a wheel well. The exhaust from the idling buses hung heavy in the alleyway, a toxic fog that Freddie would have choked on instantly.

"Line of sight confirmed," Jessica noted, stepping back but keeping her eyes on the arrival lane. "We can see the buses coming in from the highway. But we keep this window closed. Not for sun, not for air. We keep this room a clean room. When he gets here... he's going to need clean air."

"I can't just sit here," Paige said, pacing the small kitchenette area behind her. "I feel like I need to do something. He's out there somewhere, hungry and hurting, and I'm just... standing on carpet."

Jessica turned from the window. She looked at the empty kitchenette—the bare counters, the hollow refrigerator. It was too sterile. It didn't look like safety; it looked like a waiting room.

"We need supplies," Jessica decided, opening the empty refrigerator. "When he gets here on Friday, he is going to be starving. He won't have eaten a real meal in three days. We need immediate calories. No cooking, no waiting."

They left the hotel and walked two blocks to Market Street Grocery, a local urban market that smelled of damp cardboard and produce.

They grabbed a cart. They didn't shop for themselves; they shopped for the Freddie Protocol.

"Soft foods," Paige muttered, scanning the aisles with laser focus. "He's going to be too tired to chew anything tough."

They loaded the cart with the essentials of the Avery diet:

- Two loaves of soft white bread.
- A jar of smooth peanut butter (no crunchy; texture risk).
- Grape jelly.
- Three boxes of "Honey Oat Rings" (his safe cereal).
- Two gallons of whole milk.
- A package of mild cheddar cheese slices.
- A bag of frozen chicken tenders (easy to heat in the kitchenette oven).

Then, Jessica stopped in the beverage aisle. She reached for the most critical item on the shelf.

"Comfort fuel," Jessica said, dropping a canister of White Hot Chocolate mix into the cart. "The second he walks in that door, we get a mug in his hand."

They paid and hauled the heavy bags back to the hotel, ignoring the misting rain. They rode the elevator up to the fourth floor and began stocking the kitchenette.

They filled the fridge. They lined up the cereal boxes. They put the white hot chocolate on the counter next to the kettle.

When they were done, the room didn't look like a generic hotel suite anymore. It looked like a forward operating base.

"Ready," Jessica said, looking at the stocked shelves. "Now we just need the refugee."

"One last thing," Jessica said after the groceries were put away. "We need eyes on the ground."

They walked across the wet street to the bus station.

Up close, the terminal was grim. It smelled of diesel fumes, wet wool, and floor wax. The lighting was a harsh, buzzing fluorescent yellow.

"It's loud," Paige noted, wincing at the echo of a loudspeaker announcement. "He's going to hate this."

They walked to the arrival gates. Jessica mapped it out.

"Okay," she pointed. "Buses from the east unload at Gates 1, 2, or 3. They come in through that tunnel there. We can stand right here by the glass partition. We'll see him the second he steps off."

"Gate 3," Paige whispered, touching the cold glass. "We'll be right here."

They stood there for a long moment, visualizing the bus that was currently hundreds of miles away, carrying their broken brother toward them.

"Friday," Jessica said. "We hold the line until Friday."

Thursday was the hardest day. The travel adrenaline had worn off, leaving only the waiting.

Paige sat on the King bed, surrounded by pamphlets she had grabbed from the hotel lobby rack.

"Jess," Paige said, looking at a brochure for the **Seattle Sky-Spire**. "I've been thinking."

"About?" Jessica was at the table, re-checking the Pathfinder schedule for the tenth time.

"When he gets here... he's going to be a wreck," Paige said. "If we just throw him on a plane immediately and fly back to Virginia, that's another six hours of travel trauma on top of the bus ride. He might snap."

"So?"

"So, we stay," Paige said. "Just for a few days. We turn this into a trip. We overwrite the bad data with good data."

She held up a brochure for the **Bayfront Aquarium**.

"Look. Quiet. Blue lights. Fish. He loves aquariums. It's sensory soothing."

She held up another one for the **Great Wheel**.

"Smooth rotation. A view of the city from above—like Wind Rock, but without the hike. He likes elevation."

Jessica looked at the brochures. She thought about Freddie's love for *Stellar Voyage* and systems.

"We treat him like a tourist," Jessica mused. "Not a victim. We show him the city. We show him that the world is big and cool, not just a scary bus ride."

"Exactly," Paige said. "We act like this was the plan all along. 'Hey, you made it to Seattle! Let's go see the fish.' "

Jessica smiled. It was the first time she had smiled in two days.

"Operation: Decompression," Jessica said. "Approved. Map out the itinerary. Low sensory impact only."

The room was typical for an extended stay—beige walls, generic art, a kitchenette.

But it had the asset Jessica required: A large window facing Stewart Street.

She pulled the curtains back.

Directly across the street, she could see the arrival bays of the bus station. She could see the passengers getting off, dragging their luggage, hugging their families.

"Visual confirmed," Jessica said. "We have a clear line of sight on Bay 1 through 4."

She set up a chair by the window. She placed a notebook and a pen on the sill.

"We take shifts," Jessica ordered. "Two hours on, two hours off. The bus is scheduled to arrive tomorrow at 18:00, but schedules change. We do not miss the arrival."

Paige was sitting on the edge of the King bed. She placed the orange pill bottle on the nightstand.

"Jess," Paige said softly. "What if he doesn't want to come back?"

Jessica turned from the window. Her face was hard, shadowed by the streetlights.

"He left a note saying he wanted to be free," Paige whispered. "What if... what if we drag him back and he hates us for it?"

"Did you feel him in the bathroom?" Jessica asked. "Did you feel him screaming?"

Paige nodded, tears welling up. "Yes."

"Then he isn't free," Jessica stated. "He's a hostage. And we don't negotiate for hostages. We extract them."

She turned back to the window.

"Get some sleep, Lieutenant. I'll take the first watch."

Paige curled up on the bed, fully clothed. She clutched a pillow to her chest—the same travel pillow Jessica had packed for Freddie.

Across the street, a bus pulled in. Jessica leaned forward, scanning the passengers.

It wasn't him.

She sat back. She waited.

The rain fell on Seattle, washing over the hotel, the bus station, and the miles of highway where a broken brother was counting the seconds until he could come home.

The rain had picked up again, drumming a steady, nervous rhythm against the glass of the hotel window.

Jessica sat in the armchair, her laptop open, though she wasn't really looking at the screen. She was staring at the clock on the wall, tracking the minutes like radar blips.

Paige was sitting on the edge of the King bed. She was holding the orange pill bottle in her hands, turning it over and over. Click-rattle. Click-rattle.

She wasn't just fidgeting. She was calculating.

Her mind was three hundred miles away in Pasco, Washington. She wasn't seeing a vision; she was running a physics simulation based on hard data.

- Variable A: Freddie has been on a vibrating bus for seventy-two hours.
- Variable B: He has had zero doses of Baclofen.
- Result: His spasticity is critical. His legs are locked. He is dead weight.

"14:15," Paige whispered, staring at the bottle. "Pasco. Restroom stop."

She closed her eyes. She built the scene in her head with terrifying clarity. She visualized the hard tile of a bus station bathroom. She visualized Vanessa—impatient, aggressive, needing to be in control.

The simulation ran: Vanessa tells him to move. Freddie, overwhelmed and stiff, engages the "Emergency Brake." He drops to the floor. He curls up. With me.

Paige's grip on the bottle tightened. Vanessa doesn't know the protocol, Paige thought. She doesn't know how to wait him out. She'll get angry.

Suddenly, Paige gasped.

It was a sharp, sucking sound, involuntary and violent. She dropped the pill bottle. It hit the carpet with a muffled thud. Her hand flew to her left cheek, covering it instantly, her eyes snapping open in shock.

"Paige?" Jessica was out of the chair in a second. "What is it?"

Paige wasn't bleeding, but she was trembling. She wasn't feeling magic; she was feeling the inevitable conclusion of the logic chain. She knew Vanessa's temper. She knew Freddie's silence.

She hit him, Paige realized. The thought was so loud, so certain, that she flinched from the phantom impact.

"She hit him," Paige choked out, rubbing her cheek furiously. "He wouldn't answer her... and she hit him. In the face."

Jessica froze. She didn't ask how Paige knew. She knew Paige's accuracy rating regarding Freddie was 100%.

"And now..." Paige's breathing hitched. Her mind raced forward. If he's on the floor... and the bus is leaving... she has to move him. She isn't strong enough to lift him.

Paige's body jerked forward on the mattress. She gasped again, a wet, ragged sound of distress. She grabbed her left shoulder, her fingers digging into the muscle, then arched her back, her hand flying to her lower spine.

In her mind, she saw the physics of it. She saw Vanessa grabbing his hoodie. She saw the friction of denim against industrial tile. She saw the fragile skin on his lower back—already stressed from the bus ride—tearing under the drag force.

"His back," Paige whispered, tears spilling over her lashes. "She's dragging him, Jess."

She looked up at Jessica, her face pale with the visceral horror of the math.

"He can't walk. His legs are locked. So she's dragging him across the floor. I can feel it... the skin... it's ripping."

She sobbed, curling in on herself to protect the wound that she knew, with absolute certainty, was bleeding three hundred miles away.

"She's hurting him because she has to get him on that bus. She's forcing him."

Jessica stared out the window at the empty bus bay across the street. She didn't question the intel. She processed it as fact. The abuser was escalating. The hostage was injured.

Her jaw set so hard a muscle feathered in her cheek.

"She's bringing him," Jessica said, her voice lethal. "She isn't leaving him there. She needs him as a trophy. She's dragging him onto that bus."

"He's terrified," Paige wept, rocking back and forth, holding her arm where she imagined Vanessa's grip digging in. "He's just doing what she says because she hurt him."

"Good," Jessica said, though her eyes were wet with fury. "Let her bring him. If she drags him onto that bus... she delivers him to us."

She walked over to the bed and sat next to Paige. She wrapped her arm around her sister's shoulders, pulling her into a tight, grounding squeeze.

"Four hours," Jessica promised, staring at the terminal like a sniper waiting for a target. "That bus arrives in four hours. And when it does... we extract him. Immediately."

Scene 2: The Intercept

The interior of the Seattle bus terminal was a stark contrast to the rainy street outside. It was bright, smelling of floor wax and stale coffee, humming with the noise of travelers and the PA system.

Jessica Avery stood at the ticket counter. She wasn't holding a ticket; she was holding a photo of Freddie.

"The bus from Boise," Jessica said to the agent, her voice calm but commanding. "Schedule 492. Is it on time?"

The agent tapped his keyboard. "Pulling in now, Ma'am. Gate 3. Lower level."

"Thank you."

Jessica turned to Paige. Paige was standing near a pillar, bouncing on the balls of her feet, her eyes locked on the door marked **GATE 3**. She looked like a sprinter waiting for the gun.

"Gate 3," Jessica said. "It's here."

They walked to the gate. A glass wall separated the waiting area from the bus bays. Through the glass, they saw the massive silver bus hiss to a halt. The air brakes purged with a loud *PSSHHH*.

The destination sign above the windshield flickered off. The engine died.

"He's on that bus," Paige whispered, pressing her hand against the glass.

Passengers began to file off. A family with tired children. A man in a cowboy hat.

Then, a girl with messy hair and a hard, angry expression stepped down. She looked over her shoulder, annoyed.

"Move it," she mouthed.

Behind her, a figure emerged from the shadows of the stairwell.

He was wearing a dirty orange hoodie. He was moving slowly, gripping the handrail white-knuckled, stepping down with a stiffness that screamed of pain. He looked gray, exhausted, and utterly defeated.

"Freddie," Paige breathed.

She didn't wait. The moment Freddie stepped onto the terminal floor, clearing the glass partition, Paige moved.

Freddie stumbled as his feet hit the concrete. The ground felt unstable after three days of constant vibration. His legs buckled slightly, the muscles spasming uncontrollably without the Baclofen to regulate them.

"Come on," the voice beside him snapped. Vanessa grabbed his elbow, her fingers digging in to steer him toward the exit. "Let's find a taxi."

Freddie didn't look up. He kept his head lowered, the hood of his orange sweatshirt pulled tight like a cowl. He was focusing entirely on his breathing, trying to keep the pain in his lower back from making him vomit. The denim of his jeans was stiff and stuck to his skin—glued there by dried blood.

I am a prisoner, he thought, the logic cold and absolute. *I cannot walk.*

Freddie!

The scream didn't come from inside his head. It cut through the diesel hum of the terminal from ten feet away.

Freddie froze. He knew that frequency.

He tried to lift his head, but his neck was too stiff.

Then, the impact came.

Paige didn't stop. She collided with him. It wasn't a polite greeting; it was a desperate interception. She threw her arms around his neck and squeezed, burying her face into the coarse, dirty fabric of his hoodie, sobbing his name.

"Gotcha," Paige cried, her voice muffled against the stained orange cotton. "I gotcha, Captain. I gotcha."

The force of the hug broke his remaining stability. Freddie stumbled back a step, his knees buckling. His legs gave way completely. He started to collapse backward toward the dirty terminal floor.

But he didn't hit the ground.

He felt a second impact from the right side.

Jessica caught him. She wrapped her arm firmly around his waist, locking him in. She pressed her cheek against the back of his head, her hand gripping his shoulder tight to keep him upright.

"We have him," Jessica whispered fiercely. "We have the package."

They squeezed him. They pressed in from both sides, creating the "Sandwich Configuration" right there in the middle of the bus terminal.

Freddie slumped. He couldn't help it. His legs were offline. He let his full weight hang on them, his body sagging forward. His head dropped onto Paige's shoulder, his glasses knocked askew.

He opened his eyes for a split second.

The harsh fluorescent lights of the terminal buzzed overhead. In that stark, unforgiving light, he saw Paige's face pressed against his chest. Her eyes were squeezed shut in overwhelmed relief. A single, distinct, glistening tear tracked down her cheek, catching the overhead light before soaking into the grime on his hoodie.

She looked broken. She looked relieved.

And then, she looked up.

Freddie felt Paige's body tense against his. He felt the shift from *comfort* to *defense*.

He followed her gaze. Vanessa was standing there, her bag slipping off her shoulder, staring at them with her mouth open.

Paige didn't let go of Freddie, but her expression changed. The tear was still wet on her cheek, but her eyes were lethal. She glared at Vanessa over Freddie's shoulder—a silent, terrifying demand for an explanation.

"You hit him," Paige whispered, the realization hardening into rage. "You dragged him."

Freddie closed his eyes again, letting his head fall back against Jessica. He didn't need to see anymore. The static was gone.

He was held up by the only two pillars that mattered.

"Pressure applied," Freddie gasped, letting them take his weight completely. "System... stabilizing."

"What the hell?"

The voice broke the bubble.

Vanessa was standing there, staring at them. Her mouth was open. Her bag had slipped off her shoulder.

"How..." Vanessa stammered. "How are you here?"

Jessica pulled back slightly, but she didn't let go of Freddie. She kept her arm locked around his waist, taking his weight.

She turned to look at Vanessa. Her expression shifted from love to absolute zero.

"We flew," Jessica said coldly. "We beat the bus."

"But..." Vanessa looked at Freddie, who was clinging to Paige like a lifeline, his head lolling on her shoulder. "He... he wanted to come with me. He left a note."

"He left a suicide note," Jessica corrected, her voice sharp enough to cut glass. "He thought he was saving us. He thought he was a burden."

She stepped forward, dragging Freddie slightly with her because he couldn't stand on his own. Freddie flinched as the movement pulled the raw skin on his lower back.

"Look at him, Vanessa. Look at what you did to him."

Vanessa looked. She saw Freddie's gray skin. She saw the way his legs were trembling violently in his jeans. She saw the fear in his eyes when he looked at her.

"I didn't..." Vanessa started, her voice small.

"You took a disabled adult across state lines without his medication," Jessica stated, listing the crimes like a prosecutor. "You coerced him. You isolated him. And I bet you hurt him."

Freddie flinched. Paige felt it. She glared at Vanessa over Freddie's shoulder.

"You hit him," Paige whispered, the realization from the hotel room confirmed by the bruise forming on his cheek. "In the bathroom. You hit him."

Vanessa stumbled back. "I... I was trying to help him! He wouldn't listen!"

"He's done listening to you," Jessica said. "You are deleted."

Freddie felt his legs giving out. He sagged, his knees hitting the floor, but his sisters didn't let him drop. They tightened their grip, holding him suspended between them.

Freddie gasped, arching his spine involuntarily. "Back," he choked out. "The skin... it is pulling."

Paige looked at his lower back. Even through the orange hoodie, she could see how stiffly he was holding himself. She remembered the sensation she'd felt in the hotel room—the feeling of being dragged.

"You dragged him," Paige accused, looking at Vanessa with pure hatred. "In Pasco. When he wouldn't get up. You dragged him across the floor and ripped his back open."

Vanessa went pale. "I... I had to get him on the bus."

"You made him bleed and you didn't even bandage it," Jessica hissed. "He's stuck to his clothes."

"He needs to go," Jessica said, looking at Vanessa with disdain. "He needs his meds. And you need to leave."

Vanessa looked panicked. "But... I don't have anywhere to go. I spent my money on the tickets. I thought we were... staying together."

She looked at Freddie, desperation creeping into her voice.

"Freddie, tell them. Tell them about my aunt. We were going to stay with her."

Jessica looked down at Freddie, who was barely conscious, held up only by the sheer will of the Unit.

"Does she have an aunt?" Jessica asked.

Freddie managed a weak nod. "She stated... family in the area. Aunt. Seattle."

He looked at Vanessa. He didn't see a captor anymore. He saw a glitch. A variable that had been solved.

"Go to your aunt," Freddie whispered. "I am remaining with the Unit."

Jessica looked back at Vanessa. She didn't reach for her wallet. She didn't offer help.

"You heard him," Jessica said. "Call your aunt. Use the payphone. But don't follow us."

"But—"

"Goodbye, Vanessa."

Jessica turned her back on her.

"Load up," Jessica commanded to Paige. "He's dead weight. We carry him. Careful of the lower back."

"Affirmative," Paige said, wiping tears from her face.

She took Freddie's left arm and draped it over her shoulder. She wrapped her arm around his waist, gripping his belt loop carefully to avoid the sore spot.

Jessica took his right arm, draping it over her shoulder and locking her arm around his other side.

"Freddie," Jessica said, her voice gentle now. "We have to move. The hotel is across the street. The meds are on the nightstand. Can you help us?"

Freddie tried to move his feet. His legs were numb blocks of wood dragging on the linoleum. The movement pulled at the dried scab on his tailbone, sending a fresh spike of fire up his spine.

"Negative," Freddie whispered, his voice breaking. "Legs offline. Spasticity critical. The skin is tearing."

"Okay," Jessica said, her voice thick with emotion. "Then we drag. But we do it together. On three. One. Two. Up."

They hoisted him. His feet dragged on the floor, but they didn't care. They marched him forward, a three-person unit moving as one.

They walked him toward the glass doors. Jessica stopped a businessman to make room for them with a glare that could peel paint.

They led him out of the terminal and into the cool, rainy night of Seattle.

They didn't look back.

Vanessa stood alone under the harsh fluorescent lights. She watched them go—the sisters flanking him, shielding him, carrying him across the wet pavement.

She realized then that she hadn't just lost the game. She had never even understood the rules.

She picked up her bag and looked around the empty terminal, completely on her own.

The heavy door clicked shut, sealing out the hallway, the elevator, and the rain-soaked city. Jessica threw the deadbolt and engaged the safety latch.

"Secure," she whispered.

She moved immediately to the window. She grabbed the heavy, rubber-backed blackout curtains and pulled them shut. The velcro strips in the center locked together, extinguishing the grey Seattle light and plunging the room into the protective gloom of the "Silo."

Freddie stood by the bed, swaying. He was holding onto Paige's shoulder to stay upright.

"Bed," Paige said gently. "Now."

They helped him sit on the edge of the massive King mattress. He sank into it, letting out a low moan as his spine adjusted to a surface that wasn't vibrating.

"Armor off," Jessica commanded softly. "We need to assess the damage."

They worked as a team. Paige knelt in front of him to untie his shoes, while Jessica gently peeled the dirty orange hoodie over his head.

Freddie didn't help. He couldn't. His arms were heavy, his motor control shot. He let them manipulate his limbs like a doll.

When the hoodie came off, Jessica gasped.

Even in the dim light, the red handprint on his left cheek was visible—a jagged, angry mark where Vanessa had struck him.

"She hit him," Jessica hissed, her fingers hovering near the bruise but terrified to touch it. "She marked him."

"I felt it," Paige whispered, pulling his shoes off. "I knew."

They continued the strip-down. Jessica unbuttoned his jeans. "Lift," she said gently.

Freddie tried, but the denim was stuck to his lower back. He winced, a sharp intake of breath. "Stuck," he rasped. "Adhesion."

"Easy," Jessica said. She peeled the fabric away with infinite care. The dried blood cracked and released.

They slid the pants and boxers down. Freddie was fully exposed.

Jessica and Paige didn't hesitate. They stood up and stripped off their own clothes—jeans, shirts, bras, underwear—leaving them in a pile on the floor.

It wasn't about nudity. It was a statement of total disarmament. *Defenses down. No barriers. We are the same.*

They turned Freddie so they could see his back.

The Stage 2 pressure sore at the base of his spine was an angry, purple-red crater. But below it, trailing down, was a raw, abraded scrape where the skin had been torn away when Vanessa dragged him across the tile floor.

"Oh, Freddie," Paige choked out, tears filling her eyes. "She dragged you. She treated you like luggage."

"Medical kit," Jessica said, her voice shaking with suppressed rage. "I need the saline and the pads."

She turned to go to the bathroom where the kit was stashed.

"Don't leave," Freddie panicked, reaching out blindly.

"I'm right here," Paige said instantly, wrapping her arms around his bare shoulders, pressing her skin against his chest. "I've got you. Jessica is just grabbing the tools. I am not moving."

Jessica returned in ten seconds with the kit and a plate from the kitchenette.

"Meds first," Jessica said.

Paige took the orange bottle. She shook out two Baclofen pills. She held them to Freddie's lips.

"Take them," she whispered while handing him a cup of water.

Jessica broke off a piece of soft white bread slathered in peanut butter. "Eat," she ordered gently. "You need fuel for the repair cycle."

Freddie took the bread. He ate it in two bites, realizing only then that he was starving. The soft texture was comforting.

"I... I am sorry," Freddie wept, crumbs falling on his chest. "I ran away. I left the note."

"No," Paige said, wiping his face. "You didn't run away. You were manipulated. She poisoned the data, Freddie. She told you we were trapped so she could steal you."

"She said... Italy," Freddie sobbed. "She said I was the black hole."

"You are the Sun," Paige said fiercely, pressing her forehead against his. "Everything orbits you because we *want* to. Not because we have to."

"Okay," Jessica said, uncapping the saline. "This is going to sting. Paige, hold him."

Paige tightened her grip, anchoring him against her body. Jessica cleaned the sore and the drag wound. Freddie whimpered, burying his face in Paige's neck, his tears wetting her skin.

Jessica applied a thick layer of antibiotic ointment and covered the wounds with a large, soft gauze pad, taping it securely.

"Done," Jessica said. "You're clean."

"Bed," Paige said.

She pulled back the heavy duvet. "Get in."

Freddie crawled into the center of the bed. The sheets were cool and high-thread-count smooth.

Paige climbed in immediately on his left. She lay on her side, pressing her entire length against him. She threw her leg over his thighs, pinning him down, providing the deep pressure his nervous system was screaming for.

Jessica turned off the bedside lamp. The room went pitch black.

She climbed in on his right. She pulled Freddie's head onto her shoulder, her hand stroking his hair, careful of the bruised cheek.

They closed the gap. Three bodies, skin-to-skin, creating a thermal seal that locked out the cold, the rain, and the memory of the bus.

"Squeeze," Freddie whispered into the dark.

"Squeezing," they both replied.

They held him tight. A cocoon of safety and security.

"No alarm," Jessica whispered into the silence. "We sleep until we wake up. No schedules. No buses."

"Safe," Freddie breathed.

The static in his head finally cleared. The pain in his back was a dull throb, overshadowed by the warmth of his sisters.

He was docked. He was home.

And for the first time in three days, Freddie Avery slept without fear.

Scene 3: The Time Lock

Vanessa stood by the bank of payphones near the entrance. The terminal was emptying out. The Averys were gone. The "heroic rescue" was over, and she was just a girl standing in a puddle with a duffel bag.

She dug into her pockets. She found four quarters, a dime, and a lint-covered nickel.

She picked up the receiver. It was greasy. She dialed the number she had written in her notebook months ago—a number she never really intended to use.

Ring... Ring... Ring...

"Hello?" A woman's voice. Older. Distracted. The sound of a TV game show in the background.

"Aunt Carol?" Vanessa asked, her voice trembling. She pressed a hand to her stomach. She felt nauseous—a rolling, sour feeling she assumed was from the bus ride.

"Who is this?"

"It's... it's Vanessa. Your sister's girl. From Virginia."

Silence on the line. Then, a heavy sigh. "Vanessa? Good lord, it's been ten years. Is everything okay? Is your mother—"

"I'm in Seattle," Vanessa interrupted. She couldn't do the pleasantries. She was shivering. "I... I came for a visit. I'm at the bus station."

"You're *what*?" The warmth drained out of the voice. "You're in Seattle? Now?"

"I didn't have anywhere else to go," Vanessa lied, or maybe it was the truth now. "Can I... can I come stay with you? Just for a little bit?"

"Vanessa, honey, I work double shifts at the cannery. I don't have a guest room. The house is a mess. You can't just spring this on people."

"Please," Vanessa whispered. She looked around the terminal. A security guard was eyeing her luggage. "I don't have any money for a hotel. I just need a floor. Please, Aunt Carol."

Another sigh. Long. Resigned. "Fine. But I'm not driving into the city tonight. My car's transmission is slipping. You have to get yourself to Kent."

"Kent?"

"Take the 150 bus," Carol instructed gruffly. "It picks up on 2nd and Pike. Take it to the Kent Station. Walk three blocks east to the trailer park on Central. Lot 44. I'll leave the porch light on."

Click.

Vanessa hung up the phone.

The 150. 2nd and Pike.

She grabbed her bag. A wave of dizziness hit her, making the floor tilt. She grabbed the payphone booth to steady herself.

Just stress, she told herself, swallowing back the bile. *Just hunger.*

She didn't know that the nausea wasn't from the journey. She didn't know that inside her, a new variable—a permanent consequence of a forgotten night in a dorm room—was already dividing cells.

She dragged her bag out into the rain.

The bus to Kent was not a luxury coach. It was a city transit bus, stopping every few blocks, smelling of wet wool and floor cleaner.

Vanessa sat in the back. She had paid her fare with the last of her change. She was penniless.

She watched the city fade away, replaced by the industrial sprawl of the south warehouses.

She thought about Freddie. She thought about the King bed she knew he was sleeping in right now.

He's weak, she told herself, shivering in her wet jacket. *He chose the cage.*

She rested her hand on her stomach as the bus hit a pothole, sending a jolt of nausea through her.

I'm free, she thought bitterly. *I'm in Seattle. I made it.*

The bus stopped at the Kent Station. It was dark. It was raining.

She stepped off into the night, looking for the lights of a trailer park, completely alone.

Scene 4: The Decontamination Protocol

There was no sun in the room. The heavy, rubber-backed hotel curtains were drawn tight, snapped together in the middle to prevent even a single photon of Seattle grey from entering.

The room was cool, silent, and timeless.

On the King bed, the mound of duvet shifted slightly.

Freddie opened his eyes. For a long, terrifying second, he didn't know where he was. The darkness was absolute.

He waited for the vibration of the bus. He waited for the smell of the chemical toilet. He waited for the sound of Vanessa telling him to move.

None of it came.

Instead, he felt pain.

It was a dull, throbbing ache that radiated from the base of his spine. The Stage 2 pressure sore was pulsing in time with his heartbeat. Below it, the raw scrape where he had been dragged across the terminal floor burned with a sharp, stinging heat. His legs ached. His neck was stiff. He felt like he had been dropped from a moving vehicle.

But then, he felt the weight.

To his left, a heavy arm was draped across his chest, pinning him to the mattress. To his right, a hand was resting on his head.

He took a breath. He smelled lavender detergent and the specific, familiar scent of Paige's shampoo.

The Anchor, Freddie thought. *I am docked.*

He turned his head to the left. In the dim light of the digital clock—which read **11:16**—he saw Paige's profile. She was sound asleep, her face pressed into his shoulder.

He turned to the right. Jessica was there, her arm protective over his chest, her breathing deep and even.

They were all nude. No armor. No barriers. Just skin and safety.

Freddie let out a long, shaky exhale. The sound woke Jessica.

She shifted, lifting her head. She blinked, orienting herself in the dark room. She looked down at Freddie.

"Status?" she whispered, her voice rough with sleep.

"System... online," Freddie croaked. "Damage report: High. Pain levels: Significant. But... security is 100%."

Jessica smiled. She leaned down and kissed his forehead.

"Stay put," she whispered. "Refueling protocol."

She slipped out of the bed. The loss of her warmth was immediate, but necessary. Freddie watched her silhouette move to the kitchenette.

He heard the rustle of a cereal bag. The glug of milk. The clink of spoons.

Jessica returned a moment later, balancing three bowls. She placed two on the nightstand and climbed back onto the bed with hers.

"Sit up," she commanded gently. "Just a little."

Paige stirred on his left. "Food?" she mumbled, eyes still closed.

"Honey Oat Rings," Jessica announced. "Breakfast of champions."

Paige sat up, rubbing her eyes. She helped Freddie shift, propping pillows behind his back so he wouldn't put pressure on the sore. He winced, a sharp hiss escaping his teeth as the movement pulled the skin.

"Sorry," Paige whispered, kissing his shoulder. "I know it hurts."

Jessica handed them the bowls.

They sat in the dark, three naked siblings eating cereal in a hotel bed at noon.

Freddie took a bite. The milk was cold. The sugar was immediate energy.

As the nourishment entered his system, the trembling in his hands began to slow. The glucose hit his brain, clearing the last of the fog.

He ate quickly, scraping the bottom of the bowl. He drank the sugary milk.

"Fuel transfer complete," Freddie said, handing the empty bowl to Jessica.

Jessica set the bowls on the floor.

"Okay," Jessica said, wiping her mouth. "Now we plan the day. We can—"

She stopped.

Freddie was moving. He wasn't getting up. He was sliding down.

He removed the pillows from behind his back. He lay flat.

Then, he turned to his left.

He wrapped his arms around Paige's waist. He buried his face in her neck. He pulled his legs up, tangling them with hers.

He pressed his entire body against hers, eliminating every millimeter of space.

He gripped her skin with a desperation that said, *I am not moving. Do not make me move.*

"Emergency Brake," Freddie whispered into her skin. "Engaged."

Paige didn't hesitate. She lay down with him. She wrapped her arms around his back, careful of the bandage, and pulled him in.

"Brake engaged," Paige confirmed. "We aren't going anywhere."

Jessica looked at them. She saw the way Freddie was clinging to Paige—like a man hanging off a cliff ledge.

She understood. The food had fixed his blood sugar, but his soul was still in shock. He needed time. He needed to feel the anchor hold.

"Okay," Jessica whispered. She lay back down on his right side. She draped her arm over him again, locking him in.

"We stay here," Jessica said. "We have the room for as long as we need."

"Dirt," Freddie mumbled against Paige's neck. "I am... unclean. The bus residue."

"We know," Paige soothed, stroking his hair. "We'll bathe you. A deep scrub. Hot water. Lots of soap. But not yet. You just rest."

"Bathe later," Freddie agreed, his voice slurring with relief. "Cuddle now."

"Cuddle now," Paige promised.

She tightened her grip. Jessica moved closer.

The world outside the blackout curtains—the rain, the city, the memory of Vanessa—ceased to exist.

There was only the King bed, the darkness, and the Avery Unit, holding the line until the Captain was ready to rise.

The "Emergency Brake" had held for two hours. They had drifted in a haze of warmth and silence, the cereal bowls empty on the floor, the world outside forgotten.

But biology was a clock that couldn't be paused.

Freddie shifted. He tightened his grip on Paige, trying to ignore the pressure in his bladder, but his body gave an involuntary spasm.

"Captain?" Paige whispered, feeling the twitch against her stomach.

"Status check," Jessica murmured from his other side.

"Bladder capacity... critical," Freddie admitted, his voice muffled by the pillow. "But... mobility systems offline. I do not want to move."

"We know," Jessica said, sitting up and stretching her arms. The movement let a draft of cool air into the cocoon. "But if we don't move, we're going to have a hazmat situation in the bed. And we are *not* ruining these high-thread-count sheets."

"Toilet protocol," Paige announced. She kissed Freddie's nose. "Disengage the brake, Freddie. Just for a minute."

Freddie reluctantly loosened his grip. He felt heavy—gravity seemed doubled in the hotel room.

"I cannot walk," Freddie said. "Legs are cement."

"We don't need you to walk," Jessica said, sliding off the bed and standing up. She offered her hand to Paige. "We have lift capacity."

They flanked the bed. They were both nude, moving with an unselfconscious efficiency. This was a medical transfer, not a social event.

"Sandwich lift," Jessica commanded. "On three. I'll take the right hook. Paige, left hook."

They bent down. Jessica hooked her arm under Freddie's right armpit; Paige took the left. They locked their other arms under his knees.

"One. Two. Lift."

They hoisted him. Freddie hung between them, his feet dangling inches off the carpet. He groaned as his back stretched, the sore pulling tight.

"Easy, easy," Paige soothed, taking more of the weight on her side to shield him. "We got you. You're flying."

They carried him into the bathroom. The light was brighter here—even with the door cracked, the white tile reflected the hallway glow.

They lowered him onto the toilet.

"Stabilize," Jessica said. She kept a hand on his shoulder so he wouldn't tip over while he relieved himself.

Once he was finished, they didn't stand him up yet.

"Tub prep," Paige said.

She turned to the massive soaking tub. She put the plug in.

"Okay," Jessica said. "Transfer to tub. Then we handle the rest."

They lifted him again—a short pivot this time—and lowered him into the empty porcelain tub. Freddie sat with his legs extended, his back resting against the cold slope of the tub. He shivered.

"Cold," he whispered.

"Hold on," Paige said. "Heat is coming."

"We need to use the facilities first," Jessica noted. "Don't go anywhere."

Freddie managed a weak, tired smile. "I am... contained."

Paige used the toilet quickly, then Jessica. They flushed, washed their hands, and turned their full attention to the mission.

"Bandages off," Jessica said, her voice dropping to a clinical register. "Before the water."

She knelt by the tub. "Lean forward, Freddie. Lean into Paige."

Freddie leaned forward, resting his forehead against Paige's stomach as she stood by the rim. Jessica carefully peeled back the tape.

Freddie hissed through his teeth.

"Almost done," Jessica murmured. She pulled the gauze free.

She inspected the wound. It was angry and red, but the bleeding had stopped. The Scab from the drag mark was dark and jagged.

"It's ugly," Jessica admitted. "But it's closing."

She tossed the dirty bandage in the trash.

"Okay," Paige said, rolling up a washcloth. "Deep scrub. Maximum temperature."

She turned the faucet. Steam rose instantly. She tested the water with her wrist. "Perfect."

She plugged the drain and switched the diverter to the handheld shower wand.

"Here it comes," Paige whispered.

She aimed the spray at Freddie's shoulders.

The hot water hit him. Freddie gasped, his head falling back. The heat penetrated the stiff, frozen muscles of his neck. It soaked into the grime of the orange hoodie that was no longer there. It melted the tension in his spine.

"Oh," Freddie breathed. "Systems... resetting."

Jessica knelt on one side of the tub, Paige on the other. They lathered up the washcloths with the hotel's verbena soap.

They started to scrub.

It wasn't a gentle rinse. It was an excavation.

Jessica took his left arm, scrubbing the skin until it turned pink. She washed away the smell of the diesel fumes. She washed away the sweat of the panic attack in the closet.

Paige took his right arm. She scrubbed his chest. She washed away the phantom sensation of Vanessa's grip on his hoodie.

"Get it off," Freddie whispered, tears mixing with the steam on his face. "Get her off me."

"We are," Paige promised fiercely, scrubbing his neck where Vanessa had grabbed him. "She's dissolving, Freddie. She's going down the drain."

They washed his hair, massaging the shampoo into his scalp, working out three days of grease and static.

They washed his back, being infinitely careful around the sore, but cleaning the area around it with surgical precision.

The water in the bottom of the tub turned a murky grey.

"Look at that," Jessica said, pointing to the water. "That's the bus. That's the terminal. That's her."

She pulled the plug. The grey water swirled away, sucked down into the pipes of Seattle.

"Gone," Jessica said.

She put the plug back in and filled the tub with fresh, clean, hot water.

Freddie sat in the clear water. He felt light. He felt raw, but he felt clean. The poison was out of his system.

He looked up at his sisters. They were kneeling on the bathmat, wet from the spray, their hair frizzy from the steam, looking at him with total adoration.

"Better?" Paige asked, smoothing his wet hair back from his forehead.

"Better," Freddie whispered. "Clean slate."

"Okay," Jessica said, standing up and grabbing a stack of fluffy white towels. "Extraction time. Then we go back to the nest."

"No clothes," Freddie requested, his eyes drooping. "Just... blankets."

"Just blankets," Paige agreed. "Skin to skin. Until we leave."

Scene 5: Frequency Tuned

"Extraction commenced," Jessica announced softly.

She draped a massive bath sheet over Freddie's shoulders while he was still sitting in the draining water. Paige wrapped another around his legs. They patted him dry with gentle, rhythmic motions, treating him like a newborn.

"Up we go," Paige whispered.

They lifted him out of the tub. The air in the bathroom was cooler than the water, but the towels were thick and retained the heat. They didn't bother with clothes. The promise had been made: just blankets.

They shuffled him back into the main room. The heavy curtains were still doing their job; the room was a cave of eternal twilight.

"Target acquired," Jessica said, nodding toward the bed. "Prepare for docking."

They lowered him onto the mattress. The sheets were cool and crisp against his clean, warm skin. He sank into the center, the depression in the mattress welcoming him back.

Jessica climbed in on his right; Paige took the left. They pulled the heavy duvet up to their chins, sealing the three of them in a single, continuous warmth.

Freddie let out a long, shuddering breath. He smelled of verbena soap and clean cotton. The bus smell was gone. The dirt was gone. But the silence in the room was suddenly too loud. It left too much space for his thoughts to echo.

"Input," Freddie murmured, staring up at the dark ceiling. "Need... audio input. Verify world status."

Tv? Paige asked, her hand resting on his chest.

"No," Freddie said. "Too bright. Just... signals. Radio."

Jessica reached over to the bedside table. She fumbled with the sleek, wood-paneled hotel alarm clock/radio. She clicked the dial to ON and adjusted the volume to a low hum.

The speaker crackled to life.

"...at Bob's Discount Furniture on 4th! We're slashing prices on all sectionals! If you need a recliner, we've got 'em! If you need a dinette set, come on down! Don't let your living room live in the past..."

The mundane, aggressive cheerfulness of the commercial was grounding. It was proof that somewhere, people were buying sofas. Somewhere, life was normal.

Then, the static hissed as the station signal adjusted. A smooth DJ voice broke in.

"That was a word from our sponsors. Now, we're getting back to our Saturday block. We're keeping it retro this afternoon. Here's a deep cut for anyone out there weathering a storm. This is Mirage."

The synth pads swelled—warm, expansive, and distinctly 1980s. A clean, melodic electric guitar riff cut through the air, crying out with a gentle, melancholy hope.

Freddie closed his eyes.

The female vocal came in, clear and reassuring, an alto voice that sounded like a promise kept.

"The storm is over now, the static's gone Right here is where you've been all along Your voice was lost, your world was gray We're here to chase the dark away..."

Freddie felt Paige's thumb stroking the back of his hand. The rhythm matched the beat of the song—a steady, mid-tempo pulse.

"You walked through fire, you walked through rain But you will never walk alone again"

The lyrics bypassed his ears and went straight to his chest. He *had* walked through fire. He had walked through the rain of the terminal, the fire of the shame in the closet.

The chorus swelled, filling the small hotel room.

"We are your sanctuary in the storm A fire here to keep you safe and warm Inside this circle, held so tight We'll be your true and gentle light..."

Jessica shifted, pulling the duvet tighter around his shoulders. “Inside the circle,” she whispered, echoing the song. “That’s us. The perimeter is sealed.”

“So let the painted smile fall down You’re standing on your native ground You’re home... you’re finally home”

A tear leaked out of the corner of Freddie’s eye, sliding hot into his hairline. *The painted smile.* The mask he had worn for the Dean. The mask he had worn for Vanessa. The desperate, grinning attempt to be a “good student” while he was dying inside. It crumbled.

“The mask you wore is on the floor You don’t need it anymore The silence has no power here We’ll banish every single fear... “

The song continued, the singer’s voice gaining power, urging him to let go.

“Just let it go, the heavy load At the ending of this lonely road Just lean on us, we’ll hold the line... “

And then, the line that broke him.

“Your broken heart will mend with time”

Freddie made a sound—half-sob, half-gasp.

His heart *was* broken. It wasn’t just the fear or the exhaustion. It was the heartbreak of having his autonomy stolen, of being treated like an object, of being discarded in a bus terminal. It felt shattered.

But the song didn’t say it was fixed. It said it *would* mend. With time.

“Did you hear that?” Paige whispered, her face pressing into his shoulder. “It’ll mend, Freddie. We have time. We have all the time.”

The guitar solo soared, a high, crying melody that sounded like relief. It sounded like the feeling of the hot water hitting his back. It sounded like Jessica’s arm across his chest.

“You’re home... you’re finally home We are your sanctuary... you’re not alone.”

The song faded out into a gentle reverb.

The room was silent again, but the silence wasn’t empty anymore. It was filled with the resonance of the music.

Freddie lay perfectly still, sandwiched between the two people who shared his DNA, his history, and his soul. The radio hummed with low static.

“Data received,” Freddie whispered, his voice thick. “Message... acknowledged.”

“Status?” Jessica asked, her voice fierce and protective in the dark.

Freddie took a breath. It didn’t shudder this time.

“Safe,” Freddie said. “I am safe.”

Scene 6: The Signal Cut

The reverb of "Sanctuary" had barely faded when the DJ's voice returned, slick and energetic, jarring against the heavy emotional air in the room.

"That was Mirage, holding you close. But sometimes, you gotta fight your way out of the dark before you can find the light. Here's a track that starts in the gutter and ends in the sky. This is 'Haven City' by Steel Horizon."

The speaker thumped. A heavy, distorted drum machine kicked in—thud-clank, thud-clank—accompanied by a pulsing, predatory synth-bass.

Freddie flinched. The sound was too close to the memory of the Pathfinder bus engine idling in the terminal. It sounded like the headache that had been splitting his skull for three days.

"Off," Freddie gasped. "Turn it off."

Jessica moved instantly. Her hand slapped down on the snooze/off button. Click.

The driving drums and wailing guitars were severed instantly. The silence that rushed back into the room was heavy, ringing in their ears.

Freddie lay panting, his chest heaving against Paige's side. He squeezed his eyes shut, trying to banish the afterimage of the music.

"Input overload," Freddie whispered. "System... saturation."

"We know," Jessica soothed, smoothing the hair back from his forehead. "We pushed it too fast. No more radio."

They lay there for a long time, letting Freddie's heart rate settle. The room was just a room again. The smell of verbena soap was grounding. The warmth of his sisters was real.

Freddie took a deep breath. He thought about the lyrics he had almost heard. Take me home.

He thought about the house on Pepper Street. He thought about safety. But then, he thought about the map in his head.

Currently, the sector labeled "Seattle" was a corrupted file. It contained only pain: the bus terminal, the rain, the feeling of being dragged across a bathroom floor. If he left now, that data would be permanent. Seattle would always be a monster.

He opened his eyes. He looked at Jessica. Then he looked at Paige.

"I have... a request," Freddie whispered.

"Anything," Jessica said instantly. "We can call the airline right now. We can be on a plane tonight."

"Negative," Freddie said. He shifted, trying to sit up. "I do not want to evacuate."

Paige frowned, helping him prop himself up against the headboard. “You don’t?”

“If we leave now,” Freddie said, his voice trembling but gaining strength, “the data remains corrupted. Vanessa wins. She defined this location as a prison.”

He looked at his hands.

“I want to redefine the location,” Freddie stated. “I want to overwrite the bad data with good data. I want... I want to be a tourist.”

Jessica and Paige exchanged a look. It was a look of pure relief and pride.

“Okay,” Jessica smiled. “Tourist Protocol. Let’s plan it.”

“Living room,” Freddie requested. “I require... the sofa configuration.”

They helped him out of bed. They moved to the small sitting area of the suite. Freddie sat in the middle of the beige loveseat. Paige sat on his right; Jessica sat on his left.

Freddie wrapped his arm around Paige’s waist. He wrapped his other arm around Jessica’s waist. He pulled them both in tight, anchoring himself in the center of the unit.

“Secure,” Freddie breathed. “Now. Show me the options.”

Paige grinned. She reached for her bag on the floor and pulled out a stack of glossy brochures she had grabbed from the lobby rack days ago.

“I was hoping you’d say that,” Paige said. She spread them out on the coffee table.

She picked up the first one. It showed a sleek, white tower rising above the city, crowned with a flying saucer-shaped observation deck.

“The Seattle Sky-Spire,” Paige announced. “It’s 605 feet tall. Elevators take forty-one seconds to reach the top. It has a rotating floor.”

Freddie leaned forward, adjusting his glasses. He traced the curve of the tower on the paper.

“It looks like a docking pylon,” Freddie whispered. “From Stellar Voyage.”

“It does,” Paige agreed. “And from up there? The bus station looks like a toy. You can look down on it. You can see the grid.”

“Elevation,” Freddie nodded. “Perspective.”

Jessica picked up another brochure. THE BAYFRONT AQUARIUM.

“And this,” Jessica said. “It’s built on a pier. They have a dome room under the water. Blue lights. Quiet tunnels. Fish moving in perfect, silent orbits. It’s sensory soothing, Freddie. It’s a tank.”

Freddie looked at the blue picture. He imagined the silence. He imagined the water.

"Biological systems," Freddie noted. "Predictable movement."

He looked at his sisters. They weren't looking at him with pity. They were looking at him like he was the Captain planning a shore leave mission.

"I want to do this," Freddie said firmly. "I want to go to the Spire. I want to go to the Aquarium. I want to remember Seattle as the place where we went. Not the place where she took me."

"Then we stay," Jessica declared. "We have the rental car. We have the suite. We extend the stay for three days."

"Operation: Decompression," Paige named it. "We reclaim the map."

"Reclaim the map," Freddie echoed.

He squeezed them both tighter. The fear of the city outside the window began to fade, replaced by the anticipation of a new schematic.

"Tomorrow," Freddie said. "We execute the itinerary."

"Tomorrow," Jessica agreed.

Safe in the sandwich configuration, holding the promise of a new memory in his mind, Freddie Avery closed his eyes. He wasn't running away. He was rewriting the code.

The decision to stay had settled over the room like a fresh blanket, but the emotional exertion of the "overwrite" discussion had drained Freddie's remaining battery. He sat in the middle of the beige loveseat, his arms still wrapped around both sisters, his breathing slowly syncing with theirs.

"Wait," Paige said suddenly, her eyes widening. "We forgot the fuel."

"Fuel?" Freddie murmured.

"The Comfort Fuel," Paige said. "Jessica bought the canister. White Hot Chocolate. With the little marshmallows."

Jessica stood up instantly. "You're right. Critical oversight. I'll deploy the beverages."

Paige started to shift, intending to help, but Jessica put a hand on her shoulder.

"Negative," Jessica commanded softly. "You stay. Maintain the anchor."

Jessica knew the schematic. If she left, Freddie would have an open flank. If Paige left too, he would be adrift. He needed at least one point of contact to maintain structural integrity.

"Understood," Paige said, settling back.

Jessica walked to the kitchenette.

As soon as her weight left the sofa cushion, Freddie reacted. The loss of the left-side pressure triggered a defensive reflex. He didn't sit up straight; he collapsed.

"Brake," Freddie whispered. "Engaging."

He slid sideways. He swung his legs up onto the sofa where Jessica had just been sitting. He laid his head down in Paige's lap, curling his body into a tight C-shape against the back cushions. He buried his face in the soft fabric of her pajama shorts, hiding from the light, hiding from the room.

"Brake engaged," Paige confirmed gently.

She draped her left arm over his side, her hand coming to rest flat against the center of his chest, directly over his heart. She felt the rhythm—still a little fast, but slowing down.

"I am... stationary," Freddie mumbled into her leg.

"I know," Paige smoothed his hair. "You just stay there. We'll bring the fuel to the tank."

In the kitchenette, Jessica worked with quiet efficiency. She heated the milk in the microwave—two minutes, stir, two minutes. She spooned the white powder into three mugs. She added the hot milk, stirring until it was a creamy, frothy white. She added a generous dollop of whipped cream from the can they had bought.

She carried two mugs over to the living area.

"Order up," Jessica said softly.

She set the mugs on the coffee table, within easy reach of Freddie's hand if he chose to extract it from the cocoon.

"One for the Captain," she whispered. "One for the Anchor."

She looked at the sofa. Freddie was fully extended, his legs taking up the cushion she had vacated. He was locked in. If she tried to sit back down, she would have to ask him to move his legs, and right now, asking him to move was like asking a stone to dance.

"I'll be right back," Jessica said.

She went back to the kitchen, retrieved her own mug, and returned.

She looked at the available seating. The armchair was too far away. The other side of the sofa was occupied by Freddie's feet.

Jessica didn't hesitate. She didn't ask him to scoot. She respected the protocol.

She sat down on the sturdy rectangular coffee table, directly facing them. She sat cross-legged, her knees brushing against the sofa cushion, creating a close, intimate circle.

“Table seating,” Jessica smiled, blowing on her cocoa. “Better view of the team anyway.”

Freddie peeled one eye open. He saw Jessica sitting right there, inches away, holding her mug. He saw the steam rising from his own mug on the table next to her hip.

He reached out a hand—shaky but determined.

“Refuel,” Freddie whispered.

Jessica picked up his mug and handed it to him. He took it, holding it close to his chest, letting the warmth seep into his hands.

“Refueling,” Freddie agreed.

He took a sip. It was sweet, hot, and tasted like safety. He didn’t sit up. He drank it right there in Paige’s lap, while Jessica watched over them from her perch on the table, the three of them locked in a quiet, perfect triangle of recovery.

The white hot chocolate was warm in Freddie’s stomach, a soothing ballast against the cold rain streaking the windowpanes. He lay still on the beige loveseat, his legs still draped over the cushion where Jessica had been, his head heavy and secure in Paige’s lap.

The “Emergency Brake” was fully engaged. He wasn’t moving. He didn’t want to move.

Jessica sat on the coffee table, her knees brushing against the sofa, her own mug cradled in her hands. She wasn’t rushing him. She was just... there.

Freddie took a breath. The air smelled of cocoa and the faint, clean scent of Paige’s skin. It was time to clear the cache.

“I need... to run a diagnostic,” Freddie whispered, staring at the buttons on Paige’s pajama top.

“On what?” Paige asked softly, her hand resuming its rhythmic stroke through his hair.

“On the corruption,” Freddie said. “The Vanessa Virus. I need to understand how the logic bomb was planted. I need to patch the security flaw so it... so it never happens again.”

He felt Paige tense slightly, then force herself to relax.

“Okay,” Jessica said, her voice calm and clinical. “Let’s debug it. What did she say to you? What was the input?”

Freddie closed his eyes. He replayed the scene in the lobby of Copernicus Hall. The way Vanessa had leaned in close. The way she had made her voice sound like she was the only one telling him the truth.

"She said... she said you were leaving," Freddie murmured. "She said she heard you in the bathroom. That Jessica had an internship in New York. And Paige had a study abroad program in Italy."

Paige stopped stroking his hair. "Italy?"

"She said you turned them down," Freddie continued, his voice trembling. "She said you sacrificed your dreams because... because you couldn't leave me. She said I was the gravity well. The black hole. That if I didn't leave... you would eventually hate me for trapping you."

He opened his eyes, looking up at Paige with a raw, terrifying vulnerability.

"Is there... was there an Italy file?"

Paige looked down at him. Her expression wasn't guilty. It was baffled.

"Freddie," Paige said, shaking her head. "I looked at a brochure for Italy once. In the student center trash can. I picked it up because it had a pretty picture of a statue. I looked at it for ten seconds, thought 'Wow, that's a lot of walking,' and threw it back away."

She leaned down, pressing her forehead against his.

"There was no application," she whispered. "There was no acceptance letter. I never wanted to go to Italy. I don't speak Italian. I hate flying. And most importantly... you aren't there."

"And New York?" Freddie asked, shifting his gaze to Jessica.

Jessica snorted. It was a derisive, un-ladylike sound.

"New York?" Jessica said. "The city that smells like garbage and has a cost of living that would bankrupt us in a week? No. Never. I applied for exactly zero internships in New York. My plan has always been to find a firm in Roanoke or Blacksburg so I can drive or take the bus home every night."

She reached out and squeezed his ankle, which was resting near her on the sofa.

"Vanessa made it up," Jessica stated firmly. "She took a tiny fragment of data—maybe she saw me reading a magazine about New York—and she weaponized it. She built a fiction designed to target your specific insecurity: that you are a burden."

"It was... effective," Freddie admitted. "The logic held. I believed I was a constraint."

"You aren't a constraint," Paige said fiercely. "You're the Point of Origin. You're where the map starts."

She adjusted her position, pulling him tighter against her stomach.

"Freddie, listen to me. I don't want to go to Europe. I don't want to go backpacking to 'find myself.' I know exactly where I am."

She looked around the small hotel room—the stocked kitchenette, the blackout curtains, the massive bed where they had all slept in a pile.

"My priority... my dream... isn't a place," Paige said. "It's a state. It's waking up in the morning, rolling over, and touching your arm. It's feeling you breathe. It's knowing—knowing—that you are safe."

She looked him in the eye.

"When I wake up and you're there, sandwiched between us... that is the best moment of my day. Every single time. I don't want to wake up in Rome alone. I want to wake up in Christiansburg with you."

"Forever?" Freddie whispered.

"Forever," Paige promised.

"Even... even when we are old?" Freddie asked. "The social contract suggests that siblings separate. That you find... partners."

"We found our partners," Jessica said simply. "We found each other. The Avery Unit is a closed system, Freddie. We don't need external variables."

She leaned forward on the coffee table.

"I want the King bed," Jessica declared. "I want the sandwich configuration. I want to sleep next to you for the rest of my life because it stops my nightmares too. It's not just for you, Freddie. We need it. We need the weight."

Freddie processed this. The data was overwriting the Vanessa Virus.

Vanessa's Logic: He is a burden holding them back. New Logic: He is the anchor keeping them grounded. They want to be held.

The "trap" wasn't real. The "sacrifice" wasn't real.

"So," Freddie said, his voice gaining a little strength. "New York is deleted. Italy is deleted."

"Purged," Paige confirmed.

"And the bed... is permanent architecture?"

"Permanent," Jessica agreed. "We buy a new mattress every ten years if we have to. But the formation stays."

Freddie let out a long, shuddering breath. He felt the last of the poison leave his system. He wasn't a jailer. He was a brother.

He snuggled deeper into Paige's lap, pressing his face against her stomach. He felt the tension leave his legs.

"Patch installed," Freddie whispered. "System secure."

"Good," Paige said, resting her hand over his heart again. "Now, stay right there. The Emergency Brake is still active. We aren't moving until you say so."

“I say... never,” Freddie mumbled, closing his eyes.

“Never works for us,” Jessica smiled, picking up her mug.

Safe in the lap of his sister, guarded by the other, Freddie Avery finally stopped running. The virus was gone. The code was clean. And the Unit was unbreakable.

The afternoon light behind the curtains had faded to evening grey, and the quiet conversation about Italy and New York had settled the dust in Freddie’s mind. The “Vanessa Virus” had been quarantined, if not fully deleted.

But another system was now sending urgent alerts.

Gurgle.

Freddie’s stomach growled—a low, persistent rumble that vibrated against Paige’s thigh.

“Status check,” Paige whispered, a smile touching her lips.

“Fuel levels... critical,” Freddie admitted. His voice was stronger now, less like a ghost and more like a tired man waking up.

He shifted. For the first time in hours, he didn’t just burrow deeper; he tried to sit up.

The “Emergency Brake” was disengaging.

“Assist?” Paige asked, feeling him struggle against the gravity of exhaustion.

“Affirmative,” Freddie said. “I wish to... participate. I want to sit at the table.”

Paige placed a hand on his back and another on his shoulder, leveraging him up while he pushed weakly against the cushions. He swayed for a second once he was vertical, blinking behind his glasses.

“Steady,” Jessica said from her perch on the coffee table. She stood up, stretching her legs. “Okay, Captain. Table it is.”

They flanked him for the short migration. It was only ten feet from the sofa to the small, round dining table near the kitchenette, but they moved like a security detail. Jessica took his left arm, Paige took his right. They didn’t drag him; they just offered a solid framework he could lean on.

Freddie sat in one of the dining chairs. It was firm, upright. It felt like a return to civilization.

“Menu options?” Freddie asked, looking at the kitchenette.

“I’m cooking,” Jessica announced, tying her hair back. “You stay right there with Paige. I’ve got the supplies.”

She opened the freezer. She pulled out the bag they had bought at Market Street Grocery.

Crispy Chicken Strips.

She opened the cupboard. Creamy Macaroni & Cheese (the deluxe kind with the foil pouch of liquid gold, not the powder).

"Comfort Protocol," Jessica winked. "Chicken and Mac. Zero spice. Maximum cheese."

"Acceptable," Freddie said, watching her work. "High caloric density."

Paige sat in the chair next to him, turning it slightly so her knees brushed his. She kept her hand on his forearm, a constant tactile reminder that he wasn't alone.

While the water boiled and the oven preheated, Jessica laid out the new mission parameters.

"Okay," Jessica said, stirring the macaroni. "If we're doing the tourist thing tomorrow, we need a transport plan. I don't want to drive the rental car downtown. Parking is a nightmare, and the traffic is chaos."

"Agreed," Freddie said. "Urban driving introduces stress variables."

Paige pulled a transit map from the stack of brochures. TRANSIT AUTHORITY OF THE PUGET SOUND (TAPS).

"Look at this," Paige said, spreading the map on the table. "They have a unified zone downtown. It's called the Ride Free Area."

Freddie leaned in, adjusting his glasses. He traced the shaded box on the map.

"Ride Free?"

"Between 6 AM and 7 PM," Paige read. "Any bus trip that starts and ends inside this zone is zero fare. You just hop on."

"Frictionless entry," Freddie noted approvingly. "No payment interaction required."

"And look," Jessica pointed with a wooden spoon. "Our hotel is here, on Stewart. We're inside the zone. We can catch any bus right outside the door and ride it all the way to the waterfront or the retail core without spending a dime."

"Efficient," Freddie said.

Paige traced a line north. "The zone ends here at Battery Street. If we get off at the last stop, we're only a few blocks from the Sky-Spire."

She looked at the scale of the map. Then she looked at Freddie.

"It's about a six-block walk," Paige estimated. "From the bus stop to the Spire."

Freddie frowned. He ran a diagnostic on his legs. They were stiff, sore, and currently running on reserve power. Six blocks on city pavement was a marathon.

"Range anxiety," Freddie whispered. "Six blocks is... significant."

"We don't have to walk it," Jessica called out from the stove, dumping the cheese sauce into the pot. "There's a relay."

She pointed to a blue line on the map. THE METRO-RAIL.

"It's an elevated train," Jessica explained. "It runs from the downtown mall directly to the Seattle Exposition Park. It drops you right at the base of the Spire. It's a two-minute ride."

"A monorail?" Freddie asked, his eyes lighting up. "Elevated transit?"

"Exactly," Paige said. "We take the free bus to the mall. We take the elevator up to the platform. We ride the train to the Spire. Minimal walking."

"And if we do walk," Jessica added, bringing the plates to the table, "we break it up. We stop at every bench. We stop at every coffee shop—well, for us to get coffee, you can get water. We aren't in a rush, Freddie. If you need to sit, we sit. If you need to stop, we stop."

She set a plate in front of him. Steaming mac and cheese. Three golden chicken strips.

"We move at your pace," Paige promised, squeezing his arm. "The Captain sets the speed."

Freddie looked at the food. He looked at the map. He looked at his sisters.

"The Metro-Rail," Freddie decided, picking up his fork. "That is the optimal vector."

He took a bite of the chicken. It was hot, mild, and safe.

"Tomorrow," Freddie said, chewing slowly. "We take the train."

"Tomorrow," Jessica agreed, clinking her fork against his.

They ate in the quiet hotel room, the map of the city spread out between them, plotting a course for a day that would replace the grey memory of the bus station with the bright, elevated view of a family that had found its way back to each other.

The dinner plates were pushed aside, empty save for a few streaks of cheese sauce. The map of Seattle was still spread out on the table, promising a future of monorails and space needles.

Freddie sat back in his chair. His stomach was full. The "Emergency Brake" was disengaged, and his systems were coming back online.

But as the adrenaline of the planning session faded, a different sensation took over. He felt... sticky. Not with the grime of the bus—that had been scrubbed away earlier—but with the lingering, phantom residue of the day's stress. He felt the need to be submerged again. To be held by the water and his sisters simultaneously.

He looked at Jessica, who was stacking the plates. He looked at Paige, who was folding a napkin.

They were all nude. In the soft light of the hotel room, stripped of the jeans and hoodies and armor of the outside world, it didn't feel exposed. It felt honest. It meant there were no hidden weapons, no hidden agendas. Just skin. Just the Unit.

Freddie cleared his throat. The "Admin" voice he usually used for requests—I require hygiene protocol—felt wrong. It felt too cold for the warmth in his chest.

"Jessica?" Freddie said softly. "Paige?"

They both stopped and looked at him instantly.

"System report?" Jessica asked.

"Systems are... grateful," Freddie whispered. He looked down at his hands. "I have a request. A... favor."

"Name it," Paige said.

"Could I... please... have a bath?" Freddie asked. The word please felt heavy and sweet on his tongue. "Not a scrub. Just... a bath. With both of you?"

He looked up, his eyes wide behind his glasses.

"I want to feel the water," he stammered, the emotion breaking through his usual cadence. "And I want you there. Please. If you don't mind."

Jessica's expression softened into something incredibly tender. She reached out and touched his cheek.

"You never have to say 'please' for that, Freddie," she said. "But yes. Absolutely."

"We'd love to," Paige added, standing up and taking his hand. "Let's go to the spa."

The hotel bathroom was dim, lit only by the light spilling in from the kitchenette. Jessica started the water. She didn't make it scalding hot this time; she made it warm, a gentle, enveloping temperature. She poured in a little of the hotel's complimentary bubble bath—something she usually dismissed as frivolous, but tonight, it seemed necessary.

"Ready, Captain?" Paige asked.

"Ready," Freddie said. "Thank you."

They helped him into the tub. He slid into the bubbles, the water rising to his chest. He sighed, a long, trembling sound of pure contentment.

Jessica knelt on the bathmat to his left. Paige knelt to his right. They didn't grab scrub brushes or medical saline this time. They grabbed soft washcloths.

"Arms up," Paige whispered playfully.

Freddie lifted his arms.

Paige began to wash his left arm. She moved slowly, the cloth gliding over his skin in long, soothing strokes.

"Thank you, Paige," Freddie whispered, watching her hand. "Thank you for finding me."

"I'll always find you," Paige said, her voice thick. She kissed his wet shoulder.

Jessica took his right hand. She washed his fingers, one by one, massaging the stiffness out of his knuckles where he had gripped the wheelchair armrests for so long.

"Thank you, Jessica," Freddie said, turning his head to look at her. "Thank you for the plane. For the food. For... everything."

"It's just logistics, Freddie," Jessica smiled, squeezing his soapy hand. "That's what I do."

"It is not just logistics," Freddie corrected gently. "It is love. Thank you."

They washed his chest. They washed his neck. They were careful of his lower back, washing around the dressing with infinite tenderness.

It wasn't a medical procedure. It was a ritual. With every stroke of the cloth, they were telling him: You are here. You are ours. You are safe.

Freddie closed his eyes. He listened to the water lapping against the porcelain. He felt the steam on his face. He felt four hands touching him, caring for him, asking for nothing in return.

He thought about Vanessa. She had wanted to take. She had wanted to own.

His sisters just wanted him to be clean.

"I am... so happy," Freddie whispered, the words bubbling up from a place deep inside him. "I am overwhelmed with data... but it is good data."

"Good data," Jessica agreed, rinsing the soap from his back with a cup.

"Okay," Paige said softly. "One last rinse."

She took the handheld shower wand. She turned it to a gentle spray. She rinsed the bubbles away, leaving his skin warm and clean.

"All done," Paige announced.

Freddie looked at them. They were wet from the splashing, their hair frizzy in the humidity, kneeling on the hard tile floor just to be close to him.

"Thank you," Freddie said again. He didn't know how else to say it. The vocabulary of the "Iron City" didn't have a word for this feeling.

"You're welcome, Freddie," Jessica said. "Now. Let's get you dry. The King bed is waiting."

They helped him stand. They wrapped him in warm towels. And as they walked him back to the "Silo," Freddie realized that the "Robert Virus"—the voice that said he was broken—was silent.

He wasn't broken. He was just loved.

The hotel room was dim, illuminated only by the microwave clock and the faint sliver of city light bleeding around the edges of the blackout curtains. The air conditioner hummed a steady, low-frequency drone that scrubbed the room of silence.

They moved from the bathroom to the sleeping area. They didn't bother with pajamas. The "Armor" had been discarded in the hamper. Tonight, after the bath, after the confession about Italy, and after the decision to stay, clothing felt like unnecessary friction.

"Bedtime," Jessica announced softly.

She walked to the massive King bed and pulled back the heavy white duvet.

"Positions," she murmured.

Freddie climbed in first. He moved to the dead center of the mattress. The sheets were cool and smooth against his clean skin—a sharp contrast to the grit of the denim he had worn for three days. He lay back, sinking into the pillows.

Jessica climbed in on his left—the side closest to the door. She was the Shield. She lay on her side, pressing her back against his arm, her legs tangling with his.

Paige climbed in on his right—the side against the wall. She was the Anchor. She curled into him, resting her head on his shoulder, draping her arm across his chest to lock him in.

They collapsed the 76 inches of space. They became a single thermal mass in the center of the bed.

"Pressure check?" Jessica asked from the dark.

"Optimal," Freddie breathed.

He felt the weight of Paige's arm. He felt the warmth of Jessica's back. It was a heavy, grounding sensation that pinned him to the earth.

He closed his eyes. Usually, the darkness brought the static—the replay of the trauma. But tonight, the static was quiet.

His mind drifted to tomorrow.

"Tomorrow," Freddie whispered into the quiet room. "The bus."

He felt Paige tense slightly against his side. "You okay with that? We can take a taxi if you want."

"No," Freddie said immediately. "I want the bus."

He visualized the map they had looked at during dinner. The Ride Free Area. The Tunnel.

"Vanessa made the bus a prison," Freddie murmured. "She made it a cage."

He squeezed Paige's hand where it rested on his chest. He nudged Jessica with his elbow.

"But tomorrow... the bus is a vehicle," Freddie stated. "Because the crew is correct."

"The crew is correct," Jessica agreed, reaching back to squeeze his hand. "We're riding with you, Freddie. We're riding the electric bus in the tunnel. It's going to be quiet. It's going to be smooth."

"And if you get scared," Paige promised, kissing his shoulder, "we get off. We pull the cord. We stop. You have the control."

Freddie smiled in the dark. That was the variable that changed the equation. Control.

"I am looking forward to it," Freddie admitted. "I want to see the tunnel."

"We'll see it," Paige said. "Now sleep, Captain. We have a big day."

"Goodnight, Anchor," Freddie whispered. "Goodnight, Shield."

"Goodnight, Freddie."

Safe in the sandwich configuration, clean, fed, and held by the only people who mattered, Freddie Avery let go. The bus ride of the past was over. The bus ride of the future—the tourist ride, the family ride—was waiting.

He slept without dreaming.

The Tourist Protocol

Scene 1: Fueling the Expedition

The blackout curtains held the line against the morning, maintaining the protective twilight of the "Silo," but the digital clock on the microwave insisted it was time to start the day.

Freddie woke up in the center of the King bed. He was warm. He was compressed. He was safe.

To his left, Jessica was already stirring, checking her watch with the efficiency of a shift commander. To his right, Paige was still deeply asleep, her arm thrown over his chest like a seatbelt, anchoring him to the mattress.

"Morning, Captain," Jessica whispered, sitting up and stretching.

"Morning," Freddie rasped. He ran a diagnostic. His back was stiff from the injury, throbbing with a dull ache where the skin was healing, but the "static"

in his head was low. The anxiety that usually greeted him upon waking—Where am I? Is she here?—was absent. He knew exactly where he was. He was with the Unit.

"Weather check," Jessica announced, sliding out of bed. She walked to the window and cracked the heavy curtains just an inch.

A beam of bright, clean sunlight sliced into the room, illuminating dust motes dancing in the air.

"Visual confirmation," Jessica smiled, looking back at them. "Blue skies. High of 65 degrees. Perfect visibility for the Spire."

"65 degrees," Freddie noted, sitting up carefully. "Low humidity. Optimal."

They moved with the easy rhythm of a team that had lived in close quarters for years. There was no scrambling for modesty, no hiding behind doors. They simply moved from the bed to the bathroom to the kitchenette, getting dressed in comfortable layers for a day of walking.

Freddie put on fresh jeans, wincing slightly as the waistband settled near the bandage on his lower back, and a soft grey t-shirt. He tied his orange hoodie around his waist—just in case the temperature dropped or he needed the armor.

Jessica took command of the stove. The kitchenette was small, but she treated it like a restaurant line.

"Order up," Jessica said, cracking eggs into a bowl. "The Captain needs protein for the climb."

She whisked the eggs with a fork. She added diced ham, cheddar cheese, and mushrooms she had prepped the night before from their Market Street run.

"Omelet," Freddie said, watching the pan sizzle. "Structural integrity looks good."

"Wheat toast," Paige added, popping two slices into the toaster. "Grape jelly. And..."

She held up the canister.

"White Hot Chocolate."

"Essential," Freddie agreed.

For themselves, the sisters opted for something lighter but equally fueling.

"Yogurt parfaits," Jessica said, setting out bowls of vanilla yogurt, granola, and sliced strawberries. "And coffee. Lots of coffee."

They sat at the small round table. The map of Seattle was spread out under their plates like a tablecloth.

Freddie cut into his omelet. It was fluffy, hot, and savory. He took a bite of toast with grape jelly—sweet and crunchy. He took a sip of the white hot chocolate—creamy and soothing.

"Fuel status?" Paige asked, crunching on granola.

"Tanks filling," Freddie said. He pointed to the map with his fork.

"Vector confirmed," he stated. "We exit the hotel. We enter the Transit Tunnel at Convention Place. We board the bus. We transfer to the Metro-Rail at Westlake Center. We proceed to the Sky-Spire."

"And the bus ride?" Jessica asked gently, watching him over her coffee mug.

Freddie paused. He thought about the Pathfinder. He thought about the vibration, the smell, the fear.

Then he looked at the map. He saw the "Ride Free Area" box. He saw the tunnel line.

"The bus is electric," Freddie reminded himself. "It is a dual-mode. It runs on overhead wires in the tunnel. It is silent. It is clean."

He looked at Paige.

"And the crew is correct," he added.

Paige smiled, reaching over to squeeze his hand. "The crew is ready."

"Then we launch," Freddie said, finishing his chocolate. "Tourist Protocol is active."

They cleared the table. They grabbed their bags (water, cameras, jackets). They walked out the door of Room 412, not as refugees fleeing a crime scene, but as explorers stepping out into a brand new world.

Scene 2: The Mode Switch

The walk from the Cascade Suites to the transit station was short—just a few blocks through the crisp, sunny Seattle morning. The air smelled of rain-washed pavement and coffee, a sharp contrast to the diesel fumes of the Pathfinder terminal across the street.

They arrived at Convention Place Station, the northern terminus of the Downtown Seattle Transit Tunnel. It wasn't a dark, underground hole; it was a sunken, open-air plaza where the city streets dipped down to meet the subway level.

"There," Freddie said, pointing to the dedicated bus lane. "The insertion point."

They watched as a massive, articulated bus—painted in the teal, yellow, and white livery of the Transit Authority of the Puget Sound (TAPS)—rolled into the station from the street. The diesel engine was rumbling, a low, familiar growl.

"Wait," Freddie whispered, holding up a hand. "Watch the transformation."

The bus came to a halt at the designated "changeover" line. The driver engaged the parking brake.

Then, the magic happened.

The roar of the diesel engine cut out abruptly. Silence descended on the bay.

With a mechanical whir, two long poles rose from the roof of the bus. They extended upward until they made contact with the thick copper wires strung overhead.

Snap-hiss.

The connection was made. The bus hummed to life—not with a roar, but with a high-pitched, electric whine.

"Mode switch complete," Freddie beamed, his eyes wide behind his glasses. "Diesel propulsion offline. Electric traction online. It is a hybrid organism."

"That is pretty cool," Paige admitted, squeezing his arm. "It's like it plugged itself in."

"It is cleaner," Freddie noted approvingly. "No exhaust in the tunnel. Smart engineering."

The bus pulled forward to the boarding platform, gliding silently now. The doors folded open.

"Ride Free Area," Jessica reminded them. "We just walk on."

They stepped aboard. Freddie took a window seat near the articulation joint. Paige sat next to him; Jessica took the seat across the aisle.

The interior didn't smell like the Pathfinder. It smelled of ozone and electricity.

"Next stop," the automated voice announced, crisp and clear. "Westlake Station."

The bus accelerated. It plunged into the dark mouth of the tunnel.

Freddie tensed for a microsecond, expecting the shaking, the noise, the claustrophobia.

But the ride was smooth. The electric motor provided a constant, linear acceleration with zero vibration. The tunnel walls whipped by, illuminated by the bus's headlights, but it felt controlled. It felt like a spaceship launching from a bay.

"Status?" Paige whispered, leaning close.

Freddie looked out at the tunnel lights. He felt the smooth glide of the tires on the dedicated roadway.

"Silent running," Freddie whispered back, relaxing into the seat. "This is... acceptable."

The bus glided to a halt at Westlake Station. They stepped off onto the mezzanine platform.

"Upstairs," Jessica said, pointing to the signs. "To the Monorail."

They took the escalator up, rising from the subterranean tunnel into the light-filled atrium of the Westlake Center mall.

"Level 3," Freddie recited from the research. "The station is integrated into the architecture."

They reached the Monorail platform. And there it was.

The Metro-Rail.

It wasn't a bus. It wasn't a train. It was a retro-futuristic red streak sitting on a concrete beam high above the street. It looked like something out of a 1960s sci-fi cover—The World of Tomorrow.

"Target acquired," Freddie grinned. "The Monorail. Built for the 1962 World's Fair."

"It looks fast," Paige said.

"It travels the one-mile track in exactly two minutes," Freddie said. "It is a dedicated point-to-point shuttle."

They bought their tickets ($1.50 each). They boarded the red train. The windows were massive, curving up into the roof to offer a panoramic view of the sky.

Freddie sat right at the front. He looked down through the windshield at the concrete beam stretching out ahead of them, threading between the skyscrapers.

"Ready for launch?" Jessica asked from the seat behind him.

"Ready," Freddie said.

The doors slid shut. The Metro-Rail surged forward. They were flying above the traffic, above the noise, gliding on a beam of concrete toward the white needle piercing the blue sky in the distance.

"Destination," Freddie announced, watching the tower grow larger in the window. "The Sky-Spire."

Scene 3: The Observation Deck

The Metro-Rail glided into the station at the base of the tower. They stepped off the train and walked through the park, craning their necks to look up.

The Sky-Spire rose 605 feet into the air, a slender white stalk supporting a massive, saucer-shaped top house. It looked impossible. It looked like a spaceship tethered to the ground.

“Architecture check,” Freddie murmured, shielding his eyes. “Tripod legs. Tapered waist. It is structurally efficient.”

They bought their tickets and queued for the elevator.

“High velocity,” Freddie warned as the doors closed. “This elevator travels at 10 miles per hour. It ascends 520 feet in 41 seconds.”

The lift shot up. Through the glass window, the ground fell away instantly. The trees shrank to bushes, then to dots. The cars became toys.

Freddie gripped the rail, but he didn’t look away. He watched the city grid reveal itself.

Ding.

The doors opened on the Observation Deck.

They stepped out. The view was panoramic. To the west, the Elliott Bay glittered in the sun, ferries cutting white wakes across the blue water. To the east, the skyscrapers of downtown stood like glass cliffs. And in the distance, the massive, snow-capped cone of Mount Rainier floated above the horizon like a cloud.

“Oh wow,” Paige breathed.

They walked out onto the open-air deck. The wind whipped around them, but the heavy wire cage kept them safe.

Freddie walked to the edge. He looked down.

He saw the grid of the streets. He saw the tiny, ant-like buses moving in straight lines.

And he saw the roof of the Pathfinder terminal.

From down there, it had been a prison. From up here, it was just a grey rectangle. It was small. It was insignificant.

“Perspective,” Freddie whispered.

“What do you see?” Jessica asked, standing on his left side.

“I see the map,” Freddie said. “It is just data. It is manageable.”

He pointed down at the terminal.

“That is where I was,” Freddie said. “Down in the noise.”

He looked at his sisters. They were standing in the sun, hair blowing in the wind, smiling at him.

“This is where I am,” Freddie said. “Above the static.”

“This is where you belong,” Paige said, leaning her head on his shoulder. “High ground.”

Freddie took a deep breath of the thin, clean air. He felt the vibration of the tower in the wind—a subtle sway designed to handle storms.

It bends, he thought. But it does not break.

"I like the elevation," Freddie decided. "The Overwrite is successful. Seattle is not a trap. It is a launchpad."

"Good," Jessica grinned. "Now let's go inside. I think the rotating restaurant has lunch."

"Rotation?" Freddie asked.

"One revolution every 47 minutes," Jessica promised. "Slow and steady."

"Acceptable," Freddie smiled.

They went back inside, leaving the view of the bus station behind, trading the grey memory for a lunch in the sky.

Scene 4: The Deep Blue

The "Metro-Rail" ride back from the Sky-Spire had been smooth, but the transition to the waterfront was a physical trial. They navigated the "Hill Climb" elevators at the public market, descending from the city streets to the pier level.

By the time they reached Alaskan Way, Freddie's gait had deteriorated. The adrenaline of the morning's ascent had burned off, leaving behind the heavy, grinding reality of his spastic diplegia. His right foot dragged slightly with every step. He was leaning heavily on Paige, his arm draped over her shoulders, his breathing shallow and tight.

"Target acquired," Jessica announced, pointing to the large wooden structure of Pier 59. "**The Bayfront Aquarium.**"

"Low light protocol," Freddie rasped, trying to sound like the Captain, but his voice was thin. "We're going under."

They entered the lobby. It was cool and smelled of brine, a welcome relief from the sun, but the queue for tickets was long. Freddie swayed, gripping Paige's waist to stay upright.

"Status check?" Paige whispered, looking up at him with concern.

"Legs... critical," Freddie admitted, staring at the floor. "Battery low."

Jessica looked around the lobby while waiting in line. She saw the ticket counters, the gift shop, and the eager families.

Then, out of the corner of her eye, she saw them.

Tucked into an alcove near the coat check was a row of blue vinyl wheelchairs. They were standard-issue manual chairs, folded and waiting, with a sign above them: **Complimentary Guest Use**.

Jessica stepped out of line. She walked over to the alcove and pulled one out. She locked the brakes and rolled it over to Freddie.

"Freddie," Jessica said softly.

Freddie looked down at the chair. He froze.

The "Robert Virus" flared up instantly. *Lazy. Giving up. What will people think?*

"No," Freddie whispered, backing up a step. "I can walk. I am not... invalid."

"You aren't invalid," Jessica said firmly. "You're exhausted. You just walked a mile at the Sky-Spire. You've been on your feet for four hours."

"Mom would say..." Freddie started, his voice trembling. "She would say I am quitting."

"Mom isn't here," Paige cut in, her voice fierce. She turned to face him, grabbing both his hands. "She is three thousand miles away. We are here. And we say you are hurting."

She squeezed his hands.

"Look at me, Freddie. You are shaking. If you keep walking, you're going to crash. You're going to be in so much pain you won't even see the fish. Is that what you want?"

"No," Freddie whispered. "I want to see the sharks."

"Then sit down," Jessica said, her hand resting on the push handle. "Let us be the engine. You just be the Navigator."

Freddie looked at the chair. He looked at Jessica's determined face. He looked at Paige, who was nodding encouragement.

"You promise?" Freddie asked, his voice small. "You won't... think less of me?"

"Oh, Freddie," Paige said, pulling him into a tight, crushing hug right there in the lobby. "We could never think less of you. We think you're the strongest person we know. But even tanks need treads."

Jessica joined the hug, wrapping her arms around his back. "Get in the chair, Captain. That's an order."

Freddie let out a long breath. He nodded.

"Okay," he whispered. "Chair protocol engaged."

He turned and sat. The vinyl seat was cool. As he settled in, the weight came off his spine. The fire in his legs dimmed. He slumped slightly, the relief so profound it almost made him dizzy.

"Better?" Jessica asked.

"Much better," Freddie admitted.

Jessica unlocked the brakes. “Then let’s roll.”

They moved through the exhibits with a new, effortless rhythm. Jessica pushed the chair, her stride confident and smooth. She navigated the crowds like a pro, using the bulk of the chair to clear a path.

Paige walked right beside him on the left. She didn’t just walk; she connected. She rested her hand on the armrest, her fingers lacing through Freddie’s.

It was a physical promise. *I am right here. I am not letting go.*

They passed the jellyfish tank—a tall cylinder of blue light. Freddie leaned back in the chair, his head resting against the canvas, watching the jellies pulse.

“No skeleton,” Freddie murmured, relaxed. “Pure propulsion.”

“Like us,” Paige smiled, squeezing his hand. “Just moving.”

They reached the **Underwater Dome**. The moving walkway carried them into the center of the massive glass sphere.

Jessica locked the brakes in the middle of the tunnel.

Fish swam everywhere—above them, beside them, below them. The light filtered through twenty feet of water, casting rippling patterns of teal and azure on Freddie’s face.

He didn’t have to worry about balance. He didn’t have to worry about falling. He just sat there, safe in his rolling throne, holding his sister’s hand.

He looked up. A shark glided over the glass, its white belly visible.

“It is a closed system,” Freddie whispered. “Biological equilibrium.”

“It’s peaceful,” Paige said, leaning her head on his shoulder.

“It is weightless,” Freddie corrected. “In here... gravity is negotiable.”

He looked at his hand laced with Paige’s. He looked back at Jessica, who was leaning over the handles, smiling down at him.

He realized then that the wheelchair wasn’t a defeat. It was just another tool in the Avery inventory. It was a vehicle that let him stay in the fight.

“I like the blue,” Freddie decided. “It is the opposite of the bus.”

“Then we stay,” Jessica said. “As long as you want. We just float.”

They stayed in the dome for an hour, the three of them suspended in the blue light, watching the fish circle in their endless, silent orbits, letting the cool water wash away the last of the red alert.

Scene 5: The Wheelchair Epiphany

The hour in the **Underwater Dome** had been a total reset. The cool blue light, the silent circling of the sharks, and the weightless feeling of the water pressing against the glass had scrubbed the last of the bus vibration from Freddie's bones.

But more importantly, the chair had worked.

Freddie sat in the blue vinyl wheelchair, his legs relaxed for the first time in four days. He wasn't fighting gravity. He wasn't spending 60% of his processing power just trying to stay upright. He was just... looking.

"Time to surface," Jessica announced gently, checking her watch. "The tank is closing."

"Acknowledged," Freddie said.

Jessica unlocked the brakes. She spun him around with an effortless pivot.

As they rolled toward the exit, Paige didn't let go. She walked beside the chair, her hand still resting on the armrest, her fingers laced tightly through his.

"You okay?" Paige asked, looking down at him.

"I am... efficient," Freddie realized. "The energy cost of this excursion was minimal. If I had walked, I would be in system failure by now. But I am still operational."

He looked at the wheels. He thought about **Harper**, his younger sister back in Virginia Beach. Harper was fourteen. She had cerebral palsy too—mild, like his, but painful. She walked with a limp. She fell a lot.

And she was stuck with Ellen.

Mom says we just need to try harder, Freddie thought bitterly. *She says the chair is giving up.*

But looking at his sisters—Jessica pushing him without complaint, Paige holding his hand with pride—he realized Ellen was wrong. The chair wasn't giving up. It was a tool. It was a vehicle.

"I have a hypothesis," Freddie said quietly as they emerged from the dark exhibit into the bright, overcast afternoon of the pier.

"What's that?" Jessica asked, navigating the ramp down to the sidewalk.

"The chair," Freddie said, tapping the armrest. "It is not a defeat. It is a strategy. Harper... she struggles. She hurts. Mom makes her walk everywhere."

"I know," Paige said, her face darkening. "Mom thinks it builds character."

"It builds pain," Freddie corrected. "I think... when we get back... we should tell her. We should tell Harper about the chair."

"We'll do better than that," Jessica said firmly. "We'll buy her one."

Freddie looked up, surprised. “We can?”

“We have the Avery Grant,” Jessica reminded him. “Aunt Marge left that money for ‘Educational and Medical Necessities.’ I think a titanium chariot for Harper counts as a necessity.”

Freddie smiled. He imagined Harper spinning in a chair like this, fast and purple (her favorite color), instead of limping behind them.

“Purple,” Freddie decided. “She would want purple.”

“Done,” Paige agreed, squeezing his hand. “Project: Harper’s Wheels is a go.”

They reached the curb. Jessica parked the chair.

“Okay, Captain,” she said. “We have to leave the rental here. But the lesson stands. If you need wheels, we get wheels.”

They helped him stand. His legs were stiff, but because he hadn’t walked the aquarium, they weren’t trembling. He felt strong enough to make the transit back.

“One more thing,” Paige said, stopping him before they started walking. She looked him dead in the eye, still holding his hand.

“About what Vanessa said. About Italy. And New York.”

Freddie flinched. “We deleted that file.”

“I want to overwrite it,” Paige said fiercely. “Listen to me. If Jessica gets a job in New York… we all go to New York. If I get a fellowship in Italy… we all go to Italy. If you get a job at NASA in Houston… we all go to Houston.”

She squeezed his fingers until his knuckles cracked.

“We are a unit, Freddie. We move together. If one of us relocates, the headquarters relocates. No one gets left behind. Ever.”

Jessica stepped up on his other side. “I second that motion. The Avery Corporation is a package deal. You don’t get one without the other two.”

Freddie looked at them. The fear that had been gnawing at him since the lobby—the fear that he was holding them back—evaporated. They weren’t staying because they were stuck. They were staying because they were a team.

“Agreed,” Freddie whispered. “The Unit moves as one.”

“Good,” Paige said. “Now let’s get out of here. I need a nap.”

Scene 6: The Scar

They walked from Pier 59 back toward the **Hill Climb** elevator. The waterfront was noisy, smelling of diesel from the ferries and frying dough from the tourist stands.

Above them, a massive, double-decked concrete structure loomed over the street, blocking out the sky. It roared with the sound of thousands of cars thundering overhead.

The **Alaskan Way Viaduct**.

Freddie stopped. He looked up at the grey, stained concrete underbelly of the highway. It was loud. It dripped water. It cut the city off from the sea like a prison wall.

"Architecture check," Freddie muttered, wincing at the noise of a truck hitting an expansion joint above. "That structure is... hostile."

"It's ugly," Jessica agreed. "It's like a scar."

"It is a barrier," Freddie corrected. "It severs the connection between the urban grid and the hydrological system. It is inefficient. It is loud. It should be removed."

"Maybe they'll tear it down one day," Paige said, guiding him toward the elevator.

"They should put it underground," Freddie decided. "Like the bus tunnel. Hide the noise. Open the view."

They rode the elevator up to the market level, leaving the roar of the Viaduct behind.

They walked to the **TAPS** bus stop on 1st Avenue. A teal-and-white trolleybus was approaching, its electric poles sparking slightly against the overhead wires.

"Electric trolley," Freddie noted, pleased. "Route 10. It goes near the hotel."

They boarded. The bus was quiet, humming with electric power. Freddie took a window seat. Paige sat next to him, re-establishing the anchor. Jessica sat across the aisle.

Freddie looked out the window as they rolled through the city. He saw the buildings. He saw the people.

He didn't see a prison anymore. He saw a city that had problems (the Viaduct) and solutions (the Tunnel). Just like him.

He looked at his hand, still laced with Paige's.

We move as a unit, he thought. *Italy. New York. Or just back to the hotel.*

"Status?" Paige whispered.

"Mobility verified," Freddie said. "The chair is... a valid option. I will consider acquisition."

"We'll get you a fast one," Jessica promised from across the aisle. "Titanium. Matte black. Like a stealth fighter."

Freddie smiled. "Stealth mode," he whispered. "I like that."

The electric bus hummed up the street, carrying the Unit back to base, ready for the next day's mission.

Scene 7: High Voltage

The door to Room 412 clicked shut, sealing out the hallway.

Freddie wasn't walking. He was suspended between his sisters, his arms draped over their shoulders, his feet dragging slightly on the carpet. The "Hill Climb" from the waterfront—even with the elevator assist—had drained the last reserves of his physical battery. His legs were offline.

"Easy," Jessica grunted, adjusting her grip on his waist. "Almost there. Sofa first, then we strip the gear."

"You did good, Captain," Paige said, her voice breathless but proud. "See? If you had walked the aquarium, you would have collapsed on the pier. The chair saved your energy for the climb."

Freddie nodded weakly, his head lolling against Paige's shoulder. "Logic... confirmed. Chair was... efficient."

They shuffled him into the main living area. To get to the sofa, they had to pass the large picture window.

Jessica had left the curtains open earlier to let in the light.

As they pivoted Freddie to lower him onto the beige cushions, his head turned. His gaze tracked past the sofa, through the glass, and down to the street below.

He saw it.

Directly across Stewart Street, inside the open-air bay of the terminal, a massive silver bus was idling. The logo on the side was unmistakable: **Pathfinder**.

Blue diesel smoke curled up from its exhaust pipe, drifting toward the hotel window.

The "Overwrite Protocol" failed. The "Good Data" from the aquarium vanished instantly, deleted by the raw, visceral trauma of the visual trigger.

Freddie didn't see a vehicle. He saw a cage. He saw the miles of vibration. He saw the bathroom in Pasco. He saw Vanessa dragging him.

"Ah!" Freddie yelped. It was a sharp, high-pitched sound of physical pain, as if he had been burned.

Then, the air in his lungs compressed. A low, guttural rumble started deep in his chest, vibrating against Paige's side. It rose in pitch and intensity until it tore out of his throat—a scream of absolute, primal terror.

No! No! No!

He violently recoiled, trying to twist away from the window, his body spasming so hard he nearly pulled his sisters down.

"Freddie!" Jessica shouted, tightening her grip.

"THE VESSEL!" Freddie shrieked, his eyes rolling back, lost in the static. "IT IS HERE! IT IS WAITING!"

He wasn't in the hotel room anymore. He was back in the terminal.

"Code Red!" Paige yelled. "Meltdown! Get him to the bed! NOW!"

They abandoned the sofa. They hauled him toward the sleeping area, dragging him as his legs kicked out involuntarily. He was thrashing, fighting them, fighting the air, fighting the invisible restraints of his own mind.

They reached the King bed.

"Down!" Jessica commanded.

They pushed him onto the mattress. Freddie scrambled, trying to curl into a ball, his hands clawing at his ears to block out the sound of the bus engine that only he could hear. He was hyperventilating, short, sharp gasps that sounded like a dying engine.

"Restrain him!" Jessica shouted.

Paige didn't hesitate. She climbed onto the bed.

"On your back, Freddie!" Paige ordered, grabbing his shoulders and forcing him flat.

He fought her. *Let go! Trap! Trap!*

"It's me!" Paige screamed over his noise. "It's Paige!"

She threw her leg over his hips. She climbed directly on top of him, straddling his waist, then lowered her entire body weight onto his. She pressed her chest against his chest, her stomach against his stomach.

She wrapped her arms around his head, pinning his arms to his sides with her elbows. She locked her legs around his thighs.

She became a human straitjacket.

"Jessica!" Paige gasped. "Shield!"

Jessica climbed onto the bed beside them. She didn't pin him; there wasn't room. She sat cross-legged right next to Freddie's head, placing her hands firmly on his shoulders, adding her weight to the anchor.

"We have you," Jessica said, her voice dropping to a low, commanding chant. "We have you. You are in the Silo. You are safe."

Freddie bucked beneath Paige. He was strong—hysterical strength fueled by adrenaline. He arched his back, sobbing, a high, keen sound of misery.

Get it off! Get it off!

"I'm not getting off," Paige whispered fiercely into his ear. She pressed down harder, using gravity to compress his ribcage. "I am the ground wire, Freddie. Send the voltage to me."

He was vibrating with electricity. His muscles were rock hard, firing random signals. He tried to turn his head, to bite, to scream, but Paige held him fast.

"Breathe," Paige commanded. She exaggerated her own breathing, expanding her chest against his. *In. Out. In. Out.* "Match me. Find the rhythm."

"Paige..." Freddie choked out, his voice broken. "Paige... Paige..."

"I'm right here," she promised, locking her arms tighter. "It's Paige. It's just Paige. And Jessica. No one else. The bus is gone."

"Vanessa..." he sobbed.

"Deleted," Jessica said, stroking his hair with a firm, repetitive motion. "She is gone. She can't get in here. We are the firewall."

They held him. They rode the wave of the meltdown. It was violent. It was loud. It was ugly.

But they didn't let go.

Ten minutes passed. Fifteen.

Freddie's thrashing began to slow. The screams turned into ragged, wet sobs. The electrical storm in his nerves began to ground out into Paige's body.

Twenty minutes.

Freddie went limp. His head fell back against the pillow. His hands stopped clawing and uncurled. He lay there, gasping for air, sweat soaking his grey t-shirt.

He was exhausted. Physically and mentally depleted.

Paige felt his muscles release beneath her. She felt his heart rate drop from 'Critical' to just 'High.'

But she didn't move.

She knew the protocol. If she got up now—if she removed the weight too quickly—the sudden loss of pressure would trigger a rebound. His system was rebooting; it needed stability.

"Holding," Paige whispered to Jessica.

"Holding," Jessica confirmed. She kept her hands on his shoulders, wiping the sweat from his forehead with her thumb.

Paige kept her arms locked around him. She kept her legs tangled with his. She pressed her cheek against his damp hair.

"I'm staying right here," Paige murmured into his ear. "I'm staying until you tell me to move. You are the Captain. You give the signal."

Freddie lay under the crushing, saving weight of his sister. He focused on the pressure. It was heavy. It was real. It was the only thing keeping him from floating away.

He couldn't speak yet. The words were gone. So he just lay there, safe in the press, waiting for the world to stop spinning.

Scene 8: The Silent Signal

The violence of the storm had passed, leaving behind a heavy, exhausted silence in the hotel room.

Freddie lay flat on the mattress, pinned beneath the full weight of his sister. His chest heaved in shallow, ragged hitches, the aftershocks of the scream still rattling his ribs.

Paige hadn't moved. She was still lying stomach-to-stomach on top of him, her legs hooked around his thighs, her arms locked around his head. She was a human blanket, heavy and hot and immovable.

To his left, Jessica sat cross-legged, her hand resting firmly on his shoulder, her thumb rubbing a slow, rhythmic circle into his deltoid muscle.

Safe, Freddie's brain whispered. *Safe.*

But the logic engine was firing misfires.

He wanted to speak. He needed to issue a command.

Evacuate, he screamed inside his head. *Relocate Base. The perimeter is compromised. The enemy is across the street.*

He tried to force the words up his throat. He opened his mouth.

Nothing.

His vocal cords were paralyzed. The "Audio Driver" had crashed during the meltdown, severed by the sheer voltage of the panic. All that came out was a dry, clicking sound at the back of his throat.

He squeezed his eyes shut. Tears leaked out, hot and fast.

He couldn't tell them. He couldn't tell them that seeing the **Pathfinder** bus idling in the bay—the exact same model of vehicle that had been his prison for three days—had ripped the scab off his mind.

He realized, with a sickening lurch of vertigo, that they had been sleeping here since Friday night. They had been sleeping directly across the street from the scene of the crime.

Too close, his mind wailed. *Too close to the cage.*

And then, the second wave hit.

It wasn't the panic of the bus this time. It was the weight of the truth.

He thought about the note on the counter in Christiansburg. *I am setting you free.*

He thought about Vanessa's voice in the lobby. *They are trapped. You are the black hole.*

He had believed her. He had walked out the door. He had turned off his phone and left it in Christiansburg. He had almost thrown away the only two people in the universe who understood his code.

I almost lost them, Freddie thought. *I almost deleted the Unit.*

The guilt was a physical pain, sharper than the pressure sore on his back. It swamped him.

He didn't fight Paige this time. He did the opposite.

He freed his hands from where they were pinned at his sides. He reached up. He wrapped his arms around Paige's back, clutching the fabric of her t-shirt in desperate, clawing handfuls. He pulled her down even harder against him.

"Oh," Paige breathed, feeling the shift.

"Round Two," Jessica whispered, her hand tightening on his shoulder. "Hold fast."

They braced themselves, expecting another thrashing fit.

But Freddie didn't thrash. He just broke.

A new sound tore out of him—not a scream, but a high, keen whine of absolute misery. He buried his face in the crook of Paige's neck, soaking her collar with tears. He shook, his whole body vibrating with the force of his remorse.

I'm sorry, he tried to say. *I'm sorry. I'm sorry.*

But he was mute. So he just cried. He cried for the boy on the bus. He cried for the sisters he had scared. He cried because he was safe, and he didn't feel like he deserved to be.

Paige felt the shift instantly. This wasn't fight-or-flight. This was surrender.

"I know," Paige whispered into his ear, her voice thick with emotion. She didn't pull away. She pressed down harder, maximizing the contact. "I know, Freddie. Let it out."

She felt his arms crushing her ribs. He was holding onto her like she was the only solid thing in a dissolving world.

"We've got you," Jessica murmured, leaning in close so her hair brushed his forehead. "We aren't going anywhere. You can't scare us off, Freddie. We're right here."

Freddie sobbed, his chest heaving against Paige's stomach. He tried to nod, tried to signal that he heard them, but his motor control was offline.

He just held on. He locked his fingers together behind Paige's back, creating an unbreakable loop.

Don't let me go, he begged silently. *Even if I try to leave... don't let me go.*

"Never," Paige whispered, as if she could hear his thoughts. "I've got you. I'm never letting go."

She laid her cheek on top of his head. She closed her eyes. She settled her weight, prepared to lie there for an hour, a night, or a week—however long it took for the storm to pass and the Captain to find his voice again.

Jessica kept her hand on his shoulder, the steady anchor in the sea.

They stayed in the pile, three siblings on a hotel bed, riding out the aftershocks of a disaster they had survived together.

Scene 9: The Restoration

The storm in the hotel room had passed, leaving behind a stillness that felt fragile but solidifying.

Freddie lay beneath Paige, his chest rising and falling in a slow, rhythmic cadence that finally matched hers. The violent tremors that had racked his body twenty minutes ago had smoothed out into a low-level vibration of exhaustion.

Paige was still lying fully on top of him, stomach to stomach, her legs hooked around his thighs, her arms locked around his shoulders. But the quality of the hold had changed. She wasn't restraining a thrashing patient anymore; she was hugging a brother who was holding on for dear life.

She felt his arms tighten around her back, his fingers digging into her t-shirt, pulling her down.

He likes the weight, Paige realized. *He isn't fighting it. He needs it.*

She didn't move. She let her full weight settle, becoming a human gravity blanket. She pressed her cheek against his damp hair.

"We stick together," Paige whispered into the silence, repeating the mantra. "The Unit is solid. No matter what."

"Unconditional," Jessica added softly from her spot on the mattress beside them. She rested her hand on Freddie's arm, her thumb rubbing a slow circle. "We don't leave. We don't quit. We just hold the line."

Freddie squeezed his eyes shut. He couldn't speak—the audio driver was still offline—but he squeezed Paige's ribs in response. *Acknowledged.*

They lay there for a long time, the grey Seattle light fading outside the blackout curtains. The only sound was the air conditioner and the synchronized breathing of the three siblings.

Then, a new sound broke the quiet.

Gurgle-rumble.

It was a deep, resonant protest from Freddie's stomach.

A second later, Paige's stomach answered with a high-pitched growl of its own.

Freddie's eyes opened. He looked up at Paige. A flicker of awareness returned to his gaze—the "Captain" coming back online, realizing that the "Crew" was running on empty.

He tapped Paige's shoulder twice with his index finger. *Tap-tap.*

The Signal.

"Hungry?" Paige asked softly, lifting her head to look at him.

Freddie nodded, a small, jerky movement against the pillow.

"Okay," Paige said. "That means we have to move. Are you ready for the weight to lift?"

Freddie hesitated. He liked the pressure. It was safe. But the biological imperative for fuel was becoming critical.

He tapped her shoulder again. *Proceed.*

"Slowly," Jessica commanded.

Paige disengaged carefully. She unhooked her legs. She pushed herself up, sliding off him and settling onto the mattress at his side.

The loss of pressure was jarring, but Freddie didn't panic. He immediately reached out and grabbed Paige's hand, lacing their fingers together.

"I'm here," Paige promised.

"Dinner," Jessica announced, standing up from the bed. "I'm on mess duty."

She looked at Freddie. He was lying flat, staring at the ceiling. If she went to the kitchenette, he wouldn't be able to see her. He would lose visual contact with one-third of the Unit.

"Reorient," Jessica ordered. "Paige, help him turn. Head to the foot of the bed. Prop him up. I want him to have eyes on the kitchen."

"Copy," Paige said.

She helped Freddie shift. His legs were heavy and stiff, but together they rotated his body 180 degrees. He leaned back against a stack of pillows at the foot of the King bed.

From this vantage point, he had a direct line of sight to the small kitchenette.

"Visual confirmed?" Jessica asked, standing by the stove.

Freddie nodded. He could see Jessica. He could feel Paige next to him, her arm wrapped around his waist, her head resting on his shoulder.

The formation was broken, but the connection was intact.

"Menu," Jessica mused, opening the fridge. "We need soft. We need comfort. We need... Grilled Cheese."

She pulled out the loaf of soft white bread and the package of mild cheddar slices they had bought at Market Street Grocery.

"And tomato soup," she added, grabbing a can from the cupboard. "Classic protocol."

Freddie watched her work. The rhythm of her movements—buttering the bread, lighting the burner—was soothing. It was domestic. It was normal.

His mind began to drift. He wondered about the time zone. *18:15 PM PST.* That was *21:15 PM EST.*

Back in Virginia, the "Prime Time Block" would be starting.

He thought about the show they watched on WNRV. **The Local**. The bar where "everybody knows your name."

He wanted that. He wanted to hear the piano theme song. He wanted to see the wood-paneled bar where people were safe, where they were recognized, where they belonged.

He looked at the TV mounted on the wall. He opened his mouth to ask for it.

The Local, he tried to say.

But his throat just clicked. The words were stuck behind the firewall of the meltdown. He felt a tear leak out of his eye in frustration.

Paige felt the tension in his arm. She looked at him. She saw him staring at the blank TV screen with a longing that broke her heart.

Tv? Paige guessed softly.

Freddie nodded.

"You want to watch something?"

He nodded again. He tried to hum the theme song, but it came out as a shaky breath.

"It's okay," Paige soothed, rubbing his arm. "We'll find something. Jessica, remote?"

Jessica tossed the remote onto the bed. Paige picked it up.

"Let's see what Seattle has," Paige said, pointing it at the screen.

She turned it on. She cycled through the channels. News. Sports. Static.

Then, she hit a channel showing a familiar, grainy image. A bar. A tall man drying a glass. A short man walking in the door.

"NORM!" the TV audience shouted.

Freddie's breath hitched. *They found it.* Even here, on the other side of the continent, the signal existed.

"The Local," Paige smiled. "Good call, Captain."

She put the remote down. Freddie leaned his head against hers. He watched the show. He listened to the laugh track.

"Soup's on," Jessica called out.

She brought two plates over to the bed. Grilled cheese sandwiches, cut into triangles (no crusts), and mugs of tomato soup.

She placed the tray on the mattress between them.

"Eat," Jessica commanded gently. "Soft food. Easy chewing."

Freddie picked up a triangle. It was warm. It was soft.

He took a bite. The cheese was melted perfectly.

He looked at the TV where the characters were raising a glass. He looked at Jessica, who had pulled the desk chair over to sit right next to the bed so she could eat with them. He looked at Paige, who was blowing on her soup.

He couldn't say the words yet. He couldn't say *Thank you* or *I love you* or *I'm sorry I tried to leave.*

But as he dipped his sandwich into the soup, surrounded by his sisters and the glow of the TV, Freddie knew one thing.

He was in the place where everybody knew his name. And he was never leaving again.

Scene 10: The Flight Plan

The episode of *The Local* ended, the piano notes fading into the hum of the air conditioner. The dinner plates were stacked on the nightstand. The city outside was dark, but inside the "Silo," the lighting was warm and low.

"Shutdown sequence," Jessica whispered, turning off the TV.

They prepared for sleep. There was no hesitation, no modesty. In the aftermath of the meltdown, clothes felt like barriers—layers of friction that prevented the necessary data transfer of heat and safety. They stripped down, leaving their clothes in piles on the floor, and climbed into the massive King bed.

The configuration was absolute.

Freddie lay in the center. He was exhausted, his body heavy and limp, but his eyes were alert. He watched his sisters settle in.

Jessica took the left flank. She lay on her side, pressing her back against his, creating a solid wall between him and the door.

Paige took the right flank. She curled into him, draping her leg over his thighs to pin him down, resting her head on his shoulder. She wrapped her arm across his chest, her hand finding Jessica's hand in the dark. They interlaced their fingers over his heart, locking him in.

"We've got you," Paige whispered, her breath warm against his neck. "Defenses are down. No armor. Just us."

Freddie let out a long, shaky breath. He felt the skin-to-skin contact—arms, legs, ribs. It wasn't just warmth; it was verification. *They are real. They are here.*

Paige closed her eyes, listening to his heart rate slow down. This was her favorite moment. It wasn't the sightseeing or the jokes; it was this. The moment when the tension left his body. If she could wake up tomorrow morning and know that he had slept through the night—that the night terrors hadn't found him—that would be the greatest victory of her life.

Sleep, she willed him silently. *Just sleep.*

But Freddie tapped her arm. *Tap-tap.*

He pointed to the nightstand where Jessica's laptop sat charging.

"You want the computer?" Jessica asked, lifting her head.

Freddie nodded. He opened his mouth to explain, but his throat clicked. The mutism was still holding the line. He pointed to his head, then to the machine. *Input required.*

Jessica reached over and grabbed the **MagnaByte**. She opened it and set it on his stomach, resting it against his bent knees.

Freddie opened **Quantum Word**. The screen glowed white in the dark room.

He began to type. His fingers were slow, but deliberate.

MISSION PLANNING: MONDAY

He looked at them.

VECTOR: NORTH.

"North?" Paige asked, reading over his shoulder. "Why north?"

Freddie typed.

VANESSA'S AUNT = KENT. KENT = SOUTH. SOUTH IS COMPROMISED. NORTH IS CLEAN DATA.

Jessica nodded, her expression fierce. "Logic is sound. We go North. What's the target?"

Freddie minimized the document and opened the web browser. He navigated to a map of the region north of Seattle—Snohomish County.

He found it. A massive gray footprint near an airfield in Everett.

The Aerospace Assembly Plant.

He clicked the link. *The largest building in the world by volume. Home of the 747.*

He typed again.

AEROSPACE FACTORY. SYSTEMS TOUR. I WANT TO SEE THE MACHINE.

"Airplanes," Jessica smiled. "Big ones. That works. We can drive the rental car up I-5."

Freddie shook his head. He deleted the text.

NEGATIVE. TRANSPORT MODE: BUS.

Paige stiffened against his side. "Freddie... are you sure? After... everything?"

Freddie looked at her. He saw the worry in her blue eyes. He typed fast, the keys clacking softly.

PATHFINDER = PRISON. TAPS = FREEDOM. I NEED TO RECLAIM THE CODE. I NEED TO RIDE A BUS WITH THE UNIT.

He looked at them. It was the only way to delete the trauma. He had to replace the memory of the old dog from hell with a memory of a clean bus ride with his sisters. He had to prove to himself that the vehicle wasn't the enemy.

"You want to overwrite the file," Jessica realized.

Freddie nodded.

"Okay," Paige said, squeezing him tighter. "We take the bus. We take the commuter express from downtown. We hold your hand the whole way."

Freddie smiled. He typed one last line.

THANK YOU. END OF LINE.

He closed the laptop. Jessica set it on the floor.

The room went dark again.

"We're going North," Jessica whispered into the silence. "Away from her. Away from the south."

"And we're never leaving you," Paige promised, kissing his cheek. "I don't care if we have to move to the North Pole. We stick together. Always."

Freddie closed his eyes. He imagined the massive factory. He imagined the bus ride. But mostly, he felt the weight of his sisters holding him down, keeping him safe from the gravity of the past.

He slept. And for the first time in four days, he didn't dream of the road.

Scene 11: The Northern Trajectory

The morning broke grey and misty—a classic Pacific Northwest start. Inside the hotel room, the mood was operational. The emotional storm of the previous day had washed away the panic, leaving behind a clear, hard resolve.

They dressed for the mission. Freddie put on his jeans and the orange hoodie—reclaiming the armor. Paige and Jessica wore their rain shells.

"Objective," Freddie stated, adjusting his glasses in the mirror. "North. Everett. The Factory."

"Transport," Jessica replied, checking the **TAPS** schedule she had grabbed from the lobby rack. "We need the **Regional Express Route 510**. It's a commuter line. High frequency. Professional ridership."

"Where do we board?" Paige asked.

Freddie consulted the map he had studied on the laptop.

"The hotel is at 8th and Stewart," Freddie visualized. "The Pathfinder terminal is at 811 Stewart—directly across the street. The Route 510 Northbound stop is one block over. **9th Avenue and Howell Street**."

"One block," Jessica nodded. "We can do one block."

08:45 AM — Stewart Street

They stepped out of the hotel lobby. The air was cool and wet.

Directly across the street, the **Pathfinder** terminal was busy. A bus was idling in the bay, smoke curling from its exhaust.

Freddie stopped. He looked at it. He felt Paige's hand tighten around his.

"Don't look," Paige whispered.

"No," Freddie said. He looked at the bus. He looked at the dirty windows. He looked at the destination sign: **PORTLAND**.

"It is just a machine," Freddie stated, his voice trembling slightly but firm. "It has no power. We are taking a different machine."

He turned his back on the terminal.

"Vector: North," he said.

They walked one block east to 9th Avenue, then north to Howell. The bus stop sign was sleek and blue, marked **TAPS Regional**.

08:52 AM — 9th & Howell

The bus rounded the corner. It wasn't a grey, dirty coach. It was a clean, white-and-teal articulated bus with the TAPS logo.

510 EVERETT

"Boarding," Freddie whispered.

He stepped up. He didn't look back. He paid the fare. He walked down the aisle.

It smelled of wet raincoats and coffee. It was quiet. People were reading newspapers or looking at their phones. No one was shouting. No one was trapped.

Freddie took a window seat on the right side. Paige sat next to him. Jessica took the seat directly behind them.

"Secure?" Jessica asked, leaning forward.

Freddie looked out the window. He reached out and took Paige's hand. She laced her fingers through his instantly.

"Secure," Freddie said.

The bus hissed and pulled away from the curb. They merged onto I-5 North, heading away from the city, away from the south, away from the memory of the mistake.

The ride was smooth—forty-five minutes of steady highway driving. They arrived at **Everett Station**, a brick transit hub that felt more like a train station than a bus depot.

"Transfer," Freddie announced, reading the signs. "We need the local connector to the factory."

They boarded a smaller TAPS bus. It wound through the industrial park, passing massive hangars and parking lots filled with thousands of cars.

"Shift change," Freddie noted. "The workforce is massive."

The bus climbed a hill and dropped them off in front of a building that looked like an airport terminal.

They stood on the observation balcony of the massive assembly plant. The tour guide—a retired engineer—was speaking over the PA system, but Freddie barely heard him. He was too busy processing the visual data.

The factory floor was a canyon. It was 98 acres under a single roof. Clouds formed near the ceiling.

Below them, the production lines stretched out for nearly a mile.

To the left, the massive **Atlas-400** (In-universe 747). The "Queen of the Skies." Its signature hump was unmistakable.

To the right, the new **Vector-700** (In-universe 777). Twin engines. Massive wingspan.

"Look at the line," Freddie whispered, pointing. "Station 1. Station 2. Flow methodology."

He watched a massive yellow overhead crane lift a wing section. It moved with slow, hydraulic grace, lowering the multi-ton component onto the fuselage with millimeter precision.

"It fits," Freddie breathed. "No forcing. Just engineering."

"It's amazing," Paige said, leaning on the railing next to him. "It's like building a skyscraper sideways."

"It is a system," Jessica noted, standing on his other side. "Just like you like."

"It is a perfect system," Freddie agreed. "Every part has a number. Every rivet has a home. Nothing is lost."

He watched the workers. They moved with purpose. They checked clipboards. They followed the manual.

If you follow the manual, Freddie thought, *you can fly.*

He stood there for an hour, mesmerized by the slow, deliberate birth of the airplanes. It was orderly. It was quiet (in the way machines are quiet). It was safe.

12:00 PM — The Return Trip

They took the connector back to Everett Station. They waited for the Southbound 510.

"Destination?" Paige asked.

"9th and Stewart," Freddie said. "The hotel."

They boarded the bus. This time, Freddie didn't just endure the ride. He watched the world go by. He saw the trees. He saw the mountains in the distance.

He realized that the bus wasn't the enemy. The bus was just a tool. It could take you to a prison, or it could take you to see the biggest building in the world. It depended on who was holding the map.

And this time, he was holding the map.

"Status?" Jessica asked from the seat behind.

"Mission complete," Freddie said, resting his head on Paige's shoulder. "We saw the Machine."

"We saw the Machine," Paige agreed.

The bus rolled south, carrying the Avery Unit back to base, ready for whatever came next.

Flight to Tahoma

Scene 1: The Bypass

Jessica dropped the room key on the front desk counter. The *clack* of plastic on marble was the final punctuation mark of their time in the city.

"Checking out," Jessica told Dave the clerk. "We're heading for the trees."

"Safe travels," Dave said.

They took the elevator down to the garage. The white **Vanguard Senator** rental car waited in the concrete gloom.

"Keys," Paige demanded, holding out her hand. "I need to drive. I need to do something with my hands besides worry."

Jessica tossed her the keys. "All yours, Lieutenant. Get us out of the grid."

Paige climbed into the driver's seat. She adjusted the mirrors and reached for the gear stick. She gripped it, her foot instinctively stomping on the floorboard for a clutch pedal that wasn't there.

Her foot hit empty carpet.

"Ugh," Paige groaned, wiggling the shifter in its gate. "It's a slushbox. An automatic. It feels like driving a golf cart."

"It's a rental, Paige," Jessica laughed, opening the back door. "They don't trust tourists with clutches."

"It's boring," Paige muttered, putting the car in Drive with a look of disdain. "No torque control. Just... mush."

Freddie stood by the open back door. He looked at the front passenger seat where he usually sat as the Navigator. Then he looked at the back seat where Jessica was sliding in.

He thought about the last few days. Paige had held him in the hotel bed. Paige had grounded him in the lobby.

He looked at Jessica. She was the Shield. She had organized the rescue, booked the flights, and scrubbed the bus dirt off his back. He missed her gravity.

"Change of formation," Freddie announced.

He climbed into the back seat next to Jessica.

"Backseat driver?" Jessica teased, scooting over to give him room.

"I require... equal time," Freddie whispered. "The Shield needs to be deployed."

He buckled his seatbelt, pulling it snug across his hips. Then, he slid across the bench seat until he was pressed against Jessica's side. He wrapped his arm through hers, leaning his head on her shoulder.

Jessica smiled, a warm, bright expression that lit up the dim garage. She wrapped her arm around him, pulling him in tight.

"I've got you," Jessica said, resting her cheek on top of his head. "I'm right here."

"Secure," Freddie breathed, closing his eyes.

Paige navigated out of the garage, grumbling about the car's turning radius. They turned onto Stewart Street one last time, driving past the **Pathfinder Terminal**.

Freddie didn't flinch. He felt the solid warmth of Jessica's arm. He felt the steady rhythm of her breathing. The terminal was just a building.

"Ghost town," Freddie whispered into Jessica's sweater.

"Ghost town," Jessica agreed, squeezing his hand.

They reached the massive junction south of the city. The traffic on **I-5 South** was heavy—a river of red taillights and grey steel.

"Navigation update," Jessica called out from the back, playing the role of Navigator now. "We aren't taking I-5 all the way. Take Exit 154B. Merge onto **I-405 North**."

"North?" Paige asked, checking her blind spot. "We're going south."

"Just for a minute," Jessica explained. "To catch the drop to the valley."

Paige executed the merge, the automatic transmission whining as it downshifted aggressively. "Come on, shift," she muttered. "Find a gear."

A mile later, she took **Exit 2**, sweeping onto the ramp for **SR-167 South**.

Freddie stiffened slightly. "Kent," he read aloud.

"That's where she said she was going," Jessica whispered, rubbing his arm. "The aunt's trailer park."

"If there even *is* an aunt," Paige muttered from the driver's seat, her eyes narrowing as she glared at the exit sign. "Knowing Vanessa, she probably made the whole thing up. She's probably sitting on a curb somewhere wondering why her life isn't a movie."

"It is a valid hypothesis," Freddie murmured, looking out at the sprawling, bleak expanse of the suburb. It wasn't the romantic, sleepless city Vanessa had promised. It wasn't the mountains. It was just... parking lots. Fast food. Concrete.

He thought about Vanessa standing at the payphone in the terminal, desperate and alone. He thought about her lies—about New York, about Italy, about the "freedom" she claimed to offer.

And he thought about where he was right now—warm, safe, held by his sister in a car driven by his twin.

A sound bubbled up in his throat. A chuckle.

"She missed the exit," Freddie said.

"What?" Jessica asked, looking down at him.

"She wanted a life," Freddie said, a real smile breaking across his face for the first time since the bus station. "She wanted to be free. She wanted to be the hero. And she ended up... in Kent."

He laughed. It was a dry, dark, satisfied laugh.

"Or she ended up nowhere," Freddie added. "Maybe the aunt is a fiction. Maybe she is just... deleted."

"Fate," Jessica grinned, pressing a kiss to the top of his head. "The variable resolved itself. She is static. We are the signal."

"We are just passing through," Paige agreed, pressing the accelerator.

The Vanguard roared past the exit. They left Kent—and the ghost of Vanessa—in the dust, just a blur of grey in the side mirror.

Scene 2: The Iron Creek Lodge

The drive south on SR-167 had turned into SR-161, winding through the Puyallup Valley.

Then, they hit the turn for **State Route 7**.

The four-lane highway narrowed. The concrete median disappeared. The road became a simple, two-lane blacktop winding through the trees.

The warehouses vanished. The strip malls disappeared. They were replaced by Douglas firs that towered two hundred feet into the air.

Freddie sat up straight in the back seat. He looked out the window.

“Two lanes,” Freddie whispered. “Yellow line in the middle. Trees on the shoulder.”

“Just like home,” Jessica said, squeezing his hand.

“It looks like the New River Valley,” Freddie said, his voice full of wonder. “It looks like Route 8 to Riner. Or the road to Wind Rock.”

He relaxed completely. The knot of “city tension” that had been in his chest since Seattle finally unraveled. This was a scale he understood. One lane forward. One lane back. No merging. No chaos.

“Approaching target,” Paige announced from the front. “Ashford. Population: Small.”

They turned off the main road onto a gravel drive marked by a heavy wooden sign: **THE IRON CREEK LODGE**.

It wasn’t a hotel. It was a collection of heavy timber cabins nestled deep in the woods, spaced far enough apart that you couldn’t see your neighbors.

“Cabin 4,” Jessica read the key packet she had picked up. “The Bear’s Den.”

Paige pulled the car up to a sturdy log cabin with a wide front porch and a stone chimney. She put the car in Park.

“Engine off,” Paige said.

The silence was instant. No sirens. No bus engines. No traffic drone. Just the sound of the wind in the trees and the rushing water of the Nisqually River nearby.

“Audio check,” Freddie whispered, stepping out of the car.

“Clear,” Jessica said, standing beside him. “Zero static.”

They walked into the cabin. It smelled of cedar and woodsmoke. The main room was cozy, with a leather sofa and a fireplace. But the main attraction was through the bedroom door.

There it was. **The California King.**

It was massive. Bigger than the one at the Cascade Suites. A vast expanse of flannel sheets and heavy quilts.

“72 by 84 inches,” Freddie recited the specs, a smile touching his lips. “Maximum capacity.”

“We fit,” Paige said, dropping her bag.

Freddie walked to the window. He looked out at the forest. He couldn’t see the road. He couldn’t see a single bus stop.

“We stay here,” Freddie decided. “Until the battery is 100%.”

"As long as it takes," Jessica agreed, locking the heavy deadbolt on the front door.

They were off the grid. The rescue was over. The vacation had begun.

Scene 3: The Bear's Den

The silence was the first thing Freddie noticed.

Usually, when he woke up, there was a background track: the hum of a refrigerator, the distant whine of traffic, or the frantic pounding of his own heart.

But here, waking up in the center of the Alaska King bed, there was only the sound of breathing.

He lay still. To his left, Jessica was breathing in a slow, deep rhythm. To his right, Paige was snoring softly—a tiny, vibrating snuffle that she always denied doing.

The weight of the heavy down duvet was perfect. It was a "Class 4" weighted blanket, pressing him into the mattress.

He wiggled his toes. He was wearing his thick grey wool socks. The flannel sheets felt soft against the denim of his jeans.

"Status: Restored," Freddie whispered to the ceiling.

Beside him, Paige shifted. She groaned, stretching her arms over her head, her knuckles cracking. She blinked her eyes open, staring at the massive log beams crossing the ceiling.

"Ugh," Paige muttered, rubbing her face. "I had a dream I was driving a go-kart in a swamp."

"Interpretation?" Jessica mumbled, not opening her eyes yet.

"That stupid rental car," Paige complained, sitting up and shaking her hair out. "The transmission feels like pudding. You step on the gas and it just... thinks about it for three seconds before doing anything. I need a clutch. I need to tell the car what to do, not ask it for permission."

"It got us here," Freddie pointed out, pushing himself up on his elbows. "The slushbox was adequate."

"Don't encourage the machines to be lazy, Freddie," Paige teased, nudging him with her shoulder. She looked at him, really looked at him.

His eyes were clear behind his glasses. His hands weren't shaking. The "vibration" that usually hummed under his skin—the anxiety of existing in a loud world—was gone.

"You look good," Paige said softly. "You look... settled."

"I am regulated," Freddie agreed. He looked around the massive bed. "The perimeter held."

"Okay," Jessica said, throwing the duvet back and swinging her legs over the side of the high mattress. Her feet, clad in white cotton socks, hit the wooden floor with a soft *thud*. "Nap protocol complete. Let's inspect the Base."

They slid off the bed. The floorboards were wide-plank pine, smooth and polished. They were cool through their socks, but not cold.

They walked out of the bedroom into the main living area.

"Architecture check," Freddie announced, looking up.

The ceiling vaulted twenty feet high, supported by peeled cedar logs. Two skylights let in the afternoon sun, filtering it through the canopy of the fir trees outside so the light on the rug was dappled and green.

"Leather," Freddie noted, walking to the sofa. He ran his hand over the back. "Cool to the touch. No microfiber static."

"And look at this," Paige said, kneeling in front of the hearth.

It wasn't just a fireplace; it was a black cast-iron woodstove with a glass door. A stack of dry, split birch logs was piled neatly in a copper bin next to it.

"Thermal unit," Freddie said, joining her. "Controlled combustion. We can seal the door and watch the fire without the smoke smell getting in the fabric."

"I'll build one tonight," Paige promised. "Get it roaring."

They moved to the kitchenette. It was small but efficient. Slate countertops (smooth, cold). A small fridge (quiet). A basket on the counter contained packets of local coffee and hot cocoa mix.

"Cocoa detected," Jessica noted, holding up a packet.

"Inventory approved," Freddie smiled.

He walked to the sliding glass door that led to the back porch. He didn't open it yet; he just pressed his hand against the glass.

Outside, the forest was a wall. Ferns grew waist-high right up to the porch railing. Moss hung from the maple trees like green beards. It was dense. It was wild.

"Visual isolation," Freddie observed. "I cannot see the road. I cannot see the office. I cannot see the other cabins."

"Just the trees," Jessica said, coming up to stand on his left.

"And the river," Paige added, standing on his right.

They could hear it clearly now—the constant, rushing white noise of the Nisqually River churning over glacial rocks. It sounded like a massive ventilation fan, scrubbing the air clean.

Freddie looked down at his socks on the wood floor. He wiggled his toes again.

He felt the floor beneath him. Solid. Real.

"This is better than the hotel," Freddie decided. "The hotel was a transition point. This... this is a bunker."

"A Bear's Den," Paige corrected, wrapping an arm around his waist. "And we're hibernating."

"Hungry?" Jessica asked, opening the mini-fridge to check the supplies they had bought at a gas station. "I think we have cheese, crackers, and very expensive beef jerky."

"Rations," Freddie nodded. "Acceptable."

He turned away from the window. He didn't need to check the perimeter anymore. The woods were doing it for him. The static of the city—the buses, the neon, the disappointment of Vanessa—felt a thousand miles away.

Here, there were only logs, fire, river, and the Unit.

"Let's eat," Freddie said. "Then... fire protocol."

Scene 4: The Supply Run

"Logistics run," Jessica announced, grabbing the car keys. "The fridge is empty, and the Vanguard is thirsty. We need fuel and food."

They piled back into the car. The drive from the lodge to the "town" of Ashford took less than three minutes.

Ashford wasn't a city. It was a strip of civilization carved out of the forest: a few inns, a pottery shop, and the main hub of local life—**The Ashford Outpost**.

It was a gas station, but it looked like a log cabin that had grown gas pumps.

"Pulling in," Paige said, steering the white sedan up to the pump.

"I'll handle the fuel," Jessica said. "You two handle the rations. We need dinner. Something hot. Something simple."

"Copy that," Freddie said.

He stepped out of the car. The air smelled of gasoline, yes, but also of damp earth and the massive cedar trees that loomed right behind the store.

He walked into the store with Paige.

It was perfect.

It wasn't a sprawling supermarket with fluorescent glare and forty aisles of choices. It was a village store. Tight, cluttered, and cozy. The aisles were narrow wooden shelves packed with camping gear, fishing bait, and cans of soup.

"Scale: Manageable," Freddie whispered, adjusting his glasses.

He walked down the aisle. He didn't have to dodge carts. He didn't have to filter out a thousand faces. There was just a guy in a fishing hat buying worms and a woman buying milk.

"What's the menu, Captain?" Paige asked, grabbing a red plastic hand basket.

Freddie scanned the shelves. He didn't want fancy. He wanted *grounding*.

"Macaroni and Cheese," Freddie decided, pointing to the shelf. "The deluxe kind. The one with the liquid cheese pouch. Not the powder."

"Shells and Cheddar," Paige identified, tossing two blue boxes into the basket. "Solid choice."

"And meat tubes," Freddie added.

"Hot dogs?"

"Affirmative. Beef franks. We can roast them on the woodstove if the power fails. Or just boil them."

They moved through the small store, gathering the components of a comfort meal.

- A bag of **Ridged Potato Chips** (essential for the crunch texture).
- A gallon of 2% milk.
- A pack of **Milk Chocolate Bars**, **Honey Grahams**, and **Marshmallows**.

"S'mores protocol?" Paige grinned, holding up the bag of marshmallows.

"Essential thermal experiment," Freddie agreed.

They brought their haul to the counter. The cashier was a teenage girl reading a paperback book. She didn't look at Freddie like he was weird. She just scanned the items.

"Heading up the mountain?" she asked.

"Just to the lodge," Paige said.

"Nice night for a fire," the girl said. "Total was $24.50."

Freddie watched the transaction. Simple. Exchange of goods. Friendly data. No threats.

They walked back out to the pumps. Jessica was just clicking the nozzle off.

"Tank full," Jessica reported. "Rations?"

"Secured," Freddie said, holding up the grocery bag. "We have the components for a feast."

Back at the cabin, the sun was beginning to dip behind the tree line, casting long, indigo shadows through the forest.

Inside, the cabin was warm. Paige had made good on her promise; a small fire was crackling in the cast-iron woodstove, orange light dancing behind the glass door.

Jessica took charge of the kitchenette. The smell of boiling pasta and rich, melting cheese soon filled the small space, masking the scent of the rental car's upholstery that still clung to their clothes.

They didn't eat at the small dining table. They ate on the floor, sitting on the thick rug in front of the fire.

Freddie held his bowl of shells and cheese. It was hot, salty, and creamy—pure comfort data. He took a bite of a hot dog.

"Status?" Jessica asked, sitting cross-legged next to him.

Freddie looked at the fire. He listened to the river outside. He looked at his sisters, eating macaroni in their socks on a cabin floor in the shadow of a volcano.

He thought about the "fancy" dinner Vanessa had promised him at the Space Needle—a rotating view, expensive wine, strangers watching him eat.

This was better. This was real.

"Optimal," Freddie whispered, scraping his spoon against the bowl. "Battery is charging."

"Good," Paige smiled, reaching over to steal a ridged chip from his plate. "Because after this, we are testing the S'mores Protocol. And I don't roast marshmallows lightly. I burn them."

"Carbonized sugar is an acceptable variant," Freddie allowed.

He took another bite. He was full. He was warm. He was home—even if home was temporarily a log cabin in Pierce County.

Scene 5: The Hypothesis & The Lock

The dinner plates were washed and dried. The fire in the woodstove had settled into a steady, glowing bed of coals.

Outside, the weather finally turned. It started as a whisper against the cedar logs, then grew into a steady, rhythmic tapping on the skylights. The Pacific Northwest rain had arrived—not a storm, but a curtain of grey water enclosing the cabin.

"Perimeter sealed," Freddie noted, looking up at the skylight. "The rain is the final layer."

They were sitting on the rug again, the "S'mores Protocol" abandoned for the moment. The mood had shifted from comfort to calibration.

"Freddie," Jessica said gently, sitting opposite him with her legs crossed. "We need to debug the code. You said Vanessa told you we wanted to leave."

Freddie nodded. He pulled his knees up to his chest, wrapping his arms around his shins.

"She explained the plot," Freddie said. "Of the movie. *The Skyline Wait*."

"I don't know that one," Paige said, leaning against the sofa.

"Vanessa said it is a classic," Freddie explained. "A man and a woman are lonely. They live small, sad lives. But they both hear a signal... a call to meet on top of the tallest tower in the Rainy City. They meet in the rain. And suddenly, the data resolves. They are happy. They are complete."

He rested his chin on his knees.

"She said I was the man in the movie. And she was the woman. And if we went to the Sky-Spire... we would fix the glitch in our lives."

"And us?" Jessica asked.

"She said I was the anchor dragging you down," Freddie whispered. "She said Paige wanted to study art in Italy. She said Jessica wanted to work in finance in New York City. She said the only reason you stayed in Christiansburg... was because I couldn't function without you."

He looked at them, his eyes wet behind his glasses.

"She said if I left... you would be free."

"Oh, Freddie," Paige breathed. She scooted across the rug and grabbed his hand. "That is a lie. A total, system-wide error."

"I don't want Italy," Paige said fiercely. "I want *here*. I want the New River Valley. I want to draw in our room while you play video games."

"And I definitely don't want New York," Jessica added, shaking her head. "I want to manage the Silo. I want to keep us safe. We stay because we *want* to stay. Not because we have to."

Freddie absorbed this. "So the Black Hole hypothesis... is false?"

"False," Jessica confirmed. "You are the Sun. We orbit you because it's warm."

Freddie let out a long breath. One weight lifted. But the heavier one remained.

He looked at the fire. The orange light danced on the glass.

"There is... one more variable," Freddie said. His voice dropped to a frequency so low they almost missed it. "The Pasco Lock."

The room went silent. The rain tapped harder on the roof.

"In Pasco," Freddie started, his hands gripping his shins until his knuckles turned white. "In the bus terminal. She... initiated a sequence."

Paige froze. Jessica went perfectly still.

"She tried to kiss me," Freddie whispered. "She tried to... access the hardware. She said it was part of the movie. The consummation."

He squeezed his eyes shut.

"I froze. I locked up. System failure."

"Good," Jessica said, her voice hard as flint. "You rejected the input."

"I rejected it," Freddie agreed. "But... the logic remains."

He opened his eyes and looked at Paige. This was the hardest thing he had ever calculated. It went against every social protocol, every line of code in the manual. But it was the truth of his operating system.

"I told her no," Freddie said. "Because she is a Stranger. She is an Unknown Variable. I cannot trust her data."

He swallowed hard.

"If..." Freddie stammered. "If the rules were deleted. If the taboo did not exist in the database... and I *had* to choose a partner..."

He looked straight at Paige.

"It would be you."

The confession hung in the air, heavy and terrified. Freddie braced himself for the recoil. He waited for them to pull away. He waited for the disgust. *Incest. Broken. Monster.*

But Paige didn't flinch.

She looked at him with sad, deep understanding. She didn't see a predator. She saw a boy who equated Intimacy with Safety.

"I know," Paige whispered.

She reached out and pulled him into her arms. She held him tight, rocking him slightly.

"I know, Freddie. It's because you trust me."

"It is logic," Freddie sobbed into her shoulder, the tears finally breaking loose. "Sex requires trust. I only trust the Unit. Therefore... the only logical partner is the Unit."

"It makes sense," Jessica said softly, moving to sit beside them, rubbing his back. "It's not weird, Freddie. It's just... your wiring. You equate safety with love. And we are the only safety you have."

"I don't want to do it," Freddie choked out. "I know it is wrong. I know the code forbids it."

"We know you don't," Paige soothed, stroking his hair. "We know you aren't trying to hurt me. You were just rejecting *her*. You were saying, 'I would rather have my sister, who I trust, than this stranger who scares me.' "

"Yes," Freddie wept. "That is the calculation."

"Then the calculation is valid," Jessica declared firmly. "You aren't a monster, Freddie. You're just a Navigator who wants to stay on the map."

They sat there for a long time while the rain washed the roof. Freddie cried out the shame of the bus terminal, the confusion of his own body, and the fear that he was broken.

And his sisters just held him. They didn't judge the thought. They understood the source.

He wasn't choosing incest. He was choosing Safety. He was choosing the only people in the world who had never hurt him.

"You are safe," Paige whispered, kissing his forehead. "You are safe with us. No more strangers. No more movies."

"Just the Unit," Freddie whispered back, his voice ragged.

"Just the Unit," Jessica agreed.

The Pasco Lock was broken. The secret was out. And the walls of the cabin didn't collapse. The fire kept burning. The rain kept falling. And his sisters kept holding him.

Scene 6: The Iron Giants & The Safe Mode

The rain continued to drum against the skylights, a steady rhythm that sealed the cabin off from the rest of the world. The difficult conversation was over. The tears had been dried. The "Pasco Lock" was broken.

Now, it was time to plan the parameters for the next day.

Jessica pulled out a brochure she had grabbed from the front office rack.

"Tomorrow's forecast is overcast but dry," Jessica reported. "We have options nearby. There is a place called **Iron Spirit Park**. It says here it's a 'sculpture garden of recycled heavy machinery.' "

Freddie perked up, leaning forward on the rug. "Recycled machinery? Define."

"It says it was created by an artist named Dan Klennert," Jessica read, tilting the paper toward the firelight. "He takes junk—old logging trucks, rusty gears, driveshafts, tractor parts—and welds them into sculptures. Dinosaurs, giants, birds."

"Acceptable," Freddie noted, nodding slowly. "Reassigning function to obsolete hardware. Taking something broken and making it structural again. I like that."

"We'll go there first," Jessica promised. "Right after breakfast. You can inspect the welds."

"And right down the road in Elbe," Jessica continued, "is the train depot. They have steam locomotives parked on the tracks. Static display."

"Steam power," Freddie said, a faint smile returning. "High pressure. Mechanical linkage. Approved."

"There is also a historic site," Jessica added, flipping the brochure to the back panel. "The Little White Church. It says here it's the smallest church in the state. It seats forty people. It's supposed to be—"

"Negative," Freddie cut in. His voice was sharp, the frequency spiking.

Jessica stopped immediately. "Negative?"

"No churches," Freddie said, staring into the glowing embers of the woodstove. "Vanessa... she used a code I did not understand."

He frowned, looking down at his hands.

"She said Sunday mornings are for 'cleaving.' She kept using that word. 'Leave and Cleave.' "

He looked up at Paige, genuine confusion and fear in his eyes.

"Does that not mean... to chop? Like a meat cleaver?" Freddie asked, his voice trembling. "She said I had to 'cleave' to her. I thought she meant I had to cut you off. Like an amputation. She made it sound like... violence. Like the only way to be with her was to sever the limb that connects me to you."

He shuddered.

"I do not understand why a church would want people to be amputated. It is a hostile algorithm."

"It's an old saying, Freddie," Jessica said softly, her face hardening as she realized how Vanessa had twisted the scripture to terrify him. "But the way she used it? Yes. It was violence."

"I do not want to cleave," Freddie whispered. "I do not want to be cut."

"Then we delete the church," Jessica said firmly, crumpling the brochure slightly and tossing it onto the table. "We stick to the machines. Iron and steam. Things that are welded *together*, not cut apart."

"Welded is better," Freddie agreed.

The plans were set. The fire was dying down.

Freddie looked at the bathroom door. He felt the sweat of the panic attack, the residue of the tears, and the lingering, phantom touch of the motel room in Pasco.

He stood up. He looked at his sisters.

"I require... full decontamination," Freddie stated.

"A bath?" Paige asked.

"Assisted," Freddie clarified. He looked down at his hands. "I cannot reach the back. I cannot... I don't want to be alone in the water."

"You don't have to be," Jessica said softly. "We're here."

They moved into the bathroom. It was spacious, with a deep soaking tub and slate floors.

They stripped off the day clothes—the jeans, the wool socks, the t-shirts. They left them in a pile by the door.

There was no shame. There was no awkwardness. They were the Unit. Clothing was armor for the Outside World—for airports, buses, and strangers. In the Bear's Den, armor was unnecessary.

Jessica started the water, making it hot—steaming hot. She poured in a capful of the lodge's cedar bath soak.

Freddie stepped into the water. He sank down until the water lapped at his chin.

Paige knelt on the bathmat behind him. Jessica knelt by the side.

They washed him.

Paige took the washcloth. She scrubbed his back, moving in slow, firm circles. She washed away the pressure sore's memory. She washed away the bus seat. She washed away the fear.

"Clean," Paige whispered.

Jessica washed his hair, massaging the shampoo into his scalp, her fingers strong and sure.

Freddie closed his eyes. He didn't feel like an invalid. He felt like a king being tended to by his guard. He felt cherished.

"Status?" Jessica asked, rinsing the suds from his hair with a cup.

"Purified," Freddie breathed.

When he was done, he stepped out and wrapped himself in a thick towel. He sat on the closed toilet lid, waiting while Jessica and Paige took their turns in the water, washing off their own stress, their own worry.

When they were all clean, dried, and warm from the steam, they dropped the towels.

They turned off the lights in the main room. The only illumination came from the dying embers in the woodstove and the grey moonlight filtering through the rain on the skylight.

They walked into the bedroom. The massive bed waited—nine feet of white flannel.

"Formation," Freddie whispered.

They climbed in.

They didn't wear pajamas. Pajamas were just another layer of static, another barrier between the components of the system.

Freddie lay in the center.

Jessica climbed in on his left. She pressed her back against the cool air of the room, her front pressed against Freddie's side. Skin to skin. Warmth to warmth.

Paige climbed in on his right. She curled into him, her leg hooking over his, her arm draping across his chest to hold Jessica's hand.

The Sandwich Configuration. Optimized.

Freddie felt the beat of Paige's heart against his ribs. He felt the slow rise and fall of Jessica's breathing against his shoulder.

There were no secrets here. No "Pasco Lock." No Vanessa. No hidden agendas.

There was just the biological reality of the three of them, huddled together against the vastness of the world.

"Safe?" Freddie whispered into the darkness.

"Safe," Paige mumbled into his neck.

"Safe," Jessica confirmed, squeezing his hand.

Freddie closed his eyes. For the first time in a week, the map in his head was clear. There were no monsters in the dark. Just the Unit.

And that was enough.

Scene 7: Factory Settings

Sunlight.

Not the harsh, fluorescent glare of a hospital or a terminal. This was soft, green-filtered light streaming through the skylights, dappled by the fir branches overhead.

Freddie opened his eyes.

He didn't panic. He didn't check the time. There was no alarm clock screaming at him.

He was warm. He was in the center of the Alaska King.

To his left, Jessica was still asleep, her arm thrown over her eyes. To his right, Paige was awake, quietly scrolling through the digital camera screen.

"Morning," Paige whispered, noticing he was online.

"Morning," Freddie croaked. "Status?"

"Rain stopped," Paige reported, tilting the camera screen so he could see. She pointed to a blurry but majestic shot of the massive, snow-capped volcano looming over the road. "Jessica actually got a decent shot while we were moving. I was too busy fighting that slushbox transmission to look up, but she caught the mountain."

Freddie stared at the tiny LCD screen. The mountain looked huge even in 2 megapixels.

"It is... significant," Freddie whispered.

He stretched. His legs extended into the vast, cool flannel at the foot of the bed. He felt the absence of clothing—no waistband digging in, no twisted fabric. Just skin and sheets. It felt... streamlined. Pure.

"Hungry?" Jessica mumbled from the other side, rolling over and yawning.

"Cereal protocol," Freddie suggested.

They didn't rush to cover up. They didn't scramble for robes or hide behind towels. They simply slid out of the massive bed, moving with the easy comfort of people who had shared a womb and a lifetime of close quarters.

Freddie walked to the kitchenette. The pine floorboards were cool under his bare feet. He liked the sensation. It was raw, honest data.

He opened the fridge and pulled out the gallon of milk. Jessica grabbed the box of **Honey Nut Hoops**. Paige grabbed the ceramic bowls.

They sat at the small round wooden table near the window. The sunlight played across their shoulders.

They ate in comfortable silence for a few minutes, the only sound the crunch of cereal and the clink of spoons.

"This is correct," Freddie said, looking at his sisters. "No armor. No secrets."

"It's easier," Jessica agreed, resting her chin on her hand. "Clothes are just costumes we wear for the Outside. In here, we don't need to perform."

"We have to put the costumes on soon, though," Paige reminded them, gesturing to the brochure on the counter with her spoon. "The Iron Giants are waiting. And welding slag is sharp."

Freddie nodded. He finished his milk, drinking the sweet remnants from the bowl.

"We will armor up," Freddie said, standing up and stretching his arms overhead. "But only because the environment requires protection. Not because we are hiding."

He walked to the pile of clothes they had left by the bathroom door the night before. He picked up his jeans.

"Initiating boot sequence," Freddie announced. "Let's go see the machines."

Scene 8: The Iron Spirits

The "Boot Sequence" was efficient. They traded their natural state for the necessary armor of the outside world: blue jeans, sturdy sneakers, and hoodies against the morning chill. Freddie pulled his orange sweatshirt on, hood up, sunglasses on.

"Shields active," Freddie announced.

They walked out to the white **Vanguard Senator**. The morning air was crisp and smelled heavily of damp earth and pine needles.

"I'm driving," Jessica announced, snagging the keys from the table. "I want to see if the transmission is actually broken, or if Paige just has a lead foot."

"It's mush," Paige insisted, opening the back door. "It hunts for gears like it's lost."

Jessica settled into the driver's seat and started the engine. She shifted into Reverse, backed out smoothly, and put it in Drive. The car accelerated down the gravel lane.

"Seems fine to me," Jessica teased, glancing in the rearview mirror as the car shifted smoothly into second gear. "Maybe you just lack the gentle touch, Lieutenant. You treat the gas pedal like a stomp box."

"I drive with conviction," Paige countered, leaning back against the seat. "This car drives with hesitation."

In the back seat, Freddie ignored the mechanical debate. He buckled his seatbelt, pulling the strap tight across his chest. Then, he slid to the middle, pressing his side against Paige.

She wrapped her arm around his shoulders, pulling him in. He rested his head on her shoulder, watching the forest blur past the window.

"Status?" Paige asked, resting her chin on his hood.

"Passenger secure," Freddie whispered. "Navigation is set."

The drive was short—less than six miles down SR-706 toward the town of Elbe.

"Target acquired," Jessica announced, slowing down. "On the left."

They pulled into a gravel lot. It wasn't a formal museum. It was a field, a forest clearing, filled with... monsters.

But they weren't scary monsters. They were mechanical ones.

"Engine off," Jessica said.

They stepped out. Freddie adjusted his glasses, his eyes widening behind the lenses.

Standing in the tall grass was a dinosaur—a massive, skeletal T-Rex. But its ribs weren't bone; they were curved steel leaf springs from an old truck. Its legs were driveshafts. Its teeth were rusty railroad spikes.

"Whoa," Paige breathed. "It's... junk. But it's alive."

Freddie walked toward it. He moved slowly, respectful of the machinery.

He stopped in front of a sculpture that looked like a giant bird. He leaned in, studying the weld marks.

"That is a transmission housing," Freddie identified, pointing to the bird's chest. "And those feathers... are shovel heads."

He looked around the park. There were dozens of them. Giants made of tractor seats. Horses made of chains.

"He didn't melt them down," Freddie whispered, awe in his voice. "He kept them. He saw the shape inside the broken parts."

"Reassigned function," Jessica said, walking up beside him. "Just like you said."

Freddie reached out and touched the cold, rusty iron of a gear that was now an eye.

"It is logical," Freddie said. "The machine broke. It could not do its job anymore. But it was not thrown away. It became... art."

He looked at Paige.

"It is a valid upgrade," Freddie decided. "To stop working, and start being."

"Exactly," Paige smiled, squeezing his hand. "Just be."

They wandered the park for an hour, Freddie identifying the original purpose of every rusty bolt and beam, finding comfort in a world where broken things weren't discarded, but turned into giants.

Scene 9: The Silent Engines

The drive from the sculpture park to the tiny town of Elbe took less than five minutes. Jessica parked the white **Vanguard Senator** on the gravel shoulder near the historic depot.

"Target acquired," Jessica announced. "Heavy metal, twelve o'clock."

There they were.

Resting on the siding tracks, backed by the dark green forest, sat the steam locomotives. They weren't hissing or whistling. They were cold. They were massive black iron beasts, silent and sleeping.

"Engine off," Jessica said.

Freddie unbuckled his seatbelt. He stared through the window at the nearest locomotive—a massive Heisler geared engine, built for climbing mountains.

"Static display," Freddie whispered, his eyes tracking the lines of the boiler. "Safe mode."

They stepped out of the car. The air here smelled of creosote from the railroad ties and faint, old lubricating oil. It was an industrial perfume that Freddie found instantly calming. It was the smell of work, but without the noise of it.

He walked up to the tracks. Paige and Jessica flanked him, but they let him take the lead. This was his domain.

He approached the massive steel driving wheels. They were taller than he was.

"Look at the linkage," Freddie said, pointing to the thick steel connecting rods. "Direct mechanical transfer. No transmission fluid. No slushbox."

"Pure torque," Paige agreed, nodding as if she understood the engineering. "It goes where you tell it to."

Freddie reached out. He hesitated for a second, checking for heat, but the metal was cool to the touch. He pressed his palm against the heavy iron of the drive rod.

It felt solid. Immovable.

"It is designed to contain fire," Freddie murmured, looking up at the black cylinder of the boiler. "To hold high-pressure steam and turn it into motion. But right now... it is just resting."

He walked along the length of the train, his sneakers crunching on the gravel ballast. He inspected the rivets on the tender. He looked at the complex valve

gear. He loved it because he could *see* how it worked. There were no hidden computer chips. If a part moved, you could see it move.

"Honest engineering," Jessica said, reading the plaque near the cowcatcher. "Built in 1929. It used to haul logs down the mountain."

"It worked hard," Freddie said, patting the cold steel of the cylinder like it was a horse's flank. "And now it gets to sit in the trees and sleep."

He looked at his sisters.

"Like us," Freddie added.

"Exactly like us," Paige smiled, leaning against the heavy iron wheel, looking small next to the machine.

Freddie stood there for a long time, just breathing in the smell of oil and iron, surrounded by things that were heavy, permanent, and currently at rest.

"Inspection complete," Freddie finally decided, wiping a smudge of grease from his hand onto his jeans—a badge of honor. "The system is sound."

"Good," Jessica said, checking her watch. "Because looking at all this heavy machinery has made me hungry. And I smell onions."

"Onions?" Freddie asked, sniffing the air.

"Across the street," Jessica pointed. "There is a shack. It smells like burgers."

Freddie looked from the cold iron train to the small wooden shack.

"Fuel required," Freddie stated. "Let's proceed."

Scene 10: The Refueling

They walked across the two-lane highway from the train depot. The air smelled of grilled onions and beef—a distinct, heavy scent that signaled "food" to the primitive part of the brain.

"Target identified," Jessica said, pointing to the small wooden building with the line of people out front. "**The Junction Grill**."

"It is... small," Freddie noted.

"It's a shack," Paige corrected. "But the smell is correct. That is the smell of grease and victory."

They joined the line. Freddie stood between his sisters, sandwiched safely. He watched the operation through the serving window. It was an assembly line. One person grilling. One person dressing buns. One person taking money.

"Efficiency," Freddie whispered, admiring the workflow. "High throughput. No wasted motion."

When they got to the window, the order was simple.

"Three cheeseburgers," Jessica ordered. "Fries. And..." She looked at Freddie.

"Chocolate shake," Freddie said. "Viscosity check."

"Three shakes," Jessica finished.

They took their brown paper bag and the carrier of styrofoam cups to a wooden picnic table near the road. The sun was fully out now, warming the damp wood.

Freddie unwrapped his burger. It wasn't gourmet. It was a smashed patty, melted American cheese, pickle, and onion on a soft bun. It was wrapped in plain white paper that was already turning translucent.

He took a bite.

Grease. Salt. Protein.

"Status?" Paige asked, dipping a fry into her chocolate shake.

"Optimal," Freddie mumbled, mouth full. "This is better than the fancy dinner."

"Way better," Jessica agreed, wiping a drip of ketchup from her thumb.

"Vanessa said we would eat at the top of the **Sky-Spire**," Freddie said, chewing thoughtfully. "She said the floor rotates. She said I would see the whole city."

He looked at the burger in his hands.

"I do not want the floor to move while I am eating," Freddie stated firmly. "And I do not want to see the city. I want to see the trees. And I want the burger to taste like... this."

"Like 100% real American cholesterol," Paige joked.

"Like fuel," Freddie corrected. "Simple fuel."

They ate watching the cars drive by on SR-7. Every time a logging truck rumbled past, Freddie felt the vibration in the picnic table. It was a heavy, low frequency.

He didn't flinch. He just chewed his burger, grounded by the heavy food and the heavy trains across the street.

"What's the plan for the afternoon?" Jessica asked, crumpling her wrapper into a ball.

Freddie looked at the empty shake cup. He looked at the mountain looming above the trees. He felt the "good" fatigue of a day spent processing new, safe data.

"Return to Base," Freddie decided. "Nap protocol. Then... maybe we sit by the river."

"River watch," Paige nodded. "I like it."

"Then let's go," Jessica said, standing up. "The Bear's Den is waiting."

They walked back to the *Vanguard Senator*, full, tired, and content, leaving the iron giants and the burger shack behind for the quiet sanctuary of the woods.

Scene 11: Glacial Flour

The nap was short—just a quick system reboot after the heavy burger. Now, they were outside.

They had walked past the porch, pushing through the waist-high ferns to the riverbank. The air was colder here, radiating off the water. The roar of the river was constant, a wall of white noise that drowned out the distant highway.

They sat on a large, bleached drift-log that had been tossed up by a winter storm. It was stripped of bark and smooth as bone.

Freddie stared at the water. It wasn't the clear, blue water of a swimming pool. It wasn't even the brown of a muddy creek. It was opaque. It was a milky, grey-green color, rushing violently over the smooth river stones.

"It looks dirty," Paige observed, tossing a small pebble into the current. It vanished instantly into the murky flow. "Like someone poured concrete mix in it."

"It is not dirt," Freddie corrected gently. He adjusted his glasses, looking up toward the invisible summit of the volcano hidden by the trees. "It is rock."

"Rock?" Jessica asked, pulling her knees to her chest to stay warm. "How can water be rock?"

"Glacial flour," Freddie explained. "The glacier... the ice is so heavy. It grinds against the mountain. It crushes the stone into dust. Fine powder."

He pointed to the rushing grey water.

"The water picks up the dust. That color... it is liquid mountain. We are watching the volcano dissolve, one grain at a time."

"That is... incredibly metal," Paige laughed. "We're watching the mountain bleed."

"No," Freddie shook his head. "We are watching it change. It flows down here. It goes to the ocean. It becomes sand. It becomes something else."

He picked up a smooth, grey stone from the bank. It was cold and heavy in his hand.

"It doesn't stay stuck," Freddie whispered. "It moves."

He looked at the stone, then out at the rushing water.

"Vanessa wanted me to be a statue," Freddie said softly. "She wanted me to stay in her story. To be fixed in one place. But I am not a statue. I am the river."

"You flow," Jessica agreed, leaning her head on his shoulder.

"I flow," Freddie repeated.

He threw the stone. It splashed into the grey current and was gone, carried away toward the Pacific Ocean.

They sat there for an hour, watching the liquid mountain rush by, listening to the roar that scrubbed the air clean.

"I like this place," Freddie decided. "The Iron Creek Lodge. The grey water. The quiet."

"We can come back," Paige promised. "Whenever the static gets too loud. We know where the bunker is now."

"Coordinate saved," Freddie nodded.

"Come on," Jessica said, standing up and dusting off her jeans. "It's getting cold. Let's go inside. I think we have enough supplies for one last round of Mac and Cheese before we have to head back tomorrow."

"Affirmative," Freddie said.

He took one last look at the grey river—the grinding, moving, living force of nature—and then turned back toward the warmth of the cabin and the safety of the Unit.

Scene 12: The Return Vector

The packing sequence was silent and efficient. The "Bear's Den" had served its purpose—it had been a sanctuary, a bunker, and a hospital—but now the mission was over.

Freddie folded his orange sweatshirt and placed it into his duffel bag. He checked the drawers. Empty. He checked under the Alaska King bed. Clear.

"Perimeter check complete," Freddie announced. "No artifacts left behind."

"Good," Jessica said, zipping up her bag. "Let's load the Senator. It's a straight shot to the airport."

They walked out to the white sedan. The sun was shining, but Freddie didn't look back at the cabin. He didn't get sentimental about buildings once they were empty. He simply logged the data: *Safe location identified for future reference.*

The drive back was the reverse of the arrival, but the feeling was different. As the towering fir trees of Ashford gave way to the strip malls of Spanaway, and then the concrete ribbons of Interstate 5, Freddie didn't panic.

He sat in the back, sunglasses on, watching the world speed by. He wasn't trapped in the noise anymore; he was just passing through it.

Jessica spotted the sign—**VANGUARD RENT-A-CAR**—and pulled off International Boulevard into the sprawling open-air lot. It wasn't a fancy garage;

it was acres of asphalt surrounded by chain-link fencing, smelling of exhaust and car wash soap.

She pulled into the return lane under the metal awning. A guy with a thick jacket and a handheld computer walked up.

"Mileage?" the attendant asked.

"Enough," Jessica smiled.

She handed over the keys. The receipt printed with a buzzing sound from the device on his belt.

"Vehicle surrendered," Jessica said, patting the white roof of the car. "Goodbye, slushbox. You did okay."

"It was adequate," Paige admitted, slinging her bag over her shoulder. "But I still missed the clutch."

"Bus is loading!" the driver of the Vanguard shuttle yelled.

It was a standard cutaway van—the kind with the folding hydraulic door and the fiberglass body. They hauled their bags up the steps.

The interior smelled of vinyl seats and diesel fumes. The seating was two-by-two with a narrow aisle down the center.

Freddie slid into a window seat on the right side. Paige immediately slid in next to him, blocking the aisle. Jessica took the seat directly in front of them.

"Perimeter secure," Paige whispered, buckling the lap belt.

Freddie leaned his head against the window, watching the rental lot disappear as the bus lurched forward, merging back onto the highway toward the terminal.

The shuttle dropped them at the curb on the lower level of the terminal. The noise was louder here—buses idling, whistles blowing, the announcements over the PA system.

"Hold the line," Freddie whispered to himself.

They walked to the island marked **COURTESY VANS**.

They didn't have to wait long. A white van with **THE AIRPORT GRAND HOTEL** stenciled on the side pulled up to the curb. The driver, an older man with a friendly nod, hopped out to grab their bags.

"Heading to the Grand?" he asked.

"Affirmative," Freddie said, climbing into the back row of the van. He liked the back row. It was defensible.

The hotel was a stark contrast to the lodge. It was glass, steel, and beige marble. It smelled of cleaning chemicals and conditioned air.

Jessica walked to the front desk while Freddie and Paige stood near a potted palm tree, guarding the luggage.

"Checking in under Avery," Jessica told the clerk. "We have an Early Check-In add-on."

The clerk typed for a moment. "I see it here. Housekeeping is just putting the finishing touches on the room. It should be ready by noon. If you'd like to have a seat in the lobby, I'll wave you over the second it's clear."

"Understood," Jessica said.

She walked back to the siblings. "Fifteen minutes. Holding pattern."

They sat on a leather sofa near the elevators. Freddie watched the business travelers rolling their suitcases across the polished floor. He watched the automatic doors slide open and shut.

"It is busy," Freddie noted. "But organized."

"It's a transit point," Paige said. "Nobody stays here. They just pause here."

At exactly 12:00 PM, the clerk caught Jessica's eye and held up a key card packet.

"Green light," Jessica announced.

They entered the room. It was a standard "Executive King." A large bed, a desk, a TV in an armoire, and a window that looked out over the airport tarmac.

Freddie dropped his bag and walked straight to the window. He inspected the glass immediately.

"Triple-pane," Freddie noted, pressing his finger against the cold surface. "There is a four-inch air gap. Soundproofing is active."

He watched a massive 747 taxiing slowly toward the runway, its engines shimmering with heat. He could feel the low rumble in the floor, but the high-pitched whine was gone.

"Machines," Freddie whispered. "Going home."

"How are you holding up?" Jessica asked, sitting on the edge of the King bed to test the mattress. "It's not the Alaska King, but we'll fit."

"I am functional," Freddie said, turning away from the window.

He looked at his sisters. They looked tired. Not the "good tired" of the river, but the deep, bone-weary exhaustion of adrenaline wearing off.

"I am ready," Freddie stated clearly.

"Ready for what?" Paige asked, kicking off her shoes.

"Ready to go home," Freddie said. "To Christiansburg. To the basement. To the static."

He adjusted his glasses.

"The adventure was... necessary. The data was valid. But the mission is complete."

"Agreed," Jessica sighed, flopping backward onto the white duvet. "I miss my own bed. I miss the Silo."

"I miss driving a car that listens to me," Paige added, sitting next to her.

Freddie walked over and sat between them. The bed dipped under his weight. It was tighter than the log cabin bed, but that just meant the pressure would be better.

"Tomorrow we fly," Freddie said. "Tomorrow we execute the final leg."

"Tomorrow," Paige confirmed, leaning her head on his shoulder.

They sat there in the generic hotel room, listening to the muffled roar of jet engines outside, ready to close the file on the Pacific Northwest and return to the safety of the known world.

Scene 13: The Holding Pattern

The door clicked shut. Jessica threw the deadbolt. She hung the "Do Not Disturb" sign on the handle outside.

"Bunker secured," Jessica announced. "No entry authorized."

Freddie stood by the window, shivering slightly. The room was set to a crisp 68 degrees, and the air conditioner was blowing directly across the bed.

"It is... cold," Freddie noted, rubbing his arms.

"It's the climate control," Paige said. "It feels like a refrigerator in here."

"Initiating comfort mode," Jessica said. "Pajamas."

They opened their bags. This wasn't the raw, "factory settings" nudity of the cabin—that environment was warm and isolated. This was a hotel room—sterile and chilled. They needed a soft layer that was decent enough for the "semi-public" nature of a hotel.

Freddie pulled on his grey flannel pajama bottoms and a clean white t-shirt. Paige put on her oversized sleep shirt and leggings. Jessica changed into yoga pants and a tank top.

"Better," Freddie sighed, the soft flannel replacing the stiff denim of the travel day.

Jessica claimed the left side of the King bed, sliding under the heavy white duvet to warm up. She was asleep within minutes, the exhaustion of the drive finally shutting her system down.

Freddie walked to the window. He looked at the ergonomic desk chair. It looked efficient, but it was lonely. He looked at the tarmac—the movement, the heavy machinery, the chaos of departure. He felt a spike of static.

"I need... grounding," Freddie whispered.

"Way ahead of you," Paige said.

She didn't go to the binder. Instead, she helped Freddie drag the heavy, upholstered armchair from the corner right up to the window glass.

Freddie sat down, curling his legs up. Paige climbed in right next to him, squeezing into the oversized chair. She tucked herself under his arm, her head resting on his chest, her legs draped over the armrest.

It was tight, but it was perfect. The pressure of her weight against him acted like an anchor.

"Status?" Paige asked, looking out at the runway.

"Stabilized," Freddie breathed, resting his chin on the top of her head.

"Hey," Paige whispered, picking up the remote control from the side table. "I found the calm channel."

She clicked the TV on.

Blue screen. Yellow text. Smooth, elevator jazz saxophone. **THE METEOROLOGICAL NETWORK.** Freddie smiled.

"Local forecast loop?" Freddie asked.

"Just started," Paige confirmed.

They spent the next four hours in that suspended animation—huddled together in the armchair, warm in their pajamas, watching the rain on the radar and the planes on the tarmac.

The sun was starting to dip lower, casting long shadows across the runway. The golden light filtered through the sheer curtains.

Jessica stirred, stretching her arms overhead.

"Time?" she croaked from the bed.

"17:00," Freddie reported, still holding Paige. "Shift change on the tarmac."

"We need food," Jessica decided, sitting up. She picked up the heavy cardstock Room Service menu. "The Executive Club."

"Check the specs," Freddie warned. "Sourdough is too sour. The texture is abrasive."

"And no slime," Paige added, burying her face in Freddie's t-shirt. "No tomatoes. No onions."

"Understood," Jessica said. "Wheat bread. Dry payload."

She stood up and walked to the door.

"I'm taking the sign down," Jessica announced. "If the runner sees 'Do Not Disturb,' he might leave the cart in the hall. We need a clean hand-off."

She cracked the door, removed the plastic hanger, and closed it again.

"Perimeter open for supply drop," she confirmed.

She sat back on the bed and dialed.

"Room Service? Yes. Room 512. We need three Executive Club Sandwiches. But we need a modification. Can we get those on whole wheat? Yes. And for two of them—absolutely no tomatoes and no onions. Just meat, cheese, lettuce, and mayo. The third one can be standard. Thank you."

The knock came at the door.

Freddie glanced down at his attire. Flannel pants. T-shirt. He looked at Paige. Leggings. Sleep shirt.

"Status?" Freddie asked.

"Decent," Jessica confirmed, standing up. "We are covered. No armor required."

Jessica opened the door. A waiter in a crisp vest wheeled in a cart covered in white linen. He didn't blink at their pajamas; he was used to airport travelers keeping odd hours.

"Dinner is served," he said professionally. "I have two modified clubs and one standard."

"Perfect," Jessica said, signing the bill. "Thank you."

She locked the door and threw the deadbolt.

"Cart parked," Jessica announced.

They sat on the floor, using the linen-draped cart as their table.

Freddie inspected his sandwich. Golden brown wheat toast. Turkey. Bacon. Crisp lettuce. Not a single slice of tomato or ring of onion in sight.

"Compliance," Freddie noted with satisfaction.

"It's good," Paige said, taking a huge bite. "The wheat is softer than the sourdough."

"It is structurally superior," Freddie agreed.

He chewed slowly, looking at his notepad full of flight times, then at the triple-paned glass.

"I can do the flight tomorrow," Freddie stated, more to himself than to them. "I have watched forty planes take off today. None of them fell."

"That's good stats," Jessica nodded, sipping her cola.

"Physics works," Freddie said. "Lift equals weight. Thrust equals drag. We will simply be part of the equation."

"And then we're home," Paige said softly.

"Home," Freddie repeated. "Back to the static."

He took another bite of his sandwich, ready for the final leg of the mission.

Scene 14: The Null Hypothesis

The meal was finished. The "structural triangles" of the sandwiches had been dismantled and consumed.

Jessica stood up. She wheeled the room service cart into the hallway, ensuring the smell of bacon didn't linger in their bunker. She hung the "Do Not Disturb" sign back on the handle.

Click. The latch engaged. *Thud.* The deadbolt slid home.

She walked to the window and pulled the heavy blackout drapes shut. The view of the runway—the flashing lights, the movement, the world—vanished. The room was plunged into a soft, artificial twilight.

"Perimeter sealed," Jessica announced. "We are offline."

Freddie stood by the bed. He looked down at his flannel pajamas. He looked at Paige's leggings. They were soft, yes, but they were still a layer. They were still a costume worn for the benefit of a waiter who was no longer there.

"The air gap is active," Freddie said, referencing the window. "The door is locked. The armor is... illogical."

"Agreed," Paige said, pulling her shirt over her head without hesitation. "I want to be comfortable."

They stripped. The pajamas joined the hoodies in the pile on the chair.

They stood there in the dim light of the hotel room, completely exposed.

Freddie looked at his sisters. He saw the curve of Jessica's hip. He saw the softness of Paige's stomach.

Suddenly, a line of code from the "Vanessa Database" flashed in his mind.

"You have to let go, Freddie. You're too controlled. I want to see your passion. I want you to take what you want."

He froze.

He had always thought she was warning him about his "sinful nature." But now, standing here in the quiet safety of the Unit, he ran the simulation again.

"She... she wanted it," Freddie whispered, his face twisting in revulsion.

"Wanted what?" Jessica asked, pausing as she folded back the duvet.

"The Wolf," Freddie said, his voice trembling with disgust. "She wasn't afraid I would lose control. She *wanted* me to lose control. To her."

He wrapped his arms around himself, feeling sick.

"She wanted me to look at her like she was... prey. She wanted the violence. She wanted the chaos."

He looked up at Jessica and Paige. He checked his internal sensors.

Heart rate: Steady. Intent: Protective. Desire: Safety.

There was no wolf here. There was no hunger. There was just... family.

"I am not a wolf," Freddie stated fiercely. "I do not want to consume. I want to build."

He reached out, grabbing both of them. He pulled them into a crushed, desperate hug. Skin against skin, three hearts beating in a close cluster.

He buried his face in Jessica's neck, his hand gripping Paige's shoulder.

"She was gross," Freddie whispered into the hug. "Her algorithm was corrupted. She wanted a beast, but I am just... a brother."

"You're just Freddie," Paige whispered back, squeezing him tight. "And that's all we ever want you to be."

"Safe," Freddie breathed, the disgust washing away, replaced by the warm, solid data of their presence. "This is safe. This is correct."

"Formation," Jessica murmured softly against his hair.

They broke the hug and climbed into the massive bed.

Freddie lay in the center. Jessica on his left. Paige on his right.

They pressed in tight, sealing the gaps. There was no static. No awkwardness. Just the transfer of heat and the reassuring pressure of contact.

Freddie closed his eyes. He felt Paige's breathing synchronize with his. He felt Jessica's arm drape over his chest, anchoring him to the mattress.

"Lights out," Jessica whispered, reaching over to click off the bedside lamp.

The room went pitch black.

"We fly at 0900," Freddie murmured into the darkness.

"We'll be ready," Paige promised.

Freddie drifted off, finally purging the last of Vanessa's "hostile code." He wasn't broken. He wasn't a monster in a cage. He was a system administrator, and his network was finally secure.

The Flight Home

Scene 1: The Final Bill

You could tell the quality of a hotel by its breakfast.

If it was a "motel" (like the ones they had avoided), breakfast was a sad table in the lobby with stale donuts and a dispenser of watery orange juice. If it was a "mid-range" hotel, it was a buffet with rubbery scrambled eggs and a waffle maker you had to operate yourself.

But this was **The Airport Grand**.

Here, breakfast wasn't free. It was a destination.

They sat in a booth upholstered in dark green velvet. The table was set with heavy linen napkins, silver forks that felt cold and substantial in the hand, and crystal water glasses. The air smelled of fresh-ground coffee and expensive bacon.

"This is correct," Freddie noted, unfolding his napkin and placing it across his lap. "The acoustics are dampened. The lighting is low. It is calm."

"It's expensive," Jessica corrected, looking at the menu. "Twelve dollars for eggs? That's highway robbery."

"It's 'Airport Pricing'," Paige said, scanning her own menu. "But we have the budget. Let's eat like kings before we get shoved into a metal tube for five hours."

A waiter in a white shirt and black vest approached the table with a silver coffee pot.

"Good morning," he said softly. "Coffee to start?"

"Please," Jessica said, turning her cup over.

"And for you, sir?" the waiter asked Freddie.

Freddie didn't hesitate. He had been denied his preferred liquid fuel for the entire trip because of Vanessa.

"Chocolate milk," Freddie ordered. "Large. No ice."

"Excellent choice," the waiter nodded.

When the glass arrived, it was tall, cold, and dark brown. Freddie took a long sip. It was thick, sweet, and coated his throat.

He remembered Vanessa watching him drink milk once at the university cafeteria. She had wrinkled her nose in disgust. *"Ugh, Freddie. It's mucus. It's for baby cows. It makes you soft."*

Freddie wiped a chocolate mustache from his lip.

"Vanessa was wrong," Freddie whispered. "Calcium is structural. Sugar is energy."

"She hated everything that made people happy," Paige noted, ordering her own stack of buttermilk pancakes.

"I am happy," Freddie decided.

He looked at the waiter. "I will have the Belgian Waffle. Two eggs, over easy. Bacon, crisp. And wheat toast. Dry."

"Wheat toast," the waiter wrote. "Not sourdough?"

"Never sourdough," Freddie and Paige said in unison.

The meal arrived on large, hot ceramic plates. It was efficient and delicious. Freddie cut his waffle into a precise grid, dipping each square into the syrup in a systematic pattern.

When they were finished, the waiter didn't bring a cash register receipt. He brought a leather folio.

Jessica opened it. She didn't reach for cash. She didn't reach for her wallet.

"Room 512," she said, uncapping a pen. She wrote the room number on the 'Charge to Room' line and signed her name with a flourish. *Jessica Avery.*

"Thank you, Ms. Avery," the waiter said, taking the folio. "It will be added to your final folio at checkout."

Freddie watched the transaction.

"That is... efficient," Freddie noted. "We eat now. We pay later. It consolidates the data into one final transaction."

"It's how business travelers do it," Jessica said, standing up. "And today, we are strictly business."

"Agreed," Freddie said, finishing the last of his chocolate milk.

He stood up, feeling full, caffeinated (via the sugar), and ready.

"Let's go checkout," Jessica said. "The shuttle leaves in thirty minutes."

They walked out of the quiet, velvet-lined restaurant and toward the front desk, ready to settle the account and close the file on Washington State.

Scene 2: The Departure Protocol

The lobby was busier now. Businessmen in suits were rolling jagged lines of black luggage toward the automatic doors. Flight crews were gathering near the elevators.

Jessica walked up to the high marble counter.

"Checking out of 512," she said, sliding the two plastic key cards across the surface. "Avery."

The clerk typed for a moment. The dot-matrix printer behind the desk whirred to life, spitting out a long strip of perforated paper.

"Here is your folio, Ms. Avery," the clerk said, tearing off the sheet and presenting it. "Room charge, tax, and the breakfast charge from this morning. The total is on the bottom."

Jessica scanned the numbers. It was a significant amount, especially with the "Airport Pricing" on the eggs, but she didn't flinch. She pulled out her personal credit card—the one backed by the trust fund Great Aunt Marge had left her. Marge had been a shrewd woman who believed in "mad money," and Jessica was more than happy to use it to secure her brother's safety.

"Approved," the clerk said after swiping it. "You're all set. The shuttle is loading now."

"Transaction complete," Freddie whispered, watching the paper receipt being folded into an envelope. "Debt settled."

They walked out into the cool, grey morning air. The white cutaway van was idling at the curb, its diesel engine clattering rhythmically.

The driver tossed their duffel bags into the rear luggage cage.

"All aboard!" he called out.

They climbed up the steps. The interior was the same as before—grey vinyl seats, 2x2 configuration, smelling of coffee and exhaust.

Paige moved toward the window seat on the left. She paused, looking at Freddie.

Freddie stood in the aisle, looking at the empty row on the right. He looked at Jessica. He felt heavy. The waffles, the eggs, the bacon, and the chocolate milk were sitting in his stomach like lead weights. Good weights. Ballast.

He didn't want to be alone in a seat. He wanted the absolute, immovable bedrock of his big sister.

"Jessica?" Freddie asked softly, gesturing to the seat next to hers. "Permission to... dock?"

Jessica smiled, a warm, genuine expression that softened the hard lines of her face.

"Permission granted," she said immediately. "Get in there."

"I'll take the solo watch," Paige said, hopping into the seat across the aisle. "I've got the perimeter."

Freddie sat down in the aisle seat. It was tight, but that was the point.

"Buckle up," Jessica said, clicking her lap belt.

Freddie clicked his. The van lurched forward, pulling away from the curb and merging into the airport loop traffic.

Freddie let out a long breath. He let his head drop to the right, landing heavily on Jessica's shoulder.

Jessica didn't stiffen. She shifted instantly, slumping slightly against the cold window to create a better angle for him. She lifted her left arm and wrapped it around his waist, her hand coming to rest flat against his stomach.

She felt the warmth of him through his hoodie. She felt the solid fullness of his belly, packed with the expensive breakfast she had gladly paid for.

"Status?" Jessica asked, her voice vibrating against his ear.

"Full," Freddie mumbled, closing his eyes. "Systems are... heavy. Safe."

He felt her hand squeeze his stomach gently—not a tickle, just pressure. It was a reassuring clamp. It said, *I have you. You are fed. You are mine.*

Across the aisle, Paige watched them. She saw her big sister acting like a shield, and her twin brother resting against her like a tired soldier.

A smirk tugged at the corner of Paige's mouth.

She thought about Vanessa. She thought about how possessive Vanessa had been, how she had hated it whenever Freddie showed affection to anyone else. Vanessa had wanted to be the *only* woman in Freddie's world. She had wanted to be the only source of comfort.

She had no idea, Paige thought, almost laughing out loud.

Vanessa's head would probably explode if she knew the truth. Back home in Virginia Beach, at Mom's house (Ellen's domain), there wasn't just Jessica and Paige. There was an entire battalion.

There were the younger twins, **Sarah** and **Jenna** (14), already chaos agents in their own right. There was **Harper** (11), zooming around in her wheelchair, always demanding Freddie listen to her music. And the babies, **Amanda** and **Elara** (9), who treated Freddie like a living jungle gym.

Seven sisters. Seven women who loved him, claimed him, and protected him.

Vanessa tried to compete with a harem, Paige thought, watching Jessica rub Freddie's arm soothingly. *She never stood a chance against the Avery girls.*

Then, another thought crossed Paige's mind as she watched the grey Washington landscape roll by.

"We're in his sector," Paige whispered, leaning across the aisle so only Jessica could hear.

Jessica's eyes narrowed slightly. She knew exactly who Paige meant.

Robert. Their father.

"Clark County," Jessica confirmed quietly. "Orchards. Just across the river from Portland."

"That's less than three hours south," Paige noted.

They both looked at Freddie. He was fast asleep on Jessica's shoulder, oblivious.

Their mother, Ellen, had finally divorced Robert in 2001. He had refused to work, refused to help with the kids, and refused to "better himself." He had drifted out here to the Pacific Northwest to start over, leaving the wreckage of his family behind.

"Did we. . . ?" Paige started.

"No," Jessica cut her off, her voice firm but low. "We didn't look him up. We didn't call. He is a deprecated system."

"Good," Paige nodded, looking out at the fir trees. "I don't miss him. And honestly? I'm glad we didn't waste a single mile of this trip on him."

"He made his choice," Jessica said, tightening her arm around Freddie's stomach. "He left. We stayed. We are the unit now."

"Sleep," Jessica commanded softly, resting her cheek against the top of Freddie's head, closing the file on their father just as easily as she had closed the hotel bill. "It's just a ten-minute ride. I'll wake you at the terminal."

"Affirmative," Freddie sighed in his sleep, sinking deeper into the embrace of the only family he would ever need.

Scene 3: The Gateway Protocol

The hotel shuttle hissed to a halt at the curb marked **GATEWAY AIRLINES**.

The sliding door opened, and the noise of the airport invaded the van. Whistles, shouting police officers, idling buses, and the roar of jets overhead.

"Armor up," Freddie whispered.

He pulled his hood up. He slid his black sunglasses onto his face. He reached into his pocket and jammed the foam earplugs deep into his canals. The world muffled instantly, turning from a scream into a dull roar.

"Let's move," Jessica said, grabbing his duffel bag.

They stepped out onto the sidewalk. The air smelled of jet fuel and exhaust.

Inside the terminal, the chaos was visual. Lines of people snaked around velvet ropes. Screens flashed red and yellow updates.

They approached the counter for **Gateway Airlines**. The signage was bright blue and gold.

"I need the Chariot," Freddie said, gripping the strap of his backpack until his knuckles turned white. Standing in this line was impossible. The floor felt like it was vibrating.

"I'm on it," Jessica said.

She walked up to the counter, bypassing the main queue by heading to the "Special Assistance" desk. The agent, a woman with kind eyes and a Gateway scarf, looked up.

"Checking in?" she asked.

"Three for Roanoke (ROA), connecting through Chicago (ORD)," Jessica said, handing over their IDs. "And we need a wheelchair request for my brother. He has Cerebral Palsy and is autistic. The standing and the noise are... not an option today."

"Not a problem at all," the agent typed quickly. "I'll tag him for 'WCHR'—that means he can walk to the seat, but needs distance assistance."

She looked at Freddie, who was standing slightly behind Paige, his hood pulled low, wearing sunglasses indoors.

"Is he okay?" the agent asked gently.

"He's shielding," Jessica explained clearly, making sure the security officer standing nearby could hear. "The hoodie and glasses cut the sensory input. He's not trying to hide; he's trying to cope."

"Understood," the agent smiled. "I'm printing your boarding passes now. You are marked 'Pre-Board.' That means you go down the jetway first. You can take any seat you want."

Freddie let out a breath he didn't know he was holding. Gateway's "Open Seating" policy was usually a source of anxiety for travelers, but for the Unit, it was a tactical advantage.

"The Sandwich is confirmed," Freddie whispered to Paige.

"What's the formation?" Paige asked, leaning in.

"Middle," Freddie stated firmly. "I want the middle seat. You on the window. Jessica on the aisle."

"You want the middle?" Paige clarified. "Usually people hate the middle."

"I need containment," Freddie explained, pressing his hands to his sides. "I need pressure from both sides. I want to be held."

"We can do that," Jessica promised, taking the boarding passes. "We'll lock you in."

A young man in a Gateway uniform arrived pushing a standard airport wheelchair—blue vinyl seat, heavy chrome frame.

"Ride for Avery?" the attendant asked.

"That's him," Jessica pointed.

Freddie sat down. The relief was instantaneous. His legs stopped trembling. He wasn't supporting his own weight anymore; the machine was doing it for him.

"I can push him," Jessica offered, reaching for the handles.

"Insurance says I gotta take him through the checkpoint," the attendant smiled. "But you ladies can be his wingmen."

"We're his sisters," Paige corrected, stepping to the side of the chair. "And we stick close."

"Let's roll," Freddie commanded from the chair.

He gripped the armrests. He thought about the connection in Chicago—**O'Hare (ORD)**. He had read the forums. It was the busiest airport in the world. It was a city of glass and steel, filled with millions of people running.

But he had the Chariot. He had the Pre-Board status. And in a few hours, he would be sandwiched between Jessica and Paige, pressurized and safe, cruising at 30,000 feet.

"Next stop, Chicago," Jessica said, patting his shoulder.

The convoy moved forward toward the security checkpoint, a small island of order in the sea of travelers.

Scene 4: The Checkpoint Protocol

The line for the metal detectors was a snake of stressed travelers, shedding belts and shoes like molting reptiles. The air was thick with the sound of plastic bins clattering on rollers and TSA agents shouting instructions.

"Laptops out! Shoes off! Jackets off! Empty your pockets!"

To Freddie, the commands were physical blows. *Bark. Bark. Bark.*

The Gateway attendant pushed Freddie's wheelchair to the "Special Assistance" lane, bypassing the main coil. Jessica and Paige flanked him closely, carrying the duffel bags.

They reached the conveyor belt. A TSA agent in a white shirt and blue trousers pointed at Freddie.

"He needs to walk through," the agent said, pointing to the magnetometer. "Can he stand?"

"He can stand," Jessica said, stepping forward to take charge of the bins. "But we need a minute. He has sensory processing issues."

"Just get him through," the agent said, waving a hand impatiently.

Jessica turned to Freddie. She knelt down so she was eye-level with him in the chair.

"Okay, Freddie," she said calmly, ignoring the chaos around them. "Protocol is 'Strip and Scan.' You have to take off the hoodie. You have to take off the shoes. You have to walk through the gate."

Freddie gripped the armrests. Take off the hoodie? That was his shell. Take off his shoes? The floor was cold. It was dirty.

"Exposure," Freddie whispered, trembling. "Unsafe."

"Ten seconds," Paige promised, leaning in on his other side. "I'll be right on the other side. I'll hold your hoodie. As soon as you step through, I'm putting it back on you. Ten seconds of cold, then back to warm."

Freddie looked at the grey archway. It was a portal.

"Execute," Freddie whispered.

He stood up. The wheelchair was taken away to be inspected.

Freddie unzipped his orange hoodie. He peeled it off, feeling the cold airport air hit his t-shirt. He felt naked. He kicked off his sneakers. He stepped onto the grey carpet in his socks.

He shuffled forward. He clutched his own elbows, trying to hold himself together without the compression of the sweatshirt.

He walked through the arch.

Silence. No beep.

"Clear," the agent grunted.

Paige was there instantly. She didn't wait for him to ask. She draped the orange hoodie over his shoulders like a blanket before he even fully cleared the checkpoint.

"Armor on," Paige whispered, guiding him to a metal bench.

Freddie jammed his arms into the sleeves and zipped it up to his chin. He pulled the hood up. He grabbed his shoes from the bin Jessica slid over.

“System rebooting,” Freddie muttered, jamming his feet back into the safety of his sneakers.

“You did good,” Jessica said, hoisting the heavy duffel bags back onto her shoulders. “We’re through. We’re airside. The hard part is over.”

The Gateway attendant returned with the wheelchair. “Ready to roll to C10?”

“One stop first,” Jessica said. “We need supplies.”

They rolled into the brightly lit convenience store near the concourse entrance. It smelled of glossy paper, peppermint, and expensive coffee.

“Target: Redundancy,” Jessica announced. “Gateway usually serves those little bags of dry roasted peanuts. Just salt. No flavor.”

“Risk assessment,” Freddie said from the chair, looking anxious. “I need the glaze. The plain ones are too dry. The texture is... like dust.”

“We know,” Paige said, squeezing his shoulder. “We aren’t risking a four-hour flight on airline peanuts. We’re getting the good stuff.”

Jessica grabbed a shopping basket.

“Pick,” she commanded.

Freddie scanned the rack of overpriced candy and snacks. He needed predictability.

“Honey Roasted Peanuts,” Freddie pointed to the rack. “The six-ounce bag. The sweet and salty glaze is essential.”

“Got it,” Jessica said, tossing the bag into the basket.

“Cheese crackers,” Freddie added, pointing to the familiar orange bag of fish-shaped snacks. “Baked. Uniform texture.”

“Pretzels,” Paige added, grabbing a bag of twists. “Salty. Good for nausea if the turbulence hits.”

“And chocolate,” Freddie added. “For dopamine.”

“Candy-coated chocolates,” Jessica decided, grabbing a King Size bag of the plain variety. “They don’t melt in your hand. No mess.”

She walked to the cooler.

She grabbed three 20-ounce bottles of cola.

“Why are we buying soda?” Paige asked, looking at the price tag. “They give us the whole can for free on Gateway.”

“Spill risk,” Jessica corrected. “On the plane, they pour it into a plastic cup with ice. It sits on the tray table. It vibrates. If it spills, Freddie is wet for four hours.”

She held up the bottle.

"Screw-top lid," Jessica said. "Sealed. Controlled. And it's cold *now*."

"Accepted," Freddie said, looking at the bottle. "Safety first."

"Aunt Marge is buying," Jessica said, marching to the counter.

She put the pile of "safe food" on the counter. The total was nearly thirty-five dollars. She swiped the card without hesitation.

"We are self-sufficient," Jessica told them, handing the heavy plastic bag to Freddie to hold in his lap. "We don't need to ask the flight attendant for anything. If we get stuck on the tarmac, we eat. If they only have plain peanuts, we have honey roasted."

"We are a closed loop," Freddie agreed, clutching the bag of crackers and the cold bottles.

"Okay," Jessica said, checking her watch. "Gate C10. Let's go get in position for the sandwich."

Scene 5: The Soundtrack Protocol

They were rolling past a duty-free shop when the vibration hit.

Through his foam earplugs, Freddie felt a rhythmic thumping. It wasn't the chaotic noise of the terminal; it was a beat. A specific, high-energy, synthesized bassline. *Thump-thump-thump-thump.*

He recognized the frequency.

"Halt," Freddie said, gripping the armrests.

"What's wrong?" Jessica asked, stopping the chair instantly. "Too crowded?"

"The audio," Freddie whispered.

He reached up and pulled the yellow foam plug out of his left ear.

The sound rushed in. It was coming from the overhead speakers of a trendy clothing store called *Urban Pulse*.

It was **"Strut Like a Man."**

But it wasn't the original 1960s version by **Vinnie & The Valiants**, with its high-pitched falsetto and doo-wop snapping.

It was the 1980s Hi-NRG cover by the drag superstar **Delight**.

The beat was relentless. The synthesizers were aggressive. And Delight's voice wasn't asking for permission—it was barking orders with a gravelly, powerful growl. The perspective wasn't first-person; she was telling a story about a man breaking free.

Freddie listened to the verse thundering through the store entrance:

"Oh how she tried to cut him down to size, Telling dirty lies to his friends. But he stood up taller, didn't let her bother, Said 'The world isn't coming to an end.' "

Freddie sat frozen. The data matched perfectly. Vanessa had tried to cut him down. She had tried to minimize him, to make him small, to isolate him from his "friends" (his sisters).

Then the chorus hit, an explosion of synthesized brass and drums:

"Strut like a man, talk like a man, Strut like a man, my son. No woman's worth crawling on the earth, So strut like a man, my son."

"She's singing about me," Freddie whispered.

"Who?" Paige asked, leaning in.

"Delight," Freddie said, nodding toward the speaker. "The lyrics are in the third person. She is observing the subject. The subject is leaving a toxic variable."

He listened as the bridge kicked in:

"Bye bye baby, I don't mean maybe, Gonna get along somehow. Soon she'll be crying on account of all her lying, Oh yeah just look who's laughing now. He's gonna strut like a man, Fast as he can, Strut like a man from you."

"Fast as he can," Freddie repeated, gripping the wheels of his chair. "He is escaping. He is walking away from 'Her'."

"That's exactly what you did," Jessica said, tapping her hand on the handle of the wheelchair in time with the beat. "You didn't crawl. You walked."

"I am rolling," Freddie corrected. "But the trajectory is the same."

A random file from Freddie's "Pop Culture Database" popped open as he watched the music video playing on a monitor in the window.

"Trivia," Freddie murmured, his eyes losing focus as he accessed the fact. "The character design for **Oceana the Sea Witch** in the movie *The Sea Princess* was based on Delight. The arch of the eyebrows. The body type. The confidence."

He paused, a shadow of sadness crossing his face.

"Delight never saw it," Freddie added softly. "He died of heart failure three weeks before the premiere. He never knew he became an animation icon."

He looked at the store one last time. The song was fading out.

"He'll tell the world 'Forget about it girl, I'd strut like a man from you.' "

"Forget about it, girl," Freddie whispered to the memory of Vanessa.

He took the yellow foam plug and rolled it between his fingers, compressing it into a tight cylinder. He jammed it back into his ear canal. He held it there for ten seconds until it expanded, sealing the world out again.

"Protocol complete," Freddie said, his voice muffled in his own head. "Let's go to the gate."

Jessica pushed the chair forward. Freddie sat a little taller, the bassline still thumping in his chest. He wasn't crawling on the earth for anyone. He was going home.

Scene 6: The Hub Dilemma

The waiting area for Flight 492 was a sea of humanity. The "open seating" policy meant that while the siblings had pre-board status, everyone else was jockeying for position in the dreaded *A, B,* and "C" boarding groups.

Freddie was parked near the podium, his wheelchair brakes locked. He was clutching the plastic bag from *Emerald City News*, his knuckles white around the neck of a plastic cola bottle.

To his right, two businessmen in grey suits were loudly discussing their itinerary.

"I don't know why they routed this flight into O'Hare," the taller one complained, snapping his newspaper. "It's a zoo. Midway is so much easier. You get off the plane and you're in a cab in ten minutes."

"Tell me about it," the other groaned. "O'Hare is a black hole. You land in one zip code and taxi to another. By the time we get to the gate, we could have driven to the Loop."

Paige, sitting on the metal bench next to Freddie, frowned. She looked at Jessica.

"Everyone keeps saying that," Paige whispered. "That Midway is the 'good' airport and O'Hare is the 'bad' one. Did we mess up?"

Jessica looked at the boarding passes in her hand. For a second, a flicker of doubt crossed her face. She hated inefficiency. If she had booked them into a logistical nightmare when an easier option existed, she would be furious with herself.

"Midway is smaller," Jessica admitted. "It's closer to the city. Less traffic."

Freddie turned his head. His sunglasses reflected the grey light of the tarmac.

"Irrelevant," Freddie stated, his voice muffled slightly by the high collar of his hoodie.

"How is it irrelevant?" Paige asked. "If we're walking into a 'black hole'?"

"The destination is not Chicago," Freddie corrected. "The destination is Roanoke (ROA)."

He tapped his temple, accessing the route map stored in his memory.

"Gateway Airlines does not fly between Midway and Roanoke," Freddie explained. "No carrier does. Roanoke is a regional spur. The only major hub that connects

to Roanoke is O'Hare."

He looked at the businessmen with a distinct lack of sympathy.

"They are terminating in Chicago," Freddie said. "For them, O'Hare is a bug. For us, it is a feature. It is the only door that opens to Virginia."

Jessica let out a sigh of relief. The logic held.

"You're right," she said, smoothing out the boarding passes. "We didn't have a choice. We have to slay the beast to get home."

"The beast is big," Freddie warned. "O'Hare has seven runways. It handles 2,700 operations per day. It is chaotic."

"But we have the Chariot," Paige reminded him, patting the armrest of the wheelchair. "And we have the Sandwich formation."

"And honey-roasted peanuts," Freddie added, clutching the bag of nuts tighter.

"Good morning, folks," the gate agent announced over the PA system. **"We are ready to begin pre-boarding for Gateway Flight 492 to Chicago O'Hare. We welcome any passengers needing special assistance or extra time down the jetway to board at this time."**

Jessica stood up. She grabbed the handles of the wheelchair.

"That's us," she said. "Ignore the grumbling. We're on the only path that leads home."

She released the brakes. They rolled past the businessmen, past the long lines of impatient travelers, and headed into the tunnel that would take them to the busiest machine on earth.

Scene 7: The Safety Protocol

The jet bridge was a ribbed tunnel of white metal, sloping downward. The air grew cooler with every foot they advanced, smelling of ozone and burnt kerosene.

Jessica pushed the wheelchair all the way to the aircraft door. A flight attendant with a perfectly pinned scarf stood there. Next to her was a narrow, strappy contraption that looked like a dolly with a seat cushion.

"Do you need the aisle chair to get to his seat?" the attendant asked efficiently.

Jessica looked at the "aisle chair"—a device designed to strap a person in like a piece of luggage and wheel them down the narrow path. She looked at Freddie. He was terrified, but he was mobile enough for this.

"Negative," Jessica said. "He can transfer. We'll walk him."

"Okay, take your time," the attendant smiled.

Freddie stood up. His legs were shaky, vibrating with the engine hum that resonated through the floor. He gripped Jessica's arm on one side and Paige's on the other. They shuffled into the cabin.

"Target acquisition," Freddie whispered, scanning the rows.

"Row 2," Jessica decided, pointing to the seats immediately behind the bulkhead wall. "First row with tray tables. Close to the exit."

They shuffled into the row. Paige slid into the window seat (2A). Freddie collapsed into the middle seat (2B). Jessica took the aisle seat (2C).

The formation was set. The Sandwich was active.

Freddie fumbled with the heavy silver buckle. *Click.* He pulled the strap tight across his lap. The seat was narrow, the upholstery scratchy, but the pressure of his sisters on both sides was instant and reassuring.

He let out a long, shuddering breath. He turned to his left, ready to initiate "Shutdown Mode." He leaned heavily against Paige, aiming to bury his face in her shoulder and close his eyes until the movement stopped.

"Emergency brake," Freddie murmured, his eyelids fluttering. "Going offline."

"Negative," Paige said gently.

She didn't push him away, but she placed a firm hand on his shoulder, keeping him upright.

"You have to stay online, Freddie. Just for ten minutes."

Freddie blinked, hurt. "Rejection?"

"Safety," Paige corrected. "This is your first flight. You need to be awake for the briefing. And you need to be alert for takeoff. Your body is going to feel g-forces it doesn't know how to interpret. If you're asleep when we hit 150 miles per hour, you'll panic."

"Physics?" Freddie asked, sitting up straighter.

"Physics," Paige confirmed. "Listen to the lady with the microphone. Watch the demo. Once the bell chimes—the *bing-bong* sound—then you can crash. I promise."

Freddie nodded. He fixed his eyes on the flight attendant standing at the front of the cabin. He watched her hold up the yellow oxygen mask. He watched her demonstrate the seatbelt. He filed every instruction into his "Survival Database."

Next to him, Paige was doing her best to look calm.

She gripped the armrest with her right hand, her knuckles turning white. She hated this.

She remembered the flight out two days ago—the terrifying hop from Roanoke to Nashville, then the long haul to Seattle. She remembered the way the plane

dropped in the air pockets over the Rockies. She remembered the feeling of having no ground beneath her feet, just empty air and trust in a machine she didn't understand.

She wanted to be on the ground. She wanted to be back in the living room in Christiansburg, with the solid slab foundation under her feet and the humidity sticking to the windows.

But she looked at Freddie. He was watching the safety demo with wide, terrified eyes behind his sunglasses. He needed a Safe Person, not a terrified sister.

Paige took a deep breath, unclenched her hand from the armrest, and placed it on Freddie's knee.

"We're okay," Paige lied, forcing a smile. "It's just a bus with wings."

"A bus that goes 500 miles per hour," Freddie corrected.

"Exactly," Paige said. "Fast travel. We'll be home before you know it."

The engines roared to life, a high-pitched whine that climbed in frequency. The plane lurched backward.

"Pushback," Freddie noted, his voice trembling.

"Here we go," Jessica said from the aisle, taking his other hand.

As the plane taxied to the runway, Paige looked out the window at the grey Washington sky. She hated the sky. But she loved her brother. And for him, she would ride this metal tube all the way to hell if she had to.

"Systems ready?" Paige asked, squeezing his knee.

"Ready," Freddie whispered, gripping her hand so hard it hurt. "Launch sequence initiated.

Scene 8: The Ascent Protocol

The aircraft turned onto the runway. The pilot didn't wait. He pushed the throttles forward, and the engines screamed.

Freddie felt the invisible hand of physics slam him back into Seat 2B. The g-forces were heavier than he expected—a crushing weight on his chest that made it hard to breathe.

He squeezed his eyes shut. He tried to lean left, to bury his face in Paige's shoulder immediately.

"Not yet," Paige said, her voice strained by the vibration. She gripped his hand tightly, but she kept her body upright, forcing him to stay centered. "Eyes open, Freddie. Process the data. You have to ride it out."

The nose of the plane lifted. The ground fell away. The sensation of "falling up" washed over them.

"Unnatural," Freddie gasped. "We are defying gravity."

"We are using lift," Jessica corrected from the aisle seat, her hand clamped over his right wrist. "It's just math."

The plane banked hard to the left, circling back over the Puget Sound. The grey water and green islands spun beneath them.

Then came the pressure.

As they climbed through 5,000 feet, the air density dropped rapidly. Freddie clawed at his ears.

"Internal error," Freddie winced, shaking his head. "My head is inflating. The pressure is unequal."

"It's the pressurization system catching up," Jessica explained calmly. "You need to equalize. Swallow."

"I can't," Freddie panicked. "It's stuck."

"Drink," Jessica commanded. She cracked the seal on one of the cola bottles she had bought. The hiss of escaping gas sounded loud in the quiet cabin. She handed it to him. "Take three big gulps. Force the swallow."

Freddie grabbed the bottle. He chugged the cold, sugary liquid. *Gulp. Gulp. Gulp.*

Pop.

His right ear cleared with a sharp crack. Then his left. The pain vanished, replaced by a dull, muffled hum.

"Equalized," Freddie breathed, lowering the bottle.

"Good," Paige said, watching the horizon tilt. "We're almost there."

"Time?" Freddie asked.

"We've been flying for six minutes," Jessica noted, checking her watch. "We just passed 8,000 feet. The first milestone is 10,000."

"Four more minutes?" Freddie asked, doing the math.

"Roughly," Jessica nodded. "Depending on air traffic."

The plane punched through the thick layer of grey clouds. Suddenly, the cabin was flooded with brilliant, blinding sunlight. They were above the weather. The ride smoothed out instantly.

Bing-Bong.

The chime echoed through the cabin. The overhead sign flashed, but the "Fasten Seatbelt" light stayed illuminated.

"Ladies and gentlemen," the pilot announced. "We have reached 10,000 feet. You may now use approved electronic devices. However, we ask that you keep your seatbelts fastened while we continue our climb to our cruising altitude of 35,000 feet, which should take another fifteen minutes."

Freddie looked at Paige.

"The bell," Freddie whispered. "The bell rang."

"Permission granted," Paige smiled softly, lifting her arm. "Engage the emergency brake."

Freddie didn't hesitate. He collapsed.

He slumped to his left, dropping his heavy head onto Paige's shoulder. He curled his legs up as much as the tight pitch would allow. He let all the tension—the terror of the checkpoint, the noise of the terminal, the g-forces of the climb—drain out of his muscles.

"System... shutdown," Freddie mumbled.

Paige wrapped her arm around him, pulling him in tight. She rested her chin on the top of his head, smelling the faint scent of the hotel shampoo and the airport air.

She felt him shake slightly. A single, hot tear leaked from Freddie's closed eye, soaking into the fabric of her t-shirt.

It wasn't a tear of pain. It was a tear of absolute, overwhelming gratitude. He wasn't alone in the sky. He wasn't being told to "man up" or "stop acting like a child." He was being held.

"I've got you," Paige whispered, pressing a kiss to his hair. "I'm right here. I'm not going anywhere."

Across the aisle, passengers began clicking their seatbelts open to stretch or reach for bags.

"Stay buckled," Jessica ordered quietly, tightening her own strap. "We are still climbing. The air is thin. Turbulence is unpredictable."

"Confirmed," Freddie whispered into Paige's shirt. "Strap stays on. Anchor is secure."

"Just sleep, Freddie," Paige soothed, rubbing his arm. "We have fifteen minutes until we level off, and three hours after that. I'll wake you when we see Chicago."

Freddie let the darkness take him, safe in the sandwich, hurtling toward Virginia at 500 miles per hour, held by the sacred vow of a sister who would never let him fall.

Scene 9: The Mid-Air Transfer

The cabin was quiet, save for the steady, white-noise roar of the engines. Outside the scratched plastic window, the sky was a deep, impossible blue, and the clouds were a solid floor of white cotton thousands of feet below.

In Seat 2B, the "Emergency Brake" was still fully engaged.

Freddie was dead weight. He was slumped entirely to the left, his head buried in the crook of Paige's neck, his legs curled up, his breathing slow and rhythmic.

Paige was grimacing. She was staring straight ahead at the fabric of the seatback in front of her, trying to ignore the fact that she couldn't feel her left arm below the elbow.

"Paige," Jessica whispered from the aisle seat. "Switch. Your hand is purple."

"Negative," Paige whispered back, barely moving her lips. "If we move him, he resets. You know the protocol. Once the anchor is down, you don't drag the ship."

"He's cutting off your circulation," Jessica pointed out.

"I have a right arm," Paige countered. "I'm fine."

At the front of the cabin, the metal cart rattled. The flight attendants were moving down the aisle.

"Beverage and snack service," the attendant chirped.

Jessica lowered her tray table. "We'll take three waters, please. And the snacks."

"Sure thing," the attendant smiled, handing over three clear plastic cups (which Jessica accepted, knowing she would drink them quickly to avoid spills) and three small foil packets.

Jessica picked up one of the packets. She held it up for Paige to see.

Roasted Peanuts. Ingredients: Peanuts, Salt.

Paige smirked, though it looked more like a wince of pain. "Vindication," she whispered. "No honey. Just dust."

"Good call on the stash," Jessica admitted, tucking the airline peanuts into the seat pocket for emergency reserves.

She reached into the bag from the airport newsstand and pulled out the bag of Honey Roasted Peanuts. She tore the corner open. The smell of sweet glaze wafted up—a familiar, safe scent.

Freddie stirred. The smell had penetrated his shutdown mode. He didn't open his eyes, but his mouth opened slightly, like a baby bird.

"Hunger detected," Jessica noted.

"He can't feed himself," Paige said softly. "His hands are trapped under the blanket. If he moves them, he wakes up."

"I've got it," Jessica said.

She poured a small handful of the sticky, sweet peanuts into her palm. She reached over Freddie's slumbering form.

"Open," she commanded softly.

Freddie complied. Jessica placed two peanuts on his tongue. He chewed slowly, his eyes still squeezed shut behind the sunglasses.

"Water," Jessica whispered.

She held the bottle of cola (the one with the screw top) to his lips. He took a sip.

"More peanuts," Freddie mumbled.

Jessica fed him again. It was a slow, rhythmic process. *Peanuts. Chew. Cola. Swallow.* It was intimate and necessary. He was fueling the machine without engaging the conscious mind.

Then, gravity took over.

As Freddie leaned forward slightly to accept the next peanut from Jessica's hand, the plane banked gently to the right to correct its course.

Freddie's center of gravity shifted. He didn't return to Paige's shoulder. Instead, he slumped heavily to the right, collapsing against Jessica.

His head landed on her shoulder. His heavy orange-clad arm flopped across her lap.

Paige let out a sharp gasp as the blood rushed back into her dead arm. She began shaking her left hand violently, grimacing as the "pins and needles" firework show started.

"Oh god," Paige hissed, rubbing her elbow. "It stings."

"My turn," Jessica said calmly.

She adjusted her position, wrapping her left arm around Freddie's shoulders to secure him. She felt the weight of him instantly—the solid, dense reality of her brother.

He was heavy. He was warm. And he was safe.

Jessica leaned her cheek against the top of his hood. She didn't mind the weight. In fact, she welcomed it. For the last 48 hours, she had been the General. She had been the Logistics Officer, the Bank, and the Enforcer. She had been carrying the *mental* weight of the entire rescue mission.

Now, she was just carrying the *physical* weight. And compared to the fear of losing him to Vanessa, a numb arm was a price she would gladly pay.

She looked at her watch. **1:45 PM (CST).**

"Status?" Paige asked, finally getting feeling back in her fingers.

"We have about forty minutes at cruise," Jessica calculated. "Then twenty minutes for descent and approach."

"And then?" Paige asked.

"And then O'Hare," Jessica said, her eyes narrowing slightly.

She was already visualizing the map of Chicago O'Hare. They would land at Concourse C (Gateway's hub). To get to the regional jet for Roanoke, they would likely have to transfer to Concourse B.

That meant **The Tunnel**.

Jessica knew about the tunnel. It was an underground passage connecting the concourses. It was famous for its neon light show—rainbow tubes of gas pulsating on the ceiling and walls—and the long moving walkways.

For a tourist, it was cool. For an autistic person in sensory shutdown, it was either going to be a nightmare or a hypnotic trance.

"We have an obstacle on the ground," Jessica told Paige quietly, stroking Freddie's arm. "The connector tunnel. It's loud. It has flashing lights. We need to be ready to shield him."

"We'll sandwich him," Paige promised. "Hood up. Glasses on. Eyes down."

"Agreed," Jessica said.

She felt a tingle in her left fingers. Her arm was starting to fall asleep.

She didn't move. She just held him tighter, watching the clouds go by, counting down the minutes until they could get him onto the ground and one step closer to the quiet, green safety of the New River Valley.

Scene 10: The Descent Protocol

The cabin chime sounded. *Bing-Bong.*

"Flight attendants, prepare for arrival."

Jessica looked out the window. The white floor of clouds had broken apart, revealing the flat, grey-green grid of the Midwest. To the east, the massive expanse of Lake Michigan looked like an ocean.

She tried to move her left arm. Nothing happened. It was a dead weight, pinned beneath Freddie's chest.

"Freddie," Jessica whispered, leaning her head down to his ear. "Reboot. We are entering the pattern."

Freddie didn't move. He was deep in the void.

"Freddie," she said, louder this time. She used her right hand to gently shake his shoulder. "Systems online. Now."

Freddie gasped, his body jerking awake. He sat up abruptly, pulling away from the warmth of her shoulder.

"Status?" he panicked, looking around wildly behind his dark glasses.

"Descent," Jessica said, grimacing as the blood rushed back into her left arm. It felt like fire ants were marching from her shoulder to her fingertips. She cradled the limb against her chest, trying to massage life back into it.

"Your arm," Freddie noticed, seeing her wince. "Damage report?"

"Just asleep," Jessica promised, biting her lip. "Pins and needles. It means you were safe. It's a fair trade."

"Look," Paige said, pointing out the window to distract him. "Lake Michigan. It's huge."

Freddie looked. The water was choppy and grey.

"It looks cold," Freddie assessed.

"It's Chicago," Paige said. "It's always cold."

The plane banked sharply. The landing gear dropped with a heavy *thud-clunk* that vibrated through the floor. The wind noise increased to a roar.

"Prepare for impact," Freddie whispered, gripping the armrests.

"Not impact," Jessica corrected, flexing her tingling fingers. "Arrival."

The plane flared over the runway. The tires kissed the concrete—a screech, a bump—and then the roar of the reverse thrusters threw them forward against their seatbelts.

"Braking," Freddie recited. "Decelerating. Runway confirmed."

The plane slowed to a taxi speed, exiting the runway and joining the long conga line of aircraft moving toward the terminal.

The seatbelt sign pinged off. instantly, the cabin erupted in the sound of clicking buckles and overhead bins slamming open.

"Hold," Jessica commanded. "We wait."

They sat in Row 2 while the river of passengers flowed past them. Freddie kept his head down, hood up, waiting for the aisle to clear.

Finally, the flight attendant waved at them. “Wheelchair is right at the door, folks.”

“Let’s move,” Jessica said.

She stood up, but her left hand was still clumsy, the sensation not fully returned. She reached for Freddie’s bag, but her grip was weak.

“I’ve got the heavy stuff,” Paige said, grabbing both duffel bags and slinging them over her shoulders. “You just guide him.”

“Okay, Freddie,” Jessica said. “Can you walk to the door?”

“Affirmative,” Freddie said.

He stood up. His legs were stiff from three hours of being folded. He wobbled.

Jessica reached out with her good right arm to steady him. Paige used her hip to guide him from behind.

They walked the ten feet to the aircraft door. The cold air of the jet bridge hit them—that distinct Chicago smell of damp concrete and diesel.

The wheelchair was waiting. It was a wide, heavy-duty airport model with a “Stowell” logo on the back.

Freddie sat down.

It was instant relief. The moment his weight hit the vinyl seat, the “Emergency Brake” re-engaged. He wasn’t asleep, but he was safely contained. He pulled his legs up onto the footrests. He pulled his hood down tight. He checked his earplugs.

“Armor check,” Freddie muttered. “Secure.”

“I’m driving,” Paige announced, stepping behind the chair. “Jessica, your arm is still twitching. You fly point.”

“Copy,” Jessica said, shaking her hand out one last time. “We need to get to Concourse C for the connection. That means we have to go under the tarmac.”

“The tunnel,” Freddie whispered from inside the hood.

“We’ll be quick,” Jessica promised. “Eyes down. Focus on the floor.”

They moved up the jet bridge and into the terminal.

O’Hare was an assault. It was louder, brighter, and faster than Seattle. The ceilings were low in this part of the concourse, amplifying the noise of thousands of people.

Jessica led the way, cutting a path through the crowd like an icebreaker. Paige pushed the chair close behind, keeping Freddie in her slipstream.

They reached the central rotunda. In the middle of the chaos was a set of wide, stainless-steel elevators marked **“To Concourse C / Baggage Claim.”**

Jessica hit the down button.

"Here we go," she warned Freddie as the doors slid open. "Next stop: The Light Show."

They rolled into the elevator car. The doors closed, cutting off the terminal noise for a brief, merciful second before they began the descent into the underground.

Scene 11: The Neon Horizon

The elevator doors slid open.

They didn't step into a hallway. They stepped into a computer chip.

The connector tunnel between Concourse B and Concourse C was unlike anything else in the airport. The ceiling was low and curved, lined with hundreds of feet of mirrored panels and neon tubes.

As they rolled out of the elevator, the lights flared—electric blue, turning to violet, turning to hot pink.

And there was music. It wasn't a song; it was a synthesized, ambient hum that seemed to vibrate the very air. *Woom-woom-woom-woom.*

"Sensory warning," Jessica said, her voice echoing off the glass walls. "It's intense."

"I see it," Freddie whispered.

He looked up from under his hood. Even through his dark sunglasses, the colors were vivid. To a neurotypical person, it was a cool art installation. To Freddie, it was a raw data stream.

Blue. 4 seconds. Fade. Magenta. 3 seconds. Pulse. Sound frequency 440Hz shifting to 432Hz.

He couldn't just "watch" it. His brain tried to **solve** it. He tried to find the algorithm that controlled the chaos.

"Let's take the ride," Paige said.

She pushed the wheelchair onto the first moving walkway. It was a horizontal escalator—a continuous track of grooved metal plates.

Clack-clack-clack.

The wheels of the chair hit the metal pallets, vibrating instantly. The sound was mechanical and grinding, a sharp contrast to the smooth synth music above.

To their left, another metal track carried passengers the same direction. To their right, two lanes of traffic moved against them, faces illuminated by the neon glow.

Freddie gripped the armrests. His head snapped back and forth.

"The sequence is irregular," Freddie panicked, his breathing speeding up. "Blue doesn't always follow Teal. There is a random number generator. I can't... I can't predict the next photon."

He was hyperventilating. The sheer volume of variable data was crashing his processor. The music was syncing with the lights in a way that felt like it was physically touching his skin.

"He's looping," Paige said, seeing his hands flapping slightly inside his sleeves. "He's trying to decode the wall."

"Block him," Jessica commanded.

Jessica, who was standing beside the chair, stepped directly in front of it. She planted her sneakers on the grooved metal plates, facing forward.

She was a wall of denim and cotton.

"Eyes on me, Freddie," she said, her voice cutting through the synth music and the mechanical rumble of the floor. "Look at my shirt. Look at my hair. Ignore the perimeter."

Freddie stared at the back of Jessica's white t-shirt. It was a solid, non-glowing object. It was static. It was safe.

"Focus locked," Freddie wheezed, squeezing his eyes shut for a second to reset.

They reached the end of the first span. The metal plates disappeared under the comb teeth at the end of the track.

Ka-clunk. The wheelchair rolled off the track and onto the tiled floor.

They had to walk twenty feet to the next set of walkways. The neon ceiling above them pulsed a deep, angry red.

"Halfway," Jessica said, checking Freddie. He was sweating. The humidity in the tunnel was higher than the concourse. "We need to clear this sector. He's overheating."

"New tactic," Paige decided. "We don't ride. We run."

"On the plates?" Jessica asked.

"Speed multiplier," Paige confirmed. "If I push him *on* the track, we move at double velocity. We get out in half the time."

"Do it," Jessica said.

They approached the second span.

Paige hit the metal walkway at a jog. She shoved the heavy wheelchair onto the moving plates, but she didn't stop walking. She kept her legs pumping, her sneakers thudding against the metal slats, pushing the chair forward relative to the track.

"Moving!" Paige shouted to a businessman standing on the right. "On your left!"

Jessica sprinted ahead, clearing the path.

"Make a hole!" Jessica called out, her voice authoritative. "Medical transport coming through!"

Freddie felt the wind pick up. The vibration of the metal plates buzzed through the frame of the chair. The neon lights smeared into streaks of color—blue-green-yellow—blurring into a single line of light.

He didn't try to decode it anymore. It was moving too fast.

"Warp speed," Freddie whispered, clutching his chest.

He kept his eyes glued to Jessica, who was jogging backward now, five feet in front of him, making sure no one stepped into their path.

"Almost there," Jessica yelled over the increasing volume of the music. "I see the elevators!"

The end of the tunnel loomed. The neon stopped. The ceiling turned to boring, beautiful white tile.

"Brakes!" Paige yelled.

She hauled back on the wheelchair handles.

Ka-clunk.

They flew off the end of the metal track, the wheels hitting the tile with a skid. They carried enough momentum to roll straight across the lobby.

Jessica slammed her hand against the "Up" button for the elevator.

The doors opened instantly, as if the building knew they needed sanctuary.

They rolled inside. The doors slid shut, cutting off the neon glare and the wailing synthesizer.

The silence in the elevator was heavy.

Freddie pulled his hood down slightly. He was trembling, but he was intact.

"Algorithm... unsolved," Freddie gasped.

"It doesn't matter," Paige said, leaning against the elevator wall, breathing hard. "We beat the level."

Jessica hit the button for the Concourse Level.

"Next stop: The Gate," she said. "And actual air."

The elevator began to rise, lifting them out of the underworld and toward the final plane that would take them home.

Scene 12: The Refueling Protocol

The elevator doors opened with a polite chime.

They stepped out into Concourse C. The contrast was jarring. The neon madness and throbbing bass of the tunnel were gone, replaced by the mundane, grey-carpeted reality of the terminal. It smelled of floor wax and grease.

"Reality restored," Freddie breathed, pulling his hood down just enough to see his periphery.

"That was intense," Paige admitted, wiping a bead of sweat from her forehead. "I felt like we were inside a pinball machine."

"We need to re-calibrate," Jessica said, looking at the departure board. "The flight to Roanoke is at Gate C4. We have an hour. We need real food. The peanuts were just a patch."

They scanned the food court options. There were the usual fast-food suspects, but the lines were long and chaotic. Jessica pointed to a sit-down restaurant with dark wood paneling and a view of the tarmac called **The Lakeshore Grill**.

"Booths," Jessica noted. "High backs. Sound dampening. Let's go."

They rolled the wheelchair to the hostess stand. The restaurant was busy, but Jessica's "General" energy got them a corner booth in the back, away from the clattering kitchen doors.

Freddie slid into the booth next to Paige. The vinyl was cool and cracked with age. He took off his sunglasses for the first time in hours, blinking in the dim light.

A waitress in a striped apron appeared, tossing coasters onto the table. "What can I get you folks started with?"

"Three ice waters," Jessica said immediately. "And we're ready to order."

She didn't need to look at the menu. She knew the "Safe Foods" protocol by heart.

"For him and her," Jessica said, gesturing to the twins. "The Club Sandwich. Turkey, ham, bacon. But listen carefully: **No onions. No tomatoes.**"

"No garden?" the waitress clarified, scribbling on her pad.

"Lettuce is acceptable if it is crisp," Freddie added quietly. "But tomatoes compromise the structural integrity of the toasted bread. They create moisture pockets."

"No tomatoes, got it," the waitress nodded, not batting an eye. "And for you?"

"The Cheeseburger," Jessica said. "Cheddar. Medium-well. And a basket of fries for the table. Extra crispy if you can."

"You got it. Be right out."

When the food arrived ten minutes later, it was a masterpiece of beige predictability.

The club sandwiches were cut into perfect triangles, held together by frilled toothpicks. The toast was golden brown. There wasn't a red, soggy tomato slice in sight.

Freddie pulled the toothpicks out one by one, lining them up on the table.

"Inspection complete," Freddie announced. "Safe to consume."

He took a bite. It was crunchy, salty, and dry. It was exactly what his nervous system needed after the neon assault of the tunnel.

Paige ate her half of the sandwich with equal enthusiasm. "Oh my god," she mumbled around a mouthful of bacon. "Real food. I thought I was going to survive on peanuts forever."

Jessica attacked her burger. It was greasy and heavy, grounding her.

They ate in silence for a few minutes, the only sound the clinking of ice in their water glasses and the distant roar of jets taking off outside the window.

"We did it," Paige said, dipping a fry into a puddle of ketchup. "We crossed the country. We navigated the biggest airport in the world. We survived the tunnel."

"One leg left," Jessica reminded them, wiping her hands on a napkin. "The hop to Roanoke. It's short. Less than ninety minutes."

"And then?" Freddie asked, looking up from his sandwich.

"And then Mom's house," Jessica said. "The minivan. The New River Valley. Quiet."

Freddie nodded. He took a long sip of water.

"I am ready for 'Quiet'," he decided.

Jessica signaled for the check. She paid quickly—Aunt Marge's credit card taking one last hit for the team.

"Let's move," Jessica said, standing up. "Gate C4. It's time to bring you home."

They gathered their bags. Freddie settled back into the wheelchair, feeling full and heavy. The panic of the morning felt distant now. He had fuel. He had his sisters. And the departure board showed the one word he had been waiting to see for weeks: **ROANOKE - ON TIME.**

Scene 13: The Propeller Protocol

The gate for the Roanoke flight wasn't a gate. It was a door that led to the concrete.

"Gateway Express Flight 104 service to Roanoke," the agent announced. "This is a prop service. Any carry-on bags that do not fit under the seat must be pink-tagged and left on the cart."

Freddie looked out the window. The plane was small. It had high wings and two massive, six-bladed propellers hanging off them.

"Turboprop," Freddie identified. "ATR-72 or similar variant. 2-by-2 configuration. It's loud."

"It's a puddle jumper," Jessica corrected, grabbing the pink tags for their duffels. "But it gets us there."

Because there was no jet bridge, the boarding process for a wheelchair was different. A large white truck with a scissor-lift box on the back—known as an **Ambulift**—pulled up to the side of the plane.

"Your chariot awaits," the ramp agent said, guiding Freddie's wheelchair away from the stairs the other passengers were using and toward the truck.

They rolled onto the lift platform. The doors hissed shut.

Whirrrrrrrr.

The hydraulics engaged. The entire box lifted straight up, rising ten feet into the air until it aligned perfectly with the aircraft's rear door.

"Vertical integration," Freddie noted, enjoying the mechanical precision of it.

The door opened, and they rolled directly into the cabin. It was tight. The ceiling was low—Freddie would have had to duck if he were standing.

"Row 8," Jessica directed. "Right over the wing."

The configuration was 2x2. Freddie slid into the window seat (8A), looking directly at the engine nacelle. Paige took the aisle seat (8B). Jessica sat across the narrow aisle in 8C.

"Propellers mean vibration," Freddie warned as he buckled the seatbelt. "It will be a different frequency than the jet."

"We can handle it," Paige said, yawning. She looked exhausted. The adrenaline of the tunnel run was fading, leaving her drained.

The engines kicked over. *Whine-CHUG-CHUG-CHUG-ROAR.*

The blades spun into a blur. The cabin filled with a steady, rhythmic thrumming that rattled the plastic window shade.

"Harmonic resonance," Freddie murmured, feeling it in his teeth. It wasn't unpleasant; it was just... present.

The plane taxied quickly and sprinted down the runway. Unlike the heavy 757, the turboprop leaped into the air. They banked hard, aiming southeast toward the Appalachian Mountains.

As soon as they leveled off, the vibration settled into a white-noise drone.

Paige shifted in her seat. She tried to lean against the aisle armrest, but it was hard and uncomfortable. She looked at Freddie.

He was staring out the window, watching the prop spin. He looked stable. He looked... okay.

"Freddie?" Paige asked softly.

"Status?" Freddie asked, turning to her.

"Can I...?" Paige gestured to his shoulder. "I'm crashing. I need to dock."

Freddie blinked. Usually, he was the one asking for the anchor. He was the one who needed the pressure. But looking at his twin sister, he saw the dark circles under her eyes. She had fought the TSA, the crowds, and the Tunnel for him.

He lifted the armrest between them.

"Permission granted," Freddie said gently. "Initiate docking."

Paige let out a sigh that was half-laugh, half-sob. She curled up, leaning heavily into him. She tucked her head into the crook of his neck, her arm looping through his.

Freddie stiffened for a microsecond, then relaxed. He leaned his head against hers, resting his cheek on her hair.

He felt strong. For the first time in days, he wasn't the burden. He was the support. He was the wall she could lean on.

"I've got you," Freddie whispered, repeating the words she had said to him on the ascent.

"Thanks, brother," Paige mumbled, her eyes already closing. "Wake me when we see the Star."

Across the aisle, Jessica watched them. She saw Freddie sitting up straighter, taking his job as "The Pillow" seriously. She saw Paige finally letting her guard down.

Jessica smiled, leaning her head back against her own seat. The propellers droned on, carrying the three of them over the Ohio Valley, closer and closer to the green hills of home.

Scene 14: The Valley Protocol

The pitch of the propellers changed. The steady drone shifted to a higher, biting whine as the blades bit into the thicker air of the Blue Ridge Mountains.

"Wake up," Freddie whispered, nudging Paige's head gently with his own. "We are crossing the ridge."

Paige blinked awake, pulling her arm back from Freddie's grasp. She rubbed her eyes, looking out the scratched plexiglass window.

Below them, the world had changed. The flat, grey grid of Chicago was gone. In its place was the rolling, deep green ocean of the Appalachian Mountains.

"Home," Paige breathed, pressing her hand against the plastic.

Freddie leaned forward, his nose almost touching the window. He wasn't looking for the mountains. He was looking for the infrastructure.

He scanned the valley floor. And then, he saw it.

A long, grey ribbon of asphalt cutting through the green, packed bumper-to-bumper with 18-wheelers. **Interstate 81.**

"The Artery," Freddie announced, a massive smile breaking across his face. "Look at the volume. That is a heavy freight day. Look at the spacing. It's beautiful."

He watched the trucks—tiny white rectangles from this height—moving in their relentless, logical supply chain. He had thought he would never see them again. He thought he was trapped in Washington forever. But there they were, hauling cargo north to New York and south to Tennessee, right through his backyard.

"I missed the trucks," Freddie admitted, his voice thick with emotion.

"I know you did," Jessica smiled from across the aisle.

The plane banked hard to the left, circling the "bowl" of the valley to line up with Runway 33.

As the wing dipped, the view opened up to **Mill Mountain**.

Standing proud on the summit, white steel against the dark green trees, was the **Roanoke Star**.

It wasn't illuminated yet—the sun was still low in the western sky, casting long shadows over the valley—but the massive white star structure was unmistakable. It stood watch over the city like a guardian.

"Visual confirmation," Freddie reported, pointing a trembling finger. "The Star. It is present. We are in the correct sector."

"We're home, Freddie," Paige said, reaching over to squeeze his hand. "We actually made it."

The turboprop dropped lower. They flew over the familiar landmarks—the mall, the car dealerships on Williamson Road, the train tracks.

Thump-squeak.

The wheels hit the Virginia tarmac. It wasn't the smooth, endless concrete of O'Hare. It was rougher, shorter, and felt like a handshake.

The propellers roared into reverse, slowing them down before they ran out of runway. The plane turned off the active strip and taxied toward the small, brick terminal.

It was quiet here. There were no lines of jets waiting to take off. There was just the mountains, the evening light, and the smell of honeysuckle and diesel fuel that seeped into the cabin as the engines wound down.

"Welcome to Roanoke," the flight attendant announced, her voice sounding tired but friendly. "Local time is 7:15 PM. Please stay seated until the prop has come to a complete stop."

Freddie unbuckled his seatbelt the second the light turned off.

"Mission Status," Freddie declared, looking at his sisters.

"Mission Accomplished," Jessica said, unbuckling her own belt.

Paige let out a long, satisfied sigh, stretching her legs. She was thinking about the parking lot.

"Long Term A," Paige said, smiling at the thought. "The Sanctuary is waiting. And thank God for that."

She flexed her left foot, imagining the clutch pedal. After days of riding in shuttles, airplanes, and that horrible automatic rental car in Seattle (the "slushbox," as she called it, where the gears changed with the enthusiasm of a wet sponge), she was desperate for control.

"I'm driving," Paige announced firmly. "I need to feel a real transmission. I need to shift gears myself."

"Agreed," Jessica said, grabbing her bag. "Get us to the car. Get us home."

Scene 15: The Final Mile

The air in the parking lot was heavy, humid, and smelled like damp earth. To Freddie, it smelled like victory.

They had retrieved their duffel bags from the carousel—which had taken all of five minutes, given the small size of the airport—and returned the wheelchair to the attendant near the sliding doors. Freddie was walking on his own now. He was tired, his legs felt like jelly, but the ground beneath his feet was Virginian asphalt.

He stopped in front of the car.

It was a dark green **Takara Sanctuary**. A sensible, reliable family sedan. But to Paige, it was a chariot of precision.

"Hello, beautiful," Paige whispered, patting the hood.

She unlocked the doors.

"Shotgun," Freddie called out instantly, grabbing the handle of the front passenger door.

"Accepted," Jessica said, tossing her bag into the trunk. "I'll take the Executive Suite in the back. I'm off duty."

Paige slid into the driver's seat. She didn't just sit; she docked. She adjusted the mirror. She depressed the clutch pedal with her left foot—a firm, mechanical resistance that felt a thousand times better than the mushy rental car pedal in Seattle.

She reached for the gearshift. It was a 5-speed manual stick rising from the center console. She wiggled it in neutral. *Left-right. Left-right.*

"System check," Paige smiled, the tension of the flight melting away. "Transmission is manual. Driver is in control."

"Engage," Freddie commanded, buckling his seatbelt.

Paige turned the key. The engine purred to life. She shifted into first gear, eased off the clutch, and felt the car bite the pavement. They rolled out of the lot, paid the ticket (Aunt Marge again), and merged onto the access road.

They merged from the city spur onto the main artery. **Interstate 81.**

It was a river of steel. The sun was setting behind the mountains, casting long purple shadows, but the highway was alive.

"Traffic report," Freddie announced, staring out the windshield. "Volume is high. Flow is continuous. Zero accidents reported."

He watched a massive tractor-trailer roar past them in the left lane, its diesel stack puffing a small cloud of black smoke.

"Look at the torque," Freddie marveled. "Hauling 80,000 pounds uphill."

"It's a beautiful sight," Jessica agreed from the back seat, leaning her head against the window.

Paige downshifted to fourth to pass a slow-moving minivan, revving the engine slightly. She felt connected to the road. No autopilot. No turbulence. Just gears and tires.

They cruised south, passing the Salem exit, then the climb up Christiansburg Mountain. The truck lane was packed with heavy haulers grinding their way up the grade, hazard lights flashing.

Freddie counted them. "One. Two. Three. Four... Big rigs. All of them."

They crested the hill. The New River Valley opened up before them.

"Exit 114," Paige said, flipping her turn signal. "Descending."

They took the off-ramp, swinging onto Route 8. The highway noise faded, replaced by the slower rhythm of town driving. They passed the fast-food joints, the gas stations, and the familiar brick buildings of Christiansburg.

They turned left. Then right.

The street sign flashed in the headlights: **Pepper Street SE**.

"Target acquired," Freddie whispered.

Paige slowed down. She pulled up to the curb in front of a modest house. It was dark. The porch light was off because they hadn't been there to flip the switch in days. It looked quiet. It looked empty. It looked safe.

"We're here," Paige said, shifting into neutral and pulling the handbrake. *Click-click-click.*

The engine idled for a second.

"Home," Freddie said.

He didn't wait. He unbuckled his seatbelt and opened the door. He stepped out onto the sidewalk. He listened.

He didn't hear sirens. He didn't hear Vanessa calling him a project. He didn't hear his mother criticizing him for wanting a wheelchair or judging them for needing to sleep in a pile to feel safe.

He heard crickets. He heard the distant hum of I-81. He heard the wind in the trees.

"The audio profile," Freddie said, closing his eyes and taking a deep breath of the cool evening air. "It is quiet. It is ours."

"It's perfect," Jessica said, stepping out of the back seat and stretching. "No judges. No juries. Just us."

They stood there for a moment, the three of them, looking at the house. This was the one place where the "rules" didn't apply. If Freddie wanted to use a wheelchair here, he could. If they wanted to sleep in the living room together because the trauma of the last week was too much to handle alone, they could.

"Let's go inside," Paige said, grabbing the keys from the ignition. "I'm unlocking the door. Freddie, you turn on the lights. Jessica, bring the snacks."

"Copy that," Jessica said, grabbing the half-eaten bag of peanuts.

They walked up the path together, crossing the threshold into the only world that truly understood them.

Scene 16: The Shutdown Protocol

The house was cool and smelled faintly of old wood and laundry detergent. It was the smell of stasis. Nothing had changed while they were gone. The furniture was exactly where they left it. The silence was heavy and protective.

There was no unpacking. There was no sorting of laundry. There was only the imperative of rest.

"Protocol: Crash," Jessica announced, dropping her keys in the bowl by the door. "Zero energy remaining."

"Agreed," Paige said, rubbing her face with both hands. "My battery is at 1%."

They moved as a unit to the master bedroom at the back of the house. It was a large room, dominated by a massive King-sized bed. It wasn't just furniture; it was the raft. It was the one place where the geometry of their family made physical sense.

Freddie walked to the edge of the bed. He felt the soft carpet under his socks. He looked at the expanse of the mattress.

"Target acquired," Freddie whispered.

He didn't need to ask permission here. He didn't need to explain why textures bothered him or why clothing felt like a cage after a fourteen-hour travel day.

He pulled off his hoodie. It fell to the floor in a heap of orange fabric. Next came the t-shirt. Then the jeans. Then the rest.

Paige and Jessica did the same. There was no hesitation, no modesty, and no sexualization. It was simply the removal of the "outside" layer. The airport air, the seatbelt grime, the stress of the checkpoint—it all clung to the fabric. By stripping it off, they were shedding the mission.

They climbed in.

The sheets were cool cotton, clean and crisp.

Freddie scrambled to the center. It was his designated coordinate. Paige climbed in on the left (the driver's side). Jessica climbed in on the right (the guard side).

They settled instantly.

Freddie lay on his back, staring up at the dark ceiling. He felt the heat of Paige's arm against his left side. He felt the weight of Jessica's leg draped over his shin on the right.

"Sandwich complete," Freddie murmured.

"Lights out," Jessica whispered, reaching over to the bedside lamp. *Click.*

The room plunged into darkness. Not the scary darkness of a hotel room, but the familiar, heavy blackness of home.

"Alarm status?" Freddie asked into the void.

"Disabled," Paige promised, her voice already thick with sleep. "No alarms. No schedules. We sleep until the sun wakes us up."

"And then?" Freddie asked.

"And then we make pancakes," Jessica mumbled. "But not until noon."

Freddie closed his eyes.

He visualized his internal dashboard. The warning lights that had been flashing red for days—*Stress*, *Fear*, *Overload*—flickered and turned off, one by one.

Checkpoint: Cleared. Flight: Landed. Tunnel: Survived. Vanessa: Gone.

"System... shutting down," Freddie whispered.

He rolled onto his side, facing Paige, curling his knees up. Jessica shifted closer, her arm coming over to rest on his hip, locking him in place.

For the first time in a week, Freddie didn't just sleep. He rested. The emergency brake was off. The engine was cold. The truck was parked in the yard.

He was home.

The Trojan Horse

Scene 1: The Invalid Variable

The living room of 105 Pepper Street was a sanctuary of controlled variables. The air conditioner hummed its steady, white-noise lullaby, keeping the Virginia humidity on the other side of the vinyl siding.

Freddie sat curled on the beige sofa, the weight of his Iron-Logic laptop warm against his thighs. He was deep in the code for the "Asteroid Belt" page of Project Helios, optimizing the table borders to ensure perfect alignment.

On his right, Paige sat thigh-to-thigh with him. She was reading a paperback, but her presence was a constant stream of tactile data: Heat. Pressure. Safety. Her leg pressed against his, a grounding wire that kept his own nervous system from fraying.

In the kitchen, the clink of glass jars signaled that Jessica was organizing the spice rack—a rhythmic, domestic sound that Freddie filed under "Normal Operations."

Knock. Knock. Knock.

The sound was wrong. It wasn't the heavy, rhythmic thud of a delivery driver. It was a weak, scratching sound against the wood. A hesitation.

Freddie froze. His fingers hovered over the keyboard. The sudden introduction of an unknown variable caused a spike in his heart rate.

"Stay put," Jessica commanded softly.

She moved past the sofa, her socks silent on the carpet. She approached the door but didn't touch the handle. She leaned in, pressing her eye to the peephole.

Freddie watched her back muscles tense. She stood perfectly still for a second, processing visual input. Then, she reached up and threw the deadbolt.

Click.

But she didn't open the door fully. She engaged the brass security chain, sliding it into the track. She cracked the door two inches. The chain went taut, a golden line of defense.

"What do you want?" Jessica asked. Her voice was zero degrees Kelvin.

"I didn't have anywhere else to go," a voice whispered from the porch.

Freddie flinched. He knew that frequency. It was scratchy, broken, and terrified.

Vanessa.

"My aunt kicked me out," Vanessa sobbed through the crack. "I... I hitchhiked back. I walked from the highway."

"Not our problem," Jessica said, starting to push the door shut. "You're banned. Leave."

"Wait!"

Vanessa jammed her foot into the gap at the bottom of the door, wedging her dirty sneaker between the frame and the heavy wood.

Jessica stopped pushing. She looked down at the foot. Then she looked through the crack, her eyes cold.

"Remove the obstruction," Jessica warned calmly. "Or I will remove it for you."

"Jessica, please—"

"I am going to slam this door in three seconds," Jessica stated. "If your foot is there, I will break it. One."

Vanessa hesitated.

"Two." Jessica pulled the door back slightly to get momentum.

Vanessa yanked her foot back instantly.

WHAM.

Jessica didn't close it all the way. She caught it just before the latch clicked, keeping the chain taut, maintaining the two-inch visual sliver.

"I'm listening," Jessica said through the gap. "Make it fast."

Freddie set his laptop on the coffee table. He stood up. The pull of the doorway was magnetic—a source of error that needed to be resolved. He walked up behind Jessica, looking over her shoulder.

Vanessa stood on the porch. She looked wrecked. She was wearing a faded, oversized flannel shirt that hung off her shoulders like a tarp. Her hair was greasy and loose. Her face was gaunt, dark circles bruising the skin under her eyes.

She looked like a system in total collapse.

"Illness?" Freddie asked softly.

Vanessa's eyes locked onto his through the gap. They widened, filling with fresh tears.

"Freddie," she breathed. "Freddie, please. You have to help me."

"Why?" Jessica demanded, not moving an inch. "Why does he have to help you?"

Vanessa looked at Jessica, then back at Freddie. She took a shuddering breath.

Then, she moved. She placed her hands low on her stomach, over the loose flannel fabric. She arched her lower back slightly, thrusting her hips forward. She pressed the fabric down against her skin, molding it to emphasize a shape.

It wasn't a natural stance. It was a pose. It was a performance.

"Because I'm pregnant," she said.

The word hit the cool air of the living room like a physical object. *Pregnant.*

Freddie blinked. He processed the definition. Biological reproduction. Gestation. Fetus.

He looked at her stomach. He saw the curve she was straining to emphasize with her hands and her posture. To his literal mind, the visual data was absolute.

Input: Convex curvature of the abdomen. Input: Verbal confirmation. Conclusion: Advanced gestation.

"So?" Jessica said, her voice dripping with skepticism. She didn't look at the stomach; she looked at Vanessa's arching back. She saw the effort. She saw the act. "Congratulations. Go find the father."

Vanessa didn't look away from Freddie. She pushed her stomach out further, selling the silhouette.

"I did," she whispered. "He's standing right there."

The silence that followed was absolute. The hum of the AC seemed to vanish.

"It's Freddie's," Vanessa claimed, her voice gaining a desperate, terrifying strength. "It happened in Pasco. In the bathroom. I... I tried to stop him, but..."

She let the sentence trail off, painting a picture in the negative space. A picture of a traumatized boy losing control. A picture of a blackout rage.

For a split second, the "Pasco File" opened in Freddie's mind. The memory was fragmented by panic—the cold tile, the shouting, the pain in his back.

Did I? The "Robert Virus" flared up, suggesting that he was broken, that he was a monster capable of things he couldn't remember. *Did the system fail? Did I lose time?*

He looked at her stomach again. The bump looked real to him because she was presenting it as real. But then, his logic engine kicked in.

"The... the geometry," Freddie stammered, pointing a shaking finger at the crack in the door. "The mass is significant. Biology dictates time. If the conception was Pasco... that was sixteen days ago."

He frowned, his logic processor struggling to reconcile the visual input with the math.

"A sixteen-day embryo is microscopic," Freddie whispered. "Your abdomen suggests... months."

Vanessa flinched. She realized she was overselling it. She adjusted her stance, slouching slightly to make the flannel bunch up more, trying to hide the lack of actual mass.

"It's... it's fast," Vanessa lied, desperate to bridge the logic gap. "It's growing so fast, Freddie. It's a strong baby. It's *yours*."

Jessica snorted. A harsh, derisive sound.

"Oh, stop it," Jessica snapped. "Stop pushing your gut out, Vanessa. You look ridiculous."

"I'm not!" Vanessa cried, clutching the shirt.

"You are," Paige said, stepping up beside Freddie. She glared through the crack. "I took AP Biology. Sixteen days? You wouldn't even be late yet. You're bloating, and you're arching your back to manipulate him."

Paige turned to Freddie, grabbing his arm to ground him.

"She is faking the visual, Freddie," Paige stated firmly. "Do not accept the input. It is a performance."

"But she said..." Freddie started, confused by the conflicting data.

"She lied," Paige said. "And about Pasco? That didn't happen either. I felt you. I felt the panic. I felt the pain. If you had done that... if you had crossed that line... I would have felt it. It didn't happen."

Freddie looked at Vanessa. He looked at the hand pressing the flannel.

Then, a different file opened. It wasn't a memory of trauma. It was a memory of hard, medical data.

- **Date:** 1999

- **Location:** Pediatric Specialist, Norfolk
- **Subject:** Freddie Avery (Age 14)
- **Result:** Anomalous development. Seminal fluid present. Sperm count: Zero.
- **Diagnosis:** Azoospermia

The panic evaporated. The static cleared instantly, replaced by the cool, blue screen of logic.

Vanessa was claiming an output that his hardware could not produce.

He looked at her tears. He looked at her desperation. He looked at the fake bump she was straining to maintain.

He realized, with a sudden, clinical clarity, that she must have been with someone else. She must have had an affair.

Freddie processed this "betrayal."

Did it hurt? No.

To Freddie, the terminology of relationships was literal, not social. To be a "girlfriend" meant she was a girl who was a friend. To be a "partner" meant a shared project. It meant synchronization. It meant two systems running in parallel to maintain the same server.

Vanessa was not his partner. She was a user who had spent time in his orbit. She was a guest account with limited privileges. The fact that she had docked with another port was irrelevant to him emotionally. It was just data. She had sought compatibility elsewhere.

There was only one valid "partner" in his architecture.

He glanced at Paige, who was standing beside him, her arms crossed, her eyes blazing with protective fury.

Paige. She was his twin. His co-processor. The redundant system that kept him online when his own hardware failed. She was the one who managed the inputs he couldn't handle. She was the one who shared his timeline, his biology, and his survival.

That was a partner.

Vanessa was just noise.

Freddie adjusted his glasses. He stepped closer to the chain.

"That is," Freddie stated, his voice flat and devoid of emotion, "a biological impossibility."

Vanessa blinked, thrown off by his calm. She straightened up slightly, losing the "bump" posture for a second before remembering to slouch again. "Freddie, please... I know you're scared. I know you blocked it out... "

"You remember a fiction," Freddie said. "Your data is corrupted."

Jessica stepped forward, her face hardening into a look of supreme victory. She looked at Vanessa through the crack.

"Vanessa," Jessica said, her voice dropping to a conversational bore. "Do you know what 'Azoospermia' is?"

Vanessa paused, her sob hitching. "What?"

"It means he shoots blanks," Jessica said, crossing her arms. "Complete sterility. We've known since he was fourteen. We have the charts. We have five years of lab reports on file."

Vanessa's face went white. She stood up straight, forgetting to arch her back. The "bump" vanished instantly under the loose flannel.

The "victim" mask slipped, revealing the raw panic underneath.

"Your variable is invalid," Freddie said quietly. "The output you are claiming—the pregnancy—cannot be derived from my input. The system does not support that function."

"Maybe the doctors were wrong!" Vanessa grasped, her voice rising in pitch. "Miracles happen! Stress can change things!"

"Stress doesn't rewrite DNA," Jessica snapped. "And doctors aren't wrong five years in a row."

Jessica looked at Vanessa's stomach, which was now flat again as Vanessa panicked. Her eyes narrowed.

"You're pregnant," Jessica deduced. "I believe that part. You look sick. But it isn't Freddie's. It's probably one of the random guys you hooked up with at a party before you decided to 'kidnap' him. Or maybe someone back at school."

Freddie watched Vanessa's face. He saw the flinch.

"You tried to kidnap him," Jessica hissed through the crack. "You abused him. And now you tried to pin your mistake on him because you thought he was 'broken.' You thought he would believe he was a monster just because you puffed your stomach out."

Jessica smiled, but it was a terrifying expression.

"But he knows his code. And so do we."

Vanessa stood on the porch, the heat radiating around her. Her Trojan Horse had burned down before it even breached the wall.

"Please," she whispered, her voice small. "I have nowhere else to go."

"You aren't coming in here," Freddie said.

He reached past Jessica. He grabbed the door handle.

"You are dismissed," Freddie said. "If you return to these coordinates, we will contact law enforcement for trespassing."

"Freddie—"

"Connection terminated," Freddie whispered.

He slammed the door.

Click-THUNK. The deadbolt slid home.

Inside, the cool air returned. The silence of the house wrapped around them.

"Status?" Jessica asked, turning to face him.

Freddie looked at his hands. They were steady.

"Status: Secure," Freddie said. He looked at Paige. "I did not blackout. I remembered correctly. I stopped her."

"You did," Paige beamed, hugging him hard. "You stopped her then, and you stopped her now."

"She had an affair," Freddie noted, resting his chin on Paige's head. "She sought compatibility elsewhere."

"She sought chaos," Jessica corrected, walking to the phone. "And she found it. Now, I'm calling the lawyer. We're getting that paper trail started."

"Agreed," Freddie said.

He walked back to the sofa. He sat down and picked up his laptop. The screen glowed with the clean, orderly lines of his code.

The threat was deleted. The variable was null.

"Resuming orbit," Freddie murmured.

Scene 2: The Legal Shield

The conference room smelled of lemon polish and old leather binders—a scent Freddie categorized as "Bureaucracy." It was a low-stimulus environment: beige walls, heavy curtains drawn against the morning sun, and a long mahogany table that reflected the overhead can lights like a dark pool.

Freddie sat in a high-backed leather chair on the left side of the table. Paige sat immediately to his right, her chair pulled close enough that their arms touched. Her hand rested on his knee, a static anchor point that kept his leg from bouncing.

Jessica sat at the head of their side of the table, acting as the spokesperson. She had the "Medical Binder"—a thick, black three-ring notebook—open in front of her.

Across from them sat **Mr. Sterling**, the same attorney who had handled Aunt Marge's deed transfer. He adjusted his glasses, looking from the siblings to the file.

"So," Mr. Sterling said, his voice grave. "You have a trespasser claiming paternity."

"She isn't just claiming it," Jessica said, her voice sharp. "She's trying to use it as a key. She wants entry to the house. She wants financial support."

"She attempted to breach the perimeter yesterday," Freddie added quietly. "She used the pregnancy variable to induce guilt."

Mr. Sterling nodded. "And you are certain the claim is false? In paternity cases, usually we wait for the birth to test, but if you want to be proactive..."

Jessica didn't answer with words. She slid a document from a plastic sleeve in the binder and pushed it across the polished wood. It was a photocopy of a lab report from a pediatric specialist in Norfolk, dated October 14, 1999.

Mr. Sterling picked it up. He read the header. He read the diagnosis code.

"**Azoospermia**," Sterling read aloud. "Congenital."

"Zero count," Jessica clarified. "The hardware doesn't produce the output. It never has. We've known since he was fourteen."

Sterling looked at Freddie. He didn't look with pity; he looked with professional appreciation for a slam-dunk defense.

"This is... definitive," Sterling said. "Biologically absolute."

"She doesn't know," Paige said, squeezing Freddie's knee. "She thinks she can bluff him because she assumes he's... naive. She thinks he doesn't know how his own body works."

"She assumes my data is incomplete," Freddie corrected. "She is projecting ignorance onto me."

"Precisely," Sterling said. He opened a legal pad. "We will draft a Cease and Desist immediately. We will cite harassment, trespassing, and attempted extortion. We will attach a redacted copy of this report—just the diagnosis line—to prove that her claim is fraudulent on its face."

He picked up his pen. "Now, the logistical issue. Service of process. Where do we send this? Does she have a local address?"

"She's homeless," Jessica admitted. "She said her aunt in Seattle kicked her out. She drifted back here. She was wearing dirty clothes on our porch."

"If she has no fixed address, service is difficult," Sterling noted. "We can't mail a letter to a park bench."

Freddie frowned. He accessed his memory archives. He searched for the file labeled *Project Helios: Group Meetings*.

Date: February 12, 2004. **Location:** Newman Library. **Context:** Spring Break logistics discussion.

He saw Vanessa sitting across the table. She was complaining about the dorms closing for break.

Memory Playback: "I hate Spring Break," Vanessa had sighed, playing with her pen. "They kick us out of the dorms. I have to go back to my mom's place in Portsmouth. It's a five-hour haul back to the coast, and the house smells like cat litter."

Freddie blinked.

"Portsmouth," Freddie stated.

Sterling looked up. "Excuse me?"

"She has a permanent address," Freddie said, his voice steady. "She stated during the Helios project that her mother resides in Portsmouth, Virginia. She returns there when the university housing is unavailable."

"Portsmouth," Jessica repeated, nodding. "I remember that. She complained about the drive being too long."

"Do we have the street address?" Sterling asked.

"No," Freddie admitted. "But the University Registrar does."

Jessica sat up straight. "She's a student, Mr. Sterling. Even if she dropped out or is suspended, her permanent record is on file at CPI. Her home address—her mother's address—will be listed as her legal residence."

"And since she is currently claiming to be carrying a Avery child," Sterling smiled tightly, "we have sufficient cause to request that information for 'legal family matters' via the directory. Most students forget to unlist their permanent addresses."

Sterling turned to his computer. He typed for a moment, accessing the public directory database.

"Found it," Sterling confirmed. "**Vanessa Lawson**. It's in the Churchland area. **[Redacted Street], Portsmouth, Virginia 23703**."

"Send it there," Jessica decided. "Certified Mail. Return Receipt Requested. That establishes the paper trail. If she's homeless here, her mother will get it. Her family will know we know."

"And for the immediate threat?" Paige asked. "What if she comes back to the porch today?"

"We create a distribution strategy," Sterling said.

He turned to his printer. He typed rapidly for five minutes. The printer whirred, spitting out three crisp, heavy sheets of paper on the firm's letterhead.

NOTICE TO CEASE AND DESIST RE: Fraudulent Paternity Claims & Trespassing

To Ms. Vanessa Lawson:

Please be advised that we represent Mr. Freddie Avery. We are in possession of medical documentation dated 1999 confirming that Mr. Avery is medically sterile (Diagnosis: Azoospermia).

Your claim of paternity is therefore biologically impossible and constitutes an attempt to defraud.

You are hereby notified that you are forbidden from entering the property at 105 Pepper Street SE. Any further presence will be treated as criminal trespassing. Any further demands for money will be treated as extortion.

Sterling signed all three copies with a flourish. He stamped them with his notary seal.

"Three copies," Sterling said, laying them out.

"Copy One," he tapped the first pile. "This goes into the outgoing mail to the Portsmouth address today. Certified."

"Copy Two," he handed a thick envelope to Jessica. "This is your 'Field Copy.' Keep it on you. If you see her in public, or if she approaches you on campus, you hand it to her. That counts as personal service."

"I'll find her," Jessica promised, taking the envelope. "I know where she hunts."

"Copy Three," Sterling said, holding up the final sheet. "This one is for the house. You need to tape it to the front door. Eye level."

Jessica winced. Paige looked disgusted.

"Tape it to the door?" Paige asked. "It looks... trashy. Like we're in a feud. It tells the neighbors we have drama."

"I do not like the aesthetic," Freddie agreed. "It disrupts the visual symmetry of the entryway."

"It disrupts the symmetry," Sterling agreed, "but it establishes **Constructive Notice**. If she comes to the house while you are in class, or while you are asleep, and she sees that... she knows she can't plead ignorance. If she knocks after reading that, the police can arrest her immediately."

Jessica sighed. She hated it. It felt like admitting the infection had reached the skin of the house. But the logic was sound.

"Fine," Jessica said. "We tape it. Just until she's gone."

Freddie looked at the letter. It was a shield made of paper.

"It validates the truth," Freddie whispered. "The math wins."

"The math always wins, Freddie," Sterling agreed. "And in this case, the math says zero."

Jessica took the remaining copies. She folded Copy Two carefully and put it in her bag.

"Thank you, Mr. Sterling," Jessica said. "We're done being victims."

"She won't come back," Paige said, squeezing Freddie's hand. "Once she sees this... she'll know the game is over."

They stood up. Freddie felt lighter. The legal wall was built. The medical wall was built.

"Let's go home," Freddie said. "I want to verify the locks."

"Locks verified," Jessica promised. "Then I'm going to the library."

They walked out of the office, armed with the truth, ready to defend the Base against the variable that tried to crash the system.

Scene 3: The Null Hypothesis

Jessica walked through the automatic sliding doors of Newman Library. She wasn't wearing her usual student attire of jeans and a Forger t-shirt. She was wearing "Business Armor"—black slacks, a crisp blouse, and boots that clicked with authority on the tile floor.

She carried a thick, cream-colored envelope bearing the return address of **Sterling & Associates, Attorneys at Law**.

She scanned the first-floor study area. It was the "Quiet Zone," usually populated by stressed engineering students. Today, it was mostly empty, save for a few summer session stragglers.

Target Acquisition.

She found her.

Vanessa was holed up in a study carrel in the far back corner, hidden behind a barricade of unread periodicals. She wasn't studying. She was sleeping, her head resting on her folded arms. Her large duffel bag—her entire life—was wedged under the desk, guarded by her leg.

She looked rough. Her hair was greasy, pulled back into a messy bun. She was wearing the same flannel shirt she had worn on the porch yesterday.

Jessica walked over. She didn't stomp; she moved with the silent, lethal grace of a predator closing in.

She stopped at the carrel. She looked down at the girl who had slapped her brother.

Jessica raised the heavy legal envelope and dropped it flat onto the table.

WHACK.

Vanessa jolted awake, gasping. She wiped a line of drool from her cheek, her eyes darting around in panic. She saw Jessica standing over her like a monolith.

Instantly, the mask slammed back into place. Vanessa slumped in her chair, hunching her shoulders. She placed a protective hand over her stomach, arching her back slightly against the chair to simulate the "bump" she had tried to sell yesterday.

"Jessica," Vanessa whispered, her voice trembling. "I... I haven't eaten. The baby needs food."

Jessica stared at her. She didn't blink. She looked at the hand clutching the flannel.

"Drop the act, Vanessa."

"I'm not acting!" Vanessa cried, though she kept her voice low to avoid the librarian. "I'm carrying his child! You can't just abandon us! I have nowhere to go!"

Jessica pulled out the chair opposite her and sat down. She looked relaxed, almost bored.

"Open the envelope."

Vanessa hesitated. Her hand shook as she reached for the cream-colored linen paper. She tore the seal.

She pulled out the documents.

1. **Cease and Desist Order:** Formally banning her from 105 Pepper Street.
2. **The Medical Record:** A photocopy of a lab report from 1999.

"Read the highlighted section," Jessica commanded.

Vanessa looked at the yellow highlighter mark.

DIAGNOSIS: Azoospermia (Congenital). SPERM COUNT: 0.00 CONCLUSION: Absolute Sterility.

Vanessa read it. She frowned. She read it again. The color didn't drain from her face immediately; first, there was confusion.

"What... what is this?"

"It's a lab report from 1999," Jessica explained calmly. "It means Freddie is sterile. He has zero sperm count. He cannot father a child. Biologically, physically, absolutely impossible."

Jessica leaned forward, resting her elbows on the table.

"So," she said, her voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "We know you're lying about Freddie. The math proves it. The biology proves it."

She looked at Vanessa's hand, still clutching her stomach.

"But here is the question, Vanessa: Are you pregnant by someone else and trying to pin it on him? Or are you just lying about the whole thing to get a free room?"

Vanessa froze. The gambit had failed. The ace she thought she was holding—Freddie's guilt—had been trumped by hard medical data.

She looked at the paper. She looked at Jessica's cold, knowing eyes.

She realized there was no point in the posture anymore. The con was dead.

She dropped the act.

She sat up straight. She took her hand off her stomach. The "bump" vanished as she stopped arching her back. Her face shifted from "tragic victim" to "cornered rat."

"Fine," Vanessa spat, tossing the paper onto the table. "You win. I'm not pregnant."

Jessica raised an eyebrow. "I figured. The timeline was sloppy. Sixteen days doesn't look like four months, Vanessa. You oversold the bump."

"I just needed a place to stay!" Vanessa hissed, her desperation turning into anger. "I have no money. My aunt kicked me out in Seattle. I spent my last dollar getting back here. The dorms don't open until August. What was I supposed to do? Sleep under a bridge?"

"The shelter is on Roanoke Street," Jessica reminded her. "The Valley Mission."

"I am a student!" Vanessa snapped, glancing around to make sure no one heard her. "I don't belong in a shelter with... with junkies!"

"You don't belong in my house, either," Jessica said, standing up. "Freddie isn't your ATM, Vanessa. And he isn't your housing plan. He's done with you."

Jessica tapped the Cease and Desist letter on the table.

"This is official notice. If you come to Pepper Street again, I show this to the Dean of Students. Fraud. Harassment. Attempted extortion. You'll be expelled before the Fall semester starts."

Jessica looked down at her one last time.

"Find a new mark, Vanessa. The Avery Unit is closed."

Jessica turned and walked away, her boots clicking rhythmically on the tile floor. She didn't look back. She walked out of the library, into the bright May sunshine, leaving the threat neutralized.

Vanessa sat alone in the carrel. She was fuming. Her hands were shaking with rage and adrenaline.

Sterile, she thought bitterly. *Of course he is. Just another way he's broken.*

She grabbed her stomach as a sudden, sharp cramp twisted her insides.

Stress, she told herself. *Just stress and hunger.*

She reached into her bag to grab a bottle of water. As she dug past her wallet and her keys, her hand brushed against a small box she had stolen from a drugstore in Roanoke two days ago.

Early-Read Pregnancy Test.

She had stolen it as a prop. The plan had been to get into the Avery house, use the bathroom, and leave the positive test in the trash can for Paige to find later. A little piece of physical evidence to back up her lie.

She looked at the box. She looked at the library bathroom sign across the room.

The thought crept in, unbidden. *What if?*

She remembered the party at Westgate. The guy with the tattoo. The guy in the kitchen. She remembered the nausea on the bus ride home from Seattle.

I might as well check, she thought, a dark, cynical laugh bubbling up in her throat. *Just to be sure I'm not actually carrying some frat boy's mistake.*

She stood up, grabbing her bag. She walked to the bathroom. It was empty. She went into the large stall and locked the door.

She tore open the box. She followed the instructions. She set the stick on the toilet paper dispenser.

She waited three minutes, leaning against the graffiti-covered wall, arms crossed. She stared at the ceiling tiles, counting the water stains.

This is stupid, she told herself. *I'm not pregnant. I just said that to get in the house. I'm just stressed.*

Tick. Tick. Tick.

She looked down at the stick.

One pink line.

Control line only.

Negative.

Vanessa let out a breath she didn't realize she was holding. Her shoulders sagged.

She wasn't pregnant.

There was no baby. There was no "miracle." There was no leverage.

She was just... empty.

She picked up the stick and tossed it into the sanitary bin. It landed with a hollow *clatter*.

She looked at herself in the mirror above the sink. She saw the greasy hair. She saw the flannel shirt she had been wearing for three days. She saw a girl who had tried to play a high-stakes game and lost everything.

"Nothing," Vanessa whispered to her reflection. "I have nothing."

She washed her hands, the cold water stinging her skin. She picked up her bag.

She walked out of the bathroom and back into the library. She had three months to kill before the dorms opened. She had no money. She had no friends. And the one person who might have cared about her—Freddie—was now locked behind a legal wall she couldn't breach.

She sat back down at the carrel and put her head on the desk.

The trap had sprung. But it was empty. And so was she.

Scene 4: The Restoration

The front door clicked shut. Jessica threw the deadbolt. She hung her keys on the hook and turned to face her siblings.

"Done," Jessica announced. "The letter is delivered. The threat is neutralized. She knows."

Freddie was sitting on the beige sofa in the living room. Paige was already sitting next to him, her arm draped over his shoulder, her hand resting on his chest.

"She accepted the data?" Freddie asked quietly.

"She folded," Jessica said, kicking off her boots. "She admitted she isn't pregnant. She admitted it was a ploy for housing. And she knows that if she comes within fifty feet of this house, I will have her arrested."

Jessica walked over to the sofa. She looked at Freddie. She saw the lingering tension in his jaw, the shadow of the fear Vanessa had planted.

"It's over, Captain," Jessica said softly. "The virus is deleted. The system is clean."

Freddie let out a long breath. He leaned his head back against Paige's shoulder.

"She wanted to isolate the variable," Freddie whispered. "She wanted to be the only input."

"She was jealous," Paige said, tightening her grip on him. "She hated that you loved us. She wanted to own you."

"But she failed," Jessica said, sitting down on Freddie's other side. She wrapped her arm around his waist, locking him into the center of the formation. "Because

she didn't understand the architecture. She thought she was fighting two sisters. She didn't know she was fighting an army."

Freddie looked at them. He felt the familiar, grounding pressure of their bodies pressing against him. This was the sensation Vanessa had tried to shame out of him. This was the "sickness" she had tried to cure.

But it didn't feel sick. It felt like gravity.

"I missed this," Freddie admitted, his voice thick with emotion. "In Seattle... on the bus... I missed the weight."

"We're here," Paige promised, kissing his temple. "We're heavy. And we're staying."

"And speaking of armies," Jessica grinned, pulling her phone out of her pocket. "I think it's time we called in the reinforcements. Aunt Linda called while I was at the library. She's bringing the girls up for the weekend. All of them."

Freddie's eyes widened. "The Satellites?"

"Sarah, Jenna, Harper, Amanda, and Elara," Jessica listed. "They're coming on Friday. They want to see the new house. And Harper wants to race you."

Freddie smiled. A real, genuine smile that reached his eyes.

"Vanessa would not survive that encounter," Freddie noted. "Seven sisters. Simultaneous input."

"Her head would explode," Paige laughed. "Can you imagine? She freaked out over two of us holding your hand. If she saw Amanda sitting in your lap and Harper hanging off your wheelchair and Jenna using you as a pillow... she would stroke out."

"It is a high-density environment," Freddie agreed. "But I like the density."

"So do we," Jessica said, squeezing him.

She looked at the clock.

"Okay. Protocol shift. We spent the morning dealing with lawyers and liars. The rest of the day is ours. What do you want to do, Freddie? No judgments. No 'Wolf'. Just you."

Freddie thought about it. He looked at the window. He looked across the street.

"I want... lunch," Freddie decided. "The Thick-Stack."

"Brawny Burger?" Jessica asked.

"It is proximal," Freddie said, pointing out the window. "We can walk. The weather is optimal."

"Done," Jessica said. "Let's go. I'm starving."

They stood up. They didn't need to drive. They walked out the front door, locking the fortress behind them.

They crossed **Pepper Street SE**.

They walked through the small asphalt parking lot that separated their house from the commercial strip.

Ahead of them, at **103 Roanoke Street**, the backlit sign of **Brawny Burger** glowed in the afternoon sun. The smell of charbroiled beef wafted across the pavement.

"Target acquired," Freddie said.

They walked inside. The air conditioning was cool. The booths were red vinyl.

They ordered three **Thick-Stack** combos. They sat in a corner booth.

Freddie took a bite of his burger. It was greasy, salty, and perfect.

"Status?" Paige asked, dipping a fry in her shake.

"Optimal," Freddie said.

He looked out the window. He could see his house across the street. It was safe. It was his.

"After this," Freddie said, wiping ketchup from his lip. "We return to Base. We activate the TV. And we watch *The Local*."

"Pajama protocol?" Jessica asked.

"Immediate execution," Freddie ordered.

They finished their meal. They walked back across the street, a three-person unit moving in lockstep.

They entered the house. They stripped off the "Business Armor" and the "Public Defense" clothes. They put on soft flannel pants and worn-out t-shirts.

The "Heap" formed naturally on the sofa.

Freddie lay in the middle. Paige was on his left, Jessica on his right. They tangled their legs together. They rested their heads on his shoulders.

There was no shame. There was no fear.

Vanessa was gone, alone in a library bathroom with her lies.

But here, in the fortress of 105 Pepper Street, Freddie Avery was surrounded by the only thing that mattered.

He closed his eyes, feeling the steady heartbeat of his sisters on either side.

"Status," Freddie whispered.

"Optimal," they answered together.

The Unit was online. And it was unbreakable.

The Optimization Protocol

Scene 1: The Transaction

The dining room table was covered in a sea of paperwork. It wasn't the usual clutter of textbooks or laptops; these were heavy, legal-sized documents on bond paper, bound with blue backers.

At the head of the table sat **Great Aunt Marge**. She was eighty-two, frail, and breathing with the help of a portable oxygen tank, but her eyes behind her bifocals were as sharp as cut glass.

Surrounding her was a phalanx of professionals she had summoned personally.

- **Mr. Sterling:** Her estate attorney, a man who wore suspenders and had zero sense of humor.
- **Mrs. Gable:** Her real estate agent, there to facilitate the transfer of the title.
- **Dr. Vance:** The family physician, there for a specific, legal purpose.
- **A Notary Public:** A woman named Brenda with a heavy embossing seal.

Sitting opposite them were the Averys: Jessica, Paige, and Freddie. They looked nervous. They felt like they were in a courtroom.

"Alright," Mr. Sterling said, adjusting his glasses. "Before we execute the Deed of Sale, we must establish the capacity of the Grantor. Dr. Vance?"

Dr. Vance stepped forward. He didn't smile. He looked at Marge.

"Margaret," Dr. Vance said gently. "I need to ask you a few questions for the record. Can you tell me today's date?"

"It is June 16th, 2004," Marge said, her voice raspy but firm. "It is a Wednesday. And it is getting warm outside."

"Can you tell me where we are?"

"We are at 105 Pepper Street. My house. Which I am about to sell."

"And can you tell me," Dr. Vance continued, glancing at the lawyer, "why we are here? Do you understand the nature of this transaction?"

Marge straightened up in her chair. She looked past the doctor, past the lawyer, and locked eyes with Freddie.

"I am selling this property to my great-nieces and great-nephew," Marge stated clearly. "I am bypassing my niece, Ellen, entirely. I am doing this to ensure that when I die, Ellen cannot evict them, harass them, or force them to live according to her... outdated standards."

She looked at the lawyer.

"I am of sound mind, Mr. Sterling. My lungs are failing, not my brain. I know exactly what I am doing. I am securing their perimeter."

Freddie blinked. *Securing the perimeter.* She used their language.

Dr. Vance nodded. He signed an affidavit attached to the file. "Medical capacity confirmed. She is lucid and fully aware of the consequences of her actions."

"Excellent," Mr. Sterling said. He slid the heavy stack of papers toward Marge.

"This is a **Quitclaim Deed** transferring ownership from Margaret E. Lewis to Jessica, Paige, and Freddie Avery as **Joint Tenants with Right of Survivorship**," Sterling explained. "This means if anything happens to one of you, the house automatically belongs to the others. It cannot be inherited by parents or spouses. It stays in the Unit."

"Perfect," Jessica whispered.

"Now," the Real Estate Agent spoke up. "Regarding the purchase price. We are listing the sale price as **One Dollar**."

"One dollar?" Paige asked. "Is that legal?"

"It is essential," Mr. Sterling said. "If Marge simply *gave* you the house, Ellen could argue in probate court that it was a gift made under duress or senility. She could try to claw it back as part of the estate inheritance."

He tapped the table.

"But a **Sale**? A sale is a contract. If money changes hands—even a nominal amount—it is a completed transaction. Consideration has been paid. The deal is closed. Ellen cannot overturn a valid real estate sale just because she doesn't like the price."

Marge reached into her purse. She pulled out a pen.

"I want them safe," Marge said, her hand shaking slightly as she hovered over the signature line. "I know about the bed, Jessica."

The room went silent. Jessica stiffened. Paige grabbed Freddie's hand under the table.

"I know you three sleep together," Marge continued, her voice soft. "And I know Freddie wants a wheelchair."

"Mother says..." Freddie started, his voice small. "Mother says it is giving up."

"Your mother," Marge snapped, "is a fool. She cares more about what the neighbors think than what her children need."

Marge looked at Freddie with fierce affection.

"If a wheelchair helps you move, you get one. If sleeping in a pile like puppies keeps the nightmares away, you do it. This house is yours. You make the rules. No one else."

She pressed the pen to the paper.

Scritch-scratch.

She signed her name with a flourish. **Margaret E. Lewis.**

The Notary stamped it. *KER-CHUNK.*

"It is done," Mr. Sterling said. He looked at the Averys. "Now. We need the consideration. Who is paying?"

"I have the asset," Freddie announced.

He reached into his pocket. He pulled out a crisp, single George Washington one-dollar bill. He had ironed it that morning.

He stood up. He walked to the head of the table.

He handed the bill to his Great Aunt.

"Payment rendered," Freddie said formally. "Thank you for the... base."

Marge took the dollar. She held it up to the light, then tucked it into her blouse pocket over her heart.

"Best deal I ever made," Marge whispered. She reached out and squeezed Freddie's hand. "Take care of them, Captain."

"I will," Freddie promised.

Mr. Sterling gathered the files. "I will file this with the County Clerk within the hour. By 2:00 PM, the deed will be public record. The house is yours."

Marge slumped back in her chair, exhausted but smiling.

"There," she breathed. "Let Ellen try to break that."

The firewall was installed. The Avery Unit had a permanent home. And it only cost them a dollar.

Scene 2: The Hardware Upgrade

The living room was transformed into a command center. The coffee table was covered in glossy brochures Freddie had requested by mail: *TiLite*, *Quickie*, *Colours*.

Freddie sat on the floor, surrounded by the paperwork. He wasn't looking at the "Lifestyle" photos of people playing basketball or smiling on beaches. He was looking at the technical specifications table on the back page of the *TiLite TR* brochure.

"Titanium," Freddie murmured, tracing the line item. "Grade 9. Seamless aerospace tubing."

"Strength-to-weight ratio is optimal," Jessica agreed, reading over his shoulder. "And it absorbs vibration. That means less static on the sidewalk."

"Matte black," Paige added, pointing to the color swatch. "Stealth mode. No shiny chrome to attract attention."

"The Rover," Freddie christened it. "It is not a chair. It is a vehicle."

Rring. Rring.

The phone on the wall chirped. The caller ID flashed: **ELLEN AVERY (NORFOLK).**

The atmosphere in the room shifted instantly. The warm, creative energy of the "Rover Project" evaporated, replaced by the familiar tension of the "Parental Firewall."

"I'll handle it," Jessica said, standing up. She picked up the receiver. "Hello, Mother."

Freddie and Paige went silent. They could hear Ellen's voice tinny and sharp on the other end.

"Jessica? I just got a notification from the insurance company. Something about a 'Durable Medical Equipment' pre-authorization? Please tell me Freddie isn't... he isn't getting a wheelchair."

Jessica leaned against the counter. "He is. We're ordering a custom rigid-frame. Titanium."

"Absolutely not," Ellen snapped. *"He can walk, Jessica. The doctors said if he keeps up with his PT, he can walk. Getting a chair is giving up. It's... it's making him an invalid. What will people think?"*

Jessica rolled her eyes. It was always about the *optics*. To Ellen and Robert, disability was a failure of discipline. If Freddie just "tried harder," he would be normal. If he just "focused," he wouldn't be autistic.

"People will think he's moving efficiently," Jessica said coolly. "Walking causes him pain. It drains his battery. The chair extends his range."

"He's nineteen years old!" Ellen argued. *"He shouldn't be rolling around like an old man. And Great Aunt Marge... God rest her soul... she would be heartbroken to see him stop trying."*

Freddie flinched. He looked at the photo of Great Aunt Marge on the mantle. He remembered the last time he saw her in June, before the end. She had been frail, but she had been certain.

Memory Log: Marge. "Sit down, Freddie ," Marge had wheezed. "Stop trying to be a soldier. Just be comfortable."

Freddie reached out. He took the phone from Jessica.

"Mother," Freddie said. His voice was flat.

"Freddie," Ellen's voice softened into that pitying tone he hated. *"Honey, listen to me. Don't let your sisters talk you into this. You're strong. You don't need a wheelchair. You just need to—"*

"I do not need to struggle," Freddie interrupted.

"But—"

"The walking variable is inefficient," Freddie stated, staring at the TiLite brochure. "It consumes 60% of my processing power just to maintain balance. That leaves only 40% for observation, calculation, and interaction. With the Rover, mobility cost drops to 10%. Processing power increases to 90%."

"Freddie, life isn't a computer program," Ellen sighed. *"It's about appearance. It's about fitting in."*

"I do not fit in," Freddie said. "I am a divergent system. And regarding Aunt Marge..."

He looked at the checkbook sitting on the counter. The one linked to the trust fund Marge had left them. The fund that paid the mortgage, the bills, and the grocery tab. The fund Ellen had no access to.

"Marge provided the resources for optimization," Freddie said. "She did not attach conditions of 'normalcy.' She accepted the output as is."

"She was an enabler," Ellen muttered. *"And she let you three... well, I don't want to get into the sleeping arrangements again. It's unnatural, Freddie. Adults don't share a bed. It's sick."*

"It is secure," Freddie corrected. "It is a zero-friction environment. And since Marge pays the mortgage, her protocol overrides yours."

He handed the phone back to Jessica.

"Authorize the purchase," Freddie commanded.

Jessica grinned. She put the phone back to her ear.

"You heard the Captain, Mother. We're buying the chair. And we're buying the 'Sport Package' wheels because they look cool. We'll send you a picture."

She hung up without saying goodbye.

"Status?" Paige asked, rubbing Freddie's back.

Freddie looked at the brochure. He felt a weight lift off his chest. For years, he had walked because *they* wanted him to. He had endured the cramps, the spasms, the fatigue, just to avoid the "shame" of the chair.

But Marge hadn't cared about shame. Marge had cared about *him*.

"Status: Upgrading," Freddie said. He pointed to the order form. "Camber the wheels 2 degrees. Better turning radius."

"Done," Jessica said, grabbing a pen. "Let's build this tank."

That night, they didn't just sleep; they hibernated.

Freddie lay in the middle of the King bed.

- **Left Flank:** Paige, her leg thrown over his hip to anchor him.
- **Right Flank:** Jessica, back-to-back with him, a solid wall against the door.

Ellen called it "sick." Robert called it "weird." But as Freddie drifted off, surrounded by the heat and scent of his sisters, he knew the truth.

It wasn't sick. It was **survival**. And for the first time in his life, he was going to stop apologizing for surviving.

"Rover arrives in two weeks," Freddie whispered into the dark.

"Two weeks," Paige promised, kissing his shoulder. "Then we see how fast you can really go."

Scene 3: The Deed of Trust

The afternoon sun filtered through the sheer curtains, illuminating the dust motes dancing in the air. The atmosphere in the living room was one of drowsy contentment.

They were in the "Sandwich Configuration" on the plaid sofa. Freddie sat in the middle, his legs resting on the coffee table. Paige was on his left, her head on his shoulder, reading a paperback. Jessica was on his right, tapping away on her laptop.

In the corner of the room, gleaming in matte black titanium, sat **The Rover**. It had arrived two days ago. Freddie had spent the morning learning to spin it on a dime in the kitchen. For the first time in years, his back didn't hurt.

Rattle. Jiggle. Click.

The front door knob turned.

The three of them froze. They hadn't changed the locks yet—a logistical oversight.

The door swung open. Ellen Avery stood in the doorway, her key in hand, a look of thunderous disapproval on her face. She stepped inside without knocking, her eyes immediately locking onto the wheelchair in the corner.

"So," Ellen said, her voice tight. "You actually did it. You bought the thing."

"Hello, Mother," Jessica said. She didn't stand up. She didn't move away from Freddie. She simply closed her laptop lid with a deliberate *snap*.

Ellen walked into the room, her heels clicking aggressively on the hardwood. She gestured at the wheelchair. “I told you not to. I told you it was giving up. But you never listen, do you? You three live in this... this fantasy world where Freddie is a cripple and you two are his nurses.”

“I am not a cripple,” Freddie said, his voice steady. “I am optimized. The Rover increases my efficiency.”

“It makes you look weak!” Ellen snapped. She turned her glare to the sofa. “And look at you. Middle of the afternoon, huddled together like a litter of puppies. It’s weird. It’s unnatural.”

She pointed a manicured finger at Paige.

“You are enabling him, Paige. You’re nineteen. You should be out dating. You should be going to parties. Instead, you’re sleeping in the same bed as your brother. Do you know what people would say if they knew? They’d call it sick.”

Paige stiffened. She felt Freddie’s heart rate spike—the “Robert Virus” triggering the shame protocol.

Paige didn’t pull away. Instead, she shifted closer. She wrapped both arms around Freddie’s left arm, squeezing hard. She looked her mother dead in the eye.

“Let them talk,” Paige said, her voice fierce. “I don’t care about dates. I don’t care about parties. I care about him.”

She turned her head and kissed Freddie’s shoulder, right in front of Ellen.

“I am going to sleep next to him tonight,” Paige announced, making it a vow. “And tomorrow night. And every single night for the rest of my life. If that keeps the nightmares away, if that keeps him safe, then I will never leave that bed. Ever.”

“And neither will I,” Jessica added, leaning her head on Freddie’s right shoulder, locking him in. “He sleeps between us. That is the protocol. It is non-negotiable. It stops the night terrors. It works.”

Ellen’s face turned a blotchy shade of red. “This is... I won’t have it. Not in my aunt’s house. Marge let you get away with this nonsense because she was soft, but she’s gone now. I am the executor of the family standards.”

She crossed her arms.

“I want that wheelchair gone. And I want you to start acting like normal siblings. Separate rooms. Separate lives. Or else I will evict you. I’ll sell this place out from under you.”

Jessica started to laugh. It was a dry, humorless sound.

“Oh, Mother,” Jessica said, shaking her head. “You really should have checked the public records before you drove up here.”

"Excuse me?" Ellen demanded.

Jessica reached under the coffee table and pulled out a thick manila envelope. She tossed it onto the table. It slid across the wood and stopped at Ellen's feet.

"Read it," Jessica said.

Ellen picked it up. She pulled out the document. Her eyes scanned the header.

DEED OF SALE Grantor: Margaret E. Lewis (Owner) **Grantees:** Jessica Avery, Paige Avery, Freddie Avery (Joint Tenants with Right of Survivorship) **Consideration:** $1.00 (Paid in Cash) **Date:** June 16, 2004

Ellen's hands shook. "What is this?"

"Marge wasn't soft," Jessica said, her voice sharpening into a blade. "She was lucid. She watched you judge Freddie for years. She watched you try to force him to be 'normal.' And she knew exactly what you would do when she died."

Jessica stood up then. She rose to her full height, blocking Ellen's view of Freddie.

"She sold us the house in June. We paid her one dollar. A token consideration to make the contract binding. We own this house, Mother. Lock, stock, and barrel. You aren't on the deed. You aren't on the lease. You have zero authority here."

Ellen looked at the paper, then at the wheelchair, then at the three of them—the united front she couldn't break.

"You stole this house," Ellen whispered.

"We secured our base," Freddie corrected from the sofa. "Marge understood the mission requirements. She approved the King Bed. She approved the wheelchair. She accepted the data."

Jessica walked to the front door and opened it wide. The heat from outside rushed in.

"Here is the new reality," Jessica said. "Freddie uses the wheelchair because it stops his pain. We sleep in the same bed because it stops his fear. We are happy. We are functional."

She pointed outside.

"If you can accept that—if you can walk in here and treat Freddie with respect and stop trying to 'fix' us—then you can visit. But if you are going to come in here and call us sick? If you are going to insult the Captain?"

Jessica's eyes flashed.

"Then you are trespassing on private property. And I will remove you."

Ellen stood there for a long moment. She looked at Freddie, safely sandwiched between his sisters, looking stronger and more peaceful than he ever had under her care.

She realized she had lost. The divorce had removed Robert. The deed had removed her.

She dropped the envelope on the table. She didn't say goodbye. She turned around and walked out the door.

Jessica slammed it shut. She threw the deadbolt.

"Paige," Jessica commanded. "Go get the screwdriver. We're changing the locks. Today."

"On it," Paige said, jumping up.

Freddie looked at the wheelchair in the corner. Then he looked at Jessica.

"Sector secure?" Freddie asked.

Jessica smiled, sitting back down and wrapping her arm around him.

"Sector secure, Captain. The house is ours."

The Satellite Convergence

Scene 1: The Invasion Force

The sun was beginning to dip behind the Blue Ridge Mountains, casting long shadows across the driveway.

Freddie sat on the front porch in The Rover, acting as Air Traffic Control. He held a walkie-talkie (a set they used to communicate between the house and the porch without yelling).

"Target is visual," Freddie spoke into the device. "Maroon minivan turning onto Pepper Street."

"Copy that," Jessica's voice crackled back. "Pizza is in the oven. The landing zone is clear."

The minivan—a bruised and battered voyager of the highways—pulled into the driveway. It looked heavy, riding low on its suspension from the weight of five children, one adult, and luggage for a weekend.

The engine died. For a split second, there was silence.

Then, the doors slid open.

"We're here!" Harper (11) yelled, tumbling out first. She stretched her legs, grimacing at the stiffness, her headphones around her neck blasting tinny pop music.

The twins, Amanda and Elara (9), scrambled out next, moving like a single entity. They blinked at the new house, processing the data.

Sarah and Jenna (turning 15 in two days) emerged from the back row. They looked exhausted.

And finally, Aunt Linda stepped out of the driver's seat. She looked like a woman who had survived five hours of "Are we there yet?" and "She's touching me!"

"Welcome to the Base," Freddie said, rolling down the ramp to meet them.

"Freddie!" Elara screamed. She ran up and hugged his knees. Amanda followed silently, placing her hand on his arm to verify he was real.

"Hey, Captain," Sarah said, adjusting her glasses. She looked at the house. "So this is the fortress?"

"It is fortified," Freddie confirmed. "Come. Jessica has carbohydrates."

Scene 2: The Dungeon

The tour of the main floor was quick. The kitchen (small), the living room (beige), and the Master Bedroom (The Silo).

Then came the logistics briefing.

"Okay, listen up," Jessica announced, standing at the door to the basement stairs. "We have high occupancy and low square footage. We have to be strategic."

She pointed to the living room sofa.

"Aunt Linda, you have the fold-out sofa bed. It's lumpy, but it's close to the coffee pot."

"Sold," Linda said, dropping her bag.

"Freddie, Paige, and I remain in the Silo," Jessica continued. "We do not disrupt the Core."

She opened the door to the basement. A draft of cool, earthy air drifted up.

"You guys," Jessica pointed to her five younger sisters, "are in the Underworld."

They descended the wooden stairs. The basement was unfinished—a cavern of concrete floors, exposed rafters, and cinder block walls. It smelled of damp earth and laundry detergent.

Jessica and Paige had set it up as best they could. Five vinyl air mattresses were arranged on the floor, covered in bright sleeping bags. A string of Christmas lights hung from the copper pipes to banish the gloom.

"It's like a bunker!" Jenna shouted, her voice echoing off the concrete. "Awesome!"

"It's cold," Sarah noted, pulling her cardigan tighter.

"It's thermal regulation," Freddie called down from the top of the stairs. He did not descend. "The temperature is constant."

Then, Harper saw it.

In the far corner of the basement, sitting all by itself against the cement wall, was a porcelain toilet.

There were no walls around it. No curtain. No stall. Just a lonely toilet plumbed directly into the floor, sitting next to a deep utility sink and the furnace.

"What," Harper asked, pointing a trembling finger, "is that?"

"That," Jessica explained, trying not to laugh, "is a Pittsburgh Toilet. Miners used to use them to clean up before going upstairs."

"It's... naked," Elara whispered, horrified.

"It is fully functional," Jessica promised. "But, as you can see... it offers zero visual cover."

Sarah stared at it. She imagined sitting there while her four sisters played cards on the air mattresses ten feet away.

"Absolutely not," Sarah declared. "I will hold it for three days if I have to."

"If you really have to go," Paige offered, "it's right there. But yeah... it's the Throne of Shame."

Scene 3: The Privacy Protocol

They went back upstairs (retreating from the toilet as fast as possible). Freddie was waiting in the hallway.

He looked at his younger sisters. He saw the potential for anxiety.

"Briefing," Freddie said, his voice serious.

The girls looked at him.

"I do not possess the agility to navigate the stairs safely," Freddie stated, gesturing to his legs. "Therefore, I will never descend to the Underworld."

He looked specifically at Sarah and Jenna, the teenagers who were most sensitive about privacy.

"Once you are downstairs, you are invisible to me," Freddie promised. "I will not breach the perimeter. Your privacy is absolute."

"Thanks, Freddie," Sarah exhaled, relieved.

"However," Freddie continued, pointing to the hallway bathroom—the only distinct room with a locking door. "Because the downstairs facility is... compromised... you will likely require this bathroom."

"Likely?" Jenna snorted. "Definitely."

"This creates a traffic bottleneck," Freddie analyzed. "We must implement a Knock Protocol. One knock: Check status. Two knocks: Urgent. Three knocks: Emergency."

"And if the door is locked?" Amanda signed, and Elara translated.

"If the door is locked," Freddie said, "you wait. Unless you are brave enough to use the Pittsburgh."

"I'd rather die," Harper decided.

Scene 4: Settlement

The house had settled into a hum of activity.

Downstairs, the sound of electric pumps filled the air as the air mattresses inflated—WHIRRRRRRR. The girls were setting up their camp, giggling and complaining about the cold floor.

In the living room, Aunt Linda was wrestling with the sofa bed mechanism.

"Why do they make these things out of cast iron?" she grumbled, finally getting it to snap open.

In the Silo, the Triad prepared for shutdown.

Freddie lay in the center of the King bed. The door was closed. He could hear the muffled thumps of his sisters below the floorboards.

"They are loud," Freddie noted.

"They're excited," Paige smiled, climbing in next to him.

"And they're terrified of that toilet," Jessica laughed, turning off the lamp. "I saw Jenna running up the stairs three times already."

Freddie stared at the ceiling. He liked the noise. He liked that the house was full.

"The Base is at capacity," Freddie whispered.

"And the perimeter holds," Paige agreed.

They closed their eyes. Below them, five sisters slept in a concrete bunker, safe in the knowledge that their brother would never invade their space, and above them, the Triad slept in their fortress, guarding the door.

The reunion had begun. And the Pittsburgh Toilet remained, fortunately, unused.

Scene 5: The Throne of Shame

The basement was pitch black, save for the faint, ghostly glow of the streetlamp filtering through the tiny window well high on the wall. The only sound was the rhythmic whoosh-hiss of the air mattresses shifting as five girls slept.

Harper woke up.

She didn't wake up groggy. She woke up in Red Alert.

Her bladder was screaming. It was a sharp, demanding pressure that signaled she had about thirty seconds before catastrophic failure.

Oh no, Harper thought, squeezing her eyes shut. Not now.

She lay still for a second, hoping it would pass. It didn't. It got worse.

She sat up on her elbow. Her air mattress wobbled.

She looked toward the stairs. In the darkness, the wooden staircase looked like a mountain. It was steep. It was far away.

She tried to move her legs. They were stiff blocks of wood. The long car ride, the wrestling, and the cold concrete floor had seized her muscles up tight. If she tried to run up those stairs, she wouldn't make it. She would stumble. And the jolt of stumbling would...

I can't make it, Harper realized with icy terror. I'm going to wet the bed.

She looked at her sisters. Sarah was asleep five feet away. If she wet the sleeping bag, everyone would know. Sarah would know. Jenna would know. The twins would tell everyone. She was eleven. She was almost a teenager. Wetting the bed was social suicide. It was the end of her life.

She looked into the dark corner.

There it was. The Pittsburgh Toilet.

It gleamed faintly in the shadows. No walls. No door. Just a porcelain bowl sitting in the open, right next to the furnace, facing the sleeping audience of her sisters.

Harper gagged.

I can't, she thought. It's right there. Everyone will hear.

The pressure spiked. Her body gave her a final warning: Move or flood.

She had no choice.

Harper scrambled out of her sleeping bag. She didn't stand up fully—her legs were too stiff. She did a desperate, crouching shuffle-run across the cold concrete floor.

She reached the toilet. She looked back at the air mattresses.

Sarah shifted in her sleep, rolling over.

Harper froze like a deer in headlights. Don't wake up. Please, please don't wake up.

Sarah settled. Silence returned.

Harper turned to the toilet. She grabbed the cold rim of the utility sink to steady herself. She pulled her pajama pants down. She sat.

To Harper, the sound was deafening. In the quiet basement, the trickle sounded like a waterfall. It sounded like a fire hose. She squeezed her eyes shut, burning with a shame so hot she thought she might actually glow in the dark.

This is it, Harper thought melodramatically. My life is over. I am peeing in a dungeon in front of my entire family. I am a feral animal.

She finished. She reached for the roll of toilet paper Jessica had mercifully left on top of the furnace.

Scritch. Scritch. The paper sounded like sandpaper on a microphone.

She stood up, pulling her pants up with trembling hands.

Now came the final hurdle: The Flush.

If she flushed, the roar would wake the dead. The pipes in this house were loud. It would announce her shame to the world.

But if she didn't flush... Sarah would see it in the morning.

Harper looked at the bowl. She looked at her sleeping sisters.

She chose the lesser evil. She didn't flush. She would wake up at dawn, before anyone else, and flush it then. It was a risky covert op, but it was better than the acoustic explosion.

She crept back across the floor, her bare feet numb on the concrete. She dove back into her sleeping bag and pulled the quilt over her head, burying herself in the darkness.

She lay there, heart hammering against her ribs. She listened.

From the far mattress, Jenna let out a small, sleepy snore.

Harper exhaled. No one had moved. She was safe.

She had survived the Pittsburgh Toilet. But as she drifted back to sleep, she made a solemn vow: I am never drinking soda after 6 PM ever again.

Scene 6: The Morning Audit

Morning in the basement was grey and hazy. The small window wells let in just enough light to turn the concrete room into a shadowy landscape of sleeping bags and messy hair.

Sarah was the first to wake. It was a habit born of being the oldest of the "Little Five." She opened her eyes, reached for her glasses case, and slid her frames onto her nose. The world snapped into focus.

She sat up on her air mattress. Her back cracked. Air mattresses are evil, she thought.

She looked around the room.

Jenna was drooling on her pillow, one leg thrown completely off the mattress onto the cold floor. The twins, Amanda and Elara, were curled up together like puppies in a single sleeping bag.

Then Sarah looked at the corner.

She looked at the Pittsburgh Toilet.

In the grey light of morning, the porcelain bowl stood out starkly against the cinder block wall. And inside the bowl, the water wasn't clear. It was a distinct, undeniable shade of yellow.

Someone used the Throne, Sarah deduced. And someone didn't flush.

She frowned. Leaving it mellow was gross, but she understood the logic. The pipes in this house were loud. A flush in the middle of the night would have sounded like a jet engine.

She scanned the sleeping suspects.

Jenna was sleeping too deeply; she hadn't moved an inch. The twins were a tangled knot.

Then Sarah looked at Harper.

Harper was lying stiff as a board in her sleeping bag. Her eyes were squeezed shut tight—too tight. Her breathing was a little too controlled. She looked like a possum playing dead.

Sarah sighed. She stood up, shivering slightly in the morning chill, and walked over to Harper's mattress.

"Harper," Sarah whispered.

Harper didn't move. She let out a fake, theatrical snore. Honnk-shoo.

"Harper, cut it out," Sarah said, her voice flat. "I know you're awake."

Harper opened one eye. It was filled with panic.

"I didn't do it," Harper whispered instantly. "It was... a ghost. A basement ghost."

Sarah just pointed a finger at the toilet.

"It's yellow, Harper. And you're the only one who looks like you're about to explode from embarrassment."

Harper pulled the sleeping bag up over her nose. Her face was bright red.

"I couldn't hold it," she muffled through the fabric. "And I couldn't make it up the stairs. My legs hurt. Don't look at me."

Sarah didn't laugh. She didn't make a face. She looked at the toilet, then back at her sister.

“So you used the asset,” Sarah said, sounding very much like Freddie for a second. “Good.”

Harper lowered the blanket. “Good? It’s disgusting! I peed in a dungeon!”

“It’s better than wetting the bed,” Sarah stated matter-of-factly. “If you had wet the sleeping bag, we’d have to wash it. And dry it. And everyone would know. This? This is just plumbing.”

She nudged Harper’s foot with her toe.

“Go flush it. Before the twins wake up and ask why the water is colored.”

Harper groaned. She crawled out of her warm bag. She walked the walk of shame to the corner. She reached out and pushed the chrome handle.

KA-WHOOSH.

The sound was thunderous. The pipes banged against the rafters. The water roared.

On the other mattresses, heads popped up.

“Wha—?” Jenna sat up, wiping drool from her chin. “What exploded?”

Elara rubbed her eyes. “Is it a storm?”

Jenna looked at Harper standing by the toilet. She looked at the swirling water. A grin spread across Jenna’s face.

“Oh my god,” Jenna laughed. “Did Harper use the Throne of Shame? Did you actually—”

“Jenna, shut up,” Sarah interrupted. Her voice was sharp. It wasn’t a request.

Jenna blinked. “I was just—”

“She had to go,” Sarah said, crossing her arms. “The toilet is there for a reason. It works. It saved the sheets.”

She looked at the other girls, daring them to make a joke.

“We are practical people,” Sarah declared. “We use the facilities available. If anyone else needs to go, the line starts now. If not, go back to sleep.”

Jenna looked at Sarah’s serious face. She looked at Harper, who was staring at her feet, waiting for the mockery.

Jenna shrugged. “Okay, okay. Chill, Sarge.”

Jenna flopped back onto her pillow. “But seriously, that flush is louder than a bomb.”

Harper walked back to her mattress. She looked at Sarah.

“Thanks,” Harper whispered.

"No problem," Sarah whispered back, taking her glasses off and sliding back into her bag. "But next time? Just flush. We'll get over the noise."

Harper nodded. She climbed back in. The shame didn't vanish completely, but under Sarah's practical logic, it shrank down to something manageable. She hadn't ruined her life. She had just used a toilet.

Better than the bed, Harper repeated to herself. Way better than the bed.

Scene 7: Fueling the Army

"Troops, mobilize," Sarah commanded.

She stood at the bottom of the basement stairs, fully dressed in jeans and a sweater. She clapped her hands twice. "We depart for the surface in T-minus five minutes. Fold the sleeping bags. Do not leave a mess in the Underworld."

Jenna groaned, rolling off her mattress. "You're too loud for morning."

"I smell bacon," Elara sniffed the air, her eyes popping open. "And syrup."

That got them moving. The promise of sugar was the ultimate motivator.

They dragged their heavy limbs up the wooden stairs. Harper hung back. Her legs were stiff, yes, but mostly she was feeling the lingering "Basement Shame" of the night before. She felt vulnerable. She needed to recalibrate.

She trudged up the steps, gripping the rail. She reached the top and opened the door.

The smell hit her first—a thick, warm cloud of frying bacon, brewing coffee, and vanilla batter. The kitchen was a hive of activity.

Aunt Linda was at the stove, flipping pancakes on a griddle that spanned two burners. Jessica was managing the oven, pulling out a tray of biscuits.

"Reinforcements have arrived!" Linda cheered, waving a spatula. "Grab a plate, girls. It's a buffet line."

In the dining area, the table had been extended, but it still looked crowded.

Freddie was sitting at the head of the table. He was dressed in soft flannel pants and a grey t-shirt. Paige was sitting on the chair next to him, but she was leaning heavily against his right side, her arm looped through his, her head resting on his shoulder.

They looked like a single unit. Safe. Grounded.

"Morning, Satellites," Freddie said, smiling as the younger girls filed in.

Amanda ran straight to him. She squeezed his arm, hummed a greeting, and then ran to get a plate.

Then came Harper.

She stood by his chair. She looked at him. She was eleven years old. She was tall for her age, all elbows and knees, growing fast. In any other family, she would be told she was "too big" for what she wanted.

She looked at his lap. Then she looked at his face, hesitating.

Freddie saw the hesitation. He saw the need for a docking maneuver.

He didn't care about the logistics. He didn't care that his legs sometimes cramped or that his wheelchair (parked nearby) was usually his primary seat. Right now, he was in the dining chair, and he had space.

He tapped his thigh.

"Come to port," Freddie invited softly.

Harper didn't wait. She climbed up.

It was a clumsy operation. She was heavy—a solid, growing girl. Her knees bumped the table. Her legs dangled awkwardly, nearly touching the floor. She had to curl up tight to fit, burying her face in the crook of his neck, pressing against his chest.

For a moment, Freddie's sensory system flashed a warning. Input High. Weight Heavy. Heat Rising.

But then, Freddie accessed the Archive.

He remembered the Pathfinder bus. The cold, vibrating window against his head for three days. The smell of diesel and stranger's sweat. The crushing loneliness of staring at the highway markings, terrified that he had made a mistake.

He remembered the Pasco Lock. The bathroom tile. The fear that he was broken. The feeling of Vanessa trying to hollow him out, to make him a vessel for her needs while ignoring his own.

He felt Harper's breathing against his collarbone. He felt Paige squeezing his arm on the other side.

This wasn't noise. This was signal.

He wrapped his left arm around Harper, holding her tight against him. He rested his chin on the top of her messy hair.

"You fit," Freddie whispered to her.

"I'm heavy," Harper mumbled into his shirt.

"You are substantial," Freddie corrected. "I prefer the weight. It verifies gravity."

Harper relaxed. The tension of the toilet incident melted away. She wasn't a weird kid who peed in a basement; she was safe in the Captain's chair.

"Okay, feeding time!" Jessica announced, slamming a platter of pancakes onto the table. "Eat up. We need energy."

"Why?" Jenna asked, sliding into a chair and grabbing a fork. "What's the mission?"

"Tomorrow," Jessica said, pointing a pair of tongs at the twins. "Monday, June 21st. The Big One-Five."

Jenna grinned, her mouth already full of biscuit. "We're finally gonna be old."

"Mid-teens," Sarah corrected, pouring syrup with precision. "It is a significant milestone."

"It's gonna be better than the Twelfth," Paige promised, leaning her head against Freddie's shoulder while he held Harper.

The table went quiet for a second. Even the younger ones stopped chewing.

They all remembered the 12th Birthday. The "Black Year." The shouting match in the kitchen. The way Freddie, Paige, and Jessica had silently packed them into the car and driven them to the Emerald Creek Mall.

They remembered sitting in the food court, eating soft pretzels, pretending they didn't have parents who hated each other. Freddie had bought them each a token bag for the arcade. Paige had won Sarah the blue bear.

It was a sad memory, but it was also a foundational one. It was the day they realized that the Avery Unit was stronger than the parents who created it.

"That was the Mall Rescue," Sarah recalled, adjusting her glasses.

"We extracted the assets," Freddie nodded, tightening his grip on Harper. "We secured the perimeter."

"And tomorrow," Jessica grinned, "we do it again. But without the crying parents. Tomorrow is just us. We're going to hit the town. We have a plan."

"What plan?" Jenna asked, eyes wide.

"Classified," Freddie said. "Security clearance level: Birthday."

Harper shifted on his lap, reaching out to grab a piece of bacon from the platter without getting down. Freddie didn't flinch. He just held her steady so she wouldn't fall.

He was home. The bus was gone. Vanessa was gone.

He had his army. And he was never letting them go.

Scene 8: Division of Labor

The breakfast dishes were cleared. The sun was climbing higher, heating up the vinyl siding of the house. Inside, the air conditioner hummed its steady, protective note.

In the entryway, Jessica was putting on her boots. Aunt Linda stood by the door with her purse, checking her shopping list.

"Okay, listen up," Jessica announced, addressing the troops in the living room. "Linda and I are initiating Operation: Sugar Rush. We are going to hit the grocery store and the party supply shop. We have to prep for the twin's 15th tomorrow."

"We need candles," Jenna shouted from the floor. "Fifteen of them. Don't skimp."

"Noted," Jessica said. She looked at Freddie.

He was sitting on the beige sofa. Paige was right next to him, her arm looped through his, her leg pressed against his thigh. She hadn't moved more than six inches from him since he woke up.

"Paige," Jessica asked, though she already knew the answer. "Do you want to come? We could use help carrying the soda."

"Negative," Paige said instantly. She tightened her grip on Freddie's arm. "I am remaining at Base. The Captain needs a co-pilot."

Jessica nodded. She saw the look in Paige's eyes—a hard, defensive glint. The Vanessa incident had rattled the cage. Paige wasn't just being affectionate; she was standing guard. She was the firewall, and she wasn't leaving the server unattended.

"Understood," Jessica said. "You have the con. Don't burn the house down."

"We will maintain status quo," Freddie promised.

"Now, for the rest of you," Jessica pointed to the younger sisters. "We have a logistics issue. Five girls, three days of travel clothes, and one weekend. We have a mountain of laundry."

Sarah sighed, pushing her glasses up her nose. "The Clothing Mountain."

"Exactly," Jessica said. "Sarah, Jenna, Harper. You are the Laundry Brigade. The machines are in the Underworld. Detergent is on the shelf. I want everything washed, dried, and folded by the time we get back."

"What about Amanda and Elara?" Jenna protested.

"They are nine," Jessica said. "They are assigned to Cuddle Duty. They help Freddie regulate. Now, move out."

Jessica and Linda walked out the door. The lock clicked shut.

Scene 9: The Laundry Brigade

The Laundry Brigade descended into the cool, concrete depths.

They carried baskets overflowing with flannel shirts, jeans, and colorful t-shirts. The pile was massive. It looked like a fabric explosion.

Sarah marched to the utility corner. The washer and dryer were sturdy, white metal beasts—older models, brand name Titan-Wash, known for being loud but indestructible.

"Okay," Sarah organized. "We sort by structural integrity. Jeans and heavy fabrics in Pile A. Shirts and delicates in Pile B. Socks and underwear in Pile C."

"This is boring," Jenna groaned, dumping her basket onto the floor in a chaotic heap. "Why do we have to separate them? Just shove it all in."

"Negative," Sarah corrected, channeling Freddie. "If you wash jeans with t-shirts, the zippers chew up the cotton. Do you want holes in your favorite shirt?"

Jenna rolled her eyes. "Fine, Lieutenant."

Harper stood by the dryer. She was trying very hard not to look at the Pittsburgh Toilet in the corner. It loomed there like a white porcelain monument to her shame. She kept her back to it, as if acknowledging its existence would make the memory of last night reappear.

"Harper," Sarah said kindly, noticing her staring at the wall. "Focus on the socks. Match them up."

"Right," Harper whispered. She sat on the concrete floor (far away from the toilet) and started sorting socks.

"How many loads?" Jenna asked, kicking a pile of jeans.

"At least four," Sarah calculated. "The washer capacity is limited. We'll be down here for hours."

"At least it's cool," Harper offered. "It's hot upstairs."

"And no parents," Jenna added, pouring a cup of Fresh-Breeze detergent into the machine. "Just us."

Sarah started the washer. KA-CHUNK. WHOOSH. The water began to fill, and the heavy agitator began to churn. The noise was significant—a rhythmic, mechanical thrum that echoed off the cinder blocks.

"Okay," Sarah said, sitting on an overturned milk crate. "First load is running. Now we wait. And fold."

Ten minutes passed. Jenna was pacing. She had finished a can of Citrus-Pop on the drive over and had just guzzled a bottle of water.

She stopped pacing. She did a little hop.

"Ugh," Jenna groaned. "My bladder is full."

She looked at the wooden stairs. They looked steep. Then she looked at the ceiling, imagining the hallway bathroom.

"Freddie said the upstairs bathroom is a 'bottleneck,' " Jenna noted. "And I don't feel like walking up there just to find out Aunt Linda is in there doing her hair."

Jenna turned and looked at the corner.

Harper froze. She watched Jenna look at the Pittsburgh Toilet.

"Jenna, don't," Harper whispered. "It's... out in the open."

"So?" Jenna shrugged. "We're all sisters. Besides, listen to that washer."

THUNKA-THUNKA-WHOOSH.

"It's loud," Jenna pointed out. "It's basically a sound barrier. Sonic privacy."

Jenna made a decision. She walked over to the toilet.

"Turn around, troops," Jenna commanded, waving her hand. "Eyes on the laundry."

Sarah calmly turned her back, picking up a flannel shirt to inspect a button. Harper hesitated, eyes wide, then quickly spun around to face the dryer.

"I am using the asset," Jenna announced dramatically.

Harper heard the rustle of denim. She heard the seat creak.

She waited for the shame. She waited for the awkwardness to suffocate the room.

But nothing happened. Sarah was humming to herself. The washer was roaring. Jenna was just... peeing.

"You know," Jenna called out casually from the corner, her voice echoing slightly. "This is actually kind of efficient. No doors to open. No waiting. It's a power move."

Harper blinked. Jenna wasn't dying of embarrassment. She was making a review.

"Flush incoming!" Jenna warned.

KA-WHOOSH.

The pipes banged, shaking the rafters.

Jenna walked back to the group, adjusting her jeans. She washed her hands in the utility sink with the bar of harsh yellow soap.

"See?" Jenna said, flicking water at Harper. "I survived. No lightning struck me."

Sarah looked at Harper over the rim of her glasses.

"It is a toilet, Harper," Sarah said, her voice gentle but practical. "It is a tool. If you have to go, you go. It doesn't matter if there are walls or not. Biology doesn't care about architecture."

"And honestly," Jenna added, sitting back down on a pile of dirty clothes. "Whatever happened last night? Forget it. If I'm willing to use it in broad daylight, you don't need to worry about using it in the dark."

Harper looked at the toilet. It didn't look like a monster anymore. It just looked like a toilet.

"Okay," Harper whispered. She relaxed her shoulders.

"Good," Sarah said. She tossed a pair of socks at Jenna. "Now get back to work. Pile C isn't going to sort itself."

The Laundry Brigade resumed operations. The washer churned, the dryer hummed, and the Pittsburgh Toilet sat in the corner—no longer a throne of shame, just another part of the plumbing.

Scene 10: The Anchor Point

Upstairs, the house was quiet, save for the muffled rumble of the washer below the floorboards.

Freddie sat on the sofa. He was completely surrounded.

- Port Side: Paige was glued to him. She was reading a book, but her head was on his shoulder, and her hand was holding his hand, tracing the lines of his palm.
- Starboard Side: Amanda sat cross-legged next to him. She was drawing in a sketchbook, occasionally resting her head on his knee to check in.
- Forward Position: Elara sat on the floor, leaning back against his legs, reading a comic book.

Freddie felt the weight of them. It was heavy. It was hot.

"Status?" Paige whispered, turning a page with her free hand.

"Grounding is at 100%," Freddie reported. "The signal is clear."

He looked at Paige. He saw the tension in her neck.

"You are guarding me," Freddie stated softly.

Paige didn't look up from her book. "She tried to get in, Freddie. She tried to take you."

"She failed," Freddie reminded her. "The math won."

"I know," Paige said. She looked up then, her eyes fierce. "But she made you doubt. She made you think you were broken. I felt it, Freddie. I felt your panic. I am not letting that happen again."

She squeezed his hand so hard it almost hurt.

"You are the Core," Paige whispered. "If the Core crashes, the whole system goes down. I am the firewall. No one touches you unless they have clearance."

Freddie looked at Amanda drawing on his left. He looked at Elara leaning on his legs. He looked at Paige.

"You have clearance," Freddie said. "All of you."

"Yeah," Paige softened, resting her head back on his shoulder. "We do."

Amanda looked up from her drawing. She saw the serious look on their faces. She put her pencil down.

She stood up on the sofa cushions. She climbed onto Freddie's lap, careful not to hurt his legs. She wrapped her arms around his neck and buried her face in his shirt.

"Anchoring," Elara narrated from the floor.

Freddie wrapped his free arm around Amanda. He held Paige's hand with the other.

"Anchoring received," Freddie whispered.

Downstairs, the washing machine hit the spin cycle, vibrating the floor. Upstairs, the Avery Unit held onto each other, refusing to let go, proving that the strongest gravity wasn't physics—it was family.

Scene 11: The Zero-Privacy Protocol

Two hours had passed. The pile of dirty clothes had shrunk, replaced by neat, geometric stacks of folded laundry on the folding table Sarah had set up.

The basement air was thick with the scent of Fresh-Breeze detergent and warm lint. The Titan-Wash machine was grinding through Load 3 (Heavy Denims), while the dryer tumbled Load 2 (Delicates).

Sarah wiped sweat from her forehead. "Status check," she announced, folding a pair of jeans with a sharp snap. "We are at 60% completion. The denim cycle is taking longer than anticipated."

"It's because Freddie wears those heavy carpenter jeans," Jenna noted, tossing a pair of socks into the 'orphan' pile. "They weigh a ton when they're wet."

Jenna reached for another can of Citrus-Pop. She cracked the tab. Hiss-snap.

"You know," Jenna said, taking a sip. "All this liquid input equals output."

She stood up. She didn't announce it dramatically this time. She just walked over to the corner.

Harper didn't flinch. She didn't turn around. She just kept matching socks.

"Turn up the radio," Jenna called out casually over her shoulder. "I don't need a soundtrack."

Sarah reached over and turned up the volume on the small boombox they had brought down. A pop song filled the basement, masking the sound.

Jenna used the Pittsburgh Toilet. She washed her hands. She came back.

"Next load," Jenna said, sitting back down as if she had just fetched a glass of water.

Ten minutes later, Sarah stood up. She dusted off her knees.

"My turn," Sarah stated pragmatically. "I'm not walking up two flights of stairs just to wait for Aunt Linda."

Sarah—the Lieutenant, the one who enforced the rules—walked to the corner. She didn't ask anyone to turn around. She trusted her squad.

Harper watched her out of the corner of her eye. She saw Sarah unbutton her jeans, sit down, and stare blankly at the furnace while she did her business. Sarah looked bored. She looked completely unbothered.

It really isn't a big deal, Harper realized. It's just us.

A few minutes later, the urge hit Harper again. The basement was cold, but the dryer made it warm, and the combination always made her have to go.

She stood up.

"I have to use the asset," Harper said, testing the words.

"Go for it," Jenna said, not looking up from a t-shirt she was folding. "Don't forget to flush."

Harper walked to the corner.

She lowered her pants. She sat on the cold porcelain.

She looked at her sisters. Jenna was tossing a shirt to Sarah. Sarah was stacking it. They were ten feet away. They could see her.

And they didn't care.

Harper relaxed. She let it go.

For the first time in her life, she felt a total absence of social anxiety. In the outside world—at school, at the mall—privacy was a fortress you had to defend. You locked doors. You checked for gaps in the stall. You died of shame if someone heard a noise.

But here, in the Avery Underworld, the walls were down.

We don't hide anything, Harper thought. We don't hide our bodies. We don't hide our problems. We don't hide Freddie.

She stood up, pulled up her pants, and flushed.

KA-WHOOSH.

The roar of the water was the sound of victory.

Harper washed her hands and walked back to the group. She sat down on the concrete.

"You know," Harper said, picking up a pair of Freddie's socks. "I think I like this toilet. It's honest."

"It's efficient," Sarah corrected, handing her another sock. "Now hurry up. The dryer is buzzing. Load 3 is ready for transfer."

The Laundry Brigade worked on. They rotated through the loads, and they rotated through the corner, bound together by soap, warm flannel, and the absolute freedom of having nothing left to hide.

Scene 12: Structural Integrity Test

While the Laundry Brigade conquered the mountains of denim in the basement, the living room had been transformed into a high-density affection zone.

Freddie sat in the center of the beige sofa. To an outside observer, he might have looked like a hostage. To Freddie, he felt like a tree that had been colonized by very aggressive, very loving wildlife.

Paige was the root system. She hadn't moved in an hour. She was pressed tight against his left side, her arm locked through his, her head resting heavily on his shoulder. She was reading a paperback with one hand, her thumb rhythmically stroking the side of his arm. She was the static variable—the unmoving anchor that kept him from floating away.

The twins, Amanda and Elara, were the dynamic variables.

"Scaling the north face!" Elara announced.

Elara (Age 9) had climbed up the back of the sofa. She draped herself over Freddie's shoulders like a human scarf, her chin resting on top of his head, her arms dangling loosely over his chest.

"Elara," Freddie noted, his voice vibrating through her chest. "You are obstructing my visual field."

"I'm a hat," Elara giggled, swinging her legs which were dangling behind his head. "I'm keeping your brain warm."

Amanda (Age 9) occupied the southern territory. She was kneeling on the sofa cushions on Freddie's right side. She wasn't content to just sit next to him; she treated him like a piece of playground equipment.

She climbed carefully onto his lap, avoiding his sensitive knees with practiced precision. She straddled his waist, facing him, and wrapped her arms around his neck. She pressed her forehead against his nose—her signature "Mind Meld."

Input Warning: Restriction of movement. Temperature critical. Oxygen intake reduced by 15%.

Freddie's logic brain flashed the red lights. He was completely immobilized. He had a sister on his left, a sister on his head, and a sister on his chest. He couldn't scratch his nose if he wanted to.

He closed his eyes. He took a breath, smelling the vanilla shampoo Elara used and the faint scent of crayons on Amanda's hands.

He compared this to the Pathfinder bus. He compared it to the empty apartment in Norfolk. He compared it to the cold, clinical way Vanessa had touched him—like he was a project to be fixed, not a person to be held.

This wasn't fixing. This was fusing.

"Status?" Paige asked softly, feeling his breathing shift under the weight of the twins. "Are they crushing you?"

"Structural integrity is holding," Freddie whispered. "The pressure is... acceptable."

Amanda pulled back from the Mind Meld. She looked at Freddie with wide, dark eyes. She took his glasses off his face and put them on her own. They were way too big; they slid down her nose instantly.

She smiled—a silent, gummy grin.

"She says you look like a bug with them on," Elara translated from the top of his head. "And she says you are squishy."

"I am not squishy," Freddie corrected, gently taking his glasses back from Amanda and sliding them back on. "I am resilient."

Amanda hummed a low note—Mmm-hmm—and collapsed forward, burying her face in the crook of his neck. She went boneless, turning into dead weight.

"Docking complete," Freddie murmured, wrapping his free arm around Amanda's back to keep her from sliding off.

"I want in," Elara decided.

She slid down from the top of his head, tumbling over his shoulder like a slinky, and wedged herself into the tiny gap between Freddie and the armrest on the right. She grabbed Freddie's right hand and started playing with his fingers, counting them one by one.

"One, two, three, four, thumb," Elara counted.

Freddie sat there. He was a lattice of limbs. He was the center of their universe.

"You know," Paige said, not looking up from her book, but squeezing his arm tighter. "Vanessa would hate this."

"She would categorize it as chaotic," Freddie agreed. "She would say it lacks boundaries."

"Do we have boundaries?" Elara asked, interlocking her fingers with Freddie's.

"Negative," Freddie said. "We have connections."

He rested his chin on top of Amanda's head. He leaned his cheek against Elara's hair. He felt Paige breathing against his ribs.

The sensory overload was massive. It was loud, hot, and heavy.

And Freddie wouldn't have traded it for all the silence in the world.

"Hold position," Freddie ordered softly.

"Aye aye, Captain," Elara whispered.

Amanda just squeezed him tighter.

The Jungle Gym was open, and it was never closing down.

Scene 13: The Rotation of the Guard

The front door opened with a rattle of keys. Jessica and Aunt Linda backed into the entryway, arms laden with plastic bags from the party store and the grocery market.

"Mission successful," Jessica announced, kicking the door shut with her heel. "We have enough sugar to kill a horse and... oh."

She stopped. Aunt Linda stopped beside her.

They looked at the living room.

It was a sculpture of human entanglement. Freddie was barely visible. He was the buried foundation of a structure built entirely of sisters.

- Paige was the immovable wall on his left, her arm locked through his, her eyes darting up to check the door before relaxing when she saw it was just them.
- Amanda was draped over his lap, asleep, her face pressed into his neck.
- Elara was perched on the back of the sofa, her arms wrapped around his forehead, her chin resting on his hair.

Aunt Linda set her bags down quietly. She watched them for a moment.

She knew what her sister, Ellen, would say. Ellen would purse her lips and talk about "propriety." She would say it was "unseemly" for a nineteen-year-old man

to be cuddling with his sisters like a litter of puppies. She would worry about what the neighbors thought.

She knew what Robert would say. He would clear his throat, uncomfortable with the emotion, and tell Freddie to "man up" and stop being a pillow.

And she knew what that girl Vanessa would say. She would call it "codependent." She would say it was "sick." She would try to cut the wires one by one to isolate the power source.

Linda looked at Freddie's face. His eyes were closed. He wasn't flinching. He wasn't grey and shaking like he had been after the divorce. He looked peaceful. He looked anchored.

Screw them, Linda thought fiercely. This isn't sick. This is survival.

Just then, the basement door creaked open.

The Laundry Brigade emerged. Sarah, Jenna, and Harper walked into the hallway, carrying baskets of warm, folded clothes. They smelled like Fresh-Breeze and victory.

They stopped. They looked at the sofa. They looked at the monopoly the twins held on Freddie.

Jenna put her hands on her hips. "Hey! We've been slaving away in the dungeon for three hours! We want in."

Elara tightened her grip on Freddie's head. "Squatter's rights!"

"Negative," Aunt Linda stepped in, her voice firm but kind. "We operate on a fair-trade policy in this house."

She walked over to the sofa. She reached out and gently poked Elara in the ribs.

"Okay, monkeys. Detach. You've had him all morning. The Laundry Brigade needs to recharge."

Amanda stirred, blinking sleepily. She looked at Linda, then at Harper standing by the laundry basket with a hopeful look on her face.

Amanda sighed—a long, dramatic exhale through her nose—and untangled herself from Freddie's neck. She climbed off his lap, patted his knee twice (a thank-you), and slid to the floor.

Elara groaned but slid down from the back of the sofa. "Fine. But I'm sitting next to Jessica."

"Deal," Jessica said, dropping onto the love seat.

The path was clear. Paige, of course, did not move. She shifted slightly to make room, but her grip on Freddie's left arm didn't loosen by a millimeter. She was the permanent fixture.

"Rotation initiated," Freddie announced softly, adjusting his glasses which Elara had knocked crooked.

Harper moved first. She needed this. After the shame of the Pittsburgh Toilet and the cold basement, she needed to know she was still welcome in the warm spot.

She walked over and sat exactly where Amanda had been—right on Freddie's lap. She was heavy, leggy, and awkward, but Freddie wrapped his right arm around her instantly, pulling her against his chest.

"Welcome back, Specialist," Freddie whispered into her hair.

Sarah sat on the coffee table in front of him, leaning forward to rest her forehead against his knee. "Laundry is at 100%. Socks are matched."

"Efficiency noted," Freddie said, reaching out to tap her shoulder.

Jenna flopped onto the sofa on his right side, wedging herself into the gap Elara had vacated. She grabbed Freddie's hand and threw her leg over his shins.

"We conquered the toilet, Freddie," Jenna bragged, closing her eyes. "We are warriors."

"You are a formidable unit," Freddie agreed.

Linda watched the pile reform. The faces changed, but the structure remained the same. Freddie was the core, and his sisters were the shielding.

"Okay," Linda whispered to Jessica, picking up the grocery bags again. "Let's get this ice cream in the freezer before it melts. I think the army is occupied for a while."

"Yeah," Jessica smiled, looking at her siblings. "They're good."

Linda looked one last time at Freddie, buried once again under a fresh set of sisters, looking happier than she had ever seen him.

Eat your heart out, Vanessa, Linda thought with a grim sense of satisfaction. You can't break this.

Scene 14: The Black Box Review

The laughter had died down. The ice cream was put away. Aunt Linda stood in the center of the living room, her hands clasped in front of her. She looked at the sprawling pile of happiness on the sofa, but her expression was serious.

"Alright," Aunt Linda announced. "I need the room."

The girls looked up.

"Laundry Brigade + Twins," Linda commanded. "Head to the Underworld. I need to speak to the Triad. Adults only."

Harper groaned, clinging to Freddie's shirt. "But I just got back on! I'm comfortable!"

"Harper," Linda said, her voice dropping that specific octave that meant business. "Basement. Now."

Sarah and Jenna stood up immediately. They recognized the tone. This wasn't a punishment; it was a debriefing. They grabbed Amanda and Elara.

"Come on," Sarah said, pulling Harper up by her arm. "Let's go play cards."

Harper pouted, her lower lip trembling slightly as she looked at Freddie, but she let go. She trudged after her sisters. The basement door clicked shut.

Silence descended on the living room.

Linda pulled the ottoman over to the sofa and sat down, so she was knee-to-knee with Freddie.

Freddie was still in the center of the sofa. Paige was clamped to his left side. Jessica had moved from the love seat to his right side, taking the space Jenna had vacated. They sandwiched him.

"So," Linda said softly, looking Freddie in the eye. "We've done the food. We've done the laundry. We've done the distraction."

She leaned forward.

"Talk to me, Freddie. Really talk to me. What did she do to you?"

Freddie felt the air pressure in the room drop. His heart rate spiked. Warning: Accessing Corrupted Files.

He felt Paige's hand tighten on his bicep. He felt Jessica's hand cover his on his knee.

"She... reconfigured the narrative," Freddie whispered, staring at his hands.

"How?" Linda asked.

"She told me I was a parasite," Freddie said. The word hung in the air, ugly and clinical. "She said that my reliance on the Unit was preventing Jessica and Paige from executing their primary functions."

He took a shaky breath.

"She said Jessica wanted to move to New York," Freddie continued, his voice trembling. "To work in fashion. To be successful. She said I was the reason Jessica was stuck in 'muddy Virginia.' "

Jessica squeezed his hand so hard her knuckles turned white. "She lied, Freddie. I hate New York. It smells like garbage and anxiety."

"She said Paige wanted Italy," Freddie went on, tears pricking his eyes. "To study Art History. To live in a villa. She said Paige was only staying here... out of pity. Because I couldn't function alone."

"I have never wanted to go to Italy without you," Paige hissed, her voice furious. "Never."

"I know," Freddie choked out. "I know that now. But then... the data felt real. She isolated me. She repeated the input until it became truth."

He looked up at Linda. His glasses were fogging up.

"She made me write a note," Freddie confessed. A tear escaped, tracking down his cheek. "A suicide note. She dictated it. She told me to write that I was 'setting them free.' That I was deleting myself so they could live."

Linda's face went pale. She brought a hand to her mouth.

"I was going to do it," Freddie whispered, his body starting to shake. "I was on the bus. I was going to wait until we got to Seattle, sign the papers she wanted... and then terminate the connection. I thought... I thought I was saving them."

The shaking became violent. The "Pasco Memory" tried to surface—the cold, the fear, the emptiness.

"Ground him," Jessica ordered sharply.

It happened instantly.

Paige threw her leg over his, pinning him to the sofa. She buried her face in his neck. "You are here. You are here. You are here."

Jessica wrapped both arms around his chest from the other side, crushing him between them. "Overwrite, Freddie. Overwrite the data. We came for you."

"You came," Freddie sobbed, collapsing into them. "You flew to Seattle. You found me."

"We will always find you," Paige promised fiercely. "There is no distance we won't travel."

"We turned it into a vacation," Freddie gasped, struggling to regulate his breathing. "We went to the Sky-Spire. We ate fish. We overwrote the bad data with good data."

"Yes," Jessica whispered into his ear. "We fixed it."

"I am never leaving," Freddie vowed, his voice breaking. "I am never leaving the Unit again. I cannot survive the silence."

They held him for a long time. The only sound in the room was Freddie's ragged breathing and the steady hum of the air conditioner.

Finally, the shaking stopped. The pressure of his sisters—the sheer physical weight of their love—forced the panic back into its box.

Aunt Linda reached out. She placed her hand gently on Freddie's knee, right on top of Jessica's hand.

"She was a monster, Freddie," Linda said, her voice shaking with suppressed rage. "What she did... that wasn't love. That was torture."

She looked at the three of them. She saw how they were tangled together. She saw how Paige was practically sitting in his lap, how Jessica was shielding him.

She knew what the world would say. She knew what psychologists might say about "enmeshment."

"I know you three sleep together," Linda said suddenly.

Freddie froze. Paige tensed up, ready to fight.

"I saw the bed in the Master room," Linda continued calmly. "I saw the pillows. And I know you've been doing it since you got back."

She looked Freddie dead in the eye.

"Does it stop the nightmares?" Linda asked.

"Yes," Freddie whispered. "When I feel them... the terror cannot manifest."

"Does it make you feel safe?" Linda asked.

"Yes," Freddie said. "It is the only time the system fully powers down."

Linda nodded. She sat back on the ottoman.

"Then to hell with anyone who has a problem with it," Linda declared.

Paige blinked. "Really?"

"Really," Linda said firmly. "After what you've been through? After almost losing him? If sleeping in a puppy pile keeps him here, on this earth, safe and sound... then you buy a bigger bed if you have to."

She smiled, a sad, weary smile.

"Ellen would hate it," Linda noted. "Which makes me like it even more."

Freddie let out a wet, shaky laugh. He wiped his eyes on his shoulder.

"Thank you, Aunt Linda," Freddie said.

"Don't thank me," Linda said, standing up and smoothing her skirt. "Just promise me one thing."

"Anything," Freddie said.

"Don't you ever believe you're a burden," Linda said, pointing a finger at him. "You aren't the anchor holding them down, Freddie. You're the gravity holding them together. Look at them."

Freddie looked. He saw Paige, fierce and protective. He saw Jessica, strong and steady.

"Without you," Linda said, "they drift away. You keep them home."

She walked to the basement door.

"Now," Linda said, her voice lightening. "I'm going to release the prisoners before Harper claws through the drywall. Are you good?"

Freddie took a deep breath. He felt the weight of his sisters. He felt the truth of Linda's words.

"Status," Freddie whispered.

"Green," Paige answered.

"Green," Jessica answered.

"Optimal," Freddie confirmed.

Scene 15: Clearance Denied

The door at the top of the stairs clicked shut, sealing the younger sisters in the concrete bunker.

Sarah sighed and sat down on her air mattress, shuffling a deck of worn playing cards. Jenna cracked open another soda, leaning against the dryer. Amanda and Elara were on the floor, building a tower out of plastic cups they had found in the pantry.

But Harper didn't sit down.

She stood at the bottom of the wooden staircase, staring up at the door. Her hand gripped the banister.

"Come on, Harper," Sarah called out, dealing the cards onto the sleeping bag. "Crazy Eights. You're in."

"I don't want to play," Harper whispered. She took a step up. The wood creaked.

"Harper, stop," Jenna warned. "Aunt Linda said to stay down here."

"I just want to listen," Harper said, taking another step. "I want to know what they're saying. Why did they make us leave? We're part of the Unit too."

"It's adult business," Sarah said, flipping a card. "That means boring stuff. Taxes. Insurance. The divorce."

"It's not taxes," Harper insisted. She climbed two more steps, putting her ear close to the gap under the door.

For a moment, there was only the low rumble of voices—Aunt Linda's calm tone, Freddie's soft murmur.

Then, the sound changed.

It wasn't a word. It was a sound Harper had never heard before. It was a ragged, high-pitched gasp. Then a sob. A deep, wrenching sound that vibrated through the floorboards.

Harper froze. Her eyes went wide.

"He's crying," Harper whispered, her voice trembling. "Freddie is crying."

On the floor, Amanda stopped stacking cups. She looked up at the ceiling, her expression darkening. Elara frowned, dropping a red cup.

"He never cries," Harper said, panic rising in her chest. "He didn't cry when he fell. He didn't cry when Mom yelled. Why is he crying?"

Another sob filtered down—a sound of pure, raw heartbreak.

"I have to go," Harper decided.

She scrambled up the stairs, her feet thumping on the wood. "I have to fix it! He needs a cuddle!"

"Harper, no!"

Sarah moved fast. She vaulted off the air mattress and sprinted to the stairs. Jenna was right behind her.

Harper reached for the doorknob.

"Let me out!" Harper yelled. "He's sad! I can help!"

Sarah grabbed Harper's ankle through the railing. Jenna grabbed the back of her shirt. They hauled her backward.

"No!" Harper kicked, tears springing to her own eyes. "Let go! He needs me! I fit in his lap! I can make it better!"

"You can't go up there!" Sarah hissed, wrapping her arms around Harper's waist and pulling her down to the concrete floor. "Aunt Linda said stay out!"

"But he's hurt!" Harper sobbed, struggling against Sarah's grip. "Listen to him! He sounds broken!"

"He is broken!" Jenna snapped, her voice cracking slightly as she helped pin Harper down. "That's why they're talking! They're fixing him!"

"I can fix him!" Harper screamed.

"No, you can't!" Sarah shouted, finally wrestling Harper into a sitting position on the bottom step. "You're eleven, Harper! You can't fix this!"

The basement went silent, except for Harper's heavy breathing and the muffled sounds of Freddie weeping upstairs.

Sarah took a deep breath, adjusting her glasses. She looked at Harper, whose face was red and wet with tears.

"Listen to me," Sarah said, her voice shaking but firm. "Freddie has... bad data. From the bad girl. From Vanessa."

Harper sniffled. "The one he ran away from?"

"Yes," Sarah said. "She put bad things in his head. And now... he has to get them out. And getting them out hurts. It's like... it's like popping a blister. It hurts before it heals."

"But why can't I hold him?" Harper whined, wiping her nose on her sleeve. "He likes it when I hold him."

"Because right now," Jenna said softly, sitting down next to them, "he needs the Triad. He needs Paige and Jessica and Aunt Linda. They have... higher clearance."

"Clearance?" Harper asked small voice.

"Yeah," Sarah nodded, using Freddie's word. "Level 1 Clearance. We are Level 2. We handle the laundry. We handle the cuddles after. But the Triad handles the heavy stuff."

Harper looked at the top of the stairs. She could still hear the faint sounds of comfort—Jessica's voice low and soothing, Paige's fierce whispering.

"Is he going to be okay?" Harper whispered.

Amanda walked over. She stood in front of Harper. She reached out and patted Harper's head, then pointed to the ceiling and gave a thumbs up.

"Amanda says yes," Elara translated from the floor. "She says the bad noise is stopping."

Harper listened. The sobbing had quieted. It was replaced by a steady, low murmur. The storm had passed.

"Okay," Harper whispered. She leaned her head on Sarah's shoulder. "I hate Level 2."

"Me too," Sarah admitted, wrapping an arm around her little sister. "Being a kid sucks. You don't know anything."

"But we know he's safe," Jenna reminded them. "He's upstairs. He's not on a bus."

"Yeah," Harper sighed. She looked at the cards scattered on the sleeping bag. "Can I be the dealer?"

"Sure," Sarah said, standing up and pulling Harper with her. "But if you cheat, I'm telling Freddie."

"I never cheat," Harper lied, wiping her eyes.

They went back to the circle. They played cards in the cool, grey light of the Underworld, waiting for the signal that the adults were done and the Captain was ready for his Satellites again.

The card table was a blue sleeping bag pulled taut over the concrete floor. The five sisters sat cross-legged around it in a circle.

Sarah shuffled the deck. She did it the way Freddie did—a perfect bridge shuffle that made a satisfying thwip-thwip-thwip sound.

"Game is Crazy Eights," Sarah announced, dealing five cards to each player. "Eights are wild. Twos are pickup-two. Queens are skip. Acetaminophen rules."

"It's 'Aces High,' not 'Acetaminophen,' " Jenna corrected, picking up her hand and fanning it out. "You spend too much time reading Freddie's medical dictionaries."

"Standard rules apply," Sarah ignored her. "And since we have five players, we are using two decks mixed together. The draw pile is heavy."

Harper picked up her cards. She held them close to her chest, shielding them from Jenna's prying eyes.

She looked at her hand: Two Hearts, a King of Spades, a Five of Diamonds, a Seven of Clubs, and... the Eight of Hearts. The magic card.

Usually, this was the part where Harper would slide the Seven of Clubs under her leg. Or maybe she would cough and accidentally-on-purpose drop a bad card into the discard pile when no one was looking. Cheating was her way of leveling the playing field against the older, smarter twins.

She glanced at Jenna. Jenna was distracted, trying to crack her knuckles.

Harper's thumb hovered over the Seven. She could drop it. It would be so easy.

Then she looked up at the ceiling.

It was quiet upstairs now. The crying had stopped. Freddie was recovering.

She remembered Sarah's threat. If you cheat, I'm telling Freddie.

Harper imagined Freddie's face. Not angry—he never really got angry. But disappointed. She imagined him looking at her with those sad eyes behind his glasses and saying, "Your data is corrupt, Harper."

She didn't want to be corrupt. She wanted to be Level 1. She wanted to be worthy of the hug she was going to get when the door opened.

Harper tightened her grip on the cards. She pushed the Seven back into the fan.

I'm playing clean, she told herself. I'm going to win for real.

"Play commences," Sarah stated. She flipped the top card: Four of Diamonds.

"Boom," Jenna said, slapping down a Four of Spades. "Match."

Amanda and Elara (playing as a single team) whispered to each other. Elara nodded. Amanda placed a Four of Hearts on the pile.

"Stop changing the suit!" Jenna groaned. "I was hoarding Spades!"

It was Harper's turn. The suit was Hearts. She had a Two of Hearts.

"Pickup two, Sarah," Harper said, slapping the card down.

Sarah glared at her over her glasses. "Aggressive."

Sarah drew two cards. "Fine. My turn."

The game moved fast. Cards slapped against the sleeping bag. The tension in the basement shifted from "scared listening" to "competitive focus."

Five minutes later, it was down to the wire.

Jenna had one card left. She was grinning, bouncing her leg. "UNO! Wait, wrong game. Last card!"

"Don't get cocky," Sarah muttered, checking her own hand of three cards.

The twins played a Queen.

"Skip Jenna!" Elara shouted.

"Hey!" Jenna yelled. "That's sabotage!"

"Strategy," Elara smirked. Amanda high-fived her.

The play passed Jenna. It came to Harper.

Harper looked at her hand. She had the Eight of Hearts. The wild card.

The current pile was a Queen of Diamonds.

Harper looked at Jenna, who was clutching her single, winning card (which Harper was 90% sure was a Spade).

If Harper played the Eight, she could change the suit to anything. She could change it to Hearts. Jenna didn't have Hearts. Jenna would have to draw.

Harper played the card.

"Eight," Harper announced clearly. "Suit is Hearts."

Jenna's jaw dropped. She looked at her last card (the King of Spades). She looked at Harper.

"You little..." Jenna narrowed her eyes. "You peeked! You saw my hand!"

"I didn't!" Harper shot back, sitting up straight. "I didn't look! I just guessed because you were complaining about Hearts earlier!"

Jenna looked at Sarah. "She cheated. Lieutenant, execute her."

Sarah paused. She looked at Harper. She studied Harper's face—the defiant chin, the wide, honest eyes, the hands placed flat on the sleeping bag where everyone could see them.

Sarah had been watching. Harper hadn't dropped a card. She hadn't leaned over. She had played a perfect, clean game.

"Negative," Sarah ruled. "Her play was valid. Logic dictates you were hoarding Spades. Harper intercepted the pattern."

Sarah smiled a tiny, proud smile.

"Good kill, Harper."

Harper beamed. She felt lighter than air. She beat Jenna, and she didn't have to hide anything.

"Draw, Jenna," Harper commanded, pointing to the deck.

Jenna groaned and snatched a card from the pile. "I hate this game. I hate Level 2."

Upstairs, the floorboards creaked. Heavy footsteps moved toward the basement door.

The lock clicked. The door opened.

"Coast is clear!" Aunt Linda's voice called down, sounding cheerful and relieved. "Who wants ice cream?"

Harper threw her cards into the air—ruining the game instantly.

"ME!" she screamed.

She scrambled up, abandoning the victory for the prize she really wanted. She bolted up the stairs, past Aunt Linda, and ran straight into the living room.

Freddie was still sitting on the sofa, sandwiched between Paige and Jessica. His eyes were red, and he looked tired, but when he saw Harper, he opened his arms.

"Come to port," Freddie whispered.

Harper launched herself at him. She climbed into his lap and buried her face in his neck, smelling the soap and the salt of his tears.

"I didn't cheat," Harper whispered fiercely into his ear. "I played honest. I promise."

Freddie held her tight, resting his chin on her head.

"I believe you," Freddie said. "Good girl."

The force of Harper's hug knocked the wind out of him, but Freddie didn't pull away. He adjusted his grip, wrapping his arms around her waist to secure her. She was trembling against him, her face pressed so hard into his shoulder that he could feel the dampness of her tears soaking through his flannel shirt.

Paige reached out and rubbed Harper's back. Jessica leaned in, resting her chin on Freddie's shoulder, watching the youngest sister with a soft, sad expression.

"I heard you," Harper whispered into his neck, her voice thick with mucus and emotion. "I heard you through the floor. It sounded like you were hurting."

Freddie took a steadying breath. He didn't try to lie. He didn't try to say 'I wasn't crying' or 'It was just allergies.' Harper was smart. She dealt in facts, just like him.

"I was hurting," Freddie admitted, his voice low and rumbling against her ear. "But it was a necessary hurt. Like resetting a bone."

Harper pulled back just an inch. She looked at him. Her eyes were red, but they were sharp. She scanned his face, looking for the cracks.

"It was her, wasn't it?" Harper said. It wasn't a question. "The girl from the porch. Vanessa."

Freddie blinked. He looked at Aunt Linda, who was standing by the kitchen door. Linda gave a small, barely perceptible nod. She knows.

"Yes," Freddie said. "She introduced... significant errors into my system."

"She tricked you," Harper stated firmly. She wiped her nose with the back of her hand. "She made you think we didn't want you. That's why you went on the bus."

Freddie felt a pang in his chest. He hadn't realized how much she had pieced together from the whispers and the tension.

"She did," Freddie whispered. "I thought I was... taking up too much space. I thought you would be better off without the extra weight."

Harper frowned. Her eyebrows scrunched together in a way that looked exactly like Jessica.

"That's stupid," Harper declared.

Freddie let out a tiny, surprised huff of laughter. "Is it?"

"Yeah," Harper said. "You're the Captain. The satellites fall out of orbit without the planet. You can't just leave."

She reached up and touched his cheek, her fingers sticky from the card game but warm.

"Besides," Harper added, her voice dropping to a conspiratorial whisper. "Jessica and Paige went and got you. They flew on a plane. That means you're worth a lot of money."

"They rescued the asset," Freddie agreed, glancing at his twin. Paige smiled, squeezing his arm.

"So you're fixed now?" Harper asked, looking deep into his eyes behind his glasses. "The bad thoughts are gone?"

"The data has been overwritten," Freddie promised. "I told Aunt Linda everything. We purged the system. I am empty of the bad stuff."

He squeezed her tighter.

"And now I am refilling the space with good stuff. Like you."

Harper relaxed. Her shoulders dropped. The panic that had driven her up the stairs evaporated, replaced by the heavy, sleepy comfort of being exactly where she wanted to be.

"Good," Harper murmured, resting her head back on his shoulder. "Don't let her back in. She's banned."

"Banned for life," Jessica confirmed from his right side.

The basement door opened again. Sarah, Jenna, Amanda, and Elara filed out. They saw Harper safe in Freddie's lap. They saw Freddie's dry eyes. They saw the calm returning to the room.

"Status?" Sarah asked, adjusting her glasses.

"Stable," Freddie announced.

"Excellent," Aunt Linda clapped her hands together, breaking the heavy mood. "Because I believe I promised ice cream. And I have a gallon of Mountain-Peak Vanilla and a gallon of Fudge-Swirl melting on the counter."

"Ice cream!" Elara cheered.

Harper shifted on Freddie's lap. She didn't get down.

"Can I eat mine here?" Harper asked. "I don't want to move."

Freddie looked at Jessica. Jessica shrugged, smiling. "It's a flannel shirt, Freddie. It washes."

"Affirmative," Freddie said to Harper. "You remain at port. I will request a delivery."

"I'll get it," Paige said, standing up and pressing a kiss to the top of Freddie's head. "One bowl of fudge swirl, coming up."

Freddie sat back against the beige cushions. He held Harper. He listened to his sisters arguing over bowls in the kitchen. He felt the phantom weight of the suicide note dissolving in his memory, replaced by the very real weight of an eleven-year-old girl who refused to let him go.

He was home.

The Big One-Five

Scene 1: Trajectory Calculations

The house was buzzing. The twins were officially fifteen.

In the kitchen, Sarah was demonstrating her "Suffocation Protocol" on a lit match over the sink, just to show off to Harper. She licked her fingers, pinched the flame, and grinned as the smoke curled up.

"See?" Sarah said. "Physics. The moisture absorbs the thermal energy."

Freddie and Paige, sitting at the kitchen table, recoiled in unison. They both pulled their hands into their sleeves.

"Negative," Freddie said, shaking his head. "That is thermal insanity. I require my nerve endings."

"Agreed," Paige shivered, leaning against him. "I prefer blowing. Or water. Touching fire is a glitch."

"It's efficient!" Sarah argued.

"It's terrifying," Jenna countered, walking in. "Okay, enough science class. Jessica said we're going out. Where are we going?"

Jessica walked in, twirling the keys to the sedan. Aunt Linda jingled the keys to the minivan.

"Since you are now fifteen," Jessica announced, "and technically adults-in-training, we decided against the kiddie pizza palace. We are going to Galaxy Lanes."

"Bowling?" Jenna pumped her fist. "Yes! I'm gonna crush you, Sarah."

"We shall see," Sarah said coolly, adjusting her glasses. "Bowling is just geometry with heavy spheres."

Freddie hesitated. He looked down at his wheelchair. He looked at his hands, which weren't strong enough to swing a ten-pound ball.

"I will... observe," Freddie suggested. "I can keep score."

"Nope," Jessica grinned. "You're playing, Captain. They have technology."

Scene 2: The Ramp

The bowling alley smelled of floor wax, rental shoes, and greasy fries. It was a cacophony of crashing pins, arcade bells, and synth-pop music.

To **Freddie**, it was chaos. But it was good chaos. It was the sound of people having fun, not the sound of people fighting.

They secured two lanes at the end of the row.

Jessica walked up to the control console. She looked at the blinking green screen.

"Okay," Jessica announced to the group. "Since we have players ranging from age nine to... well, Aunt Linda... and since we are here to celebrate, not to suffer, I am activating the **Safety Protocol**."

She pressed a button. Bumper Rails: ON.

HISSS-CLACK.

Down the length of both Lane 1 and Lane 2, long black rubber rails rose up from the gutters. They snapped into place, effectively sealing off the trench on either side.

"Bumpers!" **Harper** cheered, jumping up and down. "Pinball bowling!"

"Hey!" **Jenna** protested, crossing her arms. "I don't need bumpers. I'm fifteen."

"You threw three gutter balls in a row last time," **Sarah** reminded her, adjusting her glasses. "The data supports the bumpers."

"Besides," **Aunt Linda** laughed, lacing up her shoes. "It makes the game faster. No one likes watching a ball roll into the sewer."

Freddie rolled his wheelchair up to the approach on Lane 2. He looked at the long wooden lane. With the bumpers up, it looked less like a challenge and more like a chute. A safe path.

"I approve," Freddie stated, looking at the black rails. "It is a containment field. The error margin is reduced to zero."

"Exactly," Jessica grinned. "You literally can't miss. Now, let's get you set up."

She dragged over the metal ramp—**The Launcher**.

"Okay, Captain," **Paige** said, grabbing a six-pound orange ball. "You have the ramp. You have the bumpers. Do your worst."

Freddie leaned forward. He studied the geometry.

Without the bumpers, he would have had to aim for a perfect center line. But with the bumpers... he could get creative.

"Angle the ramp ten degrees to the right," Freddie instructed.

"Right?" Jessica asked. "That points at the wall."

"Trust the ricochet," Freddie said.

Jessica shifted the ramp. Freddie placed the orange ball at the top. He held it with one hand. He waited for the lane to clear.

"Launch," Freddie whispered.

He let go.

The ball rumbled down the metal ramp—clank-clank-clank. It hit the wood and rolled slowly toward the right side.

"It's gonna hit the rail," Jenna critiqued from the next lane.

THUMP.

The ball hit the right bumper. It bounced off the rubber at a sharp angle, redirecting toward the left.

THUMP.

It hit the left bumper. It zig-zagged back toward the center.

It was a slow-motion pinball game. The ball wove back and forth, gathering no speed but maintaining its forward momentum.

It reached the pins. It hit the head pin on a perfect, glancing angle.

CRASH.

The pins toppled. Because the ball was moving slowly, they didn't explode; they fell over like dominos, knocking each other down in a lazy, satisfying cascade.

STRIKE.

The overhead monitor flashed a cheesy animation of a bowling pin dancing.

"Geometry!" Freddie announced, raising a fist.

"That was total luck!" Jenna yelled.

"Calculated trajectory," Freddie corrected. "The bumpers are part of the equation."

The younger sisters took the lane next.

Amanda and **Elara** (Lane 1) took full advantage of the rails. They didn't even try to aim. They just hurled the ball as hard as they could. Their balls bounced 4, 5, sometimes 6 times before hitting the pins.

PING-PONG-PING-PONG-CRASH.

They giggled maniacally every time it hit a rail.

Even **Harper** found her confidence. Usually, she was afraid of messing up. But with the rails up, she couldn't fail. She stepped up, closed her eyes, and bowled a spare.

Paige sat next to Freddie while Aunt Linda took her turn.

"You like the bumpers?" Paige asked, handing him a soda.

"Affirmative," Freddie said, watching the ball bounce safely down the lane. "It prevents the 'gutter' scenario. It keeps the object in play."

He looked at his sisters—laughing, high-fiving, safe within the lane.

"It is... a good system," Freddie decided. "We should keep the bumpers up."

"Don't worry," Paige smiled, squeezing his shoulder. "We are the bumpers. You aren't going in the gutter, Freddie. Not on our watch."

Freddie watched his orange ball return through the ball return machine.

Safe return, he thought. Always.

Scene 3: The Arcade Intervention

After two games (Freddie won the second one thanks to his "ramp precision"), the group migrated to the arcade section.

It was a flashy area filled with flashing lights and ticket munchers.

Sarah and Jenna went straight for the Rhythm-Mat-Mania machine. They were fifteen now; they had to prove their coordination. They stomped on the flashing arrows on the metal platform, laughing as they missed the beats of the techno music.

Harper took the twins (Amanda and Elara) to play Alley-Roller (the game where you roll wooden balls up a ramp into numbered rings).

Freddie and Paige rolled over to the Claw Machine.

It was filled with generic plush aliens.

"Remember the blue bear?" Paige asked, leaning on the joystick console next to him.

"Affirmative," Freddie said. "The Mall Rescue."

"We did good today," Paige said, watching Sarah and Jenna laughing on the dance floor. "They're happy. They aren't thinking about Mom and Dad."

"We successfully diverted the narrative," Freddie agreed.

Just then, a loud noise erupted from the Velocity-X racing game nearby. A kid lost his game and kicked the machine hard. BANG.

Freddie flinched. His hands flew up to cover his ears. The sudden, violent noise triggered a flash of the "bad data"—the shouting, the bus engine.

Paige reacted instantly. She didn't make a scene. She just stepped in front of him, blocking his view of the angry kid. She placed her hands on his hands (which were over his ears).

"Focus on me," Paige said. Her voice was calm. "Look at the aliens."

Freddie looked at the claw machine. He looked at Paige's face.

"Green alien," Paige said. "Top left corner. Do you see it?"

Freddie focused. "Affirmative. Three eyes."

“Target acquired,” Paige smiled. “Let’s get it.”

She guided his hand to the joystick. She kept her other hand on his shoulder, grounding him.

“You steer,” Paige said. “I’ll hit the button.”

Freddie took a breath. The loud kid was gone. The noise faded into the background. He focused on the claw.

He moved the stick. Whirrr. He adjusted the angle. Whirrr.

“Drop,” Freddie whispered.

Paige slammed the red button.

The claw dropped. It grabbed the green alien by its bulbous head. It lifted. It held.

Plunk.

Freddie reached into the prize chute and pulled out the cheap, neon-green alien. He handed it to Paige.

“For the co-pilot,” Freddie said.

Paige took it. She squeezed it, then she squeezed his hand.

“Thanks, Captain.”

They turned back to watch their sisters. Sarah had just tripped over her own feet on the rhythm machine, and Jenna was laughing so hard she was crying. Aunt Linda was buying everyone sodas.

“Mission status?” Paige asked.

Freddie looked at the green alien in her hand, and the smile on Jenna’s face.

“Victory,” Freddie said.

Scene 4: The Carbohydrate Loading

The convoy returned to Base. The minivan and the sedan pulled into the driveway, unloading nine tired, hungry, but victorious Averys. The adrenaline of the bowling alley was wearing off, replaced by the primal need for fuel.

Aunt Linda dropped her purse on the counter. “Okay, birthday girls. You have the conn. What is the menu?”

Jenna didn’t hesitate. “I want grease. I want cheese. I want Tony’s.”

Sarah adjusted her glasses. “Pizza is the most logical caloric distribution system for a group of this magnitude. It minimizes dishwashing protocols.”

“Pizza it is,” Jessica agreed, grabbing the cordless phone and the thick phone book. “But we have a conflict of interest. What are the toppings?”

This was the annual debate.

"I want the Garbage Truck," Jenna declared. "Sausage, pepperoni, onions, peppers, mushrooms, jalapenos. If it fell on the floor, I want it on the pie."

"Disgusting," Sarah wrinkled her nose. "I require structural integrity. I want the White Garden. Garlic sauce, spinach, chicken. No tomato interference."

"And the rest of the troops?" Jessica asked, looking at the younger ones.

"Plain cheese!" Harper, Amanda, and Elara shouted in unison.

"And for the Captain?" Jessica looked at Freddie, who was parked at the head of the table, with Paige already sitting next to him.

"Standard pepperoni," Freddie requested. "Predictable variables."

"Okay," Jessica dialed the number. "One Garbage Truck, one White Garden, two large Cheese, one Pepperoni. And... five liters of soda. God help us."

The doorbell rang.

The delivery driver was a teenager named Kyle. He stood on the porch holding five massive, steaming cardboard boxes. He looked terrified as the door opened and he was greeted not by an adult, but by a wall of excited girls.

"Pizza!" Elara screamed.

"Make a hole!" Jenna shouted, grabbing the top two boxes. "Hazardous materials coming through!"

They loaded the dining room table. It was a tight squeeze. The table was extended to its limit, but with nine people and five pizzas, there was barely room for elbows.

The Seating Chart:

- Head of Table: Freddie (The Core).
- Right Flank: Paige (The Anchor). She served Freddie his slice (Pepperoni), cutting it into strips for him so he didn't have to struggle with the floppy crust.
- Left Flank: Jessica (The Shield).
- Center Stage: Sarah and Jenna (The Birthday Girls).
- The Satellites: Harper, Amanda, Elara, and Aunt Linda filled in the gaps.

"A toast!" Aunt Linda announced, raising a red plastic cup of Citrus-Pop.

Everyone raised their cups (or juice boxes).

"To Sarah and Jenna," Linda smiled. "Fifteen. You survived middle school. You survived the move. You survived the... family drama."

"We survived the genes," Jenna grinned, taking a massive bite of her loaded pizza. A piece of sausage fell onto her plate. "Oops. Casualty."

"To the Unit," Sarah corrected, clinking her cup against Freddie's. "Status: Operational."

"Operational," Freddie agreed, taking a bite of his pepperoni slice.

The room filled with the sounds of chewing, laughing, and the specific chaos of a large family dinner.

Jenna ate with enthusiasm, getting sauce on her chin. Sarah ate methodically, folding her thin-crust white pizza in half to prevent spillage. Harper tried to see how far she could stretch the cheese from her slice before it snapped (record: 14 inches).

Freddie sat in the middle of it all.

He watched Amanda steal a pepperoni off Elara's plate. He watched Paige wipe a crumb off his own shirt before he even noticed it was there. He listened to Jenna describing her "epic" strike in frame 7 (conveniently forgetting the bumpers).

He felt full. Not just from the pizza, but from the noise.

"Freddie," Harper called out from the end of the table. "Do you like the pepperoni?"

"Affirmative," Freddie said. "The spice level is nominal. The crust is optimal."

"Good," Harper beamed. "Because we saved you the last piece."

Freddie looked at the decimated boxes. They were greasy cardboard skeletons now. But true to her word, in the center of the pepperoni box, one single slice remained, guarded by Harper like a treasure.

"Thank you, Harper," Freddie smiled.

The boxes were cleared. The table was wiped down (mostly).

"Okay," Jessica stood up, exchanging a quick, subtle glance with Aunt Linda. "The main course is demolished. Now, for the procedure."

"Procedure?" Jenna asked, burping quietly.

"The Cake Protocol," Jessica said seriously. "Now, listen. Linda and I discussed this. We know you guys wanted fifteen individual candles."

"Yeah," Jenna nodded. "One for every year of suffering."

"Well," Jessica sighed, shaking her head. "We did a risk assessment. Fifteen open flames in a small room with this many people wearing flannel? It's a fire hazard. The insurance won't cover it."

Sarah pushed her glasses up. “That is a valid safety concern. The heat output of fifteen wicks could trigger the smoke detector. Furthermore, the melted wax distribution would ruin the icing integrity.”

“Exactly,” Jessica said, keeping her face perfectly neutral. “So, we compromised. We got the big number candles. A ‘1’ and a ‘5’. It’s safer. Less fire. Easier to blow out.”

“Boring,” Jenna rolled her eyes. “But fine. Bring out the sugar.”

“Prepare the table,” Aunt Linda commanded. “Lights out!”

Harper ran to the light switch. The room plunged into darkness, save for the ambient street light filtering through the front window.

Jessica went into the kitchen. She struck a match.

Fzzzt.

She lit the large blue 1. She lit the large blue 5.

The wicks caught, and the numbers glowed with a steady yellow flame.

Jessica lifted the heavy sheet cake.

“Incoming!” Jessica sang out, walking the glowing cake into the dining room.

Scene 5: Pyrotechnic Redundancy

The dining table was a disaster zone of empty Tony’s Pizza boxes, crumpled napkins, and drained soda cans. Nine people had just consumed enough carbohydrates to fuel a small power plant.

The noise level was severe. Jenna was recounting a story about the drive up, gesturing wildly with a fork. Harper, Amanda, and Elara were vibrating with sugar energy. Aunt Linda was laughing loudly at something Jessica said.

At the head of the table, Freddie sat in his wheelchair. He was the eye of the hurricane. Paige was sitting on a dining chair next to him, but her body was angled entirely toward him, her arm hooked through his, her head resting on his shoulder. She was his physical anchor against the sonic waves.

“Status?” Paige murmured into his sleeve.

“Input is maximum,” Freddie reported, his eyes scanning the chaotic table. “But the data is positive.”

“Okay, clear the runway!” Jessica shouted.

She set the massive sheet cake down in the center of the debris field. The blue wax 1 and 5 burned with surprisingly intense, bright yellow flames, bridging the gap between Sarah’s neat vanilla side and Jenna’s chaotic chocolate side.

“Alright, no speeches,” Jenna said, eyeing the frosting. “Let’s just blow them out so we can eat.”

They began the song. It was the loudest, most off-key rendition of “Happy Birthday” ever performed in Christiansburg. Freddie didn’t sing, but he tapped his fingers on his armrest in perfect time with the rhythm, humming the bassline under his breath.

The song ended in messy cheering and applause.

“Make a wish!” Elara screamed.

Sarah and Jenna leaned in over the cake. They looked at each other.

“One, two, three!”

WHOOSH.

They blew hard. The two bright flames flickered, danced, and then vanished, leaving behind two thick trails of white smoke curling toward the ceiling lamp.

The room cheered. Linda started to reach for the cake server.

Freddie, watching closely from the end of the table, noticed an anomaly.

The wicks weren’t glowing the usual dull red of dying cotton. They were sparking. Tiny, intense pinpricks of white light were dancing on the blackened tips.

Magnesium, Freddie’s internal database supplied. Pyrotechnic redundancy.

Crack. Hiss. FWOOSH.

Suddenly, the smoke trails ignited. The flames jumped back onto the wicks of the 1 and the 5, burning just as brightly as before.

The room fell silent.

“What the heck?” Jenna blinked.

“Did you miss?” Harper asked.

“We didn’t miss,” Sarah frowned, leaning closer. “Airflow was sufficient.”

Jessica was biting her lip, trying desperately not to laugh. Aunt Linda was hiding her grin behind a napkin.

“Try again,” Jessica suggested sweetly. “Maybe you didn’t wish hard enough.”

Sarah and Jenna leaned in again. They took deeper breaths.

WHOOOOOOSH.

They blew until their faces were red. The flames died again. Smoke billowed.

They waited one second. Two seconds.

Crack. Spark. FWOOSH.

The 1 and the 5 roared back to life.

"IT'S MAGIC!" Amanda silently screamed, clapping her hands wildly.

"They're rebooting!" Harper yelled.

Jenna glared at the candles. It was personal now.

"Oh, you want to play?" Jenna growled. She stood up, leaning over the table, and started actively chopping at the smoke with her hand while blowing short, furious puffs of air. "Die! Die! Die!"

Sarah took a tactical approach. She pursed her lips into a tight O shape, aiming a laser-focused stream of air at the base of the 1.

They went out.

They relit.

They went out again.

They relit again, faster this time.

Freddie watched the chaos with a calm fascination. He loved the physics of it. He loved the sheer stubbornness of the chemistry.

"Self-repairing systems," Freddie murmured to Paige. "Highly efficient."

"Jessica is evil," Paige whispered back, giggling against his shoulder.

Finally, Sarah realized wind wasn't the answer.

"Suffocation protocol!" Sarah commanded.

She licked her thumb and forefinger and pinched the wick of the 1. At the same time, Jenna grabbed a glob of chocolate icing and dunked the wick of the 5 into it.

The flames died with a final hiss. They did not relight.

The room erupted in laughter. Jessica finally cracked, doubling over in her chair.

"Happy birthday, suckers!" Jessica gasped. "Trick candles. The guy at the party store said they were 'relentless.' "

"You're the worst sister ever," Jenna said, licking chocolate icing off her fingers, grinning ear to ear.

"Ingenious mechanism," Sarah admitted, wiping soot from her fingers onto a napkin. "Magnesium-infused wicks. Well played."

Aunt Linda turned the lights back on. The room was bright, messy, and full of the people Freddie loved most in the world.

He looked at the cake, scarred by the battle with the unkillable candles. He looked at Sarah and Jenna, laughing as they cut the first slices.

He felt Paige squeeze his arm, grounding him in the moment.

Vanessa had offered him silence. She had offered him a life where nothing ever went wrong because nothing ever happened.

But this—this loud, messy, resilient chaos, where even the candles refused to quit—this was his life.

"System status," Freddie whispered to himself, watching Amanda take a massive bite of blue icing.

Optimal.

Scene 6: The Voltage Spike

The cake was decimated. The blue numbers were smoking ruins on the platter.

Jessica and Aunt Linda, wise to the ways of glucose, had carefully sliced thin, reasonable pieces for Amanda and Elara. They were happily coloring on the floor, content and stable.

But the Birthday Girls (Sarah and Jenna) and the opportunist (Harper) had gone rogue. They had consumed massive corner pieces laden with thick buttercream roses.

The result was immediate and terrifying.

At the center of the room, Freddie was in his safe mode. He was docked on the sofa, with Paige heavily leaned against his left side. Her head was on his shoulder, her arm looped through his, her leg pressed against his leg. She was warm, heavy, and still. She was the anchor that kept the room from spinning.

Then, the anomaly occurred.

Harper was vibrating. Literally vibrating.

She was standing in the middle of the living room, bouncing on the balls of her feet. Her pupils were dilated. She had a smear of blue icing on her chin that looked like war paint.

"I'm not tired," Harper announced, her words coming out like bullets from a machine gun. "I could run to the bowling alley. I bet I could run there right now. Do we have a jump rope? I need to jump."

"Harper, sit down," Aunt Linda suggested from the kitchen.

"I can't sit!" Harper yelled happily. "My legs are full of bees!"

She swiveled her head. She locked eyes with Freddie.

To Harper, Freddie was the Core. He was the designated Cuddle Station.

"Cuddle!" Harper shouted.

She launched herself at the sofa.

“Incoming!” Paige warned, bracing herself.

Harper scrambled onto Freddie’s lap. Usually, this was a docking maneuver he welcomed. He liked the weight of her. He liked the quiet way she would rest her head on his chest.

But this wasn’t a dock. It was a collision.

Harper tried to settle in, but her body wouldn’t cooperate. She was a live wire. She twitched. She kicked her legs. She drummed her fingers on his chest in a manic, irregular rhythm. She buried her face in his neck, breathing fast and hot, then immediately popped up to look around the room.

Freddie flinched. His hands hovered over her waist, unsure of where to grab.

The sensation was wrong. It wasn’t the deep, steady pressure he needed. It was erratic. It was sharp. It was like holding a bag of popcorn while it was popping.

“Negative,” Freddie said, his voice tight. He pressed back into the sofa, trying to retreat into Paige’s stillness.

“Harper,” Freddie said, trying to hold her still, but she slipped through his grip like a ferret. “You are oscillating. I cannot ground you.”

“I know!” Harper giggled, squirming. She poked his nose. She poked his glasses. “I’m buzzing. Can you feel it? It feels like sparkles!”

“Input is too high,” Freddie said, squeezing his eyes shut. The erratic movement was disrupting his equilibrium. “Paige, assist.”

“She’s a hazard,” Paige laughed, but she saw the tension in Freddie’s jaw. “Harper, eject. You’re too hot for the Captain right now. You’re scrambling his sensors.”

“I have too much voltage!” Harper agreed happily.

She realized she couldn’t stay still long enough to enjoy the hug anyway. Her skin felt too tight for her body.

“Okay, gotta go!” Harper declared.

She slid off Freddie’s lap, leaving his shirt rumpled and his glasses crooked.

Freddie immediately grabbed Paige’s hand and pulled it tight against his chest, needing to reset the baseline.

“Status?” Paige asked, smoothing his shirt.

“Frequency mismatch,” Freddie exhaled, leaning his head back on Paige’s shoulder. “She is operating on AC current. I require DC.”

Harper began doing laps around the coffee table, making race car noises.

Meanwhile, the twins were experiencing their own manic episode.

Jenna was on the floor, wrestling with a sofa cushion. She was laughing hysterically at nothing. "The pillow is fighting back! It's got me! Send reinforcements!"

Sarah, usually the calm Lieutenant, was pacing the room, gesturing wildly with a napkin she was shredding into confetti.

"Did you know magnesium burns at 3,100 degrees?" Sarah lectured rapidly to no one in particular, walking in tight circles. "That's hot enough to melt iron. We ate cake next to melting iron. That is statistically unsafe but awesome. Do we have any iron? We should test it."

"Status check?" Jessica asked, leaning in the kitchen doorway with a trash bag, watching the asylum.

"System overload," Freddie reported, watching Harper blur past him for the fifth time. "Meltdown imminent."

"Ten minutes," Jessica predicted, checking her watch. "Then we crash."

Scene 7: The Shutdown Sequence

The crash was absolute.

One minute, the living room was a mosh pit of vibrating sisters. The next, it was a field of casualties.

Harper was lying face-down on the carpet, one arm draped over a footstool. Jenna was slumped against the armchair, blinking in slow motion, her mouth slightly open. Sarah was staring blankly at a knot in the wood floor, her glasses sliding down her nose.

Jessica stood over them, hands on her hips.

"Alright, zombies," Jessica announced, clapping her hands once. "We are not sleeping in sticky clothes. Hygiene protocol is active. Teeth and Toilet. Move out."

Harper groaned into the carpet. "Can't move. Bones are melted."

"If you don't move, I'll carry you to the hose in the backyard," Jessica threatened affectionately.

Aunt Linda emerged from the hallway. "I'm taking the hallway bathroom to get my makeup off. It's occupied for ten minutes."

The hallway bathroom was the only "official" bathroom on the main floor. With Linda inside, that created a bottleneck.

Amanda and Elara (the responsible ones who hadn't overdosed on sugar) stood by the doorway holding their toothbrushes.

"We can wait," Elara said.

Jenna, however, had no patience left. She peeled herself off the armchair.

“I’m not waiting,” Jenna slurred. She grabbed her toothbrush from the side table (where she had left it earlier for some reason). “I’m going to the Underworld.”

“Me too,” Sarah sighed, standing up like an old woman. “Efficiency.”

“Wait for me,” Harper mumbled, crawling upright.

Freddie watched them shuffle toward the basement door. He stayed firmly planted on the sofa, Paige still resting against his shoulder.

“I will remain at Command,” Freddie stated clearly.

He knew the layout. The basement was an open zone. Now that the “Laundry Brigade” had broken the seal on the Pittsburgh Toilet, the girls were treating it like a normal facility.

But Freddie operated on a strict code of chivalry and logic. He was nineteen. They were his younger sisters. And there were no walls down there.

“You aren’t going down?” Paige asked, stifling a yawn.

“Negative,” Freddie said, adjusting his glasses. “That is currently a restricted zone. I will respect the perimeter.”

Paige smiled, squeezing his arm. “Good Captain.”

Down in the cool concrete bunker, the “Sugar Crash Squad” went to work.

There was no modesty, only tiredness.

Sarah turned on the faucet of the deep utility sink. It groaned and spat cold water. She and Jenna stood side-by-side, brushing their teeth over the paint-stained drain.

“Move over,” Jenna grumbled, spitting foam. “You’re hogging the water.”

“You have a massive head,” Sarah retorted weakly, rinsing her brush.

In the corner, Harper didn’t even hesitate. She walked over to the Pittsburgh Toilet—the lonely porcelain throne sitting right next to the furnace.

She pulled down her pajama pants and sat down.

A day ago, she would have died of embarrassment. She would have held it until her bladder exploded rather than go in front of her sisters.

But now? Sarah was spitting toothpaste three feet away. Jenna was splashing water on her face. The dryer was humming.

Harper just sat there, swinging her legs, staring at the exposed pipes on the ceiling.

“Did you see the look on Freddie’s face when I tried to hug him?” Harper asked, her voice echoing slightly in the open room. “He looked like he was holding a bomb.”

"You were a bomb," Sarah said, wiping her mouth on her sleeve. "You were oscillating at a frequency incompatible with his sensory processing."

"I was just happy," Harper yawned.

She finished, stood up, and flushed. KA-WHOOSH. The sound was deafening in the concrete box.

"My turn," Jenna said, handing Sarah her toothbrush to hold.

Jenna swapped places with Harper. Harper went to the sink to brush her teeth, standing next to Sarah.

They rotated through the stations—sink, toilet, sink—with the efficiency of a pit crew. No doors. No locks. No secrets. Just sisters getting ready for bed in the only way that worked for a family this size.

Scene 8: The Photographic Evidence

The "Hygiene Squad" had returned from the basement, and Amanda and Elara had descended from the upstairs bathroom. The living room was now filled with eight clean, minty-smelling siblings wearing mismatched flannel pajamas.

Jenna and Sarah were heading toward the basement door to retrieve the air mattresses for the "Mega-Bed" construction.

"Hold it," Aunt Linda commanded, standing in the center of the room.

She was holding a silver and black camera—an Opti-View 35mm—which she had dug out of her purse.

"Before we turn this room into a campground," Linda announced, winding the film wheel with a satisfying crk-crk-crk sound. "I need evidence."

"Aunt Linda," Jessica groaned, rubbing her eyes. "We look like train wrecks. I have pizza grease in my pores."

"I don't care," Linda said firmly. "Everyone on the sofa. Now."

"All of us?" Harper asked, yawning. "It's a three-person sofa."

"It's a family sofa," Linda corrected. "We improvise. Freddie, stay put. You are the anchor."

Freddie, still parked in the center of the beige sofa, adjusted his glasses. "I am ready to receive docking procedures."

Linda began directing traffic like an air traffic controller.

"Okay, Triad in the middle," Linda ordered. "Paige, port side. Jessica, starboard side. Squeeze him in. I want no daylight between you."

Paige snuggled into Freddie's left, resting her head on his shoulder. Jessica wedged herself into his right, wrapping an arm around his waist.

“Okay, now the layers,” Linda pointed. “Harper, you are cleared for landing. Low voltage this time.”

Harper, significantly calmer now that the sugar had left her system, climbed up. She didn’t bounce. She didn’t vibrate. She simply curled up on Freddie’s lap, tucking her legs in and resting her head on his chest.

“Acceptable,” Freddie whispered, resting his chin on the top of her head. “Heart rate is nominal.”

“Twins, up and over,” Linda gestured.

Amanda and Elara climbed up the back of the sofa. They draped themselves over the top cushions, their arms hanging down over Freddie’s shoulders, their chins resting near his ears. Freddie was now wearing a hat made of sisters.

“Birthday Girls, flank positions,” Linda directed.

Sarah and Jenna, too big to fit on the cushions without crushing someone, sat on the floor in front of the sofa, leaning back against Freddie’s knees. Sarah rested her cheek against his left leg; Jenna rested hers against his right.

Linda stepped back. She looked through the viewfinder.

It was a mountain of flannel, hair, and limbs. You couldn’t tell where one sibling started and another ended. In the center of it all, Freddie looked small, weighed down, and overwhelmed.

And he looked happier than she had ever seen him.

The terror of the last week—the bus, the note, the empty wheelchair in the hallway—felt a million miles away.

“Squeeze in!” Linda called out, her voice thick with emotion. “Smile!”

“Cheese!” Elara yelled.

“Pizza!” Jenna corrected.

Whiiiiiiine-CLICK.

The flash blinded them for a second.

“One more,” Linda insisted, winding the film. “Just in case someone blinked.”

Whiiiiiiine-CLICK.

“Okay, now a silly one,” Linda laughed, wiping a tear from her eye. “Go nuts.”

Jenna stuck her tongue out. Elara made bunny ears behind Freddie’s head. Harper crossed her eyes. Jessica puffed out her cheeks. Freddie simply pushed his glasses down his nose and looked over the rim with a “stern librarian” face.

Whiiiiiiine-CLICK.

Linda lowered the camera. She looked at the tableau one last time before breaking the spell.

She thought about Vanessa. She thought about how hard that girl had tried to make Freddie feel like a burden—like his needs were too heavy for anyone to carry.

Look at this, Linda thought fiercely. He isn't a burden. He's the foundation.

"Alright," Linda sniffled, putting the camera back in her purse. "Photo session adjourned. Laundry Brigade, go get the mattresses. Let's get this camp set up."

As the pile slowly disentangled itself—limbs retracting, sisters sliding off—Freddie stayed still for a moment, savoring the lingering warmth of the pressure.

"System check," he whispered to Paige as she sat up.

"Full battery," Paige smiled, squeezing his hand. "We're full."

"Affirmative," Freddie said.

He watched Sarah and Jenna drag the deflated air mattresses up from the basement, ready to build the raft that would keep them all together through the night.

Scene 9: The Platoon Deployment

The photo session was over. The evidence was secured in Aunt Linda's camera. Now, the logistics began.

Aunt Linda clapped her hands. "Alright, listen up. Tomorrow morning, the minivan leaves for Virginia Beach at 0900 hours. The invasion force is retreating."

A collective groan went up from the younger siblings. They didn't want to leave.

"But," Linda continued, smiling. "For tonight, we are not separating. No one is going to the basement. We are doing a full-scale camp-out right here."

Jessica took charge. This was their house—hers, Paige's, and Freddie's. They had bought it from Great Aunt Marge before she passed, using the settlement money. It was their fortress, and tonight, they were lowering the drawbridge.

"Operation Mega-Bed is a go," Jessica announced. "Sarah, Jenna—haul the air mattresses up from the Underworld. Harper, help me move the coffee table."

The heavy oak coffee table was slid all the way against the TV stand, opening up a vast rectangle of beige carpet.

Then, Jessica turned to the sofa.

"Evacuate the cushions," Jessica commanded.

She and Paige pulled the cushions off. Jessica gripped the metal handle hidden inside the frame and pulled.

CREAAAK-CLUNK.

The mechanism unfolded. The beige sofa transformed into a Queen-sized sleeper bed with a thin but acceptable mattress.

"The Command Module," Freddie noted, looking at the bed. "Capacity: Three."

"Exactly," Paige said, smoothing a fitted sheet over the mattress. "You're in the middle, Captain. We're the bumpers."

Sarah and Jenna returned from the basement, dragging bundles of vinyl. The electric pumps roared to life—VRRRRRRRRR—filling the living room with the sound of inflation.

One by one, the "Platoon" took shape on the floor.

- Command Module (Sofa Bed):
  - Freddie transferred from his wheelchair to the center of the Queen bed. He lay back against the pillows, finally taking the weight off his spine.
  - Paige climbed in on his left (Port Side).
  - Jessica climbed in on his right (Starboard Side). It was a tight squeeze for three adults, but they fit like puzzle pieces—a solid wall of Averys.
- The Perimeter (The Floor):
  - Sarah and Jenna took two twin air mattresses on the far side of the room, near the window.
  - Amanda and Elara shared a double air mattress near the kitchen entrance.
  - Aunt Linda claimed a twin mattress near the armchair, acting as the overseer.

That left one spot.

Harper stood holding her pillow, looking at the layout. There was one twin air mattress left.

"I want that one," Harper pointed.

She dragged her mattress until it was jammed right up against the metal frame of the sofa bed, directly below where Freddie was lying.

"Harper, you're going to be underfoot," Sarah warned.

"I don't care," Harper said, dropping her pillow. "I need to be near the Captain. In case of... turbulence."

Freddie looked over the edge of the sofa bed. He could see Harper looking up at him, her eyes wide and tired.

"Permission granted," Freddie whispered.

"Lights out," Aunt Linda whispered from her corner.

She clicked the lamp off. The room plunged into darkness, lit only by the faint green glow of the VCR clock: 10:15.

The room settled. The rustle of sleeping bags and the creak of the vinyl mattresses slowly faded.

It was a full house. A house that Freddie, Paige, and Jessica owned. A house that was usually quiet, now filled with the breathing of nine people.

"Freddie?" Harper's whisper came from the floor, inches from the bed frame.

"I am here, Harper," Freddie murmured into the dark.

"Are you okay?" Harper asked. "Are you squished?"

Freddie felt Paige's arm draped over his chest. He felt Jessica's shoulder pressed against his. He felt the solid presence of his sisters on all sides.

"I am contained," Freddie whispered back. "It is optimal."

"Okay," Harper yawned. "Goodnight, Captain."

"Goodnight, Harper."

Freddie closed his eyes. The nightmares couldn't get in here. There was no room for them. The bed was full. The floor was full. The house was full.

For the first time since the bus ride, Freddie Avery slept without dreaming.

Scene 10: The Decompression Chamber

The sun streamed through the living room blinds, illuminating the wreckage of the sleepover.

The "Platoon" was dismantling. The air was filled with the sounds of zippers zipping, nylon rustling, and the distinct whoosh of air mattresses being deflated.

Jenna was rolling on top of her mattress to squeeze the air out. Sarah was folding hers with military precision. Harper was sitting on the edge of the pull-out sofa, eating a strawberry toaster pastry and looking miserable.

"Do we have to go?" Harper asked, kicking her legs against the metal frame.

"Yes," Aunt Linda called from the kitchen, where she was filling travel mugs with coffee. "I have a shift tomorrow, and you have summer reading to start. The van leaves in T-minus twenty minutes."

Freddie sat in his wheelchair near the window, fully dressed in a fresh flannel shirt. He watched the organized chaos. He felt tired—a good, heavy, physical tiredness—but his mind was clear.

"Status of the perimeter?" Freddie asked.

"Perimeter is clearing," Paige said, walking by with an armful of sheets. "We're almost packed."

The van was loaded. The side door was open. The engine was idling.

It was time for the final extraction.

The Twins (Amanda and Elara) went first. They didn't do single hugs. They attacked Freddie simultaneously.

"Twin sandwich!" Elara yelled.

They squeezed him from both sides. Freddie patted their backs. "Safe travels, units."

Sarah stepped up. She adjusted her glasses. She looked at Freddie, then at the house.

"The statistical probability of us returning before school starts is high," Sarah stated. "I have calculated the fuel costs. It is feasible."

"I look forward to the data," Freddie smiled, shaking her hand firmly, which then turned into a quick, awkward hug.

Jenna punched Freddie lightly on the shoulder. "Happy birthday to me. Thanks for the bowling, Captain. Keep the bumpers up."

"Always," Freddie nodded.

Then came Harper.

She dragged her feet. She stood in front of his wheelchair, looking at her sneakers.

"Hey," Freddie said softly. "Look at me."

Harper looked up. Her eyes were glassy.

"You played a clean game," Freddie told her, referencing the cards. "And you give excellent hugs. You are Level 1 clearance, Harper. Never forget that."

Harper sniffled. She lunged forward, wrapping her arms around his neck one last time.

"Don't get sad again," Harper whispered into his ear. "Call us if the bad thoughts come back."

"I will," Freddie promised. "I have the Triad. I am safe."

Aunt Linda was the last. She hugged Jessica and Paige first, whispering instructions about groceries and locks. Then she came to Freddie.

She didn't hug him like a child. She cupped his face in her hands.

"You did good, Freddie," Linda said. "You survived the storm. Now enjoy the quiet. You earned it."

“Thank you, Aunt Linda,” Freddie said. “For the rescue.”

“Anytime,” she winked. “Alright, load up! We’re burning daylight!”

The doors slammed shut. The engine revved.

Freddie, Paige, and Jessica stood on the porch (Freddie on the ramp). They waved as the van backed out, turned onto Pepper Street, and disappeared around the corner.

They walked back inside. Jessica locked the deadbolt.

The silence was sudden.

It wasn’t the scary, empty silence of the apartment in Norfolk. It was the settling silence of a house that had been vibrated to its core and was now resting.

The living room was still messy. The pull-out bed was stripped but open. The coffee table was pushed against the wall. Deflated air mattresses sat in a pile by the basement door.

Freddie rolled to the center of the room. He stopped.

He closed his eyes and took a deep breath. He listened to the hum of the refrigerator. He listened to the AC unit click on.

“Status?” Paige asked softly, walking over to stand by his left wheel.

Freddie opened his eyes.

He looked at the empty room. He looked at the sunlight hitting the carpet where Harper had been sleeping.

“Input levels are dropping,” Freddie said. His shoulders relaxed. The tension he had been holding in his neck for two days finally released. “Decompression initiated.”

Jessica walked over to his right side. She sat down on the edge of the pull-out bed, leaning back on her hands.

“It’s quiet,” Jessica noted.

“It is,” Freddie agreed.

“Is it too quiet?” Paige asked, touching his hand.

Freddie considered this. He ran a diagnostic on his brain. Was the silence dangerous? Did it leave room for Vanessa’s voice?

He listened. He heard nothing but his sisters breathing.

“Negative,” Freddie said. “It is... peaceful.”

He looked at Paige. He looked at Jessica.

The “Platoon” was gone. The “Army” had retreated. It was just them now. The Core, the Anchor, and the Shield.

"We have the house," Freddie stated. "We have the food. We have the silence."

"And we have the remote," Jessica grinned, reaching for it.

Freddie let out a long breath. He leaned his head sideways, resting it against Paige's hip as she stood next to him.

"We are home," Freddie whispered.

System Integration

The Transfer Point

Scene 1: The Pathfinder

The air inside Campbell Court was a familiar, hostile mixture of diesel soot, stale tobacco, and the damp smell of concrete that never quite dried. It was a sensory environment Freddie usually categorized as "Critical Threat," but today, the static in his head was drowned out by the hum of anticipation.

He sat in *The Rover*—his matte black titanium TiLite wheelchair—parked near Gate 4. He wasn't wearing his orange hoodie today; it was too warm. Instead, he wore a soft grey t-shirt and dark jeans, his hands resting on the cambered wheels.

Paige stood directly behind him, her hands resting on his shoulders, her thumbs rubbing a rhythmic, grounding circle into his trapezius muscles.

"They're close," Paige whispered, leaning down so her cheek brushed his hair. "I can feel the chaos inbound."

Jessica stood to his left, checking her watch against the arrival monitor. She looked every inch the Matriarch: posture rigid, eyes scanning the perimeter, holding a sheaf of printed bus schedules like a weapon.

"Pathfinder Schedule 404 from Richmond," Jessica announced. "Arriving in Bay 2. On time."

"Bay 2," Freddie repeated, logging the variable. "That is the center lane."

He looked at the concrete pillar near the gate. The last time he had been in this terminal, he had been freezing, terrified, and alone with Vanessa. He had sat on a metal bench breathing in poison.

Today, he was the center of a phalanx. He wasn't running away. He was the Welcome Committee.

A massive silver bus roared into the tunnel, its air brakes hissing with a violent *PSSSHHH* that echoed off the low ceiling. The destination sign scrolled in jagged yellow LEDs: **KNOXVILLE**.

"That's them," Jessica said, stepping forward but keeping one hand on Freddie's arm to maintain the chain. "Hold the line."

The doors hissed open. A few tired travelers stepped off—a man with a guitar case, a woman with a crying baby.

Then, a blur of motion appeared in the doorway.

Jenna Avery didn't step off the bus; she launched.

She was wearing a neon green tank top, baggy cargo pants with too many zippers, and carrying a messenger bag that looked like it was exploding with wires and sketchpads.

"ROANOKE!" Jenna shouted, leaping down the stairs and landing on the oil-stained concrete with a thud. She spun in a circle, her eyes wild and bright. "WE ARE IN THE MOUNTAINS! I SMELL DIESEL! I SMELL VICTORY!"

Behind her, Sarah stepped down with measured precision. She was wearing a crisp button-down shirt and pressed jeans. She carried a single, hard-shell carry-on case that looked like it had been sanitized. She scanned the platform, her eyes darting from the oil stain on the floor to the flickering light overhead, assessing threats.

Then, she saw them.

"Target acquired," Sarah said, her shoulders dropping three inches as the tension left her frame.

"FREDDIE!" Jenna screamed.

She didn't wait for permission. She didn't ask if it was okay. She sprinted across the gap.

Freddie barely had time to brace himself before Jenna collided with him. She dropped to her knees on the dirty concrete and threw her arms around his waist, burying her face in his lap.

"I missed you! I missed you! Mom is so loud and the house was so quiet without you!" Jenna wailed, hugging him with a frantic, vibrating energy.

Usually, this kind of sudden impact would trigger a sensory crash. But Freddie had prepared. He had the manual.

Jenna = High Frequency / High Pressure.

"Hello, Jenna," Freddie said, bringing his hand down to rest on her messy hair. "You are... vibrating."

"I know!" Jenna looked up, grinning maniacally. "I have been sitting for six hours! I need to spin!"

Sarah reached them a second later. She didn't run. She walked up to the side of the wheelchair. She looked at Freddie, then at Paige, then at Jessica.

“The bus was unsanitary,” Sarah noted, her voice trembling slightly. “There was a sticky substance on the armrest. I used four packets of wipes.”

“You’re safe now,” Jessica said, opening her arms. “Decontamination is waiting at the Base.”

Sarah dropped her bag and stepped into the circle. She didn’t hug Jessica first. She knelt down next to Jenna, on Freddie’s other side.

She reached out and took Freddie’s hand. She gripped it hard—a static, unmoving clamp. She verified he was real.

“Freddie,” Sarah whispered. “You have the chair. You actually got it.”

“The Rover,” Freddie corrected, tapping the titanium frame. “It increases efficiency.”

“It’s clean,” Sarah approved, inspecting the matte finish.

Then, the dam broke. Paige let go of Freddie’s shoulders and dropped to her knees, wrapping her arms around both Sarah and Jenna. Jessica crouched down behind Freddie, wrapping her arms around his chest.

It was a five-person pile-up in the middle of Bay 2. A tangle of limbs, tears, and relief.

Travelers stepped around them, looking confused, but the Avery Unit didn’t care. They were complete.

“We’re here,” Jenna sobbed into Freddie’s knee. “We’re actually here. We escaped.”

“You are docked,” Freddie confirmed, feeling the weight of them anchoring him to the ground. “The perimeter is expanded.”

Jessica stood up after a long minute, wiping her eyes. “Okay. Logistics check. You shipped the heavy stuff?”

“Twelve boxes,” Sarah confirmed, standing up and brushing the terminal dust off her knees with a grimace. “UDS Ground. Tracking numbers indicate arrival at 105 Pepper yesterday.”

“They’re in the garage,” Jessica confirmed. “Waiting for deployment.”

“Then we are light,” Jessica said. “We can make the transfer.”

She pointed to the far end of the terminal, where a smaller, white-and-maroon bus was idling.

“**Roanoke Valley Transit**,” Jessica announced. “The **Roanoke Express**. It departs in ten minutes. It takes us straight to the Falling Branch Park & Ride.”

“Then what?” Jenna asked, bouncing on her heels.

"Then we transfer to **Blue Ridge Transit Route 1**," Freddie recited, the schedule appearing in his mind like a soothing green terminal screen. "It will deposit us at **Pepper Plaza**. The walk to the Base is three minutes."

"Three minutes to freedom," Paige smiled, grabbing Sarah's hand. "Come on. Let's get you guys home."

They moved as a unit toward the express bus—Jessica taking point, Paige and the twins flanking the wheelchair, and Freddie rolling in the center, the Captain of a fleet that had just doubled in size.

Scene 2: The Bunker

The short ride from **Pepper Plaza** to the driveway took less than two minutes, but for Sarah, it was a data-gathering mission. She scanned the neighborhood through the bus window, noting the distance between houses (low density), the condition of the sidewalks (acceptable), and the proximity to the transit hub (optimal).

They crossed the street. Jessica unlocked the front door of **105 Pepper Street** and held it open.

"Welcome to the Base," Jessica said.

Jenna didn't walk in; she spilled in. She dropped her messenger bag on the hardwood floor and spun in a circle, taking in the living room, the beige sofa, and the open archway to the kitchen.

"It's real!" Jenna shouted, vibrating with energy. "It's not just a picture in an email! It smells like lemons!"

"Lemon polish," Sarah corrected, stepping inside and closing the door firmly behind her. She checked the deadbolt. *Click.* "Perimeter secured."

Sarah stood in the foyer, her eyes scanning the corners for dust bunnies or structural defects. She saw the **MagnaView** TV, the stacks of **Galaxy Wars** tapes, and the general orderliness of the main floor.

"It is... acceptable," Sarah decided, her shoulders relaxing slightly. "The clutter density is low."

"That's because we keep the chaos contained," Jessica said, pointing toward the back door. "Speaking of chaos, your assets are already here."

"The boxes?" Jenna asked, her eyes lighting up.

"In the Depot," Freddie said. He was sitting in *The Rover* in the center of the living room, pivoting effortlessly on the hardwood. "The detached garage structure to the right. **UDS Ground** delivered twelve units yesterday."

"United Delivery Systems," Sarah nodded approvingly. "They have a 98% on-time rating. Good choice."

"We moved the perishables inside," Paige added. "But the heavy stuff—your computers, your books, your... Jenna stuff—is all in the garage. We can haul it in as needed."

"Show me the room," Jenna demanded, bouncing on her toes. "Where do we sleep? Where is the studio? I need to plug in!"

Jessica exchanged a look with Paige. This was the moment of truth.

"Follow me," Jessica said.

She led them through the kitchen to a narrow, wooden door that looked like a pantry closet. She opened it.

Behind the door was a steep, narrow wooden staircase leading down into cool darkness. It smelled of dry concrete and old lumber.

"The Bunker," Jessica announced.

Jenna peered into the abyss. "A dungeon? We get a dungeon?"

"It's an unfinished basement," Freddie explained, rolling his wheelchair up to the doorway but stopping abruptly at the threshold. The front casters of *The Rover* hovered inches from the drop.

"Note the gradient," Freddie said, pointing down. "The stairs are steep. The width is narrow. My wheelbase cannot navigate this architecture. I physically cannot go down there."

Sarah looked at the stairs, then at Freddie. She realized the implication immediately.

"It is a filter," Sarah observed.

"Exactly," Paige smiled. "It's a natural barrier. Freddie can't go down there. Mom—if she ever visits—can't handle those stairs in her heels. It is the only place in the house that is completely, 100% yours. No inspections. No oversight."

Jenna's eyes went wide. "Zero oversight?"

"Total autonomy," Jessica confirmed. "It's a blank slate. Concrete floors. Open rafters. You can paint the walls neon green. You can hang lights from the ceiling. You can make a mess, and as long as it doesn't smell, we don't care."

Jenna didn't wait. She bolted down the stairs, her footsteps thundering on the wood.

Dibs on the big wall! Jenna's voice echoed up from the cavern. "I'm putting the easel there! And the servers! Sarah, look at the space! It's huge!"

Sarah walked to the top of the stairs. She looked down. She saw the concrete floor—perfectly sweepable. She saw the high, small windows that offered light but prevented anyone from looking in.

She saw a space that she could organize, label, and defend.

"It is a defensible position," Sarah murmured.

She looked back at Freddie. He was watching her, a look of concern on his face.

"Is it... acceptable?" Freddie asked. "It is raw. Industrial."

Sarah looked at her brother—the boy she had protected from bullies, the boy she had worried about every day since he left for Seattle three years ago. She saw the titanium chair. She saw the sisters flanking him.

She realized she didn't have to protect him from the house. He had built the house to protect *them*.

"It is perfect, Freddie," Sarah said, a rare, genuine smile touching her lips. "It is separate. It is safe."

She picked up her sanitized carry-on case.

"I will establish my perimeter near the laundry units," Sarah decided, stepping onto the first stair. "Jenna requires the blast zone. I require the utilities."

"Good luck," Jessica called down after her. "Dinner is pizza. Papa Tony's. 18:00 hours."

"Affirmative," Sarah called back.

As the twins disappeared into their new subterranean kingdom, Freddie turned his chair back toward the living room.

"Roster update," Freddie stated, looking at Paige and Jessica.

"Five active units," Paige agreed, leaning down to kiss his forehead. "The house is full."

"Systems nominal," Freddie whispered.

Scene 3: The Heap Protocol

The house had settled into a quiet hum. Downstairs, the basement lights were still blazing as Jenna unpacked chaos onto the concrete floor, but upstairs, the main floor was dim. The air conditioner cycled on, a low rumble that vibrated through the floorboards.

In the living room, the "Docking Protocol" was already fully engaged.

Freddie lay on the beige sofa, his body curled into the corner. His head rested in Paige's lap, his cheek pressed against the soft fabric of her pajama shorts. He wasn't asleep, but he was in "Safe Mode"—eyes closed, breathing slow and rhythmic.

Paige sat upright, her back against the armrest. Her left hand was resting flat against the center of Freddie's chest, directly over his heart. It wasn't just a touch; it was a sensor reading. She could feel the steady *thump-thump-thump* of a regulated system.

Jessica sat in the recliner nearby, watching them with a small, satisfied smile.

"Briefing time," Jessica announced softly, checking her watch. "Sarah! Jenna! Upstairs! Pajama Protocol!"

A moment later, footsteps thundered on the steep wooden stairs.

Jenna burst into the living room first. She was wearing an oversized t-shirt covered in paint stains and boxers that looked three sizes too big. Her hair was a static-charged halo.

Sarah followed, moving with measured precision. She wore matching blue cotton pajamas, buttoned all the way to the neck. She looked crisp, clean, and alert.

"Report," Jenna said, breathless. "The Bunker is awesome. It echoes. I love it."

"It is functional," Sarah agreed, standing by the entryway. "I have established the laundry perimeter. Do not cross the yellow tape."

Then, they both stopped.

They looked at the sofa. They saw Freddie curled up, defenseless and relaxed. They saw Paige's hand resting possessively, protectively over his heart. They saw the absolute, tranquil lack of tension in their brother's face.

Jenna tilted her head. "He looks... soft."

"He is regulated," Paige whispered, not moving her hand.

"Why did Mom hate this?" Sarah asked aloud, her brow furrowing as she processed the visual data. "She always said it was 'sick.' She said it was 'wrong.' But looking at it... it just looks like a battery charger."

"Mom was operating on corrupted software," Jessica said from the recliner. "She confused intimacy with sexuality. She couldn't process a connection that didn't have an agenda."

"It makes sense," Jenna decided, flopping onto the rug. "It's efficient. Like plugging in a phone."

"Exactly," Freddie murmured, not opening his eyes. "Inductive charging."

"Okay," Jessica said, standing up. "As cute as this is, we have logistics. Freddie, Paige—disengage. We need to deploy the bed."

Freddie groaned, a low sound of protest, but he sat up. Paige removed her hand from his heart, breaking the circuit gently. They stood up and moved the coffee table aside.

Jessica gripped the handle hidden under the sofa cushions. With a heavy *creak-thunk*, the beige sofa unfolded, transforming into a double bed with a thin mattress.

"Temporary quarters," Jessica explained. "Until you guys get beds set up downstairs, this is the dock."

"Cool," Jenna said. "It's like a sleepover every night."

"Now," Jessica said, turning to face the twins. "Before we initiate Sleep Mode, we need to review the House Rules. Specifically, the dress code."

Sarah stiffened slightly, smoothing her button-down top. "Dress code?"

"Or lack thereof," Paige clarified, sitting on the edge of the newly deployed bed.

Freddie cleared his throat. He stood by the window, checking the blackout curtains to ensure the seal was tight.

"The house operates on a 'Zero Friction' protocol," Freddie stated, turning to face them. "We prioritize sensory regulation over social norms. Clothing is often... binding. It creates static. It traps heat."

"So," Jessica continued, "we don't enforce modesty here. If you want to sleep naked, you sleep naked. If you want to walk to the kitchen for water in the middle of the night without clothes, you do it. No one flinches. No one cares. We are a closed system."

Sarah blinked. Her eyes darted to the window. "But the neighbors..."

"Project Blackout," Freddie pointed to the window. "Layer 1: Blinds. Layer 2: Sheers. Layer 3: Rubber-backed blackout curtains. The Silo is sealed. No photons escape. No photons enter."

Sarah processed this. *Sealed environment. High efficiency.*

"Less laundry," Sarah noted.

"Exactly," Jessica smiled. "Efficiency."

"I hate pants anyway," Jenna announced. She hooked her thumbs into the waistband of her boxers and shimmied them down, stepping out of them right there in the living room. She kicked them toward Sarah. "Free!"

Sarah caught the boxers with two fingers, looking horrified but accepting the logic. "Variable accepted."

"Now," Paige said, patting the mattress. "The 'Heap' Protocol."

"The Heap?" Sarah asked.

"Cuddle pile," Freddie translated. "We sleep in the King bed upstairs. But before sleep... we dock here. We calibrate. All five of us."

He looked at Sarah. He knew she needed verification. He knew she needed to know she was safe.

"Sarah," Freddie said softly. "You provide... stability. You are a clamp."

Sarah looked at him. She saw the way Paige was waiting. She saw the way Jessica was moving to the bed. She realized this wasn't just about sleeping; it was about structural integrity.

“I can clamp,” Sarah whispered.

She unbuttoned her pajama top and folded it neatly, placing it on the coffee table. Wearing just a simple cotton tank and bottoms, she climbed onto the sofa bed.

The configuration began.

The Base: Freddie climbed into the center of the double mattress. He lay on his back, the gravity of the group pulling everyone toward him.

The Anchor: Paige took her standard position on his left. She curled into his side, resting her head on his shoulder, her hand returning immediately to its post over his heart.

The Shield: Jessica took the foot of the bed, leaning her back against Freddie’s legs, weighing him down, grounding his restless limbs.

The Clamp: Sarah wedged herself into Freddie’s right side. She didn’t just drape her arm; she grabbed his forearm with both hands and squeezed. A firm, static, unmoving grip.

“Secure,” Sarah said.

“Secure,” Freddie confirmed, feeling the grounding weight of her grip.

The Roof: Jenna scrambled up. She didn’t take a side. She sprawled across the top, draping herself over Freddie’s chest and Sarah’s legs like a weighted blanket.

“I’m the noise dampener!” Jenna whispered.

“Jenna,” Freddie wheezed slightly under the weight. “Stillness protocol.”

“Right. Stillness,” Jenna said. She stopped vibrating. She let her body go heavy, melting into the pile.

They lay there in the dim light of the living room—five adults, shedding the armor of the outside world, locking into place like puzzle pieces that had finally found their matching edges.

The house on Pepper Street was small. The sofa bed was crowded. But as the air conditioner hummed and the breathing of his four sisters synced with his own, Freddie knew one thing for certain.

The system was fully integrated.

“Lights out,” Freddie whispered.

“Lights out,” four voices answered.

The Avery Unit powered down, safe in the dark.

Scene 4: The Pressure Check

The "Heap" protocol had been active for fifteen minutes. The living room was silent, save for the rhythmic white noise of the air conditioner and the synchronized breathing of five adults compressed onto a single double mattress.

Freddie lay in the center of the crush.

To his left, Paige (The Anchor) was curled into his side, her head resting on his shoulder, her hand flat and warm over his heart. To his right, Sarah (The Clamp) held his forearm with a grip that hadn't loosened by a single millimeter, grounding him with static, unmoving force.

At his feet, Jessica (The Shield) leaned back against his legs, her weight preventing any involuntary kicks or spasms. And draped over the top of him, heavy and warm, lay Jenna (The Roof), who had successfully entered "Stillness Mode" and was now melting into the pile like a weighted blanket.

Freddie closed his eyes. He ran a diagnostic on his nervous system.

Usually, this much sensory input—limbs everywhere, body heat rising, the smell of four different shampoos—would trigger a "Buffer Overflow". But tonight, the data wasn't chaotic. It was structural.

He thought about the bus ride to Seattle three years ago. He thought about the vibration of the window against his head, the smell of the chemical toilet, and the terrifying emptiness of the seat next to him where Vanessa had sat, controlling him.

He remembered the feeling of being dragged across the floor in Pasco. The feeling of being light, unsecured, and easily stolen.

Here, he wasn't light. He was heavy. He was pinned to the mattress by four hundred pounds of love and loyalty.

Vanessa could not drag me now, Freddie calculated. *The mass is too great. The gravity well is inescapable.*

A profound sense of relief washed over him, deeper than the ocean trench. The static in his head—the low-level hum of anxiety that had been running in the background since 2004—finally went silent.

"Status?" Paige whispered, feeling his breathing shift.

"Maximum density," Freddie murmured, his voice thick with sleep. "System is... secure."

He felt Jenna shift slightly on top of him, getting comfortable. He felt Sarah's grip tighten just a fraction in response.

He realized he didn't want them to move. He didn't want to send the twins down to the basement bunker. He didn't want to retreat to the King Bed with just the original three.

He wanted *this*. All five units. Online. Connected.

But then, his logic engine flagged a hardware limitation.

He shifted his hip. The metal bar of the sofa bed frame dug into his side. The mattress was a standard Double. It was designed for two people, maybe three in a pinch.

It was not designed for five adults.

"Crowded," Freddie whispered.

"Yeah," Jessica murmured from the foot of the bed, her eyes already closed. "It's tight. But it works."

Freddie frowned in the dark. It worked for *now*. But it wasn't efficient. Limbs were overlapping. Circulation was being compromised.

He ran a query in his mind.

The King Bed is 76 inches wide. It fits three units with zero clearance.

Five units require...

He did the math. If the average shoulder width was 18 inches, five people needed 90 inches of lateral space just to lie flat. A King was only 76.

We need a bigger platform, Freddie thought. *A custom architecture.*

He visualized it. A bed that spanned the entire room. A bed where Sarah could clamp, Jenna could sprawl, and Paige could anchor, all without hitting the edge.

"We need..." Freddie started to say, but the words were heavy.

"Shh," Sarah whispered, not opening her eyes. "Sleep protocol initiated. No talking."

"Understood," Freddie breathed.

He let the thought drift away. He let the sensation of the "Heap" take over. The pressure was heavy, hot, and absolutely perfect.

Within minutes, the breathing in the room deepened. Jenna began to snore softly—a tiny, whistling sound. Jessica's head lolled onto Freddie's ankle.

They didn't disperse. They didn't go to their designated zones.

The Avery Unit simply shut down where they were, a tangle of limbs and trust, sleeping in a pile because for the first time in years, everyone was exactly where they were supposed to be.

Scene 5: The Migration

The silence of the living room was broken by a groan.

It wasn't a sound of distress; it was the sound of a spine complaining about physics. Jenna shifted in the "Heap," her leg kicking out involuntarily as she tried to find a cool spot on the mattress.

There were no cool spots. The beige sofa bed, while functional, was a standard Double. It was fifty-four inches wide.

Packed with five adults, the thermal output was immense. The body heat had pooled in the center of the bed, turning the "cuddle pile" into a kiln.

"Hot," Jenna mumbled, pushing the sheet off her legs. "Too hot."

She tried to sit up, but she was pinned. Sarah's arm was clamped across her waist. Freddie's leg was under hers. Jessica was a dead weight on her ankle.

Jenna wiggled. The movement sent a ripple effect through the Unit.

"Movement detected," Freddie whispered, his eyes flying open. He winced. His neck was stiff from sleeping at an odd angle against Paige's shoulder.

"Jenna?" Sarah mumbled, her grip tightening instinctively before waking up fully. "Status?"

"I need juice," Jenna announced, her voice rasping in the dark. "Cranberry. And I can't feel my left foot. This bed is a trap."

"It's a sofa," Jessica corrected, yawning and stretching her arms, which caused a domino effect of limbs untangling. "It wasn't built for a platoon."

Jenna finally managed to extract herself. She stood up on the cool hardwood floor, wobbling slightly. She pulled at her oversized t-shirt, which was twisted and damp with sweat.

"Ugh," Jenna complained, flapping the shirt to generate airflow. "I'm boiling. I feel like a burrito in a microwave."

She looked at the others. They were all sitting up now, rubbing sore necks and stretching cramped backs. The "Heap" had been emotionally perfect, but ergonomically disastrous.

"Why are we wearing clothes?" Jenna asked, looking down at her boxers. "It's 105 Pepper Street. It's the Base. Why are we roasting in pajamas?"

"Habit," Sarah said, buttoning her top button which had come undone. "Protocol dictates sleepwear for communal areas."

"Correction," Jessica said, swinging her legs off the edge of the mattress. "Protocol dictates *comfort*. I told you earlier: we don't hide bodies here. The house is 1,100 square feet. There is no privacy. Pretending there is just creates laundry and heat stroke."

Jenna didn't need to be told twice.

"System purge," Jenna declared.

She grabbed the hem of her paint-stained t-shirt and pulled it over her head. She shimmied out of her boxers. She tossed the pile onto the recliner.

She stood there in the dim light of the streetlamp filtering through the cracks—naked, unbothered, and finally cooling down.

"Oh, that is *so* much better," Jenna sighed. "Airflow."

Freddie blinked behind his glasses. He looked at Jenna. He ran a diagnostic.

Shock level: Zero.

He had read the manual. He had done the coursework. This wasn't "scandalous." It was just Jenna.

"Efficiency," Freddie noted. "Thermal regulation optimized."

He looked at Paige. Paige nodded. She sat up and pulled off her tank top. She stood and stepped out of her shorts.

Jessica followed suit.

Freddie sat on the edge of the bed. He reached for the waistband of his grey pajama pants.

He hesitated for a microsecond—the "Robert Virus" whisper of *shame* trying to run a background script—but he looked at Sarah.

Sarah was sitting perfectly still, fully buttoned up in her blue pajamas, staring at Jenna. Her eyes were wide. She was processing the data.

"It is... unstructured," Sarah whispered. "It violates the standard social contract."

"The social contract is for strangers," Jessica said gently, standing up and stretching her back. "We aren't strangers. We're the Unit. And Sarah? Think about the washing machine. Five sets of pajamas every night? That's two extra loads a week. Water. Detergent. Folding time."

Sarah's eyes narrowed. The logic centers of her OCD flared to life.

Inefficiency detected.

"Two loads," Sarah calculated. "Plus wear and tear on the fabrics."

She looked at Freddie. He was waiting. He hadn't stripped yet. He was giving her time to calibrate.

Sarah took a deep breath. She unbuttoned the top button. Then the second.

"Laundry reduction is a valid goal," Sarah stated.

She stripped off the blue pajamas. She folded them neatly—even in the dark—and placed them on the stack.

She stood up. She looked at Freddie.

It was the first time she had ever seen him without clothes.

She looked at his chest, the scar from a childhood bike accident on his knee, the way his shoulders were set.

She didn't feel shame. She didn't feel the "ick" factor Ellen had warned them about.

She just felt... accurate. This was the raw data. This was her brother.

"Freddie," Sarah said, nodding to him. "You are authorized."

Freddie stood up. He let the grey pants drop.

Jenna turned from the kitchen doorway. She saw him.

She saw the reality of his body—the slight curvature of his spine from the muscle spasms, the definition in his arms from using the wheelchair.

"You look strong, Freddie," Jenna observed, tilting her head. "Like a swimmer."

Freddie felt a flush of warmth that had nothing to do with embarrassment. "Thank you," he whispered. "I am... aerodynamic."

"Okay," Jenna said, turning back to the kitchen. "Juice run. Then we fix the sleeping arrangement."

She returned a moment later with a glass of cranberry juice. She drank it in three gulps.

"Okay," Jenna wiped her mouth. "The sofa is a failure. My hip hurts. Sarah's elbow was in my spleen."

"Agreed," Paige said, rubbing her shoulder. "Crowding was critical."

"The Silo," Jenna pointed to the ceiling. "The King Bed. It's 76 inches, right? That's twenty-two inches wider than this thing."

"It is," Freddie confirmed. "Spatial capacity is significantly higher."

"Let's go," Jenna said. "We migrate to the Silo. We test the King configuration."

"All five?" Sarah asked.

"All five," Jessica confirmed. "We aren't splitting up. Not on the first night."

They moved to the stairs—a procession of pale shapes in the dark house.

They entered the Master Bedroom. The blackout curtains were sealed tight. The room was pitch black, cool, and silent.

They climbed into the massive bed.

- **Center:** Freddie. The Core.
- **Left Flank:** Paige (The Anchor). She curled into his side, leg over his, hand on his chest.

- **Right Flank:** Jessica (The Shield). She pressed her back against his, locking him in.
- **Far Left:** Jenna (The Roof/Chaos). She sprawled next to Paige, stealing the pillow but draping an arm over the pile.
- **Far Right:** Sarah (The Clamp). She took the edge, but she reached across Jessica to grip Freddie's wrist. A static, verifying hold.

It was tight. They were shoulder-to-shoulder, skin-to-skin.

But it fit.

Freddie lay in the center of the mass. He felt the weight of four sisters.

He closed his eyes.

The memory of the Pasco bus terminal—the cold floor, the dragging, the searing pain of his back tearing open—flashed in his mind.

Phantom Pain. He felt a ghost-sting on his lower back.

But then he felt Paige's hand over his heart. He felt Sarah's grip on his wrist. He felt Jessica's solid warmth on his back. He felt Jenna's breath on his shoulder.

The phantom pain flickered and died. It couldn't survive in this environment.

Vanessa had one hostage, Freddie thought. *I have an army.*

"Status?" Paige whispered from the dark.

"Fortified," Freddie breathed. "The walls are... impenetrable."

"Goodnight, Unit," Jenna mumbled, already drifting off.

"Goodnight," four voices answered.

The breathing synced up. The heat rose. The Avery Unit slept, safe in the Silo, five hearts beating in the dark.

The Physical Layer

Scene 1: The Descent

The morning light filtered through the blackout curtains of the Master Bedroom, signaling that the "Silo" had successfully protected its occupants for another rotation.

Freddie woke up in the center of the mass. The heat was immense.

To his left, Paige was still asleep, her arm thrown over his chest. To his right, Jessica was awake, staring at the ceiling. At the foot of the bed, Jenna was sprawled diagonally across everyone's ankles, and Sarah was curled into a tight, efficient ball on the far edge, holding Freddie's wrist.

"Status?" Freddie whispered, his voice raspy.

"Crowded," Jessica whispered back, smiling. "But secure."

Jenna stirred, kicking out a leg. "I need coffee. And I need to calibrate the servers."

"Coffee first," Sarah mumbled into the pillow.

They disentangled themselves from the "Heap." One by one, they climbed out of the King bed.

No one reached for clothes. The "No Armor" protocol was in full effect. The air conditioning was set to a brisk 68 degrees, making the cool air feel refreshing against their warm skin.

They moved into the living room. Jenna grabbed the digital camera from the coffee table.

"I can film it again," Jenna offered, seeing Freddie look toward the kitchen door—the gateway to the basement. "I can get better lighting this time. I'll do a commentary track."

Freddie sat in The Rover, spinning the wheels slightly. He looked at the closed door.

He appreciated the data. He appreciated the video. But staring at a screen was not the same as verifying the architecture. He needed to know the distance. He needed to gauge the acoustic properties.

He needed to know exactly where his sisters were going to sleep so he could map them in his mind when he was upstairs.

"Negative," Freddie stated. "I require physical verification. The video lacks depth perception."

Sarah paused in the middle of stretching. "The stairs are non-compliant, Freddie. Steep gradient. No landing."

"I have legs," Freddie said, though they felt stiff. "And I have a team."

He looked at Jessica and Paige.

"Spotters?" Freddie asked.

"Always," Paige said immediately, moving to his side.

"If you want to go down there, we get you down there," Jessica confirmed. "Formation Alpha."

They moved to the kitchen. Jessica opened the narrow pantry door. The smell of dry concrete and old lumber wafted up—a sharp contrast to the lemon polish of the main floor.

The stairs were indeed steep. They were unfinished wood, narrow and open-backed.

"Okay," Jessica strategized, looking down into the gloom. "I take point. I'll be two steps below you. I'm the catch net. If you slip, you fall into me."

"I take the rear," Paige said, stepping behind Freddie. "I control the descent speed. Hand on the waist."

"Jenna, Sarah—go down first," Jessica ordered. "Clear the landing zone."

The twins scampered down the stairs, their bare feet thumping on the wood. They waited at the bottom, looking up like ground crew waiting for a shuttle landing.

"Ready?" Jessica asked, descending two steps and turning around to face him. Her eyes were level with his knees.

Freddie stood up from The Rover. He gripped the handrail with his right hand. It was rough wood—he made a mental note to sand it later.

"Ready," Freddie said.

He took the first step.

His right leg—the tighter one—trembled as it took the weight. He wobbled.

Instantly, Paige's hands were on his hips, stabilizing him. Jessica reached up and placed her hands on his thighs, guiding his foot placement.

"Easy," Jessica murmured. "One step. Good. Next."

It was a slow, intimate procession. Without clothes, there was no fabric to slip, no loose shirts to get caught.

Paige's skin pressed against his back, her chest warm against his spine. Jessica's hands on his legs were firm and grounding.

They moved as a single organism, flowing down the narrow chute.

Step. Stabilize. Step. Stabilize.

"Halfway," Freddie breathed, focusing on the top of Jessica's head.

"You got it," Paige whispered in his ear. "Gravity is under control."

They reached the concrete floor. Jessica stepped back, allowing Freddie to take the final step.

He landed on the slab. It was cold under his feet—a sharp, industrial shock compared to the hardwood upstairs.

"Touchdown," Freddie announced.

He looked around.

The basement was vast. It ran the full length of the house. The concrete floor was bare, save for the temporary setups the twins had thrown together last night.

To his left, Sarah's domain was currently just a sleeping bag neatly rolled out on the floor near the washer and dryer. Her carry-on case was open, her clothes already stacked in precise piles on top of the dryer.

To his right, Jenna's kingdom was a chaotic nest of blankets and pillows thrown into the corner, surrounded by boxes of computer parts that hadn't been unpacked yet.

"It is... potential," Freddie noted. "Currently unfurnished."

"We haven't ordered the beds yet," Jessica explained, walking over to inspect the water heater. "We were going to do a run to the mattress store tomorrow. Two twins? Or maybe bunk beds to save floor space?"

Jenna looked at her pile of blankets. Then she looked at Freddie, who was rubbing his arms in the cool basement air.

"Do we want beds down here?" Jenna asked suddenly.

Sarah looked up from her neat stack of shirts. "Clarification?"

"Last night," Jenna said, gesturing upstairs. "The Heap. The Silo. It was... crowded. But it was good crowded."

She looked at Freddie.

"You slept better, didn't you?" Jenna asked. "With all of us?"

"I did," Freddie admitted softly. "The pressure was... complete. The perimeter was sealed on all sides."

"If we move down here," Jenna continued, pacing the concrete floor, "then at night, the team splits. You guys are upstairs. We're downstairs. If Freddie wakes up scared... we aren't there."

Sarah frowned, processing the logic. "Separation of forces creates vulnerability."

"Exactly," Jenna said. "And honestly? I liked it too. I liked the weight. It stopped my brain from spinning."

"So what's the proposal?" Jessica asked, leaning against a support pole. "We can't fit five people in a King bed forever. Someone is going to get kicked in the face."

"We get a bigger bed," Sarah stated.

"They don't make bigger beds," Paige said. "King is the max."

"Then we build one," Freddie said.

The idea hit him like a lightning bolt. He looked at the vast, open floor plan of the basement.

"We possess the technology," Freddie murmured, his eyes scanning the space. "We can combine mattresses. Two Queens? Or a King and a Twin? We can build a frame that locks them together. A 'Mega-Bed'."

"A Mega-Bed," Jenna whispered, eyes shining. "Down here?"

"The space is sufficient," Freddie confirmed. "But..." He looked back at the stairs.

The steep, dangerous, narrow stairs.

"Access is the bottleneck," Freddie said, his shoulders slumping. "I cannot commute to the basement. The energy cost of the stairs is too high for daily ingress and egress."

"Then we fix the stairs," Jenna said. "We build a ramp!"

"Too steep," Freddie corrected. "The angle would require fifty feet of run."

Sarah walked over to the corner of the room, near where the old coal chute used to be. She looked up at the ceiling.

"What about... an elevator?" Sarah asked.

"An elevator?" Jessica laughed. "Sarah, this is a ranch house, not a hotel. You can't just put in an elevator. It costs fifty thousand dollars and you need a shaft."

"Not a people elevator," Sarah clarified, her hands moving as she visualized it. "Like... a platform. Just for one person. Like a forklift, but for a house."

Freddie perked up. "A vertical lift," he whispered. "Hydraulic or screw-drive. Low footprint."

"Yes!" Jenna shouted. "We cut a hole in the floor! Right there!" She pointed to a spot between the joists. "We put in a little platform. Freddie rolls on upstairs, pushes a button, zzzzzip, he's downstairs! No stairs! No spotters!"

Freddie looked at the ceiling. He imagined it. A dedicated lift. A direct line from the living room to the basement.

"If we had the lift," Freddie said, his voice trembling with excitement, "the basement becomes accessible. The Mega-Bed becomes viable."

"And we all sleep together," Paige finished the thought, squeezing his hand. "No one gets left out."

"We need to research," Freddie said. "The terminology. The cost. The structural requirements."

"I'll get the laptop," Jessica said, starting for the stairs. "Let's look it up. Right now."

"Wait," Freddie said. "I want to... verify the dimensions first."

He walked—slowly, carefully—across the concrete to the center of the room. He lay down on the floor.

"Freddie?" Paige asked.

"Mapping," Freddie said. "Lie down. Let's see if five fit."

Jenna didn't hesitate. She flopped down next to him. Sarah lay down on his other side. Paige and Jessica filled in the gaps.

They lay on the cold concrete floor of the unfinished basement, five naked adults staring up at the exposed rafters, visualizing a future where walls didn't matter, stairs didn't matter, and they never had to sleep apart again.

"It fits," Freddie whispered. "The architecture holds."

"Then we build it," Jessica declared. "We build the hive."

Scene 2: The Search Query

The Ops Room (formerly the second bedroom) was operating at peak capacity.

Jessica sat at her desk, her **MagnaByte** laptop open. Jenna and Sarah stood behind her, leaning in like co-pilots in a cockpit.

Freddie sat in **The Rover** near the door, watching the screen. Paige sat on the floor next to his wheel, her arm resting on his knee.

"Okay," Jessica said, cracking her knuckles. "Operation: Vertical Access. Let's find us an elevator."

She opened the search engine. She typed: elevator for house

She hit Enter.

The first result loaded. It was a website for **Royal Ascendancy Elevators**.

The landing page featured a photo of a woman in a ballgown stepping out of a glass cylinder in the middle of a marble foyer. The elevator had gold trim. It had a chandelier inside it.

"Whoa," Jenna said. "Is that a spaceship?"

"It is... ornate," Freddie noted. "Gold plating is unnecessary weight."

Jessica clicked the **Pricing** tab.

The Monarch Series: Starting at $55,000 (Installation not included). **Requirements:** 4-foot deep concrete pit. Dedicated machine room.

"Fifty-five thousand dollars," Jessica read flatly. "And we have to dig a hole under the house."

"Negative," Sarah said immediately. "That exceeds the budget. And it violates the structural integrity of the foundation."

"Okay," Jessica said, hitting the back button. "Too fancy. Let's look at the stairs."

She typed: wheelchair lift for stairs

Two types of results appeared.

Option A: The Chair Lift The first image showed an elderly woman smiling as she sat on a beige seat sliding up a rail.

"No," Freddie said instantly. He recoiled slightly in his chair. "Absolutely not."

"It gets you down there," Jenna pointed out.

"It requires a transfer," Freddie explained, his voice tight. "I would have to get out of The Rover. I would have to sit in that... seat. I would have to ride down slowly, exposed. And then? I would need a *second* wheelchair waiting at the bottom. I do not leave the vehicle."

Option B: The Inclined Platform Lift Jessica clicked the next link. "Okay, what about this?" Jessica asked. "It's called an Inclined Platform Lift. It's a platform that rides the rails. You roll The Rover right onto it, and it carries you down the stairs."

Freddie leaned forward. "Better," he admitted. "No transfer. I stay in the chassis."

"But look at the dimensions," Sarah interrupted, pointing to the specs. "Folded width: 14 inches. Unfolded width: 32 inches."

She turned to look at the hallway door.

"Our basement stairs are exactly 30 inches wide," Sarah calculated. "They are steep and narrow. If we bolt that rail to the wall, and the platform folds down... it takes up the entire stairwell."

"Which means," Jessica realized, "if Freddie is using it, no one else can use the stairs. And even when it's folded up, we lose half the walking space. We'd be squeezing past a metal wall every time we did laundry."

"It blocks the artery," Freddie said, shaking his head. "We cannot sacrifice the primary egress for the rest of the Unit. The stairs must remain clear."

"Okay," Jessica said. "So the stairs are out. We can't go *down* the stairs. We have to bypass them."

She typed: Thu-Floor Lift home

The results populated with images of industrial equipment.

Option C: The Shaft Lift The image showed a simple platform inside a Plexiglas box.

Indoor Installation: Requires a hoistway (shaft) constructed of drywall or plexiglass to prevent shear hazards.

"A shaft," Sarah noted. "If we put that in the living room, we have to build a closet around it. It blocks the sightlines. It eats up square footage."

"I do not want to ride in a closet," Freddie murmured. "I want to see the Bridge."

"Wait," Jenna said, pointing to a small link on the sidebar. "What's that? 'Through-Floor Series'?"

Jessica clicked the link.

The Access-Pro TFL-3000 (Through-Floor Lift). The image changed.

It wasn't a box in a shaft. It was a sleek, open capsule that ran on two vertical rails bolted to the wall. But the genius was in the floor.

The diagram showed the lift in the "Up" position. The car was in the living room. Then it showed the lift in the "Down" position. The car was in the basement. And the hole in the ceiling was sealed by a panel attached to the top of the lift. "Look at the mechanics," Jessica breathed, reading the specs. "**Self-Sealing Aperture.** When the lift goes down, the 'roof' of the car stays in the floor to plug the hole. When the lift goes up, a 'false floor' on the bottom of the car fills the hole so you can walk over it."

"It plugs the breach," Freddie whispered, mesmerized. "It is a vanishing airlock."

"No shaft required," Jessica read. "No pit. It bolts to the floor and the ceiling joists. It travels through the aperture."

"Through-Floor Lift," Freddie tested the name. *Tfl.*

He looked at the image of the tracks—two skeletal steel rails that looked like the launch towers for a rocket. It was industrial. It was raw. It didn't try to hide what it was.

"It looks like the turbo-lift on the *Avalon*," Freddie decided. "It transports between decks."

"Price?" Sarah asked, ever the pragmatic one.

Jessica clicked **Get Quote**.

Standard Model: $9,500. **Installation Kit:** Included.

"It's at the top of the budget," Jessica said, biting her lip. "But we don't have to build a shaft. That saves us lumber and drywall costs. And it saves the stairs."

Freddie looked at the screen. He looked at the term **Through-Floor Lift**.

It wasn't an "elevator" for a rich person. It wasn't a "stair lift" that blocked the hallway. It was a piece of specialized hardware designed to punch a hole in the universe and let him pass through.

"This is the solution," Freddie stated firmly. "We have found the terminology."

"Then let's order it," Jenna cheered. "I'll go get the tape measure. We need to find the spot!"

As Jenna ran out of the room, Freddie sat back in The Rover. He looked at the diagram on the screen—the tracks, the floating floor, the safety sensors.

It looked like something that belonged on the *Sanctuary*.

Tfl, Freddie repeated, testing the acronym. "It sounds... operational."

"It sounds like freedom," Paige whispered, resting her head on his shoulder.

Scene 3: The Mega-Bed

The "Thru-Floor Lift" was found. The TFL-3000 was in the virtual shopping cart. The method of descent was secured.

Now, they had to secure the destination.

"Phase Two," Jessica announced, opening a new browser tab. "The Landing Pad. We need a bed for the basement that actually fits five adults without someone waking up with a foot in their mouth."

"The King is 76 inches wide," Freddie recited, staring at the ceiling as he ran the numbers. "Divided by five occupants, that creates a lateral allotment of 15.2 inches per person."

"That is... coffin width," Sarah noted with a shudder. "It restricts circulation. I woke up with a numb arm."

"I woke up on the floor," Jenna added, though she didn't look upset about it.

"We need width," Paige said, sitting on the floor and leaning against *The Rover*. "But not *too* much width. Freddie likes the squeeze."

Freddie nodded. It was a delicate variable.

He thought about the night before—the weight of Jenna on his legs, the pressure of Sarah's grip on his arm, the warmth of Paige and Jessica flanking him. The sensation of being *buried* in his sisters was the most secure he had ever felt.

"I require... contact," Freddie clarified. "I do not want isolation. I want the tangle. But I require the option to rotate my spine without elbowing a ribcage."

"So, bigger than a King," Jessica summarized. "But we have to get it down those stairs."

She typed: biggest mattress size

The search results populated.

Alaskan King: 108" x 108". "Whoa," Jenna gasped. "Nine feet? That's an arena!"

Jessica clicked the price tag. **$7,500 (Mattress Only). Custom Freight Shipping Required.**

"Negative," Sarah said instantly. "That is the price of a used car. And we cannot get a nine-foot mattress down those narrow stairs. It physically won't fit through the door. It is a logistical impossibility."

"Agreed," Freddie said. "We need a modular solution."

"Modular," Jessica mused. "Like... building blocks."

She opened a new tab. combine mattresses to make bigger bed

The results were full of "family bed" forums and DIY hacks.

- **Option A:** Two Full Beds side-by-side. (54" + 54" = 108"). Same width as an Alaskan King.
- **Option B:** King + Twin XL. (76" + 38" = 114").
- **Option C:** Two Queen Beds. (60" + 60" = 120").

"Two Queens," Freddie calculated instantly. "Total width: 10 feet. Depth: 80 inches. That provides 24 inches of lateral space per person."

"That's double what we have now," Paige noted. "That's luxury. We could all lay flat on our backs and barely touch."

"But," Sarah interrupted, her brow furrowing as she visualized the schematic. "The seam. The crack between the mattresses. If you sleep in the middle—which is Freddie's position—you fall into the void. It collects debris. It pinches. It is unsanitary."

"There is a patch for that," Jessica said, scrolling down. She pointed to a product image: a T-shaped piece of foam called a **Bed Bridge**.

"You put this wedge in the crack," Jessica explained. "Then you use this..." She pointed to a heavy-duty nylon strap system. "...a connector belt. It wraps around the perimeter of both mattresses and ratchets tight so they don't slide apart."

"Structural integrity," Freddie noted. "But the texture... the bridge creates a bump."

"Layering," Jessica said. "We put the bridge in. We strap the beds together. And then..."

She clicked on a listing for a **Memory Foam Topper**.

"We buy two massive Queen-sized memory foam toppers. We lay them over the mattresses *and* the bridge. It unifies the surface. You won't even feel the seam."

Freddie closed his eyes. He pictured it.

Two Queen beds locked together in the center of the basement. A ten-foot-wide island of soft foam. No edges to fall off of. No fighting for covers.

He could lie in the center. Paige could be on his left, Jessica on his right. Sarah and Jenna could take the flanks, or they could all pile in the middle. The extra space meant they *could* spread out if it was hot, but the Bed Bridge meant they could still roll to the center and form the "Heap" without a gap stopping them.

"Two Queens," Freddie decided. "The geometry is sound. The modularity allows for transport down the narrow stairs."

"And the frame?" Jenna asked. "We can't just put them on the concrete. Spiders. Moisture."

Freddie looked at the specs for the *Access-Pro TFL* they had just found. He looked at his sisters.

"We are Forgers," Freddie stated, his voice firm. "We do not buy a frame. We build a platform."

"Wood?" Jessica asked.

"Lumber," Freddie confirmed. "2x4s and plywood. We build a riser in the basement. We carpet it. We drop the mattresses in. A custom install."

"I can build that," Jenna said, flexing her fingers. "I built stage sets in drama club. Give me a drill and a saw."

"Then it is settled," Jessica announced, closing the laptop. "Project: Mega-Bed is a go."

She looked at Freddie.

"We get the lift. We get the bed. And then... we never have to leave the pile."

"Never," Freddie whispered. "Systems... optimal."

Scene 4: The Pittsburgh Toilet

The "Mega-Bed" specifications were locked. The Thru-Floor Lift was in the cart. The digital architecture of the new basement was taking shape on the screen of the *MagnaByte* laptop.

"Okay," Jessica said, scrolling through a home improvement website. "Phase Three: Environment. We have a lift and a bed. But we are putting them into a concrete box."

She pulled up a listing for drywall and framing lumber.

"If we're going to make this a permanent habitat," Jessica suggested, "we should probably finish it. Put up studs. Drywall. Paint. Make it look like a real room instead of a dungeon."

"Objection," Jenna said immediately, raising her hand. "Denied."

"Clarification?" Jessica asked.

"I like the dungeon," Jenna stated, gesturing wildly. "It's raw. It's industrial. The exposed rafters? That's where I hang the lights. The concrete walls? That's my canvas. If you put up drywall, I can't drill into it without finding a stud. Concrete takes a masonry bit anywhere I want."

Sarah nodded in agreement, though for entirely different reasons.

"Drywall hides pests," Sarah noted. "It hides moisture. With the open concrete, I can visually inspect the foundation for cracks or water intrusion instantly. It is a transparent system."

Freddie considered this. He looked at the ceiling of the living room—smooth, painted white drywall. It was clean, but it was also a barrier.

"The industrial aesthetic aligns with the ship," Freddie murmured. "Exposed conduit. Structural beams. It looks like... Engineering."

"Exactly!" Jenna beamed. "It looks like the *Sanctuary* engine room. We keep it raw. We just clean it."

"Okay," Jessica conceded, closing the drywall tab. "We keep the bunker look. But we have a sanitation issue."

She pointed to the floor plan Freddie had sketched. In the far corner of the basement, near the laundry hookups, sat a lone, porcelain fixture.

It was a toilet. Just a toilet. Sitting out in the open on the concrete floor, with no walls, no sink, and no context.

"The Pittsburgh Toilet," Jessica said. "It's a plumber's early warning system for sewer backups. But if Freddie is going to be spending time down there... if we're *all* going to be sleeping down there... we can't just have a loose toilet in the corner."

"It lacks... infrastructure," Freddie agreed. "No handwashing station. No shower. Hygiene protocol cannot be completed."

"And while I appreciate the 'No Secrets' policy," Sarah added, adjusting her glasses, "hygiene requires containment. Vapors. Splashes. It needs a perimeter."

"We build a bathroom," Jenna decided. "We frame *that* in. Just that corner."

"A wet room," Jessica suggested. "Since we're on concrete, we don't need a tub. We can build a roll-in shower. A wide stall with a trench drain. Freddie can roll *The Rover* right in."

Freddie's eyes lit up. "Zero barrier entry," he whispered. "No lip to step over."

"Yes," Jessica said. "We frame a small room around the existing toilet stack. We add a sink. We add the shower head. We tile the whole thing so it's waterproof."

"Enclosed?" Paige asked. "Door or curtain?"

"Door," Sarah insisted. "For vapor control. But..." She looked at Freddie. She remembered the clear shower curtain upstairs. She remembered Paige telling her about the panic in his eyes when he couldn't see them.

"Maybe a door with a window?" Sarah offered. "Frosted glass? So light gets in, but it's still a room?"

"Or just a wide door we can leave open," Jenna shrugged. "Like upstairs. If Freddie is in there, we just guard the door. We're good at that."

"We are," Paige smiled, squeezing Freddie's hand.

"Okay," Jessica summarized. "We build a Bathroom Module in the corner. Sink, toilet, roll-in shower. The rest of the basement stays raw."

"And the floor?" Sarah asked, looking at the cold concrete. "Thermal regulation for the Mega-Bed. We cannot put mattresses on cold stone. It will wick the heat away."

"Carpet," Freddie said. "But not wall-to-wall. That traps dust."

"Area rugs?" Paige suggested.

"No," Jenna said. "Carpet tiles. Industrial squares. We buy a box of grey office carpet. We glue them down *just* under the bed platform and the walking area around it. We create a 'Soft Zone' in the middle of the concrete."

"Zone control," Freddie approved. "Hard perimeter, soft core."

"Perfect," Jessica said. "We have the plan. TFL for access. Mega-Bed for sleeping. Bathroom Module for hygiene. Raw concrete for aesthetics."

She looked at her siblings.

"We aren't just renovating a basement," Jessica realized. "We're building a command center."

"The Bridge," Freddie corrected softly. "We are building the Bridge."

"The Bridge," Paige agreed. "Let's order the lumber."

Scene 5: The Permit Phase

The kitchen table was covered in blueprints.

They weren't professional architectural drawings; they were CAD drawings Freddie had generated on his **Iron-Logic** laptop using the dimensions Jenna had gathered with a laser measure. The schematic clearly showed the "aperture"—the precise rectangular cutout required for the lift car to pass through the living room floor.

Jessica walked through the front door, slamming a thick folder onto the counter with a triumphant *thud*.

"Victory," Jessica announced. "The Town of Christiansburg has officially authorized the modifications. We have the building permit for the structural alteration (the aperture in the floor), the electrical permit for the 220-volt screw-drive motor, and the plumbing permit for the basement wet room."

"Did they ask about the joists?" Sarah asked, looking up from her label maker. "Cutting a structural member requires heading it off. Did they question the load calculations?"

"The clerk asked why we were cutting a hole in a perfectly good hardwood floor," Jessica grinned, pouring herself a glass of water. "I told her we were installing a 'Through-Floor Accessibility Conveyance' for a wheelchair user."

She leaned against the counter, looking pleased with herself.

"Technically, the ADA doesn't apply to private residences," Jessica explained, tapping the permit. "Legally, they could have bogged us down in code reviews for weeks. But no town official wants to be the person who said 'no' to a disabled kid getting to his bedroom. I said 'accessibility,' and she stamped it so hard the desk shook."

"Social engineering," Freddie noted from **The Rover**, inspecting the red stamp on the permit. "You leveraged the fear of litigation."

"I leveraged the culture of compliance," Jessica corrected. "The ADA is a powerful shield, even when it's just a suggestion."

"Excellent," Freddie decided. "Bureaucratic hack successful."

"Now," Jessica said, pointing to the drawing of the basement corner. "Phase Two: The Wet Room. We need to finalize the materials list. The plumber is coming tomorrow to rough in the shower drain."

They looked at the schematic.

The Pittsburgh Toilet Upgrade:

- **Existing:** One exposed toilet on a concrete slab.
- **New:** A framed enclosure (6' x 8'). A roll-in tiled shower with a trench drain. A wall-mounted sink (wheelchair height).

"The walls are easy," Jenna said. "2x4s and green-board. But the door?"

She looked at Freddie.

"Standard doors are opaque," Jenna noted. "Wood. Hollow core. If you're in there, and the door is closed... you're in a box."

Freddie stiffened slightly. He thought about the closet in Pasco. He thought about the feeling of walls closing in, cutting him off from the Unit.

"I do not like boxes," Freddie whispered. "Visual confirmation is... preferred."

“We could leave the door off?” Sarah suggested. “Like the upstairs bathroom when we shower?”

“Moisture control,” Jessica countered. “If we take hot showers down there, the steam will rot the floor joists above if we don’t contain it. We need a door to keep the humidity in the wet room.”

“Glass,” Paige said.

Everyone looked at her.

“A glass door,” Paige clarified. “Like a patio door. Or a full-lite interior door. Clear glass. Tempered.”

“See-through?” Sarah asked, blinking. “For a bathroom?”

“We are already naked,” Paige shrugged. “We already use a clear shower curtain upstairs. What difference does a clear door make? It keeps the steam in, but Freddie can look out and see us sitting on the Mega-Bed. He never feels trapped.”

Freddie visualized it.

He is in the shower. The warm water is hitting his back. He looks up. Instead of a white wooden door blocking his view, he sees a pane of glass. Through it, he sees the basement—Jenna working on her servers, Sarah organizing shelves.

He is not cut off. He is contained, but connected.

“Glass,” Freddie decided. “Transparency allows for safety monitoring. If I slip... you see it instantly.”

“Plus,” Jenna grinned, “it looks cool. Very industrial. Like a lab.”

“Glass door it is,” Jessica noted, writing it down. “And the shower curtain?”

“Clear vinyl,” Freddie and Paige said in unison.

“Standard protocol,” Freddie added. “No hiding.”

The contractor Jessica had hired—a gruff man named Miller who usually built decks—arrived with a reciprocating saw and a solemn expression.

“You sure about this?” Miller asked, looking at the pristine hardwood floor in the corner of the living room. “Once I cut this hole, there ain’t no putting it back.”

“Cut it,” Jessica commanded.

Freddie watched from the kitchen, wearing his earplugs.

RRRRRR-CHHHK.

The saw bit into the wood. Dust flew. The noise was a deafening vibration that rattled the plates in the cabinets.

Freddie gripped Paige’s hand. He felt the floor shake.

It wasn't destruction. It was surgery. They were carving a new artery into the heart of the house.

An hour later, it was done.

A perfect, rectangular hole, 4.5 feet by 5 feet, gaped in the living room floor.

Jenna poked her head up through it from the basement, grinning like a goblin.

"Hello from the underworld!" she shouted. "The portal is open!"

The **Access-Pro TFL-3000** arrived on a flatbed truck.

It didn't look like an elevator. It looked like the spine of a robot.

Two massive, skeletal steel tracks were bolted vertically to the basement floor and the living room wall, passing straight through the newly cut aperture. The lift car itself wasn't a box; it was a sleek, three-sided capsule that rode between the rails.

"Through-Floor technology," Freddie noted, rolling **The Rover** closer to inspect the drive mechanism. "No hoistway. No pit. It utilizes the structure of the house itself."

"Look at the cap," Jessica pointed out.

Sitting on top of the lift car was a rectangular panel. Miller, the contractor, was currently attaching the piece of hardwood flooring he had cut out of the living room to this panel.

"The Sealing Plug," Sarah identified. "When the lift is down, that panel fills the hole in the living room floor. When the lift is up, the bottom of the car fills the hole. The breach is always sealed."

"Binary state," Freddie nodded. "Open or Closed. No fall hazard."

The installers wired it to the new 220v circuit. They tested it.

Whirrrrrrrr.

The lift rose from the basement. It moved silently on the rails. As it crested the living room floor, the bottom of the car locked flush with the hardwood.

Then, they sent it down. As the car descended, the "Plug" on the roof of the car settled perfectly into the opening, turning the living room floor back into a solid surface.

"Ready for a test drive?" the installer asked.

Freddie looked at the open cab. It was metal. It was industrial. It looked like a turbo-lift from a starship.

It was perfect.

He rolled The Rover onto the platform. He locked his brakes.

"Going down," Freddie announced.

He pressed the button.

Whirrrrrrrr.

The floor dropped away.

He sank smoothly through the aperture. For a moment, he was in the "between"—seeing the cross-section of the floor joists, the wiring, the guts of the house.

Then, he was through.

Above him, the "Plug" clicked into place, sealing the ceiling of the basement and restoring the floor of the living room.

He descended into the cool, grey light of the Underworld.

He landed gently on the concrete floor.

Jenna was waiting for him, standing next to the newly framed (but not yet tiled) bathroom walls.

"Welcome to the Bridge, Captain," Jenna said, saluting.

Freddie looked up. The ceiling was sealed. He was in the bunker. And he hadn't used the stairs.

"Access confirmed," Freddie whispered, tears pricking his eyes. "The Base is... fully operational."

Scene 6: The Wet Room

The noise was absolute.

Miller, the contractor who had cut the aperture for the lift last week, was back. This time, he was wielding a concrete saw to carve a channel into the basement slab for the new trench drain.

REEEEE-GRIND.

Upstairs in the living room, Freddie sat in **The Rover**, his high-fidelity earplugs inserted deep. He could still feel the vibration in the wheels of his chair.

"Structural modification," Freddie noted, feeling the floorboards buzz. "They are rewriting the foundation."

"They're making a path," Paige said, sitting on the arm of the sofa. "A zero-entry path."

Downstairs, the grinding stopped abruptly. The dust hung in the air like fog.

Miller stood up, wiping concrete dust from his safety goggles. He took a drink of water, and then his eyes drifted to the center of the room.

The **Access-Pro TFL-3000** was parked in the "Down" position. The sleek steel rails shot up through the ceiling, vanishing into the living room. The "Plug" on the roof of the car was perfectly flush with the ceiling joists above.

Miller walked over to it. He tapped the heavy steel track.

"Well, I'll be damned," Miller muttered, looking up at the hole he had cut. "I thought you folks were crazy for cutting into that oak floor. But this... this is slick."

He looked at the open cab, then at the ramp he was cutting into the concrete for the shower.

"It ain't an elevator," Miller realized aloud. "It's a transporter."

The dust had settled. The noise had stopped.

Freddie rode the TFL down to the basement to inspect the progress.

The corner was transformed. Where once there was just a lonely toilet sitting in the open, there were now walls—2x4 framing covered in green mold-resistant drywall.

Miller had built a 6-foot by 8-foot enclosure. It was spacious.

"Clearance check," Freddie said, rolling inside the framed "room."

He spun The Rover in a 360-degree circle. He didn't hit a wall.

"Five-foot turning radius confirmed," Freddie nodded. "ADA compliant."

He looked at the floor. The concrete had been sloped gently toward a long, stainless steel grate along the back wall—the linear drain.

"No curb," Freddie whispered. "I can roll right over the drain."

"And look," Jenna pointed to the electrical box wired into the doorframe. "That's for the door. Miller thinks we're crazy for spending the money on it, but he wired it."

The Finishes

The tiling was complete.

True to the "Industrial/Sci-Fi" aesthetic of the Avery Unit, they hadn't chosen beige bathroom tile. They had chosen White Subway Tile for the walls (clean, institutional, bright) and Matte Black Hexagon Tile for the floor (high grip for the wheelchair).

The grout was dark grey.

"High contrast," Sarah approved, inspecting the grout lines. "Easy to identify dirt. Easy to clean."

The fixtures were installed next.

• The Sink: A wall-mounted "trough" style sink with no cabinet underneath, allowing Freddie to roll his knees completely under it.

• The Shower: A heavy chrome unit with a rainfall head on the ceiling and a handheld wand on a long hose, positioned low enough for a seated user to reach.

"It looks like a decontamination chamber," Freddie said approvingly. "It is... sterile."

The Smart Glass

The final piece arrived in a crate marked FRAGILE: SWITCHABLE PRIVACY GLASS.

This was the most expensive single item in the renovation, funded by a significant chunk of the Avery Grant.

Miller and his assistant carefully lifted the heavy glass slab into the doorframe. It was a single, massive pane of glass, framed in brushed aluminum.

"Okay," Miller said, wiping his hands on his pants. "It's wired. You want to test it?"

Freddie rolled up to the door.

Currently, the glass was opaque—a milky, frosted white. He couldn't see through it.

"Default state is 'Privacy'," Jessica explained. "When the power is off, the liquid crystals are scattered. It blocks the view."

"Switch is here," Jenna pointed to a sleek rocker switch on the outside wall (and a matching one inside).

Freddie reached out. He flipped the switch.

Click.

Instantly—faster than a blink—the glass turned completely transparent.

The milky white vanished. It looked like the door wasn't even there. He could see the subway tile, the chrome shower, the black floor.

"Whoa," Jenna breathed. "Star Trek force field."

"PDLC technology," Freddie murmured, mesmerized. "Polymer Dispersed Liquid Crystal. Voltage aligns the particles."

"Here's the logic," Jessica said. "99% of the time, we leave it ON (Clear). When you're showering, we can see you. We know you're safe. You can see us working on the servers or folding laundry. You aren't in a box."

"But," Sarah added, "if we ever have a guest... or if a plumber comes... or if Mom forces her way in... we hit the switch. Frost Mode. Instant visual barrier."

"Privacy on demand," Freddie said. "Security default."

He rolled into the bathroom. He looked out through the clear glass. He saw his sisters standing in the basement.

He flipped the switch inside.

Zap. The world turned white. He was hidden.

He flipped it back.

Zap. He was connected again.

"Optimal," Freddie decided. "The variable is controlled."

The First Cycle

The contractors were gone. The dust was swept. The basement was theirs.

"Maiden voyage," Paige announced. "Shower protocol."

The Avery Unit descended—Freddie via the TFL, the sisters via the stairs.

They stripped down in the main basement area. The "No Armor" rule was now standard operating procedure.

Freddie rolled The Rover into the new bathroom.

He didn't have to be lifted over a tub rim. He didn't have to be transferred to a slippery plastic bench.

He simply rolled his titanium chair right under the shower head. The titanium wouldn't rust. The cushion was waterproof.

"Water on," Freddie said.

He reached out and turned the lever.

Warm water rained down from the ceiling. It soaked him, running over the matte black frame of the chair, swirling into the trench drain.

He looked up.

Through the clear glass door, he saw the basement.

He saw Jenna plugging cables into her server rack, bathed in the blue glow of LEDs.

He saw Sarah organizing a shelf of towels, lining up the edges.

He saw Jessica and Paige sitting on the newly constructed platform of the Mega-Bed, watching him.

They weren't hovering. They weren't panicked. They were just... there.

He wasn't cut off. He wasn't alone in a closet. He was in the center of the hive.

Freddie closed his eyes, letting the water run over his face.

"System status," he whispered to the steam. "Perfect."

Scene 7: The Mega-Bed Assembly

The driveway of 105 Pepper Street looked like a construction staging area.

A large delivery truck from Comfort-Rest Mattress Depot was idling at the curb. Next to it, the family's silver Horizon Sanctuary was parked with its trunk open, filled with bags of hardware and rolls of grey carpet tiles.

"Delivery for Avery," the driver called out, checking his clipboard. "I've got two Queen mattresses and two Queen box springs. You guys got a team to move this?"

"We are the team," Jessica announced, stepping out onto the porch. She was wearing her 'construction uniform'—denim shorts and a tank top. "Bring them to the garage door."

"Garage?" the driver asked. "Usually people want these in the bedroom."

"We're building the bedroom," Jenna grinned, bouncing on her heels. "Just drop them. We'll handle the insertion."

The driver shrugged and unloaded the plastic-wrapped mattresses onto the driveway. As soon as he drove away, the Avery Unit mobilized.

"Phase One: The Platform," Freddie commanded from The Rover. He was positioned on the front porch, overseeing the operation with a clipboard. "We need to construct the riser before we deploy the foam."

"Lumber is already downstairs," Sarah reported. "I staged the 2x4s and the plywood sheets last night. All cuts were made at the hardware store to my specifications."

"Precision cutting," Freddie nodded approvingly. "Let's descend."

They moved to the living room. Freddie rolled onto the TFL-3000 platform.

"Going down," he said, pressing the button.

Whirrrrrrrr.

He sank into the floor, disappearing into the basement.

The sisters took the stairs.

The center of the basement floor was cleared. The concrete was swept clean.

"Layout," Jessica ordered.

They laid out the pressure-treated 2x4s in a massive rectangle: 10 feet wide by 80 inches long.

"We need cross-bracing every 16 inches," Sarah reminded them, holding the tape measure. "Standard code. We don't want the middle to sag under the weight of the pile."

"We aren't building a deck, Sarah," Jenna laughed, grabbing the power drill. "But okay. Over-engineering is our brand."

They worked as a crew.

- **Jessica and Paige:** The muscle. They held the long boards in place.
- **Sarah:** The architect. She measured the spacing and marked the drill points with a pencil.
- **Jenna:** The mechanic. She drove the 3-inch screws with a satisfying ZZZT-THUNK.
- **Freddie:** The supervisor. He rolled around the perimeter, checking the angles.

"Square the corners," Freddie instructed. "If the frame is rhomboid, the mattresses won't fit."

"It's square," Sarah promised. "I measured the diagonals. Within 1/16th of an inch."

Once the grid of 2x4s was built, they laid the sheets of 3/4-inch plywood on top. Jenna screwed them down.

ZZZT-ZZZT-ZZZT.

The platform was complete. A massive, low wooden stage sitting six inches off the concrete floor.

"Carpet time," Paige said, grabbing the box of tiles.

They peeled the backing off the industrial grey carpet squares and stuck them to the plywood. They also carpeted the sides of the platform so no one would scrape a shin on raw wood.

"Soft edges," Freddie noted. "Safety feature."

"Okay," Jessica wiped sweat from her forehead. "Heavy lift time. We have to get the mattresses down here."

"The stairs are too narrow for a Queen to go flat," Sarah analyzed. "We have to taco them."

"Taco?" Freddie asked.

"Fold it in half," Jessica explained. "Like a taco shell. Then strap it so it stays bent. It's not great for the springs, but for a short trip, it'll survive."

They went out to the driveway. They wrestled the first mattress into a U-shape and used ratchet straps to hold it.

It took four of them to guide the beast down the narrow stairs—Jessica and Paige pulling from the bottom, Sarah and Jenna pushing from the top.

"Pivot!" Jenna yelled, laughing as they navigated the turn.

They got both mattresses down. They cut the straps. The beds popped back into shape with a loud whump.

They placed them side-by-side on the carpeted platform.

"The Gap," Freddie pointed out immediately.

There it was. A distinct canyon between the two beds where the rounded edges met.

"Deploy the Bridge," Jessica commanded.

Paige opened the package. She took out the T-shaped foam wedge. She pushed it into the crack. It filled the void perfectly, creating a flush surface.

"Now the strap," Sarah said.

They ran the heavy nylon connector belt around the entire perimeter of the 10-foot mega-structure. Jessica ratcheted it tight.

Click-click-click.

The two mattresses were squeezed together until they became one solid unit.

"Unified," Freddie whispered.

"Final layer," Paige said.

They unrolled the two massive memory foam toppers. They laid them over the mattresses and the bridge.

The foam absorbed the seam completely. Freddie rolled The Rover up to the edge of the platform (it was low enough for him to transfer easily). He reached out and pressed his hand into the center.

He couldn't feel the crack. He couldn't feel the bridge. He just felt foam.

"Seamless," Freddie declared. "Surface continuity is 100%."

Making a 10-foot-wide bed required teamwork.

They put on the fitted sheets. Then came the custom creation: The Mega-Duvet.

Jessica and Sarah had spent the last week sewing three King-sized duvet covers together. They had stuffed it with three down comforters.

It was enormous. It was a sea of maroon fabric.

They threw it over the bed. It floated down, settling like a cloud.

"It's huge," Jenna whispered. "It's an island."

"It's the Silo," Freddie corrected. "Mark III."

He looked at the bed. It sat in the center of the raw, industrial basement. To the left was the sleek new glass-walled bathroom. To the right, Jenna's server lights blinked in the dark.

Overhead, the exposed floor joists created a cozy, lowered ceiling.

It didn't look like a bedroom in a catalog. It looked like a habitat module on a space station.

"Test run?" Paige asked.

"Test run," Freddie agreed.

He locked his brakes. He transferred from The Rover onto the edge of the bed. The memory foam contoured to his body.

He scooted to the dead center—the place where the crack used to be. He lay back.

He felt... nothing. No ridge. No dip. Just support.

"Center is stable," Freddie announced. "Deploy the Unit."

Jessica, Paige, Sarah, and Jenna climbed onto the platform.

They crawled toward the center.

Configuration:

- Freddie: Center.
- Paige & Jessica: Flanking him tightly.
- Sarah & Jenna: taking the outer wings, but still close enough to touch.

There was so much room. They could sprawl. They could roll. But true to form, they didn't. They huddled in the middle, a knot of humanity in the center of their vast new empire.

Freddie looked up at the rafters. He listened to the hum of the servers and the distant trickle of the shower drain.

"This is it," Freddie whispered. "The architecture is complete."

"We built it," Jessica said, resting her head on his shoulder. "We actually built it."

"Nap time?" Jenna suggested.

"Nap time," everyone agreed.

And in the cool, quiet basement of 105 Pepper Street, on a bed big enough for an army but used by a family, the Avery Unit finally rested.

The Satellite Link

Scene 1: The Radford Protocol

The Saturday morning routine at "The Base" was usually a slow, deliberate boot sequence. Freddie would roll The Rover onto the TFL platform, descend to the

“Bridge” (the basement), and join the twins for a server diagnostic or a round of Super Plumber Bros.

But today, the house was vibrating with a different kind of energy.

The phone on the kitchen wall rang. It wasn’t the shrill, demanding ring of Ellen calling from Norfolk. It was a softer, melodic chirping—the ringtone assigned to “Friendly Forces.”

Jessica picked it up. “Avery Base, Jessica speaking.”

“Jessie!” The voice on the other end was loud, warm, and distinctly Appalachian. “It’s Aunt Linda! We’re in the neighborhood!”

Jessica’s posture relaxed instantly. “Aunt Linda? Where are you?”

“We moved back!” Linda announced, her voice crackling with excitement. “I told Ellen I couldn’t take the humidity anymore. I packed up the girls and we headed for the hills. We got a place in Radford! Just across the river!”

“Radford?” Jessica repeated, her eyes widening. She covered the mouthpiece and looked at Freddie, who was eating toast at the island. “It’s Aunt Linda. She moved to Radford. She has the girls.”

Freddie stopped chewing. “The younger units? Harper? Amanda? Elara?”

“All of them,” Jessica confirmed. She went back to the phone. “Linda, that’s amazing! Where are you staying?”

“We got a big apartment at Highland Village,” Linda said. “It’s right near the university. But listen, we’re in the van right now. We’re coming to see you! Ellen gave me the address—though she made a sour face when she did it. We’ll be there in twenty minutes!”

“Twenty minutes,” Jessica repeated. “Okay. We’ll be ready.”

She hung up.

“Action stations!” Jessica shouted. “Aunt Linda is inbound! ETA 20 minutes! And she’s bringing the satellites!”

The house exploded into motion.

“Clean sweep!” Sarah yelled from the basement stairs. “Hide the laundry! Clear the counters!”

“Wait,” Freddie said, raising a hand. “Protocol check. Does Linda know about... the configuration?”

He pointed to the basement door. He pointed to The Rover. He pointed to the fact that they were all currently naked.

“Linda isn’t Mom,” Jessica said, grabbing a stack of mail off the table. “Linda is cool. But... maybe we put on clothes? Just for the initial handshake?”

“Pants are logical,” Freddie agreed. “Social camouflage.”

They scrambled.

A beat-up maroon minivan pulled into the driveway behind the Avalon. The side door slid open with a grinding crunch.

Out spilled the chaos.

First came **Harper** (Age 14). She was wearing purple headphones around her neck and a t-shirt that said LOUD NOISES.

She hopped out of the van, but she didn’t run to the porch. She turned back to the open door and grabbed the frame of a wheelchair—neon purple, lightweight, and folded.

She yanked it out, snapped it open with a practiced thwack, and sat down in it right there in the driveway.

“Deployed!” Harper shouted, spinning the chair in a tight circle. “Tires on the ground!”

Then came the twins, **Amanda and Elara** (Age 12). They moved like a single organism. Elara was talking a mile a minute. Amanda, the silent twin, was making soft, happy humming noises—hmm-hmm-hmm—as she flapped her hands gently by her sides, looking at the trees.

Finally, Aunt Linda stepped out of the driver’s seat. She was wearing a floral muumuu and oversized sunglasses. She looked like a woman who had survived a war and decided to throw a party to celebrate.

“Look at this place!” Linda shouted, waving her arms. “You guys got a whole house! It’s adorable!”

Jessica opened the front door. “Aunt Linda!”

They hugged on the porch. It was a real hug—warm, squishy, and smelling of peppermint.

“Get in here, you nuggets!” Linda waved at the younger girls. “Come see your big sisters! And your Captain!”

The girls rushed the porch—Amanda and Elara running, Harper rolling up the ramp with aggressive speed.

Freddie sat in The Rover in the living room. He felt a spike of anxiety. He hadn’t seen the younger ones in three years. Would they think his chair was weird? Would they be scared?

Harper burst through the door, her purple wheels blurring. She slammed on her brakes, stopping inches from Freddie.

She didn’t look pitying. She looked... competitive.

"Sick wheels," Harper said, eyeing his setup. She reached out and tapped his titanium rim. "Cambered? Matte black? That is high-performance."

Freddie blinked. "It is... optimized. For agility."

"Nice," Harper grinned, patting her own armrest. "I finally got mine. Mom wouldn't let me use it in the house, but Aunt Linda says if my legs hurt, I roll. So I roll."

"Efficiency," Freddie agreed, feeling a massive weight lift off his chest. She wasn't scared. She was a fellow pilot.

"Cool," Harper said. She looked around the living room. "Where's the stereo? This room needs bass."

"Basement," Jenna yelled, popping up from the hole in the floor (riding the TFL up). "We have the subs down there!"

Harper's eyes went wide. "You have a hole in the floor? That moves?"

"It's a TFL," Freddie explained. "Thu-Floor Lift. Access to the Bridge."

"I want a ride," Harper declared.

"Authorized," Freddie smiled.

Then came the twins. Elara walked up to Freddie. She looked at him with serious, dark eyes.

"Mom said you were sick," Elara said. "She said you were 'broken.' "

Freddie stiffened. The "Robert Virus" had a variant: The "Ellen Virus."

"Mom is incorrect," Paige said, stepping up behind Freddie and putting her hands on his shoulders. "Freddie isn't broken. He's upgraded."

Amanda walked up to him. She didn't speak words. She looked at his face, then at the wheels of his chair.

"Mmm," Amanda vocalized, a low, inquisitive grunt. She reached out and touched his knee.

She smiled. It was a tiny, private smile.

She reached into her pocket and pulled out a small, perfectly smooth grey stone. She placed it on Freddie's knee.

"Ah!" she exclaimed softly, tapping the stone.

"Data transfer," Freddie whispered, recognizing the gesture. "Object of value."

"She likes you," Elara translated. "She thinks the chair makes you look like a robot. Robots are cool."

"Robots are superior," Freddie agreed.

“Okay!” Linda clapped her hands, stepping into the living room. “So here’s the deal. I have custody. Full stop. Ellen signed the papers last week. She said she ‘couldn’t handle the noise’ anymore.”

Linda rolled her eyes.

“Her loss, my gain. We are living in Radford. Highland Village apartments. It’s nice. It’s got a pool. And the best part?”

She looked at the Avery Unit.

“You guys have full visitation rights. Anytime. Day or night. You want to come over for dinner? Come over. You want to take the girls for a weekend? Take them. We are a satellite office.”

“Satellite office,” Jessica repeated, grinning. “That means the network is expanding.”

“And,” Linda added, leaning in conspiratorially, “I heard about the bed.”

The room went silent.

“The... bed?” Sarah asked.

“The Mega-Bed,” Linda winked. “Marge told me before she passed. She said, ‘Linda, those kids are sleeping in a pile like hamsters, and it is the sweetest thing I ever saw. Don’t let Ellen ruin it.’ ”

She looked at the TFL. She looked at the open door to the basement where the Mega-Bed waited.

“You guys doing okay? Sleeping good?”

“We sleep... optimally,” Freddie said.

“Good,” Linda said firmly. “Because if anyone gives you grief about it, you send them to me. I’ll hit ’em with my purse.”

She hugged Freddie, bending down to wrap her arms around him in the chair.

“We’re back, Freddie,” Linda whispered. “The mountains are full again.”

“The grid is reconnected,” Freddie said, feeling the warmth of the family expanding around him. “Signal strength... maximum.”

“Now,” Harper shouted from the TFL platform, having already rolled onto it. “How do I make this thing go down? I need to see the servers!”

“Press the down arrow,” Freddie instructed. “Enjoy the descent.”

Whirrrrrrrr.

Harper sank into the floor, cackling with glee as she disappeared into the underworld.

The Avery Unit was back online.

Scene 2: The Holding Pattern

The basement was vibrating.

It wasn't the hum of Jenna's servers or the rumble of the TFL. It was the sheer, uncontained energy of Harper Avery.

She sat in her purple wheelchair in the center of the concrete floor, spinning circles around the support columns. She looked at the server rack glowing blue in the corner. She looked at the glass-walled bathroom. She looked at the massive Mega-Bed platform.

"Okay," Harper announced, slamming her brakes. "I've run the diagnostics. This place is optimal. I'm moving in."

She looked up at Jessica, who was leaning against the TFL tower.

"My bags are in the van," Harper said. "Just grab 'em. I can sleep on the Mega-Bed. Or I'll sleep under the servers. I don't care. I am not leaving."

Jenna, who was currently soldering a wire at her workbench, grinned. "Roommate! We can set up a DAW (Digital Audio Workstation) right next to the render farm!"

"Hold on," Jessica said, holding up a hand. "Pause."

"Why pause?" Harper argued, her voice rising in pitch (Sensory Seeker volume). "Mom is gone. Linda has custody. We're all here. Why can't I stay?"

Aunt Linda descended the stairs—carefully—followed by Sarah. Linda walked over to Harper and placed a hand on her shoulder.

"Because, Little Bit," Linda said gently, "I promised the judge I would provide a stable home for you in Radford. If you move in here with five adults in a basement... well, Ellen would have a field day. She'd call social services so fast your head would spin."

"She can't!" Harper yelled. "She signed the papers!"

"She signed custody to me," Linda corrected. "Not to Jessica. And definitely not to a fraternity house of siblings."

Jessica stepped forward. She knelt down so she was eye-level with Harper.

"Harper, listen to the strategy," Jessica said, her voice calm and logical. "Right now, you are fourteen. You are a minor. As long as you are a minor, Ellen has a lever she can pull. She can claim we're 'corrupting' you. She can claim the environment is unsafe."

"It's safer than her house!" Harper shot back.

"We know that," Jessica agreed. "But the law loves paperwork. So, here is the rule. The 'Adult Protocol'."

Jessica held up three fingers.

"You stay with Aunt Linda. You go to school in Radford. You get good grades."

She folded one finger.

"You visit us whenever you want. Weekends. Holidays. Summer breaks. You have a key to the front door."

She folded a second finger.

"But you do not officially move your address to 105 Pepper Street until the day you turn eighteen."

Harper slumped in her chair. "Eighteen? That's... that's three years! That's forever."

"It is 1,217 days," Freddie said.

He was sitting in The Rover near the glass bathroom door. He rolled forward.

"I waited," Freddie said softly. "I waited for the bus to Seattle. I waited for the diagnosis. The wait is... difficult. But the execution must be clean."

He looked at Harper.

"If you move now, there is static. There is legal noise. If you move at eighteen... you are a legal adult. Ellen cannot speak. The law cannot speak. You simply... transfer."

"Clean execution," Harper mumbled, kicking at the floor with her footplate. "Like a code update."

"Exactly," Jessica said. "And the same goes for the twins. Amanda and Elara stay with Linda until they're eighteen. We do this by the book."

"But I want to hang out!" Harper protested. "I want to record! I want to be part of the Unit!"

"You are part of the Unit," Linda smiled. "And listen, honey... my apartment isn't a prison. It's Highland Village. It's got a pool."

Linda looked at Freddie.

"And it's fully accessible," Linda added. "Ground floor. Wide doors. Roll-in shower in the master bath—just like this one, though maybe not as fancy with the glass door. Freddie can come to us just as easily as you come here."

Freddie perked up. "Accessible?"

"I made sure of it," Linda nodded. "I told the leasing agent, 'I have a niece in a chair and a nephew in a chair, and if they can't get in the bathroom, I'm not signing the lease.' The Rover will fit just fine."

"A satellite base," Freddie whispered. "Radford is... online."

"We can take the bus!" Paige said, coming down the stairs with a tray of sodas. "Route 3 connects Pepper Plaza to Radford. It runs every thirty minutes on weekdays. It's a direct link."

Harper looked at Freddie. She looked at the TFL. Then she looked at Aunt Linda, who was smiling patiently.

She realized she wasn't being rejected. She was being protected.

"Okay," Harper sighed. "Protocol accepted. But I'm spending every weekend here."

"Deal," Jessica said.

"And," Harper added, pointing a finger at Jenna. "I want a countdown clock. On the server. Counting down to October 30, 2010. The second it hits zero, I'm bringing my speakers."

"I'll code it tonight," Jenna promised.

"Then it's settled," Linda said, clapping her hands. "Now, who wants to give me a tour of this 'Mega-Bed' I keep hearing about? I want to see if it's as comfy as Marge said it would be."

"Initiating tour," Freddie said, spinning The Rover around. "Follow me."

Scene 3: The Cargo Bay

The migration to the "Bridge" began.

Because the TFL-3000 was a single-occupancy transport, the descent had to be staggered.

"Captain first," Harper insisted, rolling her purple chair back to give him clearance. "I want to see how the suspension handles the landing."

"Acknowledged," Freddie said. He rolled onto the steel platform. He pressed the DOWN button.

Whirrrrrrrr.

The screw drive turned, lowering him smoothly into the floor. As he sank, he looked up to see Harper grinning at him from the rim of the aperture.

When the platform hit the basement concrete, Freddie rolled off.

"Lift clear," Freddie called up. "Send the next unit."

Upstairs, Harper rolled onto the platform. She hit the button. She descended with a squeal of delight, her hands gripping the yellow safety rails.

"It's like a spaceship!" Harper yelled as she touched down. "Freddie, this is way better than a ramp!"

"Screw drive technology," Freddie noted, tapping the threaded rod. "Reliable."

While the wheelchair users took the lift, the rest of the family—Jessica, Paige, Sarah, Jenna, Linda, and the twins—navigated the steep wooden stairs.

Within five minutes, the basement was fully populated.

Nine people stood (or sat) on the concrete floor. The space, which usually felt vast with just the five residents, now felt comfortably full.

Freddie looked around.

To his left, Sarah stood by the washer and dryer, explaining her sorting system to Aunt Linda. To his right, Jenna was showing Elara the server rack, explaining how the blue LEDs indicated drive activity. Near the bathroom, Amanda was staring at the switchable privacy glass, entranced by the way it turned from frost to clear. And right next to him, Harper and Paige were inspecting the wheels of The Rover.

Seven sisters. All of them.

Freddie felt a pressure in his chest that had nothing to do with anxiety. It was fullness. The "System" wasn't just operational; it was thriving.

"Okay," Jessica announced, clapping her hands to gather attention. "Welcome to the Hive. Let's do the grand tour."

She pointed to the far wall.

"Zone 1: Logistics. Sarah's domain. Laundry, bulk storage, and emergency supplies. Everything is labeled. Do not move a box unless you want a lecture."

"It is an inventory system," Sarah corrected, adjusting her glasses. "Movement creates entropy."

Jessica pointed to the corner with the blinking lights.

"Zone 2: Data. Jenna's domain. Servers, art supplies, and general fire hazards. Don't touch the wires."

"They aren't hazards!" Jenna protested. "They're cable-managed!"

Jessica pointed to the glass enclosure.

"Zone 3: Hygiene. The wet room. Roll-in shower, accessible sink, and yes, that is a glass door. We value visibility over privacy down here."

Amanda walked up to the glass. She pressed her hand against it. She looked at Freddie and tapped the glass. Tap-tap.

"Transparency," Freddie explained to her. "Safety."

"And finally," Jessica said, turning to the massive structure in the center of the room. "Zone 4: The Silo."

The group gathered around the Mega-Bed.

It sat on its carpeted platform, a ten-foot-wide expanse of maroon duvet and memory foam. It looked less like a piece of furniture and more like a geography.

"It's huge," Aunt Linda breathed. "Marge wasn't kidding. You could sleep a football team on that thing."

"We sleep five," Paige said, sitting on the edge and patting the mattress. "And it works. No one falls off. No one gets cold."

Harper rolled up to the edge of the platform. She looked at the bed. She looked at the open floor plan. She looked at the glass bathroom door.

"This is awesome," Harper said, her eyes wide. "It's like a slumber party that never ends. Seriously, Jessica, why can't I stay? There's plenty of room on the bed. I'm small!"

Jessica sighed. She exchanged a look with Aunt Linda.

This was the hard part.

"Harper," Jessica said gently. "Look around. Really look."

She gestured to the room.

"There are no walls. There are no doors except for the bathroom, and even that is glass. When we say we have 'no privacy,' we mean it. We sleep together. We change clothes together. We shower with the door clear so we know Freddie is safe."

Jessica stepped closer to Harper.

"You are fourteen. You are a teenager. You need a door you can close when you want to talk on the phone. You need a room where you can figure out who you are without five adults watching you."

"I don't care about privacy!" Harper argued. "I care about the Unit!"

"You care now," Aunt Linda stepped in, putting a hand on Harper's shoulder. "But honey, in a year? When you start dating? Or when you just want to cry over a bad grade? You're going to want a wall."

Linda looked at the bed.

"This works for them," Linda said, gesturing to the older siblings. "Because they are adults who made a choice to live in a... very specific way. A way that helps Freddie. But you? You deserve to be a kid a little longer. You deserve your own space."

Freddie rolled forward. He stopped next to Harper.

"The architecture is open-source," Freddie said quietly.

Harper looked at him.

"This environment," Freddie explained, gesturing to the open basement, "is designed for my support needs. It requires total exposure. Zero secrets. That is a heavy tax on the user."

He looked her in the eye.

"You are a Satellite," Freddie stated. "Satellites have their own orbit. If you crash into the planet, you burn up. Stay in orbit, Harper. Maintain your own gravity until you are ready for re-entry."

Harper looked at him. She looked at the bed—which suddenly looked very crowded in her imagination. She thought about having to change clothes in front of her brother and four sisters every day.

She realized they were right. She wanted to be with them, but she didn't want to be them. Not yet.

"Okay," Harper sighed, slumping in her purple chair. "Fine. I stay in Radford. But I'm coming over every weekend to use the lift."

"Authorized," Freddie smiled.

"And," Elara piped up, holding Amanda's hand. "We want to use the pool at the apartment. So you guys have to visit us, too."

"We will," Paige promised. "We'll take the bus. Route 3 drops us right at your door."

"Good," Linda said. "Now, I believe someone mentioned pizza? I'm starving, and this basement smells like... well, it smells like clean laundry and ozone, which is better than I expected, but it's making me hungry."

"Pizza protocol," Jessica agreed. "Everyone upstairs. Let's feed the fleet."

They began the ascent—Freddie and Harper taking turns on the TFL, the others filing up the stairs—leaving the Bridge silent and waiting for the night shift.

Scene 4: The Mess Hall

The "Decoy" bedroom was left behind, its door clicked shut on a life they didn't live.

The Avery Unit—now expanded to a platoon of nine—migrated back to the main living area. The house was small, but the energy was expansive.

"Change of plans," Jessica announced, stepping into the kitchen and tying her hair back. "Pizza is cancelled. We have a full kitchen, we have a grocery stockpile in the garage, and we have Aunt Linda. We are cooking."

"Home cooked?" Aunt Linda asked, her eyes lighting up behind her sunglasses. "Now you're speaking my language. What's the inventory?"

“Pasta,” Jessica said, opening the pantry. “We have ten pounds of spaghetti, three jars of sauce, and I think Sarah bought a bag of frozen meatballs the size of a pillowcase.”

“I did,” Sarah confirmed from the hallway. “Cost-per-unit analysis favored bulk purchase.”

“Spaghetti it is,” Linda declared, tossing her purse onto the counter. She washed her hands at the sink, the bracelets on her wrists jangling. “I’ll make the garlic bread. You handle the noodles. Let’s feed this army.”

The kitchen of 105 Pepper Street transformed into a high-efficiency production line.

Jessica stood at the stove, managing two massive pots of boiling water. The steam rose around her, humid and smelling of starch.

Aunt Linda owned the oven. She was slicing loaves of French bread, slathering them with butter and garlic powder with a speed that blurred the eye.

“So,” Linda chatted over the sizzling of the garlic. “Radford is nice. It’s quiet. The river is right there. I think the girls are going to like the schools.”

“The schools are good,” Jessica agreed, stirring the sauce. “And the transit link is solid. They can take the bus here after school if they want.”

“Oh, they’ll want to,” Linda laughed. “Harper is already obsessed with that lift.”

In the dining room—a small nook adjacent to the kitchen —the logistics of seating nine people were being solved by the twins.

“The table seats four,” Sarah analyzed, looking at the small wooden rectangle. “We have nine units.”

“Expansion protocol,” Jenna said. She ran to the Ops Room (Bedroom 2) and dragged out the desk chairs. “We pull the table away from the wall. We add the chairs. We put the stools from the island at the ends.”

“It will be tight,” Freddie noted, parking The Rover at the head of the table. He locked his brakes. “Elbow clearance will be minimal.”

“We like tight,” Paige smiled, squeezing a chair in next to him.

The atmosphere was chaotic, but it wasn’t the jagged, scary chaos of the outside world. It was the warm, rhythmic chaos of family.

Harper was in the living room, showing Elara and Amanda how to hook up her MP3 player to the TV’s auxiliary input (a trick she figured out in five minutes).

Freddie watched them.

He saw Amanda swaying to the music, holding her grey stone. He saw Elara talking to Jenna about anime. He saw Harper laughing.

“Noise levels,” Paige whispered, leaning over Freddie’s shoulder. “You okay?”

Freddie closed his eyes for a second. He listened to the clatter of pots, the laughter of his sisters, the sizzling of garlic bread.

It was loud. It was crowded.

"It is... harmonious," Freddie decided. "Signal-to-noise ratio is acceptable."

"Order up!" Jessica shouted.

She carried a massive serving bowl of spaghetti to the table. Steam curled off the mountain of pasta.

Linda followed with a platter of meatballs and a basket of garlic bread that was stacked like Jenga blocks.

They squeezed in.

Freddie sat at the head. Paige was on his right, Jessica on his left (the standard flank). Sarah and Jenna took the corners. Aunt Linda sat at the other end, acting as the rear guard, with Harper, Amanda, and Elara filling the gaps.

Legs bumped under the table. Elbows knocked together. There was zero personal space.

"Okay," Aunt Linda said, raising a glass of iced tea. "A toast."

Everyone raised their glasses—soda, water, tea.

"To the Valley," Linda said, her voice thick with emotion. "To Marge, for giving us the Base. And to the Unit... fully assembled."

"To the Unit," eight voices echoed.

"To the Unit," Amanda hummed, tapping her glass.

They ate.

It wasn't a fancy meal. It was jarred sauce and frozen meatballs. But to Freddie, eating his spaghetti while surrounded by every single person he loved, it tasted like victory.

He looked at Harper, who was trying to balance a meatball on her fork while talking with her hands.

He looked at Amanda, who was eating methodically, one noodle at a time.

He looked at Elara, who was listening to Jenna explain the server architecture.

They were safe. They weren't in Norfolk. They weren't under Ellen's roof.

They were here, in the mountains, eating pasta in a house that cost a dollar.

"Status," Freddie whispered to himself, wiping sauce from his lip. "Maximum capacity."

"Hey," Harper called out from down the table. "This sauce is good. But you know what would make it better?"

“What?” Jessica asked.

“If we ate it in the basement,” Harper grinned. “On the Mega-Bed.”

“Don’t push your luck, kid,” Linda laughed. “We eat at the table. We’re civilized.”

“For now,” Jenna muttered.

Freddie smiled. He looked at the window. The sun was shining on the Blue Ridge Mountains.

The satellites were in orbit. The core was stable.

The system was finally, perfectly integrated.

Scene 5: The Supply Line

The garlic bread was decimated. The spaghetti bowl was empty. The “Mess Hall” protocol had been a resounding success.

Now, the table was cleared, and Freddie had deployed the maps.

He smoothed out a laminated chart on the dining table: The New River Valley Transit Schematic (2007 Edition).

“Mission planning,” Freddie announced, looking at Harper. “If you are to execute a weekly visitation schedule, we must establish the logistics of the supply line. The ‘Rover-to-Base’ link.”

Harper rolled her chair closer, her chin resting on her hands. “Lay it on me, Captain. How do I get here without Mom knowing?”

“Public transit,” Freddie stated. “It is the only secure channel.”

He pointed to a spot on the map in Radford.

“Origin Point: Highland Village Apartments. Aunt Linda’s sector.”

He traced a line with his finger to a large blue dot near the university.

“Waypoint Alpha: McConnell Transit Center. The Hub. Located directly across from Valley University on Main Street.”

He traced a thick red line moving east along US-11.

“The Artery: Blue Ridge Transit (BRT) Route 3. The Connector. It runs every thirty minutes.”

He tapped a spot in downtown Christiansburg.

“Destination: Pepper Plaza. Located at 9 Roanoke Street. It is the transit depot for the county seat.”

He pointed out the window to the parking lot diagonally across the street.

"That is Pepper Plaza. You disembark there. You cross the street. You are at Base."

"It's that close?" Harper asked, looking out the window. "I can see the bus stop from here."

"Visual contact confirmed," Freddie nodded. "However, the tariff structure is complex. We are currently in the 'Summer Window'."

He pulled up a notepad and began writing the fee structure.

"Until school starts," Freddie explained, "you are a civilian passenger. You must pay cash."

- **Leg 1 (Radford Transit):** You board the bus near your apartment. Cost: $0.50. Exact change required. No transfers issued.
- **Leg 2 (Blue Ridge Transit Route 3):** You board at McConnell Transit Center. Cost: $1.00. You must request a Transfer Slip upon boarding if you need to switch to another BRT bus, though for this route, it is a direct shot.

"Total cost, one way: $1.50," Harper calculated. "Round trip: Three bucks."

"Affirmative," Freddie said. "Do you have funding?"

"I have an allowance," Harper grinned at Aunt Linda.

"She does," Linda confirmed from the kitchen, where she was helping Jessica dry dishes. "But for the first few runs? I'm riding with you. I need to make sure those bus drivers know how to work the wheelchair lifts. I don't want you stranded on Route 11."

"Agreed," Freddie said. "The lift mechanism can be temperamental. Supervision is required for the beta test."

Freddie drew a line on the paper.

"However," Freddie said, his eyes gleaming behind his glasses. "Once the academic cycle begins, the rules change. You will be a freshman at Radford High School."

"Ugh, don't remind me," Harper groaned.

"No," Freddie corrected. "This is a tactical advantage. Your Student ID is a 'Skeleton Key'."

He tapped the map.

"Starting in September, showing a valid Radford High School ID grants 100% Fare Exemption on both Radford Transit and Blue Ridge Transit."

Harper sat up straight. "Free rides?"

"Unlimited," Freddie confirmed. "You flash the badge. You board the bus. No cash. No friction. You can transit between Radford and Christiansburg as often as the schedule allows."

"That is power," Harper whispered. "I can come here every day after school."

"Negative," Linda called out. "Homework first. Weekends only."

"Fine," Harper rolled her eyes. "Free rides on weekends."

Amanda and Elara crowded around the map.

"What about us?" Elara asked. "Do we get free rides?"

Freddie looked at the twins. He looked at Aunt Linda.

"You are twelve," Freddie said gently. "Middle School Protocol is... restrictive."

"You guys are cargo," Harper teased. "You don't have clearance."

"Harper is correct," Linda said, walking over and putting her hands on the twins' shoulders. "You two are too young to ride the inter-city bus alone. Not yet. When you hit High School? You get the badge. Until then, if you want to visit the Base, you ride with me in the van, or you ride the bus with Harper and an adult."

Amanda looked at the map. She traced the red line of Route 3. She looked at Freddie.

"Bus," Amanda hummed.

"One day," Freddie promised her. "Upgrade pending."

"There is one more variable," Freddie added, looking at his notes. "Intel suggests a system update in January."

"What update?" Jessica asked, leaning against the doorframe.

"Integration," Freddie said. "Regional Passes. Currently, the agencies are siloed. But in 2008, they are launching a unified fare card. One pass for Radford, Blue Ridge, Bluewater, and Roanoke Valley. Total freedom of movement across the entire New River Valley."

"The Grid expands," Paige smiled.

"Exactly," Freddie said. "But for now... we focus on Route 3."

He handed the map to Harper.

"Study the timetable," Freddie ordered. "Memorize the stops. Next Saturday, we execute the first run."

Harper took the map. She folded it carefully and tucked it into the side pocket of her wheelchair.

"Mission accepted," Harper said. "See you next Saturday, Captain."

“See you next Saturday, Satellite,” Freddie replied.

The supply line was established. The Base was no longer an island; it was a Hub.

Scene 6: The Transit Bible

The garlic bread was gone. The spaghetti bowl was empty. The “Mess Hall” (dining room) was littered with dirty napkins and empty sweet tea glasses.

Aunt Linda checked her watch.

“Alright, Satellites,” Linda announced, pushing her chair back. “We need to head back to base. I’ve got boxes to unpack, and if I don’t get Elara to a power outlet soon, her game is going to die and we’ll have a meltdown.”

“Aww,” Harper groaned, slumping in her purple wheelchair at the table. “Already? We just got the system running.”

“You can come back next weekend,” Jessica promised, stacking plates. “But before you go, we need to review the Transport Protocol. If you’re going to be a Satellite, you need to know how to maintain orbit.”

“I know how,” Harper said. “Aunt Linda drives the van.”

“Incorrect,” Freddie said. He rolled The Rover to the kitchen counter, where he had laid out a series of folded paper maps. “The van is a backup system. The primary link is Public Transit.”

Harper rolled over, intrigued. “Buses?”

“The lifeblood of the independent operator,” Freddie stated.

He pointed to a map labeled Regional Transit Schematic (2007).

“Here is the data,” Freddie began, his finger tracing a line. “We are currently at 105 Pepper Street SE. The drop zone is right there.”

He pointed out the window. Across the street, diagonally adjacent to their house, was a paved area with a brick shelter.

“Pepper Plaza,” Freddie identified. “Located at 9 Roanoke Street. It is the primary node for Christiansburg.”

“That’s close,” Harper noted. “I could roll there in thirty seconds.”

“Exactly,” Freddie said. “Now, here is your route from Radford.”

He tapped a spot on the map marked Highland Village Apartments.

“Step 1: You depart Base Radford. You board a Radford Transit (RT) bus. It costs fifty cents. No transfers. You ride it to the McConnell Transit Center.”

“That’s the Hub,” Jessica clarified. “Right across from Radford University. Big brick building. You can’t miss it.”

“Step 2:” Freddie traced a thick blue line running along US-11. “At McConnell, you transfer to Blue Ridge Transit (BT) Route 3. This is the Shuttle. It runs every thirty minutes on weekdays. It connects Radford to Christiansburg via Route 11.”

“Cost?” Harper asked, entering ‘Logistics Mode’.

“One dollar,” Freddie said. “If you need to switch to another Blue Ridge bus later, you ask for a transfer slip. But for this trip? It is a straight shot. Thirty minutes. It drops you right at Pepper Plaza.”

“So,” Harper calculated. “One bus, one transfer, thirty minutes. Cost: $1.50 one way.”

“For now,” Aunt Linda interrupted, digging into her massive purse.

She pulled out a plastic card in a clear sleeve.

“This,” Linda declared, holding it up like a badge, “is a Regional 30-Day Pass. It works on everything. Radford Transit, Blue Ridge Transit, Bluewater, Roanoke Valley... all of ’em. I bought one for myself so I can take the girls around without fishing for quarters.”

“Pass technology,” Freddie approved. “Frictionless entry.”

“And here is the best part,” Jessica added, leaning against the counter. “You start Radford High School in September, right?”

Harper nodded. “Freshman year. Ugh.”

“It has a perk,” Jessica grinned. “Starting in September, your Radford High Student ID is a Golden Ticket. You flash that ID, and you ride Radford Transit and Blue Ridge Transit for free. Zero cost.”

Harper’s jaw dropped. “Free? Seriously?”

“Unlimited rides,” Freddie confirmed. “School policy. They want students mobile.”

Harper looked at the map. She looked at the blue line connecting her new home to Freddie’s house. She looked at the bus stop across the street.

In Norfolk, getting anywhere meant begging Ellen for a ride. It meant being loaded into the van like cargo. It meant hearing Ellen sigh about the “inconvenience” of the wheelchair.

Here?

“I can just... go,” Harper whispered. “I can get on the bus with my chair—”

“All buses are low-floor or lift-equipped,” Freddie assured her. “ADA compliant.”

“—and I can come here whenever I want. For free.”

"On weekends," Aunt Linda reminded her gently. "School nights are for homework."

"Right, right," Harper waved her off. "But the capability exists."

"What about us?" Elara asked, tugging on Linda's sleeve. "Do we get free rides?"

"Not yet," Linda said, patting Elara's head. "You and Amanda are twelve. That means you don't ride the city bus alone. Not until high school. For now, you ride with me, or with Harper if I sign off on it. But mostly me."

Amanda made a soft hmm sound, looking at the map. She traced the blue line with her finger, then pointed to Freddie.

"Yes," Freddie nodded to her. "That line leads to me."

"Okay," Aunt Linda said, checking her watch again. "Lesson over. Load up the van. We'll simulate the bus route next weekend."

The departure was chaotic but happy. Hugs were exchanged. Amanda gave Freddie one last long look and a small wave. Harper spun a 360 in the driveway before hopping into the van.

"Don't forget the countdown!" Harper shouted as the door slid shut. "October 2010! I'm moving in!"

The maroon van backed out of the driveway. It turned onto Pepper Street, drove past the bus stop at Pepper Plaza, and disappeared toward Route 11.

Freddie sat on the front porch in The Rover. The house was quiet again.

"They made it," Jessica said, standing beside him and crossing her arms. "They're safe."

"They are in orbit," Freddie corrected, looking at the empty street. "And the telemetry is good."

He looked at the bus stop across the road.

Route 3.

It wasn't just a bus line. It was a lifeline.

"Let's go downstairs," Freddie said, turning his wheels toward the door. "I need to calibrate the Mega-Bed."

"You just want to take a nap," Jessica teased.

"I am recharging," Freddie said with a small smile. "System maintenance."

The map was folded. The "transit bible" seemed complete. Harper was vibrating with the realization that starting in September, her high school ID was essentially a magic wand for regional travel.

"This is going to be epic," Harper grinned, looking at Amanda and Elara. "So, on Saturdays, I'll just flash my badge, grab the nuggets, and we'll roll over here for breakfast. We'll be like a squad."

"Halt," Aunt Linda said, her voice cutting through Harper's fantasy like a brake squeal.

"Pause," Jessica added, stepping in. "Protocol correction."

"What?" Harper asked, looking between them. "I have the pass. They have the pass—well, Linda has the pass for them. We can ride."

"You can ride," Linda clarified, pointing a manicured finger at Harper. "You are fourteen. You are going to high school. You have demonstrated... moderate situational awareness."

She turned to the twins, Amanda and Elara, who were twelve. Amanda was currently humming at the refrigerator magnets.

"These two," Linda stated, "are twelve. And city buses are public spaces. Strangers. Traffic. Confusion."

"So?" Harper shrugged. "I'll watch them."

"Negative," Freddie said from The Rover. "You are a minor unit. You cannot accept liability for other minor units."

"Freddie is right," Jessica said. "Harper, you can ride solo. That's your privilege. But Amanda and Elara are grounded to Adult Chaperones Only."

"That means," Paige counted off on her fingers, "They can ride with Linda. They can ride with me. Or Jessica. Or Sarah. Or Jenna. Or Freddie."

"Wait," Harper frowned. "So if I want to bring them, I can't? I have to wait for Aunt Linda to drive us?"

"Or," Jenna grinned, leaning against the doorframe, "one of us rides the bus to Radford, picks them up, and escorts the cargo back to base."

"It's a chain of custody issue," Aunt Linda said firmly. "Until you are eighteen, Harper, you are a passenger, not a conductor. You worry about getting yourself and that chair on and off the lift safely. Do not worry about wrangling your sisters."

Harper pouted for a second, but then she looked at Amanda, who was wandering toward the basement door again, completely unaware of the conversation.

"Yeah, okay," Harper admitted. "Amanda might try to get off at the wrong stop if she sees a bird she likes. Good point."

"Safety protocols are absolute," Freddie confirmed. "The twins require an 18-plus escort. No exceptions."

"Fine," Harper sighed. "But I'm still coming every weekend."

"That," Linda smiled, "is the plan. Now, load up. The ice cream I promised them is melting in my imagination."

The departure finally happened. The maroon van backed out of the driveway, carrying the "Satellite Unit" back to Radford.

Freddie watched them go from the porch.

He looked at the bus stop across the street at Pepper Plaza.

The network was established. The rules were set.

Harper had her freedom (The Route 3 Shuttle). The twins had their safety (The Adult Chaperone Rule). And Freddie had his team.

"System status," Freddie whispered to the empty driveway. "Green across the board."

The Fishersville Protocol

Scene 1: The Last Supper

The silver Horizon Avalon sat in the gravel parking lot, its trunk heavy with Harper's luggage. Inside the restaurant, the Avery Unit occupied a large corner booth.

This was the fueling stop. The "Last Supper" before deployment.

The table was covered in heavy ceramic plates piled high with fried chicken, mashed potatoes, and green beans. It was comfort food—heavy, warm, and designed to induce a food coma that would dull the anxiety of separation.

"Eat," Jessica commanded, pushing a basket of rolls toward Harper. "Dorm food is an unknown variable. You need a caloric buffer."

Harper picked at a roll. She was wearing her favorite purple hoodie, the hood down, her headphones resting around her neck like a safety collar. She looked small in the booth, sandwiched between Freddie and Paige.

"I'm nervous," Harper admitted, dropping the roll. "What if I get a bad roommate? What if she listens to country music?"

"Then you use your noise-canceling headphones," Freddie said, dipping a fry in gravy. "You have the technology."

"And remember the specs," Jessica added, consulting the intake packet she had memorized. "You're in the PERT block. That means High School age only. You won't be rooming with a 40-year-old welder retraining for a new career. It's peers only. You are separated from the adult population."

"Peers," Harper muttered. "Great. Teenagers. Even worse."

"You are a teenager," Paige smiled, squeezing her shoulder. "You'll be fine. Just find the other geeks. Look for the people with soldering irons or sketchpads."

"Status check," Aunt Linda said, checking her watch. "Check-in at Barnett Hall starts at 15:00. We have one hour to finish this pie."

"Pie is mandatory," Freddie stated. "Peanut butter cream."

They ate the pie. They drank the sweet tea. They delayed the inevitable for as long as they could, sitting in the warm, noisy restaurant, a family unit holding onto its satellite before the launch.

Scene 2: Barnett Hall

The drive from the restaurant to the campus was short. They took Exit 222, winding past the hospital and up the hill to the rehabilitation center.

They pulled up to Barnett Hall. It was a large, brick dormitory building, functional and institutional, but softened by the autumn leaves blowing across the lawn.

"Target acquired," Freddie whispered from the back seat. "Dormitory Office."

They unloaded the car. Harper transferred into her purple chair. She gripped her bag in her lap.

"Let's go," Jessica said.

They walked into the lobby. The air smelled of floor wax and industrial cleaner. A sign on the wall pointed to the Dormitory Office.

Inside, the office was buzzing with activity. Staff members in polo shirts were checking names off lists.

"Avery, Harper," Jessica announced at the desk.

The housing coordinator looked up. "Ah, yes. PERT Program. You're in the West Wing. All-female suite."

She handed Harper a key card and a packet of rules.

"You are in Suite 200," the coordinator explained. "It's a three-room suite. Rooms A, B, and C. You are in Room A. There are two students per room, so you'll have one direct roommate, and four suitemates. All high school age."

"Security check," Freddie asked. "Are the adult clients isolated?"

"Strictly," the coordinator nodded to Freddie. "The adult vocational students are in a different wing. The PERT students have their own staff and their own curfew. It's a controlled environment."

"Acceptable," Freddie noted.

"We have an escort ready to take you up," the coordinator said, signaling a staff member—a young woman named Sarah (not Avery) with a lanyard.

"Right this way," the escort said. "Elevators are down the hall."

Scene 3: Suite 200

They rode the elevator to the second floor. The escort led them down a wide hallway to a door marked 200.

She swiped a master key. The door clicked open.

They stepped into a small common area. It had standard dorm furniture—a vinyl couch, a sturdy table. Three doors branched off it.

"Room A," the escort pointed to the left.

Harper rolled in.

The room was simple. Two twin beds. Two desks. Two wardrobes. The floor was tiled linoleum—easy to roll on.

"Bed 1 is yours," the escort said. "Your roommate, Kayla, hasn't arrived yet."

"Okay," Jessica said, dropping the duffel bags. "Setup protocol. We have thirty minutes before we have to clear out."

The Avery Unit sprang into action.

Jessica unpacked the clothes, hanging them in the wardrobe with military precision. Paige made the bed. She put on the sheets Harper had brought from home—flannel, purple, smelling of the laundry detergent from Pepper Street. She arranged the pillows to create a "nest." Freddie rolled around the room, checking the outlets and the clearance.

"Desk height is adjustable," Freddie noted. "Good ergonomics. The turning radius between the beds is tight, but sufficient."

He looked at the bathroom attached to the suite.

"Shared facility," Freddie observed. "You must coordinate shower times with five other females. I suggest a schedule."

"I'll make a chart," Harper muttered, putting her laptop on the desk.

They set up her station. Laptop. Headphones. A picture frame with the photo Aunt Linda had taken on the sofa—the "Heap."

Within twenty minutes, the sterile dorm room looked like a forward operating base.

The Signal-to-Noise Ratio

Scene 1: The Circuit

The classroom smelled of ozone and hot flux. To Harper Avery, it smelled like potential.

She sat at a workbench in the Electronics Assembly evaluation sector. In front of her was a schematic, a soldering iron, and a bag of resistors.

"Okay," the evaluator, Mr. Henderson, announced. "Your task is to assemble the circuit board according to the diagram. You have two hours. Accuracy is more important than speed."

Harper pulled her goggles down. She looked at the diagram.

It was a logic gate. A simple loop. Input A + Input B = Output C.

She picked up the soldering iron. Her hand, which usually had a slight, nervous tremor when she was dealing with people, was steady as a rock.

Heat the pad. Feed the solder. Lift. Cool.

For three hours, the world made sense. There was no yelling. There was no sarcasm. There was just the clean, binary reality of the circuit. If you did it right, the green LED lit up. If you did it wrong, it didn't.

Harper finished in forty-five minutes. She hooked up the 9-volt battery.

Click. The green light glowed steady and true.

"Done," Harper said, raising her hand.

Mr. Henderson walked over. He inspected the joints with a magnifying glass.

"Clean," he nodded, looking impressed. "Very clean. You have a knack for the flow, Harper."

Harper smiled. She felt like Freddie. She felt like she was part of the Machine.

This, she thought, is the Signal.

Scene 2: The Shift Change

The Signal died the moment she walked out of the lab. The Static took over.

The Dining Hall was the epicenter of the chaos. It was a large, echoey room divided by an invisible timeline.

17:00 - 17:45: PERT Students (High Schoolers). 17:45 - 18:30: Adult Vocational Clients.

Harper sat at a round table near the exit, her tray guarding her space like a shield wall. She was eating mashed potatoes, trying to make herself as small as possible.

Around her, the high schoolers were vibrating with drama.

"I told you," a girl with aggressive eyeliner shrieked at a boy two tables over. "If you sit with her, we are done."

"It's just a seat, Ashley!" the boy shouted back, slamming his tray down.

Harper winced. Volume spike, she noted. Emotional regulation: Failed.

To her left, a group of girls were whispering furiously about a rumor involving a stolen MP3 player. To her right, a guy was bragging loudly about how he was going to sneak out past curfew to meet a girl from the Nursing Assistant program.

It's inefficient, Harper thought, stabbing her green beans. It's just noise.

She checked her watch. 17:40.

The doors opened. The adult clients began to line up in the foyer, waiting for the PERT students to clear out.

Harper watched them through the glass partition. It wasn't any better. She saw a man and a woman arguing intensely near the vending machines, their body language sharp and jagged.

Adults are just tall teenagers, Harper realized with a sinking feeling. The drama doesn't stop. It just gets louder.

She finished her food quickly. She didn't want to linger. She wanted to get back to the one place that was supposed to be safe.

Scene 3: The PERT Lounge

The PERT Lounge was designed to be a recreational space—a place with couches, a TV, and board games where the high schoolers could relax after a day of assessments.

To Harper, it was a pressure cooker waiting to explode.

She rolled her purple chair into the corner, parking behind a bookshelf filled with battered paperbacks. She pulled out her sketchbook, trying to look busy, trying to be invisible. She was drawing a schematic for a soundboard, focusing on the clean, straight lines of the faders.

The room was packed. It was "Free Time," which meant "Chaos Time."

The door banged open.

A group of boys walked in. They were wearing black t-shirts with skulls on them. The leader was a big kid named Travis. He was a Senior, broad-shouldered and loud, with a sparse mustache that he seemed very proud of.

He scanned the room. He ignored the group of girls watching TV. His eyes landed on the corner.

On Harper.

He broke away from his pack and sauntered over. He didn't respect the perimeter. He walked right past the bookshelf, stepping into the small triangle of space Harper had claimed for herself.

"Hey, Wheels," Travis grinned, leaning his arm against the bookshelf, effectively boxing her in.

Harper gripped her pencil. "I'm working," she whispered, not looking up.

"Working?" Travis laughed. He reached out and tapped the page of her sketchbook with a thick finger. "That looks like homework. We're supposed to be chilling."

"I like homework," Harper said, her voice tight. "Please move. You're blocking the light."

Travis didn't move. He leaned in closer. He smelled of stale cafeteria chili and too much body spray.

"You're feisty," Travis said, his voice dropping to a low, suggestive register that made Harper's skin crawl. "I like that. You know, you're pretty cute for a cripple."

Harper flinched. The slur hit her like a slap.

She looked up at him. She saw the arrogance in his eyes. He was seventeen, maybe eighteen. He was a man-sized boy who thought the world was his playground.

"Don't call me that," Harper said, her hand shaking.

"Just teasing," Travis smirked. He reached out and grabbed the handle of her wheelchair. He gave it a little jiggle, rocking her back and forth. "So, what's your deal? You got a boyfriend back home? Or are you waiting for a real man?"

Harper felt a cold spike of terror in her chest. He was touching her chair. To a wheelchair user, the chair was part of their body. He was touching her.

She ran the math in her head.

Variable: Age. He looked old. He had to be a Senior. He was probably turning eighteen any day now.

If he turns eighteen, Harper thought, panic rising, and I am sixteen... that changes the legal code. If he touches me then... is it a felony? Or just creepy?

She didn't know the specific statutes of the Virginia Code, but she knew the feeling in her gut. He was a predator. And he was getting too close.

"Let go of my chair," Harper said, her voice rising in pitch.

"Calm down," Travis laughed, leaning down so his face was inches from hers. "I'm just being nice. Why don't we go for a roll? There's a vending machine down the hall. My treat."

"No," Harper said.

"Come on," Travis insisted, his grip tightening on her handle. "Don't be a stuck-up—"

She said no!

The voice boomed across the lounge.

Mr. Henderson, the vocational evaluator who was on chaperone duty, crossed the room in three long strides. He stepped between Travis and Harper, breaking the line of sight.

"Step away, Travis," Henderson ordered, his voice hard. "Now."

Travis let go of the chair. He held up his hands, feigning innocence. "Whoa, chill. We were just talking."

"She didn't look like she was talking," Henderson said. "She looked like she was cornered. Back off. Go find your friends."

Travis glared at Henderson, then shot a look of pure venom at Harper over the teacher's shoulder. It was a look that said: You got me in trouble.

Harper shrank back into her chair, pulling her knees to her chest. She was shaking violently.

He's huge, she thought. And he's angry. And he's going to be an adult soon. He could hurt me.

This was why she couldn't stay. It wasn't just the noise. It was the vulnerability. At home, Freddie and Jessica and Paige were the wall. Here, she was just a girl in a chair in a corner.

Travis turned away, his ego bruised, his face red. He needed to reassert dominance. He needed to prove he still owned the room.

He looked at the center of the lounge.

The group of girls—the "Pop Squad"—were huddled around the TV, watching Star Search Academy. They were laughing and singing along.

Travis's eyes narrowed.

"It's Tuesday," Travis announced loudly, marching toward them.

"So?" one of the girls asked, not looking away from the screen.

"Tuesday is Ignition," Travis grunted.

He reached out and snatched the remote control from the table.

Click.

The screen flickered. The singing competition vanished. Instead, heavy metal music blasted from the speakers. Pyrotechnics exploded on the screen. The logo flashed in chrome letters:

"Hey!" the girl screamed, jumping up. "We were watching that!"

"Wrestling is on," Travis said, sitting on the sofa and putting his feet up. "Deal with it."

"Give it back!" The girl lunged for the remote.

Travis held it over his head. "Get away from me."

"You can't just take the TV!" another boy from the Pop Squad shouted, stepping up. "Change it back!"

"Make me," Travis sneered.

The shouting escalated. It wasn't just about the TV anymore. It was about dominance. It was about territory.

Harper shrank into her corner. Her heart was hammering against her ribs.

Violence imminent, her brain screamed. Evacuate.

But she was blocked in. The argument was happening between her and the door.

"Change. It. Back!"

Travis stood up. He grabbed a metal folding chair from the card table.

"I said," Travis roared, "IT'S IGNITION!"

He threw the chair.

It didn't hit anyone, but it smashed against the drywall with a deafening CRASH, leaving a dent in the plaster.

The room erupted. Screams. Shouting. People scattering.

Harper pulled her knees to her chest. She pulled her hood up tight, covering her face. She jammed her fingers into her ears, trying to block out the sound of the shouting and the GWF commentators screaming on the TV.

Static. It's all static.

Staff members rushed in, blowing whistles. "Everyone to your rooms! Now! Move!"

Harper waited until the herd dispersed. She rolled out of her corner, shaking, and fled down the hallway to Suite 200.

Scene 4: The Carrier Wave

Harper slammed the door to her room. Her roommate, Kayla, wasn't there—she was probably still in the hall gossiping about the fight.

Harper was alone. But she felt unsafe. The vibration of the chair hitting the wall was still in her bones.

She pulled out her phone. Her hands were trembling so hard she almost dropped it.

She scrolled to Captain.

She hit send.

"Hello?" Freddie's voice answered on the first ring. It was calm. It was flat. It was perfect.

"It's awful," Harper whispered, hunched over her phone in the dark room. "Freddie, it's a zoo."

"Clarify," Freddie said. "Is the facility dirty?"

"No," Harper said, tears spilling over. "The facility is fine. It's the people. The clients. They... they scream. They fight."

She squeezed her eyes shut.

"There was a fight in the lounge. Over the wrestling show. A guy threw a chair."

"Physical violence?" Freddie asked, his voice tightening.

"He hit the wall," Harper said. "But it was loud. It was so loud."

"Ah," Freddie said. "Entropy. Disorder."

"I hate it," Harper admitted. "I like the soldering. I like the evaluation. But the unstructured time? The 'Free Time'? It makes my skin crawl. I just want to go home."

There was a pause on the line. She could hear the faint hum of the server rack in the background at Pepper Street. It sounded like the ocean.

"Harper," Freddie said. "Activate the Firewall."

"How?"

"You are a Satellite," Freddie reminded her. "Satellites do not engage with the atmosphere. They orbit above it."

He paused.

"Put on your headphones," Freddie commanded. "Play the playlist I made you. 'Orbital Mechanics'. It is instrumental. No lyrics. No drama."

"Okay," Harper sniffled.

"Do not engage with the chaos," Freddie continued. "Observe it. Catalog it. Treat it like a nature documentary. 'Here we see the humans creating unnecessary conflict.' "

Harper giggled. A wet, shaky sound. "They are loud humans."

"You are Avery," Freddie said firmly. "You thrive on clean data. If the data is corrupted, do not process it. Just filter it out."

"Filter it out," Harper repeated.

"I will stay on the line," Freddie offered. "I will not speak. I will just keep the connection open. You put the phone in your pocket. Put on the headphones. I will be the carrier wave."

"You'd do that?"

"Affirmative," Freddie said. "Leaving the line open."

Harper put her earbuds in. She plugged them into the phone. She put the phone in her hoodie pocket.

She could hear it—the faint, rhythmic breathing of her brother three hours away. A steady, white-noise presence.

She turned on her own music, low, mixing it with the open line.

She lay back on the bed. She closed her eyes.

She wasn't in Fishersville anymore. She was in the Unit.

Scene 5: The Countdown

The week had been a gauntlet, but the "Freddie Protocol" had worked. Harper had worn her headphones like armor. She had eaten quickly. She had hidden in the library during free time.

Now, it was the final night.

Harper sat on her bed. Her suitcase was already packed. Every shirt was folded. Every sock was matched.

Her roommate, Kayla, was crying on the other bed.

"He isn't calling me back!" Kayla wailed, throwing her phone at the pillow. "He's probably with Jessica!"

Harper looked at Kayla. She ran a diagnostic.

Variable: Boyfriend. Status: Unreliable. Reaction: Hysteria.

Harper stood up. She walked over to Kayla's bed. She didn't offer a hug (she reserved those for the Unit). She offered data.

"Kayla," Harper said, her voice steady.

Kayla looked up, mascara running. "What?"

"We leave in fourteen hours," Harper stated. "If he isn't calling you, he is a bad variable. You are wasting processing power on a glitch."

Kayla blinked. "A... glitch?"

"You passed your evaluation," Harper reminded her. "You got a recommendation for the Culinary program. That is real. The boy is just static."

Kayla sniffled. She wiped her eyes. "Static?"

"Noise," Harper said. "Turn it off."

She handed Kayla a tissue.

"We're going home tomorrow," Harper said. "Focus on the exit strategy."

Kayla took the tissue. She blew her nose. "You're weird, Harper."

"I know," Harper smiled, thinking of the Mega-Bed waiting for her. "I'm a Avery."

She walked back to her desk. She opened her notebook.

She drew a large square. She wrote a number inside it.

14 HOURS.

"System standby," Harper whispered. "Prepare for extraction."

Scene 6: The Midnight Threshold

It was the final breakfast. The "Exit Protocol."

Harper sat at her usual defensive table near the door, her noise-canceling headphones around her neck. She wasn't eating. She was watching the clock on the wall.

08:32 AM. The family would be here in four and a half hours.

Across the room, the source of the static was holding court.

Travis was sitting on a table—not a chair, the table—surrounded by his sycophants. He was wearing a new t-shirt that said LEGALLY LETHAL.

He was louder than usual today. He was vibrating with a specific, arrogant energy.

"Tomorrow," Travis shouted, pointing a fork at a terrified freshman. "Tomorrow is the day, little man. Midnight tonight. The clock strikes twelve, and I am a free agent."

"Happy birthday, Travis," one of the girls simpered.

"It ain't just a birthday," Travis sneered, looking around the room until his eyes locked on Harper in the corner. "It's a license. I turn eighteen tomorrow. That means I'm an adult. I can do what I want. I can sign myself out. I can go where I want."

He grinned at Harper. It was a wolfish, hungry grin.

"No more kiddie rules," Travis said, his voice dropping just enough to be terrifying. "Tomorrow, I'm a grown man. And grown men take what they want."

Harper gripped her tray. The math hit her like a physical blow.

Today is Friday the 14th. Tomorrow is Saturday the 15th. He turns 18 tomorrow.

She realized with a jolt of cold terror that she was escaping just in time. If she stayed for the weekend... if she was still here when he became a legal adult... the dynamic would shift. He wouldn't just be a bully. He would be a man targeting a child.

He thinks turning 18 gives him permission, Harper realized. He doesn't know it just gives him a prison sentence.

She stood up. She dumped her tray. She rolled out of the cafeteria without looking back.

Four hours, she told herself. Just four hours until the Unit gets here.

The Extraction

Scene 1: The Pickup

The silver Horizon Avalon pulled up to the curb outside Barnett Hall. The engine was idling with a familiar, low rumble that sounded like safety.

Harper Avery was already waiting outside. She sat in her purple wheelchair, her duffel bag on her lap, her backpack slung over the handles. She was wearing her noise-canceling headphones, but they weren't plugged into anything; they were just earmuffs against the world.

She looked tense. Her shoulders were hunched up to her ears, and she was scanning the parking lot with the hyper-vigilance of a soldier behind enemy lines. She kept checking the automatic doors behind her, terrified that they would open.

The car door opened.

"Extract!" Jessica shouted from the driver's seat, grinning. "The eagle has landed!"

Harper didn't smile back immediately. She wheeled toward the car with frantic urgency.

Freddie opened the passenger door. He looked at her face. He saw the tight jaw, the wide eyes, the way she was gripping her bag until her knuckles were white.

"Status?" Freddie asked softly.

"Open the trunk," Harper said, her voice tight. "Just get me out of here. Before he comes out."

Paige jumped out of the back seat to help. She took the duffel bag.

"Harper?" Paige asked. "Who is 'he'?"

"Just load the chair," Harper commanded, climbing into the backseat next to Freddie. She buckled her seatbelt instantly and locked the door. "Drive. Please. Just drive."

Jessica looked in the rearview mirror. The playful mood in the car evaporated. She put the car in gear.

"We're rolling," Jessica said.

As they pulled away from the brick dormitory, heading toward Exit 222, Harper didn't look back. She stared straight ahead at the headrest, her breathing shallow and fast.

Freddie reached out. He placed his hand on her knee.

"You are safe," Freddie stated. "The perimeter is secure."

Harper let out a long, shuddering breath. She ripped the headphones off her neck and threw them onto the floorboard.

"I am never," Harper whispered, "ever going back there."

Scene 2: The Debrief

The car was quiet. The hum of the tires on the highway was the only sound for twenty miles.

Finally, Harper spoke.

"It was a war zone," she said.

"The vocational assessment?" Freddie asked. "Did the soldering fail?"

"No," Harper shook her head. "The work was fine. I liked the electronics. I liked the drafting. It was the people. The downtime."

She looked at her siblings.

"There was a fight," Harper said. "A big one. On Tuesday."

She described the scene in the PERT lounge. The argument over the TV. The metal chair hitting the wall.

"Violence," Freddie noted, flinching. "Uncontrolled kinetic energy."

"But it wasn't just the fight," Harper whispered. She hugged her arms to her chest. "It was the guy who started it. Travis."

Jessica glanced in the rearview mirror. "Did he hurt you?"

"He tried," Harper said, her voice trembling. "He cornered me. Before the fight started. He grabbed my chair. He... he wouldn't let me leave."

Freddie's hand tightened on her knee. "He breached your perimeter?"

"He's a Senior," Harper said. "He's huge. And he's mean."

She looked out the window at the passing trees.

"He turns eighteen tomorrow," she added softly. "November 15th."

The car went silent.

"He was bragging about it at breakfast," Harper continued, tears leaking out of her eyes. "He said that at midnight tonight, he becomes a 'free agent.' He said grown men can take what they want. He looked right at me when he said it."

Freddie processed the data. His face hardened behind his glasses.

"He is operating on a false algorithm," Freddie stated coldly. "He believes age grants immunity. In reality, age grants liability."

"Liability?" Harper asked, wiping her nose.

"If he touches you today," Freddie explained, his voice devoid of emotion but heavy with threat, "it is a juvenile offense. A misdemeanor. He gets counseling."

He adjusted his glasses.

"If he touches you tomorrow... after 00:00 hours... he is an adult male assaulting a minor female. That is a felony. That is the registry. That is prison."

"He doesn't know that," Harper whispered. "He thinks he's Romeo. He thinks I'm playing hard to get."

"He is not Romeo," Jessica hissed from the front seat, gripping the steering wheel. "He is a target for Mr. Sterling. If he ever comes near you again, we bury him."

"You got out just in time, Harp," Paige said, rubbing Harper's back. "You beat the clock. He wakes up tomorrow a man, and his victim is gone."

"I know," Harper exhaled. "That's why I had to leave. I couldn't stay for the weekend."

She looked at Freddie.

"I just want to be boring," Harper said. "I want to sit in the basement and sort laundry. I want to watch The Local. I don't want to be hunted."

"Boring is underrated," Freddie said. "Boring is stable."

He squeezed her knee.

"You are a Avery," Freddie stated. "We do not engage in chaotic social friction. We withdraw to the bunker."

"Exactly," Harper nodded. "Take me to the bunker."

Scene 3: The Reunion

The silver Avalon pulled into the driveway.

The house looked exactly the same. The white siding. The green grass. The ramp.

"Home," Harper breathed.

They unloaded. Harper rolled up the ramp faster than she had ever moved. Jessica unlocked the door.

Inside, the living room was waiting.

Sarah and Jenna (now 19) were sitting on the floor, surrounded by textbooks. They were sophomores at Radford University now, commuting from the Base.

"Survivor returns!" Jenna cheered, jumping up.

"Status?" Sarah asked, adjusting her glasses.

"Traumatized," Harper announced, rolling into the center of the room. "People are crazy. I require immediate stabilization."

"We have pizza coming," Jenna said. "And we rented a movie. A quiet one."

"Where's Linda?" Harper asked.

"She's picking up the twins from school," Jessica said. "She'll bring them over for dinner, then take you all back to Radford tonight."

Harper's face fell. The relief vanished, replaced by a heavy, sinking weight.

"Back to Radford," she repeated.

She looked at the basement door. She looked at the TFL lift. She looked at the sofa where Freddie was transferring from his wheelchair to his "Docking Station."

"I don't want to go back," Harper whispered.

She rolled over to the sofa. Freddie was settling in. He patted the cushion next to him.

Harper climbed out of her chair. She didn't sit next to him; she climbed onto him. She was sixteen, tall and lanky, but she curled up on his lap like she was five. She buried her face in his neck.

"Freddie," she whispered. "Let me stay. Please. I can sleep on the floor. I can sleep in the bathtub. I don't care."

Freddie wrapped his arms around her. He felt the tension in her frame.

"You want to transfer residency," Freddie noted.

"I hate the apartment," Harper cried softly. "I mean... Aunt Linda is great. She tries. But it's not here. It's not the Unit. I feel like... like a satellite that's drifting too far away. And after Travis... I just want to be where the walls are thick."

She tightened her grip on his shirt.

"I'm sixteen. I can drop out of high school. I can get a GED. I can move in."

Jessica sat down on the coffee table. She looked at Harper with sad, serious eyes.

“Harper,” Jessica said. “We want you here. You know that. The Mega-Bed has a spot with your name on it.”

“Then let me stay!”

“We can’t,” Jessica said. “Not yet.”

“Why?” Harper demanded, pulling back to look at them. “Mom isn’t even looking anymore! She doesn’t care!”

“Because of the law,” Sarah said from the floor. “Custody is a legal framework. Aunt Linda has guardianship. If you move in here... if you technically ‘run away’ to live with your adult siblings... Ellen could sue. She could claim Linda is unfit. She could try to take Amanda and Elara back.”

Harper froze.

“She could take the twins?”

“She could try,” Jessica said. “She could say Linda lost control of the household. We can’t risk the twins, Harper. They need Linda. They need the stability of that apartment until they’re old enough to choose.”

Harper slumped against Freddie. The logic was ironclad.

“So I have to wait,” Harper whispered.

“Two years,” Freddie said. He held her tight. “730 days.”

“It feels like forever,” Harper sniffled.

“It is a finite set,” Freddie corrected. “We can count it down.”

He pointed to the wall. There, next to the TV, Jenna had installed a digital countdown clock she had built from an LED kit.

DAYS UNTIL ORBITAL MERGE: 712

“We are counting,” Freddie said. “Every day, the number gets smaller.”

Harper looked at the red numbers.

“Two years,” she repeated.

“And until then,” Paige said, sitting next to them and rubbing Harper’s back. “You have weekends. You have holidays. You have summers.”

“And you have the bus,” Freddie reminded her. “The Free Ride.”

Harper nodded slowly. She wiped her eyes.

“Okay,” she said. “I can do two years. But I’m staying tonight. Aunt Linda said I could have a sleepover.”

“Affirmative,” Freddie said. “The Mega-Bed is prepped.”

“And no fighting over the remote?” Harper asked, looking at Jenna.

"I hereby grant you remote control privileges for the duration of the weekend," Jenna solemnly vowed.

Harper smiled. She leaned back against Freddie, listening to his heartbeat.

"No drama," Harper whispered. "Just us."

"Just us," Freddie agreed.

The Base was secure. The Satellite was docked. And outside, the world could be as loud and chaotic as it wanted, because inside 105 Pepper Street, the volume was always perfect.

The Closed Circuit

Scene 1: The Intruder

The pizza delivery car pulled into the driveway, its headlights sweeping across the living room window.

Inside, the atmosphere was fragile. The Avery Unit had shifted into "Bunker Mode." The curtains were drawn. The lights were low. Freddie was parked in The Rover near the kitchen, watching Harper.

Harper was sitting on the floor, sorting through her backpack. She was moving frantically, pulling out clothes and books as if checking for contamination.

Ding-Dong.

The doorbell rang. It was a standard, two-note chime.

Harper flinched. She scrambled backward, crab-walking across the carpet until her back hit the sofa. Her eyes went wide, fixed on the door.

"It's just the pizza, Harp," Jenna said from the recliner, standing up. "I got it."

Jenna opened the door.

Standing on the porch was the delivery driver. He was young—maybe nineteen or twenty. He was tall, broad-shouldered, and wearing a baseball cap pulled low.

He looked, from a distance, just enough like a high school senior. Just enough like Travis.

"Large pepperoni, large cheese," the driver said, his voice deep and booming. "That'll be eighteen-fifty."

Harper let out a small, strangled whimper. She pulled her knees to her chest, burying her face in her arms.

"Male," Harper whispered, her voice shaking. "Proximity alert."

Freddie saw the reaction. He didn't hesitate.

He rolled The Rover forward, placing himself directly between Harper and the door. He turned the chair sideways, creating a matte-black titanium wall.

"Visual block established," Freddie said calmly.

He looked at Harper. He extended his hand down to her.

"Grab on," Freddie commanded softly. "Anchor point active."

Harper reached up. She grabbed his hand with both of hers, squeezing with a desperate, white-knuckled grip. She didn't look at the door. She looked at Freddie's wheel.

Jenna paid the driver quickly. "Thanks. Keep the change."

She slammed the door. She threw the deadbolt.

"Secure," Jenna announced.

Harper didn't let go of Freddie's hand. She pulled herself up, using his chair as a ladder, until she was standing. Then, she didn't stop. She climbed into his lap.

She was sixteen years old. She was tall. But she curled up on him like a child, hiding her face in his neck, her legs draped over the armrest of the wheelchair.

"He was loud," Harper whispered into his shirt. "He sounded like him."

"He is gone," Freddie promised, wrapping his arms around her waist to hold her steady. "He was a logistical variable. Pizza delivery. Nothing more."

"I hate them," Harper cried softly. "I hate boys. They're loud and they grab."

She tightened her grip on his shoulders.

"Except you," she whispered. "You don't grab. You hold."

Scene 2: The Emergency Brake

They ate the pizza in the living room, picnicking on the floor. Or rather, the sisters ate on the floor.

Freddie sat on the sofa. Harper sat next to him.

Usually, Harper was the satellite—orbiting the room, grabbing a slice, moving to the TV. Tonight, she was static.

She had engaged her own Emergency Brake.

She sat with her left side pressed completely against Freddie's right side. Her arm was looped through his. Her head was resting on his shoulder. Whenever she took a bite of pizza, she did it quickly, then immediately returned her hand to his arm, re-establishing the circuit.

"Status?" Paige asked, handing Freddie a napkin.

"She is... docked," Freddie said. "Hard lock."

He looked down at Harper. Her eyes were closed. She was chewing slowly. She wasn't vibrating. She wasn't manic. She was just... clinging.

"I'm sorry," Harper mumbled, swallowing her bite. "Am I squishing you?"

"Negative," Freddie said. "Structural integrity is 100%."

He rested his cheek on the top of her head.

"Why me?" Freddie asked quietly. "There are seven females in this room. Statistically, they are safer targets."

Harper opened her eyes. She looked at the sisters scattered around the room.

"They're safe," Harper agreed. "But... they're soft."

She knocked her knuckles gently against Freddie's chest.

"You're solid," Harper said. "You don't flutter. You don't panic. You just... sit."

She shivered, remembering the chaotic energy of Travis—the pacing, the shouting, the unpredictable violence of the chair throw.

"Travis was like static," Harper whispered. "He was all over the place. I never knew what he was going to do next."

She squeezed Freddie's arm.

"You're the dial tone," she said. "You're always the same. I know you aren't going to jump up. I know you aren't going to yell. You're just... The Base."

Freddie processed the data. Consistency as a safety feature.

"I am a fixed point," Freddie confirmed.

"Yeah," Harper sighed, closing her eyes again. "And right now? I really need a fixed point. I feel like I'm floating away."

"Gravity increased," Freddie said.

He shifted his weight, leaning into her, pressing her down into the sofa cushions. He applied the Deep Pressure technique Paige used on him.

Harper let out a long breath. Her shoulders dropped. The tension that had been holding her rigid since Fishersville finally melted.

"Thanks, Captain," she whispered.

Scene 3: The Exception

The house was winding down. The younger twins, Amanda and Elara, were asleep on air mattresses in the living room upstairs (the "Overflow Protocol").

But the core of the house—the heat source—was down below.

In the unfinished basement, the Mega-Bed dominated the room. It was a ten-foot-wide island of maroon duvet and memory foam, resting on its custom-built carpeted platform. The LED lights from Jenna's server rack cast a soft, rhythmic blue glow against the concrete walls.

The "Regulars" were already assembling.

Sarah was organizing her pillows on the far left edge (The West Wing). Jenna was flopping onto the far right (The East Wing). Jessica and Paige were arranging the center.

Freddie sat on the edge of the mattress in his flannel pajamas. He was transferring from The Rover, his movements slow and stiff.

Harper stood at the bottom of the wooden stairs. She was wearing her oversized sleep shirt. She looked at the massive bed. She looked at the five adults who usually occupied it.

"Can I..." Harper hesitated, her voice small in the large room. "Can I stay in the Bridge tonight? I don't want to be upstairs. It's too open."

Jessica looked up from fluffing a pillow. "Clearance granted," she said softly. "We have the square footage."

Harper walked to the bed.

Usually, the formation was fixed: Sarah - Paige - Freddie - Jessica - Jenna.

But tonight, the architecture shifted.

"I need the middle," Harper said, looking at Freddie. "I need the Core."

Freddie looked at her. He saw the tremor in her hands. He saw the way she was hugging her own ribs.

"Adjusting formation," Freddie announced.

He scooted over. He didn't just make room; he created a gravity well.

Harper climbed into the dead center of the massive bed. The memory foam absorbed her weight. She lay down.

"Freddie," she whispered. "Left flank."

Freddie lay down on her left. He rolled onto his side, facing her.

Harper grabbed his arm. She didn't just hold it; she pulled it over her, draping his heavy forearm across her chest like a seatbelt. She tucked her head under his chin.

"Shields up," Harper murmured.

Jessica took the right flank. She pressed against Harper's back, sandwiching her.

Paige took the far left, pressing against Freddie's back, locking the formation.

Sarah and Jenna filled in the edges, closing the ranks.

They were a six-person layer cake of protection on a bed built for five. It was tight. It was warm. It was perfect.

Harper lay in the dark. She breathed in the scent of Freddie's laundry detergent. She felt the heavy, dead weight of his arm pinning her to the mattress. She felt the bridge—the foam wedge connecting the two Queen mattresses—beneath her hip, but the thick topper smoothed it out so it felt like one continuous surface.

She thought about Travis. She thought about his hands grabbing her chair. She thought about his laugh.

Then she felt Freddie's heartbeat against her cheek. Slow. Steady. Logical.

He is the only one, Harper thought. The only boy who doesn't want to take. The only boy who just wants to hold.

"Freddie?" Harper whispered.

"Listening," Freddie murmured into her hair.

"If he comes here..." Harper's voice trembled. "If he finds out where I live..."

Freddie's arm tightened on her chest. It wasn't a spasm. It was a reflex of pure defense.

"He will encounter the Firewall," Freddie stated, his voice devoid of sleepiness, sharp as a blade. "I will not let him breach the perimeter. I will run him over."

Harper giggled. A tiny, wet sound. "With The Rover?"

"Titanium frame," Freddie noted. "High impact velocity. I will aim for the tibia."

"And if he gets past the Rover," Sarah's voice came from the dark on the far left, "he has to get past the Laundry Brigade."

"And the Server Rack," Jenna added from the far right. "I have cables. I can bind him."

Harper smiled in the dark. She snuggled closer, wrapping her legs around Freddie's.

"Okay," she whispered. "Break his legs."

"Affirmative," Freddie said.

Safe in the arms of the only male she trusted, surrounded by the sisters who built a bed big enough to hold them all, Harper Avery finally closed her eyes. The countdown to midnight—to Travis's 18th birthday—ticked away, but it didn't matter anymore. She was in the Bridge. She was with the Unit. And she was safe.